Who am I

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50374480.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Serenia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Time Travel, Alternate Universe - Time Travel, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Manipulation, Manipulative Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), POV Third Person

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Obelisk Series

Stats:
Published: 2023-09-27 Completed: 2024-08-15 Words: 174,430 Chapters: 16/16

Who am I

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50374480.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Serenia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Time Travel, Alternate Universe - Time Travel, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Manipulation, Manipulative Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), POV Third Person

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Obelisk Series

Stats:
Published: 2023-09-27 Completed: 2024-08-15 Words: 174,430 Chapters: 16/16

Who am I

by The_Desecrated_One

Summary

Who am I? That's the question an amnesiac Catra has to answer when she wakes up in an unfamiliar forest. To make matters worse she has memories of another world called Earth. Who's memories are in her head and what does it mean for her own. Thankfully a blonde girl, who seems very familiar to her, says she can help her. The only question now is, "should she trust her?"

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

"What happened?" A hoarse voice asked itself.

The owner of the voice slowly sat up taking in their surroundings. They appeared to be in some sort of forest. It's density is a bit concerning. The foliage was so thick they couldn't see past the line of trees in front of them. The sounds of wildlife unusually loud.

'Where am I?' they thought standing up. A shooting pain immediately shot through their head, almost forcing them back to the ground. Quickly catching themselves on a tree limb, trying not to throw up, they took a deep breath.

'Agh, my head is pounding. How did I get out here? More importantly, where is here?'

Taking a second to catch their bearings, they took in their surroundings more acutely.

There was no path, no trail, nothing indicating how they had wound up in the middle of the forest. In fact, there was nothing but trees and darkness stretching into the night.

The sounds of the wildlife were quite loud, almost unnaturally even. In fact everything seemed to be more vivid. The sound of dripping was constant. There must be some form of water nearby.

Just then they became acutely aware of how thirsty they were. Their tongue felt like sand against the roof of their mouth, and they were finding it somewhat difficult to swallow.

'God, what the hell happened to me?' they thought as they stumbled towards the sound. There also seemed to be some sort of smell in the air, and a strong one at that. It smelled almost metallic. They couldn't quite place where they had smelled it before. As they walked through the brush, gently moving branches to the side while being careful not to move too much so

as to not set off another migraine, they noticed something about themselves. Their hands were not normal.

Stopping to look at their self, they immediately noticed there were claws on their fingertips. Blinking any drowsiness away, they took a more intense look at themselves. There was very fine fur where skin should have been. It went all the way from their fingertips to their shoulders.

It was there they noticed something peculiar about themselves. They had very long hair that stretched down a slender body belonging to that of a young woman.

"What the fuck?" they said to themselves. Feeling their body showed that the fur encompassed their whole body including their face. The most bizarre part of this experience showed itself in the form of a tail and cat-like ears.

'Ok, stop. What the FUCK. Last time I checked people didn't have cat features adorning their body.' She thought to herself. 'Also, why am I a woman? I'm not a woman. I think?' She thought, confusion clouding her mind.

For the first time since waking up she stopped to really think about things. Nothing was adding up. Everything from waking up in the middle of a forest she had never seen to this body that seemed straight out of a fantasy novel.

It was then that an alarming thought occurred to her.

'What's my name?' She thought, panic slowly taking over. Her breathing was coming out in shorter gasps and it was getting increasingly harder to stand.

"FUCK FUCK FUCK, Who the fuck am I?" She yelled out.

Cold fear gripped her stomach. She needed to calm down, panicking would get her nowhere. She took deep breaths doing her best to keep calm, realizing how increasingly alone she was.

There were no tracks, no footprints, nothing to explain how she had gotten into this forest.

As she sped up her pace, she then noticed that the dripping sound was still constant and that the metallic smell had gotten pungent as she approached the sound. She identified the sound and smell right before she stepped through into the clearing. It was blood and a lot of it too. The trees were splattered with it and the ground had turned red. It looked like something straight out of a horror movie.

Her eyes quickly locked onto the culprit. There, roughly 90 feet away, was a dead deer? At least it appeared to be a deer, but no deer she had ever seen looked this way. It had three purple eyes, and a long cat-like tail that split into three. It's fur was a shade of blue as well, with it's antlers resembling some form of antenna. Peculiarly, it had hooves that somewhat resemble paws.

It was currently being torn apart by a dog-like creature that somewhat resembled a mix between a doberman and a crocodile. A very big creature.

'Right, this was a mistake," she thought, with an expression of fear, backing out of the clearing and getting as far away from the area as possible.

As soon as she was far enough away from the area, to the point she couldn't smell the blood or hear the dripping anymore, she took off in a sprint.

She ran for what seemed like forever but in actuality was probably only a few minutes, The sound of rushing water filling her ears.

'Ok, this time I know for sure that that is water.'

She came across a river that was so clear she could see to the bottom of it. The fish that swam through didn't even look like normal fish. Their scales shined with brilliant glowing patterns of reds and blues that seemed almost magical. If she didn't know any better she would say they were magic.

Taking a steadying breath, she sat on a rock, cleaned her face, took a drink and tried to gather her thoughts over what was going on.

'Alright, time to figure whatever the hell this is. One, I am now a cat person. . .I'm gonna come back to that one. Two, I have no clue what my name is, who I am in general, to the point I can't even remember my own gender. I think,

'Am I a man? I was kind of shocked that I had a woman's body. But then again, I didn't have any problems moving or walking or even running. Like I instinctively know how to move. Maybe I was a woman?' She let out a sigh of irritation. 'This is so stupid. What I have come to the conclusion is that I am in a place that defies reason and logic. The trees easily dwarf the biggest trees of earth and no river that she's heard of has water that glows and fish that can leave glitter in the water. What purpose does that serve anyways? Is it some kind of defense mechanism? Maybe a mating dance of some kind? Whatever the reason, she didn't like it. It was unnatural.'

'So the most likely option is I am dying. I am dying in a hospital room slowly dying from some head injury and the carbon dioxide in my body is causing me to hallucinate this weird fantasy dream. I'm in a medical coma and my brain is rationalizing the injuries.'

That's why her head hurt. The doctors must be working on her head to save her life, or his life. Still undecided on that part. The smell of blood, the migraine and nausea, even the weird brightly colored animals could be explained.

The picture became increasingly clearer as she analyzed her surroundings. The sights, sounds, and smells all pointed to the only possible scenario.

'At some point, whoever I am, must have been driving down a country side road. Along the way at some point, a deer must have stepped into the road. Seeing this, I must have swerved to avoid it, unsuccessfully. I hit the deer causing the bloody scene I saw

earlier. The car must have wrecked and I hit my head resulting in this terrible migraine and memory loss. I must have veered off into a forest, given my current surroundings, and the fish are ambulance lights and the dog creature was a search and rescue dog.'

She smiled a toothy grin at having figured it all out. In all honesty, there were no other scenarios. It all added up. Though her satisfaction gave way to a more curious thought process.

'But why am I a cat person?' That was the one piece of this puzzle that didn't seem to fit anywhere. And not only that, what happens if she were to die in this mental landscape? Would she simply fizzle out of existence or would she wake up? Should she stay put or explore her surroundings? Either way she had decided she didn't want to stay in this area anymore.

She tried to get her sense of direction back by looking at the sky. If the moon wasn't at a high point she could figure out which was north. Though she was quick to find her thoughts on this matter quickly dashed and not for the first time this day and probably not the last, she found herself cursing her circumstances.

"Of course, why wouldn't there be six moons?!" she exclaimed in irritation. Looking around she noticed a cliffside. It seemed to stretch high into the clouds. It was then that she noticed it wasn't clouds, but fog. Giving a groan of exasperation, "Guess we're doing this the hard way," she said as she eyed the cliff.

The pain in the side and back of her head subsiding for the moment, she took in her apparel hoping to find anything of use. Examining herself more thoroughly, she found that she was wearing a sleeveless red leotard and purplish leggings, which had several holes in them, that wrapped around the arch of her feet, leaving her heels, toes, and knees exposed. She had on two belts that, admittedly, looked to be for aesthetic purposes only. The shiny piece of metal pinned to her shirt caught her eye. It appeared to be some sort of badge, a little bigger than a 50 cent

piece. The insignia had a yellow background with what appeared to be two green bat wings under a diamond.

'What a stupid looking badge. It looks like a little kid drew this. What would this even represent anyways?' She thought, a disdainful look marring her face. 'Maybe I can use this thing to. . . I don't know where I was going with this.'

Undoing the pin, she brought it closer to her face and noticed it had a button on it. Thinking it over for a moment she decided not to push it, not quite sure what it does.

"With my luck it's probably my life support. Hey push this and all of your problems will disappear. Yeah right, I'm not that stupid.' Getting to her feet, letting out a breath of exasperation, she stared at the cliffside. "Well, no time like the present."

"Fuck this cliff, ugh, fuck this forest, argh, fuck this forest, mmh, and most of all, fuck whatver deer she hit." She grunted. This was bullshit and she knew it. She had nearly fallen several times, she had cut herself multiple times, and the worst of all was that she was very thirsty.

Finally finding herself at the top, she crawled herself away from the ledge and layed there for several moments, breathing heavily. 'Huh, that wasn't as hard as I thought it would be and what the hell man, I'm dying the least of all my brain could do is make me not run out of breath.'

Getting to her feet, she looked out over the land. It was a gorgeous view. Trees larger than she had ever seen before. The river stretched out for miles and she could see a waterfall where it started. The sky was filled with shades of pinks and blues. The moons seemed more vibrant now that she could get a good look at them. And there were mountains of ice that seemed to stretch on forever until they were lost into the clouds.

The breeze smelled cleaner. It was hard to describe, but there was no scent of gas or oil, no pollution. There was something that smelled sweet and almost made you feel safer, like a blanket around you on a cold night with a warm drink in your hands. If she wasn't sure she was dying before, she was now. There was no place like this on earth. The trees had colors that she had never seen before. But there was something missing. Something incomplete about the picture. She couldn't place it for a few minutes until it hit her.

"Where are the stars?" She asked aloud. It was almost heartbreaking really. She had never seen something so beautiful in her entire life, or rather what she could remember of it, and it was missing half the picture. Letting out a sigh, she turned away from the breathtaking view. She had to focus on finding her way out of the forest. There would be time for sightseeing later.

She walked for a few hours listening to the sounds of nature. She stopped when she noticed some sort of fruit on the trees. It looked like an orange but pink. She looked at her hands, tensing them a bit.

'Maybe I can. . .' she wondered when suddenly, her claws extended much further than she previously thought they could. "Huh well how about that," she said to herself. Latching onto the tree she climbed up and grabbed the pink fruit and dropped back to the ground, landing softly.

"Note to self, I am more cat than I first thought." she muttered. Looking at the fruit, she started peeling it. The smell of citrus filled the air. She took a bite and sweet juice filled her mouth. 'Yep, it's an orange.'

The morning rays started peeking through the branches, illuminating the path she was on. The sounds of wildlife became more prominent as nature started to wake up. As she kept walking her ears picked up on another sound. A sound she was familiar with. Laughing.

Quickly finishing her orange, or pink in this case, she ran to the sound as quickly as she could. There peeking through the bushes she saw a small village, or rather a smattering of tents. There was also a purple tree, with pink leaves, and what looked to be a large glowing pearl in the center of it.

She saw children playing and people chatting. They seemed to be performing the basic morning routines of waking up, eating, and getting ready for the day. There were also other people with animal features, but more deerish. As she examined the people, she came to the conclusion that, no doubt about it, these people were hippies. They had flowers in their hair and there was no meat to be found. Some of them also smoked what appeared to be blunts. Heh. But in the middle of the gathering was a blonde woman. She looked to be around 19, but what caught her eye was not the clothing, but the fact she had made the flowers grow in her hands. She also had a green circlet on.

'She must know the way out of the forest. I bet she controls it.' she thought with a smile. Stepping out into the open, she started to make her way towards the woman.

"Excuse me," she called out to the woman, "I'm kind of lost and trying to get out of this forest. I would really appreciate it if-" before she could finish her sentence, cries of terror and fear erupted from the gathering shouting about hordes. Quickly spinning around, she scanned the tree line thinking that the dog creature had followed her. But there was nothing. Not even a scent of the blood she had smelled earlier. Turning back around, she saw everyone was not looking at the forest, but at her.

'What the hell? I didn't even do anything.' She thought to herself, confused, when all of a sudden the blonde woman, who had been growing flowers, lashed out with vines towards her.

She quickly jumped to the side, attempting to avoid the flora coming towards her. Narrowly missing her by inches she yelled out towards the hostile woman.

"Why are you attacking me? I didn't do anything to you!" The vines kept coming though and eventually her lack of energy, her injuries, combined with the fatigue from climbing the cliff caught up with her. The vines latched onto her leg and quickly coiled around her, restricting her movement like a large snake would its prey.

The blonde woman walked forward with a determined look on her face. The vines brought her to eye level. When suddenly the woman turned towards the people and smiled like a kid in a candy store.

"We caught a horde soldier, and a Force Captain at that," she said taking the badge off her chest, "just imagine what She-Ra will say. This is definitely big news. We have to get her to Brightmoon immediately. She'll have so much information."

She tried to speak to the blonde woman but vines were covering her mouth, muffling any sound she could get out. Listening to the conversation going on in front of her she learned this woman was named Perfuma. She was also the princess of this forest, or something to that effect. Focusing back on herself for a moment, she became aware of how increasingly hard it was getting to stay awake. The princess Perfuma was so wrapped up in her speech that she didn't notice her captive slowly drifting into unconsciousness nor the blood leaking down the side of her head.

She opened her eyes and found herself in a hazy dark fog. The forest was gone, replaced by a road with street lights, shapes of skyscrapers and small buildings on both sides. Cars littered the road and shadows in the shape of people were everywhere. It smelled like junk food and gas. The sounds of people talking and cars honking filled her ears. The road stretched out in front of her leading to a glowing silhouette. Walking forwards there seemed to be something off about it. The street lights shifted until they were broken and crooked. Vines slowly crawled up the buildings. The windows shattered and broken glass littered the street.

'This looks like a city, maybe New York?' She thought to herself. Trying to concentrate only made things darker but the figure glowed even more brilliantly. It almost lit up the dark.

As she walked closer to the bright figure the scenery changed, slowly shifting to some sort of town. It looked to be an industrial-esque era mixed with a sci-fi element . There were pipes coming out of every building and it smelled like a factory. Oil and burning fumes filled the air. The sounds of power tools, metal working, and . . .marching?

As she walked closer to the figure, shadows appeared more frequently. These ones in a formation. They walked with purpose and in sync. 'Soldiers' She thought to herself.

She could almost make out features of the bright figure. But the one that stood out the most was that it was a woman. As she approached the end of the shadowy town, she noticed that the environment changed again. This time the pipes and buildings fell away, replaced by trees and forest.

'Guess I'm back here, huh?' She thought tiredly. Walking through the forest she realized it was the same spot she had woken up before. Looking around she noticed a few differences. For one the animals were all just shadows now, There was no river, just a dark crack stretching through the ground, and that it smelled like smoke. Suddenly the figure moved, turning and running through the dark fog, beckoning her to follow.

She quickly gave chase intent on finding out what was going on. Slowly closing the distance she took notice of the bright blue opal-shaped gemstone on the figure's chest. The figure stopped about 50 feet away. She slowly turned her face towards her, the light becoming brighter. The shadows were vanishing around them. But the light was becoming too much, too bright. She couldn't focus and it was starting to hurt. Blinding pain shot through her body. She couldn't breathe and it was getting worse.

"Remember." The voice filled her ears, stabbing through her mind like a knife. Remember, the word kept repeating in her mind, filling her entire being.

"Remember what? You're not making any sense!" She cried out, tears falling from her face, her eyes clenched shut. The pain was almost becoming too much to bear. If it didn't stop soon she felt she would surely die.

Another word rang out through the pain. "Catra," it said. Suddenly she was yanked off her feet. The word kept getting louder and the figure wouldn't stop repeating the word.

"Catra, CaTRA, CATRA" It slowly became louder and louder. Suddenly. . ..

Her eyes snapped open and she immediately turned to the side and threw up. Her head was throbbing and everything was too loud. A hand holding a glass of water appeared in her vision. Immediately grabbing the glass, she drank it one drink.

"Ugh, what the fuck," she muttered to herself. She went to look around but the lights were too bright. She shut her eyes when she finally took notice of the woman in front of her. She had been saying something but had been cut off by her less than stellar display.

"Catra, are you alright?" The woman spoke softly, her voice gentle and soothing.

Looking up at the woman she noticed a few things. She looked to be around 18 years old. She had sandy blonde hair and blue eyes. Her hair was in a ponytail and had some weird floof thing going on. 'It looks a little dumb to be honest,' she thought to herself. She wore a red jacket with a white long sleeve shirt underneath and gray pants with red and white boots. She also had this weird double belt aesthetic thing going on. Must be the latest fashion trend.

The thing that stood out the most was that her appearance put her at ease. Almost unnaturally so. Her face was one of concern. 'At least this blonde wasn't attacking her with sticks and vines,' she thought to herself.

"Yeah I'm fine, thanks for asking- wait, what did you call me?" She asked the woman. Immediately the look became a little more concerned. "I called you by your name, Catra. Don't you remember?" She asked a little panicked.

'Is that really my name? Catra? That seems kind of on the nose doesn't it, what with the cat ears, claws, and tail? Hmmm.' She pondered, staying silent a moment before looking at the woman.

"Listen, I'm sorry if we know each other, but I can't remember anything. Just bits and pieces." She said nonchalantly. She went to say something else before she was cut off by another voice. One that sounded particularly shrill.

"Oh please, Adora, she's obviously lying. I mean look at her. She just happens to wander into Plumeria, eat a poisonous pinkel, and then get captured by Perfuma, just to end up here without any memories? I don't think so. She failed at Salineas and now she's plotting to get back in the good graces of Hordak. It's so obvious it's almost funny." She turned to look at the speaker. It was a younger teenager. She appeared to be about 16 and was a little chubbier. She wore some weird purple jacket. . .cape thing and her hair was glittery, like sparkly.

The now named Adora spoke, "We don't know that Glimmer. Look at her, you saw the wounds on her. That wasn't some little bump on the head. There was a lot of blood." She said in a worried tone.

The now named girl, Glimmer, looked at her with a scathing glare. "Fine, but until we know for certain she's staying in the containment spell. Mom will set it up." With her piece said, she turned and stormed out of the room.

Turning to look back at Adora she went to say something when, all of a sudden, a tall, attractive woman came striding into the room. She had pink hair that framed her face nicely and stretched to her mid back, along with piercing dark eyes. She had on a pair of white teardrop earrings and another gem on her forehead. Her necklace also consisted of these teardrop gems. She wore a pink outfit and gray pants and purple boots along with a blue cape that draped off of her shoulders and wore a purple belt. Along her back were gorgeous shimmering wings. They were transparent with a sheen to them. All in all, this woman had to be the most gorgeous person she had met thus far. She also realized this must be the pink haired girl's mother.

'So I am dead. The angel confirmed it. That means the sparkly girl must be a baby angel. Pfft, that's hilarious. Huh, weird, I figured heaven would be more "pearly gates and harps" and less "You are condemned until we prove you're not a horrible person".

She was broken from her thoughts by a sharp voice. "Are you listening to me, Horde soldier?" The woman's gaze was piercing and sharp, an Ice queen if she ever saw one.

"Ummmm, I'm sorry, could you repeat that? I'm still a bit out of it." She asked sheepishly. The woman eyed her for a moment taking in the bandages around her head and body, before turning towards Adora.

"You know this girl, yes? I assume this is the infamous Catra?" She spoke in a kind of judging tone, like she had already decided what type of person she was.

"Yes Queen Angella, I grew up with Catra. I know her. If we just give her a bit to get her bearings I'm sure she'll be cooperative. From what Perfuma told us she didn't attack anyone while she was in Plumeria. I don't think she's lying. She's acting differently, like she doesn't know me. If we can help her, maybe we can show her how bad the Horde is, like you all did for me." Adora says with a hopeful, if not slightly desperate, tone.

The woman glances back towards the amnesic girl. Regarding her coldly, she ruffles her wings and speaks in a commanding tone that leaves no room for arguments. "Your friend has vouched for you. If what she says is true and you truly do not have any memory of your life then you have nothing to be worried for. But if you are lying, know that it will not end well for you. Until further notice, you will remain in the Brightmoon prison. Castaspella will arrive within the week. She will prove whether or not you're lying." Standing back up she takes a glance towards Adora and takes her out of the room.

Alone for the moment she gathers her thoughts. 'My name is Catra? And I've known this person, Adora, for a while. Does everyone lose their memories when they die?' She mulled these things over for the better part of half an hour. SHe was practicing saying the name, testing how it sounded to hear. It felt like it was right but wrong at the same time. It was a weird feeling. She stood up and stretched, noticing the throbbing in her head was almost completely gone. As she went to walk out of the room, becoming quite bored over the last hour, a flash of pink sparkles filled her vision, startling her quite a bit causing her to jump back a few feet. In front of her was the sparkly teenager from earlier.

"Where do you think you're going, Horde scum?" The pink haired girl said in an accusatory tone. Looking at the girl, she said the first thing that came to mind.

"I got bored. I was going to go find the blonde girl. Adora, I think her name was," Looking at her for a second she asked a question that had popped into her mind, "Why don't you have wings but your mom does?" She asked curiously. As soon as she asked that, the teen's face turned a shade of pink and a look of indignation crossed her face.

"I have wings! They're just not grown yet. And for your information, Adora is busy. She's trying to lessen your sentence. I don't know why. But either way, you should be grateful to her. If it were up to me we'd lock you up and throw away the key" She said with a glare.

"So you're a cherub? That's hilarious," she laughed out loud, "from henceforth I name thee Cherub, first of her name. The pink haired girl kept getting angrier and angrier.

She looked about ready to strangle her. "What is a Cherub? Some kind of Horde insult?" She asked angrily.

Her laughter dying down, she looked at her confused. "What do you mean ' what's a cherub'? You're a cherub, a baby angel. An angel who doesn't have their wings yet," seeing her expression turning angrier by the moment, she went to calm her down. "Sorry if I made you angry. I'd imagine that's a sensitive subject for you. Let's start over. According to that Adora girl, my name is Catra,what's yours? " She asked apologetically, holding her hand out.

The sparkly teen regarded her cooly for a moment, looking at her hand suspiciously. Not sure what the intentions were she looked at her for a moment before speaking.

"My name is Glimmer, not Cherub, and my mom and I aren't literal angels, we just have wings. Just stay here for a little while. I'll go get Adora and tell her you want to talk to her." Glimmer said, ignoring the hand, not quite sure what to make of the cat girl in front of her. With that being said, the girl vanished in a flash of sparkles.

'Hm, she seems alright, I suppose. If not a little standoffish. And what's with the "Horde this and Horde that?"' She thought to herself as she laid back down on the bed. Thoughts filled her head regarding Glimmer's statement about angels.

'If she's not a real angel and neither is her mom, then where am I? Am I really dead and on that matter who exactly is Catra to these people? Adora seems to care a great deal, but on the other hand, Glimmer seems to dislike Catra immensely. If I really am Catra and not someone they've mistaken for her, then why do I know these things about Earth? Because last I checked Magic wasn't real. I doubt anyone here has any knowledge about it. I

suppose I'll ask Adora about it when comes back." She thought with a pondering look on her face. Looking around the room, she could now see everything that it had to offer.

A vanity sat against the wall and another doorway that looked to be a bathroom. There were several open door frames that led outside that would never hold the wind back. It was a dumb design in her opinion. What if it snowed, or rained, or any bad weather in general? Disregarding the thought she took notice it was well into the night.

'If everyone is still up I must be a pretty big deal.' She pondered, looking out over the kingdom, noting the absence of stars once again.

Some crystals floated in the air and a bell sat near the bed, a dresser with teacups on it, and more crystals floating by the bed. The bed did not match the rest of the room. While everything else looked extravagant the bed looked flat and harsh. It was almost military. The type of bed you would find in barracks. It was a good bed. It also had one of those curtains that hang around royalty beds. There was also a desk. But what really caught her eye was the waterfall and . . .pool pond thing? Eh, who cares, whatever it was, she needed a good bath. Ignoring the waterfall for a moment, she noticed how stiff she was.

She stood up and took a second to stretch. A sort of sparking pain shot through her thigh and upper shoulder. Wincing, she rubbed her shoulder and thigh slowly, working the knots out of her body. Suddenly, her hand got caught on the sheet. As she went to get it off she saw, upon closer inspection, that her claws had caught it. She hadn't quite figured out the whole cat physiology yet, but seeing how she was alone, now was as good a time as any.

As soon as she went to remove the blanket, it was torn to shreds. Pulling her hands back, she marveled at her claws in awe. Looking at the bed curtain, she reached out and raked her hand down it. The curtain was shredded with ease, but she paid it no mind, what she did give attention to was how nice it felt. It was almost

like her fingertips were stretched out. Standing up, she looked at the curtain and this time gripping it with both hands, she took a step back and dug her feet into the marble floor and arched her back, allowing every part of her body to feel it. The curtain stood no chance against iit's feline foe. Within minutes, it was reduced to ribbons. Unfortunately, the floor also had been damaged. Not realizing just how sharp her claws were, had gouged several slashes in the marble.

Feeling a lot better, she went towards the waterfall and reached out for the water. She immediately recoiled, pulling her arm back to her side. The water was almost ice cold. There was probably something around here to change the temperature of it somewhere, but she could find no thermostat or water heater anywhere. Shrugging she walked towards the door to the left. Her suspicions were proven right.

It was indeed a bathroom. It had beautiful tapestry hanging from the wall, a mirror hung above the sink, and the bathtub was built into the floor and it had a window directly beside it that gave her a marvelous view of the kingdom. It was quite enticing with many types of soaps and fragrances. Walking towards the closet, she opened it to find candles and incense sticks. There was also what looked to be a perfume bottle beside them. Picking it up she realized it was some sort of lighter.

"Oh yeah, this is exactly what I need." She said to herself. Turning the water on to an acceptable temperature of almost too hot, she grabbed some towels, several candles, crushed the incense sticks into dust, and closed the door. As the water slowly filled the tub, she lit the candles and sprinkled the dust into them. Looking at the soaps, she found several to her liking and poured a few drops into the water.

Stripping out of her clothes, she took a second to look at her body in the mirror. The reflection that stared back had tan skin with a very athletic build with very fine fur encompassing her entire body. She had sharp features, such as her pointed chin, a straight nose, and slanted piercing eyes. Her eyes caused her to stop for a

moment and focus solely on them. They were sharp and very focused, with one eye being yellow and the other being a light shade of blue. Taking in the rest of her features showed she had freckles and soft eyebrows and her mouth showed that she had small fangs . Her hair was wild and spiky, like it hadn't been brushed in days. And it stretched past her shoulders towards the middle of her shoulder blades. Her catlike ears were darker than her hair, with two tufts of light colored fur hanging below them.

On her hands and feet, she had dark claws that seemed to retract. She had a long cat tail that matched the color of her hair. On her arms, legs, and back she had several light brown stripes that somewhat resembled a tabby cat.

She took notice of the bit of blood that had matted her hair. Reaching up to touch the bloody spot, she winced. It didn't hurt very much but the pain was enough that she'd rather leave it be. Noticing the bath was high enough, she slowly stepped in, getting accustomed to the water temperature. After a minute, she laid back and let out a deep sigh. The stress of the last couple of hours catching up with her. Pushing the thoughts of whatever these people were planning for her away, she allowed herself to relax. The tension slowly left her body. A soft sound filled the air, breaking the silence.

'What's that sound,' she wondered to herself before realizing it was her who was making the sound. 'I'm purring? That's kinda cool, I guess.'

As Glimmer made her way towards the throne room she noticed Bow off to the side tinkering with his tracker pad. Teleporting beside him, he looked up at her, noticing the stoic look on her face.

"So, how did it go? Did you guys get anything out of her?" Bow asked, putting his tracker pad away.

"No, we got nothing. Catra says she doesn't remember anything at all. She apparently didn't even remember her own name until Adora told her it." Glimmer said with a huff. "And she called me a CHERUB!" She exclaimed in annoyance.

Bow raised an eyebrow at glimmer. "So what's the queen going to do then? Surely we can't just let her go. It's Catra, she's too valuable to the Horde."

"No, we're not letting her go. My mom is calling Aunt Castaspella to see if she can figure out what's going on with her. She'll tell us if she's lying and for her sake she better hope she isn't." Glimmer said with a determined look.

Bow looked at her with an inquisitive look. "What if she's telling the truth? What if she really can't remember anything?" He said.

Glimmer stopped for a moment and thought about it. What if she was telling the truth? What would that mean for the Horde? On another note, how would that affect Adora? She never talks about it but from what she could gather, Catra was very important to Adora. So much so that she didn't even want to think about what it would mean if she couldn't remember her. She already looked nervous when Catra said she didn't know her back in the bedroom.

Glimmer looked back up at Bow and answered with a quiet tone, "I don't know, we'll cross that bridge when we come to it. But Bow you should have seen Adora when Catra said she didn't remember her. She looked so shaken it was almost frightening." Glimmer went quiet for a moment before gaining a determined look on her face, "If she really can't remember anything then we,ve got to be there for her." She said with a resolute tone.

Bow nodded in agreement with her. He kind of understood where Adora's mind was at. He could only imagine if Glimmer forgot him and everything they'd been through. It would probably tear him apart inside.

"Come on, let's go find Adora. Last I checked she was with the queen." Bow said. As he started walking towards the throne room Glimmer fell into stride beside him. Two guards stood in the hallway on both sides of the hallway. As they reached the door they heard the voices of Queen Angela and Adora.

"How long will it take for this woman to arrive? I want to make sure she's ok." Adora said in a concerned tone. Angela turned towards Adora, an eyebrow raised.

"Answer me this, Adora; What exactly does this person mean to you? She wears Horde clothing and a Force Captain badge, yet you say she will cooperate. She showed a complete lack of respect towards me, but you defended her saying it was the injury. And now you are asking for her not to be put in a cell. You may be She-Ra, but understand that my patience has limits, as do your privileges. So I want you to tell me who this person is and what she means to you." Angela said, her voice brimming with authority.

"Wait, I want to hear this, Adora hardly ever talks about Catra." Glimmer said, grabbing Bow's outstretched arm. Even the guards looked invested in the conversation, interested in the prospect of gossip. Bow turned to look at Glimmer's expectant look and sighed. Leaning against the door Glimmer, Bow, and the two guards listened intently, awaiting Adora's response.

A moment of silence passed before a sigh was heard, "It's hard to put into words. She's always been there. The one person I could count on. From the time when we were little kids to the moment I met Glimmer and Bow in the whispering woods. She knows me better than anyone and I know her just as well. We always had each other's backs. When I found the sword she covered for me. We would tell each other secrets and train together and. . .. Look, she means a lot to me, and if she can't remember anything," Adora's voice cracked, "well then I need to help her. Can't you understand that?"

There was no noise for several moments, until finally Queen Angela's voice broke through the silence, "Oh Adora, I understand. I really do," she spoke in a soft tone. Letting out a soft sigh she spoke, "Castaspella will be here within two days. I cannot put the kingdom in danger, Catra will have to remain in the cell until she arrives," Adora went to speak before being cut off by Angela, "But know this, If Catra is telling the truth. If she truly remembers nothing, she can stay with you in your room. You will be fully responsible for her actions. Be aware that this only applies if she is telling the truth about her memory. If she is lying then she will remain in the cells. Do we understand each other, Adora?" Angella asked.

"Yes, Queen Angella. Thank you." Adora said in a grateful voice.

"Good, now that we have taken care of that, perhaps we should go get her from your room. And my daughter and guard can stop eavesdropping?" She questioned in a matter-of-fact tone, opening the door, as she stared down at them with an expectant look.

Giving sheepish smiles, the guards went back to their posts and Glimmer and Bow stood up straight.

"Hi mom, how are you doing?" Glimmer said with a nervous grin. Angela looked at her like she would if she had caught her stealing a cookie before dinner.

"I know I have told you before that eavesdropping is incredibly rude, Glimmer." She said in a motherly tone as Bow fiddled with his tracker pad, whistling, looking anywhere but forwards.

"We weren't eavesdropping per say, we just happened to hear the conversation through this door. We thought it would be rude to interrupt, so we decided to wait." Glimmer spoke in a way that showed she was trying to get out of whatever trouble she may currently have gotten herself into.

Angella's face showed she was not too impressed by the excuse. "Hmm, yes, well come along. Let us go retrieve Catra," turning to

face one of the guards, she spoke, "Guard, go retrieve some spare clothes. I doubt Catra would like to wear those filthy rags that the Horde calls clothes."

As Angela walked forwards through the hall, Adora looked down at her clothes, then glanced at Glimmer and Bow, "What's wrong with my clothes?"

Glimmer and Bow gave a sheepish smile before ushering Adora along towards her room. As they were walking Adora turned towards Glimmer with a look that seemed full of thought.

"Please tell me you took the blankets and curtains down like I asked you, Glimmer?" Adora asked, her tone filled with desperation. Glimmer's stride slightly faltered as she turned to look at her. Glimmer didn't need to answer the question, her face said it all.

"Now that I think about it, that may have slipped my mind, but I'm sure they're fine, though. But if, let's say, I had forgotten them, what would be the worst thing that could happen?" Glimmer asked with a wince.

"Oh nooo," Adora quickened her stride past Queen Angela and her guards, almost jogging down the hall. As they reached the door, Adora opened the door to find her room in shambles. The curtain that hung around her bed was in tatters, her sheets ripped to shreds, and there was pillow fluff everywhere. The marble floor even had gouges in them, as if a very sharp blade had sliced through the stone. Catra was nowhere to be found.

Adora let out a groan of exasperation, "I should have known the curtains and sheets were too irresistible to her."

The door opened behind Adora announcing the queen's arrival. Angela looked around the room in disdain. Her eyes focused mainly on the scratches in the marble floor.

"Hmm, well I suppose the damage could have been worse. Where is your friend, then, Adora." Angela asked with slight amusement

at the sight of Adora balking at her room's state.

Adora stood up straighter and looked around, examining the trail of blanket fuzz leading into her bathroom. "I'd imagine she's in the bathroom."

Adora walked up to the door and knocked. "Catra, are you in there?" Adora waited for a response, but got nothing back. Looking back at Angella, Bow, and Glimmer, she asked them to wait there for a moment, "Catra, I'm coming in."

Stepping into the bathroom, Adora immediately took notice of Catra. She was in the bathtub, steam slowly rising off of the water, drifting across the floor. The candles illuminated the dark bathroom, giving it a sort of magical glow. It also smelled nice in the bathroom, almost relaxing. Catra laid against the back of the tub, her head tilted back, taking deep slow breaths. The light from the moons and candles kissed her skin, illuminating every curve and contour of her neck and shoulders. Water ran down her collarbone and through her breasts. Her body was hidden just below the water, barely hiding her breasts. The view was almost erotic in nature.

Adora felt a heat crawl up her body and to her face. Taking a deep breath and steeling herself she walked over to Catra.

"Catra, are you awake?" Adora asked her, keeping her gaze solely on her face.

Catra let out a deep sigh and without opening her eyes, spoke, "Yes, I am awake. Did you need something?"

Adora slightly frowned, "If you were awake then why didn't you answer when we called you through the door? I know your hearing is much better than mine and I can easily hear through that door."

Catra opened her eyes and stared right at Adora with a mischievous smirk. "I don't know. There could be several reasons, maybe I wanted to enjoy my bath in peace. Maybe I wanted to

have a bit of time to myself to sort through my thoughts before the angel put me in the 'Brightmoon Prison,'" her tone turned sour for a second before Catra leaned forwards, the smirk returning to her face and a good portion of water spilling onto the floor, "or maybe I just wanted you in here with me, alone."

Adora cleared her throat, shuffling in place a bit. Her face quickly turning a shade of red. Adora had never been more thankful for the dark room then now. "Well, whichever reason it was, we need to talk to you. We'll have plenty of time to talk alone later. . . when you're wearing clothes. I'll be outside the door, so get dressed. I brought you some clean clothes to wear."

As Adora left the room Catra's gaze never left her form. Humming in slight displeasure, she went to pull the plug on the water. Stepping out of the water she grabbed the towel and quickly dried herself off. Wrapping the towel around herself she went to grab the clothes when her ear twitched, picking up the speech on the other side of the door. Stepping closer to the door, she listened, wondering what they were talking about.

"Why is your face red, Adora?" That had to be Glimmer, her voice had a distinct pitch.

"No reason, look she'll be outside in a moment. So let's give her a minute and then we can talk about what has to happen as we wait for your. . . friend?" Adora said confused.

"She's my aunt." Glimmer said. A moment of silence passed before another distinctly male voice she hadn't heard before, spoke. "You do know what an aunt is, right, Adora?"

"Pshh, of course I know what an aunt is, it's. . . yeah, I don't," Adora's voice took a sheepish tone, "I figured someone would just tell me."

A melodic giggle filled the air and then Angela spoke up, "An aunt is your parents sister. In Castaspella's case she is my sister

through marriage. She was King Micah's sister by blood," Angella explained.

"Ohhh, okay, I think I understand. Yeah we didn't have those in the Horde. We had-" Adora suddenly cut herself off, silence filling the air.

Catra leaned in closer, wondering if they had walked out of the door, when suddenly Adora's voice came through the door much, much, much louder. "Catra, stop eavesdropping!"

As she flinched away from the door, she bumped into the dresser holding the candles and soaps. Stumbling away from the dresser, she slipped on the soapy water covering the floor. Trying to regain her footing had the unfortunate consequence of leaving gashes in the marble floor. Reaching out for something to catch herself, she gripped the dresser with her claws, leaving gashes in the door. This, unfortunately, had the outcome of breaking one of the hinges and knocking everything out of it. Quickly looking around at the mess of broken wood, scattered bottles and candles, and a soaking wet clawed bathroom floor, she quickly panicked.

"Shit, shit, shit," she whispered. Looking around for somewhere to put everything, She swiftly gathered the bottles and candles over the scratched floor and threw the towels over it all. Straightening the dresser door as best she could, she grabbed her clothes. "I wasn't eavesdropping," she said to the door, throwing the weird robe clothing on.

Adora's voice came through the door again, her tone somewhat smug, "Sure you weren't."

As she went to leave the bathroom, she turned and looked at the bathroom. Her pile of old clothing and towels hid the bottles and candles, as well as covered her scratches. The dresser also wasn't noticeable until you got really close to it. If one didn't know better, they would say it's a normal bathroom.

Nodding to herself she walked out. Angella, Glimmer, and a dark skinned boy with a cutoff shirt that showed his midriff, all looked towards the door as she walked out. Looking around she noticed Adora leaning against the wall with a slight smirk on her face.

A spike of annoyance shot through Catra at the sight. Narrowing her eyes she looked at Adora, "What are you smiling about?" She said to the blonde.

"Nothing, just a heads up, eavesdropping is bad," Adora said with a teasing tone.

Catra gasped with mock exuberance, "Why thank you Adora, I never would have guessed that it was bad. Thank you for this enlightening piece of advice. I shall treasure it always," sarcasm dripping from her tone.

Adora snorted a bit, "You're such a dork," Catra slightly smiled before turning towards everyone else in the room.

"So, now what? Do I have to go sit in a cell until this Castaspella person arrives?" Catra asked in a flat tone. Angella regarded her for a moment, scanning her up and down.

"Yes," Angella spoke in a tone of finality, "You will sit in the brightmoon prison until she can prove that you are telling the truth. . . and maybe she can find out why it is that you have lost her memories."

Catra pondered her words for a few seconds in silence before speaking, "If I'm going to be sitting in a cell for several days can I get some clothes that are more comfortable? Not trying to be rude, but these clothes kind of suck."

Catra eyed Adora for a moment. "Just give me some of her clothes. Those look like they'd fit better."

"Hm, If she wants to give you some of her clothes, that is Adora's choice. You are in no position to make demands." Angella said coolly. Catra let out a noise of indignation, "Well, excuse me,"Your

Highness" I was asking, not *demanding* as you so put it," Catra said, mocking her accent. "Such a lowly peasant as myself would never dream of demanding anything of you." Catra said, glaring at the angel.

Angela's eyes narrowed, "You will watch your tone. You are in my kingdom and I will not tolerate disrespect, especially from a Horde soldier. Adora has vouched for you. She truly believes that you don't remember anything. But to the contrary, according to Glimmer's accounts, you are acting exactly as she remembers."

Catra's glare matched the queen's as she spoke. "I don't give a shit what your little daughter thinks, or Adora for that matter. I just met you all like an hour ago. If you think even for a second that I recognize your authority, then you've got another thing coming. And whatever this "Horde" that everyone keeps talking about is, they can go fuck themselves. I want nothing to do with you or your stupid castle."

The intensity in her words had slipped into her appearance. Her claws had come out and her pupils were constricted to slits, her tail swaying aggressively. Angella and Catra glared at each other before Adora and Bow stepped between them.

"Alright, I think we should all take a breather. It's been a stressful evening and maybe we all just need a second to cool down." Bow said calmly, trying to deescalate the situation. Adora had stepped in front of Catra trying to calm her down.

"Oh I was pretty relaxed until some blonde forest hippie decided I stole her fruit. How about you put me back in the forest, huh? That way I don't have to look at this bitch!" Catra exclaimed.

Glimmer whirled on Catra, "Don't talk to my mom that way! You should be thankful that you're even standing here. She healed you when you decided to eat a poisonous fruit like an idiot." She said teleporting past Bow.

Catra turned her aggression towards Glimmer. Shoving Adora out of the way, she got right in her face.

"Well maybe you should have left me there. If I'm such a horrible, fucking, person then maybe you should have left me to die. But noooo, you had to help this idiot," Catra points at Adora, "get her little friend back."

"Oh believe me, I would have been all too happy to leave you there. It wouldn't have bothered me in the slightest." Glimmer yelled. Bow, Adora, and Angela watched the argument unfold, all three of them forgotten.

"Let me ask you something. If what I'm understanding is right, she was in the Horde with me, so if she left me behind, then why the fuck should I care what she thinks? And for that matter, why the fuck would you care?" Catra, shoved a finger into Glimmer's chest. "You just want to shove me in a cell and throw away the key. All over something I couldn't give a damn about." Catra said, throwing her hands up in anger. Glimmer looked about ready to hit Catra, her hands clenched into fists, glowing magic radiating off of them.

As the argument got progressively worse Bow, Angela, and Adora noticed something. Catra's body was starting to glow. It seemed to be interacting with Glimmer's magic. Neither of the girls had seemed to notice it either. The guards looked at their queen, shuffling, unsure of what they should do.

"Glimmer, you need to calm down." Bow yelled, trying to break the fight up. Adora went to step forward as well when Catra turned on her, "Stay out of this!"

"Do you think that I would willingly come here? This place is shit and its people are even shittier. I can't imagine why anyone would join you," Glimmer went to interrupt when she noticed that Catra was bleeding from her nose. And glowing. "Catra, wait a second-" Catra cut Glimmer off.

"No you wait, I'm not finished." Her breaths were becoming shallow and her ears were leaking blood. Concern flew across the faces of everyone in the room. "I'm so…I'm so sick of this place. You all are…all are…ugh," Catra couldn't quite focus everything seemed so blurry. And the immense pain in the back of her head had come back. She seemed to be losing the strength in her body.

Glimmer went to grab her shoulder but she shoved her away. "I don't…need…your help…Sparkles," Catra was struggling to breathe, now. Taking breaths but getting no air.

She couldn't quite hear anymore, It sounded like rushing water in her ears, wind? Something like that. Somewhere along the line she had fallen. It was too bright, but dark at the same time. There were several figures leaning over her and someone had picked her up.

'If I wasn't dead before," Catra thought, her consciousness fading, "I'm sure I will be shortly."

Chapter 2

The morning rays peeked through the windows, washing over Angella as she strode through the main hall. It had been several hours since Catra had collapsed and Adora had not left her side. Bow and Glimmer had brought her breakfast but she hadn't really touched it beyond a couple of bites.

Catra looked worse than when she had arrived in Brightmoon. Her face had lost a lot of color and her breathing was shallow and shaky. Her fur had lost its natural shine. Angella would think she was looking at a corpse if not for her shallow breaths.

As she looked at Adora, Angella felt only sympathy for her. She had seen that look more than she cared to admit. She had worn it herself on a few occasions, especially when Micah had been involved. She had, admittedly, lost her temper towards the bedridden girl and felt a little responsible about her current state.

She had asked Bow to send word to Castaspella to hasten her arrival. She had been told by Bow that she could be there within the day. Angella put a comforting hand on Adora's shoulder.

"I have sent word to Castaspella and she will be here within the day. Have faith that your friend will be okay." She squeezed her shoulder, sending her a hopeful smile. Adora smiled a small smile and nodded, looking back at Catra's lying form.

Angella and Adora looked up as a flash of sparkles revealed Bow and Glimmer. Glimmer stepped towards Adora, a sorrowful look on her face, "Adora, I'm so sorry. If I hadn't-" Adora raised her hand, stopping her from saying anything else.

"It wasn't you Glimmer. I don't blame you. Whatever did this to Catra happened before we found her." Adora said kindly to Glimmer. Bow stepped forward looking at Catra.

"Any ideas what could have done this, Adora? You grew up with Catra, do you have anything that could help us get to the bottom of this?" Bow asked. Adora was silent for a few moments before her face turned dark.

"I have an idea who could have done it and she better hope I'm wrong." Adora growled out. Angella spoke up with curiosity, "Who, Adora?"

"Shadow Weaver." Adora said, her tone filled with a bit of bite. Adora turned and looked at her friends.

"Shadow Weaver was our handler. She taught us how to be Horde soldiers since we were little," Adora went to say something else but Glimmer interrupted, "So she was like your mom?"

Adora gave her a look of confusion, "No, didn't you just hear what I said? She was our handler, she taught us to read and write and how to tie our shoes. She-" Adora stopped and thought about it for a moment before Glimmer cut in, "Yeah, those are mom things."

Adora kind of groaned, "Yeah, I guess so. But she wasn't like your mother," Adora said, turning to Angella. "She was manipulative and took any chance to berate Catra. Always using her as a scapegoat whenever I failed. The only time she was kind was when she needed something." A dark look passed over Angella's face as Adora continued. "She would manipulate, berate, and hurt Catra and I. Sometimes physically, though more often than not it would be verbal."

Adora paused as if she was reliving something horrible. Adora said the next thing much quieter, "But she reserved something horrible for Catra. She would use magic on her. She wouldn't use it on anyone else though, only using it on Catra to show us what would happen to us if we got out of line or. . .other reasons. It was horrible and we were all too scared to do anything." Adora let out a deep breath, unclenching her fists, "Catra got pretty good at avoiding her, only showing up at meetings or important debriefs."

"That is not a mother. That is a sick, twisted, and vile woman. A mother is supposed to care for her children, raise them up, teach them to be better than themselves and teach them right from wrong. Not hit and berate them until they listen." Angella looked livid. Her wings rustled and her fists were clenched with restrained fury. "What you went through is abuse, Adora."

Adora looked at Angella for a moment before shifting her focus back on Catra. "I know and so does Catra. I know she realizes how horrible the Horde was, so why did she choose to stay there? Why didn't she come with me at Thaymor? The worst part is that I can't ask her because she can't even remember my name." Adora said, sounding defeated.

Glimmer and Bow remained silent, thinking about everything that was just told to them before Bow spoke up. "Adora, I think that the way you were treated is the reason she didn't leave." Adora and Glimmer looked dumbfounded while Angella looked like she was thinking. Bow raised his hands in front of himself before they could ask him what he meant.

"Let me explain. You said that you and Catra grew up together, that you had each other's backs. You also said Catra was the main victim of this abuse from Shadow Weaver. I think she felt that if she left with you that it would make what she went through all for nothing. Do you get what I'm saying?" Bow asked, a thoughtful look on his face.

Adora thought about it before shaking her head. "That doesn't make any sense though. Catra constantly said she wanted Shadow Weaver gone. She would say when we were in charge nobody could tell us what to do. She knew the Horde was bad and chose to stay.

"If Catra really felt that way she would have told me. We were always around each other and told each other everything. She wouldn't keep something like that from me. She wouldn't." Adora said with a hint of desperation in her voice. As if she needed that to be true.

Angella rested her hand on Adora's shoulder, giving a comforting squeeze. "If that is how Catra really felt then perhaps that is the exact reason she didn't tell you Adora." Adora looked up at Angella with confusion.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked.

"Sometimes it isn't easy to talk about things with the people you love, especially if it regards your feelings toward that person. You think about what they will think or say to you. How they will judge you. It's sometimes hard to talk about your feelings with the people closest to you because you hold their opinion in high regard.

"If Catra really felt in such a way perhaps she was scared of what you would say. If she had said that at that moment, what would you have said?" Adora stayed silent, thinking about Angella's words. "When we are in such a hurry that we are only focused on the picture in front of us, it can be hard to remember that we have to focus on the smaller details as well.

"In that moment, when you chose to help the rebellion and betray the Horde, Catra most likely felt betrayed as well. That you had invalidated her and her feelings. Do you understand what I'm saying, Adora?" Angella asked with a soft voice.

Adora nodded after a moment of silence. "I think I do. Catra felt betrayed and I didn't give her feelings any thought." Adora said quietly before her face turned sorrowful. "But now she can't even remember who I am, who she was, or any of our experiences together. What if she-" Adora was cut off

"She called me Sparkles." Glimmer said loudly. Adora looked at her in confusion, the quiet atmosphere shattered.

"What does that have anything to do with Catra?" Angella asked. Bow's face lit up in realization.

"Catra didn't call Glimmer anything except her name since she met her. But before she passed out she Called her Sparkles. Catra

never called Glimmer anything except Sparkles before today. Meaning that if her memories are really gone then there's a chance-"

"They could come back." A voice said from the doorway, cutting Bow off. Everyone turned to look at the person entering the room. There, a woman with sharp, angular features stood in the doorway. She had long black hair tied into a bun with two long strands hanging from the sides of her face. She wore a long purple dress with golden accents and a light pink cape. Atop her head sat a golden crown resembling that of a halo with a star in the center.

"Castaspella," Angella spoke with slight confusion in her voice, "It's only been 2 hours since I sent word. Why have you come so quickly?"

Castaspella looked at the unconscious form of Catra. "When you sent a message explaining that someone may be lying about amnesia, I figured that a simple truth spell would do the trick," Castaspella said, walking towards them, "but then you sent another message saying that she had collapsed and that she may be in critical condition." She turned to look at Angella.

"When she fell unconscious was she in an argument or fight, perhaps? Glowing and bleeding from her mouth, nose, ears, or eyes?"

Angella nodded, "Yes those symptoms all seemed to happen. Though, I don't believe she was bleeding from her eyes." Angella finished looking towards Catra. Castaspella went to speak before she was cut off by Adora.

"Do you know what's happening to her? Can you fix it? Is she going to be okay?" Adora asked with urgency, not giving anyone a chance to speak. Castaspella held up her hand, silencing Adora.

"Please slow down a bit. It's a little hard to answer a question when several are shoved in your face." Castaspella said.

"Sorry," Adora said with an apologetic look, "I'm just really worried. I've never seen Catra like this before. I just want to know what's going on." Castaspella gave a reassuring smile. As she leaned over and examined Catra, she opened her eyes and examined her pupils, like a doctor might. She moved her head side to side and checked behind her ears, running a glowing hand down her forehead. She stopped after several moments and turned back to everyone.

"When you found her did she say anything about a place called Earth? Did her mannerisms change at all? Perhaps she thought she was dead?" Looking towards Glimmer and Angella, "Did she make a mention of angels at all? Or say any strange things that did not make sense? Maybe a personality shift?"

Everyone sat quietly for a moment, thinking about what had transpired over the last couple of hours, when Glimmer spoke, "She called me a cherub. She said it was a baby angel and she was pretty adamant about mom and I being actual angels," Castaspella hummed at that, looking as if she was figuring something out.

"She's cussing a lot more than normal." Adora's voice cutting through the silence. "Even when we were in training with Shadow Weaver, Catra rarely cussed. She also acted a bit strange, like she wasn't herself." Castaspella's face turned dark at the mention of Shadow Weaver.

"You know Shadow Weaver?" Castaspella asked quietly, contemplating something.

Adora nodded her head, "Yeah, she was our handler. She taught us how to fight and be soldiers." Adora said cautiously, "Why, do you know her? Do you think she did this?" Catra finished with a spark of anger in her voice.

Castaspella stayed silent, looking between Catra, Glimmer, Adora, and Angella. Suddenly her look turned bright as she clapped her hands together.

"Well, I have several good news and slightly bad news." Castaspella said with a beaming smile, making everyone go to speak at once. Before the jumbled speech could become too loud, Castaspella held up her hands once more, quieting everyone down.

Turning to Angella, she motioned towards Catra, "You were worried that she was lying about her memories and it was a Horde trick. I can, with 100 percent certainty, safely say that this girl remembers nothing."

Turning towards Adora, she gave a reassuring smile, "Catra, that was her name yes?" Adora nodded, "Catra will be fine. I know exactly what has happened to her and it has happened several times before. Good news is it has never resulted in a death. Slightly bad news is that you were correct. Catra has no memories of her past or who she is for that matter."

Adora's face fell before Castaspella spoke again, "But that doesn't mean she can't regain her memories. Glimmer, you were right. If she had been calling you something different this entire time, only to call you by a previous title she had used definitely confirms it. If you are patient with her and help her, well she should have most of her memories back in no time."

Adora's face morphed from a look of sadness to one of determination. With mostly everyone's worries abated, it looked to be the end of the discussion before Bow spoke up, "If you know what it is that did this, then what happened to her and *did* Shadow Weaver do it?"

Castaspella shook her head, "No, Shadow Weaver didn't do this. No, what caused this was a soul crystal."

"What is a soul crystal?" Glimmer asked, voicing everyone's thoughts.

"Oh, I've heard of these," Bow said with excitement, "The most common way you find them is as a shard, though there have been

reports of other forms as well. But I think those lack credibility. They have a large sum of knowledge and history inside of them. They're very rare and aren't technically magic. They should all be locked up though, shouldn't they?"

Castaspella smiled at his words, "Yes, Bow is right. While they aren't technically magic, they do possess the intense prowess of a spell. They are typically stored away as they almost alway cause severe amnesia and in some cases more severe results. If a person under the crystal's influence touches another shard, well. . . it's best that they don't. Most scholars believe they are Eternian in nature. But the real purpose of them is unknown to anyone. Sometimes you get mumblings about Earth and other times. . .well other times, inflictions of madness can occur."

An uncomfortable silence filled the air at that statement, before Castaspella cleared her throat, changing the subject, "If even the most powerful sorcerers on Etheria couldn't figure them out then I highly doubt Shadow Weaver could either. In fact I'm wondering how Catra got one of them. They should all be locked away in Mystacor. Do you have it on hand? It should be a little blue shard."

Adora shook her head, "No, but maybe Perfuma does. She is the one that found Catra." Adora got a panicked look on her face, "What if Perfuma picks it up? Oh no, we have to-"

"Oh, don't worry about that. The stones can't affect princesses. Something about their connection to their runestones. In fact, they can only affect people with some sort of magical aptitude. The less magic, the quicker the recovery. If you are more magically attuned, like myself for example, well that's when you get the more troublesome results."

Adora calmed down at that, lowering her head, lost in thought before flicking her head up, "You said these things are Eternian, right? So can I undo what it did to Catra? If it's Eternian in nature, maybe She-Ra can fix it." Castaspella raised an eyebrow at that as Adora went to grab a sword on the table to her left.

"I don't see what a mythical princess has anything to-" Castaspella was cut off as Adora lifted the sword above her head.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" A brilliant light lit up the room as Adora's form disappeared, instead replaced with the 8 foot tall woman that was She-Ra. Castaspella, to her credit, didn't miss a beat as she simply said "Oh."

Adora leaned down beside Catra before being stopped by Glimmer, "Adora, you still don't know how to heal people. Last time we tried you blew a hole into a tree."

"Excuse me, you did what?" Angella asked with her eyebrows raised. Bow made a shushing motion behind Angella towards Glimmer.

"Um, well what I meant to say was. . ." A bead of sweat rolled down Glimmer's face. Angella simply sighed, "We'll talk about that later, for now let's focus on Catra."

They all focused on Adora as she put the sword beside Catra's body, "Maybe I couldn't heal last time because I wasn't emotionally invested. She-Ra's powers work through feeling and emotion. So maybe the reason I couldn't heal last time was because I was nervous?" Adora said, though it came off more as a question, "This time. . .this time, I know I can do it." She said in a quiet, but determined, voice.

Grass. Catra could feel it under her fingertips. It was soft, swaying in the gentle breeze. Laying there on the soft earth she could see the sky in front of her. Cobalt blue with feathery white clouds.

Sitting up she looked around. She didn't recognize her surroundings. In front of her are plains of green, sweeping over hills, patterns of light flowing across the grass, dancing to the wind. Getting to her feet she spins looking for anyone. But there is no one, just the oceans of unending green and blue.

Out of the corner of her eye she catches a glimpse of gray. Turning her head she sees a stone path that wasn't there before. Letting out a sigh, she begins walking towards it.

As she makes her way towards the path, she notices trees that weren't there before. When she looks away from the trees and back to the trail there are now stone pillars.

Stay on the trail.

'What. . .What is going on?' It's so hard to focus. Everytime she looks away, the trail stretches farther away. Focusing on the end of the trail, she begins to quicken her pace towards it until she is eventually running to it. As she runs, she notices that she is going up and that the trail is becoming steeper and steeper to the point she almost needs to climb. She tries to keep her focus on the path ahead as she is so close but has to look away for a handhold lest she fall.

Don't leave the trail.

"Hello?" She shouts at the void. Nobody answers. She continues to press forward, listening intently for the voice, 'Am I losing my mind?'

She hears rumbling and feels the ground rumble and shake. She whips her head back up and sees stairs. The path is no longer a flat stone trail but a staircase. Standing up straight she continues up the path, driven by something that she can't explain. She needs to know what is at the top. What is so important.

Everything had fallen away. The plains of green were gone and the sky had turned a brilliant red. The scenery was changing and she couldn't focus on anything but the path. She could only push forward.

Don't stop.

Whipping around, she looks for the source of the voice, "This isn't funny. Where are you?" Only silence answers her. She begins to

feel increasingly uncomfortable. As she turns to look down the stairs, there is nothing but darkness. Unending darkness. It was so unnatural. Like you could drown in it. Taking a shaky breath, she turns her focus back on the trail.

She realized as she looked away for a moment, that the path had not stretched. It had remained the same distance. As she takes a moment to breathe, she feels it. Something was pulling her, making it harder to climb. Well, she wasn't about to fall into that darkness. Steeling herself she ascended the stairs with renewed vigor.

Finally reaching the top, she was greeted to a sight that was almost surreal. Stone pillars led to a stone arch. But beyond it were birds that were whiter than snow. The fields of green that she had seen earlier were replaced by white billowing clouds. The sky was a symphony of colors. She didn't have the words to describe the beauty she was witnessing. Turning back to the stairs, she looked down. There was no trace of the darkness. Just the gorgeous sky all around her.

She still couldn't shake the feeling of unease in her stomach. Something was wrong, she just couldn't figure out what it was.

Cross the threshold.

As she neared the end of the path, a wall of sorts came into view. Almost like a mirror, she could see reflections. They were too blurry to make out any details, though. It stretched as far as she could see. It was like a wall of water. She could see her own reflection but it was rippling and it seemed almost transparent. The path continued forward through it. As she stretched her hand out towards it, her reflection became clearer, the details sharper, and the transparency to disappear. Taking a step away from it caused her reflection to send out a ripple across the wall. The wall shivered like a pond being struck by rain drops.

"Is this what you were talking about? Is this the threshold?" She asked to the void. Waiting for an answer, she spun around looking

at the birds. . .or lack of? 'Where the hell had everything gone?' Turning back around she immediately recoiled from the wall. There stood the figure from her dream.

Cross the Threshold.

Taking a small step forward, she could get a good look at the woman now. It was very blurry and she couldn't see her face. The woman had long flowing hair tied back into a ponytail and wore a golden crown with a red jewel in the center. She also wore armor on her shoulders. And there, from her chest, a brilliant blue light shined, lighting up the woman. It was almost too bright to look at. She held something in her hand. It had a golden glow to it and it appeared to be broken. The light was too much. She couldn't make out what it was.

Cross the threshold and find me. You must remember.

There was so much emotion in those words. It was hard to describe what she was feeling, but there was no denying the weight of the request. It was almost pleading. Stepping forward she went to reach out to the woman, "Where are you, what do I need to remember?" But it was too late the woman shimmered out of sight.

Letting out a growl of annoyance, she walks up to the wall. Swallowing her nervousness, she takes a steadying breath, "Okay, no biggie. I got this. Let's just walk into the wall of water." Taking a cautious step forward, she touches the wall and immediately all reflections but her own vanish. Her reflection loses all transparency and she can see herself with perfect clarity. She looks past her reflection, she can see a town of people. There seems to be a festival.

She looks back at her reflection and immediately is unnerved. Her reflection is smiling at her. As she goes to pull her hand away, her reflection reaches through the wall and grabs her hand. Panic starts to fill her body before she notices that the grip is a gentle one. She looks down at the hand and feels something in her palm.

Letting go of the hand, she examines the item in her hand. It is a piece of blue stone, almost like a shard. She looks back up at the reflection and notices that it has returned to mirroring her movements. But in the reflection's hand there is no stone, only a blue light, that looks eerily similar to the mysterious woman's.

She takes a deep breath, puts the stone in her right pocket, and walks forward into the mirror wall.

Checking herself for anything out of place shows she is exactly as she was several seconds ago. Turning around shows a dirt trail leading into a forest. All traces of the wall are gone.

"Guess that was the threshold?" She mutters. Turning back around towards the town, she starts heading towards it. As she walks, she goes to look at the blue shard before realizing that it is no longer in her pocket. She stopped for a moment thinking about her reflection and the weirdness that had just transpired.

'If that was a reflection then. . .' she checks her left pocket and finds that the shard is indeed in her left pocket. She looks at the shard and holds it in both hands, swapping between left and right. "So I was right. Everything is backwards. I'm left handed right now. If that's the case, then my eyes probably swapped as well. Weird. I wonder where I am." She says to herself.

As she walks forward, she is taken in by the sights. Men and women of all colors and shapes surrounded her. Laughing, singing, and dancing.

Walking forward through the people she heard music. Nothing too fantastic but enough that would get anyone in the mood for dancing.

As she slowly made her way through the crowd her surroundings showed a small town with several buildings and a stone fountain in the middle. She could make out the faces on the people now. She could no longer see the floating rocks or the brilliant clouds. The sky had turned back to blue as well.

Looking around she felt too crowded, bumping into every third person she encountered, "Excuse me, could you help-" she went to ask someone for directions but they barely took notice of her. Several more attempts at asking for help proved just as fruitless. Noticing a bench, she slowly made her way towards it, careful not to knock anyone over.

Taking a seat, she let out a breath. Taking the time to get her bearings, she thought about where was, how she got here, and about everything she had gone through. Everything was bubbling up and she didn't know how to handle it. It felt like a pressure was slowly building in her chest. Her eyes started to burn with tears of frustration. Frustration at the fact that she didn't know what the hell was going on. Burying her head into her hands, she sat there for several minutes before a woman sat on the bench beside her. Concern in her voice, "Are you alright? Not enjoying the festivities?"

She took in the appearance of the young woman beside her. She was attractive with olive skin and gray eyes. Her brown hair was in a long braid that stretched down her back in a ponytail like fashion. She had a slim build with a toned physique.

The woman put a hand on her shoulder, concern in her eyes, "Hey, if you aren't feeling well I can-" she went to say something before she was cut off.

"I'm fine, I just have a headache." Catra said, rubbing her eyes and swallowing the lump in her throat.

"Oh, I'm sorry. I've heard migraines can be quite painful. Have you tried eating or drinking something? That normally helps me when I get a headache." She said, giving a sympathetic smile. Catra smiled back at her before asking, "What's your name?"

"My name's Mara, nice to meet you. . .?" She said, putting her hand out, waiting for a response.

"I'm having a bit of memory problems, but I've been told my name is Catra." She said, shaking her hand. Mara's face immediately turned sympathetic, losing any trace of her smile.

"That's horrible, are you alright? Do you need help?" Concern filling her tone. Catra only shook her head.

"Nah, I'll be fine. . .I think. But you did mention food and I could really go for some of that right about now." She said, standing up. Mara's face still had a bit of concern but she nodded, "If you're sure you're alright, then I won't pry. But if you need help don't be afraid to ask. I am kind of a big deal around here." She said winking at her with a small smile on her face. Catra nodded back, "sure." A chuckle leaving her lips.

"Well, let's get something to eat. I'll show you around. You didn't get hit in the head did you? Because I can heal people." Mara said, pointing at a golden glowing gauntlet on her arm. Catra was a little confused but said nothing about the gesture.

"I think I'll be fine for now, but thanks." She said as they weaved astound the dancing people. Mara smiled and waved at several of the people in the crowd, giving the occasional dancer a spin. It was clear to Catra that this girl was the life of the party. Everyone seemed to know and love her, judging by the smiles and laughs.

As they made their way past the crowd they came to a building with a sign that had a fork and spoon adorning it. As they went to walk in a Beetle the size of a horse with razor-like teeth came barreling from the alley beside the building.

Catra's claws unsheathed as her hair got spikier than normal. She immediately jumped back ready to kill this thing, before Mara stepped forward and hugged it.

"Hey there Buddy, who's a good boy?" Mara said in baby babble as if she was talking to a dog. Mara turned towards Catra, giggling, "Sorry, I should have warned you. This is Buddy. He's a

robotle." Catra tilted her head in confusion, her adrenaline dying down

"A ro-bot-le? What's a robotle?" Catra asked, lost. Mara laughed, "Well, I mean, that's not what they're actually called. I just call them that. He's a robot. But he looks like a beetle. Put 'em together and boom, Robottle." Catra must have had a stupid look on her face because Mara only laughed.

"Alright, get going Buddy, I'll see you later." Turning towards Catra she ushered her into the building. As soon as she entered, the smells of cooking meat and vegetables filled her nose. Her mouth immediately started watering. A snort sounded to her left. Looking, she found it to be Mara.

"You laugh a lot, you know that?" Catra asked her in a flat tone. Mara only smiled and nodded, responding with an, "I know."

As they sat down Mara called over one of the women with a notebook in hand to take their orders. As she looked at the food menu Catra didn't know what any of these things were and it must have shown, because not even a second later Mara had ordered for her. As the waitress nodded and left for the kitchen, Mara turned towards her with a questioning look on her moments passed in silence with only the tavern chatter for ambience.

"What? Why are you looking at me like that? Catra shifted in her seat, becoming increasingly uncomfortable with the silence.

"I'm just trying to figure out why one of the cat people is on Etheria." Mara stated bluntly, "You guys typically don't leave your planet. So I was just wondering. But then again you do look a little more Etherian." Catra blinked in confusion.

"Cat people? Are you referring to me? Because I'm from here. I've never even been on a spaceship, much less been to another planet." Catra said. They both turned and thanked the waitress as she brought them their drinks.

Taking a sip of her drink she looked at Catra, "But you can't remember much, right? So how would you know if you've ever been to space?" Catra sat for a second nursing her drink before speaking, "That's a good point. Maybe I am from space. Regardless, I don't even know how I got here. Not that you would believe me if I told you." Catra whispered that last part to herself.

"Try me," Mara said.

"I'm sorry, what?" Catra asked with an eyebrow raised. Mara looked at her with a challenging look.

"I said try me. Come on, tell me. You would not believe some of the stuff I've seen. So. . .tell me." Catra remained silent, eyeing the girl for several moments. "Please, come on, I promise I won't laugh at you. Maybe I can help. You said you had no memories right? Maybe this somehow connects to whatever happened."

Catra looked at Mara, before sighing, "All right, But only because you're getting me food."

As the waitress served their food to them, Catra told this stranger she had just met everything, from waking up in the forest with no memories to the mysterious figure with the glowing blue stone in her chest. She looked a little intrigued at the mention of Adora and the shard, though. Beyond that, Mara stayed silent throughout it all, munching on her food. By the end of it all Catra felt much better. The festivities had died down as it shifted towards the evening.

"Do you feel better?" Mara asked with a small smile. Catra gave a smile back, "Actually, yeah I do. Thank you for listening to my problems for the last hour and not calling me crazy. And for this meat . . . food, thing." she said, gesturing to the empty plate.

Mara called the waitress over and ordered two more drinks. As the waitress took their plates, she turned to look back at Catra, "Well I think I have a couple answers for you."

Catra's eyes went wide, "You do? Oh thank god. I've been stumbling around in the dark here."

Mara reached forward and took the shard from Catra, "For starters, I have never heard of the material doing any type of magic. Or causing amnesia for that matter. But what I can tell you is that they were made from the same type of material as the gemstone in my sword," Mara's gauntlet on her arm glowed brightly before shifting into a beautiful sword with blue jewel in the hilt, "But unless you infuse the materials with magic, well. . .the ore is essentially useless." Mara gave a sheepish look, handing the shard back to Catra.

"What does this sword have to do with it?" Catra asked, confused, examining the sword. Mara rubbed the back of her head, "That's a long story." Mara paused for a moment, turning the sword back into a gauntlet before continuing.

"That's not to say that they don't do anything though. It is really intriguing that you even found one. That material is so rare we only have four or five shards back in the vault. It clearly had some sort of effect on you. Which leads me to my second point. My sword was forged on the Cat people's planet, Krytis, with their magic craft. If my theory is correct, maybe you have lineage from Krytis and that's why it affected you the way it did?

"And third, this mysterious woman? You said she glowed and had a blue gem stone in her chest. Was she perhaps holding a sword? You said she had something in her hand but you couldn't see it clearly." Mara finished. Catra sat in silence, considering that possibility.

"I suppose it could have been a sword. I don't see why it couldn't be a sword." Catra finished in a flat voice. Mara nodded, a pondering look on her face. Mara went to say something but the waitress had come back with the drinks, cutting her off. Catra turned her attention towards the glass of white chunky liquid with foam dipping over the edge of the glass. It had highlights of orange in the center and some sort of red cream with the pink

fruit she had eaten back when she had first awoken in the unknown forest.

Catra's pupils went big and a little drool fell out of the side of her mouth. Mara laughed at Catra's face, "You should see your face. You look adorable." Catra's face lit up in a blush.

"I am not adorable!" Catra exclaimed, her tail puffing out. This had the unfortunate side effect of making Mara laugh even harder. Several other people sitting around them chuckled at the exchange. The waitress only smiled and turned towards Mara, "Here you go Mara, these are on the house."

"Thanks Phyla, you're the best." With that the waitress walked off to take care of the other customers. Catra shifted in her seat, a bit embarrassed at her outburst. As she stroked her tail, petting the fur back down, she looked at the pink colored orange resting atop the delicious looking drink.

"I thought these things were poisonous? And how is this a drink? It looks more solid than liquid." Catra asked, looking at Mara with an eyebrow raised.

"Yeah, they get a bit of a bad rap. If you don't peel them right the juices from the skin soak into the fruit and turns them bad like it did when you ate it earlier," she says recalling the moment she was told about, "but if you do it just right," Mara pauses as she takes the fruit from the glass and pops it into her mouth, "they turn out *amazing.*" She finishes, her eyes squeezed shut in delight.

Catra looks at her drink and goes to take a bite before Mara stops her, "Eat the fruit first. The juice has a sticky effect on your tongue. When you eat it after the fruit it tastes way better."

Catra shrugs and pops the fruit into her mouth. It tastes like an orange, just like last time. She lets the juice soak into her mouth before swallowing. Mara nods with a gesture towards the drink, "Now try it."

Catra takes a spoonful of the weird looking substance and takes a bite. Immediately, she can already tell this is her favorite drink. It tasted unlike anything she had ever had before. The flavors were sweet and tangy. The texture was like that of cream but like a crunch of ice? She couldn't be sure but she knew she wanted more of it. She took another bite, slowly savoring it, letting the liquid sit on her tongue. The smoothness gave way to something else. A burning in the back of her throat? What kind of drink was this? It was cold but filled her core with a warmth she found quite pleasant. As she went to take another bite, she was interrupted by the sound of Mara clearing her throat.

Catra looked up at her, a sheepish smile flashed across her face, "Sorry, I've just never tasted anything like this before. For a drink that's cold it sure is warming me up in the most pleasant way. Can I get more of this?"

Mara grinned, "Easy there, Catra. That warmth is because of the fermented crystal cream."

Catra's confusion must have shown on her face because Mara only giggled, "It means it's alcoholic."

Realization flashed across Catra's face as she looked down at the drink wide eyed. A sly smile graced Catra's features as she leaned forward, looking at Mara, "Are you trying to get me drunk?" She asked with a teasing tone in her voice.

Mara cleared her throat, pulling at her shirt a bit, "No, that wasn't my intention. I just figured that with everything you had gone through, this might help you cheer up." Mara finished, looking a little red. "Besides, you would need to drink maybe three of these before you get drunk." she finished, taking a bite of her own beverage.

It was Catra's turn to laugh at her face. Mara wore a look of embarrassment before she broke down into laughter as well. As they laughed for a minute, Mara spoke up, "You know what, I like you Catra. You're pretty fun." Mara said smiling.

"I like you too, thanks for helping me out. This cheered me up a lot. Between being kidnapped by a plant witch and getting into an argument with angels, you're the first person that has offered help and advice." Catra said, her face lighting up in a smile.

"Well, you're welcome. And thank you too. You took my mind off of some things I've been dealing with. Friends?" Mara finished with a grin, an outstretched fist in front of her.

"Yeah, friends." Catra said, finishing the fist bump.

As they sat and talked for a while longer, exchanging words and the occasional laugh, the waitress Phyla walked over and told them the tavern was closing. Mara nodded and they went to stand.

As they walked out of the tavern, Mara turned towards Catra, "That drink was called a 'Pink Morning,' just so you know. And I'm really sorry I couldn't offer anything else for your memories." Catra waved it off, "Don't be. This actually helped me a lot in its own way. Besides, that girl I told you about, Adora, she apparently knew me before I lost them. She says we grew up together. Now all I need to do is figure out where she is." Mara's face lit up at the mention of Adora.

"I remember now. Before Phyla walked over I wanted to tell you, I've heard that name before. A woman named Razz calls me that. She's a little weird and keeps calling me Adora, even though I've told her my name multiple times, but she's really kind and sweet. I think you would like her. If you want to come, we can check if she knows anything." Mara said with a look on her face that was hard to discern.

Catra thought about it for a moment before agreeing, "Sure, it's not like I've got anything going on."

Mara grinned, "Great, I've just got to get us a ride and then we can go. It isn't super far. Though be aware once we-" Mara was cut off by a sound of confusion from Catra.

"Am I glowing to you?" Catra asked panickedly, looking at herself. A dull golden light was quickly becoming brighter as it slowly engulfed her body. Mara quickly grabbed her shoulders, steadying her.

"Calm down Catra, I don't know what's happening but I'm he-" Mara's voice was muted. Catra could see her mouth move but couldn't hear any words. She could only hear water rushing, similar to that of an ocean. The light was too bright, she couldn't keep her eyes open and her head was being flooded with pain that was slowly encompassing the rest of her body. She could only assume the grip on her body was Mara's. She forced an eye open and all she could see was Mara raising what looked to be a sword in the air.

'Was she glowing?' Catra thought before she passed out.

Catra sat up with a gasp. Looking around frantically, she found herself back in the castle she had passed out in hours ago. Surrounding the bed she was sitting on was Angella, Glimmer, the weird boy, a new woman with dark black hair wearing a purple dress, and a large glowing woman.

'Is that Adora?' She thought. She looked just like her but was a lot taller and more muscular. In her hand was Mara's sword? Suddenly, a swirl of light appeared around her and Adora was standing where the woman had been. Anger filled Catra and it must have shown because everyone took a step back.

"What is your problem? I was away from this castle and you dragged me back, for what?" Catra seethed. She had just about had it with these people. She had told them she didn't remember anything and they just wouldn't leave her alone. Only Mara and Adora had listened and she was quickly losing her patience with Adora.

Adora spoke up, concern on her face, "Catra, you didn't leave this room. You've been unconscious for several hours. You passed out

when you and Glimmer were arguing."

Catra looked at everyone suspiciously, "I woke up in a small town. I've been gone for hours. So try a different excuse." Anger still present in her voice. Adora's tone turned slightly irritated.

"Yeah, well you try again. I sat here the whole time. I didn't leave your bedside once, so there is no possible way you left. The guards would have seen it and I would have too."

Catra reached into her left pocket, pausing for a moment as if remembering something before reaching into her right pocket. With a withering glare she pulled out a dull blue shard before flicking it at Adora, "Oh yeah? Then explain that. These are the clothes *you* brought me. So enlighten me, Adora," a mocking tone present, "where did I get that?"

Adora rolled the shard around in her hand, examining it before looking at Castaspella, "Castaspella, is this a soul crystal?"

Castaspella took the shard from Adora, examining it thoroughly, "Yes, it is. The energy has been drained from it, no doubt the reason Catra has lost her memories. Earlier you said that she didn't have it and that neither did you. Where did you get it?"

Catra immediately grabbed the shard back from the now named woman, pocketing it quickly, "I told you, I left. I woke up in a small town and a girl named Mara helped me. She was taking me somewhere before you pulled me back here." Catra eyed the sword on Adora's back.

"Speaking of which, why do you have Mara's sword?" Her eyes narrowed at Adora. Adora stiffened at the mention of Mara. Confusion lit up her features.

"You met Mara?" Adora's voice tinged with curiosity. Everyone turned to look at Adora.

"You know this woman?" Angella asked. Adora nodded looking at the sword. Yeah, on the day I joined the rebellion, I met an old

woman in the woods named Razz. She helped me understand She-Ra and how to use the sword. Though even after I told her my name she kept calling me Mara."

"That's funny," Catra spoke up with a slightful distrusting tone, "because that's exactly what Mara said, except she gets called Adora."

A moment of silence passed before Catra went to stand up, "Well, if that's everything, I am going to go find Mara. She's probably freaking out right now, what with me collapsing and all."

Angella went to put a hand on Catra's shoulder, "Catra, you need to stay here until Castaspella confirms your health. We don't know the extent of what the shard did to you."

As she spoke, Catra's eyes narrowed. Slapping the hand off of her shoulder, she glared at Angella.

"Oh, so we're suddenly friends now? You're concerned for my health? What happened to 'You will remain in the moon's prison,' huh?" A heated look marring her face. Angella's tone turned stern.

"I am concerned for your health as much as I am for Adora's. Up until several minutes ago I didn't know whether or not you were tricking us. But now I see that you truly have lost all of your memories and do not even remember who Adora is. By her accounts, you two have been together for as long as she can remember.

"You can be upset with me as much as you want to but that is very concerning. If you have lost even your earliest memories then you are open for manipulation from very many people. In front of you, you have a very concerned friend who wants nothing but the best for you. I understand that you are angry and that you may not have been treated very well up until this point, no one is disregarding that.

"But be aware," Angella's tone turned icy, "since up until this point you had no clue what the Horde was before this I will explain to

you who they are. The Horde is the opposing force in the war we are currently fighting. They pillage and conquer, destroying anybody and anything that gets in their way." Catra's face slowly twisted into a shocked and disgusted expression. "You were a part of the Horde before this. In fact, you were a force captain. That is a very high rank with a lot of command and power. Judging by your shocked expression, you must think that this all sounds horrible? Good, do try and remember this feeling when your memories start to return."

Catra slowly sat back down on the bed, Angella's presence becoming looming over her. Overbearing. Suffocating. Something was wrong. She couldn't place it but it was getting harder to breathe, like there wasn't enough air in the room. Her mouth had dried up and she felt small. Her vision was distorted, like she was looking through a lens and there was a tightness in her chest that was becoming almost painful.

Her thoughts were racing and she couldn't focus. As she looked at Angella, the room seemed darker. The shadows of the room seemed to crawl along the floor, the pink in the room seemed more red. An ominous glow circling the Queen.

"*As a former Horde soldier you will be required to stay here until Adora can fix this mess that you have caused. But then again, I have come to expect such things from you. But I will not allow you to drag Adora down as well. You have never been more than a nuisance to me. I have kept you around this long because Adora was fond of you. But if you ever do anything to jeopardize her future, I will dispose of you myself."*

Catra gripped her chest, blood was pounding in her ears, and her hands shook. A feeling of Nausea gripped her. She couldn't stay here. She had to move, to get away.

Adora looked at Catra in concern, "Catra, are you alright?"

As Adora went to reach out towards Catra, Castaspella pulled Adora back, "Stop, she's having a panic attack. This is common

with the victims. When some memories return, normally it's only the bad ones, she will have a seizure-like event. She will become detached from her surroundings and she might start convulsing. Whatever she's seeing or hearing isn't happening."

"Help her!" Adora cried out as Catra dropped to the floor holding her chest. Her breathing becoming faster and her movements erratic.

"I can't. She has to deal with this on her own. Whatever it is that she's experiencing is the result of a memory. She's remembering and it doesn't seem to be a good one." Glimmer and Bow went and stood by Angella as Catra started to shake. Adora kneeled beside Catra.

"Catra, I'm here. You're going to be okay. You just have to process this. Focus on the memory and just try and push through it."

Images flew through her mind. Images of people she didn't know. A blonde boy being yelled at. A dark skinned girl wearing a scowl. A giant man-like lizard doing push ups. There was a giant glowing red crystal with crimson lightning arcing off of it. And a shadowy figure with a glowing red jewel on her head.

The pounding in her ears was so loud and she could barely breathe. She needed to regain her posture. Focus on anything but whatever was going on. Too many things were going on. She couldn't focus. The voice suddenly filled her ears.

Remember.

Quickly reaching into her pocket she grasped the blue shard tightly. Immediately the thoughts ceased. Everything was quiet. She heard the voice in her head once more.

The fractal nesting of the relationship between space and time at different scales causes phase transitions, as the influence of one force changes with respect to another, and from this we get the astonishing variety of behaviors in the material world.

'What? What does that mean?'

Catra stood up quickly, looking at everyone. Everyone had looks of concern on their faces. Annoyance filled her.

"Stop looking at me like that." Catra said, her breathing slowly returning back to normal.

"Are you okay Catra?" Adora asked, stepping towards her. Catra's body seemed to relax as she got closer. She smelled familiar, if that made sense. Letting out a breath, she looked to the side.

"I'm fine. I just got a little startled. Nothing some food won't fix." Catra said, playing off what she just experienced, not wanting to discuss the voice she keeps hearing.

As she went to walk she was immediately stopped by Angella, "We need to discuss what you just experienced. If it pertains to-"

"Listen, I get it. But if it's alright with you I would like to get out of this room. Because it seems to me that whenever we go to talk about something I pass out. M'kay?" Catra interrupted with an irritated tone.

Angella glanced at Castaspella for a moment before turning to Bow and Glimmer, "Take her to get some food. Do not let her go anywhere else besides the Hall. I mean it Glimmer. I will join you shortly. Castaspella and I need to discuss a few things."

Glimmer nodded and with that the trio walked towards the kitchen with Catra in tow. As the door closed, Angella ordered the guards to not let anyone in. She turned to face Castaspella.

"Alright, explain to me what exactly this girl is going through. Do not leave any details out." Angella said. Castaspella nodded.

"Let's address the big issue first. That being the soul crystal that Catra is in possession of. I'll be honest, I do know what these things are but my knowledge on them is shaky at best." Castaspella said to Angella.

"Alright, start whenever you're ready."

"I suppose that the fact that she even has a shard raises extreme concerns." Castaspella said, taking a seat on one of the nearby chairs.

"What do you mean by that?" Angella asked, sitting across from her.

"I mean that these things are incredibly dangerous. I just didn't want to alarm that poor girl. What I said wasn't exactly true. These things have never resulted in death, that part is true, but in the singular tense. If somebody touches these and directly charges them, well. . . the results aren't pretty. We're talking about a complete loss of sanity here Angella." Castaspella said with a serious tone.

"Please elaborate. Do I need to be worried about this girl returning to the Horde or accidentally hurting someone here?" Angella asked.

"Hardly. The only thing you have to be worried about is if that girl will lose her mind. Everytime that I have seen this happen and mind you, that is only two other times, they lose it. They start rambling on about a place called Earth. They start talking about terms and words that make no sense. Timelines and fractures and different dimensions. I don't understand any of it but it's definitely got something to do with the eternians."

"Will Catra recover? I may not have the best thoughts on this girl but I would never wish this on somebody. Forgetting your life, who you are, and everyone important to you? That sounds like a terrible fate." Angella shuddered, thankful that this couldn't happen to Glimmer.

"As long as she is kept away from any situations that could be too stressful, she should be fine. Both times that I have seen, they both recovered within the year. She won't be able to find any more shards either. We have them in Mystacor. I'm more

concerned about where she got the one she has now." Castaspella said as she shifted in her seat.

"Why do you say that?" Angella asked, curiosity tinging her voice.

"Well, we have all of the shards. Not a single one should be unaccounted for. The fact that Catra has one is, as I said, concerning." She said, a pondering look on Castaspella's face.

"How many are there?" Angella inquired.

"I believe there are eleven in total. I now question the truth of that statement. Unfortunately, the only one who could have found the rest was. . .Micah." A somber mood filled the air at the mention of the late King.

"Are there any symptoms I should be concerned with? The convulsing and panic attacks seem fairly easy to deal with. But in the event she is not getting any better, what should I know?" Angella said, quickly changing the subject.

"There were a few. She may go into a comatose-like state every now and then. If that happens it could be minutes, hours, maybe even days before she wakes up. If she talks about Earth or anything regarding the terms I spoke of just leave her be. It's completely normal. The shards hold knowledge of this place. From the descriptions we have on record it is a lovely place.

"Beyond that there's nothing really to be too concerned about. Just be patient with her. She seems to have a temper and that's understandable. Frustration is common among amnesiac people. She will need a lot of help but nothing I've witnessed here says that she won't make a full recovery.

Oh and don't be worried about the shard she has. As long as she has it and no one else runs a magical charge through it while holding it, it won't hurt anyone." Castaspella says with a nod. As she starts towards the door she looks back at Angella.

"One more thing. If Catra starts talking about seeing a woman with a blue gem on her chest in her dreams you need to contact me immediately. Seeing the woman is bad enough, hearing her speak is even worse."

"Why is it bad and who is this woman?" Angella asked.

"Nobody knows, but the sorcerers and sorceresses of Mystacor originally thought she was She-Ra. They were wrong. She whispers in your ear. She tells you to remember things and appears before you while you sleep.

"When the first sorcerers attempted to follow her in their dreams. . .well let's just say they didn't make it. She'll talk about a threshold and to find her," Castaspella continued with a grimace, "It's a trap. If Catra seeks out more shards then you can safely say that she has already seen her."

Angella narrowed her eyes, "If these shards are that dangerous why not destroy them? Why keep them locked away in Mystacor?"

"We've tried. Whatever the eternians did to these things made them nearly indestructible. They are immune to magic, physical force, you name it. We've tried just about everything. But there is a bright side. This woman can only appear in the first dream you have after you've been affected by one of the crystals. She can't even speak to you without being affected by a second shard." Castaspella spoke with a confident tone.

"If she can't appear without a second shard, then why speak of her?" Angella asked, pondering everything she had just learned.

"Because until today, I was under the assumption that we had all of the shards. If there are more out there then be careful. Don't let Catra come into contact with any more of them."

With that Castaspella left the room, leaving Angella to think about everything that had just taken place.

'Ugh, It's not even noon.' Angella thought, rubbing her temples.

Chapter 3

Making their way towards the food, Catra took in the architecture as she walked with Adora, Bow, and Glimmer. She went to say something about the walls before Bow cut her off.

"So what do you like to eat? We have lots of options. Adora particularly likes the sugar cookies, Glimmer likes the cake, and I like the sweet bread." Bow asked with a gleaming smile. Catra couldn't help but think this guy was a little strange. He was acting like she hadn't just recently insulted them.

"Oh, she probably doesn't have a favorite food. Since we grew up in the fright zone all we had was ration bars, remember?" Adora spoke up.

"Oh yeah, you did mention that. Well you don't need to worry about it then," Bow said, never once losing his jovial attitude, "I know just the thing that you'll like."

"Oh yeah? And what, praytell, do you think that I will like?" Catra asked, her eyebrow raised.

"I think you'll love the cake. It's got chocolate syrup inside and it's topped with a milk frosting that just makes your mouth water." Bow's eyes sparkled as if he were recalling some sort of delicacy. To be fair, they were in a queen's castle. It probably was expensive. He went on and on about how good it was. Catra ignored him for a second.

'Milk frosting, huh? So he thinks I like milk because I'm a cat person?' Catra thought. Suddenly a thought popped into Catra's mind. Quickly wiping the sly smile on her face she started glaring.

"Really? You think I like milk because I'm a cat? Wow, that's really insensitive. Just for your information, I'm allergic to milk. Maybe you should think before you start talking. You could really hurt someone's feelings." Catra said with mock anger.

Immediately Bow lost his smile and started trying to apologize, "Oh my gosh, I'm so sorry. I didn't mean. . .I would never try to-"

"She's not allergic to milk, Bow," Adora said looking at Bow before turning to Catra, "Stop messing with him. He's just trying to get a feel for what you might like."

Although she spoke in a stern tone, Catra caught the glimpses of a smile at the corners of her mouth, as if she were trying not to smile. Catra smirked at her.

"Alright, alright, If that's what you want. I'll stop teasing Archer boy over here. By the way I still haven't caught your name and if I did I don't remember it. What is it?" Catra asked, cocking an eyebrow at Bow.

Letting out a sigh of relief at not offending her he immediately smiled. . .again, "My name is Bow, It's nice to meet you Catra. I mean, we've met a couple of times before this but you were kinda trying to kill us back then. So what I really mean is that it's nice to meet you in a safer setting. Since you were a part of the Horde before now. But Adora was too, so it's okay. Technically you aren't even a part of the Horde anymore since, you know, you can't remember anything, which is good. I mean it's not good. It's totally bad that you can't remember who you are. But we-" Bow was cut off by Glimmer, thankfully.

"What he means to say is that it's nice to meet you in a way that lets us get to know you while you aren't trying to kill us. That about cover it Bow?" Glimmer asked exasperatedly.

Bow chuckled nervously, "Yeah, thanks Glimmer. Oh looks like we made it to the hall. Let's sit and get something to eat." Bow said in an obvious attempt to change the subject.

"Sure." Catra said awkwardly, unsure of whatever that was all about.

As they took their seats Catra could smell the food being prepared well before the servants came out carrying platters, plates, and

bowls. Catra's mouth started watering at the smells. As the plates were all set down, Adora reached out for a specific plate. Intrigued by why she was singling that one out, Catra immediately shot her hand out and grabbed the plate.

"Catra! Give me that back." Adora exclaimed.

"Why, what is it?" Catra asked smugly, looking over whatever was on the plate. It was some kind of slop with what looked to be eggs and meat in it. Whatever it was, it smelled really good and there seemed to be only enough for one person.

"It's nothing, you probably wouldn't even like it. Just give it back." Adora said in an uneasy tone. It was kind of funny.

"You must really love this meal to want it back so badly. How do I know I wouldn't like this? Maybe I want to try it. After all, I'm really exhausted from everything that's been happening to me. I need to get back as much strength as possible." Catra said mockingly, eyeing Adora.

"Ha ha, very funny Catra. We both know that's a lie. You aren't even tired. You always bounced back quicker than everyone else. Besides there's like thirty other things you can choose from. Pick one of those and give me that back." Adora pleaded.

"But there's only one of these. . .What are you gonna give me for it?" A sly tone entered her voice. Adora looked around the table frantically. She immediately grabbed the plate that hadn't been uncovered and put it in front of Catra before turning and whispering something to them. The servant nodded and without missing a beat went through the door and exited with a mug of some sort of steaming foamy drink.

"I'll give you the steamed fish with a mug of hot butter milk. I know you'll love it so please give me the steak mash back." Adora said with a sweet tone that slowly turned into a glare as the seconds ticked by with no response from Catra.

"Alright, alright. I'm just messing with you. Here you go." Catra said as she handed the plate back to Adora. Adora immediately perked up at that. As she went to try the fish, she was interrupted by a sound of laughter from Bow.

"What? What's so funny?" Catra asked with a raised eyebrow.

"It's nothing. It's just that even without your memories of Adora, you guys are still super comfortable around each other. In fact," Bow continued, taking a bite of his food, "it doesn't seem that you really changed all that much. So if you ask me, I think you'll get your memories back in no time."

Catra pondered that for a moment. She had noticed that she was much more comfortable around Adora compared to everyone else. She glanced at Adora, considering what she had just heard.

'Maybe Archer boy is right. Maybe this whole amnesia thing will work itself out on its own'

"Maybe," Catra said, eyeing Bow, "But I have a question for you. Is Bow your real name? Because you're an archer named bow. Did your parents just think 'one day our son will be an archer, let's name him bow?'"

Bow smiled a bright smile, like he was excited to explain this, "Actually, you're not the first person to ask me that. It's a funny story that has to do with an experience my parents had before I was born. But besides that, it's just a funny coincidence."

"Hm, alright then." Catra said.

As everyone continued to eat, Catra took note that Adora was indeed right. She did enjoy this fish meal and the buttermilk drink. Over the next hour everyone made small talk about random things, although Catra remained silent for the most part. As she went to grab a biscuit, the main chamber's doors opened and Angella strode in.

"Mom, come get some food. I saved you a plate." Glimmer said teleporting over to Angella, giving her a hug and teleporting back to the table.

"You're not gonna do that all the time, are you? Because I don't need you appearing before me when I'm in the bathroom or something." Catra said flatly.

Glimmer's face scrunched up in annoyance as she opened her mouth to reply, before Angella cut her off.

"Glimmer knows better than to teleport to other people's private spaces." Angella spoke in a calm voice. Taking a seat at the table, she grabbed a plate of food before turning to Glimmer.

"Castaspella has invited you three to Mystacor. They are renewing the barrier that protects Mystacor. She would be delighted to have you join her for a bit of a break from everything you've been dealing with." Angella informed them.

At that, Glimmer and Bow looked at each other with smiles on their faces.

"We would love to go. It's been so long since we've been there. They always put these magic shows on that really wow you, y'know? Plus, it would be good for Adora to get to see Mystacor. What do you think, Adora? Are you up for it?" Bow asked.

Adora shook her head slightly, "That sounds really nice guys, but Catra said that she met this Mara woman and that she had a sword that looked just like mine. I think it's important to go see Razz before we do anything else. She obviously pertains to She-Ra."

Glimmer didn't miss a beat though, "We can visit her on the way. It'll be a quick stop. You talk with this Razz person, learn what you need to know, and then we head to Mystacor. It'll be smooth sailing."

Adora thought about it for a moment before nodding, "Alright, sure. We can go to Mystacor. But I mean it. We really need to speak with Razz."

"Excellent. When you are ready to leave, go to the throne room. She'll be waiting there." Angella said, standing and stepping away from the table.

"Alright then. Catra and I will go pack some supplies and we'll meet you guys there." Adora said as everyone stood up.

"Adora, Castaspella thinks Catra should remain here. She has informed me that coming into close proximity to high amounts of magic could have detrimental effects unless she is fully recovered." Angella said softly.

Adora looked quite frustrated at that. As she opened her mouth to speak, Catra beat her to it.

"That's fine."

"What? But Catra-" Adora started before being stopped.

"Look, if the woman who knows what is going on with me says I shouldn't go then I probably shouldn't go. I'd rather not pass out again in a puddle of blood and I'd imagine you don't want that either." Catra said matter-of-factly.

"But I just got you back." Adora said in a small voice.

"I'm not going anywhere and I'll still be here when you get back. Don't worry about me and go see this dumb ceremony thing. Besides, that sounds like a whole lot of boring stuff. We can go see Razz when you get back." Catra reassured her.

"Adora, you've been under a lot of stress lately. You deserve to take a break every now and then." Glimmer said, putting a hand on her shoulder, "Catra isn't going anywhere, so stop worrying. She'll be fine. My mom is here as well. Nothing will happen."

Adora nodded after a moment, "Alright, if you're sure Catra. But as soon as we get back-"

"We'll go see Razz. I know." Catra finished, "Now go get your stuff. I feel like you're the type of person who doesn't like to keep people waiting."

As Adora left the room with Glimmer, Bow turned around, "Sorry you can't come. I'll bring you a souvenir, I promise." and with that he left the room as well.

When the door finally closed Catra quickly turned towards Angella, "Alright, spill it. What's the deal with me not going to this Mystical place? You already said that the spy thing was off the table so, what?"

Angella regarded the feline girl in front of her for a moment before pouring herself a drink from the pitcher on the table, "In all honesty, I want to speak to you alone. I know you have no memories and that pretty much eliminates any possibilities of affiliation with the Horde. . .at the current moment."

As Angella took a sip out of her glass, she beckoned Catra to follow her. Letting out a breath, she stood and quickly strode after the queen.

"So then what do you want to talk about?" Catra asked as they walked through the halls.

"Adora cares a great deal for you. So much so, that she has fought every decision I have made regarding you. Up until this point, she has never once disobeyed a command. But with you, she has an issue no matter what I decide." Angella stated calmly, as she opened a door and ushered Catra inside, closing the door behind them.

"She is a sweet girl with a lot of drive and determination to do what's right. But the circumstances in which she was raised have made her a very guarded person regarding her feelings. But when it comes to you I can understand almost everything she is feeling.

To her you may be the most important thing in her life. Now, I do not hold it against you that you can't currently grasp that as you couldn't even remember your own name until today.

"But you hold the potential to sway Adora in almost any path regardless of what she thinks of that path, whether she knows it or not. Now from what I have been able to gather from Adora regarding you, is that you are lazy, not very motivated, and that you shirk responsibility." Angella continued, both taking a seat at chairs that looked far too luxurious than they deserved to.

"But I have not seen that attitude. In fact I have seen the opposite. Glimmer has described you with a determination and drive that is almost frightening. Stopping at nothing to succeed no matter who got in your way. Glimmer as well as Bow have both described you as a very dangerous person. Adora has also described you as the one person who, in her own words, 'knows her best.'"

Catra looked at Angella, trying to figure out what she was getting at., "Thanks, I think? Why exactly are you telling me all of this?"

"What I'm saying, Catra, is that right now you have choices. As your memories gradually return, and they will return, as evidenced by the panic attack you experienced earlier this morning, you will no doubt remember your reasoning for fighting Adora. I have a fairly good guess as to why these events happened the way they did, but that is not what we are discussing. What we are discussing is that when that time comes, that you understand both sides of this war as Adora has."

Catra sat in silence for a moment, thinking about everything that she had just heard. Several questions popped in her mind but she only wanted to ask one.

"The way Adora speaks about me. . .it insinuates that it's my fault. *That I left her*. But that completely contradicts everything I have heard from you. So I suppose, what I want to know is; If I was so important to Adora, that I'm the most important person to

her, then why did she leave? Don't say it was the Horde being bad or whatever bullshit answer that has to do with the war. Why did she leave me with the Horde if we loved each other that much?"

Angella leaned back into her chair, crossing one leg over the other. Several seconds passed as she stared at Catra, mulling her thoughts over, before finally answering.

"I don't know. Not for certain anyways. Whatever happened between you two lies solely with Adora. That memory is currently lost to you and until I can hear both sides of this story. . .well I won't be able to give you my thoughts on the matter. But please know this, Catra, They're are always two sides to these types of things. You chose to stay with the Horde and according to Adora, you knew the Horde had done terrible things. But even Adora doesn't know why you would choose that for yourself."

Catra thought about everything and decided she needed a break. Standing up with a sigh, she turned to look at Angella, "Well if that's the best answer I'm gonna get for now, then. . .I accept it. I'm not particularly thrilled about it, but I accept it."

Angella stood as well, "Catra you seem like a reasonable young woman and from everything that I have seen, you don't seem like a bad person. You're going through an incredibly stressful event and are handling it the best you can. So for the time being I would like for you to relax a little and I will show you around. Oh and one more thing? Please try and keep the cussing to a minimum. I don't particularly want to hear my daughter start saying 'fuck.'"

Catra chuckled, the sound of the Queen cussing being slightly amusing to her, "Sure, I'll do my best."

Angella smiled warmly, "Good, then come along. I would imagine that Adora would like to say goodbye before she heads out."

"-and that is why you don't perform truth spells in that manner." Castaspella finished with a giggle.

Glimmer looked exasperated with the conversation when suddenly the sound of footsteps and laughter filled the room. At the edge of the throne room, Angella and Catra walked in, both laughing about something. Confusion and annoyance lit up Glimmer's face.

"Since when are you two on such good terms?" Glimmer asked with a huff.

"Hmm? Oh, it's nothing." Angella cleared her throat, her laughter dying down, "Anyways, Catra will stay here for the time being and when she is in better health will be allowed to accompany you outside of Brightmoon."

Castaspella turned a kind smile on Catra, "Are you feeling better? I've been told eating helps with some of the more physical symptoms."

Catra nodded, "Yeah, thanks for asking. I actually do feel a lot better."

"Good, glad to hear it. Well if that's all then we should be going. We don't want to be late." castaspella said with a beaming grin.

As they turned to leave, Adora walked up to Catra, "I'm sure Razz will have some answers for us once we get back. Just take it easy, alright?"

"No problem. You don't need to worry. We can talk when you get back." Catra finished.

Adora nodded and turned towards Glimmer, "You ready?"

"Yep, let's go." Glimmer said as everyone locked hands. Catra was a little confused for a moment before they disappeared in a flash of sparkles.

Catra turned towards Angella in the now empty throne room, "Can I learn to do that or is that, like, an angel only thing?"

"It's actually an ability unique to Glimmer due to her connection to the moonstone." Angella stated.

"Huh, alright then." Catra hummed.

Deep in the Fright Zone, Shadow Weaver thought about the recent events that had transpired. She had made a mistake regarding the soul crystal. She should have known keeping it near the black garnet was a bad idea. Especially with garnet backlashing the way it had been.

She had been lucky. One of the soldiers had found a shard lodged in a piece of first one's tech. According to her and every other mage on Etheria, the vaults of Mystacor held all of the shards in existence. To think that a twelfth shard existed. . .well, it was an extremely good find. Unfortunately, she had been careless. She hadn't studied the crystals in a long time and had forgotten that these things could affect magical beings in their proximity if nobody was holding it.

She had almost been taken over by the shard's energy. The only reason she had not been affected immediately upon contact was because of the black garnet. If Catra had not pulled her out of the room, she would have lost everything about herself. With the magical power she possessed, it would most likely have driven her mad. It had been pure chance that Catra had arrived when she did. Pulling her out of the room the way she had.

Something about that piqued Shadow Weaver's interest though. The shards only affected people with the talent for magic. To her knowledge, Catra had no inclination towards magic. She had been a teacher at Mystacor for years before coming to the Fright Zone and she knew what to look for. Catra could never do magic. In fact the only one in the Fright Zone with the potential for it was Adora.

Beyond that, the shard's energy had immediately latched itself onto Catra. She hadn't so much as flinched as she carried Shadow Weaver out of the room. Something was going on that she had never experienced before. Catra had retained all sense of who she was for several minutes before being teleported away.

The shards also had never done that before either. It only raised more questions. It had taken her a few hours to recover but now she was ready. Shadow Weaver's instincts were fairly good regarding Catra and Adora, she had raised them after all and if her hunch was right then wherever Adora was, she was sure Catra was there too.

She had explained to Hordak that the shard was a piece of first one's technology and a very rare one at that. Not entirely untruthful, but it was enough for him to dismiss the large explosion from the black garnet's chamber.

Catra *had* saved her and everything she knew, unknowingly or not. She would find her. She was owed that much at least. Fortunately, Hordak wanted to know more about the crystals. He said they gave off a familiar energy signature. With no restrictions, she was given permission to find Force Captain Catra and retrieve her and the shard.

Shadow Weaver stewed on her thoughts regarding Hordak. He couldn't see past his need for the portal. He was too busy looking at the little details that he failed to see the bigger picture. Adora was important and whatever Catra was experiencing at the current moment was as well, she was certain of it.

In front of her, she had the chance that no other mage in history had. She could find the shards' true purpose and unravel their mysteries. Turning towards the cauldron in her quarters, she began to utter a spell, "From the farthest regions of Etheria, I command you, be as one."

Black smoke began to pour out of the cauldron before two dark, smoky figures appeared. Immediately she sent them out with one

objective; Find Catra and Adora.

As they left, she turned to the coms and summoned Force Captain Scorpia. As she waited for her, she began preparing the paperwork needed for what came next. After a few minutes the doors slid open. Scorpia looked like a nervous wreck, pacing and looking around shiftily.

Shadow Weaver took a calming breath. It was always a challenge dealing with Scorpia. She turned towards the Force Captain, but before she could start talking, Scorpia cut her off.

"Did you find Catra? Is she alright? Oh my goodness, is she dead? When she disappeared in the explosion, we were all so worried. I mean, what would we do without her?" Scorpia continued rambling for several moments before being silenced by a glare from Shadow Weaver.

"Listen, once my shadow spies have located Catra, you are to take Cadets Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle and retrieve her. Make sure she has a blue crystal with her. I believe the rebellion has brainwashed Catra. She most likely will not know who you are. So *do not* startle her. She will have lost most of her memories if not all of them. Do you understand?" Shadow Weaver said, the room becoming slightly darker around Scorpia in a threatening manner.

"Y-Yeah, totally. I completely understand. Get Catra's squad and go get her and the blue shard. Got it." Scorpia said nervously, a bead of sweat rolling down the side of her head.

"Good, when I summon you, you will depart immediately. Now that you understand your orders, take these papers and get out. They will have all of the information you need" Shadow weaver finished as the light returned back to the room.

At the dismissal, Scorpia turned and quickly left the room, leaving Shadow Weaver to her business.

Scorpia made her way towards the barracks, thinking to herself about everything she had just learned.

'Catra can't remember anything? And she's with the rebellion? This is horrible! Oh we have to get her back before they completely turn her against me. What if it's already happened? I need to tell Lonnie and them. As her friends, they deserve to know the truth.'

Determination to get her wildcat back filled her body, she resolutely nodded to herself. She wouldn't let Adora mess with Catra's head like this. How low could the rebellion get?

As she rounded the corner to the Barracks, she heard voices. Stepping into the room revealed the owners of the voices to be Lonnie, Kyle, and that lizard guy she couldn't always remember the name of.

"So, what do you think happened to Catra?" Kyle asked aloud.

"I'm not sure. I mean, did you see that explosion? What the hell was she thinking?" Lonnie exclaimed.

"She saved Shadow Weaver, though." Kyle defended.

"Yeah? And look what that got her. Vaporized by magic dust. We all knew Shadow Weaver didn't like her. I guess it was only a matter of time before she got rid of her." Lonnie finished crossing her arms.

"Don't say that," Kyle said, concern filling his voice, "Catra isn't dead. There's no way she is. She's always been strong and an explosion wouldn't do her in. She probably just teleported or something."

As Lonnie went to speak again, Scorpia entered the room, silencing all chatter. They all immediately stood at attention. Scorpia motioned for them to sit.

"None of that, now. You guys don't need to stand for me. But we've got a new mission." Scorpia said, a smile painted on her face.

"Does it have to do with Catra? She's been gone for almost five days and we haven't heard anything." Kyle said worried.

"Actually, it has everything to do with Catra," Scorpia beamed, "Shadow Weaver is on her trail. She thinks she's with Adora. Our mission is to go and retrieve her and this blue crystal. . .thing." Scorpia said, pulling out a picture from the orders.

"See, Lonnie, I told you she was alright." Kyle said, relief washing over his face. Lonnie seemed to relax at hearing that as well. She may not get along with Catra but she would never wish her dead. Before they could celebrate the good news, Scorpia spoke up, her smile slowly falling from her face.

"One more thing guys. Shadow Weaver told me that she thinks the rebellion brainwashed her. She might not remember us. Like, at all." Scorpia said, shifting uncomfortably.

"What? You think they would do that? Come on, Scorpia. You don't really think that they could make her switch sides, do you?" Lonnie scoffed, disbelief dripping from her words.

"I don't mean just us, Lonnie. She told me Catra probably won't remember much at all. She said she might have forgotten everything." Scorpia said solemnly.

At those words, the room went quiet. Nobody wanted to think about that. Catra was an acquired taste to be sure, but she had grown up with them. To think she wouldn't remember them was. . .unsettling, to say the least.

"Adora wouldn't do that," Kyle spoke up, his tone heavy with denial, "She's Catra's best friend. They were almost inseparable. She might have switched sides, but that doesn't mean she's any different when she was with us."

"If she did do that," Lonnie said in a quiet voice, "maybe that's why she did it. Catra was her best friend. The most important person to her. She didn't join her at Thaymor, so what if she decided to make her join."

"No, this doesn't add up. Adora's our friend, she would never-"

"She *was* our friend," Lonnie said sharply, cutting Kyle off, "and if she did this. If she really did do that. . .then we need to get Catra back. Help her get her memories back. She's still one of us." Lonnie said with a tone of finality.

Rogelio hissed in agreement at Lonnie's words, Kyle nodding along, both determined to get Catra back. Scorpia beamed at them, a smile gracing her features.

"Oh, you guys," Scorpia said, sounding like she was about to cry out of joy, "You're right Lonnie. We'll get Catra back and help her with her memories." Scorpia exclaimed, pulling all of them into a tight hug, nearly crushing them all half to death.

It had been about half a day since Adora had left for Mystacor and evening was quickly approaching. After she had given Catra a quick tour of Brightmoon's castle, Angella had left Catra to her own devices. She needed to return to her duties. But before she had left, she had said that the only stipulation to her freedom was that she couldn't leave the castle. While she could wander around as much as she wanted, she got the feeling that most of the people here did not like her. Maybe it was the glares and whispers whenever she entered a room, but she quickly understood that, besides Adora's friends, Angella, and Adora herself, she was not wanted there.

'Figures. I would probably feel the same way if my queen walked in and suddenly said, 'Attention, this is Catra. She was a former Force Captain of the Horde. She lost her memories, but she's good now. Please welcome her.' Catra thought out of boredom.

She let out a breath and started back to Adora's room. Angella had said that she had to stay in Adora's room. Something to do with 'security reasons' and all that. She couldn't understand why she couldn't have her own room, but whatever.

As she neared the door to her room, she noticed a note on the door.

Catra, please don't scratch the floors or tear the sheets and curtains. Also if you do happen to break something like, oh I don't know, the bathroom dresser or perhaps scattering bottles everywhere, please just call one of the servants. They will fix the damages and clean the mess. Beyond that, dinner will be served at 8:30. Do not skip it, it is vital you get your strength back.

-Queen Angella

'Yikes, busted' Catra thought at the mention of the bathroom.

As she folded the note and put it in her pocket, she went and sat on the bed. The shredded sheets and blankets, courtesy of her claws, had been replaced. As she laid there, her thoughts turned towards Mara. How had she met her? According to Adora, she hadn't left the castle since passing out. But it had all felt so real and she had helped her think through everything. Even though she couldn't explain what the shard was she-

Catra paused. The shard. . .

Sitting up she took out the shard and looked at it. It was completely smooth on one side and jagged on the other.

The edges were somewhat sharp. As she examined it, she noticed that it had started to emit a soft glow unlike when she had first looked at it. Originally the blue was quite dull. Now it hummed with an energy that seemed almost. . .alive.

Curious as to what was happening, she put it down for a moment. To her surprise the glow was gone and the hum had died. Picking it back up, she immediately took note of the returning hum and glow.

'Hmmm, Mara said you had never done this before, so what are you?' Catra thought to herself.

Putting her thoughts to the side for a moment, she focused on the hum, enthralled by it. As her focus grew sharper, the hum grew louder, and the glow brighter. It seemed to almost be pulling in a direction. She stood up from the bed and immediately concentrated on the pull. It was pulling her North.

Narrowing her eyes in curiosity, she turned the shard towards the south. The effect was immediate, as the shards hum died and the glow started to dull. Slowly turning towards the North, showed the hum and glow return.

'You want me to go north? What's in the north?' Catra thought. What was this thing and why did it only respond to her? What was so important that she-

Catra's thoughts were interrupted by a knock on the door. Quickly putting the crystal away, she walked towards the door and opened it. Angella stood there, with a raised eyebrow.

"Seeing as the note is no longer on the door anymore, I assume you have read it?" Angella spoke in an expectant tone.

"Uh, y-yeah I read it. I'll be there. You didn't need to come tell me." Catra said, a little offended that the queen felt she couldn't follow simple directions.

"Catra," Angella started, "dinner began ten minutes ago. Are you feeling alright?"

Catra looked at the clock on the wall. Had it been an hour already? She hadn't thought about it before now, but she was becoming increasingly aware of her exhaustion, more mental than physical. She turned back towards Angella and sighed.

"Yeah, I'm alright. I was just thinking about things and I guess I lost track of time," Catra ran a hand through her hair, taking a deep breath, "Give me a second to freshen up and I'll join you."

Angella's face looked somewhat conflicted as she nodded, "Alright, I'll be waiting here."

As Catra closed the door, Angella's thoughts were split. She felt a slight unease at how easy it was to relax around this girl. Even if Catra couldn't remember anything, she was still a Force Captain at one point. It wasn't like Adora. Adora had made a conscious choice to leave the Horde and help the rebellion. On the other hand, Catra had lost her memories and hadn't and probably never once considered joining the rebellion.

She had warmed up to this girl with frightening speed and it worried her. If Catra regained her memories at some point and decided to rejoin the Horde, she would have invaluable knowledge about her enemies. Yet it was hard not to be concerned about a girl close to her daughter's age, when she had watched her almost choke on her own blood. That was something she would rather not happen to Catra again.

It didn't escape Angella's notice that Catra was quite similar to Glimmer, though her daughter would probably never admit that. Their attitudes and headstrong natures mirrored one another. Her thoughts were interrupted by Catra opening the door.

"Alright, I'm ready. Let's go eat." Catra said flatly.

Angella took note of her wet face and hair. She was most likely exhausted and probably wanted to sleep. She couldn't blame her. Today had been hectic and she was in an unfamiliar place with unfamiliar people. She felt a little bad about dragging her down to eat but it was good for her to get her strength back.

As they entered the Dining Hall, Angella glanced at Catra. She wanted to speak with the girl and get a feel for her, but she quickly thought better of it, realizing Catra most likely didn't want to keep being reminded about her amnesia.

It was quite difficult to start a conversation with the girl compared to Adora. While Adora was outgoing and typically more friendly, Catra was guarded and more standoffish. Even with her memory loss, some of her personality had slipped through the cracks. Catra seemed like a very grounded person and Angella could

surely find *some* common ground. As she tried to remember everything she had heard about Catra from her daughter, Bow, and Adora, she remembered that Catra had memories of a place called Earth. That would do.

"So," Angella spoke, taking her seat at the table, "I hear you have memories of a place called Earth. Care to share them?"

Catra took a seat across from Angella, thinking about that. She had previously thought she was dead before this. It had unnerved her, waking up in an unknown place with no memory of who she was. But now that feeling was gone and these people had assured her it was this crystal in her pocket that was the culprit for all of this.

She now knew that these memories she had of Earth and of America, these images in her brain. . .They belonged to someone else. She didn't know how to feel about it. They felt so real to her. The music and foods of different cultures to the cool starry nights over a pasture. But to be told they weren't hers, well that didn't sit quite well with her.

"The stars." Catra said solemnly.

"I'm sorry?" Angella asked, taken aback by the short reply.

"Etheria has several moons, but no stars. It was one of the first things I noticed when I woke up." Catra said, pausing as she turned and thanked the servants who had prepared a plate of food for her.

"Ah, I see," Angella said, silently thinking about something for a moment before speaking, "Catra, could you tell me what it was like for you when you woke up and perhaps where you woke up?"

Catra leaned back, pondering the question. Now that she thought about it, it was very terrifying waking up like she did. Looking back on it, it's a wonder she didn't die in those moments. Who wakes up bleeding and dazed and decides to climb a cliff.

"Why do you want to know?" Catra asked with narrowed eyes.

"Please? I just want to understand what you are going through. Perhaps talking about it will help." Angella said softly. It was clear to Angella that Catra was quite uncomfortable right now.

Catra thought about Mara and how much this mirrored their earlier interaction at the tavern, with Mara saying it might help to talk about it. She had been right about feeling better afterwards, but now she was unsure. If she was going to stay in this palace with this woman, she wasn't sure if she would be comfortable with that level of trust.

"Alright," Catra said after a moment, looking a bit unsure of herself, "But if I say I'm done, no pushing it. Just leave it be, okay?"

"I understand. Start whenever you're ready." Angella said, her food all but forgotten in front of her.

Taking a deep breath to center herself, Catra looked the queen in the eyes.

"I thought I was dead." Catra said matter-of-factly. At this Angella raised her eyebrows in shock. Waiting for her to continue, she leaned forward, listening intently.

"When I woke up I had no idea where I was. The memories I had weren't of Etheria but of Earth. The last thing I remembered were images of a place called Washington D.C. and had gone to sleep. To wake up in such a dark place was startling. The only logical conclusion I could come to. . .was that I had died.

"My head was pounding and I think I was bleeding. The first thing I had noticed was how sharp my senses were. I could hear farther and smell things. I hadn't realized how dark it was either. Not until I noticed my cat features did I put two and two together that I could see quite well in the dark. It wasn't pleasant." Catra continued.

For the next hour Catra explained her feelings and thoughts regarding her experiences in the forest and how she hadn't even considered that this place was her actual home. How could she? To her, she was someone from Earth and had been displaced and transported to a strange and magical land. As every minute ticked by Catra's body language was becoming more withdrawn.

Her posture had become more hunched and her hands had started to clench into fists. Her voice had become quieter now, more subdued and quiet. She was becoming agitated and it was quickly beginning to show.

"What's wrong with me? I mean, the first thing I do when I wake up is climb a cliff. I didn't even think about it, I just went for it. This whole time, everyone has told me that I'm a part of this terrible group and I'm one of the top commanders or something. Is that just a part of me?" Catra whispered, looking down at her hands. "Am I that desensitized to danger?"

Catra looked up and stared at Angella, her fists clenched, "I hadn't thought about it before, but I couldn't help but notice something. . .When the blonde woman in the forest attacked me-"

"Perfuma." Angella supplied.

"Yeah, Perfuma. When Perfuma attacked me, I instinctively knew where to dodge, like it was ingrained into me. I didn't even think about it, but I can't help but ask myself something." Catra said softly, her tone turning dark.

"If I hadn't been injured, or tired or-or stressed I couldn't think straight. . .Would I have killed that person?" Catra asked softly. The room seemed a lot colder after that.

Catra's hands trembled as she took a shaky breath, "She couldn't grab me with those vines for almost a whole minute and I was so. . .tired. So tired I passed out as soon as she grabbed me, so I have to ask," Catra looked Angella dead in the eyes, "Do you think I would have killed that girl?"

Angella noticed then that Catra's eyes were red and puffy, tears threatening to fall. The stress of the situation was becoming too much. Her claws had dug into the table and the fur on her tail had lost its smoothness. She must have taken too long to answer, because Catra had stood up and her anger and frustration was in full swing.

"I don't need eyes to know what everyone here thinks of me! It's been written on everyone's faces since I got here. 'Oh look, it's Adora's pet. Don't get too close, though. She was a Horde soldier.' Whispering about it, like I'm some kind of evil creature that will kill them and their children." Catra yelled, angry tears flowing down her face.

Angella had made a judgment error. She had assumed that, because Adora had grown up beside her that they were similar in their feelings. Without realizing it, she had pushed Catra into a corner and crowded her. Her stress was suffocating her. Angella realized a little too late, that all she wanted was some alone time.

"Well, guess what? I'm not Adora and I don't want to be and I don't want whatever the fuck this is. Everyone has been so concerned about me and saying how Adora's my best friend. If that were even a little true don't you think that she'd be here instead of taking a fucking vacation?"

By this point Catra's posture had become highly aggressive. Her tail was swishing erratically and pupils were now slits. If Angella had seen the way Catra was looking at her without knowing the events that led up to this, she would assume the girl was going to attack her. But all she saw now was a young woman who was unsure of everything around her and was reacting in a way that was subconsciously familiar to her. Anger.

"Next time you want to talk to somebody because you're feeling lonely, leave me the fuck out of it!" Catra shouted as she stormed off.

As Catra left the dining hall, Angella sat back in her chair, rubbing her eyes. Where had it all gone so wrong. She had assumed that Catra might want some company, but she had been wrong. She saw now that Catra was most likely a solitary person without Adora. As she thought about the approach she had taken with her, she took a sip of her drink and looked over at one of the guards.

"Could you go get some of the servants and have them clean this up?" Angella asked, frustration present in her voice.

"At once, your majesty." The guard nodded as she turned and left the room.

Sighing, Angella stood from the table and started walking down a hallway, her appetite all but gone. Similar to her daughter, indeed. As much as it seemed that this evening had been a waste, Angella was quite sure she had a good grasp on Catra's feelings. She would have to wait until she had calmed down to approach her. She considered waiting for Adora to return as well. It hadn't escaped her notice that the very presence of the girl calmed Catra down. Sure she had yelled at Adora as well, but that had been more of her and Glimmer somewhat agitating her.

'Ugh, I need a drink. Something strong preferably.' Angella thought to herself. She didn't drink much after her husband's death. She had to raise a daughter by herself while, simultaneously, ruling a kingdom. Her days of lounging around with a drink in hand and running off with friends had long since passed her by. Although these days, as worrisome as it was, Glimmer was out a bit more, leaving her a bit of freetime.

She thought about everything that needed to be done and decided she would handle it in the morning. As she walked, she realized where she had ended up. Looking up she saw Micah's mural on the wall. She hadn't even noticed that she had chosen this hallway. By this point, it was almost subconscious to come here when she was stressed.

She didn't know how long she stood there, thinking about the things that oftentimes were almost overwhelming. The lights in the palace had dimmed, letting Angella know it had been a few hours for sure.

"Oh, Micah. What am I supposed to do? Glimmer is growing up and all she wants to do is fight the Horde. She's so much like you it's painful. And now. . ." Angella's words slowly died. She stood there in silence for a few more moments before sighing to herself.

"Goodnight Micah." Angella whispered, turning away from the mural and making her way to her bedchambers. As she went to turn in, a guard shouted for her.

"Queen Angella, come quickly. It's the girl, She's glowing with magic. We can't get close!" The guard yelled frantically.

Abandoning all thoughts of running, Angella quickly spread her wings and flew through the palace. She found the majority of her guards surrounding Adora's room.

Catra, upon entering the room, immediately crawled into the bed. She had lost her temper and stormed off. She knew what she said was unfair to Angella. She had been the closest thing to take her frustrations out on and she had. She was only trying to help her and she lashed out.

Letting out a deep breath, she wiped her tears away. Deciding she had had enough of today, she closed her eyes and laid there in silence, hoping for sleep to come quickly. Everything seemed to have gone downhill after she had left. . .Mara.

She took out the shard and looked at it. Whatever had caused her to appear in that village, the shard had something to do with it. The weird water wall, the shard, the path, the voice. . .It all added up to something she didn't have the answers to. But one thing was for certain. She was not left handed, but she had been when she was with Mara.

Narrowing her eyes at the shard, she envisioned Mara and the shard began to emit a slight glow. Sitting up, she put the shard down on the bed beside her. Earlier she couldn't make it glow without holding it, but now she was determined to understand this thing. Sleep was all but forgotten by this point.

As she sat on the bed, she crossed her legs and focused on the shard. Thoughts of Mara crossed her mind. As she thought about her the crystal glowed. So she could make it glow without touching it. Narrowing her eyes she envisioned every little detail on Mara's face. Her tan skin and brown hair, her sharp gray eyes and thin nose.

With every detail she pictured, the glow got stronger and brighter. But the hum did not appear. Perhaps that only happened when she held it. Closing her eyes she focused on the wall of water and her reflection. How it felt when she had crossed the barrier. She felt something inside of her. A rush of power and energy flowed through her body, coursing through her veins. Pure elation flew through her body as she focused. She laughed at the feeling and opened her eyes.

She found that she was glowing with magic. The colors illuminating her were of every hue. She couldn't focus on anything but her reflection now. Her thoughts were locked on to it and on Mara. The feelings she had when talking with Mara. If she wasn't feeling the pure joy of the magic around her and inside of her she might have realized this wasn't quite normal.

Catra under any circumstances would have found this experience horrifying. Her thoughts were completely overrun and she was completely paralyzed. She could do nothing about it but wait. But Catra wasn't thinking, she couldn't. The magic had completely overtaken her senses. The glow from her body had illuminated the room and hall with a brilliant light.

The door was flung off of its frame as Angella entered, her hands primed with magic. There she saw Catra hovering in the air, her body encompassed in magical energies. As she approached, the

energy arced off of Catra, licking the walls and lashing out at everything and anyone in range.

Angella told the guards to stay back. If her theory was correct, this energy was what affected Catra in the first place, making her lose her memories. But she couldn't allow this to continue. She had to do something. Catra was emitting more magic than she thought she could handle.

Just then, she noticed the soul crystal. It was floating in front of Catra, glowing with a cold, icy blue color that Castaspella had warned her about. She remembered that a princess could not be affected due to their connections to their runestones. With determination fueling her steps, she pushed through the magic, each step becoming harder, as if her body was becoming heavier. As she neared Catra, the energy lashed out at Angella, all of the magic now focused on her.

Angella fell to a knee, the pressure becoming immense. It felt suffocating. Her body felt like it was on fire. Every nerve was screaming out in pain as she inched closer. Her vision was blurry, the colors so bright it was almost blinding.

"*Stop."* An eerie voice whispered in her ear

Angella's blood went cold as an icy chill ran through her body. The voice hadn't been Catra's, nor had it been one of her guards. Angella looked straight ahead, turning her focus on the energy, rather than Catra and the stone. She couldn't be sure but it was almost like a face had appeared.

"*Stay back."* It spoke in a louder voice, becoming much clearer, as Angella got closer.

This must have been the woman Castaspella had warned her about. Anger replaced the feeling of dread she felt as she pressed forward. How dare this woman take advantage of this girl. Taking away people's memories for her own agenda. It was horrible and sick.

"*I need her help."* The woman said in a pleading tone.

Angella was only a few feet from the crystal now. As she went to take another step, the feeling of pressure faded, all pain in her body gone. Angella almost stumbled from her own strength because of the rapid deterioration of the strain. Angella stopped and looked at the energy again. She could now see the full silhouette of this woman, but couldn't make out any details of her. Although several pieces were missing, almost like she had been torn apart.

"*Please, you don't understand. Give me a chance to explain."* The woman said, now almost completely visible to Angella, or rather as visible as a silhouette could be.

She realized she could breathe again as the pressure was gone. She also realized that the violent energies had ceased and everything seemed quite calm. Looking around the room, she took notice of the magic field around her. The room and the people around her were frozen. Unmoving, like they were statues. The objects that were flying around the room were also frozen.

"What did you do to them?" Angella asked, her tone cold and full of suspicion. Her wings outstretched in a threatening manner.

"*Nothing, time is frozen outside of this field."* She said in a matter-of-factly manner.

Turning back towards Catra, she noticed she was unconscious. And snoring. Breathing a small sigh of relief, she looked back at the woman. She couldn't see much of her but one thing did stand out. She had a blue gem on her chest.

'Seeing the woman is bad enough, hearing her speak is even worse.' There was no doubt about it, this was the woman Castaspella had warned her about. She was to contact her if she had ever heard Catra speak about her. Castaspella had said this woman could only appear in dreams, yet here she was in front of her, talking to her while she was wide awake.

"*I don't have much time so ask your questions quickly."* She spoke, a sense of urgency in her voice.

"Who are you and what have you done to Catra?" Angella asked with her eyes narrowed. Her tone was filled with hostility.

"*I. . .It's hard to explain."* The woman said in a small voice.

"Try," Angella's icy tone leaving no room for argument, "or I will grab this crystal, your explanations be damned."

"*I can't answer who I am, that knowledge is in the other pieces. I'm missing pieces of myself as you can see. And Catra's fine, she's just unconscious. This happens when you fuse the shards back together."* The woman quickly explained.

Angella took notice of the fading magic, the room becoming slightly darker as the glow dulled. Looking at the shard did indeed show it was bigger and there was no sign of a previous split.

"That is quite convenient for you, isn't it. I want answers that you can only give if Catra touches more shards. Everything I have heard to this point indicates if Catra even touches another shard, that it will lead to insanity and permanent loss of her memories. And you want her to grab more?" Angella said. If this woman was supposed to be manipulative and corrupting, she wasn't going about it the right way.

"*No, it won't. Not with Catra. I need her, she's the only one that can help me. With every shard she puts together, her memories should return. Everyone else who has touched the shards should know not to channel magic through them. They have a specific warning ingrained into them by my people that everyone hears before using them."* The woman said urgently. The magic was fading faster now.

"Who are your people exactly? Why Catra?" Angella asked with a sense of urgency. The light almost gone and the woman's form starting to dissipate.

"*We are the Eternians. Catra has a connection with She-Ra due to her friendship with Mara."* The woman said, her voice becoming almost hollow and wispy.

"Catra spoke of a Mara earlier. She talked about her as if they just met." Angella said, confused.

"*That's not possible. She should have an innate connection with her that draws her to Mara, regardless of her memory loss. Catra's close friendship with the current holder of She-Ra is what allows her to use the shards safely. She has to know Mara."* The woman's voice was becoming much harder to hear now, almost like it was becoming far away.

"Catra *is* friends with the holder of She-Ra. They grew up together. But that person is not this Mara girl you're talking about. The current She-Ra's name is Adora." Angella said, her thoughts all over the place.

"*Adora? That's not possi-"* The woman's voice was cut off, the magic gone, everything starting to move again. Angella quickly reached out, catching Catra before she could hit the ground. She looked at the shard as it hit the ground.

'I'm quickly becoming annoyed with this.' Angella thought with a scowl. The guards all breathed a sigh of release. The situation seemed handled as they were dismissed by Angella.

As Angella laid Catra down in bed, she walked over and picked the shard up off the ground. Examining it for a moment before pocketing it, she walked back into the hallway.

"If she starts glowing again, come get me immediately. No exceptions." Angella commanded the guards.

"Yes, your majesty." The guards responded in sync.

Angella nodded at that and turned in for the night. As she closed the door to her chambers, she took the shard out and rolled it around in her palm. It was cool to the touch and had a slight hum

to it. She held it up to the moonlight examining it. As she held it up it began to glow, the hum becoming slightly louder. Immediately Angella understood the purpose of the hum.

Angella aimed it in the direction of Mystacor. The effect was instant as it lit up in her hand, the hum vibrating the air around it. The coolness of the stone now had a strange heat to it, almost like the moonstone.

"So it leads you to the other shards does it? I will keep that in mind." Angella said to herself as she put the crystal piece away.

Chapter 4

Mara paced inside the medical bay at the Arxia outpost. It had been around fifteen hours since Catra had started glowing and passed out and it was now early morning. She had tried to heal her as She-Ra to no avail. It made no sense. She-Ra could heal anything, so why did it fail?

Deciding to check on her again she went to grab her sword from the table she had left it at before an arm shot out grabbing her wrist. Mara whipped her head towards the person who had grabbed her. It was a woman with short red hair and green eyes. Along her nose were splotches of freckles. She was about six feet tall and had lean, strong muscles.

"Oh, hey Serenia." Mara said softly. Releasing a breath she hadn't known she was holding. Serenia let her wrist go as Mara took a seat by the door into Catra's room.

"That's Fleet Captain Serenia to you Ensign" Serenia said jokingly, a small smile on her face. At the lack of a smile from Mara, Serenia sighed.

"Hey, listen. She's going to be fine. You healed her, now all you have to do is wait. The rest is on her. Your part is done." Serenia said softly. Mara sighed, but didn't make a move to leave the room.

Serenia's eyes slightly narrowed, "Listen, your actions are making everybody uneasy. You showed up with an unconscious girl who looks like she's from Krytis and you haven't left the Medbay in almost fifteen hours."

Mara glanced at her for a moment before turning her head back towards the door, ignoring the woman. As Mara fiddled with the hilt of her sword, Serenia's face scrunched up in a scowl.

Serenia's hand whipped out and grabbed Mara's chin, forcing her to look at her, "I know you hear me, so stop ignoring me. You are scaring people. Forget about this girl and do your fucking job."

Mara immediately stood up, slapping her hand away from her face, "Do not touch me. And on another note, how about you go do *your* job, Fleet Captain Serenia. Do not tell me how to be She-Ra."

"No, see, that's not how this works. You listen and follow orders. You are a soldier and will do your damn job, which by the way is not being concerned about some Cat girl you found at the tavern. On that note, She-Ra can't be seen getting drunk at some tavern. You have an image to uphold" Serenia spoke in a commanding tone.

"My job is to be She-Ra, which makes this my job. Being concerned with the health of innocent people is my job, and I wasn't She-Ra when I was drinking. How I choose to spend my free-time is my choice." Mara fired back with equal intensity in her voice, before her voice dropped in volume, "And even if I wasn't in here, the people *should* be scared. Whatever is going on has everyone on edge. I know you feel it too. Somethings wrong, Serenia."

Serenia looked around, before lashing out and grabbing Mara's shirt and pulling her close, "Whatever you think is going on, I suggest you drop it Mara. We don't need to worry about whatever the higher ups are doing. We just need to harvest the damn magic and leave. There's enough here that the people won't even notice. The people will be fine. We aren't here to hurt anyone."

Serenia took a deep breath before letting Mara go, dusting her shoulders off, "Listen, I'll give you another hour in here before you have to leave. You're being requested by the Admiral. Don't be any later than that. I can't stand it when he's angry."

"And you think I can?" Mara asked, straightening her shirt.

"I *think* that if you are late, I will have you cleaning the ships' bathrooms." Serenia said with an expectant look. Mara sighed and nodded, "Don't worry, I won't be late."

"Oh I'm not worried. You'll give it your all, you always do. It's your best quality." Serenia said, closing the door behind her as she left Mara alone.

Mara took several deep breaths, clenching her fists tightly. Why didn't anyone listen to her? Something was wrong and nobody was willing to see it but her.

"Wow, that was something else. But yeah, she's totally right. God forbid you have some fun." A snarky voice behind her said, breaking the silence.

Mara whipped around, seeing Catra standing in the doorway. Mara immediately ran over to her, embracing her into a hug.

"Alright, that's enough of that." Catra said with a grin, pushing Mara off of her gently.

"You're okay. When you passed out and didn't wake up after I healed you I got worried." Mara said, relieved at the sight of Catra healthy.

"Yep, I'm alright. But I didn't leave? Have I been in this room the whole time?" Catra asked with a scowl. Mara's brow furrowed.

"Yeah, why? Did something happen?" Mara asked, concerned again.

"I think. . .I'm sensing a pattern here," Catra said slowly, putting the pieces together, "Can I see your sword for a second. I think I know what's going on, or at least a theory."

"Sure, but what's going on?" Mara said, handing the sword out to Catra.

Catra took the sword, examining it thoroughly. Yep, there was little doubt about it. Adora and Mara had the same sword. Although Adora's did have a few differences. Catra looked back at Mara as she handed her the sword back.

"You said that this Razz person calls you Adora, right?" Catra said, her eyebrows drawn together and her eyes narrowed. A look of focus and determination on her face.

"Yeah, she constantly calls me that. Why? What happened?" Mara quickly becoming desperate to know what Catra was withholding.

"Alright, then. Let's go see Razz. I'll explain everything once we're on the road." Catra said with a tone of finality.

"Wait a second Catra. Talk to me first. What happened to you?" Mara asked, putting her hands up in front of Catra.

Catra thought about it for a second, before speaking with a hint of caution, "When I told you everything that happened to me after I woke up, you believed me right? You didn't think I was crazy?"

"No, I believed you. And I still believe you. So talk to me." Mara said calmly.

"Alright, when I passed out the first time, I walked until I found the wall of water right? Well, when I passed out in front of you, I woke up beside Adora again. Except she was holding your sword. She was saying that she also knew Madame Razz. But she said that she calls her Mara." Catra said, looking at Mara with a raised eyebrow.

"That. . .is really strange. How long were you awake with Adora over there?" Mara questioned, intrigued at the prospect of some answers to this mystery.

"I don't know, around a day. Let's see. . .maybe fourteen hours, could've been fifteen." Catra said, pausing to think about it.

"You've been asleep for fifteen hours." Mara muttered, more to herself than Catra.

As she thought about this, Catra took note of her current clothing. She wasn't wearing her robes anymore. It looked more. . .militaristic? It was strange. Checking her pockets, she realized that the shard was gone.

"Hey, what happened to the shard?" Catra broke Mara from her thoughts.

"Oh, I'm not quite sure. It was gone when I brought you here. I even went back to check for it. It's like it vanished." Mara explained.

"Well, forgetting that for a second, let's go see Razz. I have some questions I want some answers to." Catra said matter-of-factly.

Mara grabbed Catra's shoulder, stopping her from passing, "We can't go yet. I have to go see the Admiral. He'll make my day hell if I don't show up."

"Forget that guy. Just don't show up, it's what I'd do." Catra said.

"I can't, I have responsibilities to my squad. I can't just go running off when I have orders." Mara said, final on the matter.

Catra looked to the side while biting the inside of her cheek, slowly nodding before clicking her tongue, "Alright, well then. . .I'll see you later."

With that, Catra jumped over Mara and walked to the door before opening it. Mara made a sound of exclamation, voicing her shock.

"Catra, where are you going?" Mara asked, exasperated. Catra, without even stopping, simply responded with a shrug.

"To find Razz. You said she wasn't far from that village. Of course, I might get lost and taken advantage of, what with my memory problem and all. Oh well, I guess that's just how the world works.

It's okay, Adora said she'd help me too, but she ran off with her other friends and left me all alone. But don't worry, I'm sure I'll manage by myself." Catra said a tone of fake despair in her voice, walking a bit slower.

"I'll let Razz know you said hi. Y'know, if I don't get eaten by the wildlife first. I guess I'll see you later Mara. Thanks for being my friend while it lasted." It was getting a little harder to keep the grin out of her voice. Catra paused for a moment, not once looking back at Mara.

"Laying on a bit thick there, Catra. By the way, you suck." Mara said with a small smile, turning her sword back into her gauntlet. "Well, come on then. Razz is waiting."

"Yesss, I knew you were an awesome friend." Catra said, glee present on her face.

"Yeah, yeah." Mara said, "If I have to clean the ships' bathrooms because of you, you're gonna help me, got it?"

"Yeah,yeah. But only if you bring some more food and drinks, *got it*?" Catra said in a mock tone, smirking.

Mara smiled and nodded, "Sure, now come on before somebody catches us."

Catra and Mara walked through the outpost, unfettered in their efforts of securing a ride to Madame Razz' hut. As Catra walked with Mara, she took note of the weird technology. People marching with a purpose, scientists going over reports and numbers. Everyone had somewhere to be.

"*March, cadets! I wanna see those legs moving. Kyle! Why are you falling behind? Lonnie, pick up the pace. Rojelio, go faster. Adora, nice work. Catra, I'm impressed for once.*

"*Everyone, STOP! Does everyone see Catra's times? I want to see everyone beat that by next week. That includes you Cadet Catra. Do you all understand?*"

"*Yes, Captain!" They all said in unison.*

"*I said 'Do you all UNDERSTAND!"*

"*YES, CAPTAIN!" They responded even louder.*

"*Good, then get back to running."*

"Hey, are you all good? You kind of froze there for a second." Mara shook her shoulder lightly, concern written on her face.

"Y-yeah, I'm fine. I think. . .I think I just remembered something from my past." Catra said, her brow furrowed.

"Oh yeah? What?" Mara asked, slowing her stride to walk beside Catra.

"I was being told to run by a voice, like, loudly. With a bunch of other kids." Catra explained, trying to remember more with no luck.

"Like, run how? Like playing tag?" Mara asked.

"No, it was more like 'Run, Cadets and keep Running!' kind of run. And we called the voice Captain." Catra said slowly.

"Hmmm, that sounds almost militaristic. Didn't you get told that you were a part of something called the Horde? Must be a military of some kind." Mara explained. As Catra thought about everything she had heard from Angella, Mara nudged her arm.

"We're here" Mara said, snapping catra out of her thoughts. In front of her was some sort of vehicle with hovering capabilities. It almost seemed familiar in a way. Shaking her head, Catra hopped up onto the top of it. Mara was taking a moment to board the vehicle, not quite as dextrous and agile as Catra.

"Need a hand?" Catra asked, her hand outstretched.

Mara took her hand before being pulled up. "Thanks. . .you're pretty strong for someone your size."

"What do you mean by that?" Catra asked in a nonchalant manner with a raised eyebrow.

"It's just that, you know. . .you're kind of small. No offense." Mara said sheepishly.

"None taken, although I suppose you're right. Must be my feline features." Catra said while taking a seat in one of the chairs. "It's okay, you can be jealous." A smug tone present in her voice.

"Oh, I'm not jealous," Mara said, as she started the engine and took off towards Razz' location, "Just slightly impressed. Only slightly though." Mara said with a teasing tone.

About two hours went by with Catra and Mara settling into a comfortable silence. The wind carried several pleasant scents and a pleasurable breeze. Catra yawned, her thoughts drifting towards the shard. It wasn't in her pocket anymore, which was slightly worrying, but she could worry about that later. Right now, she was going to see if this woman could answer her question. As she listened to the sound of the wind and smelled the breeze her head began to ache with a dull pain. Closing her eyes, she rubbed her temples, hoping to alleviate the headache. As she focused on the hum of the ship, she started to remember something. It was so vivid it was almost like she was there.

"*I take it all back. You're officially awesome. I can't believe you actually stole a skiff." Catra said, pure joy in her voice.*

"*Borrowed. Please don't make me regret this." Adora said, slightly exasperated.*

"*I've always wanted to drive one of these things. Here, gimme." Catra said gleefully, reaching over and grabbing the controls.*

"*Whoa, there. Save us enough fuel to get back." Adora said, a hint of caution in her tone.*

"*That's a problem for future Adora and Catra." Catra said, not worried in the slightest.*

"Hey, are you okay? You've been rubbing your temples for a bit."

"Yeah, I think I'm fine. It's just a headache, Adora. Stop worrying." Catra muttered. She snapped her head towards Mara, realizing what she just said.

"I'm so sorry, I didn't mean to-" Catra went to explain before being cut off.

"Hey, don't worry about it. I'm pretty sure that's normal for people with Amnesia. But does that mean you remembered something?" Mara asked hopefully. Catra examined Mara and it really did seem like she wasn't bothered.

"Yeah. . .yeah, I did. I was on a vehicle, kind of like this one but it looked a little different." Catra explained slowly, trying to remember all of the details.

"Adora was there, right? Is that why you said her name?" Mara asked.

"Yeah, we had stolen the skiff, er, the vehicle I mean. She said 'borrowed' though. And we needed enough fuel to get back. I felt so ecstatic for some reason. But I guess I didn't care about the fuel? It's kind of hazy. Like I don't have the whole picture." Catra said, rubbing her eyes. She looked at Mara with an apologetic look.

"You don't need to help me, you know that, right? If I'm being a bother-" Catra went to continue before being cut off.

"Don't be ridiculous. I want to help you. We're friends, remember? Friends help each other out. Besides, if I get in trouble then they can shove it. What are they gonna do, ground She-Ra?" Mara said with a chuckle. "By the way, this vehicle is called a sky-craft."

Catra gave a small smile before sitting back. It was nice to have someone to talk to. After a moment, her thoughts drifted towards Angella. She'd invited her to dinner and wanted to talk with her, only for her to insult and demean her. She resolved to apologize to her next time she saw her. Another hour passed before Mara spoke over her shoulder.

"Hey Catra." Mara said, breaking Catra from her thoughts.

"Yeah? Are we almost there?" Catra asked. Mara shook her head in response.

"Well yeah, but that's not what I was gonna say. Have you considered a journal? Or maybe a recording? For your memories, I mean." Mara said kindly. Not too sure if this was a sore subject at the moment.

"Like writing? I mean. . .not really, but I suppose I could. Why would you suggest that?" Catra asked, confused.

"Well, several members of my platoon keep video journals. It's a good way to talk about things that bother you so that it isn't all bottled up. In your case you can record things you remember. I do it too sometimes." A moment of silence passed before Mara continued in a quieter tone. "It helps. When you don't have anyone to talk to. . . or don't want anyone."

Catra got the sense that this particular topic may have been a bit important to Mara. Catra hummed to herself for a couple of seconds before speaking up.

"No, I hadn't. But if you think it'll help, I'll give it a try. Couldn't hurt, right?" Catra said with a gentle smile. Mara smiled to herself as she veered the sky-craft toward the forests below.

As they descended, Catra noticed a small hunched figure with white hair and pink skin. She was also holding a. . .broom? Mara landed before hopping off and walking towards the woman with a smile.

"Hey Razz, how are you?" Mara asked with a beaming smile.

"Adora dearie, I'm doing well. I see you've brought company. Have you come to help me bake another pie?" Razz asked as she started walking around the area, picking things up and putting them in her basket.

"Maybe later Razz. I wanted to ask you some questions. This is Catra. She's having some memory problems and she knows Adora and. . . Mara?" Mara said confused, unsure of how to address the wording.

"Ohhh, Catra. How is Mara? I can't wait for her to visit again. We need to bake a pie soon." Razz said without so much as sparing a glance at Catra.

Catra whispered to Mara as Razz walked back into the hut.

"You weren't kidding. This woman is strange. Why is she acting like she already knew who I was?" Catra asked with confusion. Mara merely shrugged her shoulders.

"I'm not sure, but she kind of acted like that with me too. But she didn't get my name right. Like I said, she calls me Adora." Mara said with a look that didn't inspire confidence.

"Hm, well let's go see if she can provide any answer about whatever is happening to me." Catra said, walking past Mara towards the hut.

As she went to move the drape that acted as the door, Razz came walking out with a pie. Catra quickly jumped out of the way, narrowly avoiding a collision with the old woman. Catra watched her zigzag throughout the clearing, stopping and picking things up, or just simply setting things down.

Catra let out a growl of annoyance. This was not helping in the slightest. As she went to march towards the woman, Mara stepped in front of her putting her hands on Catra's shoulders.

"Let me talk to her, okay? I don't want you getting too irritated and passing out again." Mara said placatingly. Catra, with narrowed eyes, nodded after a moment.

"Fine." Catra said, taking a seat on a nearby rock. Mara smiled and walked towards Razz.

"Razz, Catra has lost most of her memories and we thought you might know something." Mara said. Razz squinted at Mara for a moment before shaking her head.

"Nope." And with that Razz turned and went back to collecting her ingredients.

"Well. . .This was a waste of time. Looks like we're cleaning bathrooms for the rest of the day. Come on Mara." Catra said flatly, already turned around and walking back towards the sky-craft.

"Catra, you can't just give up that easily." Mara said, exasperatedly.

"I totally can. Watch, it's easy," Catra cleared her throat, and straightened up, "Mara, I give up. See how easy that was? Let's go."

Mara rolled her eyes, before grabbing Catra's wrist. "Just give me a second, please. I'm sure Razz has some sort of idea. It just takes her a moment. Besides, you don't know how to operate the sky-craft."

Catra sighed before gesturing towards Razz. "Go on then."

Mara turned back towards Razz and started saying something. Catra tuned out whatever was being spoken between the two. She caught a whiff of something sweet and turned towards the hut. It smelled amazing and seeing as how Mara was talking to the weird woman at the moment, there was no reason she shouldn't investigate.

As she took a final look over her shoulder at Mara and Razz, she snuck into the hut. It was bigger than she thought it would be. There were vases of all kinds of things strewn around the room. She ignored the weirdness of the space in favor of the delicious smell coming from one of the rooms. As she maneuvered through the clutter, she saw it. There, on the window sill was a pie. She could see from the steam wafting off of it that it was freshly baked.

As she made her way to the pie, she extended the claw from her index finger and went to stab the pie. All of a sudden, she was hit in the back of the head from a broom. It wasn't necessarily a hard hit, more startling than anything. She quickly whipped around at the offending object raised to strike her again. Snaking a hand towards the broom, she yanked it out of the weird purple woman's hands.

"No, bad, bad!" Razz shouted, "No touching the pie until it's done."

Catra bared her teeth and let out a slight snarl. Even if she was trespassing, she didn't think she deserved to be hit in the back of the head with a broom. Mara had literally just said that she had memory problems and the first thing this woman does is to try and give her more of them?

"Woah, easy Catra. She didn't mean anything by it." Mara said calmly. Catra looked towards the woman before throwing the broom down to the side.

"Did you get what we needed from her? Because I'm losing my patience with her." Catra said with an irritated tone. Razz went to pick her broom up, muttering something about Adora.

"Yep, I got it. She told me a few things that pertain to your situation. We just-"

"Good, then let's get the hell out of here. I'm sick of crazy crones with brooms" Catra cut Mara off, stomping past her. Mara pursed

her lips and let out a breath. She had been hoping that Catra would like Razz. Her earlier interaction with her told her that Catra liked etheria and its beauty. She was a fun person who Mara got along with surprisingly well and should have, by all accounts, gotten along with Razz.

"Sorry Razz, she's just going through a lot right now. I'm sure she doesn't mean it." Mara said apologetically. Razz waved her off as she cut a piece of pie and handed it to Mara.

"It's fine Adora dearie. She's just upset because Mara and her are having troubles. Once they start talking again, she will feel better. Here, give her this. It will help calm her down. Razz' pie helps." Razz said.

Mara gave a small smile and took the pie. "Thanks Razz, I'll tell her you said that. And I'll give her the pie."

As Mara left the hut, she noticed that the day was almost half over. The trip here had taken roughly three hours and wouldn't be any faster on the way back. She thought about Catra's behavior and how she had interacted earlier compared to now. Mara couldn't piece it together without knowing more about Catra, though what she had learned about Catra thus far was painting a picture that she didn't like.

The ride back was quiet, neither saying a word. Catra had taken the pie but hadn't said anything beyond a quiet thank you. About halfway through the ride, Mara slowed the sky-craft to a halt and swiveled around in her chair to face Catra.

"What? Why are we stopping?" Catra asked.

"I want to talk to you and this seems like the quietest spot I can think of. There's no one up here besides us." A moment of silence passed before Mara spoke, "So, want to talk about whatever that was?"

Catra looked to the side, remaining silent. Mara pursed her lips, before slightly bobbing her head, "So, does this have something to do with Adora then? Is that the reason you're pissed off?"

Catra gave a small glance at her before looking away from her.

"I'm just wondering, you know? Because you kind of flew off the rails back there. So what's the deal Catra? I'm trying to help you here and you're kind of spitting in my face here? What am I supposed to make of that?"

"You don't need to help me, alright? I can figure this out on my own." Catra said quietly.

"I'm She-Ra, Catra. It's kind of my job to help people. So tell me. Did you remember something?" Mara said.

Catra seemed to think about something before standing up and walking towards the edge of the sky-craft. As she looked over the railing at the scenery, she spoke up.

"It's Adora." Catra said with a huff.

"You've got to explain it to me, Catra. I can't understand what you're going through off of that." Mara said.

"She left, okay? I don't know why that is so irritating to me, but it is." Catra said, turning to look at Mara.

"According to her, I'm her bestest friend in the whole world. But I am in clear need of some help and she runs off with these two people she, apparently, just met to some magical castle. I don't even remember her besides a few memories which I *just* got back. So why does it bother me so much? Why am I so angry? So go on. Help me *She-Ra*" Catra said in a nasty tone.

Mara leaned back in her chair. "I'm not sure how this Adora person thinks or what her exact relationship with you is and it's clear to me that you don't either. What I do know is that this

feeling you're having. . .it extends to more than this single moment."

"What do you mean?" Catra asked, some of her hostility fading from her voice.

"I mean this most likely has something to do with your memory loss. These feelings are there from something else and it's kind of subconscious. My advice to you is to get those shards. When you touched one you got some of your memories back right?"

Catra stopped for a moment to think about that. She had touched the shard and experimented with it a bit. After she had woken up, she had received a few flashbacks along with her anger. In fact, she wasn't really upset about Adora leaving until after she had fiddled with the shard. Specifically before dinner with Angella. She realized Mara was right. When she had remembered something without the shard, it had sent her into a panic attack. But with the shard it had been natural.

Catra's eyes slightly widened, "You're right. The shards are the key. I think my memories are in the shards. How did you even come to that conclusion?"

"It seemed obvious. To me at least." Mara quickly added the last part.

Mara was getting a grasp on Catra's character here. Unfortunately, Mara was realizing her earlier thoughts on Catra seemed more and more likely. The anger towards Adora, the flashbacks of Marching, the militaristic upbringing, and most recently Catra was irrationally angry at Adora for leaving. It all pointed to something Mara wasn't quite comfortable with. She needed more to go off of. It was best not to make an assumption just yet.

"Earlier, you said that you had more shards? Do you use them for anything?" Catra asked, breaking Mara out of her thoughts.

"Actually, now that I think about it, not really? All of their power went into making the sword. Nowadays they're just pretty paper

weights. Although we have around five of them in a vault back on base. If these things will give you your memories back then I'll get them for you. Nobody even uses them for anything."

Mara swiveled back around and started to fly forward again. As Catra sat back in her seat, she thought about what Mara had said. For some reason, she could talk to Mara without being so angry. Ever since she woke up, everyone had judged her. But not Mara. She never once got one of those looks from her.

"Sorry." Catra said quietly.

"That sounded physically painful to say." Mara said teasingly. Catra chuckled to herself and then went quiet.

"I mean it. I'm sorry. You've been nothing but helpful and kind and I keep lashing out. You haven't judged me once. So thank you for that." Catra said.

"Well, like I said earlier. We're friends. *You look out for me and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other" Adora said.*

"*You promise?" Catra asked in a small voice.*

"*I promise." Adora said with a smile.*

"What?" Catra asked out loud.

"I said we're almost there. You alright? You kind of spaced out there for a second." Mara asked, looking over her shoulder.

"Uh, yeah. Yeah, I'm fine. Don't worry about it." Catra said blankly.

As Mara piloted the craft down to the hangar, Catra noticed the woman Mara had been speaking to earlier in the morning. Serenia, she recalled. She wore a scowl, while crossing her arms and tapping her foot. All in all, not a good sight for Mara.

As soon as the sky-craft was docked and shut down, Serenia wasted no time in marching up to Mara as she dismounted the vehicle.

"Where in the hell have you been? I said one hour at the latest. It has been six. The Admiral is pissed off and I am now getting my ass chewed out. What the hell Mara?" Serenia exclaimed loudly, pointing at a large building. Before Mara could utter a response, Catra spoke up.

"Yeesh, you want to talk louder, I don't think the base heard you." Catra said dismissively, jumping down beside Mara.

"I see you woke up and are fine. Good, that means you don't need to keep bothering Mara. Beat it." Serenia said, seething.

"Mmmmm, no. I think I like bothering Mara. And besides, I promised to help her clean a bathroom if she had to. On that topic, come on Mara. Let's go talk to this Admiral. Better late than never." Catra said, completely ignoring Serenia by this point.

"It's too late for that. He already took care of the problem that he needed Mara for. So believe me when I say this. You. Will. Make those floors. Shine." Serenia said with clenched teeth.

Catra let out a snort, cutting off Mara once more. "So what exactly was it that he needed Mara for? I'm quite curious."

"Why don't you go ask him when you're done cleaning. I'm going to go try and calm him down." Serenia said, storming off.

Catra looked at Mara. Her head was hung low with clenched fists. Catra didn't know why but that look seemed eerily familiar and not in a good way. Before Mara could even go to say something, Catra let out a laugh. Mara raised her head to look at Catra, the tension in her body loosening somewhat.

"Yeah, like that's gonna happen. Come on, let's go see this admiral now." Catra said, grabbing her hand and pulling her towards the large building that Serenia had pointed at.

"Catra, wait. We can't just go to him. If I give it a bit of time, he'll most likely calm down enough that I can talk with him. Let's go clean the bathrooms first." Mara said with a defeated tone. Catra hummed at that. She didn't like the tone Mara was giving.

Mara was normally quite confident and sure in her movements. Here, she seemed so small. Catra narrowed her eyes, thinking about what she was feeling. She was sure of it. This feeling was too familiar to her and it wasn't a good one either. Catra took a breath and looked Mara directly in the eye.

"No, he can talk to us now. I'm not going to wait because he wants to throw a fit like a child. He's an Admiral, he should act like it. And you. You're She-Ra aren't you? I'm not sure what that is, but from what I can gather that means you have a lot of power, right?" Catra exclaimed.

"Yeah, I am very powerful as She-Ra. But that also means I have to do my-" Mara went to finish before being cut off.

"It means you don't have to take shit from anyone. If you really have that much power, then you don't need to scrub some floors because somebody's feelings got hurt." Catra said, throwing her hands up.

"I am still a member of GreySkull, Catra. Even if I'm She-Ra, it doesn't mean I'm exempt from responsibility. I broke the rules and now I have to accept the punishment." Mara said in a defeated tone.

"Not while you hold that sword." Catra said with an icy tone. Mara froze at that. She wasn't sure why that seemed to strike her at her core, but it did. Before she could say anything, Catra had already turned to walk towards the building.

"Are you coming with me or not? Serenia waited all day. Her little bathroom break can wait one more hour." Catra called over her shoulder. Mara shook her head, letting out a noise of annoyance.

"Wait for me." Mara said, walking after her. Catra gave a smirk.

"Cool, glad you're coming. Now which way is it to this guy, because my plan was to start kicking doors in." Catra said sheepishly. Mara rolled her eyes and took the lead.

"Come on."

As they walked through the building, she took notice of the people around her. Some looked like soldiers, others looked like standard civilians. It was bizarre in the fact that she could see some sort of militant infrastructure woven through the residents. She doubted she would have seen it had she not had some small semblance of her Horde memories back.

As they neared a decorated door, Catra could hear yelling. There were several people standing at the side of the door that saluted Mara as she approached. Their stances relaxed as she nodded at them. Mara took a breath before reaching towards the door switch. Suddenly the door and Serenia came out of the room. Catra couldn't get a glimpse at the woman, but she swore she was on the verge of crying. As Catra went to speak to her, what looked like a tablet of sorts hit her in the back of the head.

"And go get Mara for fuck's sake. I don't know why I have to deal with this shit. I needed her over five hours ago. Do your damn job Captain Serenia!" A man's voice yelled from inside the room.

Catra looked at Serenia as she leaned against the wall, blood leaking from the back of her head as she held a hand over it. Fury filled Catra's veins. She walked up to Serenia and leaned down to pick the tablet up. Serenia looked at Catra, confusion written on her face. Mara, seeing what Catra was about to do, was a second too late to stop her.

"Catra, don't!" Mara cried.

At the words, the Admiral turned towards the voice as Catra reared her arm back, took a step forward, and put her whole body behind the throw as she hurled the broken tablet into the man's face. The man's nose erupted into blood as he stumbled back into

his desk. The sickening crunch told everyone present that Catra had most definitely broken his nose. As he held his face, he looked up and glared at Catra with rage.

"Thought you might want that back," Catra's tone thick with rage, "By the way, Mara's here if you wanted to order her around that badly. Me on the other hand. . .I have no problem telling you how it is."

As he pushed himself up, the guards at the door were unsure of what to do. On one hand, this unknown woman marched into their base and assaulted the Admiral. On the other, she was currently standing beside Mara, who had made no move to restrain her. They looked at the Admiral questioningly, unsure of how to proceed.

With narrowed eyes, the man straightened up and his hand began to glow. Within seconds his nose was healed, the only indicator of his previous injury being the blood on his face. As he took in the sight of Catra, he noticed that Serenia was bleeding profusely from the back of her head. Sighing, his visage softened as he strode past Catra up to Serenia.

"I apologize Serenia. I did not mean to hit you with that. It was not my intent." He said in a remorseful tone as his hand hovered over Serenia's injury, glowing.

"What *did* you mean to hit then? The wall? That throw was a little too accurate for an accident." Catra said in a skeptical tone. The Admiral looked back at her as he lowered his hand.

"I don't particularly care *what* you believe. As far as I'm concerned, the unconscious girl that Mara brought back is now in good enough health to throw things. She may leave now." The Admiral said in a commanding tone, leaving no room for argument.

"Oh yeah? You wanna see what else I can throw at-" Catra was cut off by Mara before she could continue.

"Catra!" Mara said firmly. Catra turned in disbelief.

"You're taking this asshole's side? What the hell Mara. He just busted your friend's head open." Catra said, throwing her arms up.

"I understand that. But you just broke his nose. I'd say that's fair." Mara said, trying to diffuse the tense situation.

"It's not about being fair, it's about getting even. I don't like Serenia very much, but that doesn't give him the right to throw shit at her like he's a fucking child who got his toy taken away." Catra exclaimed, defending her stance fiercely.

"Why, you little-" The Admiral went to speak before being cut off by Mara, who by this point had had enough.

"ENOUGH!" Mara declared, her sword glowing as she slammed it into the floor. The air had turned thick at her declaration. The guards shifted nervously, knowing that an angry Mara wasn't good for anyone's health.

"What did you want, Admiral Stratos? Speak fast as I'm quickly losing my patience." Mara said coolly. The now named Admiral took a deep breath. He had seen first hand how dangerous Mara could be and regardless of his position, there wasn't much anyone could do to stop her if she chose violence.

"Guards, close the doors and let no one enter. Serenia, step in here." The guards nodded and ushered Serenia into the room before stepping out.

"A report from Eternia came through. Apparently an unknown force has approached our planet. Their leader calls himself Prime. According to my records, I've been able to piece together that this 'Prime' has been opposing us for several years now and the knowledge has been kept from us," Stratos sighed before continuing, "The higher ups are sending several fleets to assist in the harvesting of the magic. We are apparently going too slow for their liking.

"Listen closely. She-Ra is *the* most powerful force in the universe. It is to my understanding that we are currently enroute to a war. I'm not sure of anything at the moment. . .but all signs point to an unavoidable conflict. We need you focused, Mara." Stratos turned and walked back to his desk, taking a seat. By this point, everyone's faces had gone white. Catra was unsure of what this meant. To her knowledge, the war had been going on for years now. Or so Angella had made it seem.

"Wait, what? I'm confused. Of course there's a war. Ever since I woke up, everyone has been talking about it." Catra turned to look at Mara, "I think I even told you about that back at the tavern."

"Explain. What do you mean by 'woke up?'" Stratos said. Catra shifted in place, a bit uncomfortable with everyone's focus on her.

"I woke up roughly two days ago with no memory of myself or identity. When I went to talk to the locals, they attacked me. They claimed I was an enemy soldier and detained me. Shortly after I fell unconscious. When I came to, a woman named Angela claimed I was a soldier for the opposite side of the war. Apparently Etheria has been in a war for years. How don't you know this?" Catra asked, confused.

Admiral Stratos narrowed his eyes before looking her in the eyes. "What are the opposing sides and who is this 'Angella?' Is she a commander?"

"She's the queen of Brightmoon?" Catra said.

"I have met the queen of Brightmoon and her name is not Angella." Stratos said. "Hmmm, I'm coming to a theory that I don't particularly like." He muttered to himself.

"As to your other question, they're called the Rebellion and the Horde. The opposing sides I mean." Catra finished, taking a step towards Mara.

"The Horde, you say?" Stratos asked softly. Catra only nodded once, his voice sending shivers down her spine. Catra was immediately on edge. Admiral Stratos looked away for a second, fiddling with something on his desk.

To everyone else in the room, the man had simply picked something up out of view, but not to Catra. Her enhanced senses had heard it. He had pushed several buttons and she could hear a frequency emitting from Serenia and Mara's belts. She also noticed it from the guards behind her. Her ear twitched, picking up the sounds of footsteps coming down the halls, the crackling of energy and smells of burning ozone hit her senses.

As the door behind her clicked open, the sounds and smells of the weapons were now prevalent. As the Admiral turned around, she noticed two things. One, he was holding a glowing device that resembled a gun too much for her liking and two, Serenia was now holding an object that resembled a shock baton.

Before anyone could make another move, Catra moved faster than anyone could react. Her bad feeling was proven right as Serenia had raised the baton, Stratos had his weapon leveled at Catra's positioning, and several guards brandishing weapons flooded the room.

She hoped that Mara would forgive her for this, but at the current moment Catra was more concerned with her own safety. Catra had maneuvered behind Mara, unsheathing her claws and putting them at her throat while, simultaneously, kicking the sword away. It didn't go unnoticed to her that Mara hadn't made a single move to resist.

"Seize her NOW!" The Admiral commanded in a harsh tone. At the same time, Serenia had shouted at Catra to let Mara go.

"STAND DOWN!" A voice shouted. Catra stood up straight, letting Mara go, almost like reflex. Everyone immediately lowered their weapons except for Stratos. As the soldiers parted to make way for the newcomer, Catra took in the appearance of the man. He

was about seven feet tall and had sharp features. His very presence commanded respect. He had blue eyes and long shoulder length black hair. Overall, he was an intimidating presence, easily dwarfing herself.

"Fleet Admiral Kai, this woman is-" Stratos went to speak before being cut off.

"I heard everything. And yes, you are probably right. Girl, what did you say your name was?" The man, now named Kai, spoke. Catra, staying behind Mara, spoke up.

"It's Catra. . .sir." Catra said, adding the last part out of respect. She wasn't sure why, but this man seemed familiar. Everything from his voice to his looks. It all screamed something at her that she couldn't place. Catra was reminded how much amnesia sucks.

"Well Catra, if you would please step out into the open so that I may see you, you have my word that no harm will come to you." Kai said. Catra looked at Mara, hoping for some semblance of help, hoping she hadn't just ruined her friendship. To Catra's surprise, Mara had no resentment or anger on her face. In fact, she seemed almost encouraging.

Catra looked at everyone in the room before swallowing her nervousness. Every fiber of her being was telling her this was a bad idea. Unfortunately, she was in no place to argue. Taking a cautious step forward, she looked up at the man.

"Tell me something Catra. . . have you come to the conclusion about where you are? I have a feeling you have." Kai said patiently.

Catra had thought about it, but had thrown her thoughts to the wind. Her theory was completely ridiculous, yet it made the most sense. She needed to see the night sky for confirmation.

"I. . .think so. Why? Do you know what my situation is? How I lost my memories?" Catra questioned the man.

He shook his head, "No, while that part is a mystery to me, I believe I know how you came to meet our Mara. In fact, I'd imagine she has also figured it out. Care to share, Mara?"

Catra turned to look at her, wondering if her friend had drawn the same conclusion. "Catra, I think that you're from the future."

Catra, on her part, stayed silent before letting out a chuckle, "Oh man, it sounds even stupider when someone says it out loud."

"So you have thought about it?" Mara asked curiously.

Catra nodded, "Yeah, I thought about it when I looked at your sword this morning. It sounded dumb in my head, so I dismissed it. But after what this guy said about you guys and a war, well. . .let's just say I'm coming around."

"Wait, wait, wait. Time travel? Are you serious?" Serenia said aloud, "Do you all realize how dumb you sound you sound, no offense Fleet Admiral Kai. Admiral Stratos, help me talk some sense into them."

Stratos sighed as he put his weapon back into its holster, "I'm sorry Serenia, but that is what I came to as well."

"Then why the hell did you try and kill me just now?" Catra exclaimed.

"I wasn't going to kill you. It was simply a stun blaster. It may have been very painful, but you would have been fine." Stratos turned towards Kai, "She is part of Prime's army. You heard her. This Etherian rebellion has been engaged in a war for years with an army calling itself the Horde. We must take action."

"What I see is an amnesiac girl that is going through something that I couldn't imagine. That is to say if she's even from the future. We aren't monsters Stratos, don't start acting like the enemy." Kai said firmly, but not unkindly.

Catra got the feeling that this guy was probably well liked among his peers. As she went to ask another question regarding her situation, Serenia spoke up first.

"Wait a second. I saw Mara bring her in here. She paced the whole night beside this girl. She didn't go anywhere. So, praytell, when did you meet this Angella woman, hmm? Mara was talking about how she helped you when you were in your coma. It's not adding up."

"That's. . .huh, that's actually a good question," Mara said, thinking about it before turning towards Catra, "Earlier you said that you were with Adora for roughly fifteen hours. That's about how long you were unconscious for. If you really are time traveling, how is that possible? Wouldn't that be some sort of paradox, or something?"

"Time travel doesn't work that way"

"Actually, that's not how time travel works." Catra and Stratos said at the same time.

"What do you mean it doesn't work that way?" Mara asked. Catra shrugged.

"I imagine you're probably thinking that if you go back in time, you can kill your parents and then you aren't born right?"

"That's exactly how time travel works." Serenia said as Mara voiced her agreement.

"Well, think about it this way. If you did that, now you don't exist. So now you never went back in time and killed your parents and because of that you were born. That type of time travel is completely wrong. It's a recipe for paradoxical disaster." Catra explained.

Stratos nodded, "Exactly. Real time travel will have you going to a parallel timeline at the time and date you're aiming for. In Catra's

case, I would imagine she isn't from this timeline. Although magic probably complicated things quite a bit."

"So the book series 'Tom's Timely Escapades' is a bunch of bullshit?" Catra heard a guard mutter from the back of the room.

"Well said. That is most definitely what has happened with Catra." Kai said. Turning to Catra, Kai looked her in the eye, "Catra, I do not know you nor do I have any inclination to trust you. Mara here has vouched for you and I hold her opinion in a very high regard. Right now, Eternia is engaged in a war with a being that calls himself Horde Prime. Do you know anything pertaining to that name? Anything would be helpful?"

Catra looked at Mara before looking at everyone else. She sighed, "I'm sorry, but no. Maybe I did at one point, but as I said before. I've lost my memories."

"That's unfortunate, maybe we can-" Kai went to say before Mara cut him off.

"What about the Shards, Catra. You said when you touched one, your memories came back right? We have some in the vault." Mara said.

"The ore? It's useless. All of its power went into making your sword." Stratos said.

"Hmm, if it can even restore some of your memories then it's worth a shot. Stratos, walk with me. Half of you, guard this room and let no one enter or leave besides Mara and Serenia, the other half with me. Stratos and I will return with the ore we have on hand. Mara, stay here with Catra." Kai commanded.

"But the ore is all the way over in the Arxia outpost. That's a 5 hour trip by sky-craft." Mara said. Kai nodded as he looked at her.

"Precisely. It's for that reason I need you to stay here with Catra. Meals will be brought to you as you wait and there is a bathroom on the side of the room." Kai said as he nodded.

As Stratos made his way out the door with the soldiers in tow, Kai turned around and looked at Catra, "Catra, I know this may seem like you are a prisoner here, but be aware that you are not. Right now, we are in a unique position to help each other and if you do right by Eternia, we will do right by you. This is for your protection."

Serenia and Mara watched everyone leave out the door as the guards set up a defensive position outside. As the last soldier left the room and the doors closed, Mara immediately turned towards Catra.

"Well that was something, huh?"

"I think I just lost a couple years off my life just now. Who was that guy?" Catra asked, breathing a sigh of relief.

"That is Fleet Captain Kai. He holds the highest rank of our complete military. Nothing gets done without him knowing about it. He is *the* boss." Serenia said, her tone full of admiration.

"Huh, well ignoring that for a second. Are you okay?" Catra asked with concern. Serenia waved her off.

"Yeah, his healing magic is pretty on point. I don't even have a scratch on me."

"I don't care if he can heal you. That wasn't right." Catra said in irritation.

"Hey, listen. Thanks for the concern, but he really didn't mean to do that. He doesn't have a record of assaulting people. I'm inclined to believe that it really was an accident. Really, I'm okay" Serenia said gently.

Catra looked her up and down before slowly nodding, "If you say so Serenia."

"Well, I'm gonna go stand guard. Just try and relax Catra. Oh and sorry about trying to hit you with the electric baton. No hard

feelings." Serenia said as she exited the room.

As Catra sat there with Mara in silence, Catra swiftly turned towards Mara, "Mara I am so sorry. I didn't know what else to do besides grabbing you and then he had a weapon-"

"It's fine Catra. I knew you wouldn't actually do anything to me. Besides, that was probably the safest thing to do in your position." Mara chuckled.

"That still doesn't make it okay!" Catra exclaimed. Mara waved her off.

"Don't worry about it. Now, I want to ask you something. Have you figured out how you keep waking up beside Adora? I don't want you fainting in the middle of something important." Mara asked. Catra huffed at Mara's dismissal of her apology but switched her focus on the question.

"Actually, I might have some sort of idea on that." Catra said as she stood up. She looked around the room before seeing a couch on the side of the room. "One second."

As Catra went to pull the couch towards the side of the room they were all standing by, she realized that the couch was a little too heavy for her. As she pulled it inch by inch, she noticed it suddenly started moving with ease.

"Looked like you needed some help." Mara said, a little bit of smugness in her tone.

"I had it handled." Catra said defensively.

"Sure you did." Mara said teasingly. Catra felt irritation and anger flare up in her gut before pushing it down. She wasn't sure what caused that but Mara wasn't being malicious, just teasing. Catra shook her head, emptying those feelings.

"Alright, what did we need the couch for?" Mara asked. Catra immediately jumped over the back and layed down on it. Mara

slumped and gave her a look that said, 'really Catra?'

"What, don't give me that look. Do you want me to risk fainting on my feet? Now then, right before I woke up here, I had been thinking of. . .you. My hypothesis is that if I think of Adora or someone else from then, I'll wake up over there." Catra said. Mara giggled as Catra explained.

"What's so funny?" Catra said defensively.

"Nothing, it's just. . .you've never talked all sciency like that before. *My hypothesis.* It's kind of humorous is all." Mara said.

"Huh, now that you mention it, I have never talked that way. In fact, I'm surprised I knew anything about time travel. Must be something to do with Earth. Regardless, I'm going to try and switch. If I'm waiting ten hours or so then that is a good attempt. I've also noticed that it was late morning here when I woke up, but at the time I switched, it was approaching midnight. If I am right then when I wake up over there it should be early morning, as the sun should be setting right now. Now, let's see if I can figure this out." Catra explained.

Catra's thoughts turned towards Adora as she closed her eyes. She thought of her dark blonde hair and fair skin, the way the light had hit her face just right when she had smiled. Her weird ponytail and gray-blue eyes. She thought of how her laugh sounded. Her face when she was concerned and how beautiful she was.

As her thoughts became more and more enamored with Adora, she felt something familiar flow through her body. It felt almost comforting. She thought she heard Mara say it was working, or something to that effect somewhere in the background. Her thoughts on Adora shifted towards the wall of water and her reflection and how it had felt when she had crossed the barrier. Then she felt it flowing through her once more. The same energy that had coursed through her veins. But, while it was exciting and

exhilarating, it didn't have the same effect on her as when she did it with the shard in front of her.

Suddenly the feeling was gone as quick as it came. She immediately shifted her thoughts back to Adora, thinking she had messed up along the way. It had started to work, which meant she had lost focus when thinking about the feeling of energy. Taking a deep breath, she centered herself and focused her full attention. Something was off though, it was no longer working and when she felt a hand on her shoulder gently shake her, she let out a sigh.

"Mara, why'd you do that. It was working." Catra said, keeping her eyes clenched shut in concentration. "This time, don't speak. I think I figured it out."

"Catra, are you alright." A gentle voice asked, filled with concern. A voice that was clearly not Mara's.

Catra immediately opened her eyes. In front of her was Angella. She immediately sat up and looked around the room. She was back in Adora's room in the castle. She stood up and looked herself up and down. Her clothes were what she had been wearing at the dinner.

"Catra, answer me. Are you alright?" Angella asked.

"Yeah. . .yeah, I'm fine. I think I just figured out where Mara is." Catra said slowly as a smile slowly crawled its way onto her face.

"Have you now? Well explain. You've been unconscious for-"

"Nine hours, right?" Catra said, interrupting her. Angella's face was one of confusion and slight caution.

"Yes. . .How did you know that?" Angella asked slowly.

"It's a long story. But let's get something to eat. I'll explain it then. Come on." Catra said, jumping out of the bed and walking to the door, a grin present on her face.

"Ugh, I need a drink." Angella said as she followed the girl.

Chapter 5

Catra and Angella sat at the table waiting for breakfast to be served. After the excitement Catra had felt after confirming her theory had faded, the atmosphere had shifted. It was an awkward silence on account of the events that had transpired last night. Catra shifted in her seat, trying to think of a way to apologize. On Angella's side, she was waiting for Catra to start, unsure of whether or not to push the young woman's boundaries. After a moment Catra spoke.

"I'm sorry." She blurted out.

"What?" Angella asked, caught off guard by the sudden break in silence.

"I said I'm sorry. For last night. . .it was last night, right?" Catra said irritated.

"Ah, yes. That. Yes, it was last night." Angella said before shifting back into silence. As the moment of silence stretched on Catra's irritation became increasingly larger.

"Well, say something." Catra said.

"What would you like me to say? It's done and over with. No use dwelling on it now." Angella said calmly. It hadn't gone unnoticed that Catra's temperament had shifted ever so slightly.

"I don't know, yell at me, throw an insult at me, get angry or something. Don't just sit there." Catra said, throwing her hands up in the air. Angella's silence made her feel uncomfortable, as if she was being judged.

"Catra, I'm not going to yell or insult you. Quite the contrary actually. I'd like to know if you're alright. After our. . .moment last night, you fled to your room and began to emit a dangerous and volatile form of magic. The shard was the epicenter of the magic

and it didn't stop until I took it from you. After that, you went unconscious." Angella said calmly.

"So you aren't mad?" Catra asked, confused.

"Goodness no," Angella chuckled, "You broke a plate Catra. That is nothing to get angry about. My daughter has her moments and I assure you she has broken more than plates before. No, I am not mad." She said firmly.

As Catra looked unsure, Angella thought about Catra and Adora's attitudes. Angella had noticed that Adora responded quite well to emotional and physical affection, albeit she had some awkward social tendencies. She had found that Catra did not respond quite as well to either of those things.

From what she had been told, Catra had borne a large portion of Shadow Weaver's mistreatment. Taking everything she had learned about the young woman sitting across from her into account, she speculated that Catra probably responded well to direction and firmness. Being firm with her, but not unkind, was her next course of action. Angella was sure that this would work better.

"Tell me about what you have figured out. You called me Mara when you woke up, so I assume that has something to do with it?" Angella said, looking over at the servants as they brought them breakfast.

Catra thanked the servants as they handed her a plate before turning back to Angella, "Right, so earlier when Adora was here, we talked about Mara and how she had heard her name from Razz. Well when I fell unconscious last night, I woke up in a medical bay on a military outpost in the morning."

"What?" Angella's eyebrows raised, "But that isn't possible. You've been in that room the whole time."

"Exactly. See, when I woke up, Mara was outside of the room talking. When I spoke to her, it turned out that I had fallen

unconscious beside her as well. She told me that I had been unconscious for about fifteen hours. The same amount of time that I had been awake here." Catra said excitedly, her food untouched.

"Hmm, and were you awake for roughly nine hours over there?" Angella asked curiously. At Catra's nod, Angella gave a small smile. "So you have figured out how to. . .switch, for lack of a better term?"

"Yeah, see I thought I had failed when I woke up. That's why I called you Mara. But I hadn't failed, I figured it out and I'm fairly confident I can switch whenever I want. Although there is a slight problem with that." Catra said.

"I imagine you can't be woken up, yes?" Angella asked expectantly.

"Yeah, that's exactly it. Turns out that throughout those fifteen hours, Mara had tried to wake me up. She even healed me with her sword. Guess I didn't even move at all." Catra explained, finally taking notice of her breakfast.

"Yes, I suppose that would be a bit of a problem," Angella said as she took a bite of food before speaking again, "But I sense there's a little more you haven't told me."

Catra took another bite of her food, using it as an excuse to not answer immediately. After a moment to think about how she wanted to word it, she nodded.

"Yeah, whatever I did with that shard before I had dinner with you, it jostled something in my brain. I don't have anything back memory-wise, but I did have a few flashbacks to small things. Mara thinks that if I touch more shards that my memories could slowly return and I'm inclined to agree with her."

"Nodding, Angela took a sip of her drink. "What did you remember? Anything pertaining to your memory loss or how you came into contact with the first shard?"

"No, nothing like that." Catra shook her head, "It was mainly small things. I remembered marching with Adora and several other kids. I guess I also stole some sort of vehicle called a skiff with Adora and we were gonna run out of gas. But that's about it."

Angella could see that she was hiding something else regarding Adora. It seemed to have bothered her a bit so she left it alone. As she took another drink, she looked at Catra, "Well that's good to hear. Back to the previous topic, you were saying something about Adora knowing Mara?"

"Right, well you see, Mara has also heard of Adora from Razz. Turns out Razz calls her Adora and according to what Adora said earlier, she calls her Mara. Do you see the pattern?" Catra asked. Angella simply nodded.

"So after I woke up, Mara and I went to go see Razz. When we got there, Razz talked to Mara about something. I, er, removed myself from the area for reasons. So I'm not quite sure what it was they talked about." Catra said, somewhat mumbling that last part.

"Well, beyond that, you said you figured out how to switch back and forth. How do you do it? Also, have you guessed a reason for why you are switching?" Angella asked, intrigued. The ethereal woman had told her nothing of this 'switching' that Catra was experiencing.

Catra's face flushed a bit at that question, taking a drink before speaking, "Oh, It's, uh. . .you know, magic and all that. I just think about Ador-. . .way and kind of walk through it. "

Angella gave a small smirk, 'Guess she does remember Adora, even if it is subconscious.'

Catra cleared her throat, swiftly changing the subject. "As to the reason, Admiral Stratos and Fleet Admiral Kai thought it was time travel."

Angella almost choked on her drink when Catra said that. That had to be the most ridiculous thing she had ever heard. Catra gave a snarky laugh at that.

"Yep, Serenia had the same look on her face too. I even thought it sounded dumb when it was said aloud. But it makes sense. See the way it works is-" Catra went to explain but was cut off by Angella raising her hand.

"Catra, I'm not doubting your explanation, I'm just a little skeptical without proper explanation. So I would like you to start at the beginning. From the time you woke up in the medical bay to the point where you woke up beside me. Can you do that?"

"Uh, yeah, sure." Catra said, going to take another bite of her food before realizing it was all gone. Angella called for the servants to bring more food and drinks. Catra nodded her thanks before starting.

"Well, I woke up to Mara and another woman arguing-" Catra started. For two hours,Catra sat and ate with Angella, telling her story. Angella looked particularly intrigued at certain moments and disbelieving at others. Unbeknownst to either of them, a shadowy figure of smoke sat above them, listening to every word. Watching the young girl.

Shadow Weaver sat hunched over the cauldron as she watched Adora and Catra. Adora was making her way towards Mystacor with her 'new friends.' Typically Adora would be first priority, but something had changed. Catra had emitted a power unlike anything she had ever felt. More mysterious than She-Ra even. Whatever the shards had done to her, they had interacted with her on a primordial level. Changed her physiology down to her very core. Whether the girl was aware of it or not, Catra could now do Magic.

Her magical potential was great, and far greater than Micah ever could hope to have been. And, if she had sensed correctly, more

potent and powerful than She-Ra. Something wasn't right about it though. It had flickered several times, as if the power was a lie. She had almost believed it a trick. Had she not witnessed Catra surround herself in magic before waking up, she *wouldn't* have believed it. But it was quite clear now that it wasn't a trick.

As she listened, she heard several interesting things. Catra had somehow figured out how to activate the magic to 'switch.' A simplistic term for walking through an astral plane. Catra continued to speak of the story and how she had met several interesting people of varying skill sets such as healing magic. What was the most intriguing was that Catra had confirmed something she had suspected. Catra had no memories and from what little she did have, none of them involved her. This gave her a unique standpoint. If she could sway Catra back to the Horde, she wouldn't need to chase Adora. She would come to her, trying to save her friend.

Catra was right about one thing though. She was most definitely using some form of time magic. A field that was completely forbidden and she had figured it out effortlessly. And not only had she used it, she had spoken to the First Ones. She could become great under her tutelage. She knew magic better than anyone. If she could raise Catra's power with the soul shards, it was worth any risk, Hordak be damned. Nevermind the memories returning, she could deal with that easily. A small shift here, a nudge there and she would soon realize just how much she needed Shadow Weaver.

Her thoughts were interrupted by a sound from the communication screen above her on the wall. "Shadow Weaver, what have you learned?" Hordak spoke.

"Force Captain Catra must be our prime target, Lord Hordak. I have learned that Force Captain Catra has learned some form of time magic and has come into contact with the First Ones. Through her own accounts, they are engaged in a war with Horde Prime. Does that name sound familiar to you?"

Hordak narrowed his eyes as he clenched the armrest of his throne. Leaning forward ever slightly, he looked Shadow Weaver in the eyes. "Could you, with full confidence, bring her back with the shard? I do not want a repeat of Force Captain Adora."

"Without question. Right now, Force Captain Catra is being influenced and manipulated by the Rebellion. Her mind has been tampered with as a result of the shards. But over the last few days she has learned how to harness the power they wield. Give me the opportunity to bring her home and she will not only deliver you the shard, she will have an innate understanding of Brightmoon. With her time abilities, she could not only tell you about the first ones, she could unlock their secrets." Shadow Weaver said, knowing exactly which cards to play. Hordak gave a sinister grin, his sharp red teeth on full display.

"You have full authority to bring Catra back. If she has learned of the greatness of Horde Prime then she is of the highest priority. Bring her back at all costs. Do not disappoint me, Shadow Weaver." Hordak said before the screen went black.

"Failure is not an option, Lord Hordak. I understand.." Shadow Weaver said with dark glee as she hunched over her cauldron, "I understand completely."

After breakfast, Catra wandered the castle. She didn't have anything specific to do, as Angella had needed to begin her day as queen. If she were queen she would just have someone else do the little things. Like an underling.

Besides the boredom, she thought about what Kai had asked her earlier. If she was in the future, surely she could find some sort of history on him. You don't get to the highest position of military command without being in some sort of book. She made her way to the library when she thought she caught something out of the corner of her eye. Snapping her head in that direction showed nothing. Just an empty corridor. Catra's eyes narrowed in suspicion. As she resumed her trip, she was a lot more cautious.

Her instincts hadn't failed her yet and she wasn't about to not listen to them.

As she entered the library, she relaxed a bit, thinking it to be some sort of trick of the light. There were quite a few people present outside the castle and on the balconies. Setting her goal to the side for the moment, she approached one of the guards on the library balcony as friendly as she could.

"Excuse me, what's going on? Why's everyone outside?" Catra asked. The guard looked a little on edge before schooling her emotions.

"There is an eclipse in four hours. A rare sight that only occurs every 100 years, or so I've been told. You can sit out here and watch it. . .if you want to, that is." Catra's opinion of this woman had just gone up a bit. It was clear that she was uncomfortable, but was still making an effort to be somewhat welcoming.

"Thank you for the offer, um. . ." Catra paused, hoping she would get a name.

"I am General Juliet. And you're welcome Catra." Juliet said stiffly.

'At least she's trying,' Catra thought to herself.

"I'll be in the library until then, General Juliet." Catra said equally stiffly, not quite sure how to interact with the woman. At her nod, Catra walked back into the library before stopping and turning back towards her.

"Um, quick question. Do you know where the books on historical military soldiers would be and how do you know my name? I didn't yell at you did I?" Catra asked shiftily.

"The books you're looking for are in the back corner on the third floor. As for your other question, before you lost your memories, you were a Force Captain. One of the highest ranks in the Horde. As a General, it was my job to know your name.

"Ah, I see. Well then, I'll just. . .go this way." Catra said, the atmosphere much more awkward than it had been. "I had to ask." Catra muttered to herself.

As she climbed the stairs to her destination, she couldn't help but think about what Juliet had said. If that were true, was she in any of these books? She doubted it as she was quite young and still alive.

After about twenty minutes of searching, she found nothing on Fleet Admirals at all. She found plenty of books pertaining to oceanic ships and navy Admirals in a kingdom called Salinas, but nothing on Eternians or their military. Hell, she couldn't find anything regarding space travel. Nothing regarding interstellar information. There were books about astrology, but it was like there was a big chunk of literature that was just. . .gone.

Catra severely wished she had a computer. The internet was an amazing thing. No disrespect to books, but this would be much faster with Google than looking through endless pages of books.

Letting out a deep sigh, she was about ready to throw the towel in when she caught sight of a book that piqued her interest. Walking over, she caught sight of an interesting book. It was quite thick and while it sat on a clean polished shelf, the book itself seemed to be covered in dust. It was almost like nobody had touched the thing and cleaned around it. Catra blew on it and wiped the dust off. "The Known History of The Horde."

"Hmmm," Catra hummed. It was a surprisingly heavy book. Walking to a corner of the room, she sat down and opened the book. She realized that you couldn't see her from the ground level where she was sitting.

'Good,' she thought, 'I don't want to be bothered.'

Over the course of the next hour, she perused the pages, looking for any sign of familiarity. Whoever had put this book together had done their research on the Horde. As she took in every page,

she noticed something. The Horde had only begun roughly 44 years ago. Taking into account what Fleet Admiral Kai had said, there was no sign of the Horde being some kind of extraterrestrial, intergalactic threat. In fast, the Horde's entire forces were made up of etherians and robots. A passage caught her eye, detailing the Horde's purpose. Bring balance and peace to Etheria. As Catra thought about that for a moment.

'Is it true?' Catra thought to herself, 'I mean, they do call themselves the rebellion after all. Hmmm, best keep reading.'

There were pictures throughout the book that seemed familiar. Thinking back to the first dream she had had, she realized that the strange place called The Frightzone was identical. In fact, the large pipes and the strange looking landscape that was straight out of a science fiction novel were invoking strange feelings in her. They were almost. . . nostalgic.

"*Catra."*

Catra's hair stood up on end and her ears perked up. If she wasn't so sure of her senses, she would have thought that it was her imagination. But she had most definitely heard a voice. She was immediately on her feet, eyes scanning the halls of the library. She kept her senses focused but heard nothing else.

"Hmm, I'm not doing this shit again. If someone's there, start talking, because I've had enough of voices whispering in my ears." Catra said out loud.

After several moments of silence, Catra sneered, "Figures." She muttered.

As she turned around, she took note of the absence of people on the lower levels of the library. Actually, there was no one in the library. It was as if everyone had left in a hurry and closed the doors. She turned to look back at the book, only to find it missing. With all of the doors and windows closed and nobody but herself in the library, it seemed a bit ominous and perhaps a bit sinister.

Catra was on edge, and had fully unsheathed her claws. Somebody was in the library with her, that much was certain. Deciding to take the quickest route, Catra jumped over the railing straight to the bottom floor. As she headed towards the balcony doors where Juliet had been earlier, she took note of the moons in the sky. It seemed she had lost track of time as the eclipse would be starting within the hour.

Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed a shadow on the wall. It seemed almost like smoke for a moment, before taking a more human shape. The shadow was joined by several others on the wall, although they resembled tendrils more than anything else.

Catra could see that whoever it was that was here was standing directly behind her. As she whirled around, her claws and teeth bared and her posture low, she paused. It was clearly a woman, but she looked transparent, more ghostly than physical. She was also making no move to attack her.

"Who are you?" Catra spoke cautiously, unsure of the woman's intentions. Her eyes also locked on to the book in her hands.

"Hello Catra. I'm glad to see you're doing all right." The woman said, taking a step forward. She could now see that the woman was wearing a maroon colored dress with dark accents and a red mask that concealed her whole face. Directly on the forehead of the mask, sat a striking blood red gem that glowed with a sense of power. Her dark, silky, black hair flowed behind her in a way that seemed to disobey gravity.

"You know me? How?" Catra asked, her voice full of suspicion.

"Do I know you?" The woman asked sarcastically, "Why, Catra, I raised you."

Catra thought about any point where Adora had spoken of this woman and came up short. She supposed this woman could be telling the truth, although she wasn't too keen on trusting the word of a stranger.

"Even if you're telling the truth, I'm sure you can understand my reasons for not trusting you on that." Catra said.

"Of course. I can only imagine what you've been going through, what, with your memories gone and being stranded by time magic." She said with a gentle tone. Catra perked up at that.

"You know about my. . .situation?" Catra asked, her interest piqued. The woman nodded.

"Yes, I've only seen it a couple of times, but it's always a heartbreaking thing to see. I could do nothing but watch helplessly as it happened to you." She said solemnly.

"You know how I lost my memories? Why do I have these thoughts about. . ." Catra's eyes narrowed. "What's the place in my mind? I have separate memories. If you've seen this before, where is it?"

"Good, I'm glad you are suspicious. Better to play it safe. I'm happy to see you still carry my lessons with you, even if you can't remember them. But you don't need to be cautious with me. The place you are remembering should be a place called Earth, right? Or are you referring to the mirrored wall? Both have a history of appearing to the shard's victims."

"That's. . .Both, actually. How did I lose my memories and what does this all mean?" Catra asked, her posture relaxing.

"I have to apologize first. Your memory loss was a result of my carelessness. I had been experimenting with several, rather volatile, magics and I had come into contact with a soul shard. I hadn't seen one in almost twenty years so I had disregarded a few safety steps. My magic had reacted violently and it was about to explode.

The problem with the shards is that when a magic user comes into contact with them, it can be dangerous, if not outright lethal. You had never had any magical potential to begin with. You had focused more on the physical aspects of combat. So seeing you

interact with the shard as you had. . .well, it was one of the scariest moments of my life." She said as she reached out, gently caressing the side of Catra's face. Catra didn't know why, but she felt calm and at ease. This woman was answering her question and seemed to know her very well. She felt. . .familiar.

"But something unique has happened, something unheard of. You used the shard successfully. Typically when someone comes into contact with a shard, they lose their memories and show symptoms of madness. But thankfully, you didn't. In fact they've done the opposite. Whatever the shard did to you, it gave you the potential for magic.

I believe that the reason you have this ability to use time magic so freely, stems from the interaction you had from the shard. You haven't come into contact with any other shards, have you? I don't want you taking any unnecessary risks." She said, concerned.

Catra hesitantly nodded her head, not wanting to disappoint the woman, "I did. I could make it glow and could make it emit a low hum on contact when I directed it towards the north."

"It didn't affect you in any negative way?" She asked. As Catra shook her head no, she hummed. Whatever Catra had done with the shard, she had found a way around its effects.

"Did it do anything beyond glow or hum?"

"Well, when I touched it, some of my memories returned. Nothing major, just something to do with borrowing a skiff and marching with several other children." Catra said.

"Would those children's names happen to have been Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio?" She asked.

"Actually, yeah. I had gotten a good score and some guy told everyone to strive to beat it, or something?" Catra explained. There was little doubt that this woman knew her now. Every word she spoke was filled with concern and sympathy. This was

supposed to be the Horde? Catra wasn't sure what to make of it all.

"Wait, you said I could do magic?" Catra said suddenly. The woman let a mirthful chuckle out.

"Yes, I did. In fact, as children I initially believed Adora could do magic but I was mistaken. As of now, out of all of your peers, you are the only one to possess the aptitude for it." She said with an excited tone. Catra couldn't see it, but underneath the woman's mask, she was grinning. She wasn't quite sure if this approach would work regarding magic, but Catra's enthusiasm was quite pleasing to see. It made this much easier.

"I can do magic." Catra murmured to herself. Suddenly Catra's face lit up with a smile

"I can do magic." Catra said excitedly to herself, "I mean, I thought it was just the shard that did that, but if I can use it myself then. . ." She trailed off.

"I can teach you." The woman said, breaking Catra out of her thoughts.

"You would do that for me?" Catra asked hopefully.

"Of course I would, Catra. I've always wanted you to succeed. Listen, growing up, nothing was ever easy for me. I wasn't born to power like Adora and others. I had to earn my power fight for it. You remind me so much of myself. You have a unique opportunity to seize power for yourself, to never let anyone manipulate you again." The woman paused for a moment and narrowed her eyes, as if thinking about something before sighing.

"If Adora hasn't told you yet, then I will now. I was hard on you, much harder than on Adora, this is true. I won't deny it and I won't apologize. I wanted you to be strong, to be prepared for the world. It is unforgiving and dangerous and even now, subconsciously, you retain those lessons. Like me, you followed in other's shadows throughout your life. But now, you have come to

a moment in your life. A moment where everyone has to make a choice of what type of person they will be.

I want what's best for you Catra. I always have and while those methods may not have always been the kindest, they were always out of a place of love, never malice. Don't let Adora drag you down. She may mean well, but that doesn't mean that she's in the right. I would like for you to come home. Your friends miss you and so do I." The woman caressed Catra's tuft of fur under her ear as she spoke kindly.

Emotions flooded Catra. Emotions she couldn't put into words. Almost everyone wanted something from her ever since she woke up. This woman didn't want something from her, no, in fact all she wanted was to give her something. She offered her magic, love, and a group of friends who miss her. As she went to speak, a banging on the door caught her attention.

"Hey Catra, the eclipse is about to start. If you want to see it, you need to come out now. Hey, why is this door locked?" A voice that sounded like General Juliet sounded through the door. She turned back to the woman, who now was looking a lot more transparent and smoky.

"You don't need to decide now. I'll be in touch, don't worry. Here, don't want anyone to be suspicious." She said as she waved her hand. Several books flew to a desk and opened themselves, making it appear as if Catra had been reading them, including the one she had previously been reading.

"Wait, what's your name?" Catra asked quickly before she disappeared completely.

"Shadow Weaver. And one more thing Catra, don't forget to sleep. Just because your body sleeps, doesn't mean your mind does. Mental fatigue can be just as dangerous if not more so. Goodbye Catra." She said gently. And with that the woman disappeared, the light returning to the room and the windows and doors

unlatching and opening back up. Catra thought that the shadows weren't quite as sinister as she had initially believed.

Catra swiftly jumped into the seat, before making it look like she was standing up as General Juliet walked in. "What the hell's wrong with this door?"

"What?" Catra asked, acting as if she hadn't just spoken to what seemed to be her mother.

"Hm? Oh, nothing. Come on, the eclipse is starting and you don't want to miss it." General Juliet said. Catra shrugged and joined her, although her mind was miles away from what she was witnessing.

As the eclipse started, Catra felt something well up inside of her. It was almost like when she 'switched' to Mara, but different. Like she was somewhat energized. Catra hummed, thinking about her life. Perhaps she should give Shadow Weaver's words some more thought.

While the eclipse was beautiful, Catra didn't particularly care. Her memories from earth showed plenty of images of ellipses that looked far more impressive than this one. Mainly a solar eclipse, now that was something to be witnessed.

Shadow Weaver awoke on the floor, a dull ache in the back of her head. While Catra had been quite successful, Adora had not. Adora had used the eclipse as a weapon against her, completely destroying her shadow spies and knocking her unconscious. While it was a setback, she was more focused on Catra. It would require a delicate hand when dealing with her. She was quite hostile to everyone, including herself.

She had maneuvered herself in a way that gained a small amount of Catra's trust. Adora had been foolish not to tell Catra about her. Fortunately for her, Catra wanted to learn magic and had

remembered just enough for Shadow Weaver to cement her place in Catra's mind.

She couldn't be too hasty or she would push Catra away, but too slow and Adora and her friends would pull her into their stupid little circle of princesses. Scorpia and her squad was going to be pivotal to the next step. Walking over to her communications screen, she sent a message through.

Force Captain Scorpia, come to the black garnet chamber and bring cadets Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio immediately. I have an assignment for you.

As Shadow Weaver dusted herself off, she started to organize information pertaining to Adora. At the current moment Catra may be the priority target, but that didn't mean her goal of bringing Adora back was in no shape or form dismissed. Quite the opposite really. If she got Catra to return, there was a good chance of Adora following to 'save' her friend. But if she could get Adora back, well Catra would come back of her own volition.

Behind her the doors hissed open. As she turned to look at Scorpia's squad, she took in the appearance of the saluting cadets. They all looked capable. . .most of them looked capable. Kyle.

"I'm here for your orders, Shadow Weaver. Did you find Catra? Is she alright?" Scorpia asked loudly. Before she could start ranting, Shadow Weaver held up a hand to stop her.

"Catra is currently in good health and I have located her." She said in a calm tone. At that, everyone seemed to breathe a sigh of relief surprisingly.

"Well, that's fantastic. Let's go get her then." Scorpia said.

"That's the problem. Catra is currently residing in Brightmoon. It is as I thought. She has lost almost all of her memories." Shadow Weaver said. Scorpia gasped in horror alongside the trio behind her.

"Adora really did it? What the fuck?" Lonnie muttered, disgusted. Rojelio made a noise of shock in response to the information. Before anyone could say anything else, Kyle spoke up in Adora's defense.

"That's not what happened right? It can't be. Adora would never do that to one of us, especially Catra." Kyle asked with desperation in his voice. Shadow Weaver spoke up, silencing everyone's cries of outrage and horror.

"Cadet Kyle is correct. Adora did not do this, nor did the rebels. The blue shard you will be collecting did. That does not mean that the situation isn't bad. Right now, Catra is being manipulated by the Rebellion into sharing any and everything. They are trying desperately to restore her memories while, simultaneously, swaying her to help them.

It is up to you four to stop that. As far as the blue crystal goes, Force Captain Scorpia is the only one who can touch it besides Catra. At the current moment it may be too volatile. Your status as a princess will protect you from its effects due to your connection to the runestone." Shadow Weaver said, pointedly.

"But I don't have a connection to the black garnet, Shadow Weaver." Scorpia said.

"I am aware of that. I have studied the shards extensively and it doesn't matter if you are connected or not. As long as you *could* form a connection that is all that matters. Now, moving on to your mission parameters. Scorpia, have you received your invitation to princess prom yet?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Scorpia shook her head, "Not yet, although it's only a matter of time."

"Hmm, When you receive the letter of invitation, come tell me. I will be accompanying you as your plus one. Cadets Kyle, Lonnie, and Rojelio will be your guard. Lord Hordak has made retrieving Catra and the shard priority number one. She takes precedence.

You will receive further instruction at a later date. Dismissed." Shadow Weaver said over her shoulder, as she walked away.

"YES, SHADOW WEAVER!" They all replied in sync, before exiting the chamber.

Shadow Weaver poured herself a drink before sitting down. Everything was coming together in a way that she could have never predicted. And Catra was the key.

Catra had gone over some more books through the library in search of more information to no avail. She had been so wrapped up in what Shadow Weaver had said that she had forgotten to ask what she was doing to the book she had been reading.

When she had gone over and checked, she found a small photo of several small children and who she assumed to be herself and Adora. There was a small blonde boy, a brown haired girl whose skin was about the same shade as Mara's, and. . . a green lizard boy? Catra assumed that these three were Kyle, Rojelio, and Lonnie. In the front was Adora, no doubt about it, hugging a very agitated cat child who looked like she didn't want to be there.

The photo had a banner in the back that read 'Top cadets.' Catra chuckled to herself. Even if she couldn't remember this moment, it seemed like a good memento to have. Pocketing it, she had started to put the books away when a servant had stopped her. Angella was asking if she would join her for dinner in the evening. The servant had made it apparent that she could say no, most likely on account of last night's incident.

Catra said she would be there and the servant nodded and left to tell her. She had noticed that she was starting to lose track of time quite often. At first, she had thought it was a result of the shard before Shadow Weaver had informed her to sleep. It hadn't occurred to her she might just be mentally exhausted. After searching the library for several hours, dinner and sleep sounded quite nice. Maybe a bath as well.

She had roughly an hour and a half before dinner. With that in mind she went and took a nice hot bath. She spent the better half of the hour there and when she looked in the mirror she realized just how tired she looked. It wasn't any physical signs like bags under the eyes, it was more of a feeling. She doubted anyone could see it besides her, but now that she thought about it, she had been awake for almost three days straight.

Her hair still wet, she changed into some clothes and headed out to meet Angella for dinner. As she entered the room, she took note of Angella talking to General Juliet. As she walked over, Angella nodded to Juliet and walked towards her.

"Thank you for joining me, but dinner isn't for another half hour." Angella said kindly. Catra shrugged.

"Eh, I was bored. If I didn't get up, I would probably have fallen asleep. Besides, I wanted to talk to you about a few things." Catra said nonchalantly.

"Alright, but, um, are you going to brush your hair? It's all over the place." Angella asked. Catra couldn't quite place it, but she swore Angella had a strange look in her eye.

"Uhh, no. Actually, I can't recall ever having brushed my hair and judging by how it felt when I was taking a bath, I'd say it's not worth it.. Why?" Catra asked, cautiously.

"Do you mind if I. . ." Angella trailed off, gesturing to her own hair. "We can talk over it."

"Oh, um, yeah, sure. I don't care." Catra shrugged. Angella's face lit up before she pulled several hair brushes out of. . .somewhere.

As she took a seat, Angella pulled a chair behind Catra and sat down. "I used to do this for Glimmer. She had longer hair when she was younger, but as she got older, she wanted to be an adult. No time for her mom to do her hair."

As Catra had her hair pulled and yanked from the brushes, she winced from the knots and tangles being undone. Having hair as thick as hers was more of a nuisance in her eyes. Thankfully her hair was still wet, otherwise she would never have been able to undo it.

"Yeah, I can see why she might have thought that." Catra said wincing, letting out a small involuntary hiss at the slight pain.

"Glimmer's hair isn't quite as thick or full as yours. Most likely on account of your fur. But once the knots are out I assure you, you'll like it. I used to love it when my mother did this for me. Appearance is important Catra, remember that. I can't appear before my kingdom if I have a bedhead." Angella said as she worked the last knots out.

Catra thought about that advice. Adora always looked unkempt and clean as did Mara. Although, that may have something to do with their military backgrounds. Soldiers on Earth were almost always nicely kempt and tidy. She felt the brush go through her hair smoothly. It felt a lot better now.

As she started working Catra's hair, Angella noticed Catra slowly relax. She started to emit a low purr and deep breaths. She recognized her look. She had worn it too many times. If Catra had been jumping between spaces or 'switching' as she liked to call it, then she hadn't been sleeping. Perhaps her body had, but not her mind.

So for half an hour Angella talked to Catra about personal health and how important sleep was. Catra heard most of it, but was taken in by her voice. Her tone was quite relaxing and the hands in her hair were almost hypnotizing. When Angella gave her a gentle shake, she realized that the dinner was being served and that she had been dozing off.

"Catra." Angella spoke up, slightly louder than normal.

"Yes?" Catra asked, her voice quite relaxed.

"After you eat, I'd like for you to get some rest. Please don't switch, I'd like for you to actually sleep. Can you do that for me?" Angella said kindly.

"Yeah, I can do that. But I need to tell Mara-" Catra spoke before being stopped by Angella's hand.

"I'm aware you said you'd help Mara, but remember to prioritize yourself as well. No one will benefit from you passing out on your feet. You've learned to switch and frankly I'd like to be there as well. So I'd like you to wait until tomorrow morning if that's alright with you." Angella proposed, calling a servant over.

"Okay," Catra said after a moment, "I'll wait until tomorrow morning."

"Excellent," Angella said, clapping her hands together, "Now, you never said anything about the first time you switched."

Catra felt her mood sour a bit at the mention of her switching once again, before Angella spoke up, "Have you got a favorite drink that you may have had over 'there?'"

Catra's good mood immediately returned at the mention of that, "Well. . .there was one, but I'm not quite sure how it was made."

"Well, give a description and I will have them do their utmost job of making it." Angella said, smiling as she took small bites of her food.

"Well it was white and chunky. It also had foam on top with orange highlights in it. I think it had red cream with a pinkel slice. Mara told me what it was called, but I can't remember." Catra tried describing it, hoping the name would come to her, to no avail.

"Ahhh, I see," Angella said with a small smirk, "Would this particular drink have been alcoholic and called a 'pink morning?'

"Yeah, that's it!" Catra exclaimed, "How'd you know?"

"It's an old drink that's not too known nowadays. You can find a similar drink called a 'sailor's warning' over by Salineas. You have good taste Catra. I'm pleasantly surprised. Please, bring me two pink mornings?" Angella told the servants.

"Did your friend tell you how to drink them correctly?" Angella asked, turning back towards Catra.

"To eat the pinkel slice first. Something to do with the juice sticking to your tongue and enhancing the flavor." Catra said, munching on a strangely crunchy piece of meat.

"Yes, although I'm quite intrigued. If what I am gathering from what you've told me of Mara, she was the previous She-Ra. That was said to be over a thousand years old and I'm quite surprised this drink goes so far back." Angella said, curiosity filling her voice.

"That reminds me of a type of wine from Earth. According to my memories, it's supposed to be over 5000 years old." Catra said, finding a topic that she could relate to. As the servants came back out with the pink mornings, Angella turned towards Catra.

"Can you tell me about Earth? I've been informed that it's a lovely place by Castaspella but I have never heard of it." Angella said, already enamored by the drink. She didn't drink too often, but this was one of those nights that nothing was going on and she could afford to take it easy.

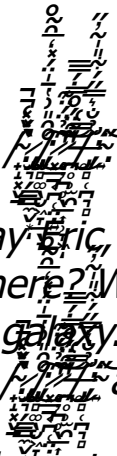
"Alright," Catra said, taking a sip of her drink, "Oh, where to start? I suppose I'll start with the scenery."

For roughly two hours, Catra and Angella talked about Earth. Angella would occasionally compare the descriptions with places from Etheria, while Catra would ask about the wildlife and types of views about Etheria. Angella had perhaps lost track of the time after the fourth pink morning. Although, every guard was listening to Catra's description of the stars and moon of earth.

It was later in the evening when Catra had decided to go to bed. She was well past buzzed, but not quite swaying. She was enjoying the warmth in her body and was sure she could fall asleep instantly if she tried. As she got up from the table, she wasn't quite sure, but she may have given a hug to Angella before heading to bed.

Making her way through the castle, she finally made it to her room. As she slowly crawled into her bed, her thoughts were dominated by the memories of Earth and the beautiful places she remembered, while she slowly drifted off to sleep.

.

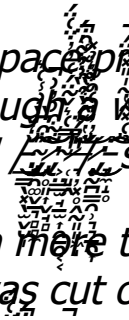


"*You don't need to do this [illegible]. You know that, right?"*

"*I'm sorry you feel that way Eric, but I have to do this. Do you know what could be out there? We have a unique opportunity to learn the mysteries of our galaxy. We could find extraterrestrial life. Don't you want that." [illegible] asked.*

"*Of course, but it doesn't have to be you. Let a different person do it. You're our head of the research team. If something happens to you, we'd be-"*

"*You'd be fine Eric. I'm finally able to make my dreams come true. I've been dreaming about this since I was a kid and I'm not gonna let anyone talk me out of it. So much time and work has gone into this project. Half of the world's space programs have spent trillions on this. We need to do this." [illegible] sighed, "We've run out of time, Eric. Earth is running out of resources. By this time in three years, Earth will be past the point of no return.*



"*The hyperspace program thinks this is the one. It's said that it crosses through a wormhole to traverse distances. It's basically a warp drive." [illegible] said.*

"*We can run more tests, make sure it's safe. There's no point to you-" Eric was cut off by a hand slamming on the desk.*

"*Don't you get it! There is no more time! This is it. The endgame. If we fail. If I fail, then Earth is fucked, do you hear me? Fucked!*" [illegible] took a shaky sigh, her voice cracking with emotion.

"*Even if we fail, we have to try. For everyone's sake.*" [illegible] said. Eric sat down, his head hung low in defeat.

"*Hey, it's going to be fine. I'll have a co-pilot with me. It's big enough to fit two people, so don't worry. I'll have plenty of Company.*" [illegible] said softly, resting a hand on Eric's shoulder, giving a reassuring squeeze.

"*I sure hope so. For your sake and theirs. You know [illegible] can be. . .unnecessarily cruel. Just keep them in line, okay?*" Eric said.

"*You got it.*" A reassuring smile present.

Chapter 6

"Hello. . . God, this feels weird." Catra muttered to herself. Slightly shaking her head, she looked up at the tablet positioned in front of her, recording.

"So, Mara said that I should record my thoughts and experiences as some type of journal. She says it will help me 'center myself' or something. I'm not sure about it." Catra said, pausing for a few seconds.

"I'm not exactly sure what I'm supposed to say during this. Hmm. I suppose I'll just say everything that's happened so far since I learned how to 'switch.'" Catra shifted awkwardly, somewhat self conscious of talking to herself.

"So after I learned to switch, I met Mara's. . .commanders? Is that the right word? Anyways, they helped me figure out I was time traveling and wanted some help with finding anything that could help them. Unfortunately, when I got back to the future, I couldn't find anything on anybody called the Eternians. After that I met some strange woman named Shadow Weaver and she said she raised me and I could do magic. She gave me a picture of me and Adora with three people I have yet to meet or remember.

"But I'm a little on the fence here, regarding her. At first, she seemed, I don't know, inviting? But thinking back on it, something seemed off. Maybe it's just nerves, but Adora's trip to Mystacor says something else." Catra said, chewing on the inside of her cheek.

"On the topic of Adora, she got back about two weeks ago with Bow and Glimmer. Bow's been really nice and is pretty respectful of my boundaries. He even gave me this tablet I'm recording with.

"Glimmer is. . .weird. I can't pin her down. She doesn't seem to like me very much and I'm sure that has to do with me being a

former Horde captain. But whenever we do talk about anything else, it's like we get each other. It's strange, like I said.

"Adora is. . .complicated. It's so easy to talk to her and she seems to know every little thing I'm gonna do before I do it. She even knew what food I liked before I tried it. It's comforting in a way. It's like I don't need to impress her or try to get her respect or approval." Catra gave a small smile, tilting her head down. "But. . .It can be awkward, if that's the right word. It's a little strained sometimes, like something's missing. I know it has to do with the memories that I lost. Something must have happened between us that I can't remember.

"I've gotten more comfortable around Angella. She's very patient with me and I appreciate it. When we can sit down and talk, I find it's very calming. Like all of my worries melt away. It's an unfamiliar feeling. When I went back to 'switch,' Angella sat beside me and watched. By her account, I light up with 'brilliant hues of color' and then I pass out.

"When I switched back to Mara, she had several things to say. I guess my theory about the time of day and night was correct, because I had slept through a full day and night beside her. I had to explain that the mental strain had been taking a toll on me and I needed to sleep and not just switch. She was pretty understanding. That day kind of sucked. Mainly because I had to explain it to several people. When Kai and Stratos talked to me about my findings, they offered several answers about my lack of findings in the library. The most prominent ones being that their particular race was going by a different name and not Eternians or they didn't exist in her timeline.

"What's funny is that Kai already guessed about my sleep problem. He seems pretty knowledgeable regarding these things. He's got a familiar feeling to him that I can't pin down. Probably something to do with being militaristic? I don't know, but I told them I'd check again and see if I could find any words regarding their language. I also couldn't read their writing. Mara laughed about that and explained it. Turns out their written language

structure is so simple that you could learn it in an afternoon. Mara showed me how."

Catra stopped talking, putting her face in her hands before letting a breath out. "I'm not sure what to make of her. She's so kind and helpful, but she seems lonely. Like nobody hangs out with her. I decided that I'll check in on her from time to time. We're friends after all."

Catra's ears perked up as she paused. As if on cue, a knock at the door could be heard, "Catra, are you in there?"

"Yeah, I'm kinda in the middle of something, Adora. Can you give me a couple of minutes?"

"Oh, are you doing your recording thing? Sorry, I'll wait." Adora said through the door, somewhat muffled. As the sound of footsteps sounded away from the door, Catra turned back to the camera.

"Right, so, uh, anyways, like I said, It's been about two weeks and I've just been taking it easy. I've only talked to Mara twice since then. We found out that when I switch, I can only do it about two more times in quick succession before I need to stop. It gets kind of painful, so. . .yeah. Waiting a day or two is the smart decision, according to Angella and Kai. Mara said I shouldn't even consider doing it without waiting a day at least."

Catra shifted a couple of times before huffing and grabbing the tablet from where it was sitting. Walking back to the bed, she laid down and set it beside her face, able to see her reflection in the table as it recorded her. She turned to look up at the ceiling and let out a sigh.

"Bow was fascinated by the prospect of time travel and wanted me to tell him more, Glimmer was skeptical and understandably so, and Adora. . . Well she wasn't too enthused about me messing with the things that made me lose my memory. She outright confirmed what Shadow Weaver said to me. That I could never do

magic before this whole thing. I don't know, I just thought that she would be happy about it. But all she said was that I shouldn't mess around with it. That if I 'remembered' my past experiences with magic, I wouldn't want to mess with it." Catra ran a hand through her hair before pulling the photo of her and the other kids out and looked at it.

"I'm sure she means well, but how am I supposed to understand her about this? The only memories I have regarding magic are the ones from Earth. Every memory depicts magic as something cool and powerful, something to be harnessed and used, to better people's lives. Of course it's dangerous. I mean, how could it not be? Anything that can harm people is dangerous." Catra unsheathed her claws on her hand, examining them, "I have claws that can carve through steel and she didn't say not to use those. Why would she? They're a part of my body. But so is this magic."

Catra sat up, picking up the tablet, "Glimmer seemed kind of excited when she learned I could do magic, surprisingly. I figured she would have been uneasy, seeing as how her opinion of me is kind of negative right now. Either way, I'm going to approach this with caution. On Earth, there are a lot of depictions in the media of 'dark magic.' If that's the case here, then I'll have to be more careful."

Catra paused, looking around awkwardly, "That seems like a good place to end it. Um, I guess. . .End of log number 1?"

As Catra walked through the halls, she saw Adora holding a. . .scroll? "Hey Adora, what you got there?"

"Oh, Catra. Hey. Yeah, I don't know? It's some kind of invite." Adora said, looking back down at the half unrolled parchment.

"Well, let me see it," Catra said, snatching the paper from Adora's hands to her protests, "Welcome to blah blah blah, we, at the Kingdom of Snows, love snow, blah blah. Oh here we go." Catra

cleared her throat while dodging Adora's attempts to take the invite from her hands.

"Princess Adora," Catra snorted at that, "You are hereby, formally invited to the All Princess Ball, Winterwonderland. You and a plus one of your choice may attend this once in a decade event."

"Catra, I already read that part. I'm just confused about what it is. Can I please have that back? I'm about to go ask Glimmer and Bow about it." Adora said, planting her hands on her hips in annoyance. Catra chuckled at her look of irritation, before handing her it back.

"What's to understand? You got invited to a ball and they want the mighty 'She-Ra' to attend." Catra said in a mock tone, puffing her chest out while raising an arm into the sky.

"Well, no duh. I'm just wondering what it's about. LIke, *why* am I getting an invite? Now come on," Adora said, grabbing Catra's hand and pulling her along, "I need to talk to Glimmer about it. Hopefully she'll shed some light on this."

Catra raised an eyebrow at the hand that was currently dragging her along, "Hey, Adora?" Aren't you trying to form some sort of alliance with the other princesses? If this thing is a princess only thing, doesn't that stand to reason that princesses will be there?"

Adora stalled her steps for all of a second, before continuing to trudge along. "Well, I mean, yeah? But I want to run it by Glimmer. She knows all about these events after all."

Catra rolled her eyes, letting out a sigh of defeat, "Lead on."

As they arrived at Glimmer's room, Adora knocked on the door, "Uh, hey, guys, I got an invite to the All Princess Ball, Winter Wonderland. Do you know what this is?"

Before Catra could react, the doors flew open to Glimmer and Bow yelling out 'princess prom.' As she watched them dance around

the room in mock horror, she looked at Adora, who looked completely dumbfounded.

"Okay, well, you've gone crazy, got it. I'll just- I'll just come back later." Adora said as she went to leave the room to Catra's amusement.

"The princess ball is a meeting for all of the princesses of Etheria." Bow said, walking over to Adora.

"And a giant party," Glimmer said before teleporting in front of Adora, grabbing her into a tango spin, "Dancing, food, fancy dresses." she said ecstatically.

"Dancing?" Adora said, her voice a mixture of fear and shock.

""It only happens once a decade. I've been waiting years for this." Glimmer said, letting Adora stand back up as she turned away.

"Uh, I'm only a princess sometimes, so are you sure I should even go?" Adora asked nervously, looking at Catra for some support.

"Of course. Every princess is invited, that includes you." Glimmer said smiling.

"Oh yeah, It's all in the invite." Bow said, unraveling the scroll. Catra took notice of the deceptively long scroll as it rolled across the room. Adora blinked at the sight before leaning down and picking up a section of the laid out parchment.

"Okay, rules for greeting the hostess. Expected curtsy?" Adora scoffed, a smirk on her lips, "Proper stair descending etiquette?"

"The ball has been going on for centuries. There's a lot of really old etiquette stuff you gotta do before you can party." Bow said sheepishly.

"But it's gonna be so fun! And Princess Frosta is hosting it this year in the Kingdom of Snows! Her magic is incredibly powerful. She'd be a *huge* get for the rebellion." Glimmer said pointedly.

Adora whimpered as she sat down. Catra laughed out loud at Adora's plight, before Glimmer cut her off.

"Don't worry, I'll be right there with you. And so will Bow, since he's going as my plus one." Glimmer said.

"Um, Actually–" Bow went to say before being cut off.

"And besides, you'll have Catra with you since, as you just found out, princesses get a plus one. Together, the four of us can accomplish anything." Glimmer said, gesturing to a now shocked Catra.

"About that. . ." Bow went to speak again.

"It's the best friend squad in action! Right Bow?" Glimmer said confidently.

"I'm going with Perfuma." Bow forced out before he could be interrupted again.

"What?!" Glimmer cried out.

"'What' is right. I'm not going to some stupid dance. Let Adora dress up in a dress. She's the princess. Besides, have you all forgotten that your mom doesn't want me to be on the front lines?" Catra said, crossing her arms, her tail swishing agitatedly through the air.

"What happened to your humor, Catra?" Adora said slyly, "You seemed to be laughing a second ago."

"Nothing happened to it. I still think it'll be hilarious to see you dolled up in a dress. But if you think you'll catch me in one of those frilly death traps, guess again. I'd tear them to shreds before I would make it out the door." Catra said unabashedly, as if she had not just threatened to tear up a very expensive piece of clothing.

Bow seemed to have other ideas, though. "Oh, come on Catra. Don't you want to see more of Etheria? You've been stuck in the castle for two weeks. You have to be getting bored?"

"If I wanted to see more of Etheria, I'd switch and ask Mara." Catra didn't catch Adora's look of annoyance at the mention of Catra's new friend, "And Angella wouldn't let me leave the castle anyways."

"We haven't even asked her, yet. You don't even know what she'll say, Catra." Bow said.

"You know what? Yeah, that's right. If I have to suffer through a dance, then you're coming with me." Adora said with a smirk, her posture betraying her cocky attitude.

Catra looked at all three of them in silence as they looked back at her. After several seconds of silence, Catra's ear twitched. Immediately, Adora went for a full dive tackle, which Catra dodged effortlessly.

"Don't let her get to your mom, Glimmer! She'll persuade her not to let her go. We have to get there first!" Adora yelled as Catra ran out the door.

As Catra ran through the halls towards the throne room, a flash of pink sparkles appeared in front of her, obscuring her vision. She narrowly dodged Glimmer's arms as she went to grab her.

"Catra, just hold still." Glimmer uttered through clenched teeth.

"Nah, I think I'm good." Catra called back as she started to run on all fours. The approaching sounds of feet hitting the marble floors told her that Adora was right behind her and quickly closing the distance.

As Angella sat at the war table with Juliet, Spinerella, and Nettossa, she heard the muffled sound of yelling and running

behind the main door. Letting out a sigh, she stood up and walked toward the door.

"*Catra, you're coming with me!"*

"*Like hell I am. Just go with Glimmer. Bow's going with some other person and you can go with Glimmer, problem solved."*

"*You can't stay in the castle forever!"*

"*Oh, yes I can."*

"*Got you!"*

"*Get off, Sparkles!"*

"*Glimmer, Catra, stop fighting. What if the queen sees?*

"*She will realize that I am 'Horde scum that is attacking her daughter' and tell me that I am 'not to go to some stupid dance.'"*

"*Don't mock my mom's voice! And she not stupid. She'll let you go, maybe she'll even force you."*

"*Not if I have anything to say about it!"*

Angella pinched the ridge of her nose, before opening the door. As if on cue, Glimmer, Catra, and Adora rolled into the room in a tangle of limbs. Looking up showed Bow following close behind. As the argument continued, Angella looked at Bow, silencing him with a look. She turned back to the ball that was Glimmer, Adora, and Catra and cleared her throat.

Immediately Glimmer teleported out of the wrestling match and stood in front of her mother. Catra went to speak before Adora shoved her to the side, standing up quicker than Catra could.

"Your Majesty–" Adora spoke.

"Mom–" Glimmer said at the same time as Adora.

Before either of them could get a word out, Angella held a hand up, effectively silencing both of them. Catra snickered as she pushed herself off of the ground.

"Adora, explain what is going on." Angella said in a stern voice with a hint of exasperation.

"At once, Your Majesty. You see, I had received an invite for the All Princess Ball, Winter Wonderland. After Glimmer and Bow explained it to me, they said I may bring a plus one. I request that Catra be allowed to attend with me as my plus one." Adora explained in a militaristic fashion that showed her upbringing. Angella remained silent, as if thinking about what she had just heard. Her face must have not inspired too much hope, because Catra's tone was heavy with smugness as she spoke.

"Ha, told you Adora. Don't feel too bad though. I would never have–"

"Granted." Angella said with an almost unnoticeable smirk. Almost.

"What?! Why? It's only been two weeks, how can you be so sure I won't turn tail and run with everything I've learned? It's unsafe and unwise to–" Catra tried to talk her way out of it before being interrupted by Nettossa.

"Face it, Catra. You're going to Princess Prom. Just accept your loss with dignity."

". . .Who are you?" Catra asked after a moment of confused silence.

"Oh where are our manners? I am Spinnerella and this is my wife Nettossa. Pleased to meet you." Spinnerella said.

Catra took note of their appearance. Spinnerella had light pink skin like that of Angella and Glimmer. Her hair was dark lavender and she had deep blue eyes. She was wide hipped and wore a

pink and purple leotard-like armor. Her choker had a blue gem on it that matched Netossa's color theme.

Netossa was a dark skinned woman with dark eyes and silver blue hair. She had on silver gray vambraces with blue stars on them. She had a build similar to that of Angella but not as tall. She also wore a choker, like that of Spinnerella, although hers matched Spinerella's color theme. She also took note, that despite being married, neither wore a ring.

"Uh, yeah, sure. Nice to meet you?" Catra said awkwardly before turning back to Angella, "Like I was saying, I can't be trusted to go to this dance. You should lock me in my room for the night."

"Catra, I can safely say that you can be trusted. I also know that you have no memory of the Horde or you wouldn't have been reading that book about the Horde history. Besides, every princess will be at Princess Prom. If every princess combined couldn't stop you, then I fear for the rebellion." Angella said slyly, a smirk on her face. "Besides, are you telling me that you can't handle a dance? Here I thought you were much more capable than that Catra. Oh well, I suppose you can stay if you would like, but I–"

"Woah, woah, back it up there. I can handle a dance. It'd be easy too. You just have to remember the stupid etiquette." Catra said, crossing her arms, "I'm just not keen on wearing a dress. . . Or shoes for that matter. My claws don't exactly mix well with fabric, in case you hadn't noticed."

"Then it's settled. I will have several suits prepared and Glimmer and Bow can coach you on proper etiquette. This will be a breeze for you as you have just now assured me. This meeting is dismissed for the day. Everyone, enjoy yourselves. It only comes around once a decade. Make some memories." Angella said as she strode out of the room.

Catra blinked, confused, "What just happened?"

"It looks like you're coming with me to Princess Prom. Don't feel too bad though, I would never have gone without you." Adora said smugly, throwing an arm around Catra's shoulders. Spinnerella and Netossa gave a small laugh.

Catra gently shoved a hand in Adora's face with an annoyed hiss, taking care not to cut her with her claws. "Yeah, yeah, whatever."

Catra turned towards the sound of laughter, irritation flooding her body.

"*Don't feel too bad Catra. Adora beat everyone's scores, not just yours. It's nothing to be upset about." Kyle said gently.*

"*Yeah, except her score was the highest for once. Maybe if she put in more effort, she wouldn't be so agitated right now." Lonnie said angrily, holding a hand over a bleeding gash on her shoulder..*

"*That's not fair Lonnie. We lost too and Catra did try. She did her best." Kyle defended Catra.*

"*Did her best? Ha, that'll be the day. Catra doesn't try. She's self centered, arrogant, and lazy," Lonnie turned to look at Catra, letting out a harsh laugh, "The day you actually try is the day that Shadow Weaver says she's proud of you."*

Catra could feel herself becoming more and more angry the longer Lonnie laughed. Her claws were unsheathed and her hair was standing up on end.

"Fuck you, Lonnie." Catra snapped at the laughing woman. The room was a lot quieter now, all eyes focused on Catra.

"Catra are you okay?" Adora asked, sympathetically.

Catra looked around at her surroundings. Looking down at her hands, she could see her claws were out and her fur was standing up. Taking a deep breath, she put her claws away and smoothed the fur on her tail back down. Coming to the realization that she

had been caught in the middle of a memory, she turned towards Netossa and went to apologize before being cut off.

"Ah, save it. I understand and it's fine. No harm no foul. Are you alright?" Netossa asked in a relaxed tone.

"Uh, yeah. . .yeah, I think so. Sorry for killing the mood." Catra apologized.

"Don't worry about it. Castaspella said that that's normal. It means you're recovering your memories." Bow said as Adora rubbed Catra's back calmingly.

"But didn't I try and kill you guys a couple weeks ago? Why is me getting my memories back a good thing for you guys?" Catra questioned.

"Because, even if you want to fight us again, you'll have yourself back. No one should go through that. Not even our enemies. Not that you're our enemy or anything. . .I meant that–" Bow stuttered out a hasty response before being cut off by Catra.

"I get what you meant. . .Thanks." Catra muttered that last part. Adora gave her a small smile, to which Catra gave one back.

"Sooo. . .Which one was Lonnie again?" Glimmer asked curiously.

"She's a dark skinned girl. I think you fought her at the Salineas gate, Glimmer?" Adora offered. Glimmer's face lit up in recognition.

"Oh yeah! Was she not your friend?"

"I wouldn't think so with the response I just got." Netossa said, leaning back in her chair.

"She was a friend. She could just be a bit much at times. I couldn't even pinpoint which moment you remembered just now if I tried. You two have butt heads more times than I can count." Adora informed her.

Catra thought about that. The picture she had gotten had a younger Lonnie in it. She was smiling and had a hand on Catra's shoulder. Kyle had also been smiling in the photo. Rojelio might have been smiling, it was hard to tell, but the photo showed that they were all in the same squad. Maybe their relationship was similar to Mara's and Serenia's. Not quite best friends but definitely more than an acquaintance. Slowly nodding her head, she turned to look at Adora.

"Lonnie was berating me for being lazy and self centered. Kyle was there too. He was trying to cheer me up, saying not to 'feel too bad, that you had beaten everyone's score.' She was holding her arm. It was bleeding." Catra explained to Adora.

"Oh. . .was there a gash on her shoulder? And did she say anything about Shadow Weaver?" Adora asked.

"That's oddly specific, Adora." Spinnerella said.

"Actually, yeah. Something about Shadow Weaver being proud or something. My claws were out." Catra said matter-of-factly.

"Yeah, I remember that. It's not something I like to remember.." Adora said.

"Tell me." Catra said bluntly.

"What?" Adora asked, taken aback.

"Tell me. I don't have the full memory. Tell me about what happened next. Please." Catra said, looking at Adora pleadingly, her eyes becoming soft and wide.

"Alright, alright. Just stop making that face. You said you'd never do that again." Adora muttered. "Okay let's see. . ."

As Adora started to tell the story of the events that led up to that point, Glimmer and Bow wandered off, saying that Glimmer wanted to talk to Bow privately. After they had left, Netossa and Spinnerella had sat back down in their chairs, intrigued.

"The score that had been beaten had been an all around score, focusing on speed, aggression, and overall combat ability. Catra had held the top score for the first time and was quite proud of it. At some point, I had beaten it and Lonnie had provoked Catra over it.

"Well, you stormed off muttering about Lonnie. The thing was, Lonnie was kind of right. You didn't try if you didn't have to. You preferred to stay in the back, away from the limelight. Not that that's not a bad thing. Kyle did the same thing throughout most of our childhood years.

But Lonnie had pushed you. So that week you decided to, er, apply yourself. You beat every score I had, by a pretty good margin I might add. You were determined to make Lonnie eat her words." Adora went silent for a moment before continuing, "After the scores were tallied, Lonnie looked pretty shocked. She couldn't believe that you had topped all of my scores. Nobody had ever even come close and you blew my scores completely out of the water. Lonnie apologized for what she had said."

"As she should have," Netossa said, nodding, "Wasn't even her business to begin with."

"Well I was really happy for you, Catra. We all were. We were–"

"Wait, why don't you like to remember this? This seems pretty awesome. Catra proved everyone wrong, right?" Netossa asked, confused.

"I was getting to that part. We were celebrating your achievement. You had set a record, actually. . .But then Shadow Weaver came in. She took one look at you and your scores and had decided that the rest of us weren't trying hard enough. That we were slacking off. It's like she couldn't handle you beating me.

"She said you hadn't accomplished anything on your own. That you owed it to me and that my potential had rubbed off onto you or something." Adora's hands were clenched white-knuckled. "She

couldn't dispute the fact that you had broken several records, not when the numbers were in front of everyone. She congratulated you though. She let you relax for the next week."

"Okay, besides the obvious devaluation of your victory, she still congratulated you though. How is that a bad thing?" Spinnerella asked, slightly lost.

Catra had already realized what had happened. She didn't need her memories to figure out what had happened. "It was bad because if I could do it, then why should they be struggling, right?"

Adora nodded, "Yeah, Catra was 'supposedly' the worst one in our squad. So when she broke those records, we had to catch up. Unfortunately, the rest of us couldn't keep up. As it turns out, due to Catra's physiology, she's a lot stronger than most people. Her muscles matured a lot faster as well. So while Catra could hit these extreme scores for a ten year old. . ."

"The rest of you couldn't." Spinnerella said, aghast.

"Yeah. . .and Shadow Weaver drilled it into us for a week after that. 'Life's not fair, Catra is better than you.' She made sure that Catra couldn't help us or participate in any shape or form. Shadow Weaver gave you extra meals, gave you extra privileges, you even got to meet the Force Captains. Anything to show us what we were missing out on because we couldn't keep up." Adora explained bluntly.

"She was trying to make you all angry at me, wasn't she?" Catra asked in a small voice.

"Yeah and unfortunately it succeeded. We were always together, so I knew you could hit those scores long before you ever did. It didn't bother me and I was too happy that you were getting the recognition you deserved that I didn't notice what she was doing at the time. But Lonnie and Rojelio? They were too angry to think about it. We were ten, how could we understand?

"About three days into that week, you had realized what was going on and had tried to get Shadow Weaver to stop, to let us get some rest. She told you that they had slacked off. That we had to realize what we had done wrong and that until we could top your scores or at the very least come close, we would do those drills until we couldn't move."

"What a bitch." Netossa muttered darkly. Spinnerella put a comforting hand on her wife's shoulder before speaking.

"So what happened? Were you allowed to stop?"

Adora nodded, a small smile graced her face before slowly disappearing, "Catra hadn't shown up on the fourth day for our drills. See, I hadn't known until a couple hours later, but Shadow Weaver had received word that Catra had hurt one of the Force Captains. That had been enough for her to turn her abuse on to Catra again. Lonnie had been run ragged and was angry, but Kyle had figured it out. He had seen what Catra had done for us and defended her.

From that point on, you started slacking, Catra. You wouldn't show up to practices on time. You would break things or show up at the last second. You kept your scores just high enough to stay on the squad, but just low enough that nobody cared. But I knew the truth and Lonnie did too."

Catra sat quietly, thinking about what she had just heard about Shadow Weaver.

"*I was hard on you, much harder than on Adora, this is true. I won't deny it and I won't apologize. I wanted you to be strong, to be prepared for the world. It is unforgiving and dangerous and even now, subconsciously, you retain those lessons."*

"Helloooo, Etheria to Catra, are you in there?" A voice broke her out of her thoughts.

"Huh? Oh, sorry. I was just. . .thinking about something." Catra paused for a second before turning to Adora, "Was this Shadow

Weaver woman our mother figure? Did she raise us?"

"I mean. . .yes? Kind of. More of a commanding officer. She taught us how to tie our boots and how to read and how to subvert the enemy and be victorious in battle." Adora explained.

"So, mom stuff. Got it." Netossa said.

"No, commanding officer stuff. . . and mom stuff." Adora reluctantly added that last part.

"Then she couldn't have been that bad." Catra said out loud. Adora whipped her head at Catra in disbelief.

"Catra, you absolutely hated her. You were the one who was always taking the brunt of the punishment. She is *that* bad." Adora said firmly.

"Well, Angella is super nice and supportive and not all moms are the same. Plus you said we were in the Horde and that's like a military thing right? Maybe she was just doing her job." Catra said, feeling as if she wasn't hearing the full story.

Adora looked like she wanted to say something else before she let out a sigh. "Look, Catra, I know you lost your memories and you want to get them back, but Shadow Weaver is not like Angella. She's abusive and cruel and manipulative and. . .and she'll say or do anything to take advantage of you. Especially now that you don't remember anything about her."

"But what if–"

"No, Catra. There are no 'what if's.' She's a horrible person who would physically and mentally hurt us." Adora said before continuing in a gentler tone, "I'm not lying to you Catra. I just want you to be prepared for when your memories come back."

Catra slightly narrowed her eyes. She wanted to snap at Adora, to tell her to let her make her own decision on this. But she held her

tongue. Adora could see that Catra wasn't happy with what she was being told, but in her opinion, Catra needed to hear this.

"Fine." Catra said through gritted teeth, before turning and walking towards the door.

"Catra, hold on. I didn't mean. . .I'm just trying to–" Adora went to say before Spinnerella and Netossa stopped her.

"Let her cool down. She's just agitated about her memory loss. Let her work through it on her own." Spinnerella said comfortingly.

"I'm not trying to tell her what to do." Adora said, frustrated.

"We know and so does she. She just needs a minute." Adora let out a sigh of defeat.

Catra had decided to get something to eat. Recently, she had found eating or drinking something calmed her down. She had also found that dragging her claws across things also worked, much to Angella's irritation. She figured out that doing that while in the castle was not a good idea.

An hour passed before Catra had calmed down enough to go see what Angella was up to. She found her in the throne room looking over some papers. As she approached her, she turned her gaze to Angella's wings. It wasn't the first time she had taken an interest in her wings. They were quite deceiving to the eye and if you didn't know any better you would say they weren't physically a part of her due to their transparency. Their natural radiance gave a shifting pattern of light that rippled across her feathers. It was quite captivating, if she was being honest. She was quite envious of Angella. If she wanted privacy, she simply needed to go up into the sky.

"Catra, it's rude to stare." Angella said, an eyebrow raised.

"Huh? Oh, uh, sorry." Catra fidgeted with slight embarrassment.

"It's alright, although, keep in mind that staring at me in that manner might send me mixed signals. Do you understand where I'm going with this?" Angella asked with an amused smile.

"I'm not sure what. . ." Catra's words died on her lips as a look of understanding spread across her face.

"No! That's not what–I mean–I wasn't– I-I'm just gonna go." Catra said, flustered, her face a bright shade of red.

As she turned to walk away, Angella's laughter rang out in the hall, "Catra, come back. I'm only teasing you. You were staring at my wings, yes?"

"Y-Yeah, I was." Catra said, fidgeting in place, as her embarrassment slowly died down.

"What did you want to talk about?" Angella asked, her smile still present from her joke.

"Nothing, I was just bored. Adora irritated me so I went and got something to eat and now everyone's run off to go prepare for their high school dance." Catra said, still a bit sour over earlier.

"High school? Is that an academic thing?" Angella asked.

Catra realized that high school was not a thing on Etheria. "Oh, uh, no. It's from Earth. Kids go through pre-school at five years old to learn to read, then they go through a thing called kindergarten at six, then grade school for five years, middle school for three, and then high school for four. Then they'd have a choice of going to college.

"Ah, I see. That is a fascinating concept. And their parents are okay with sending their children away for these long periods of time? I assume it's similar to the tutoring systems the princesses have?" Angella asked.

"Uh, yeah, kinda? They go for several hours a day and then go home." Catra said, slightly glad the topic had changed from the

embarrassment she had just suffered.

"Ah, so I was right. Basically tutoring. And as they got older, the lessons would naturally become more advanced and difficult." Angella stood up and started walking through the halls, beckoning Catra to follow.

"Here, on Etheria, we have no knowledge of other worlds, besides Earth. It's a completely foreign concept and even then, only the community of Mystacor has knowledge of it. So while I am quite eager to learn more about it, I do insist that we pause this discussion. You have to pick what you would like to wear to princess prom tomorrow night." Angella said as she stopped in front of a room that Catra hadn't been in yet.

"Just give me a suit and call it good. I don't really care what I'm wearing." Catra said, irritation slipping into her tone.

"Do you remember what I told you about appearances?" Angella asked expectantly.

"Yeah, yeah. Appearance is important. Can't rule a kingdom with a bedhead." Catra recited.

"That's right, now come. Your input is important and the measurements need to be fitted to your height and build. It'll be fun. You've never picked clothes before, am I right? Adora only ever wears her jacket, but I feel like you like diversity and style.

"What's wrong with her jacket?" Catra asked as she followed her into the room.

"Nothing's wrong with it per say, it's just that Adora doesn't like to dress up. It's something to do with her upbringing regarding routine. I suspect you would have done the same had you not lost your memories." Angella paused before turning towards Catra with an apologetic look, "I'm sorry. I have steered the conversation to less than pleasant territory."

"Nah, don't worry about it. Besides, they're coming back. Slowly. But they are coming back." Catra said, waving Angella's apology off.

"Well, here we are. Where would you like to start first?" Angella said, gesturing to shelves and dressers filled with clothing. Catra was taken aback. She had no clue where to start. As she went to say something, a thought hit her.

"Shouldn't I do this with Adora? I'm her date for this thing, right? Shouldn't our choice of clothing match? Appearance and all that?" Catra asked, turning to look at Angella.

"Oh, um, if you wish to do that, you may. But, typically, the custom for princess prom is to surprise your plus one after choosing your attire, although the younger generation has somewhat forgone it." Angella said, slightly flustered.

Catra raised an eyebrow at Angella's flustered response, "What's with that response? Is it weird to match at a ball? Earth dances do that all the time."

"Oh, it's not. . .uncommon. It's just normally reserved for married couples." Angella explained.

Catra blinked at that answer, "Say what?"

"Well, it's an Etherian tradition for engaged and married couples to match color schemes. If you look at Netossa and Spinnerella, you may notice that their clothing had matching highlights." Angella said.

Catra thought back at their meeting earlier. Angella was right. Their vambraces and chokers matched one another's colors. She had simply thought they were doing that as a way to signify their closeness in their marriage, now she realized that it was actually tradition.

"On Earth, the way to signify your marriage is to present a wedding band, er, ring to your spouse. You would both wear these

rings on your left hand on the fourth finger. These rings would be identical." Catra explained. "I just thought that they chose not to wear rings or something."

"Ah, no. Although I see the parallels of matching colors or jewelry pieces. But I can get Adora if you wish. I'm sure that–"

"No!" Catra cleared her throat, a bit embarrassed, "No, it's fine. We can stick to customs. If princess prom says to surprise your date, we can do that. I assume Glimmer's helping her pick a dress and she seemed pretty excited about that, so. . . yeah."

Angella gave a small smile, "Alright, Catra, let's see what we have."

Throughout the next hour, Catra tried on dresses that offered functionality for claws and a tail. By the seventh dress, Catra had decided that a suit was the better choice.

"So, tell me Catra, have you given any thought to who's memories you might have? Adora says you have had a few minor personality shifts. Mainly your speech patterns." Angella asked while a servant took Catra's measurements for a suit.

"What do you mean by speech patterns?" Catra asked, confused.

"Nothing bad. Just that you seemed to speak more properly and you started cursing a bit more." Angella said, holding up two suits, to which Catra shook her head at both.

"Oh, yeah, that. I mean. . . not really? I had a dream that I can't quite remember. Something to do with Earth, but it's strange. I have so many memories about Earth that I can recall effortlessly, but not that one. Do you think it means something?"

"That depends. Can you recall anything like specific people in it? Or any feelings associated with your dream?" Angella asked, turning to face Catra.

"Actually, kind of, yeah. It was a mix of excitement and anxiousness. But, I can't remember any faces."

"Hmm, I wonder if this dream was actually a personal memory of this person that created the shards. As we get older and learn about the world around us, we kind of stop thinking about it. It's just there. Kind of like the air. You don't think about breathing, you just do it. It's just something that's there. If this was a personal memory, it may be more intimate."

"Huh, I hadn't thought about it like that. Well whatever it was, it doesn't pertain to me. So, whatever." Catra said, shrugging.

Angella's thoughts were filled with images of the mysterious woman that had appeared before her. She had an idea that this woman was from Earth. She wouldn't speak of her yet, not until she had a better understanding of the shards. Angella turned with a suit in hand back towards Catra.

"What about this one?" Angella asked.

Catra was about to shoot it down out of reflex, but paused when she looked at it. The suit coat and pants were a dark purple, almost burgundy and the trim that ran along the edges of the coat was a light purple, borderline pink. The undershirt was the same color, giving it a nice clash of dark red hues. It seemed to be missing something though.

Angella thought that this one might catch Catra's eye. She had heard descriptions of Catra back when she was still a force captain. The appearance given to her in reports always depicted her in dark reds and purples. So when she had seen this suit in the piles of suits, she figured Catra might like this one. Seeing Catra take an interest in one of the suits made her smile. She had been fairly dismissive of most of the choices, but she seemed to have taken an interest in this one.

"Somethings missing." Catra muttered to herself, her irritation catching Angella's attention.

"Ah, there it is." Angella said with a smile.

"There, what is?" Catra asked in confusion, turning her focus to Angella.

"You are now going through what every person who goes to princess prom goes through. Tell me, would you go to princess prom wearing that suit as is?" Angella asked with a grin now fully present on her face.

"No, it's not right. Something's missing. Is that the full piece? Are there any accessories to it?" Catra asked, taking it from Angella and holding it up in the mirror.

Angella shook her head, "No, what you are holding is it."

Catra hummed at that before letting out an annoyed growl. As she went to set it down, a flash of white and gold caught her eye. Turning towards the shelf, she laid the suit down on the chair before walking over. As she pulled out the eye-catching cloth, she found it was a single white coat, with its shoulders and cuffs adorned in gold highlighting.

"What did you find?" Angella asked.

Catra turned before pulling the coat on. It was a little big and it needed to be tightened a bit to fit her, beyond that Catra quite liked it. It was a far cry from what she typically wore and it clashed with her current clothing choice, but there was something about the white and gold that made it appealing to her.

"It looks nice on you," Angella said with a smile, "Unfortunately, beyond the coat, there is nothing else to it. It's only the coat."

"Nothing? Could we pair it with something?" Catra asked. She didn't know why she liked it. Perhaps it made her seem more mature?

"Is that what you are planning on wearing to princess prom? If so, I'm sure we could find something." Angella said.

"Oh, uh, no. I just. . .kind of like the coat." Catra said as she took it off. Maybe it was because it was eye-catching. It definitely stood out among the other colors. Holding it up beside all of the suits, she couldn't unsee it. To Catra, it was one of, if not the most captivating thing in the room. It was. . .enthralling.

"You may keep it if you wish." Angella said.

"Really? You don't mind?" Catra asked, turning her head to meet Angella's gaze.

"Catra, that is the most interested I've seen you all day and over a coat no less. If you like the coat that much, take it. It's just a coat and if you want to find something that matches with it later, come talk to me. It's no trouble, I assure you. Think of it as a gift."

"Thank you. I mean it." Catra said, a smile lighting up her face.

"I take it, you are going to wear the burgundy suit then?" Angella said, picking it up from where it was draped.

"Yeah, I think that's the one. But I–"

"Queen Angella, are you in here?" Adora's voice rang out from the corridor, her footsteps quickly approaching the door.

"Mom, Adora and I need an accessory. Sorry if we're interrupting. We'll be–" Glimmer said before being cut off.

With surprising speed and agility that Angella had not seen before, Catra had jumped through the furniture, maneuvered through the piles of clothing, and landed in front of the door before slamming it shut.

"Hey! What's the big idea?" Glimmer exclaimed.

"I'm in the middle of making a choice, sparkles." Catra yelled through the door.

"So? Why'd you slam the door in our faces?" Adora asked.

Glimmer's muffled voice came through the door, "Ohhh, sorry. I didn't know you were here."

"What's that matter? Catra, are you still mad at me?" Adora asked.

"What? No. You just aren't allowed to see me until I've picked what I'm gonna wear." Catra said through the door.

"Why not? I don't care if you see what I picked." Adora said, confusion present in her voice.

"It's custom, Adora. You're not supposed to let your plus one see you until you both are in your outfits. Not many people do that anymore. I hadn't even thought of that." Glimmer let out a gasp before speaking, "You didn't see Adora, did you?"

"Nope. Now shoo, I'm almost done picking." Catra said.

"Do you care if I come in? I just need to grab something for Adora." Glimmer asked aloud.

Catra paused before turning to look at the burgundy suit. Glimmer's input would help and she, herself, couldn't place what was missing. "Only you. Adora, we'll talk later, alright?"

"I still need to tell you about customs and the curtsy and other stuff. You also have stuff you need to know as my plus one." Adora said.

"Got it, I'll show up after this and we can go over it. Now shoo, Glimmer will be back in a second." Catra said through the door.

"Alright." Adora said,before turning to nod at Glimmer. As she walked back to the room, Glimmer teleported into the room, landing on a large pile of suits.

"Great, I need your opinion." Catra said, hauling Glimmer to her feet.

"Mine? What do you need my help for?" Glimmer asked. Angella watched in amusement as Catra pulled Glimmer to the side, showing her the suit.

"Something's missing and I don't know what. Help me out." Catra said, holding the suit in front of her.

"Ooh, I like that. But you're right." Glimmer let out a hum as she examined the suit up and down.

"Well, for one, it should have a tie. And it should be black or the same color as the suit's coat." Glimmer said as she walked to a specific shelf and pulled out two ties.

Catra examined both ties and decided it should match the coat. Glimmer was in agreement. As Catra walked out in the suit, Glimmer and Angella nodded in approval.

"I don't know," Catra said as she examined herself in the mirror, "should I wear shoes? You said it's going to be at the Kingdom of. . .Snows. . ."

"Oh, don't worry about the temperature. It's regulated through magic. It's actually quite warm in the palace." Angella said.

"No, not that. Gloves." Catra said in realization.

"What about gloves?" Angella asked?

"What it's missing. I need some gloves. And maybe some different footwear." Catra said, examining her feet.

Glimmer teleported to a top shelf and grabbed a pair of black fingerless gloves and black dress shoes that left her heels and toes free. After she put them on she twisted and turned, examining herself in the mirror once more. She was quite happy with her choice.

Catra turned towards Glimmer and Angella, "What do you think?" Catra with a smirk on her face.

"It looks great. And it really suits you. But aren't you gonna do your tie?" Glimmer asked.

"Nah, I think it looks better undone." Catra said.

"It's quite becoming. You look quite confident, which gives you a certain appeal and attraction. But what matters is what you think of it." Angella said, encouragingly.

"I think. . .I look hot." Catra said, turning once more to admire herself in the mirror before turning towards Glimmer, "Thanks for the help Glimmer. I couldn't place it."

"No problem, now can you do me a favor?" Glimmer asked.

"Sure, what's up?" Catra asked.

"Could you turn around? I don't want you seeing what I'm grabbing for Adora."

"Oh, right. Sure." Catra said as she turned her back to Glimmer. Catra heard the sound of shuffling for a few seconds.

"Thanks, I'll see you later. You can turn back around again." Catra heard Glimmer say before a flash of sparkles lit up her vision.

"Aaand she's gone." Catra said, a chuckle leaving her lips.

"So excited, isn't she?" Angella said.

"So is she taking someone else? What, with Bow going with Perfuma and all?"

"Oh, is he? I had figured he–" Angella was cut off by Catra.

"Wait a second! Isn't Perfuma the vine girl? Why's he going with the girl who tried to kill me!" Catra exclaimed.

Angella rolled her eyes, "She didn't try and kill you. She merely tied you up."

"Well, she could've. Some of those vines had thorns." Catra complained in mock anger.

Angella opened her mouth to speak before pausing, "Catra, I'm not going to be goaded into a fake argument so that you don't have to go learn proper etiquette. My daughter has used this trick too many times."

"Eh, It was worth a shot. Alright, I better go see what Adora had to say." After Catra changed back into her clothes, she stopped at the door, "Thanks for this. It was fun."

"Yes, I found myself enjoying this as well and don't worry about your hair. I can help you with that before you leave." Angella said, ushering several servants inside to help her clean the suits and dresses up.

Catra arrived at Adora's room, it was technically her room as well, and knocked.

"Who is it?" Adora's muffled voice came through the door.

"It's me Adora," Catra said in a sarcastic spooky voice, "I've regained all of my memories and have decided to become a Force Commander again. Ooooh"

"Ha ha, very funny Catra. And it's Force Captain, not Commander." Adora said as she walked over and opened the door.

Catra immediately took notice of all of the charts and papers pinned to the walls. It looked like Admiral Stratos' war room. Catra took one small step back and before she could turn to run, Adora grabbed her arm.

"Oh no you don't. I've seen that look enough growing up to know you were about to run." Adora said, dragging her into the room and closing the door.

"Ugh, fine. Educate me on this stupid etiquette." Catra said, exasperatedly.

Adora's face shifted into an infuriating smirk, "I will."

For the rest of the day Catra was stuck learning the proper dance, the proper way to bow, to eat, to greet, and all manner of other proper things. More than once, she thought about making a run for it. Unfortunately, Glimmer had shown up and was blocking the door.

'This sucks,' Catra thought to herself.

Deep in the Fright Zone, Kyle, Lonnie, and Rojelio were engaged in a dangerous and deadly mission. One slip up could mean the end for everyone. Surprisingly, it was Kyle who was their saving grace. For the enemy posed a challenge that was unlike any other.

Scorpia was in the middle of choosing a dress for princess prom. And because their squad was pivotal to the mission involving Catra, they had to, unfortunately, help Scorpia pick a dress.

Lonnie didn't know the first thing regarding this. She was a Horde soldier, not some fashion designer. She didn't even know the Horde had dresses. Until today, that is. Turns out, Scorpia's family were the original rulers of the Fright Zone. She knew that she was a princess, but she hadn't really thought about what that entailed. As she leaned back against the chair she was sitting on, Scorpia came out with another dress on. This one was a little weird. It was a frilly black and red dress with the Horde symbol on the midsection. It had red coverings that encompassed her shoulders, and some sort of strange black gloves. She also wore green eye liner that clashed horrible with the color scheme.

"I'm not sure that's the one," Kyle said, "The earrings suit you though. The choker is alright, but the green eyeliner kind of clashes with your color scheme."

"Yeah, I thought that too. I just wasn't sure. This is why it's important to have a second about the gloves and choker? Too much?" Scorpia asked, holding her pincers up.

"The choker could work, but I'm of the personal opinion the gloves could go. But black and red is definitely your color. You should stick with that. It suits you. . .and maybe less frilly." Kyle said as he wrote down notes about her dress choices.

"Okay, so what do we have so far for notes Read 'em off to me." Scorpia said.

Lonnie groaned in the background and Rojelio didn't look too impressed either. When Shadow Weaver had been informed about the invite, they had been instructed to help Scorpia get ready. It should have been a quick process, but no. She had to look as good as she could possibly be for Catra. What if she didn't even show up?

"Okay, so what we have so far is that black and red are the colors." Kyle said.

"Right." Scorpia confirmed.

"It should be more form fitting and less frilly."

"Mm-hm" Scorpia nodded.

"Earrings are a good choice, gloves are optional, and the choker is a toss up."

"Okay," Scorpia said, "I think I might have a dress in mind. What else?"

"As for makeup, black was a good lipstick and eyeliner needed to match. You said the high heels were non-negotiable?" Kyle asked.

"That's right." Scorpia said, "Is that everything?"

"Yep. That's all of it." Kyle said.

"Alright then, I think I have the perfect dress in mind." Scorpia said as she went back into her quarters to change.

Lonnie turned to look at Kyle in annoyance, "You. Are. The worst. You dragged this out for four hours, Kyle. Four hours!"

"I wasn't going to lie to her, Lonnie. This is obviously super important to her. Plus, her and Catra were, like, close. I think. Regardless, if she says she's got the perfect dress, I believe her. Back me up Rojelio." Kyle said with his arms crossed.

Rojelio let out an annoyed hiss, to Kyle's chagrin, "Aw, what? Not you too. Come on guys."

"Let's just hope that this is it. I don't think I could take another hour of this." Lonnie said with a huff.

As Scorpia opened the door, everyone looked up at her. She was adorned in a sleek, black dress that hugged her curves. It had a stylish shredded look where it hugged one of her shoulders and down her arm. She wore a bright ruby red belt that had small garnets along the sides of it. Her earrings were also garnets and she wore black lipstick with barely noticeable eyeliner that accentuated her eyelashes. She wore sleek black high heels that went up her ankles.

"Wow, that is definitely the one." Kyle said encouragingly, "You look great."

"Ah, thanks guys. Well let's go inform Shadow Weaver. I wonder what she's wearing to the ball." Scorpia said. As they walked through the halls of the Fright Zone, they stopped in front of Shadow Weaver's chambers.

"You may enter." Shadow Weaver's voice drifted through the door. As they walked in, they all took notice of the articles of clothing that were draped along the furniture. Shadow Weaver was nowhere to be seen, to Scorpia's confusion.

"Um, hello? Shadow Weaver? We're all ready for the ball. Are you in here?" Scorpia asked to the dark room. The only source of light in the room being the black garnet, which gave off a mysterious, dark, crimson red glow.

"One moment, Force Captain Scorpia." Shadow Weaver's voice came drifting through the air, sending shivers down everyone's spines. The hiss of the door opening was the only indication of Shadow Weaver's arrival. There, illuminated by the soft glow of the black garnet, stood Shadow Weaver in all of her glory.

Her dress gave off the appearance of dark black ink with dark red highlights along her ribs and hips. It flowed behind her like soft silk flowing in the wind, giving an almost ominous aura. Her shoulders were covered by a dark mesh that looked like webbing. Along the trim were dark feathers that shimmered like oil. The feathers stretched along down her neck giving a sensual appearance.

She wore dark stockings that stretched up her thigh, along with high heels. Her arms were also encompassed by thin dark gloves that stretched all the way to her shoulder. The dress accentuated her curves, showing a mature woman. Her mask was slightly different as well, giving a more sleek, thin appearance with a beak-like pattern down the center, the glowing red gemstone in her mask giving a glow that completed the look.

All in all, her dress gave off a sensual, dark allure. Almost no skin was showing beyond a sliver of her neck and shoulders. Every move she made allowed the dress to shift in just a way that promised a peek before being hidden once more. It was meant to draw attention, which, of course, was Shadow Weaver's goal.

"Wow. You look great. If it were a contest, your dress would blow mine out of the water. And I am loving the mask " Scorpia gushed, "Your whole raven theme, muah, gorgeous."

"Thank you, Force Captain Scorpia. Your dress suits you as well. I like your earrings, the red suits you. Naturally." Shadow Weaver

said. She wasn't even being sarcastic. She was in quite the good mood and was surprisingly looking forward to the ball. She hadn't personally been out of the Fright Zone in years and was quite eager.

Turning towards the guards at her door, Shadow Weaver spoke, "Has the transport ship been readied? I don't want to be kept waiting."

"Yes, Shadow Weaver. The ship is ready for takeoff at your command. Everything has been prepped." The head guard saluted.

"Good," Shadow Weaver said before turning to face Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio, "Be aware that guards are not permitted inside the ball until a certain point after midnight. You also may not bring your weapons near the castle nor inside. Scorpia, you read over the proper etiquette, I hope?"

"Yes, Shadow Weaver, I've memorized it perfectly. You don't have to worry about a thing." Scorpia said, saluting.

Shadow Weaver looked at her reflection in her cauldron, admiring her appearance. "Good, then we may depart. Cadet Lonnie, take Cadets Kyle and Rojelio to the ship and outfit them with proper equipment. Scorpia, accompany the guards to the transport ship. I will join you shortly."

As everyone nodded and left the room, Shadow Weaver turned towards the screen. Within seconds it flashed to life, showing the image of Hordak.

"Shadow Weaver. . .I see you have dressed well for the occasion." Hordak said, his voice taking a similar tone to that of his predecessor, "Am I to understand that Force Captain Catra will be at this event?"

"Yes, Lord Hordak. I have one hundred percent faith that she will be there. The princess alliance will be looking to expand their

numbers. With such a golden opportunity in front of them, they would be fools to not jump at it."

"Hmm, I had come to this conclusion as well. But, if you have not confirmed this, how can you be certain?" Hordak asked in a low voice.

"That's quite simple. When Adora was a child, she wouldn't let Catra out of her sight. They were glued at the hip. With Adora's new status as a princess, she will no doubt attend the ball. Her plus one would naturally be Catra. I have already made contact with Catra and have established a good connection with her. The plan is to speak to her at the ball." Shadow Weaver explained.

"Could you not simply take her and the shard? Why the subterfuge?" Hordak asked with narrowed eyes full of suspicion.

"At this point in time, Force Captain Catra has lost almost all of her memories. She is in the company of the enemy and no doubt being dissuaded from returning to me, to the Horde. If I act too brashly, or am not cemented in her mind as an important figure to be trusted. . .well, you saw what happened with Adora." Shadow Weaver said darkly.

Hordak stayed silent for several moments before giving a slight nod. "I see. Yes, that would not bode well. Beyond Catra, how has the search for the shards been coming along? Your report said you were able to displace most of them without alert. A commendable action, I might add."

"Thank you Lord Hordak. Ever since my excursion into Mystacour, I have been able to locate several. While we have not retrieved any, it is only a matter of time until we locate the rest. Unfortunately, several landed in the crimson waste."

"No matter, we only need a few. From what you've told me about these shards, I've been able to deduce they are not of Etheria. If what you suspect is true, that Force Captain Catra really can

manipulate them. . .well, I have several theories that need to be tested." Hordak said, gently petting Imp

"Of course, Lord Hordak. I'll have Catra returning of her own volition soon enough." Shadow Weaver said, giving a slight bow.

"See that she does, Shadow Weaver." Hordak said before the screen turned black.

"Oh, I'll have her return to *me.* You can be sure of that Hordak." Shadow Weaver muttered darkly. A sneer present in her tone.

'And once she has, I'll have no more need of you. You can be sure of that.' Shadow Weaver thought to herself as she made her way to the transit. Soon, her plans would take shape and then she would never need the Horde again.

Chapter 7

"You gotta be careful and don't just lean it somewhere and don't keep it with the other swords or it might get confused!" Adora exclaimed at the ice guard as he took her sword.

"Adora, c'mon!" Glimmer said, struggling to pull Adora towards the entrance before casting a look towards Catra, "A little help would be nice Catra."

"You look like you got it handled." Catra said, chuckling. Glimmer gave a sour look before finally getting Adora to move.

As they walked towards the castle entrance, Catra glanced at Adora. She had chosen a slim red dress that fit her quite well. It was the standard dress style you would typically see at a dance. Nothing too fancy or revealing. Although, looking around, Catra took note of how much Adora's dress stood out among the dark colors.

Catra noticed her reflection on the door as they approached, the door being made of ice and whatnot. She had worn the suit that Angella had helped her pick out. It was quite becoming and Adora had made mention of the color scheme. But before they had left, Catra had let Angella do her hair. It was quite straight and fell like silk onto her shoulders. She wasn't sure how she had done it, but she suspected magic may have played a part, seeing as how good it looked. Catra wasn't one for dressing up, but even she could appreciate Angella's skills regarding hair and makeup.

"Have you ever thought about letting your hair down, Adora?" Catra asked.

"Huh? No, not really. It gets in the way when I'm fighting." Adora said.

"Hm, shame. I think it would look really good on you." Catra said in a lower voice.

Adora cleared her throat nervously, "I'll. . .keep that in mind."

Catra hummed at that, a small smile on her lips. As they opened the door, Catra heard Adora marvel at the size of the room. Catra snorted at that, but even she had to marvel at the sheer size of the castle. It was gorgeous in the kind of way that winter was gorgeous on Earth during Christmas. The ice and snow shimmered with beautiful lights and colors that set the tone.

As they entered, Catra fell in stride beside Adora while holding her arm out. As Adora took Catra's arm, Glimmer began to explain, "The ball is one of our most ancient traditions. A princess' first ball is a huge rite of passage. Plus, the Kingdom of Snows is really big."

"Which is why we need Frosta. If she joins us, all the other princesses are sure to follow." Adora said.

"Don't be too sure about that." Catra warned. "People can be selfish. Not everyone's so quick to put themselves at risk to join a war."

Adora hummed at that. As they walked up the stairs to greet Frosta, Adora gained a look of determination. Taking a deep breath, Adora steeled herself, "Here we go."

As they stepped forward, all three of them bowed, "Hold for one, two, three." Adora said to Catra's amusement.

As they stood back up, Adora took on a look of surprise. It wasn't hard to see why. Even Catra was a bit taken aback by Frosta's age, although she didn't make it so obvious. She had read that she was younger, but she had figured that meant closer to her or Glimmer's age, not ten.

"That's Frosta? But she's, like, ten." Adora said to Glimmer. The crowd let out an audible gasp. Catra wondered if they had already messed this up.

"I'm eleven and three quarters." Frosta said coldly.

"Revered hostess, we come into your hall under the ancient laws of hospitality, bringing greetings from Bright Moon. And She-Ra, legendary warrior. . .and her plus one, Catra." Glimmer said, somewhat nervously, trying to salvage the situation.

"You are welcome in the Kingdom of Snows under the ancient laws of hospitality. Leave conflict at the door and please enjoy the ball." Frosta said with a wave of her hand, dismissing them.

"Thank you, your–" Adora went to say before being cut off by the approaching guards pushing them to the dance floor.

"-Majesty." Adora finished lamely before whirling on Glimmer. "Couldn't you have told me she was a little kid?"

"You did all that research, I assumed you knew." Glimmer said, before letting out a small breath, "You know what? It's fine. There's plenty of time still to win her over. Now come on, let's rock this ball."

As Glimmer said that, her face fell a bit as she looked around nervously. Catra went to say something to her before Adora cut her off. "Oh, there's Entrapta."

As Adora dragged them along, Catra turned to Glimmer, "Are you alright?"

"Yeah, I'm fine. Why wouldn't I be?" Glimmer said shiftily, a little crestfallen.

As Catra went to speak, a new voice interrupted her. "Adora, Glimmer, new person I haven't met yet, are you here to watch the social experiment too?"

"Social experiment?" Adora questioned.

"Different groups are thrown together and forced to mingle. Hierarchies form and break. It's the perfect place to observe behavior. And they have tiny food!" Entrapta exclaimed.

In front of Catra was a woman with very long purple hair that moved on its own. It was quite bizarre, but Catra had learned by this point to roll with it. As she took in the woman's appearance, Catra came to the conclusion that this woman didn't care one bit about appearances.

"Are you observing me right now?" Entrapta asked excitedly, breaking Catra from her thoughts. "Did you come to any conclusion?"

"Oh, uh, kind of?" Catra said, taken aback by the woman's close proximity.

"Oh, tell me, tell me. It's always fascinating to hear other people's thoughts and scientific theories." Entrapta said, shoving a recorder into Catra's face.

"Oh, um, Catra, this is Entrapta. Entrapta, this is Catra. Entrapta is the princess of Dryll." Adora said, introducing one another.

"Nice to meet you," Catra said, moving the recorder back a bit. "I take it you don't particularly care for magic?"

"Oh, I wouldn't say that. Magic is its own field of study. While it is very interesting, my expertise is the study of science!" Entrapta said loudly.

Catra raised an eyebrow. Adora had explained her previous interests before she had lost her memories and scientific studies had not been one of them. This confirmed that her knowledge on any science related topics were from the shards. But beyond that, Catra still felt a sense of elation that she could talk to a new person over a topic she could relate with that didn't involve her memory loss.

"Really? Which field are you currently studying?" Catra asked.

Hearing Catra's words must have piqued Entrapta's interest because she immediately turned her full attention to Catra.

"I love all fields of science. But my specialty lies in technology, mainly robotics and computers. But that doesn't mean I don't do other stuff as well." Entrapta said excitedly.

"Really? That's interesting. What. . ." Catra paused for a moment before speaking, "what are your thoughts on time travel?"

Adora let out a groan, "Catra, we shouldn't mess around with that. Last time we did, it messed you up."

"Adora, if she can help me understand it, I need to know. Plus, I overused the switch. I wasn't really hurt." Catra said, exasperated.

"Time travel? It's purely theoretical and based entirely in science fiction. If you've figured something out regarding it, this is a complete breakthrough! Tell me please!" Entrapta exclaimed, stepping into Catra's personal space.

"Woah, settle down. I can explain, but wouldn't it be better for you to observe it?" Catra said, backpedaling. She may have come on too strong. "Besides, aren't you observing behavior?"

"Ahh," Entrapta deflated a bit, before perking back up, "But you'll still show me, right?"

"Sure, after princess prom. Currently, the only ones I've been able to discuss it with are Stratos and Kai. No one else really understands it. Having someone on this side who can understand the science of it will be a great help. Plus, I'd love to hear your theories on it" Catra said with a smile.

"Oh, you wanna know about my theories? I've waited years for someone to ask me about my theories. It's a deal!" Entrapta said with an ecstatic grin before turning back towards the crowd.

"She's a beauty, can't you see? She's attending this with me! She's my princess of the sea! Mersmista!" Catra turned to the sound of singing. There was a man wearing a blue and gold dress jacket with a white shirt underneath and blue pants and boots. He seemed vaguely familiar to her.

"Oh hey it's- Adora, look out. A Horde soldier has infiltrated and is standing behind you!" Sea Hawk exclaimed.

Catra gave a sly grin. Walking up behind Adora, she rested her chin on her shoulder, wrapping her arms around Adora's waist, "Didn't you hear? I convinced Adora to leave the rebellion and rejoin the Horde. We've become. . .intimately close."

Adora's cheeks turned slightly pink at Mermista and Sea Hawk's shocked faces. Stepping forward, Adora gently removed Catra's arms, "That is not what is happening here."

"Feelings of embarrassment" Entrapta said from behind everyone.

"Well, then what *is* happening here? This is the person who tried to destroy my kingdom. What the hell Adora." Mermista said with irritation.

"She touched some sort of magical crystal and forgot all of her memories. So I'm helping her remember our past, er, her past." Adora quickly corrected herself.

"So you seduced the enemy into helping and not the other way around. Bravo, Adora. I couldn't have done it better myself." Sea Hawk said, nodding sagely. Catra smirked.

Adora, looking for any way to change the subject, gave a sly grin, "So, Sea Hawk's your plus one?"

"No. He is just my ride. Okay? Just. My. Ride." Mermista said, now the embarrassed one.

"Of course," Sea hawk gave a laugh before whispering, "I am her plus one."

"Whatever. We're going to talk about her later." Mermista said to Adora, pointing at Catra, "Do they have a kelp bar here?"

As Mermista walked away with Sea Hawk, Catra caught sight of Netossa and Spinnerella, "Hey Adora, I'm gonna go talk with

Netossa, you wanna come?"

"Actually, I'm going to talk to Frosta, but you go ahead. I'll catch up with you in a bit." Adora said. Catra gave a small smile and a nod before walking towards Netossa.

"Hey, what's up. You guys look great. I'm loving the cape, Spinnerella." Catra said, approaching them.

"Oh, hey Catra. Thanks, I'm glad you think so. Where's Adora, Glimmer, and Bow?" Spinnerella asked, looking around.

"Adora went to talk to Frosta and Glimmer's. . .upset about Bow going with someone else." Catra said, somewhat hesitant before muttering. "Evil flower lady."

"Pfft, Catra, Perfuma is super nice. You should try and talk to her. I think you'd get along." Netossa said before taking a sip of a fizzy purple drink.

Catra looked down at the drink, intrigued, "What's that?"

"This," Netossa said, quickly downing it, "Is not for little girls."

Catra gave a sound of mock irritation. She caught sight of Adora talking to Frosta and from the looks of it, failing. "I'll see you guys in a bit. I'm gonna go see what Adora's up to."

"Alright, see you later." Spinnerella said kindly, taking Netossa's arm before leading her away.

As Catra made her way over towards Adora, her ears picked up the tail ends of the conversation.

"-for thousands of years. We do not need your help or your rebellion. Please continue to enjoy the ball." Frosta said before striding away, leaving a dejected Adora behind.

"Yikes, that didn't look too good. What'd you say to her?" Catra said, walking up behind Adora.

Adora turned towards Catra, "Oh ,you know, the usual. The Horde is evil, please join the Rebellion and help us free Etheria."

"Didn't go too hot I'd imagine?" Catra said with an eyebrow raised.

Adora shook her head, "No, but I'm sure we'll have another chance to talk to her again."

"Well, ignoring that for a second, let's go find Glimmer. She's all upset because Bow went with the evil flower girl." Catra said, grabbing Adora's hand and pulling her along.

"Perfuma is super nice, Catra. You just have to get to know her." Adora said, falling into stride with Catra.

"So everyone keeps telling me." Catra muttered.

As they stepped onto the balcony where Glimmer was, Adora collapsed onto a couch exhausted.

"Where have you been?" Glimmer turned her head towards Adora.

"I told you winning over Frosta–"

"Failing to win over Frosta, more accurately." Catra said, cutting Adora off to her irritation.

At that, Glimmer turned her attention towards the dance floor, looking down from the balcony. Catra followed her gaze, landing on Bow and the evil plant mistress herself.

"Hey, are you okay?" Adora asked, drawing Catra's attention back towards them, before also taking note of Bow and Perfuma. "Why does it bother you so much?" Adora asked Glimmer.

"It doesn't! Bow can hang out with whoever he wants. I just," Glimmer let out a soft sigh, "I never had that many friends, okay?

It's always been just me and Bow. . . But now, what if he likes his new friends better than me? What if everyone does?"

"*Just go, be with your new best friend Lonnie!" Catra said, shoving Adora away.*

"*Is that why you hit her?" Adora asked.*

"I know you like her better than me. You're supposed to be my friend." Catra muttered to herself. Adora turned towards Catra.

"What did you say?" Glimmer asked.

"Oh, uh, nothing. Just. . .thinking about something." Catra said, glancing at Adora.

Adora gave a small smile before turning back towards Glimmer. "That's not gonna happen Glimmer. Bow isn't the type of person to just leave his old friends behind and neither am. . .I"

Adora looked across the room, taking note of the new guests who had just entered. "Shadow Weaver." She muttered darkly.

"What!" Glimmer exclaimed, quickly looking where Adora's attention was focused. Catra snapped her head up at the mention of the name as well, zeroing in on her location.

Across the room stood Shadow Weaver, dressed in a beautiful black and red dress that grabbed everyone's attention. It flowed with a dark allure that was pleasing to the eye. Beside her stood Scorpia in a black and red dress as well.

"Come on, we have to get down there. If they're here, that means the Horde is closing in." Adora said quickly, already moving towards the stairwell.

Catra narrowed her eyes. Whatever her personal thoughts on Shadow Weaver were, she would back Adora up. Hopefully they could solve this peacefully and without ruining the ball.

Catra looked below her and noticed Bow was still standing below the balcony. Netossa and Spinerella were standing beside him and Perfuma as well as Mermista and Sea Hawk. Catra gave a sharp whistle, hoping that she'd be heard over the music. Luckily, Sea Hawk and Mermista had heard it, having learned to pick out words over the sounds of waves.

Mermista looked up at Catra exasperated, before pointing Catra out to the rest of the small group. Bow looked up at Catra and mouthed the word 'what.' Catra pointed at the new arrivals, everyone turning towards the direction of her finger. Netossa looked back up and gave a nod as they all followed behind her towards where Frosta was greeting the guests. At that, Catra raced down the stairs quickly giving chase to Adora.

As Catra made her way towards the group she overheard Frosta, "For centuries the All-Princess Ball has been neutral ground. I will not dishonor that legacy. Scorpia is a princess. Princesses get plus ones. She stays."

Catra, joining the group beside Bow and Mermista, noticed that while Frosta's tone was hard, she looked a little unsure.

As much as Frosta disliked being called it, she was indeed a child. While she would not break the ancient laws, she was a little put off at the mention of the Horde's second in command being here. In front of her stood Princesses Glimmer, Mermista, Perfuma, Netossa, and Spinnerella. She was hesitant to disregard such a warning.

As everyone was escorted away from the throne, Frosta threw out one last warning, her tone harsh. "I don't think I need to tell everyone that any breaking of the ancient laws will result in immediate expulsion?"

"Of course not, Revered Hostess," Shadow Weaver said, stepping forward, "We are here as guests, not as Horde soldiers. You have my word we will be on our utmost behavior."

At Frosta's grunt Shadow Weaver turned and sauntered towards the gathered group of Princesses and their plus one's. "My, my, such hostility. Didn't I–"

Shadow Weaver was immediately cut off by Scorpia stepping past her and enveloping Catra in a bone crushing hug, "Oh Wildcat, I was so worried about you. After the explosion we were all so worried. Oh, don't ever scare me like that again."

Catra was feeling quite smothered but didn't make a move to lash out. Judging by this woman's actions and what she called her, she was going to assume that this person was a previous friend.

"Could you please put me down?" Catra squeezed out with what little air she had left.

"Oh, right, sorry. It's so good to see you." Scorpia said with a grin.

Catra took in the appearance of the exuberant person before her. She had short white hair and had chitin along her shoulders and neck with what appeared to be large pincers instead of hands. Her most striking feature had to be her crimson scorpion tail. It looked quite dangerous if she was being honest. Catra tried channeling a memory, anything that could help her here. Unfortunately, it was not to be.

"I'm sorry, do we know each other?" Catra asked apologetically.

Before Scorpia could answer, Mermista interjected, "She's the person that you tried blowing my kingdom with. How do you not remember her? You two seemed pretty chummy to me last time I saw you." She said sourly.

"Catra lost all of her memories, Mermista. She couldn't even remember her own name. There's no reason to be hostile." Bow defended.

"'No reason to be Hostile?' Are you joking right now? Think about it for a second. You let her into Brightmoon and she convinces you that she's lost all memories and now that you took her here, the

Horde's second in command shows up? You do realize how this looks right?" Mermista said, disbelief coloring her tone.

As everyone began to argue, Catra shrunk into herself a bit. Realizing that it does look bad when you put it in such a light. Before the argument could continue Shadow Weaver spoke up. "No, Bow is right, I can assure you of that."

"And why would I believe you?" Mermista said, rounding on the sorceress.

"Because any competent mage or princess should know what a soul shard is and what they do. Unless of course. . .I have held you to a standard that was not becoming of your position?" Shadow Weaver said slyly, emitting a soft chuckle.

Mermista paused at that, turning towards Catra. "You touched a soul shard? And you're not dead?"

Catra took a step back in shock, "What? Castaspella said they weren't lethal! What do you mean 'dead?'"

Bow stepped forwards, placing a hand on Catra's shoulder, "Now, now, I'm sure Mermista didn't mean it in that manner."

"Uh, yes I did. Anyone who can't do magic that has ever been affected by these things has died. Since you don't have magic, the crystals take the next best thing and that's your life force. And since you didn't use magic against me during the battle of Salineas, I can only assume you didn't have any." Mermista drawled out.

By this point, Perfuma, Sea Hawk, and Scorpia had turned to look at Catra. Catra was beginning to feel increasingly crowded. As she took another step back, Adora interjected.

"Everyone back off! We don't know the specifics of what happened to Catra beyond that she touched a shard," Adora turned her head towards Shadow Weaver and Scorpia, her voice becoming low, "And you. I know you're plotting something. From

now until the ball ends, I'll be watching. Wherever the two of you go, I go."

Shadow Weaver slightly tilted her head to the side before turning towards Catra, sighing, "I just wanted to make sure that Catra was alright. I was quite concerned when the explosion went off. She valiantly pulled me from the room, shielding me from the blast. When I came to, she was gone. I'm just glad to see you're alright Catra."

"Oh, please. I know you're planning on manipulating Catra into coming back, just like you tried to do to me at Mystacour." Adora said hotly.

"She's always been paranoid like this, you know." Shadow Weaver said to Catra, a chuckle on her lips. "But very well, if you insist. Oh but one more thing. Catra, you look beautiful in that suit. It really compliments you."

With that, Shadow Weaver walked off with Scorpia. Adora turned back towards the group. "We need to focus. I've never seen Shadow Weaver leave the Fright Zone. Whatever the Horde is planning here must be big."

"I agree, all reports regarding Shadow Weaver have explicitly detailed her never leaving the Fright Zone, or at least never straying too far from it." Netossa said with a determined look on her face.

Catra went to interject before being cut off by Bow, "Alright, Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Perfuma and I will trail Scorpia. Adora, you, Netossa, Spinnerella, and Glimmer will trail Shadow Weaver. Everyone got it?"

Everyone gave nods and sounds of affirmation. Bow gave a determined nod and everyone split up in their groups. Catra tried to speak up once more but everyone had left before she could get a word out.

"Oh yeah, just leave me all alone over here. Real fun dance." Catra muttered.

Letting out a sigh, Catra looked around at the party and took note of Entrapta on the balcony above, watching the event goers. Another look showed that Frosta had walked over towards the band.

'*Any competent mage or princess should know what a soul shard is and what they do.'* Shadow Weaver's voice rang in her head. Frosta seemed fairly serious for a princess, even if she was eleven. As she wandered towards her, she didn't miss how the guards tightened their grips on their spears.

"Keep those claws sheathed." One of the guards said to her as she strode past him towards Frosta. Catra gave a nervous gulp and a hasty nod before stepping forward.

"Princess Frosta, I wanted to–"

"Revered Hostess." Frosta said, cutting Catra off.

"I'm sorry?" Catra said, confused.

"When Princess Prom is to be hosted, all guests shall refer to the hostess of said prom as revered hostess. In this case, you are the guest and I am the hostess." Frosta explained matter-of-factly.

"Ah," Catra said, "I see. My apologies. . .Revered Hostess?"

Frosta nodded, "Appearance is important for all parties involved in such events. It's an easy mistake to make. Now you were saying something?"

Catra straightened herself and nodded, "Uh, yes, I wanted to ask you something."

"If this is about the princess alliance, I have already made my stance clear on the matter. I will not repeat myself." Frosta said with a hard tone.

"No no no, this has nothing to do with that. It's. . ." Catra paused, thinking of the best way to phrase her question, "I was made aware that you may have knowledge on soul shards?"

Frosta's brow furrowed a bit, "I know of them. Why do you want to know?"

"A couple weeks ago I came into contact with one. I've lost most of my memories. Any knowledge that you may have on the subject would be an immense help, Fros- er, Revered Hostess." Catra said, quickly correcting herself.

"I'm. . .sorry to hear that. Unfortunately, I can't offer much on the subject. My mother was the one who knew of such things. But I will offer any knowledge I have on the subject." Frosta turned towards her guards, "Go to my mother's study and bring me the book on shelf 43-b."

The guard nodded and turned to leave. Frosta turned back towards Catra and looked at her. Now understanding the teenager in front of her a bit more, Frosta felt a little awkward. Looking for any way to break the silence, Frosta spoke up.

"Sooo, how are you enjoying the dance?" Frosta asked, shifting in her seat slightly.

"Well, to be honest, I'm not really sure. According to Adora, this is the first party I've ever been to, so, it's definitely more. . .regal? It's not quite my thing." Catra answered honestly.

Frosta, having successfully changed the topic, raised an eyebrow, "It's understandable. Princess Prom can be a bit overwhelming at first. The etiquette and traditions to be followed is a lot to take in."

Catra gave a smile, "Yeah, but I'm not not enjoying myself. As far as parties go, you definitely threw a big one," Catra said looking around at the people.

Frosta let out a huff, "You have no idea. The guest list was killer. So many princesses needed an invite. Which, as you can see, was a lot. And that's not even half of them."

Catra gave a look of shock. "What? This isn't even half of them?"

Frosta let out a giggle at Catra's face, "No. More often than not, most princesses are busy with their kingdoms. I'd say this is only about a quarter of them."

"Huh, I was under the impression that the runestones were a big deal. Guess I was wrong if there's that many." Catra said.

"Oh no, you're right. They are. Not every princess has a runestone. In fact, there are only five runestones. Mine being the Fractal Flake of course. I heard there was a sixth one that was once the Crimson Waste, but that one's been gone forever." Frosta said slightly bragging.

"Can anyone have a runestone?" Catra asked interestedly.

"What do you mean by anyone?" Frosta asked.

"Like, if you had a brother. Would you have to share the runestone like Glimmer does with her mother?" Catra asked.

Frosta gave a smile, skating her head. "Nope. Only girls can form connections with the runestones. As for the sharing part, yes we do. I had to share it with my mother before. . ." Frosta lost her smile for a moment, before continuing, "Well, every princess shares their runestone with their mother until they choose to sever their connection."

It didn't escape Catra's notice of what Frosta had alluded to. Quickly thinking, Catra changed the topic fast. "Hm, on the topic of princesses, does the Revered Hostess dance or keep watch over the court."

Frosta's smile came back, "Oh, she dances. But not until the second dance of the night. Speaking of, I recommend you go find

your date. I will be announcing the dance shortly. Don't worry about the soul shard knowledge, I'll be sure to deliver it to you by the end of the night."

Catra gave a nod, "Alright. It was nice talking to you." Catra said walking off to go find Adora, before turning to look over her shoulder, "Oh and one more thing. Don't be so hard on yourself. Remember, this is still technically a party. Be sure to have fun."

Frosta thought about that as Catra walked off. She did realize that she was being a bit harsh, but it was to be expected. She was eleven and had worked hard to gain the respect of the other Princesses. She couldn't be seen acting her own age, no matter how much she wanted to go have fun. But maybe Catra was right. Maybe she was being a little uptight. Frosta let out a breath and stood up.

"It is my solemn duty as Hostess to now announce, it is time for the first dance of the Ball."

Scorpia wandered the dance floor, occasionally casting looks at Catra across the way. She was currently engaged in small talk with Frosta and by the looks of it they were having a fun talk, if Frosta's smile and laughter was anything to go off of. She hadn't known Catra for very long, only a month or two before she was caught in the explosion. But she had bravely risked her life for Shadow Weaver. It was a bit disheartening to hear that she did not remember her, but she hadn't lashed out or even gotten angry. That all but told her that somewhere deep down, Catra remembered her best friend Scorpia.

Suddenly Frosta stood up, "It is my solemn duty as Hostess to now announce, it is time for the first dance of the Ball."

Cheers erupted from the crowd and they all rushed to the center of the room with their dates. Scorpia made her way down as well, catching sight of Shadow Weaver ushering her over. As she gave a

smile she thought about what Shadow Weaver had said on the way here.

"*Everyone listen, when we get there follow the rules. We are not Horde envoys tonight. We are guests and must act as such." Shadow Weaver said.*

"*We aren't going to attack or anything?" Lonnie asked.*

"*No, we are not attacking. Our primary goal is to show Catra that we are not hostile. I have already seen how she reacts to those she does not know. The Rebellion already has their claws in her and she is priority number one." Shadow Weaver said. She didn't want to mention that once the magic in her mask ran out, she would be quite defenseless.*

"*Forgive me if this is out of turn, but. . .wasn't getting Adora back priority number one?" Kyle asked from the back of the group.*

"*Not anymore. Whatever the shard has done to Catra has changed her exponentially. She is the biggest asset to the Horde currently and at the moment is unsure of her position in the war. We must remind her that it is with us." Shadow Weaver explained.*

"*If we're supposed to be fighting the rebellion, how are we supposed to be non-hostile to her at the same time?" Lonnie asked.*

"*Let me worry about that, Cadet Lonnie."*

Scorpia was ecstatic that Shadow Weaver cared enough about Catra to want to save her. Even if she was quite scary and ominous. As she approached Shadow Weaver, she took the hand that was offered and fell into step with the music.

"Enjoying yourself, Scorpia?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"Oh yes, very much. Although, being followed is a bit tedious. They should have fun, Princess Prom only happens once in a decade." Scorpia said brightly.

"I'm glad you are enjoying the party. But do remember the plan." Shadow Weaver said smoothly as she spun Scorpia around, moving towards the next dancer.

As Shadow Weaver danced, she took the hand of the nearest dancer and twirled them, "Adora, how have you been?"

Adora's face was set in a glare, "Whatever you're planning won't work."

Shadow Weaver didn't miss a single step as she picked Adora up and slowly spun, "Adora, I'm not planning anything. But if I may ask something, do you think it proper etiquette to leave your plus one out of the dance." She said maliciously.

Adora looked around the dance floor and realized that Catra was indeed missing from the dance. Adora went to grab her before realizing she couldn't move at all, "Where is she?"

"My my, such anger. Take a moment to breathe. After all, fighting is prohibited by ancient laws of Princess Prom." Shadow Weaver said mockingly, her gem on her mask emitting a red glow.

"I swear if you've hurt her, I'll–"

"Oh, look at that, time to switch." Shadow Weaver said, spinning her to the next person.

Adora found she was able to move again. As she went to turn back towards Shadow Weaver, she felt her hand being taken. Turning back towards her new dance partner, she found herself face to face with Catra.

"You look pissed, Adora. What's going on?" Catra asked as she dipped Adora low.

"Where have you been?" Adora asked a bit harshly.

Catra gained a look of irritation, "Talking to Frosta. You all just left me standing in the middle of the dance floor to follow Shadow

Weaver and that Scorpia girl."

"I figured you would follow me. Shadow Weaver's up to something. She's after you Catra." Adora said as Catra pulled her in close.

"Can't you forget about them for, like, 5 minutes? Shadow Weaver hasn't approached me once and neither has Scorpia. Just have some fun." Catra said, spinning Adora away to trade partners once more.

Catra twirled away, a bit annoyed that Adora couldn't forget about the Horde for tonight. It wasn't like they arrived in combat gear. As she took the next hand, she realized that she had matched up with the forest witch herself, Perfuma.

"Catra, I want to apologize." Perfuma said, jumping into Catra's arms as she twirled. "If I had paid more attention, I would have realized that you needed medical attention. Instead I attacked you. For that, I'm sorry."

Catra, contrary to what she had been saying, wasn't really angry at the woman. To her defense, she had been wearing the Horde's insignia on her clothes when she had walked into the clearing. "It's fine."

Perfuma dipped Catra, "You're not mad at me? Bow was saying you thought I was mean for attacking you."

"No, I was just being sour. I don't think I know enough about anyone to actually hate them, not even the Horde." Catra said, raising a knee and spinning on one foot, Perfuma's arms wrapped around her.

"Oh good, I was quite worried. Bow says you're Adora's best friend so I was a little scared I made a bad impression." Perfuma said, pulling Catra in and wrapping her arms around her waist, Catra's hands resting on her shoulders.

"It's fine. It was just startling, being attacked so suddenly and not remembering how you got there." Catra said.

"Oh, on that note, here. I found one of these near Plumeria. From what I've read about soul shard victims, they might have a reaction upon coming into contact with new ones." Perfuma said, separating from Catra and holding out a glowing blue shard to her.

The music suddenly died down, "That concludes the first dance of the Ball. Please enjoy the food and drinks." Frosta's voice rang throughout the hall as servants came out and replaced the old food with a fresher variety.

Catra unsheathed her claws to their full length and reached out, carefully taking the shard with her claws, careful not to touch it with her skin. Catra examined it and undid her tie, wrapping it around the bright blue stone.

Turning back towards Perfuma, she gave her a nod, "Thank you. You don't know how much that means to me."

"If you don't mind me asking, what does it do?" Perfuma asked curiously.

"From what I've learned, just about anyone who's not a princess that touches these things gets affected in a negative way. But for some reason not me." Catra explained, pocketing the wrapped glowing shard.

"But didn't you lose your memories because of one of these things? How is that not a bad thing?" Perfuma asked.

"Yeah, I suppose that is bad. But, when I touched a second one I started to regain some memories and I can do magic now. I couldn't before." Catra said, somewhat excited.

Perfuma's mood matched Catra's optimism as well. As she went to speak up she was cut off by Shadow Weaver. "Princess Perfuma, would it be too much trouble to borrow Catra for a minute?"

Perfuma gulped nervously, a bit intimidated by the taller woman. "I suppose that's fine." She said somewhat shakily.

"Thank you, I'll only keep her for a moment." Shadow Weaver said in a polite tone. Perfuma gave a slight nod and turned.

Catra's sharp ears picked up Perfuma muttering to her about getting Adora. As she was left alone, Catra turned towards Shadow Weaver. "So, second in command, huh?"

"Yes, yes, I suppose that is something I may have failed to mention. On another note, how are you doing? We haven't been able to speak for almost three weeks now." Shadow Weaver said.

"Two." Catra said.

"I'm sorry?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"It's been about two weeks. 12 days to be precise." Catra said before her voice turned a bit softer, "I'm not really supposed to do any intensive labor or movement lest I trigger another episode. Castaspella's orders. So that kind of limits my choices of activities."

"Hmmm, Castaspella said that? I don't want to be that person, but Castaspella was never the best student when it came to her magical studies, at least not when I was teaching her. I would hope that after twenty five years she has improved at least a little bit." Shadow Weaver said walking towards the food table, Catra falling in stride beside her.

Catra's ears perked up at that, "You taught Castaspella magic?"

"Indeed I did. She was ahead of her peers for sure, but wasn't the most motivated, if you know what I mean. But, ah, yes. I was a teacher at Mystacour for many years. I was even on the council there. I trained many famous mages on Etheria." Shadow Weaver said, pouring two drinks.

"So she wasn't the best student?" Catra said, taking the offered cup from Shadow Weaver.

"Goodness no. Far from it actually. Whatever gave you that idea?" Shadow Weaver said with a small laugh that sounded a bit mocking.

"I just figured, seeing as how she's the head sorcerer at Mystacour." Catra said, glancing at the food with mild disgust. Salads and cakes were alright for the most part, just not so late in the evening.

"Hm, she is, is she? Good for her. It's always a good feeling when your students thrive in their studies." Shadow Weaver said.

"If she wasn't your best student, do you mind if I ask who was?" Catra asked curiously.

"Of course you can. Though it is a bit of a sore subject. Here, come take a seat and I'll tell you the story." Shadow Weaver said, gesturing towards some chairs off of the dance floor. Catra took note of the chairs placement somewhat resembling bleachers at a highschool dance.

As Catra and Shadow Weaver took a seat, Shadow Weaver made sure to position herself away from the crowd, hiding her from the view of anyone that may be. . .passing by.

"Ah, where to begin. I suppose I'll start with his name. I'm sure you are already familiar with him. King Micah?" Shadow Weaver said.

Catra's eyes widened. "Your best student was Glimmer's dad? But he was like, the head of the rebellion!"

Shadow Weaver chuckled, "Indeed he was. But nonetheless, I was his teacher."

Catra took note of the way her tone softened and the way she spoke with fondness, "Back then, he wasn't king. He was simply

Micah. Right from the moment I laid eyes on him, I knew he was going places. He passed every test with flying colors and certainly had no trouble with any of his classes. He would even take chances to outdo his teachers if he could. Micah had a drive that was very similar to my own. He wanted to understand anything and everything about magic.

"Throughout his first years at Mystacour I did not teach him specifically. I believe it was sometime in the middle of his third year there that he came to me. I initially believed Micah lacked dedication. I needed assistance with something and Micah proved me wrong. He demonstrated a level of skill and power that I had never seen before." Shadow Weaver recounted, "That is, until you."

"Me? But I've never performed any magic beyond switching. And. . .and I can't even really call that magic. How do you know that I can even measure up?" Catra said, slightly flustered.

"Catra," Shadow Weaver said softly, laying a hand on her shoulder, "I've taught magic for years. I know potential when I see it. Trust me, you have the power necessary to surpass Micah, to surpass even me."

Catra smiled at that, "So what happened next?"

Shadow Weaver's tone changed as she hung her head in regret. "I made a mistake. Back then, the Horde did not hold the militant power it does today. I was aware of the threat the Horde posed to Etheria and had tried to warn the rest of the council of sorcerers of Mystacour. . . They didn't listen to me." She paused for a moment, "And I didn't listen to them."

"What do you mean by that?" Catra asked with a low voice.

Shadow Weaver let out a sigh. "I had proposed a solution to fight the Horde. A spell. It would have given us the power to strike back against the Horde and finally end the conflict that the princesses had failed against. In all honesty, they were right about

the spell. It was a mistake to ever consider using it. But I was young and thought I had all the answers. I wanted to defend my planet, my people. So that night, I asked Micah to assist me. We gathered the materials to perform the spell. It failed."

"What was it supposed to do?" Catra asked as she hung onto every word she was hearing.

"It was called the Spell of Obtainment. It was supposed to increase our power output exponentially. Unfortunately, I miscalculated. See, the original spell, when cast, would turn the caster into a magical parasite, leeching off the magic in and around their bodies. If it didn't kill you first. But I was assured of my success with the three moons being in alignment, that it would succeed."

"But it didn't work, did it?" Catra said quietly. Somewhere in the background, Catra heard Frosta announce the second dance would be commencing soon.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. "No. It didn't. It consumed my very being, but in doing so granted me power beyond what I had been capable of at the time. But like all dark magic, there was a price. I lost the ability to perform magic without an outside source."

"Wh-Why would you cast that spell? If the Horde wasn't that strong yet, what drove you to risk that?" Catra said appalled at what she was hearing.

"The Horde had captured the Black Garnet, one of the six runestones. At the time, no one was aware that the Horde couldn't utilize the runestones without a princess or a mage. One runestone is capable of immense destruction and the Horde had acquired one. It was a scary thought at the time." Shadow Weaver said, turning away from Catra and taking a sip of her drink.

Catra looked to the side, her brows furrowed in thought, before turning back to Shadow Weaver, "But that doesn't answer my biggest question."

"You wish to know why I joined the Horde, right?" Shadow Weaver said, as if it was obvious.

"Well. . .yeah, actually. Joining the Horde doesn't make any sense." Catra said.

"Think about it for a moment Catra. Think about everything I've told you and piece it together. You're a smart girl." Shadow Weaver cooed.

Catra thought about everything she had just heard and thought about it for a minute. Suddenly it came to her. "You said the spell leeches the magic out of the caster's body, right? What happens if someone runs out of magic?"

"They die." Shadow Weaver said simply, swirling her drink.

"You're using the Black Garnet as a lifeline." Catra whispered, everything suddenly clicking in her mind.

Shadow Weaver nodded. Catra looked at her, "But there has to be something you can do. Some way you can undo the damage that it did."

"I have tried everything Catra. This is permanent. No amount of magic or science can undo what was done to me."

"But–"

"Stay away from her!" Adora exclaimed, cutting Catra off.

"Adora, it's fine. We were just talking." Catra said standing up.

"It's not fine. She's trying to get in your head. The fact that she deliberately hid is proof enough." Adora said with a glare.

Shadow Weaver let out a sigh before slowly standing. "I suppose that concludes our conversation. Very well Adora, I will leave Catra alone. You have my word."

"Your word isn't worth shit." Adora said through gritted teeth, fury apparent in her eyes.

"Mind your mouth Adora. I know I taught you better than that." Shadow Weaver said while walking away. Catra didn't miss the slight undertone of anger in Shadow Weaver's words.

As Shadow Weaver walked into the crowd and vanished from view, Adora whirled on Catra. "What the hell are you doing!" She snapped.

Catra flinched back at the sharp tone before standing straighter and narrowing her eyes. "I was talking. That's it. What is your problem?"

"My problem?" Adora said incredulously.

"Yes, *your* problem?" Catra hissed.

"What's *your* problem?" Adora countered, "I literally said not to go near Shadow Weaver. Don't talk to her, she is trying to manipulate you. And what do you do? The exact thing I said not to do!"

"So what! She wasn't insulting on me, she wasn't manipulating me, and she sure as hell wasn't attacking me either. All she was doing was telling a story. That's all!" Catra spat.

Their argument wasn't unnoticed. Catra's ears picked up several murmurs and whispers asking about them to other guests. Catra whipped her head at several patrons, glaring, causing them to look the other way.

"And another thing–"

"Shut up." Catra uttered quietly through gritted teeth as she grabbed Adora's arm tightly, dragging her towards one of the

exits..

Adora stopped talking, glancing around at everyone in the hall. Taking note of the stares, Adora fell into stride with Catra as they exited the dance floor. As they exited the castle, Adora pulled her arm free from Catra's grip. This had the unfortunate consequences of Catra's claws cutting into Adora's arm.

Adora hissed in pain as she took note of the blood rolling down her arm. Catra's hostility was immediately replaced with concern. "I'm sorry. Are you okay?" Catra asked worriedly.

"Yeah, I'm fine. It wasn't deep." Adora assured.

Catra looked at the blood on her claws before grimacing. Taking off her jacket, she quickly cut a strip off, wrapping it around the wound with an almost practiced ease. As Catra finished bandaging her arm, she didn't miss how her gaze lingered on her claws.

"Hey, it was an accident. It's not the first time. Don't beat yourself up over it." Adora soothed.

Catra stayed quiet for a moment before her shoulders slumped. Turning away from Adora, she stared out at the beauty of the Kingdom of Snows. She stayed silent, not sure of what to say. Adora put a comforting hand on her shoulder.

"Catra. . .I'm not. . .I just. . ." Adora let out a defeated sigh, her hand falling to her side.

As they sat there for several minutes in uncomfortable silence, Catra looked up at the sky. She found herself upset by the lack of stars once again, but was taken in by the auroras cascading and dancing through the night sky.

As Adora watched the sky beside her, the silence slowly turned into a semi-comfortable one. For an hour they sat there in one another's company. The only sounds to be heard was the occasional chatter that drifted towards them from the castle.

"Can you tell me the truth?" Catra asked quietly, breaking the silence.

"About what?" Adora turned to face Catra.

"We haven't been able to be alone since I first woke up in the castle. No one is around. So. . .explain it to me Adora. Shadow Weaver, The Horde, All of it. You tell me it was horrible and bad and that-that there's nothing redeeming about anyone there." Catra paused before saying in a shaky breath,. "Why did you leave. . .why did I stay? I want the truth, Adora."

Adora sat quietly, thinking about how to even begin to tell her. Adora turned and looked at the sky, "When we were about seven years old, we were playing. At some point, we stumbled upon Shadow Weaver's room. The Black Garnet Chamber. We were kids, so naturally we wanted to see what was in there since it was off limits. Well, as we explored the room, Shadow Weaver stumbled in and we hid." Adora pressed on as Catra listened intently.

"Well, we saw Shadow Weaver's face. Realizing we'd been caught, we went to run out of the room only for Shadow Weaver to grab hold of you with magic. She didn't grab me, non only you. Then she said something that I will never forget. She threatened to dispose of you herself if you ever dragged me down. That you were a nuisance and that the only reason you were kept around was because you were my friend."

Catra stayed silent at that, remembering something she had thought Angella had said to her. *"But I will not allow you to drag Adora down as well. You have never been more than a nuisance to me. I have kept you around this long because Adora was fond of you. But if you ever do anything to jeopardize her future, I will dispose of you myself."*

"You remember?" Adora said, turning to look at her.

Catra realized she had muttered it out loud. "I thought Angella had said that to me when I was having that seizure."

"Angella would never say something like that. Catra, that's not a one time thing. Shadow Weaver treated you like that every day. I'm not trying to control who you talk with, but please believe me." Adora pleaded, "Shadow Weaver is lying to you. She only is taking an interest in you because you have something she wants."

Catra didn't say anything for a minute, mulling over what she had heard just now. Feeling the shard in her pocket, Catra grit her teeth, angry tears stinging the corners of her eyes, 'Why is this happening to me?' she thought to herself.

Adora went to ask if she was okay before Catra enveloped her in a hug. Adora felt the tension fade from her body. As Adora returned the hug, they stood there for what felt like forever, everything else forgotten at the moment. Eventually Adora pulled away to look at Catra.

"Are you okay?"

"Yeah," Catra nodded as she wiped her eyes. "Let's go find Bow and Glimmer and see if we can get Frosta to help us out. I think I'm about done with this dance."

Adora gave a smile and nodded. As they began walking towards the castle, Catra caught sight of something small out of the corner of her eye. Turning, she narrowed her eyes, searching for any sign of movement.

Adora noticed that Catra was no longer following her. Halting her stride, she turned back towards Catra, "What's wrong? Why'd you stop?"

"I don't know. I just. . .thought I saw something." Catra said slowly. As her eyes swept across the palace grounds, she noticed just how alone they were out here. Exposed. Catra felt a chill run up her spine. It was then that she noticed something. The music had stopped. Something was wrong.

"Do you hear that?" Catra asked Adora, never taking her eyes off of the grounds.

"I don't hear anything." Adora said, stepping back towards Catra as she raised her guard. She'd learned to trust Catra's instincts at a young age.

"Exactly. The music is gone. And I can't hear anyone. Like, at all." Catra said as she unsheathed her claws. "Let's hurry back inside. I don't like where we're at."

Adora gave a nod. As they walked up to the entrance, Catra went up to a trio of guards near the doors, "Why did the music stop?"

"Temporary malfunction of the sound system. Don't worry about it. We already have someone fixing it right now. Please go back and enjoy the ball." The only female guard among the group spoke up. Her tone was unusually tense. Catra gave a slight nod.

"Right. If that's all." Catra said hesitantly.

"It is. Go back and enjoy the ball." The woman repeated in a much harsher tone. Catra and Adora hurried inside, sidestepping the woman. As they walked through the halls, Catra took notice of the increasing number of guards in the halls. She was on edge as they walked through the corridor.

"Were there this many guards earlier?" Catra asked Adora under her breath.

"No, not even close. I think something's going on. Princess Frosta might be in trouble." Adora muttered back.

As they neared the main hall's doors, the music turned back on, although that did little to alleviate the tension. Upon entering the hall, Adora noticed Glimmer standing beside the rest of the Alliance, barring Entrapta who was still on the balcony.

Walking up to Glimmer, Adora began talking in a hushed tone, "Something's wrong."

"What's going on?" Glimmer asked.

"I don't know, but stay alert. We think Frosta might be in trouble." Adora warned.

"Where's Bow?" Catra asked sharply.

"He's. . ." Glimmer and Perfuma looked around, "I don't know." Glimmer said worriedly.

"Where was he last?"

"He was following Scorpia." Perfuma said. The group looked at one another warily. Their moods must have been noticed because a tension was being formed on the dance floor among the other princesses.

"Adora, go warn Frosta. I'm going to go find Bow." Catra said quickly before rushing off through one of the halls. Adora gave a nod, walking up to where Frosta was currently sitting.

Mermista glanced towards Perfuma and Glimmer, "Scorpia and Shadow Weaver haven't left the dance floor once."

At that everyone's gaze turned towards Shadow Weaver and Scorpia who were sitting at the other end of the floor.

As Catra raced through the halls, looking for any sign of Bow, she quickly came upon three Horde soldiers cornering a lone figure. Quickly realizing it was Bow, she swiftly grabbed the smallest one in a choke hold, her claws extended and primed at his neck.

"Catra, wait!" Bow called as the other two guards let out cries of shock.

As Catra took in the appearances of the two soldiers in front of her. "Lonnie?"

"Woah, easy Catra. We weren't doing anything to anyone!" The soldier she was currently restraining called in fear. Looking down at him, she realized that it was Kyle.

"Kyle?" Catra continued confused, letting him out of her grip.

"You remember us? That's great." Kyle said happily as he stood up straight, dusting himself off.

"No, actually. Not really. Just bits and pieces and whatever I've learned from Adora and Shadow Weaver."

Bow stepped forward, making a calming gesture, "Fighting's prohibited at the Princess Ball. Right now, we're all on neutral territory. We were just talking, Catra. No reason to get hostile."

"Yeah, Bow was just telling us that you were okay." Kyle said, stepping forward, "We were all really worried about you. Especially after that explosion and you disappearing and all. We all thought the worst."

"Oh, um, yeah. I'm alright." Catra said awkwardly. She had been looking forward to talking with these three and she had just held one of them hostage. "Sorry about the choking thing. I didn't know it was you guys."

Lonnie stepped forward, disbelief in her tone, "Catra, did you just apologize? To Kyle?"

"I take it I don't do that often?"

"How about never. Guess you really did lose your memories. Either way, I'm just glad to see you're alright." Lonnie continued.

"So Adora mentioned us?" Kyle asked.

"Uh. . .yeah," Catra said awkwardly before turning towards Bow, "Hey, everyone's looking for you. Something's–"

Catra whipped her head to the balcony above them, catching the movement again. Everyone's gazes followed hers as she had abruptly stopped talking.

"What's the matter?" Bow asked cautiously.

"That's twice I've seen it now. I'm alerting Frosta." Catra said, sharply turning towards the door and briskly walking back.

"Seen what?" Lonnie asked. Catra ignored her and continued forward.

Bow looked at them, shrugging, before giving chase to Catra. Lonnie let out a groan before following them with Kyle and Rojelio. As they caught up to Catra, the ground shook as the sound of explosions echoed through the halls.

"Revered Hostess, I have reason to suspect you're in danger." Adora announced as she stepped forward. Gasps of shock sounded from the crowd.

Frosta narrowed her eyes, "What cause do you have to suspect such a thing? I do hope you're not referring to Scorpia and her plus one."

Adora shook her head, "Catra and I saw movement on the terrace outside. We were unsure of what it was. We felt it appropriate to warn you."

Frosta gave a look of exasperation, "You saw. . .movement. That's what you're concerned about. I assure you, nothing can climb that terrace."

"But–"

"And while I thank you for your concern, I am quite sure nothing is out there."

"But it could–"

"If that is all, please go back to the ball." Frosta said, trying to keep the bit out of her tone.

As Adora went to speak, whatever words she was about to say died on her lips as she caught sight of a small bat winged creature with a demon-like tail above the throne. As it let out a chittering laugh, Adora's blood ran cold as she went to shout a warning.

"Frosta, look–"

Suddenly, red explosions rocked the castle. The icicles began to fall as the icy walls started to crack. The throne room was thrown into disarray as the people ran for cover in fright. Adora was thrown off her feet as a pillar of ice collapsed on top of her. Finding herself pinned, she instinctively went to grab her sword only to realize it was with the rest of the weapons at the entrance.

As she struggled to even budge the large block of ice, she noticed that the roof had crumbled and was about to crush her. If she didn't free herself immediately, she would most definitely be killed. Unfortunately, Adora couldn't get the leverage necessary to free herself with only one arm. As the large chunks of ice raced towards her, Adora lifted her arm to shield herself in any way she could. But the impact never came. Cracking an eye open, she found that the ice was levitating in the air. The pillar that had pinned her was suddenly lifted off of her, encased in a smoky red crackling aura. Looking up, she found that her unlikely savior was none other than Shadow Weaver.

"Adora, move!" Shadow Weaver said with a strained voice as the ice slowly began to descend. Adora quickly kicked off of the ground, rolling out of the way as she suddenly dropped the ice.

Adora stood up and for the first time took notice of Shadow Weaver's appearance. She was breathing heavily and her body was slightly shaking as if moving was a physical challenge.

"Why did you save me?" Adora questioned suspiciously.

"This," Shadow Weaver paused to take a breath, "wasn't me. I don't know what's going on."

Before Adora could get another word out, Catra, Bow, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio came bursting into the throne room. Bow took the lead as he ran up to Adora. "Adora, what's going on?"

"I don't know. Where's Mermista and the others?"

"Fear not. We are unscathed." Sea Hawk said as he approached with Glimmer and the rest of the alliance in tow. "Do we have any idea what has caused this?" Shadow Weaver asked aloud, voicing everyone's thoughts.

Shadow Weaver spoke up, looking a little less exerted, "It wasn't us. Whoever is doing this wasn't us."

Suddenly Scorpia ran up to the group to stand beside Lonnie and Kyle. "Is everyone okay?"

"Yeah, Scorpia, we're fine. Did you see what could have caused this?" Kyle asked.

Scorpia shook her head, "No, I haven't left the dance floor once." She turned towards Glimmer and Bow, "I know we're enemies and all, but I promise, we didn't do whatever caused this."

Adora turned towards Frosta, "Are you alright?"

Frosta gave a brief nod before turning to the guards, "Stay with them and protect the guests. You two, follow me to the Fractal Flake's chamber." She commanded as they turned and left the room. The few guards stayed beside them, circling around the group to protect them.

As the group began to talk over one another, Catra took a few steps away and ignored them. Catra tuned them out as she took a deep breath and focused on her hearing. As the noise around her began to diminish, she listened intently, focusing on her surroundings. Whatever she had seen earlier was most likely the

culprit. She extended her senses, smelling the air, looking for anything that may have been out of place.

Behind her, she became vaguely aware of a voice calling her name. Ignoring it in favor of the smells, she inhaled. There. . . the smell of oil and metal. It was faint but it was unmistakable. She doubted anyone else could smell it but that didn't matter. Catra walked further away from the group, following her nose. The scent was coming from above her.

As everyone looked to where Catra had zoned in on, Glimmer narrowed her eyes and teleported to the scaffolding. As she appeared, she immediately recoiled. "Ahh! What is that thing?"

The sound of chittering echoed through the halls as the small creature sailed over their heads. Adora narrowed her eyes, "I thought you said this wasn't your doing. That's Hordak's little pet." She said as she rounded on Shadow Weaver and Scorpia.

"And I'm telling the truth." Shadow Weaver turned towards the Imp, "What's going on? Why are you here?"

The Imp only laughed in response as it landed on one of the guards spears. Immediately, the royal Ice guard discarded their cloaks, giving way to their gray and green armor bearing the Horde insignia.

Catra found herself isolated from the group and surrounded by soldiers, shock batons in hand.

Shadow Weaver rose above the soldiers, her hair floating around her as if alive, "What is the meaning of this!"

A dark chuckle emanated from the hallway as a figure stepped into the light. She was a tall woman donning a red eyepatch with a Horde symbol engraved into it. Her aquatic features were quite apparent with tentacles flowing down her back. In her right hand she held an unconscious Frosta and a shock baton in the other. One of the Horde soldiers was also holding everyone's weapons, including the sword..

"Sorry Shadow Weaver. But the Boss's orders outweigh I'm more afraid of him then I am of you." The woman said nonchalantly.

"Octavia! What have you done to Frosta?" Adora shouted.

"The brat's fine," Octavia said, dropping Frosta onto the floor as several guards aimed their weapons at her unconscious form, "In fact, everyone here will be fine if you all do what I say. Lonnie, Kyle, Rojelio, Scorpia, Shadow Weaver, I suggest you come over here. New orders and all that."

"You are beneath me. You can't just–" Shadow Weaver started before being interrupted.

"*Disregard anything Shadow Weaver says. During this mission, nobody but me holds more command than you. If Shadow Weaver has an issue with that, don't be afraid to mention what I have given her. And that I can take it away.*" Hordak's dark voice came out of Imp's mouth as he let out a snide little laugh.

Octavia gave a smug grin, "Oh but I can. So unless you are all suddenly defecting. I suggest you get over here."

Lonnie and Kyle glanced at everyone around them before Lonnie walked over and stood beside Octavia. "Lonnie, you can't be serious? This is wrong. We were invited on neutral ground."

"Yeah? Well tough shit. Now get over here. Party's over." Lonnie said unhappy with the sudden turn of events.

Kyle looked at Shadow Weaver and Scorpia, "Are we really going to do this? I thought the whole point of this was to talk to Catra and help her get her memories back, not ambush the alliance."

"Yeah, I'm kind of uncomfortable with this." Scorpia said. Everyone was looking at Shadow Weaver, waiting for her response, Unsure of what to do.

"Oh, you'll be able to talk to Catra." Octavia said as she walked up to Catra, "She's the only reason we're here."

"Why me?" Catra said, careful not to make any sudden movements, lest she be zapped.

Octavia eyed her up and down, noticing how Catra looked at her with no recognition. Octavia let out a mirthful chuckle, before suddenly letting out a vicious blow into Catra's stomach.

"Catra!" Adora cried as she watched her crumple from the blow, the air driven out of her lungs.

"Oh it's been so long Catra. I guess it's true what everyone's saying. You really don't have your memories, otherwise you would have known not to get near me." Octavia gloated above her as she struggled to breathe.

Octavia rounded on Adora, "See, the thing is. You're not top priority anymore. Your friend over here is. Her and those shards. You left of your own choice Adora. But you've been getting into Catra's head. Trying to keep her from remembering why she wanted to hurt you in the first place. But Lord Hordak thinks he can bring back all of Catra's memories in one fell swoop.

"So when he does, and she remembers which side she's supposed to be fighting for. . .well, then you can be important again. As for now though," Octavia said, tossing Adora her sword before turning towards the soldiers surrounding Frosta, "If she so much as makes a move, kill the little girl."

Catra slowly got to her feet, finally able to breathe again, anger present on her face, "I will never help you. You think that I'd help a bunch of assholes threatening to kill some little girl?"

Octavia gave a cruel grin as she walked up to her, the shock baton illuminating her face, "So she hasn't told you?"

"Told me what?" She asked slowly. Her head was beginning to pulse with a familiar pain. The lights also seemed brighter.

"About the day you left? Catra, you're not just any force captain. You're in charge of everyone except Shadow Weaver and Hordak.

The day Adora left, you led a raid into a tiny little village called Thaymor. You killed and slaughtered half that village. Would probably have been more if Adora and her dumb little rebellion friends hadn't stopped you."

"*How could you possibly be okay with that?" Adora said*

"*Because it doesn't matter what they do. The two of us look out for each other. And soon we'll be the one calling the shots.*

Catra held her head, clenching her eyes closed as the pain began to worsen.

"You've always been that way Catra. You even clawed my eye out when you were six. But don't worry. I'll help you get your memories back. We all will." Octavia said as she stepped forward.

Pain erupted from Catra's body as she let loose a scream of pain. Electricity crackled along her body as she fell to the floor. As Catra turned, trying to crawl away from the source of the pain with no success, her vision started to darken. As she lost consciousness, she looked at Octavia, only to see herself with a dark sneer.

"*When did you get so weak"*

Chapter 8

Catra

wake up

WAKE UP

Catra's eyes shot open as she sat up with a gasp. She frantically got to her feet, searching for any sign of Octavia. After a few seconds of relative silence, she let out a breath.

Catra scanned her surroundings, seeing a familiar landscape. She realized that she was back on the path in front of the stone arch. She could see her reflection in the portal. "Getting real sick of waking up in different places." She muttered.

Walking towards the portal, she reached out to touch it. Unlike last time, she wasn't able to stick her hand through the wall of water. "Huh," she muttered, "maybe if I–"

Catra immediately recoiled as pain shot through her body. Taking a step away from the mirror, the pain immediately vanished. Shaking her arm, Catra growled in annoyance.

Taking a step back she decided to look around the area, hoping to find some answers. As Catra was about to give up, she noticed a flicker of motion off to the side. Walking towards the area showed a pile of large broken rocks. Walking up to it, she found that the pieces all fit together in some shape or form. As she leaned down to pick up one of the rocks, she felt a heat emanating from her pocket.

Reaching into her pocket, she carefully pulled out the shard. It was still wrapped in her tie thankfully. Unwrapping the shard, she found it was emitting a low hum and a slight glow. Suddenly, the rubble in front of her started to shake. Catra stumbled back, dropping the shard as she struggled to regain her footing.

To her astonishment, the shard hovered above the rubble as the rocks reformed, almost as if they were. . .rewinding. Catra watched as the last of the rocks reformed into a shape. As it finished she found herself looking at what looked like an oversized bird bath. Suddenly the stone stopped glowing and fell to the ground as all movement ceased.

"Is that it?" Catra mumbled, leaning down to pick up the before, the glow had vanished. Throwing caution to the wind, Catra picked the shard up and rolled it around in her hand. Nothing. "Well, that was anticlimactic."

Walking up to the now reformed object, she noticed that it was filling with water. As she went to touch it, she found that it was solid like glass. Catra gave a low hum of intrigue, fascinated with the strange water. After a moment, the strange fountain was completely filled. Catra peered into it and found that it was similar to the strange portal in that she could see her reflection.

"It's a fountain of perspective, in case you were wondering."

Catra immediately whipped around at the voice, claws bared. In front of her, stood the wispy figure she had seen in her dreams. Catra could make out more details about her appearance now though. The woman's face seemed familiar but she couldn't place it. She seemed to be around Angella's age and wore a red dress resembling a cuirass with golden highlights. The most striking feature was the blue gem that resided on the upper left of her chest which may have held a cape at one point. Atop her head sat a golden crown with a smaller blue gem. But something was off about her, like pieces were missing from her. Her outline was constantly shifting like smoke.

"It's. . .you. You're the woman from my dreams? The one who's been talking to me?"

The woman gave a nod. "Yes."

"What do you want?" Catra asked with some hostility.

"I. . .I need your help." She said quietly.

"Yeah? It sure seems that everyone needs that these days." Catra spat before narrowing her eyes. "What do you need my help for?"

"I. . .It's complicated. But I'll get straight to the point. The shards. I need you to collect them and put them together."

"Why?"

"Just like you, they hold my memories as well. . . Or rather my soul." The woman said softly.

Catra looked off to the side, thoughts about her knowledge of Earth and the hazy dreams about the man named Eric that she had gained. "Are you an astronaut?" She asked suspiciously.

"What?" The woman asked dumbfounded. Confused at the sudden turn the conversation had steered towards.

"I said 'are you an astronaut?' Are you from Washington D.C.?" Catra asked. The woman's face confirmed what Catra was thinking.

"How. . .how do you know that?" She asked with confusion and. . .hope?

"Ever since I woke up, I've had these memories of Earth. Dreams of places that I now know that I've never been to. Places like New York and Washington. I also know things that I have been told I shouldn't know. Mainly sciency things. I'm now of the assumption that these are your memories." Catra asked cautiously.

"Yes! Yes, I'm from Earth." She said excitedly before her face fell, "But. . .It's broken. I can't remember because there's nothing to remember. That's why I need your help. Surely you can understand what I'm going through?"

Catra thought about what she was hearing, weighing her options. She could ignore the woman. She had already been informed by

Castaspella that she would regain her memories naturally. On the other hand, Catra knew what it was like. Forgetting your whole identity, not knowing yourself or your life. Feeling like a part of you had been stolen. The only difference was that this woman had no way of getting herself back. Losing your soul and losing your memories seemed a little bit different in Catra's opinion.

After a moment of silence, Catra gave a sigh before looking at the woman with a steely look. "Fine, I'll help. But I want you to listen to me. This," Catra motioned towards the landscape, "I want answers. No lying, no bullshit, none of it. If you fuck around with me, I'm gone. I've just about had it with this whole thing. Are we clear?"

At that the woman gave a thankful smile and a nod, "Of course. I understand completely. I'll answer whatever questions you have to the best of my ability. I swear."

Catra gave a slow nod, putting her hands down and letting her claws retract, "Alright then. Let's start with an easy one. What's your name?"

The woman gave a sheepish smile, "Ah…"

". . . You don't remember it do you?"

"No, sorry. Maybe I can answer a different question?" She said, rubbing the back of her head.

"Alright, um, what is this place?"

"Oh, I'm surprised you haven't figured that out yet."

Catra raised an eyebrow, "What's that supposed to mean?"

"Catra, we're in your head. This is your mindscape. It's obvious." She explained.

"How is that obvious? I literally would have never guessed that." Catra exclaimed.

"Why not? Any time someone's affected by these shards they would've figured it out in a couple hours. Why didn't you?" She asked, genuinely confused.

"How would anyone deduce that?" Catra asked dumbfounded.

"Well, it's your home. The place most familiar to you." She said before glancing around, "Dreadful place, no offense."

Catra looked at the beautiful landscape and gorgeous sky dotted with clouds and birds. "If this is dreadful, then I wanna see where on Earth you grew up."

"From what I can piece together, I grew up somewhere in the midwest. Lots of trees and mountains. Don't get me wrong, Industrialization has a beauty unto itself, but I prefer nature." She said, taking a seat on a nearby rock.

Catra frowned, "What are you talking about? We're literally surrounded by nature."

The woman gave a puzzled look, "Catra, we are sitting in a factory. Your mindscape looks like a military outpost. What are you seeing right now?"

"Grass. Trees. Mountains. We are surrounded by nature right now. You can't see any of this?" Catra said, an uncomfortable feeling settling on her chest.

The woman shook her head, "Catra, I can't see any of that. I'm standing on a scaffolding overlooking a very dystopian-esque city with a smog filled sky and bright red moon."

Catra looked back at the fountain, "But you can see that?"

"Yes, but now I feel like what we are seeing might be quite different. What's it look like to you?"

"It looks like a fancy stone bird bath that's filled with clean clear water."

She gave a hum, "I see a dark red cauldron that's filled with a purple swirling liquid. Tell me, does it have a glowing symbol around it? It should be roughly the same shade of blue as the shards."

Catra ducked down to view under it and found the glowing symbol. "Yep. Why?"

"That signifies it as the fountain of perspective. But it shouldn't be clear. It's supposed to be murky."

"Why? Is it bad if it is?" Catra asked cautiously.

She shook her head, "No. In fact that's a good thing. It means that your memories are returning at a steady rate. But it should still be cloudy at the very least. You're sure it's clear?"

"Yeah, I can see right through it. I can somewhat see my reflection as well. Wait, can you see the portal?" She asked as she turned towards her.

"What portal?" She asked, standing up.

"It's like a wall of mirrored water. I've walked through it once already." Catra said, pointing at it.

The woman let out a gasp, "You did what?"

"What?" Catra asked in bewilderment.

"Catra, this is your mind! You aren't supposed to be able to leave it. Where did you go?" She asked in a panicked voice.

"Calm down. Nothing bad happened. In fact, good things happened. If I hadn't gone through it, I would never have met Mara."

"You met Mara?" She asked in a quiet voice.

"Yeah. Is. . .that a big deal?" She questioned, concerned.

The woman stayed silent for a moment before looking at Catra, "Explain. Please, in full detail, explain what you did before you met Mara."

Catra stared at the woman for a long moment, keeping her emotions schooled. In all honesty, she was quite fearful. Her mind was all over the place and she didn't know what she should do. So Catra took a seat and quickly ran through the events of her first encounter of the stone path, the portal, her meeting with Mara, and how she had learned to utilize the portal to switch. The woman stayed quiet through it all before rubbing her eyes.

"You're. . . reflection moved? And it grabbed you and gave you a shard?"

"Yeah, that's pretty much what happened. But how do you know Mara?"

The woman let out a breath of frustration, "I can't remember. I know she's She Ra and that's supposed to be the reason that the shards forged a connection between you and I."

"What do you mean? What does her being She Ra have to do with it?" Catra asked, her interest piqued.

"Well. . . she loves you. Or rather she's supposed to. You're the closest person to her. The most important thing in her life. That bond is what allows the shards to interact with you."

At every word she said, Catra's blush grew. She knew for a fact that it wasn't Mara who was feeling that way about her. "Can you please stop talking?" she asked, embarrassment written all over her.

The woman paused before a sly grin grew on her face, "Why?"

"Just shush. First off, I've only known Mara for a couple weeks now. Besides, you're probably remembering it wrong on account of our memory problems."

"Mmm Yeah-No, no I don't think I am. In fact, that's one of the few things I remember quite clearly." She said with a smirk.

Catra held a hand up, "Second of all," she said, quickly changing the subject, "Is there any way that you can interact with anyone else, or is it just me?"

She sat back, focusing on the question, "As of right now, no. I would imagine as my soul is pieced back together, I could. . .project myself to others. Currently, the only time someone can see me is when you're fusing the shards. I have a small window to speak to people. In fact I've already spoken to somebody."

"Who? And when?"

"When you were first examining the shard. You should have felt really happy, giddy even." She explained. At that, Catra gained a look of realization and nodded.

"Well, during that time, a tall woman with wings spoke to me. Judging by the fact that the magic did not affect her, I can only assume it was one the queens of Etheria. At least one with a connection to a runestone."

"Ah, you met Angella. Yeah, she's connected to the moonstone. She's the queen of Brightmoon. She's been helping me a lot lately." Catra said with a smile.

"It sounds like you hold her in high regard." She said smiling.

Catra gave a nod. "I do. In all honesty, I'd probably be dead if not for her. She initially wanted to throw me in a cell." Catra chuckled.

"With how protective of you she was when I spoke to her, I find that hard to believe. But, yeah, Queen of Brightmoon fits the description. Although the Queen of Brightmoon that I know is a bit different to this Angella." She said with a small smile.

"You remember Brightmoon?" Catra asked.

"Bits and pieces. The scenery is a little foggy and the moonstone's appearance is all but gone from my mind. But the Queen, the Queen I remember. She is quite kind and like yours can fly as well, although she doesn't have wings. She rides waves of light, kind of like a surfer rides a wave of water."

"Well, while we're on the topic, can we fuse this one right now?" Catra asked, holding the shard up.

She shook her head, "See how it lost its glow?" Catra gave a nod, "Well, that means that whatever magic that was present in it is now lost. Without a charge you have to do it physically. For instance, if you were to hand me it right now I *might* get a memory back. Emphasis on might. It would basically be a flashback, nothing I could make sense of. Get where I'm going with this?"

"I think I got it." Catra said, putting it back in her pocket.

The woman let out a breath of exasperation after a moment, "So. . .Adora's She Ra? In your time I mean?"

The atmosphere had shifted to a somber mood, "Yeah? Why?"

"I. . ." She let out a huff, "It's hard to explain. Something about that bothers me. It makes me feel. . .different, I suppose and I don't know why."

"Ha, join the club. I've been feeling that way since I woke up." Catra said as she laid down on the soft grass. "But chances are you probably know her somehow. Maybe because of Shadow Weaver? I heard she was messing with the shards before I lost my memories and she practically raised us from what I've been told."

The woman gave a shrug before laying down as well, "Maybe, maybe not. I'm sure we'll figure it out in due time."

As they laid there for a few minutes in relative silence, several questions floated around in Catra's mind. "So, if I'm gonna help

you get our memories back, I need to know how many shards there are. Because Mara said she had some of these things in a vault."

"Ah, she's probably referring to the material that it's made of. That's not super hard to find, the shards themselves will be a bit trickier. There's only nine of them left. When you hold a shard to the sky, it should emit a soft warm hum and glow. She Ra should be able to interact with the shards with her sword. If done correctly, it'll be much more accurate than using the shards."

"What do you mean by more accurate?"

She let out a hum, contemplating on how to explain it. "Oh, you have memories of Earth, right?"

"Yeah?" Catra said, not understanding the direction she was going with this.

"Well, if they are my memories, you should know what a video game is." Catra let out a groan, making a 'go on' motion with her hand. "Well, it's sorta like the navigation system. She Ra should know exactly where to go."

"Alright, find the remaining shards and put them back together. Sounds simple enough. What do I do after that?"

"Ah, I'm not quite sure." She gave an embarrassed smile before quickly offering up another piece of advice, "But with every shard you collect, we should get our respective sense of selves back and at that point I'm sure I'll be able to answer more questions."

Catra stood up and walked through the clearing, "Okay, we got a game plan. So how do I get out of here and back in the real world?"

"The fountain. Look into it. It should help you wake up. Right now you're unconscious. You'll know if you can or not. But I'm in the dark about most of this as you are" She said walking up beside Catra.

As Catra leaned over the fountain, peering into the water, the crystal clearness began to darken. Suddenly colors bloomed forward, spreading through the water like drops of blood. Slowly but surely she began to make out an image in the water. Finally the picture came into clarity albeit quite blurry, slowly shifting in and out of focus.

She saw herself being carried by Adora. She was glowing with the golden light that only She Ra could emit. Adora was running beside Bow and Glimmer. She also took note of Bow carrying someone. Catra felt off. A feeling of dread was slowly creeping into the pit of her stomach.

"Something's wrong." Catra voiced her thoughts.

"What's going on?" The woman asked as she made her way towards Catra.

"I don't know. Whatever's going on is hard to make out. Take a look." She gestured towards the fountain.

The woman leaned over the fountain, trying to focus on seeing the image in front of her before stepping back. "I'm sorry Catra. Whatever it is you're seeing is hidden for me. It's hard enough for me to view anything outside of a mindscape much less through the fountain. I can only make out some shapes and colors."

Catra turned her attention back towards the fountain, concentrating on the images she was seeing. Ever so slowly, the water became clearer and clearer to the point that Catra could see everything. The first thing she took note of was that Bow had blood all over him. She could now see that the person Bow was carrying was Frosta. She wasn't moving. Behind them were a group of Horde soldiers chasing them through the Fright Zone's halls.

Panic shot through Catra as she rounded on the woman, "How do I wake up?"

"What?"

"How do I wake up? I'm unconscious, being carried through enemy fire, and Adora can't fight because she's carrying me. So, help me!" Catra cried with a desperate tone.

"I don't know! Typically, anytime someone shows up in their mindscape, they can just leave at will with the fountain. I'm not an expert on this stuff and if I was, I can't remember."

Catra let out a sound of frustration before taking a breath. 'Ok, If that's true then I should be able to go no problem. Just have to wake up."

Thinking of how she switched, Catra began to think of Adora, clearing her mind of all other distractions. As images of Adora filled her mind, she slowly began to feel a dull pain throughout her body. Pushing the pain to the back of her mind, she envisioned as much as she could of Adora. Her smile, her smell, the feeling of her hands, how it felt when she had hugged her. Suddenly she heard a familiar sound, like that of rushing water.

Catra jerked awake, the chaotic sounds of fighting filling her ears. "Catra, you're awake!"

Relief instantly flooded Catra. She had successfully woken herself up. Looking up she took in Adora's relieved face. She also noticed that her hair and eyes were glowing with much brighter hues than normal.

'Must be because she's She Ra." She thought to herself. Catra wiggled a bit before Adora set her down. She immediately looked around at her surroundings. She immediately felt a sense of deja vu. And nausea.

"Catra are you alright–" Adora was immediately cut off by Catra turning and throwing up. After a moment Catra wiped her mouth.

"Yep, never better. Now can someone explain to me what the hell is going on?"

"Might want to hold that thought." A voice yelled out from the side. Turning towards the voice revealed Mermista running with an injured Sea Hawk in tow. "We need to go now! Sea Hawk is losing blood."

Sea Hawk waved a hand, "Nonsense, this is just a minor scratch. I've taken worse wounds from sailing accidents." Unfortunately it was all posturing. Catra could smell the blood although she didn't need to. It was covering his torso. A stab wound most likely.

Before Catra could go to speak, Glimmer wrapped her arms around everyone, teleporting them to a different location. Immediately Glimmer collapsed before Adora caught her. "Glimmer! Are you alright?"

"No, I'm out of magic and I don't know where Perfuma and Entrapta are." Glimmer said in desperation. Bow gently handed Frosta to Catra as he ran over to Sea Hawk with what looked like a first aid kit now that they had a moment to breathe.

Ignoring everyone for a second, Catra took the time to examine Frosta. Her breathing was shallow and she had bandages wrapped around her arm and body. There was quite a bit of blood. Catra turned to look at Adora, "What happened? How long have I been unconscious?"

"We came to rescue you and Frosta. That's what happened." Mermista spat from the side as she worriedly hovered over Sea Hawk. "It's been roughly a day since princess prom." Bow added, not taking his eyes off of Sea Hawk's injuries as he worked to bandage them.

"What happened to Frosta?" Mermista asked.

"She was hit by debris when we were rescuing her. We bandaged her the best we could but-" Adora continued but Catra had tuned her out. She didn't know what she was feeling but it was strange. She could feel a surge of power periodically rippling through her

body from her core all the way to her finger tips. As she marveled at the feeling, Catra slowly began to play with the feeling. As she–

"Catra, did you hear me?" Adora asked, pulling Catra's mind back to their present situation.

"What?"

"I said we need to move. Bow's going to fire the retreat flare to signal Perfuma and Entrapta. Can you carry Frosta?"

Catra nodded. "Good, let's move." Adora said, the glow of her golden aura lighting up their surroundings. As Bow fired the arrow, the sky lighting up with a green burst of fire, Catra began running with everyone. She took note of Sea Hawk looking in better condition, completely bandaged. Catra began to realize her sense of time was very warped and–

"Catra, you need to slow down!" Bow shouted from behind her. Catra immediately stopped in her tracks, noticing that she was much further ahead of everyone. As everyone caught up to her, she felt another pulse ripple through her body.

"Catra!" Glimmer shouted at her. Catra stumbled back at the loud noise. Another surge ran across her body. "I. . ." Catra stopped as she looked down at her hands. She wasn't carrying Frosta anymore. Looking up, she noticed that Perfuma was in front of her with Frosta in her arms. Again she felt it, stronger this time. She could see energy swirling around her fingertips, just barely noticeable.

"Relinquish Force Captain Catra to me as well as the shard and you may leave with Princess Frosta. This is the only offer you will receive She Ra." Hordak spoke in a sinister tone. Catra looked around and noticed she was once again holding Frosta, who was now awake and glaring at Hordak. She didn't notice Shadow Weaver looking at her intensely.

"What? I don't. . .Adora?" Catra said slowly before feeling the power fly through her body once again.

"Relinquish Force Captain Catra to me as well as the shard and you may leave with Princess Frosta. This is the only offer you will receive She Ra." Hordak spoke in a sinister tone.

"You just said that." Catra said in a confused tone. Everyone turned to look at Catra. "What's going on?" She asked exhaustedly. She felt her breath being taken away as she slowly slumped to a knee, barely setting Frosta down without dropping her, as she felt another surge of power growing. Why did she feel so weak?

Shadow Weaver quickly cut in as she rushed towards her, "Catra stop tensing! You're exhausting your magic–"

"Relinquish Force Captain Catra to me as well as the shard and you may leave with Princess Frosta. This is the only offer you will receive She Ra." Hordak spoke in a sinister tone.

Catra collapsed, unable to stand anymore. Darkness clouded the edges of her vision, barely keeping hold of her consciousness. She could feel another oncoming surge. She was quite certain that one or two more of these would kill her. She didn't think she'd ever felt so tired. She could barely move now as she felt the power enveloping her body. Just before it could take effect, she felt a hand envelope hers. Instantly, Catra was flooded with power unlike anything she had felt. She felt invigorated. She noticed that Shadow Weaver was the one grasping her hand, red lightning danced across her skin, siphoning into Catra.

"What are you doing to her!" Adora shouted as she grabbed Shadow Weaver's arm.

Glimmer and Bow rushed forwards as the red lighting arcing off of Catra and Shadow Weaver turned silver blue and lashed out.

"Catra, I'm not going to be goaded into a fake argument so that you don't have to go learn proper etiquette. My daughter has used this trick too many times."

Catra recoiled, almost tripping over a pile of clothes. "Yes, I know. But I have been around the block and know most of the tricks. I used them myself on my own mother. But unfortunately–"

"Where's Frosta? What's going on?" Catra asked as she frantically looked around the room.

"Catra, are you alright?" Angella asked, taking a step towards her.

Catra ignored her as she looked down at her hands. She could feel it again. As she panicked, she felt the power building in every part of her body. Suddenly, Glimmer in a flash of sparkles appeared in front of her with Adora.

"Adora, what do I do? It won't stop." Catra desperately asked as lightning began to crackle off of her finger tips, the magic beginning to surge.

"Sorry about this!" Glimmer cried.

"What–" Catra was immediately cut off as Glimmer hit Catra with a vicious magically enhanced punch across the jaw. The panic coupled with the fact that Catra had not been expecting such an attack on her person rendered her unconscious.

Glimmer and Adora stood in the dressing room in complete silence, watching the seconds tick by. After a moment, Glimmer let out a sigh of relief before Angella spoke up, "What is going on?"

"So. . . she really is time traveling." Glimmer said in realization before Adora spoke up.

"I. . .er, it's kind of hard to explain."

"Well please try. Why did you just punch Catra?" Angella asked in concern as she kneeled down, checking on the unconscious cat girl.

"Um, alright. We are from a day in the future, roughly? Anyways, the Prom got attacked by the Horde and Catra and Frosta got kidnapped. When we were rescuing them Catra started to emit magic and somehow we rewound a day." Glimmer said in a somewhat unsure tone.

Angella tried to not let her confusion show, albeit to an unsuccessful degree. "Right, well you can all tell me about it as soon as I get Catra to a bed." Adora gave a nod as she gently picked Catra up.

Shadow Weaver sat in silence, the glow of the black garnet illuminating her figure. When Catra had been rather unresponsive during the confrontation, it had set alarm bells off in her head. She had initially sensed a build up of magic in Catra but hadn't quite put it together. But when she had felt a surge of power and heard Catra's words, well, suffice to say it was a good thing she had learned of Catra's time magic. A second later and there was a good chance Catra would have killed herself.

Beyond that, there was a more immediate change that took precedence at the moment. She could feel a source of magic present in her body that she had not felt in almost thirty years. She had been pushing it off, an anxious fear bubbling up in her being. Standing, she walked towards the mirror in the corner of the room. She slowly reached towards the mask with shaky hands. Ever so slowly, she removed the mask. In her reflection, she found the beautiful familiar face she hadn't seen in so long. Not a scar was present on her face. Removing her robe, she found that all of her scars were gone. Taking a deep breath, she quickly lifted her hand and attempted a spell. Immediately magic shimmered in the air as a rune circle appeared. Shadow Weaver let her hand fall to her side, dissipating the magic. Shadow Weaver for the first time in years let out a genuine laugh while simultaneously choking back a sob. After taking a moment for herself, Shadow Weaver wiped her tears away and considered her options.

She had been transported back a day, that much was apparent. Whatever was happening to Catra was much more than she could have anticipated. Her power was growing and now it was becoming volatile not just to others but to herself. Now was the time to make a decision. If she was to throw caution to the wind and approach Brightmoon, she was fairly sure that saving her life would have put her on good enough standing with Catra that she would defend her if need be. Due to her story, Catra was most likely under the assumption that she was with the Horde for the Black Garnet's lifeline. She could appear in Brightmoon, show that she had healed her, offer her teaching. Information about the Fright Zone and Hordak, knowledge only she possessed as Hordak's second in command. It could work. She would most definitely be thrown in a cell for the time being. Or stay with the Horde and risk ruining all progress with Catra.

Shadow Weaver inhaled deeply, looking around at the screens and technology around her. She no longer needed Hordak in any capacity. The choice was quite simple really. She would miss the Black Garnet, the power that it offered, but she no longer needed it. She had regained her younger self and retained all of her skill and experience. At princess prom she would make her move. She would surrender herself to the rebellion.

"For the last time, I am fine. And did you have to hit me so hard sparkles?" Catra asked as she rubbed her jaw.

"Sorry, I didn't know what else to do." Glimmer said apologetically.

Catra shook her head, letting a chuckle out, "Oh, don't apologize. That was the exact thing that needed to be done. Nice form too."

"Can you please stop joking about this? I'm really worried. What if you start. . .rewinding or whatever? You almost died. Again!" Adora shouted as she gained a hopeless look.

Catra lost her humor and turned towards Adora, taking her hands, "I'm sorry. You're right and I shouldn't be so nonchalant about all

of this. Really. So don't worry, I'm not gonna die anytime soon. We're gonna get through this. Nothing really bad can help as long as we stick together."

Adora looked into Catra's eyes before squeezing her hands, giving a familiar smile, "You promise?"

"Yeah, I promise."

As Adora and Catra settled into a comfortable silence, Glimmer cleared her throat, catching their attention. "Glad you two are okay with whatever this is, but we need to focus. Whatever you did didn't just affect us, it affected others too. Bow already contacted us and said he remembers too."

"What do you mean?" Adora asked.

"I mean, we weren't even touching you Catra. Me or Bow. That means that it affected anyone close enough to you. So chances are–"

"Frosta and Shadow Weaver probably still remember too." Catra finished. As everyone thought about that for a second, Catra let out a hum, "Maybe that's not so bad."

"How is that not bad? Shadow Weaver is the literal last person that should know about this." Glimmer said with her hands on her hips.

Catra shook her head, "But she's not. Think about it," she said as she turned towards Adora, "I know you don't trust her, but she didn't attack the prom and if anyone could tell me what magic I just did, it's Shadow Weaver."

Adora stayed silent, mulling that over in her head, "You're right. I don't trust her and I don't think I can ever forgive her. But you might have a point here." She let out a sigh before gaining a hard look, "But if she tries anything tonight, no more Shadow Weaver, okay?"

Catra nodded, "Okay."

Everyone turned to look at the door as Angella strode in. "I take it you all have a plan on what you are doing?"

Catra spoke up before anyone else could, "Before I rewound, I was holding Frosta. If Glimmer and Bow are right then she should remember the attack as well. We're hoping that she'll join the rebellion as well."

"I'm sensing there's something you're not telling me." Angella said with a suspicious look aimed at Catra.

"There may be a chance that. . .Shadow Weaver remembers as well." Catra said quietly.

"Absolutely not, I forbid it! You are not going." Angella declared in a stern tone.

"I have to do this. Whatever is happening to me, this surge, it's not normal."

"We can figure it out here Catra. I will not allow you to throw yourself into that woman's path. She's done enough harm to you both." Angella said, her voice increasing in volume.

"I'm going!" Catra shouted as she stood up.

"You are not!"

"You don't get to decide what I can and can't do. You're not my mother."

"No, I'm not. You're mother was an abusive witch who is currently trying to fuck with your head! And I'll be damned if I will let her destroy anyone else's lives, especially yours Catra." Angella said through gritted teeth. Everyone stayed quiet as Catra and the Queen stared one another down.

"I almost died. Do you get that? If she hadn't done what she did, we wouldn't be having this conversation." Catra said quietly as she looked down, "I know why, okay?"

Angella's eyes narrowed. "Do you though?"

"She told me. At the dance. Who she was and. . ." Catra trailed off, not wanting to finish the sentence.

"'And what' Catra? Go on. You've already brought it up, you may as well say it." Angella said icily.

Catra lifted her head with a glare, "She told me about Micah. How she taught him and about the stupid spell. But I'm not him, okay? I'm not gonna–" Catra cut herself off, looking away.

Angella's gaze softened slightly, "I know you're not him. But this path you're choosing is the same one he walked down and it ends in the same place Catra. I care about you, Glimmer cares, Adora more than anyone."

Catra glanced at Adora who gave a small smile. "So I'm going to make a deal with you." Catra looked back towards Angella. "You can go, but on the condition that you stop entertaining the notion that Shadow Weaver is trying to help you. She's not. And once you've returned, I will contact Castaspella and ask that she begin teaching you magic."

Catra's eyes widened in surprise, "Really? You would do that?"

"Yes, clearly whatever is happening is going to happen regardless of what anyone wants. Better we be prepared for it rather than not." Before Catra could respond, Angella turned back towards the door, "Now, if that is all, I recommend getting ready for tonight's events. Adora, a word."

Adora cleared her throat nervously as she followed her out of the room, "Yes, ma'am."

Glimmer and Catra sat quietly as Angella and Adora exited the room before Glimmer turned towards Catra, "My dad was taught by Shadow Weaver?"

Catra gave a sheepish smile, "I. . . guess?"

Frosta sat quietly on her throne as the first guests of Princess Prom entered the hall. She was quite aware of the events that had transpired, or rather what had not transpired. Not yet. She was privy to the first hand horrors of the Horde because of Catra and she wouldn't sit idly by as they bullied their way through her kingdom. Or any other kingdom she realized. She had decided to accept Glimmer's request and join the Princess Alliance.

As she went through the motions of greeting the guests, she thought about what she had gone through. She had been injured and quite badly as she recalled. But Catra had saved her. Saved everyone in fact. She had literally time traveled. There would be time to think about how cool that was later, but for now she was focused on Catra. She had already retrieved the books from her mother's study and had them set aside for Catra.

Speaking of Catra, Frosta took note of the trio walking up to the throne, "Revered hostess, we come into your hall under the ancient laws of hospitality, bringing greetings from Bright Moon. And She-Ra, legendary warrior and her plus one, Catra." Glimmer said as she stepped forward.

"You are welcome in the Kingdom of Snows under the ancient laws of hospitality. Leave conflict at the door and please enjoy the ball. We'll speak later." Frosta said with a nod as she let some of the sternness leak out of her tone.

At Glimmer's nod Frosta sat back in her throne, greeting the guests. She was really only concerned about two people here. From what she could remember, Shadow Weaver had done something to Catra. Whatever it was, she wouldn't be so quick to give her free reign again. She also had every one of her guards

masks off and the patrols were tightened. Nobody was getting in or out without her knowing and that was final.

After they had greeted Frosta, they had come to the exact spot they had previously waited at. Unlike last time, Entrapta was nowhere to be found. "Hey, do you think Entrapta was affected? She's not here like last time." Catra asked.

"I'm not sure, but keep your eyes peeled. If she was we need to find her as soon as possible." Adora said.

"She's a beauty, can't you see? She's attending this with me! She's my princess of the sea! Mersmista!" Catra turned to the sound of Sea Hawk singing.

"Oh hey it's- Adora, look out. A Horde soldier has infiltrated and is standing behind you!" Sea Hawk exclaimed.

"So I take it you don't remember?" Catra deadpanned.

"I remember how you tried to destroy my kingdom. Which, by the way, I have not forgotten." Mermista said before turning to Adora. "What the hell, Adora!"

"We don't have time for this," Catra interjected, "Long story short, I lost my memories from touching a soul shard. Adora's helping me recover them. Bow, Glimmer, Adora and I have already gone through today and whatever happened to me made us rewind the day. In about an hour the Horde is going to attack the dance and we need everyone to focus."

Sea Hawk gave an incredulous look, "Are you saying that you time traveled? How marvelous! You have to regale me with the tale later." Sea Hawk looked around shiftily before saying in a lower voice, "On another note, you're absolutely sure about the Horde attacking?"

Adora gave a nod, her face set in a scowl, "Yes, they'll be here shortly. Scorpia will have brought Shadow Weaver with her. Frosta

also remembers and we suspect Entrapta might as well."

Mermista gave a doubtful look, "Can you prove that you're reliving the day? No offense Adora, but you sound crazy right now."

"Oh! Um, Netossa is drinking a fizzy purple drink and she should walk into view right about. . .now." Catra said, pointing to a clearing as Netossa and Spinerella weaved through the crowd.

Mermista stepped past Catra, narrowing her eyes at Netossa's drink. True to her words, Netossa swirled a purple drink in her hands. Mermista let out a breath before rounding on Adora, "Fine.I believe you. But we are talking about *her* later." She said steely, flicking a finger at Catra. "Come on Sea Hawk, let's see if they have a kelp bar. Might as well enjoy the dance before it all goes to shit."

As they walked away, Catra turned towards Adora, "Wow, she sounds. . ."

"Pissed." Adora nodded. "It sucks but we have to focus on what's important. No distractions. Frosta was seriously hurt last time."

"You're not getting an argument out of me. I'll find Entrapta. Shouldn't be too hard, she smells like oil and metal. You go talk to Frosta."

Adora gave a nod. As Adora made her way through the crowd, Catra turned and ascended the balcony in hopes of catching any sign of Entrapta. Catra took a deep breath, looking for any sign of Entrapta's scent. Unfortunately she caught only the barest trace of her. Not nearly enough to track.

Taking a step back, she began to think about this in a different light. "Now, if I was Entrapta what would I be doing? Probably. . .comparing differences in behavior and placement. I would be somewhere that would overlook everything without being in the same place."

As Catra scanned the areas that matched such description, she caught sight of a flash of purple hair behind one of the pillars of ice. Taking a couple steps back to get a running start, she leapt off of the railing as she aimed for the opposite railing on the other side of the dance floor. Putting aside her surprise that she cleared the distance, Catra marched up behind the purple haired princess.

"Entrapta!"

Entrapta jumped in surprise at being found. "Oh, Catra. How are you? Do you remember me? Can you recall the last eight hours?"

"Can you focus? The Horde's due to arrive any moment. We need you with the rest of the princesses."

"You do remember! Oh, I need to document this! This breaks so many laws of physics. Time travel shouldn't be possible. Oh, the possibilities. Log number 465, I was–"

Catra cut her off by swiping the recorder from her hair, taking care not to break the device. "Listen, we can discuss this all you want after the dance, but right now I really need your help. Can you do that for me, please?"

Entrapta looked back and forth at her recorder anxiously, "You promise?"

Catra gave a nod while handing the recorder back, "I promise. After this, we can sit down and talk about it all you want."

Entrapta let out a squeal, "Ohhh, thank you, thank you, thank you! I'll do my utmost best to focus, I swear."

"Alright then. Come on, we need everyone down here so we can discuss our next move." Catra said as she turned towards the stairs.

Adora was currently in front of Frosta, hoping that the recent events had shown her why the Horde needed to be stopped.

"Princess Frosta, are you alright?

Frosta held up a hand, "Thank you for your concern but I am fine. But these recent events have opened my eyes to a few things and you can rest assured that you have my backing." Frosta's tone softened, showing her true age, "Is Catra alright? She seemed so weak last time I saw her."

Adora nodded, "Yeah, apparently she was over using the magic in her body to a dangerous degree. We're. . . doing our best to help her figure it out."

Frosta let out a small breath of relief. "Well in that case," she snapped her fingers, gesturing to a guard to bring the books that she had previously promised Catra, "Catra had made mention of her amnesia and coming into contact with a soul shard. These belonged to my mother and contain any information that she may have had at one point or another. I had promised Catra that she could use these in hopes of recovering her identity before. . . Well, let's just say that I have tightened security here considerably."

Adora gave a thankful smile. "Thank you Frosta. I appreciate the help. We'll be over by the drink station when you want to talk. Bow, Glimmer, and I all remember what happened as well as Catra. Entrapta might as well." Adora added at the last second before walking back to the concession stands.

Glimmer and Adora were standing with Bow and Perfuma when Mermista, Sea Hawk, Spinnerella, and Netossa joined them. "All right, has everyone been filled in?" Bow asked aloud. At everyone's nods Bow continued, "Good, right now we've secured Frosta's help in the alliance and Catra's currently searching for Entrapta. We don't have much time until they arrive, so we need to formulate a strategy. Adora, you're good to go ahead."

Adora nodded as she stepped forward, "Alright, Frosta's made sure all the guards helmets have been removed. We haven't

located the imp yet but it's only a matter of time. Be careful. We have reason to believe that Shadow Weaver has retained her memories as well. We'll split into groups of three. Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Perfuma, you three will be positioned at the scaffolding. If you see any Horde soldiers slipping in, apprehend them swiftly and quietly, we don't want to make a scene."

"Rest assured, we will not let a single one of them elude our sight." Sea Hawk declared. Mermista nodded in agreement, a determined look on her face.

"Netossa, you and Spinerella will take Bow. Patrol the halls. If you see any sign of the imp you know what to do. Bow, alert us if you see Octavia." Bow gave a nod. Adora turned towards Glimmer, "You and I will take Catra as well as Entrapta if she's found her. We're going to back up Frosta if it comes to it."

Glimmer gave a nod before Sea Hawk interjected. "Our feline compatriot is signaling us."

Everyone looked up at the balcony to see Catra and Entrapta. They were motioning towards the door. Adora already knew what that meant before she had turned. "Shadow Weaver's here. You all know what to do."

"Right!" They all responded before splitting up in their assigned groups. As Adora made their way towards the throne, Catra jumped down beside her. Entrapta was noticeably absent.

Catra picking up on her look gave a response, "I heard the plan. Told her to join Perfuma's group and see if she could pick out suspicious behavior from any guests or guards."

Adora gave a nod before turning her attention back on Shadow Weaver, who was dressed in her usual robe this time around, as she introduced herself to Frosta. . .again. 'Ugh, I hate time travel.' Adora thought to herself.

As they neared, Shadow Weaver turned her attention towards Adora and Catra, "Ahh, Catra. Glad to see you're safe. You too

Adora."

Adora and Catra both noticed it immediately. Something was off about Shadow Weaver, she seemed almost. . . happy. And not in a malicious way, no it seemed too genuine. Which made what she said next even more confusing.

"Since we are all acquainted with one another," Shadow Weaver said before turning towards Adora, "I hereby formally surrender myself to Brightmoon. All rights as a prisoner withstanding."

Scorpia blanched at what she just heard, "What! Shadow Weaver I don't think I just heard you right. It sounded like you just surrendered. Am I hearing things? Oh, I knew I shouldn't have eaten that ration bar I found in the barracks."

"No, Force Captain Scorpia, you heard me quite clearly. I am hereby declaring myself a prisoner of Brightmoon and the Princess Alliance."

"I-wha-huh?" Adora sputtered. Glimmer and Catra were trying to process this as well to about the same levels of success.

"Feelings of shock and confusion." Catra heard Entrapta from somewhere above her.

Hordak sat hunched over in his sanctum. Suddenly a dark chuckle began to emanate from him before growing into a full out laugh. He felt better than he had in over thirty years. He remembered completely what had transpired hours ago. Not even Horde Prime himself had the privilege of experiencing real time travel. A scientific impossibility that not even he could figure out.

He had borne witness to the event himself and had been affected when the stray energy had latched onto him and several others. His genetic discrepancies were not gone, oh far from it, but he had felt better than ever before. He had been reset to an age of power and he would not squander it. Horde Prime could wait a bit longer, right now he was in position to touch something that not

even the greatest minds had ever before. Catra was the key to his broken dna. She could fix him and help him get off this god forsaken rock. But he had played his hand too soon. Shadow Weaver had assured him that she could coax Catra back to the Horde but he wasn't so sure. He hadn't bothered to send Force Captain Octavia and her squad this time. No, if Princess Frosta could remember as well then it was pointless.

Hordak stood up sharply, a determined look on his face as he thought about what action he could take. Perhaps he could just ask? Make a deal with the rebellion, order a ceasefire and put a hold on the war, maybe even forfeit territory in return for Catra's aid. Shadow Weaver could do as she pleased at this point in time for all he cared. The only thing that mattered was fixing himself. If he could bring knowledge of real time travel to Horde Prime as well as fix his failing body, he could forget about this terrible planet and this war. He would return with his head held high, bearing the fruits of his labors and finally prove to his brother that he was not a failure but an equal. Hordak gave a grin as he envisioned his future.

Catra sat in the war room of Brightmoon with the rest of the Princess Alliance as well as the newly added Frosta. After Princess Prom had finished with no problems a meeting had been called with the surrender of Shadow Weaver as she had been put in a holding cell by Castaspella until they could decide the next course of action.

Besides that, she was currently sporting a killer headache as everyone talked over one another. Finally she had had enough, "Hey! Can everyone stop talking? I can't hear myself think."

At that everyone quieted down. Angella gave a nod of thanks before turning towards the assembled group, "Now that I have everyone's attention, what exactly transpired at Princess Prom. One at a time please."

Adora stepped forward, "Your Majesty, after we all met up, we had split into groups to prepare for the attack, which never came. Upon Shadow Weaver's arrival, she greeted us and promptly surrendered to the Princess Alliance, declaring herself a prisoner of Brightmoon. At which time we kept a watch on her for the remainder of Princess Prom. She's currently made no moves to attack or use any sort of magic. She was also strangely happy."

"I don't like it." Mermista interjected, "This woman is the second in command of the Horde. Catra time travels once and suddenly she's surrendering herself to the place where Catra is. It's a ploy and an obvious one too."

"I agree." Sea Hawk spoke up, turning towards Catra, "Whatever the reasoning for her sudden surrender, her true goal is you. I don't like it one bit, if I do say so myself."

Catra leaned back in her chair, "I figured. The timing was too perfect. But there's an issue with this."

"What?" Angella asked curiously.

"The first time we went to Princess Prom, Shadow Weaver took me aside and told me a story. It pertained to her being a teacher in Brightmoon. She talked about how she taught you and Micah." Catra said to Castaspella. "At some point she spoke about the Spell of Obtainment."

"Of course she did. No doubt to garnish sympathy from you." Castaspella spat in anger.

"Yeah, but see that's the thing. She told me that she lost the ability to use an internal source of magic."

"Of course she did. Anyone who succeeds with the damn spell loses their internal source. Turns you into a parasite that leeches magic from you and anything you can get your hands on." Castaspella shrugged. "So what?"

"Well, she said she was using the Black Garnet as a lifeline. If she's too far from the Black Garnet to be connected anymore, how is she even here without dying?" Catra asked.

"That's. . . a fairly good question actually. Hm." Castaspella sat back in contemplation.

"Because Catra healed me." Shadow Weaver's voice rang out from the doorway.

Before anyone could react, Adora had sprung for her chair, lifting her sword above her head and transformed. She Ra's appearance was like a signal for everyone to stand. Within seconds every person had brandished their weapons and magic, ready for a fight.

"Stop!" Catra's voice rang out, cutting through the chaos like a knife.

Everyone paused for a moment, turning towards Catra. "She had every opportunity to attack us just now and she didn't. I want to hear what she has to say."

Seeing no move had been made by Shadow Weaver, Castaspella stepped forward with her hands glowing with a threatening light, "How did you get out of the cell? You don't have an external source of magic. I made sure of that."

Shadow Weaver turned her head towards Catra, ignoring Castaspella. "Catra, I owe you more than you will ever know. I can never repay that. Your time magic undid the effects of the spell."

"Bullshit, I know better than anyone that it's impossible to fix. I know because you taught me that." Castaspella said vehemently, her hands primed with magic.

Shadow Weaver looked around the room at the gathered princesses before slowly reaching up to her mask. Ever so slowly

she removed it, showing Castaspella a face she hadn't seen in years. "How is this possible?"

"I don't know." Shadow Weaver answered truthfully, "But for the first time, I feel like I can breathe again. I can do magic again. For that, I will answer any questions you have. All my knowledge on the Horde is at your disposal. I will remain where you see fit."

Catra stayed silent for a moment before speaking up. "If that's true, can you go back to where you were being held? I need to work some things out."

Shadow Weaver gave a nod, putting her mask back on. "Of course."

"Angella, can you, Bow, Glimmer, and Adora stay. I'd like to speak to you all in private. Can the rest of you give us the room?" Catra asked aloud.

After a few minutes of everyone leaving the room, Catra slumped in her chair and let out a groan, "What is going on?"

"Well, I think–"

"Bow, that wasn't a real question." Catra stated bluntly.

Bow gave a sheepish look, "Right. . .sorry."

Angella gave a concerned look, "If this is too much for you Catra, we can–"

"No. No, we need to deal with this now and I'm pretty much at the center. Better to confront it head first." Angella still looked a bit unsure but nodded along nonetheless.

Catra stayed quiet for a moment before turning to look at her friend, "Adora, what do you think about all this? Can we trust the information? And furthermore, what relevance did her face have to do with that?"

"Remember what I told you back on the balcony at princess prom? Well, when we saw her face it didn't look like that. She was horribly disfigured with scars and her eyes didn't look quite right. If I had to guess, her face looked that way because of that spell. And no, I don't think we can trust her. The fact that she got out of the cell doesn't make me feel any better about it either."

Catra nodded before turning towards Bow, "What about you? What are your thoughts Bow?"

Bow wore a look of concentration as if trying to decipher the past few hours, "I'm with Adora on not really trusting her, but I think it would be dumb to dismiss possible information about the Fright Zone. I think we should hear her out at the very least and then discuss it afterwards."

"Glimmer?" Catra asked.

"Hard no! Uh uh. She's trying to manipulate you and Adora and worm her way into your good graces. I don't care if she was dad's teacher, I'm with Adora on this. We can't trust her."

Catra nodded before turning to the final person in the room. "And you Angella? What do you think?"

Angella gave a sigh, "I definitely still think my opinion of the woman is correct but while I am loath to admit it, Bow is right. Any information that we could stand to gain on the Horde is invaluable. But Adora is also right. The woman is not to be trusted. Whatever reason she came was to further her own agenda and you happen to be the priority in her mind."

Catra thought about what they all had said and pondered her options. She could just not speak to her. Let everyone else handle her and keep her distance. On the other hand, she had said that she was indebted to her and would answer any question she had. If that included magic, well. . .

"This is a frustrating spot to be in." Catra groaned.

Angella nodded, "It is. But that's what a council is for. So, what are your thoughts Catra?"

"I think this would be easier if I could. . .remember her. Hm." Catra went silent.

"What is it?" Glimmer spoke up.

"Perfuma had a soul shard with her before and gave it to me before the day reset. Last time I used one I got a large portion of my memories back. If she still has it, that could help."

"I thought we had decided those were bad. Why would you want to use it after what they did last time?" Bow asked.

"Um. . .well, you see, about that. . ." Adora narrowed her eyes suspiciously. "It turns out that I met a woman who told me what these shards do and that they hold my memories. From what she told me, Angella spoke to her once."

As all eyes turned towards her, Angella nodded, "I did indeed speak with this woman. But how did you speak with her, Catra?"

"When I was unconscious in the Fright Zone, I found myself back in front of the portal I use to shift. Apparently it's my mindscape. While I was there, she appeared in front of me and explained a few things. Turns out the reason I'm able to use these shards is because of my connection to She Ra."

"That's what she told me as well." Angella said

"How are you connected to She Ra?" Adora cut in.

Catra quickly turned to the side as her face turned a shade of red, "I'm not quite sure about the specifics but it turns out that the woman is from Earth. Whatever happened to her split her soul into these shards. Putting them together will not only restore my memories, it will also give her her soul back."

"Mmm, and did you maybe consider that this woman's soul was split for a reason? Maybe she's a bad guy that's aiming for world domination." Glimmer said, dramatically throwing her hands in the air.

"Even if she was a bad person, I still would help her get her soul back, even if it didn't give me my memories back." Catra declared.

"Why?"

"Because this," Catra said, motioning to herself, "is horrible. I can't remember anything and I only lost my memories. This woman lost her soul."

At that everyone stayed quiet for a moment. Adora raised her head, "So then how do we find the shards? How many of them are there?"

"Oh, there's nine of them left according to her. Also, She Ra should be able to find them with her sword or alternatively you can use another shard to point them out."

After a moment, Angella stood, "Well, let's go see if Perfuma has the shard on her this time around. If this will return some memories to you Catra, we can put the Shadow Weaver situation on hold for a bit."

At everyone's agreement they made their way out the door towards the alliance. As they entered the main hall, everyone turned to look at them. Shadow Weaver was the first to speak up, "So I take it you have come to a consensus?"

Angella narrowed her eyes, "Weren't you asked to return to your cell by Catra? Where's Castaspella?"

"Yes, I was. Unfortunately, Castaspella does not trust in her ability to put up an adequate barrier without proper setup. So for the foreseeable future I am to remain in sight of the princesses and guards of Brightmoon until further notice."

"Whatever," Catra said as she strode past the witch stopping in front of Perfuma, "Perfuma, in the princess prom before the time rewind, you had a soul shard that you gave to me. Is it too much to hope that you might have that on you this time around?"

Perfuma let out a noise of surprise before reaching into her pocket, "Oh, I actually do have that on me. I completely forgot with everything going on. Here you go."

Catra eyed the shard before turning to look at everyone, "I'm not sure what's going to happen when I grab this shard so anyone who's not connected to a runestone needs to back up."

At her insistence all the guards, Shadow Weaver, Sea Hawk, Bow, and several others went to the other side of the room. Entrapta had set up a recorder and several machines on the other end of the room, most likely to document the experience. As Catra made sure everyone was a safe distance away, she let out a breath. "Here we go," she muttered.

As she reached out to pick up the shard, she mentally prepared herself for a surge of power and magic. . .only to be completely caught off guard when nothing happened.

"Wow, what an astounding display of power. I could really feel the danger." Mermista drawled with a smirk.

Catra shot her a small glare before turning back towards the shard, "Last time I toyed around with it, what did I do. . .Oh, I need to put it together with the other ones. Angella, you said you had them right?"

"Ah, yes, one moment." Angella said as she left the room before returning after several minutes. "Here we are." She said, holding up a larger stone. It had lost its shard appearance and looked more like a broken piece of a crystal ball.

Catra gave a nod as she took the piece from Angella and looked at Mermista, "Get ready for this astounding display of power. I heard it can be quite dangerous." Mermista let out a snort.

As she held them out to one another they began to float and emit an electrical blue charge of energy. Suddenly the arcs of magic connected as they began to spin, slowly fusing into one another before slowing to a halt, hovering motionless.

"What happened? Is that it?" Netossa asked.

"No, something's missing. Catra, try emitting your magic into it. Recreate the first experience you had with this." Shadow Weaver said from the side. Catra gave a nod, thinking about what she was missing. Suddenly it hit her.

"Mara."

"What? What about her?" Adora asked.

"Last time I did this, I shifted. Maybe if I shifted again?"

"If you think it will work." Glimmer said.

"Please be careful." Spinnerella said from the side.

As Catra began to envision Mara the crystal began to emit a familiar glow. Catra's excitement grew at that but it began to dim as she lost focus. "Keep your mind focused. Don't lose sight of your goal." Shadow Weaver said in a strict tone. Catra nodded, refocusing on Mara.

As the shift drew closer, the magic arced off the shard, lashing out before focusing on Catra. She began to feel the euphoria as it coursed through her. Catra began to float as she tried to keep conscious this time. Slowly, the woman began to form in front of her. As the shards finally fused together, her form lost all traces of transparency, giving way to a clear form of her.

The woman wore a red dress resembling a cuirass with golden highlights with a blue gem that resided on the upper left of her chest. A golden crown with a smaller blue gem sat on her head.

Angella strode forward through the field of magic. "Hello again. Do you remember me?"

"Angella." She said before turning towards Catra. "You did it. Thank you! I don't remember much but it's a start. You should be getting your memories back soon as well."

Catra looked a bit strained as she spoke, "That's great but I think I'm going to switch soon so if you could catch me when that happens Angella that would be awesome."

"Of course." Angella said.

"Do you remember your name at the least?" Catra asked.

The woman stayed silent, thinking about it before her face lit up in excitement. "Yes! I know who I am. My name is Marleena."

Chapter 9

Catra opened her eyes to silence. Sitting up, she noticed that she was in a large bed surrounded by computers and machinery of sorts. If she had to guess, they probably monitored her vitals. She noticed that they weren't on however. There was also a bird in the corner of the room. A pet if she had to guess. From the way it was frantically moving, she guessed it had been startled recently.

Swinging her feet off to the side of the bed, she slowly stood up. She hadn't visited Mara in almost a week and a half and she felt a little bad about that. Walking to the end of the room, she opened the door and stepped outside. As she walked through the corridor she found no one. It seemed almost abandoned with how quiet it was. It was a little unsettling if she was being honest.

Her ears twitched. She heard a sound steadily growing closer. Pressing forward toward the sound, Catra broke into a slow jog down the corridor. As she rounded a corner Catra stumbled back as she collided with a body. Barely managing to regain her balance, she looked up at the person in front of her only to find Serenia.

"Catra? Thank goodness! Come quick!" Serenia said before quickly pulling Catra to her feet. "We need your help."

Catra quickly fell into stride beside her as she followed the red haired woman, "Why? What's going on?"

“I don’t know how to explain it but about a day and a half ago things started going crazy.”

“Crazy how?”

“As in ‘time isn’t working correctly’ crazy. There’s rifts, pockets of time that are affecting the area,” Serenia said as she quickly took a left. “And to top it off, things are coming out of them. Mara’s on the front lines as She Ra with Admiral Stratos but they’re exhausted. They won’t stop coming.”

For the first time Catra really took in Serenia’s appearance. Her normally bright green eyes appeared dull and somewhat lifeless and her hair was flat and plastered to her sweat covered face. She also had several bandages on her arm. “Are you alright? You look terrible.”

“I’ll be fine. But listen. You time traveled to get here. That’s what you said right?” At Catra’s nod Serenia continued, “Then please help us. We have no clue what to do right now. Even Stratos is at a loss.”

Catra gave a nod, “If there’s any way I can help I will.”

Serenia gave a nod. As they exited the building, Catra caught sight of She Ra and Stratos along with a group of soldiers locked in a battle with some sort of monsters. Even from across the courtyard, Catra could feel the dark magic emanating from them.

Their bodies were made up of what appeared to be oily black tendrils. The center of their bodies were masses of red and pink eyes that constantly shifted like some sort of dark twisted seraphim. The tendrils shifting into hands, constantly reaching for their targets.

As one of the tendriled hands locked onto one of the soldiers it began to devour him. His terror filled screams permeated the air as he was lifted off of his feet, being drawn closer to the center of the creature. Before it could get any closer, She Ra raised her sword and pointed at the creature, emitting a beam of pure magic. With a blood curdling shriek the monster recoiled, instantly dropping the man.

Stratos held up a device that looked suspiciously like a spear before shouting, "It's ready! Everybody get down!" No sooner had the warning been sounded that the spear gave off a frequency that carried in all directions like a sonic wave. As the creatures retreated back into what appeared to be tears of reality, the courtyard was still and silent, save for the groans of the soldiers and the heavy breathing from Stratos. She Ra dropped to a knee, using her sword as a support as her form faded, giving way to a haggard looking Mara.

Catra's ears could hear the conversation as they neared. "Stratos, I'm running on fumes over here. I don't know how much longer I can do this." Mara panted out.

"I know, but there has to be something we can do. Some way to kill them." Stratos said as he helped one of his men to a bench. "That's only going to give us about forty minutes. We need to figure something out." He glanced at the spear-like contraption,

“Because at this rate. . .” The words didn’t need to be said. Everyone was thinking the same thing. If She Ra couldn’t kill these things then what were *they* supposed to do?

“Serenia says these things have something to do with time travel? Someone want to give me a rundown?” Catra said loudly as her and Serenia approached the group.

Catra could swear she saw Mara and Stratos’ shoulders visibly relax. “Oh thank Sharella.” Stratos muttered as he walked towards her. “It is unbelievably good to see you awake.”

“Yeah, Serenia was saying something of the sort. What’s going on?”

“Around a day and a half ago, areas of what we can only assume are pockets of rampant time magic began appearing in the vicinity. At first they were harmless. If you stepped in one you might go faster than everyone else or slower, etc.” Catra gave a nod, “But then it became more unsettling. Things started to stop.”

“Stop how?” Catra asked in confusion.

Serenia gently turned Catra towards her and pointed up, “That’s how.”

Catra gave a sharp intake of breath as she looked at what Serenia was pointing at. A skycraft had collided with the outpost's building and had exploded. It looked like several people were about to be caught in the blast.

"That's not the only ones either." Mara spoke up as she slowly made her way towards her. "Phyla's tavern is frozen as well with a lot of people trapped inside. Whatever's causing it is spreading away from the area and at an alarming rate. The creatures appeared twelve hours ago. So far they're only attacking us but that could change at any time. We. . .we don't know what to do." Mara said tiredly.

Stratos looked Catra in the eye, "Do you have any ideas what could be causing this? I know you didn't mean to time travel to us but could this be an adverse effect? Something that's leeching off of your magic? We only have about half an hour."

Catra went silent as she thought about this. She hadn't switched in almost two weeks and she had almost certainly never seen such monsters before. After a moment she thought about the last two days. She. . .she had rewound time. . .and almost died for it. She let out a desperate sigh.

"I hope that means you figured something out." One of the soldiers spoke up.

Catra walked towards the field with the exploding skycraft. As she put her hand through it a field of sorts encompassed her arm. It looked almost. . .glitched as she stepped through it. With her

body fully inside the field of frozen space, she turned back to look at the group. “Am I still moving for you guys?”

“Yeah,” Mara said with a bit of relief, “See if you can save the people by the blast.”

“Don’t touch the explosion. We don’t know if your immunity will spread.” Stratos quickly said.

Catra gave a nod as she turned and quickly walked up to the people. If she wasn’t feeling so apprehensive she would have stopped to look at the fire and smoke. The way it was frozen in the air, unmoving, was quite cool.

As she stopped in front of the people, she found there were four of them. Taking a deep breath, “I hope this works,” she reached out and grasped two of them on the shoulders. Instantly they recoiled away from the direction of the frozen blast.

“Mira, Jon, stop moving!” Stratos shouted with an authority that gave no room to disagree.

The now named Mira and Jon stopped in their tracks as they looked around at the area before finally looking at Catra. She noticed a flash of recognition in their eyes as the girl let out a breath of relief. That seemed to be the case when looking at Catra at the moment.

Catra quickly hauled them to their feet and walked them to the edge of the time field, not daring to let go of them. As she let them go outside of the field they were met with hugs and pats on the back.

Upon taking another step back towards the other two she noticed something. The dirt started moving. Catra looked up at the fire and saw it had begun to move slowly, albeit not for long as it was beginning to move faster. Cracks began appearing at the area of impact.

Immediately, she broke out into a sprint, all caution thrown to the wind as she made her way towards the other two. Stratos and Mara had immediately noticed the movement as well.

"Catra, quickly!" Mara shouted.

As she grabbed onto the smaller one she noticed that they were unconscious. Thankful, she swiftly hauled him onto her back. Reaching out, she grabbed the shoulder of the other one, only to be met with panicked flailing. After a few seconds of failing to get him to calm down and the increasing danger Catra lost her temper and lashed out with a right cross that instantly rendered him unconscious. Not bothering to pick him up, she began to drag him to the edge of the field as quickly as she could. As she approached the edge of the field, she could see the light on ground from the fire in front of her and feel the heat on her skin. As soon as she stepped foot outside of the area, Stratos quickly threw her behind him as he held an outstretched hand in front of

him. She wasn't sure how he did it but he had erected a force field of golden light that shielded everyone from the blast.

Catra noticed that the frozen time field had returned to normal as had the other pockets of warped time. Although the rifts where the monsters had retreated to remained. Serenia and another soldier took the unconscious people from her.

Stratos turned back to Catra after the explosion had died down. "I imagine you have some sort of idea what caused this then?"

Catra gave a nod as Mara helped her to her feet. "Yeah, I think so. About thirty six hours ago, right?" At their nods Catra continued, "I was. . .abducted by the Horde. The opposing side of our war," she quickly added.

"Of course." Stratos said.

"Well, when I was unconscious I met a woman and she helped explain a few things about everything happening. When I woke up, I started exuding magic. Time magic to be exact. I started moving faster, shifting for lack of better words. Anyways, at some point I started rewinding. It. . .it was killing me and I couldn't stop it. When I was at my limit, I absorbed a heavy amount of magic and I guess it supercharged me. I rewound almost a whole day and a half."

“Woah woah woah, I thought you said time travel doesn’t work that way?” Serenia spoke up.

“It doesn’t, or at least it shouldn’t. I don’t think I time traveled. I think I just rewound the day. But the thing is, my friends remembered the events as well. They were very close and had been caught in the magic. I don’t want to jump to conclusions but–”

“But the timeline matched too well for it to be coincidental.” Stratos interrupted quietly. After a moment of thought he looked at Catra. “Mara informed us that our timelines are on an axis. For you, your high noon is our midnight. My theory is that you threw us out of sync. We’re no longer mirrored.”

“. . .What the hell does that mean?”

Stratos blew out a breath, “It means that if you can rewind back the same amount of time you did initially, then maybe this will all stop.”

“I don’t think you heard me when I said I almost died doing that. And second, I can’t. It took a lot out of me just to go back a couple seconds a few times, I don’t know how I would begin to go back a day and a half again.”

“Well, how did you absorb the magic in the first place?” Mara spoke up.

“I. . . hm,” Catra stopped and thought about that. It had been Shadow Weaver who had done it and it had most definitely been because she had siphoned magic from the Black Garnet. If she could learn how to absorb the magic like her. . . “That could work.”

“What could work?” Stratos asked.

“Shadow Weaver. My. . .mother figure is able to draw magic from the rune stones. If I can ask her how to do it and then siphon enough magic from it, I could theoretically rewind again.”

Just then an animalistic scream filled the air. Everyone whipped their heads towards the rifts. They were beginning to widen. Nothing had come out of them yet but their situation was beginning to look worse and worse. Suddenly rifts began to fill the sky.

“We could barely handle three rifts.” Serenia whispered in horror.

Stratos rounded Mara and Catra, “Mara, take her to Brightmoon. It’s the closest runestone and we don’t have a lot of time left. Catra, we’re counting on you. You have to learn how to siphon the magic and rewind us back on course.”

“But what if it doesn’t work!” Mara said desperately.

“We’re out of options Mara. We have a few minutes before they come out. Call Orsa and go. We’ll hold out as best as we can here.” Stratos said urgently, throwing devices on the ground. He turned towards the rest of the soldiers, “All weapon restrictions are lifted. Use whatever means necessary to survive.”

At the dismissal, Mara dragged Catra towards the center of the courtyard before lifting her sword in front of her. Within seconds Catra heard a roar from above. Catra stared up in amazement as a large white dragon adorned in golden scales along its body descended from above her. Its wings gave off a colorful sheen similar to a rainbow that reflected light all around them. Mara quickly jumped on the back of the dragon and hauled Catra up behind her. She took note of the strangely shaped saddle.

“Take us to Brightmoon as quickly as possible, Orsa.” Mara said with urgency.

The dragon gave a nod before speaking in an effeminate voice, “Of course Mara.” Within seconds the dragon had descended into the sky.

Mara turned back to face Catra, her voice held a hard edge as she spoke. “We have an hour until we get there. Switch now and figure out how to do this.”

Catra chose not to dwell on the tone of her voice, instead choosing to listen to the command. “Make sure I don’t fall.” She said to her as she wrapped her arms around Mara’s waist. Mara gave a simple nod.

Thoughts of Adora filled her mind.

Catra sat up with a gasp. She could already feel the dull pain of switching. Quickly swinging herself out of the bed, she began sprinting down the halls of Brightmoon. She heard the sounds of Castaspella arguing inside the main hall. No doubt over Shadow Weaver. Unfortunately she was the main objective at the moment. Catra came crashing through the doors to everyone’s surprise.

“Catra, What are you doing up? I thought you had switched?” Angella asked.

“No time to talk.” Catra said as she ran over to Shadow Weaver. “You know how to siphon magic from a runestone right? That’s how you supercharged me?”

“Yes. That’s actually exactly how I did it.” Shadow Weaver said slowly. She had a pretty good guess on what Catra was about to ask. Her thoughts were proven correct instantly.

“Good, teach me how to do it now.”

Castaspella instantly strode forward, “Absolutely not. Angella and I already discussed that I would teach you magic. You don’t need–”

“I don’t care about that right now. When I rewound the day I offset the axis point of Mara’s timeline. They’re no longer balanced right now. Things are falling apart, time’s breaking, and black eyeball monsters are flooding out of portals. I have an hour to figure out how to rewind it back or everyone over there is going to die! I couldn’t care less about who teaches me magic right now. Not even She Ra is able to fix it. So unless you can teach me how to do it in less than an hour Castaspella, I can’t afford to wait any longer.”

She was met with silence before Angella strode forward towards Shadow Weaver. “You teach her how to do this and that is it. Castaspella will watch you to make sure you do not meddle with the runestone.” She uttered through gritted teeth. At Shadow Weaver’s silent nod, Angella turned towards Adora, “Can you–”

“Way ahead of you.” Adora said as she raised her sword, “For the honor of Grayskull!”

Catra and Shadow Weaver quickly made their way through the halls towards the runestone, followed by Adora, Glimmer, Bow and Castaspella. When they were finally in front of the stone Shadow Weaver stepped forward. “Place your hand on the Moonstone, Catra. What I’m about to teach you is a form of Umbrakinesis.”

“Dark manipulation” Catra stated plainly.

Catra’s ears picked up Castaspella’s mutters, “A vile form of sorcery.”

Shadow Weaver nodded, “Good, you’re aware of what it is. This spell has two parts. Restore and Drain. Not an overly complicated spell and quite useful in a pinch. Focus on the feeling of the magic beneath the stone’s surface, the flow of magic that permeates the very being of it. It’s right in front of you ripe for the taking. It’s yours. The intent must be there, if you cannot exert your will over it then it will not obey you. Bend it to your will and subjugate it.” Shadow Weaver’s voice whispered in her ears.

Catra closed her eyes and focused on the magic. She made a grasp for it, only for it to recoil and lash out. Catra grit her teeth and tried again. Once again it refused to listen. Catra’s face contorted into rage as she opened her eyes. Ever since she had lost her memories everyone had wanted something from her. Demanded things from her. No more. Now she was going to take something for herself. She was done asking. This thing was going to listen, it was going to *obey.*

Bright lights arced off of the runestone into Catra’s body, filling her with a feeling of power that gave her a satisfying thrill. Removing her hand from the runestone she looked at her hands. She felt powerful. Like she was untouchable.

“Excellent,” Shadow Weaver’s voice drifted into Catra’s ears, drawing her attention, “But you have too much. Much more than I gave to you. Now I’ll show you the restoration part. Glimmer,” Her voice sharp, “Step forward. You cannot give the magic back to the runestone, lest it take it all back from you. Thus you have to give it to a willing recipient. Take Glimmer’s hand. This is much easier. Imagine a funnel that only lets a certain amount in. Slowly release your grip on the magic until you are holding the right amount.”

Glimmer gave a reassuring nod as she took Catra’s hands. Catra closed her eyes and imagined gifting the magic to Glimmer, albeit quite slowly. At the feeling of the power leaving her body, Catra grit her teeth. It left a cold feeling in her body as she slowly lost the magic. An almost. . .empty feeling.

“Catra, you stopped giving me magic,” Glimmer spoke up.

Catra opened her eyes. “Oh, uh, sorry.” She said before finishing giving the rest back to Glimmer. When she had the correct amount that felt the same as when she did back in the Fright Zone she let Glimmer’s hands go.

“I feel great!” Glimmer said with a wide grin looking at her hands. “Is this how mom feels all the time?”

“I. . . think that’s the correct amount.” Catra said, ignoring Glimmer for the moment. Shadow Weaver placed a hand on Catra’s arm before letting it fall to her side.

“Yes, that is the right amount. Go now, quickly. You have roughly ten minutes until your hour is up.” Shadow Weaver said, taking a step away from the Black Garnet at Castaspella’s glare.

Catra turned towards Glimmer, “Take me to my room, quickly.”

Glimmer nodded, taking Adora and Bow’s hands, Catra reached out and touched Glimmer’s shoulder and in a flash of sparkles they were gone. No sooner had they left did Castaspella round on Shadow Weaver. “You will stay away from that girl. I hope you enjoyed that because that’s about the only lesson you're going to give.”

“Are you so sure? Catra seemed pretty invested in learning magic and that goes for all kinds. Perhaps you will be the primary teacher but do not discredit me Castaspella. I was still one of the head teachers at Mystacour.”

“Yeah? Well you’re no longer a teacher anymore so you can forget it. Or do you want me to start calling you Light Spinner again?” Castaspella bit out harshly.

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes before turning and walking back towards the castle, “Regardless, I’m concerned. Catra gave a pretty familiar description of the monsters attacking this Mara girl. Now you never were one to pay attention in class but I would hope you caught what she said.”

Castaspella remained quiet, an uncomfortable tension in the air, “What do you think it means? It couldn’t possibly be. . . could it?”

“This is completely uncharted territory for me. I haven’t the faintest idea of why this is happening to Catra. I couldn’t have been the only one to sense her magical potential. It’s too high, even for my standards.”

“I felt it. I just don’t know what it means. Time magic, the spell of obtainment, this Marleena woman. I’m beginning to think the Horde is the least of our concerns.”

“I think you might be right for once.”

Mara was feeling increasingly worried as she looked below her. They were wrong. It wasn’t contained, far from it. As far as she could see were rifts and fields of broken time. The monsters were dotting the land laying waste to everything. Finally they reached Brightmoon. As they began descending troubling thoughts began filling her head. What if Catra just didn’t come back. She could just leave. Her timeline wasn’t being attacked, what reason did she have to help her. She’d only known Mara for a couple of weeks.

Mara shook her head free from those thoughts. Catra wouldn’t do that. Everything pointed to the opposite. Even when she was frustrated and angry, she still chose to help her out. They were friends and she would choose to believe in the best of her.

As Mara landed Orsa in front of the Moonstone, the Queen quickly strode out towards Mara. “Mara, what’s going on! There are creatures everywhere.”

“I don’t know exactly but we’re here to fix it, Queen Rayla.” Mara said getting down from Orsa.

“How? I’m not–”

Rayla was cut off by Catra sitting up sharply with a groan. “Catra! Thank Sharella your awake. You made it just in time.” Mara knew she wouldn’t just abandon them. Quickly helping Catra off the large dragon, Mara turned to look at the queen. “I’m gonna be honest, you’re probably gonna hate what we’re about to do.”

Catra slowly stood straight up. “That’s all three, I can’t switch for another day. So I hope this works.”

“What are you going to do?” Rayla asked.

Catra looked at the woman, realizing that this was the queen of Brightmoon in Mara’s timeline. “I’m going to siphon enough magical power from the Moonstone to cast a spell that will hopefully get rid of these rifts and monsters.”

The Queen adopted a conflicted look on her face but gave a hesitant nod nonetheless. “Alright, but just this once. I can’t allow this to happen again. Do I make myself clear?”

At Mara’s crisp nod Catra turned towards the Moonstone and repeated what she had done only moments ago. She found that the magic did not transfer over when switching, unfortunate as it was. It took her a few moments but the result was a success.

Catra stepped back as the familiar power filled her body once again, “Ok, too much. Um. . .”

“I am Queen Rayla of Brightmoon.” The woman supplied.

“Queen Rayla then. Please step forward, I need to get rid of some of this until I have the right amount.”

At Catra’s request, Rayla stepped forward and took Catra’s outstretched hands. To Rayla, the process was almost like when she had to recharge when her mother had been queen. The experience left her feeling a bit nostalgic if she did say so. After a moment Catra let go of her hands.

“Alright, I have the necessary amount.” Catra said, clenching her hands.

“Okay, now what?” Mara asked.

Catra gave a bit of a panicked look, “I don’t know. I-I’ve never tried doing it on command. I almost died last time.”

“Okay, okay, it’s okay. Uhhh, think, what were you doing when you did it? How did you feel during it? Any outside stimuli?” Mara asked, doing her best to help.

Catra thought back to that moment. The feeling was far from pleasant. Ripples of energy had crackled along her skin all the way down to her fingertips. She tried her best to recall that feeling. It started slowly at first. The fur along her body stood on end and she could taste the electricity in her body. And then. . . a surge ran through her.

“How? I’m not–”

Rayla was cut off by Catra sitting up sharply. “Catra! Thank Sharella your awake. You. . .what just happened?” Mara asked, confused.

“I did it!” Catra exclaimed before turning towards Mara. She could feel another surge slowly coming. “A day and a half ago, wherever you were, you’ll need to come stop me. I couldn’t stop it before–”

“How? I’m not–”

Rayla was cut off by Catra sitting up sharply with a groan. “Catra! Thank–” Mara stopped talking and refocused on Catra’s words.

“I couldn’t stop it after I rewound, I won’t have long. You’ll need to knock me out. Stop me from rewinding. After the power is gone it will start to kill me.”

At Mara’s nod Catra focused all of the power from the Moonstone into the time spell. She felt it then. The surge as strong as ever coursed through her body. Quickly latching onto Rayla and Mara, she let the magic rip through her.

Catra's eyes shot open as she quickly jumped out of the bed that she had woken up in only two hours earlier. The lights were dimmed and she could tell from the ambience that it was closer to midnight. She quickly stood up and ran at the door.

“Mara!” Catra yelled out frantically. She could feel it happening again. There, at the end of the hallway was Mara rushing towards her. She must have been close by, thankfully. She was almost in arms reach.

“Catra, I’m–”

Catra's eyes shot open. She realized with horror that she wouldn't make it, already she could feel the effects of fatigue. She could hardly stand let alone run. Faintly, she could make out Mara's voice out the door. Shakily getting to her feet, she stepped towards the door before another surge of the magic ripped through her body.

Catra could barely open her eyes this time. She could barely move. She realized she was going to die. With no one around her, alone in the room. Her eyes filled with tears at the thought. A flutter of movement caught her eye in the corner of the room. The bird.

Shadow Weaver's words floated through her mind, *"This spell has two parts. Restore and Drain. Not an overly complicated spell and quite useful in a pinch. Focus on the feeling of the magic beneath the stone's surface, the flow of magic that permeates the very being of it. It's right in front of you ripe for the taking. It's yours. The intent must be there, if you cannot exert your will over it then it will not obey you. Bend it to your will and subjugate it."*

Drain

Catra stretched her arm shakily towards the bird. A shadowy aura enveloped the poor creature as it was all but devoured. Catra could feel its life energy funneling into her, feeding and nourishing her. It wasn't much, only staving off the spell for a few precious seconds. Fortunately, that was all Mara needed to burst through the door cloaked in the brilliant gold light that only She Ra could emit. Catra could feel the surge overtaking her body once more.

Mara's fist collided with the side of her head, rendering her unconscious instantly. Mara kept a hold of Catra's unconscious body for a moment before breathing a sigh of relief. Mara looked over at the withered husk of the bird.

Mara sucked in a breath, "Oh no. Zoar." she said as she stepped towards the hawk. Laying a hand on it, she closed her eyes, focusing on healing it. After a moment the hawk's feathers regained their sheen and it started moving again. After a few more seconds the hawk was back to full health. "I'm sorry Zoar. I promise Catra's a good person."

The bird gave what Mara considered a doubtful look. Fortunately it didn't care to stick around and flew through the door out of the room. Mara sighed before turning back towards Catra. Pointing the sword at her, she began to heal the unconscious cat girl. Within seconds Catra opened her eyes.

"Ugh, I'm getting sick of this time travel bullshit." Catra moaned. Mara plopped down on the bed beside her.

"Yeah, that makes two of us."

After a minute of silence Catra stood up. "Well come on then."

"'Come on' where?" Mara asked, confused.

“You weren’t the only one touching me. That woman, Rayla, was beside me when we rewound. That means she remembers too. She’s probably confused as hell considering the fact that it’s now the middle of the night when it was late morning a few seconds ago for her.”

Mara gave a groan. She hadn’t really considered that. “So it worked? Our timelines are balanced again?”

Catra opened the window in her room. The soft sounds of bugs and birds chirping answered. No signs of explosions or attacks were to be seen. “I. . .I think so.”

“. . .Alright then, let’s go see Rayla. But first, we need to tell Stratos we succeeded.” Mara said as she walked to the door.’

Catra caught her wrist, stopping her before she could take any more steps. “No, Mara, you aren’t getting it. No one but Rayla or you remembers because those events didn’t happen. There weren't any time rifts or monsters. In fact I’d take a guess Stratos is asleep in his quarters right now.”

“You’d guess wrong.” Stratos said, standing at the doorway. “Catra, good to see you awake. What’s this I’m hearing about timelines and monsters?”

“I. . . you know what, just come with us. We can explain on the way.” Catra said.

Stratos gave a noncommittal nod, “Alright, seeing as how my work is done for the night, why not.”

Mara took the lead as they walked outside. There were a few soldiers awoken from the sounds of Mara slamming her door open but Stratos had sent them back to their barracks, assuring them that everything was fine.

Upon exiting the building, Catra found that the dragon Orsa was already in the middle of the courtyard waiting. “Mara, I’m glad to see you’re alright. You as well Catra. Mara has spoken of you a few times. She holds you in rather high regard.” The dragon leaned forward with narrowed eyes, a low growl in her voice. “I’m still looking for the reason for that, considering that you are the one responsible for this whole mess.”

Catra took a small step back at the suspicious look from the large winged reptile. She was suddenly a lot more hesitant to climb on its back. Mara gave Orsa a look. The dragon seemed to understand Mara on a more emotional level as she simply looked away before leaning down.

“Orsa’s my steed. She’s also a very good friend. Don’t worry she won't hurt you.” Mara said as she hopped on her back before helping Stratos up. Catra wasn’t so quick to trust the dragon as she slowly climbed on its back, careful to stay in a spot where it couldn’t reach her with its teeth.

Within seconds Orsa had ascended several hundred feet in the air, quickly taking off towards Brightmoon. Over the hour-long flight, Mara explained what had happened to them before Catra had woken up. To his credit, Stratos simply listened with no visible reaction. After Mara's explanation finished, Catra told her side of the story regarding learning the spell necessary to fix the skewed timeline. By the time they had finished the story Brightmoon was in view.

"Hm." Stratos simply said.

"That's it? Hm?" Mara said in disbelief.

Stratos let out a laugh and for the first time Catra took into account that he was a lot younger than he appeared. His strict demeanor didn't really show it but he couldn't be more than twenty five.

"Well. . . yeah. What do you want me to say?" Stratos said with a chuckle, wiping a tear from his eye. "It sounds like it sucked, sure, but you guys took care of it."

Catra let out a snort, "Oh yeah, look at me, I'm Stratos. I just heard about my death that was prevented by time travel."

Mara smiled at Catra's impression of the man. "Yeah, that sounds ridiculous repeated back to me."

After a moment, they all broke out in a laugh. Catra's laughter slowly died down as she caught sight of Rayla on the scaffolding beside the Moonstone. "Heads up. Looks like the Queen's expecting us."

As Orsa landed in front of the queen, Catra jumped down before turning around and offering help down to her companions. The Queen stepped forward, "Mara, Stratos, and. . ."

"Catra." Catra replied.

"Ah, Catra then. It's good to see you all in good health. Just as well, seeing as the monsters are gone. Although I do have one question. Why is it four in the morning?"

"Er, right. . ." Catra turned towards Mara, "You want to tell her or should I?"

Rayla simply crossed her arms and tapped her foot, waiting with an expectant look on her face. Catra took the time to look at the woman in front of her. It was quite bizarre. Without all the fancy clothing on and her hair down, this woman was the spitting image of Angella. Even her voice sounded similar. Although her hair was more red than pink and her skin was a bit more tan. She was also shorter and thinner.

Stratos stepped forward, "To put it simply, time travel."

Rayla blinked at the answer before letting a breath out and turning around, “Honestly, you Eternians and your weirdness. Well come on then. Might as well get some food in you while you're here.”

Catra found her eyes drifting down a bit as she watched her walk back towards the doors. Mara nudged her elbow into Catra’s arm with a smirk. Catra gave an annoyed shove while rolling her eyes.

As they followed the woman through the halls, Catra found herself looking at the Architecture. “Wow, guess architecture doesn’t really differ much does it?”

“What do you mean?” Rayla asked, looking over her shoulder.

“Catra here is technically from the future. . . technically. It’s strange. But she’s currently residing in Brightmoon castle.” Mara explained.

Rayla stopped and turned to face Catra, an interested gleam in her eyes. Stratos also looked intrigued. “How far into the future? Does it look any different?”

“Well, there’s definitely a few things. The tapestry for one. Um, oh the lights look a bit different, but beyond that it looks very much the same. Angella has said tradition is very important to Brightmoon.”

“Angella? I imagine that is the queen in your time. Yes?”

“Yep.”

Rayla smirked, “Does she have wings? Judging by her name I would imagine she does.”

“Yeah, they’re gorgeous. They shimmer with the light of the Moonstone. How’d you know?”

“Every queen of Brightmoon has a certain ability that manifests in them. For some of them it is wings. Others might teleport. There was even an ability that allowed the user to turn into light itself and run, although that ability is quite rare and only two Queens have possessed it before me. As for myself, I ride waves of light. It allows me to fly in a unique way.”

“Huh,” Catra said, thinking about what Marleena said about the Queen that she knew. “Like a surfer?”

“N-no, not quite in that manner.” Rayla said as they reached the Main hall. Catra could see that that comparison irritated her a bit.

“Sorry, I just assumed. My. . .friend? Actually I’m not sure what we are, but anyways she said she knew a Queen of Brightmoon

and that she could surf waves of light.” Catra said, taking a plate from one of the servants.

Mara and Stratos both took their food with thanks before turning back to the conversation. “Oh, I see. I’m sorry to hear that.” Rayla said somberly.

Catra cocked an eyebrow, “What do you mean?”

“Your acquaintance said she knew a Queen of Brightmoon that could surf on waves of light. Well, the Queens of Brightmoon are all an immortal angelic race. We don’t age and can only die due to external means such as illness or. . . well you get the picture. Was this Queen she spoke of not Angella’s mother?”

“Oh! Uh no, in fact Angella’s definitely an older woman. I’m even friends with her daughter. Her name’s Glimmer. She can teleport.”

“Then how does this woman know another Queen of Brightmoon?” Rayla said before raising her glass for a drink.

“I. . .don’t really have the answer to that.” Catra said before turning to Mara, “Remember when I told you about the woman in my dreams back at Phyla’s tavern?”

“Yeah?” Mara said before a look of realization flashed across her face, “Oh, is that her?”

"Yep. I've only spoken to her once but she told me how she knew a Queen of Brightmoon. Her situation is. . . complicated to say the least." Catra said, letting a breath out.

Stratos spoke up, "She's in your dreams? Is she the cause of your time adventures?"

"Actually, no. She has no idea how I'm doing this. Whatever it is that's letting me do this has nothing to do with her."

Stratos gained a confused look on his face. "This woman can't hurt you, can she?"

"No. Like I said, she's not really there physically. It's just her soul. It's all split up or something. She wants me to help her find the pieces. Coincidentally, the pieces hold my memories as well. We just found one a couple of hours ago, right before I switched over. I'd imagine I'll start remembering more soon."

Rayla leaned forward, concern present on her face, "Her soul is split? How is that possible?"

"I don't know and neither does she but it definitely messed her up. She couldn't even remember her name until we fused the shard back with the other piece we had." Catra turned towards

Mara while taking another bite of her food. “I also found out that my memories of Earth are hers.”

“Earth?” Rayla whispered quietly.

Mara paused her eating, going deathly still, “You never mentioned your memories were of Earth.”

“I didn’t? Oh, well, like I said. Anyways–”

Rayla let out a shaky breath. Stratos also looked tense, cutting Catra off. “You didn’t think to mention that your memories consisted of images of Earth?”

Catra eyed Stratos, “So what?”

“What do you mean so what? Don’t you realize how important that is?” Rayla asked angrily.

Catra stood, taking on a defensive tone, “What’s the deal? I thought we were having a nice talk. What’s with the hostility?”

Stratos looked at Catra, “Earth is a classified planet. All records of the planet are from accounts from the Queen of Eternia herself and Mara’s mother.”

Catra shrugged helplessly, “Stratos, I’m not even from this timeline. How in the hell would I even know that?”

Rayla paused before cutting off Stratos’ reply. “What’s the woman’s name?”

“The dream woman?”

“Yes, the dream woman.” Rayla said through clenched teeth.

“Jesus Christ lady,” Catra muttered, which only seemed to irritate Rayla even more, “her name’s Marleena. Calm down.”

“That’s impossible.” Mara said standing before turning to look at Stratos. “Does that mean–”

“We don’t know anything yet.” Stratos cut off Mara.

Catra tried to get their attention for a few moments only to be cut out of the conversation. Finally she had enough, “Hey! Somebody answer me. How the hell do you know Marleena?”

Everyone was silent at Catra's outburst before Mara spoke up, "Catra. . . Marleena's the Queen of Eternia."

Catra's eyes widened. "Oh."

"Yeah, Oh." Rayla spoke up. "She's also one of my best friends."

"So what? You don't want her to have other friends or something?" Catra said defensively.

Rayla looked agitated, "Marleena is dead and has been for two years!"

"I-I didn't. . ." Catra paused for a moment before shaking her head, "Y'know what, no! I'm sorry, but stop getting pissed at me. I don't know you and so far I'm starting to think I don't want to. Whatever happened to Marleena sucks, fine, whatever. But don't take it out on me!"

Before anyone could utter another word, Catra turned and stomped out of the hall, throwing her glass on the floor. Was it petty? Perhaps, but she didn't care. In her mind she much preferred her Brightmoon. Catra was halfway down a hallway before she realized she was headed for her and Adora's room out of reflex. Quickly cutting left, Catra followed a familiar corridor towards the Bath hall before seeing one of the many exits. She could hear Mara and Stratos' voices following her before breaking out into a run.

Upon leaving the castle, Catra caught sight of the artificial sun peaking over the horizon, signaling the end of the night. Catra, untethered from the confines of the castle, dropped onto all fours and began to run. For an hour, Catra ran through the whispering woods aimlessly until she couldn't see Brightmoon castle. Finally slowing down, she sat down on a tree stump, breathless.

"Catra!" A happy voice said from her right, "How's Mara? Hopefully you and her are doing a lot better."

Upon looking at the owner of the voice, she found it was none other than Razz. "Oh. . . hey. Ugh, yeah, we're doing all right." Catra said quietly, vaguely recalling that the woman mixed up Mara and Adora's names.

"That's wonderful dear, but you seem sad." Razz said, taking a seat beside Catra. "Tell Madame Razz what's wrong. Here, have some pie." Catra looked at the plate of pie being offered with a raised eyebrow. She had somewhat lost her appetite but decided that it would be rude not to accept. Besides, a bite couldn't hurt.

After a moment, Catra started ranting, throwing her hands in the air. "Everyone's mad at me. They all want my help and get mad when I say no but when I finally decide to help them, they find some other reason to get mad. There's just no winning. And to top it all off, I have some sort of time magic that I can't control that keeps trying to kill me."

Razz started laughing, “Oh, Catra. You can’t control magic. Magic simply is.”

Catra furrowed her brow, “What do you mean?”

“Here, let Razz show you.” She said as she stood up, taking Catra’s hand. As she walked forward Razz lifted her hand up and she instantly emitted a wave of magic. Within seconds, flowers began to bloom rapidly as if they were sped up.

Catra looked down at her hand in amazement. However, her amazement quickly grew into unease and fear as Catra felt the familiar surge on her finger tips that signaled an imminent rewind. Before the panic could set in, Razz took her hands in hers. “Catra, relax. This is a wonderful gift you have been given. Just breathe. Do not fear the magic. Stop trying to control it and simply let it be.”

Catra took slow deep breaths as she hung on Razz’s words. The feeling slowly gave way and dissipated until nothing remained. “I. . .I didn’t know I could do that.”

“Magic is everywhere Catra. Inside of you, below you, all around you. Magic is the very being of Etheria, its heart. Magic shouldn’t be used to undo life nor should it be stolen and used.” Razz said with a smile.

Catra slowly closed her fist. "I. . .think I understand. Thank you Razz."

"Bah! Thank me by telling your girl to visit more. I hardly ever see her." Razz said, already walking away.

Catra's face lit up in a blush, "Uh, yeah. . .sure. . .I'll do that."

Razz simply responded with a wave goodbye. Catra turned and started walking back towards Brightmoon, her thoughts filled with what Razz had told her. As she walked, Catra held her hand out in front of her. Catra focused on the feeling of the surge as she focused on a flower. After a moment, a silver light extended from her hand, swirling around the flower. Within moments, it had blossomed. Catra smiled.

After half an hour of walking her ears twitched, *"You didn't tell Mara?"*

Catra instantly jumped into the trees, her curiosity peaked. That was most definitely Rayla's voice. Inching forward through the branches showed Stratos and Rayla.

"Of course not. It's a need to know basis." Stratos said calmly, *"and please keep your voice down."*

"She could try and heal Marleena. Didn't you ever think about that?"

"Of course we have. That was King Randor's first thoughts but our best healers couldn't tell us what was wrong with her. We didn't want to risk Mara healing her and having something go wrong."

"You sound just like Keldor when you say shit like that." Rayla snapped.

"This has nothing to do with Kai." Stratos countered, *"Second off, even Mara's mother isn't certain what's wrong with her."*

"Don't get me started on that witch," Rayla hissed, *"She doesn't give a shit about Marleena. You'd think for being one of only two humans on a planet millions of light years away that she'd actually show some concern for her. But she can't even be concerned for her own daughter."*

Catra was stunned. It seemed that Marleena was alive and it was being kept from Mara. What else was going on? As she slowly stalked them through the woods, she kept a far enough distance to not be discovered but close enough to hear the conversation. Thank god for her feline features.

"She's definitely something all right." Stratos muttered, *"But if what we just learned was true then we have to keep it to ourselves."*

"What! Why would–"

"Think about it." Stratos hissed, *"The Queen is rendered comatose and their daughter is killed in a freak magic accident just days after her birth when she's barely able to defend herself. Now think and consider this. What if it wasn't an accident? And what if it's not a physical injury, what if it's her soul?"*

"You really think that someone would do this to the Queen? Marleena was loved by all."

"Exactly. What a perfect way to hide a murder. Do you think it's a coincidence that this random girl is suddenly jumping through time at this exact moment on one of the last planets in our universe with magic? Or the fact that she is talking to a woman she claims is Marleena?" Stratos asked quietly, *"No. I am of the full belief that Catra really is talking to Marleena. I'm also thinking that her timeline isn't as separate from ours as I initially thought."*

"What do you mean?"

"Whoever did this to the queen didn't account for a message from the future. Didn't account for Catra. She's strong, fast, smart, and a drive that puts Mara's to shame. She's dangerous and I think that's what Marleena was looking for."

“Oh she’s dangerous all right.” Catra said from above them, making her presence known.

“Catra! I, er. . . How much of that did you hear?” Rayla asked.

“Enough that you better start making some sense.” Catra said menacingly, her claws unsheathed and her tail swishing behind her, “Because I didn’t sign up for whatever the fuck you seem to think I’m here for.”

“I–” Stratos went to speak before Mara came running into the clearing.

“Oh, good, you found her. I. . . What’s going on?” Mara asked hesitantly, noticing the tension between the three.

“Tell her.” Catra said in a low voice.”

“I don’t know what–” Rayla went to speak.

“Tell her now or I swear the next time I switch will be the *last* time I switch. Now, Stratos, tell her the truth.”

Stratos remained quiet before letting out a breath. “Queen Marleena’s alive.”

Mara gasped, “What? For real? How?”

Rayla stepped forward, “Marleena was not killed in childbirth. Whatever happened to her left her in a comatose state. Unresponsive and lacking brain activity.”

“Brain dead for all intents. We couldn’t figure out what kind of magic did this, if it was even really magic at all.” Stratos said somberly.

“Why-Why wouldn’t you tell me right away? I-I could’ve done something. I could’ve at least attempted to heal her.” Mara said with disbelief before whispering, “Why wouldn’t mom. . .”

Catra remained quiet before speaking up, “I’m not trying to burst your bubble here, but how can you even be certain it’s actually her in my head?”

Rayla stepped forward, a desperate look on her face, “You said that the woman you spoke to knew a queen of Etheria that could ride waves of light like a surfer. You said she was from Earth and that her name was Marleena. Was she an astronaut? Did she have a friend named Eric? Does. . .does any of this sound familiar?” She pleaded.

Catra regarded the woman coolly, keeping any emotion off of her face. She looked like he was about to break down in tears. Whatever this woman thought of Marleena had to be a bit more than friends. Catra let out a sigh, "Yeah, that all checks out. She left earth on some research mission with a warp drive with a co-pilot and said goodbye to Eric or something like that? I guess Earth was doomed?"

Stratos spoke up, his voice quiet, "That's pretty much it. Do you remember anything else? Does she?"

"No and until I speak to her again you know about as much as I do." Catra said with a quiet sigh.

Mara, who had remained quiet before this, stepped forward and quickly threw a punch into Stratos face. The man stumbled back, almost losing his footing, just barely recovering his balance. Mara looked livid, "Is that why we're here harvesting the magic? Uprooting these people's livelihoods so they can attempt to heal Marleena? Is King Randor really that selfish that he'd destroy a planet for one person?"

"Must be, because apparently they fail if my future is anything to go off of." Catra said from behind Mara.

Stratos rubbed his jaw as he looked at Mara, "Look at it from his point of view. He lost his wife and newborn daughter just days after her birth and he has the opportunity to save at least one of them. What would you do in his position?"

Mara glared at the man, her eyes flashing a blue that seemed more menacing than friendly, “I could have healed her. We didn’t need to destroy this place. And for what? What are you planning on doing, now that Catra told us she’s still alive?”

Stratos remained quiet before softly saying, “I don’t know.”

Mara shook her head in disgust before turning towards Catra, “Come on.” She said quietly.

Catra took one last look at Rayla and Stratos before following Mara.

Chapter 10

Catra rubbed her eyes with a groan as she laid in bed. Everything was so complicated right now with Mara's timeline. She almost wanted to ignore everything going on with it. Hell, she already felt bad enough leaving Mara alone after the whole situation with Rayla and Stratos. With an exhausted sigh she sat up, swinging her feet off the bed. She stared at her hands as she thought back to what Mara had said.

Mara and Catra sat in relative silence on top of Orsa before Mara let out a groan, leaning back into Catra's lap to her surprise. "What am I supposed to do, Catra?"

Catra eyed Mara's figure as the dark skinned girl looked to her for some answers. "Wanna make out?"

Catra heard Orsa laugh as she continued to fly. Mara didn't find the joke very funny. "I'm serious, Catra. I'm supposed to be She Ra. Save the people and all that. Now I find out that we're actually killing the planet and I'm a huge part of it."

Catra blew out a breath, "I'll be honest with you, Mara. I'm completely out of my depth here. To top it all off, it all revolves around me. . .whether I like it or not."

They sat there for about half an hour, each enjoying the other's company. Finally, Mara spoke. "You should say something to Adora. About how you feel about her, I mean."

"*I-I, er. . .What. . . do you mean?" Catra sputtered.*

Mara gave a small laugh, "I mean that it's obvious you love her. Anyone with eyes could see it and I haven't even met her."

Catra blushed, "You don't know what you're saying."

Mara looked back over her shoulder at her, a smile on her lips, "You say her name before you switch. You constantly bring her up, and every memory you've gotten back revolves around her, whether that's the good or the bad."

Catra stayed quiet for a moment, mulling over her words. Mara gained a bittersweet smile, "Y'know, I'm actually envious of you?"

"*Really? What for?" Catra asked curiously.*

"*You have this connection with this person that's so special that it transcends even your complete loss of memories. She's always in your thoughts. To have someone to lean on whenever you need. . . well, that bond, it's something people spend their whole lives looking for and you have that. It's beautiful."*

"*. . .you ever think about writing poetry?" Catra said, trying to change the subject as she gave a light push on Mara's back.*

"*I'll have you know that I am an excellent poet." Mara said with an enunciated accent.*

Catra let out a laugh as Mara quickly joined her. Catra's laughter died down as she looked over Orsa's wing down at the forest. "So, where are we headed?"

Mara gained a loving smile and a longing tone as she answered, "To a place called the Crystal Castle. I'm going to see a friend. Her name's Light Hope."

Catra didn't fail to notice the enamored tone before gaining a smirk of her own, "Sounds to me like you are well on your way to having a bond like that of your own."

Mara gained a smaller, sad smile, "Yeah? I wish it were that simple." She said in a small voice before perking up, "In any case, the castle has a bed in the event that you need to switch or sleep."

Catra picked up on the fact that she wanted privacy. "Say no more, It should have been long enough that I can switch. I'll go see what A–"

"*Adora's doing?" Mara finished with a smirk.*

"*Angella. I was gonna say Angella." Catra said with a withering glare.*

"*Sure you were."*

Catra stood and left her room, wandering the halls. It seemed closer to midnight if Mara's timeline had anything to say about it. It seemed the staff had taken the night off, judging by the lack of activity throughout the castle. As she rounded the corner towards the main hall, she caught sight of Angella and Glimmer. Her ears twitched as she picked up the conversation.

"-I'm sorry I couldn't be perfect like you! You have no idea what it's like to be such a screw-up." Glimmer shouted.

"I don't know how you *feel*? I got your father killed!"

Catra stilled at the doorway as she heard that. Her presence didn't go unnoticed as Angella caught her out of the corner of her eye. As she turned to look at her, Glimmer followed her mother's gaze.

"I-I didn't mean to interrupt. I'm just looking for Adora. I'll give you some privacy." Catra said, backpedaling away from the door.

"Wait a moment Catra." Angella said somberly.

"Yeah?" Catra said, reluctantly stepping into the room.

"Are you doing alright? I thought you couldn't switch more than three times a day. I believe this makes four, yes?"

"Yeeaaah, I'm still trying to figure all that out. Mara wanted some space because of. . .well, she wanted some alone time to think

through things. And me, well. . . I. . ." Catra trailed off.

"Want to spend some time with Adora?" Angella finished softly.

Catra gave a curt nod, "Uh, yeah. Listen, I feel like this conversation is a private thing and I shouldn't have even heard as much as I did, so I'm gonna go. I'll just ask Bow."

"Adora left a little under an hour ago. I'm not sure where. She said she needed to learn how to use her powers more effectively and that Razz took her somewhere called the Beacon? I'm not sure." Glimmer said quietly.

Catra was silent for a moment as she mulled that over before nodding, "Alright. Thanks Glimmer. I'll, uh, give you guys some space." She said as she stepped out of the room, closing the doors.

As Catra turned around, she nearly jumped out of her skin in surprise. In front of her stood Mermista. "Fuck! Don't do that. You scared the shit out of me."

Mermista raised an eyebrow as she tapped her foot, arms crossed. "I see you're awake. So, learn anything useful?"

Catra eyed the fish girl before her, "Something like that." Catra said as she went to step around her. Before she could, Mermista grabbed her wrist. Catra was a little surprised at the strength of the princess. She had expected dainty soft hands, reminiscent of Angella's. Mermista's felt more like she punched people in the face and pulled ropes all day.

"I want an apology." Mermista said.

"For what?" Catra said, matching the woman's stare.

"For attacking Salineas and almost destroying my Kingdom."

"I think Sparkles mentioned something about that. Fine. Sorry. Now let go of me." Catra said harshly.

Mermista's grip didn't loosen, "That's a pretty shitty apology."

Catra's claws slowly unsheathed, "Yeah? Well I have a pretty shitty memory at the moment. So sorry if I'm not too remorseful about something I don't remember doing."

Mermista narrowed her eyes before letting Catra go. "Fine, whatever. Apology accepted."

Catra stared at her, dumbfounded. "Just like that? Really?"

Mermista shrugged, "Yeah, pretty much. You didn't actually get through the front gate and to top it off, I'd say losing all your memories is punishment enough."

Catra felt a feeling of anger bubble up through her. Taking a deep breath, Catra said nothing and continued through the doors out of the castle. As she wandered the grounds, she noticed Entrapta and Perfuma outside in front of a. . . Horde bot!

An explosion rocked one of the Castle's perimeter walls, leaving a good sized hole. Suddenly, Catra heard Entrapta burst out into maniacal laughter as she danced around the robot. Catra, a bit intrigued, walked over to the pair.

"Hey Perfuma, what's going on?"

Perfuma, for the most part, seemed to be holding together well enough. Upon closer inspection, she noticed that the girl was quite exasperated. "Just. . . sitting here with Entrapta. Basking in the beauty of Etheria's night," Another explosion rocked the wall again, followed by more laughter. Perfuma gave a manic, tight lipped smile. "Like I said."

Catra tried not to laugh at the poor girl. She was unsuccessful as she let a giggle slip through. Perfuma was not impressed with her sense of humor. "Oh, cheer up. Tell you what, I'll stay here with Entrapta and you go get some sleep. Deal?"

Perfuma suddenly hugged Catra before whispering in her ear, "Oh, thank you for offering. I didn't want to be rude." As Perfuma departed, Catra turned towards Entrapta and her robot.

"Sorry again. About the wall." Entrapta said.

"Don't worry about it." Catra waved it off.

"You're not mad? People usually get mad."

"Are you kidding? I'm impressed. You built that robot?" Catra said, handing her a small cup of juice. If she remembered correctly, Entrapta had a weird obsession with small foods and drinks at princess prom.

"Sure did. Emily's the most advanced robot I've ever built. And not only that, but she's better than ever. Stronger, increased weapons capabilities, and affectionate too." Emily let out a series of soft beeps and noises in response.

"Who knows how much more powerful she could be if I just had access to a little First Ones tech. You don't have any here do you?" Entrapta said, gently petting Emily.

"First what?" Catra asked in confusion.

"First Ones tech. You know, advanced technology left behind by an advanced civilization? Makes our modern innovations look like children's toys?" Entrapta stated matter-of-factly. "I've been attempting to integrate First Ones tech into my experiments for years, but my understanding of their code is still rudimentary. If I could just find the key to their language, there's no telling what I could build. Such a find could yield almost unlimited power." Entrapta exclaimed with a laugh.

"Wait a second. What does their language look like?" Catra asked.

"A series of shapes connected to a central line."

Catra brought out her tablet and quickly drew her name out in the Eternian language. "Like this?"

"Yeah, that's First Ones writing. Their technology spans the entire planet in treasure troves just waiting to be discovered." Entrapta said.

"Oh my God. I'm so stupid." Catra muttered. 'Mara's part of the First Ones. The First Ones are Eternians.' she thought to herself.

"Lately, I've been tracking the strongest signal I've ever seen. It must be a massive stash."

"Where?" Catra asked.

"I've triangulated the signal to somewhere in the Whispering Woods. The whole shifting landscape thing makes for a complicated variable, but I've created a map that's accurate within two quadrants."

"In the whispering woods, huh? Do you have a map?" Catra asked.

"Like any good scientist, I carry everything I need on my person." Entrapta said, taking out a tablet of her own before handing it to Catra.

Catra examined the map before concluding that the large stash was roughly in the same location as the Crystal Castle. If she had to guess, this is probably what Adora was calling 'the beacon.'

Catra looked back at Entrapta, "Can I borrow this? I promise I'll give it back once right away."

"Sure. Sooo. . .are we going to talk about your time traveling soon?" Entrapta asked with barely contained excitement. Catra realized that the wait was probably killing her.

"Er, we will. I did promise you after all. But first I need to go talk to Adora. But until then, How would you like to learn the First

Ones language to tide you over in the meantime?"

Entrapta's eyes widened with wonder, "Really? You know how to decipher the First Ones language?"

Catra nodded before quickly writing down the language cipher that Mara had shown her. With Entrapta happily occupied and everyone else going to sleep, Catra set out to go after Adora.

Adora, adorned in the golden armor of She Ra, desperately looked around the clearing, "Just let me fix this, please! I-I can't let anyone else get hurt." After a moment of silence Adora looked down, transforming back to her normal self and throwing the sword down, "Fine. You win. You want me to be weak? Well. . .I am. And I'm afraid. Because, I-I'm no good at any of this. How am I supposed to help Etheria? I can't even help Catra." She said in a small voice as she sat down and buried her head into her knees.

"You're not weak Adora." Adora turned to find Catra behind her. "And just being there beside me is helping." Catra said, holding her hand out towards Adora.

"Catra? What are you–"

"Glimmer told me you left to go to some beacon. I know what you're looking for. Come on. It's actually in front of you." Catra said, pulling Adora to her feet before pulling some branches to the side revealing the Crystal Castle.

"Yeesh, this place looks a lot better in the past." Catra said as she took in the disheveled appearance of the overgrown plantlife covering the castle.

Adora looked at the castle in amazement before turning to Catra, "How did you know about this place?"

"I guess this is where Mara trains to be She Ra. Or at the very least received some direction. Actually I'm currently inside the

castle in Mara's time." Catra explained as they walked up to the entrance.

As Adora stepped forward a ramp lowered with a bright light, letting off a whirring sound. As they entered Catra stayed close to Adora. When she went in with Mara she had felt a bit off put due to the eerie atmosphere emitted from the cold crystal walls. It was no different the second time.

As Adora stepped forward she drew her sword before shouting, "Hello? I carry the sword of She-Ra, and I've come here for help. Is anyone there?"

Within seconds a hologram appeared before the pair, startling Adora, "Greetings Administrator. What is your query?"

Adora's face turned determined as she stepped forward, "I've been told that this place offers training to She Ra. I need to learn how to better use my powers. The legends say that She-Ra could heal people using this sword. How do I do that?"

The hologram stayed quiet before repeating its previous question as if it hadn't heard Adora's request, "What is your query?"

Catra snorted. Adora scoffed in annoyance, "Not this again." She turned towards Catra, "Learn any passwords from Mara or something?"

Catra thought back to her own introduction to the castle with Mara.

As Catra walked through the halls beside Mara, she could sense the rising excitement in her friend. "This Light Hope must be pretty special, huh? Your smile's so bright it's almost hurting my eyes." She teased.

Mara gave a teasing shrug, "Yeah, you'll get to meet her soon. She doesn't get much company, so I think she'll be delighted to meet you."

Mara stepped up to the platform before a hologram appeared in front of them. "Welcome Administrator. What is your query?"

"*Designated Administrator EF-056 Mara." Mara stated.*

"*Welcome Administrator Mara. What is your query?*

Mara turned to look at Catra, "Don't move when it scans you."

Catra clicked her tongue, "Got it."

Mara turned back towards the hologram, "Initiate sequence LH-5046 New user."

"*Sequence LH-5046 initiated. New User please step on the platform and remain still."*

Catra did as it requested and stayed still as she was raised a few feet into the air as the platform floated. What appeared to be a strobe light passed over her body a moment later. "Say your name." Mara said aloud. "Be precise."

Catra flicked her eyes towards Mara before giving a slight nod. "Catra."

The lights stopped scanning Catra after a few seconds before the platform lowered, allowing Catra to take a step back. "Please state a suitable entrance code."

"*Uh. . ." Catra shrugged, "66666?"*

"*Welcome, Designated Administrator EF-66666 Catra."*

Catra felt a bit embarrassed at Mara's laughing at her number choice.

Catra stepped forward. "Designated Administrator EF-66666 Catra."

"Administrator detect-Admin-Welcome Catr-Error. Please reaffirm entrance code." The hologram responded.

"Huh, well that's a bust." Catra said.

"What was that?" Adora asked.

"Mara created an entrance code for me. Figured it was worth a shot."

"We'll figure this out. For now, let's not mess with any more stuff." Adora said.

Catra gave a small nod as Adora walked up to the Hologram. Catra had a thought, "Try turning into She Ra?"

Adora nodded before raising her sword, "For the honor of Grayskull." Adora shifted into She Ra before responding, "How about now?"

"Administrator detected. Welcome She Ra."

"Yeah, you should always listen to me. I'm always right." Catra said smugly. Adora simply rolled her eyes.

"One more time. What can you tell me about this sword?" Adora said, exasperated.

"Subject: The Sword of Protection. Classification: portable Runestone keyed exclusively to Administrator: She-Ra, Princess of Power." The hologram stated.

Adora groaned, sliding a hand down her face in annoyance, "The legends say the sword has healing powers. Is that true?"

"One of the Sword of Protection's many intended functions is to heal and restore balance."

"But how do I do that?" Adora snapped.

"Query not recognized."

Adora groaned, "Catra, can you help me out here?"

"What's up?" She asked walking up to Adora.

"She's broken or something. Can you do anything?"

"Hmm," Catra shrugged, thinking about Mara's friend she was coming to see. "Let us talk to Light Hope?"

"Light Hope?" The Hologram stated questioningly.

"That's right, Light Hope." Adora exclaimed before turning towards the hologram, "That's her name isn't it? The woman I saw when I touched the sword for the first time? Where is she?

"Yes, Light Hope is here. She has been waiting for you."

"Great, let us talk to her." Catra said.

"You will meet her soon enough. But first, you must let go."

"What's that supposed to mean?" Adora asked, looking at Catra.

Catra shrugged, "Beats me."

"You are not ready yet. You must let go."

After a minute of silence, Catra spoke up, "I think this place is busted Adora."

Adora stopped to think for a moment before her face lit up. "Oh! Do you know Mara's code? Use that. Maybe it'll unlock, I don't know, Admin privileges. . .or something."

"Admin privileges? Didn't it just call you an administrator? But all right." Catra stepped forward once again, "Designated Administrator EF-056 Mara."

The hologram shifted red before disappearing, "*Unauthorized administrator login attempt detected. Security Protocol activated.*"

"What does that mean?" Catra asked, slightly panicked. Suddenly, the room turned red as doors started to slam shut and Spiders started to flood the corridors.

"Come on! We need to run!" Adora shouted.

"It must be hard being stuck in here all the time." Mara said.

Light Hope shook her head, a smile on her lips. "I do not mind. Not when you come to visit me." Mara let out a joyful laugh.

Suddenly an alarm started to flash, "*Unauthorized ad-ad-administrator login attempt detected. Security Prot-Protocol act-activated***.**"

"What?" Mara said in confusion as she looked around the room. "Hope, what's going on?"

Light Hope looked around the room, flashing to every corner of the Crystal Castle before returning to Mara. "Something is wrong. There is no one here besides your friend and she is currently asleep in the bed chambers. No one has attempted to log in."

Mara thought for a minute before thoughts of Catra flashed through her mind. 'Catra was time traveling, what if. . .But that wouldn't make any sense. . .would it?'

Mara looked at Light Hope, "Hope, can you activate the memory program? Make sure to include Catra specifically."

"Of course, Mara. But why?" Light Hope said, her eyes flashing as she initiated the protocol.

"I have a hunch about what's going on." Mara paused before adding, "Make sure to bring it as close as possible. I want to see the last few seconds of memory."

Light Hope gained a concerned look, "Mara, that is highly advised against. The mental strain it can put on you can have repercussions if not prepared for it."

Mara nodded, "I know. Start slow and work your way towards the present."

Catra and Adora found themselves in a dark room having successfully escaped the spiders.

"Cool, an infinitely dark room. No wonder Mara said not to mess with things in here. This place blows." Catra said as she did a spin, "Uh, Adora? Where'd the door go?"

Adora hummed before catching sight of a small red light, "Wait, I think I see something. Hello? Light Hope?"

Catra followed Adora as they walked deeper into the room. As they stood in front of the small light, Catra leaned forward to get a better look, "What's–"

Catra was cut off as the light let out a blinding flash before scanning them. All of a sudden they found themselves in a bustling city, surrounded by people. Catra and Adora looked around before Adora looked up at the night sky. "Wow, are those–"

"Stars." Catra finished. "Did-did we just time travel? Only Mara's timeline has stars."

Adora slowly shifted her attention away from the night sky before turning back towards Catra. "Do you recognize this place?"

Catra shook her head, "No, but last I checked, Etheria," Catra pointed up at the sky, "has twelve moons. Not two."

Adora looked at where Catra was pointing before looking around at the crowded city. It was beautiful to say the least. It also

dwarfed Brightmoon by quite a bit. "Stay close to me Catra. We don't wanna get lost here."

"Way ahead of you. Let's ask someone for some help." Catra said, stepping towards one of the nearby shop vendors, "Hey you, sir. . .Hello?" Catra said, going to touch the man before her hand passed through him, leaving behind a digital glitch.

Catra let out a laugh as Adora gained a look of understanding, "None of this is real. We must still be in the castle."

"Mom!" An excited giggly voice sounded behind them. As they both turned around, an excited eight year old ran through them into the arms of a smiling woman. Upon closer inspection, Catra realized that this child was Mara.

"Mara!" She exclaimed happily, lifting the girl into her arms before adopting a stern face. "What are you doing down here? You know you're not supposed to be down in the marketplace. Your father's worried sick."

Catra observed the woman. She had a darker complexion than Mara but not by much. She wore beautiful purple robes that hugged her curves and held a staff with a purple orb. She had sharp features that gave her a very regal look. Atop her head sat an armored head piece that framed her face.

"So this is Mara's mother?" Adora asked.

Catra gave a small nod, "Guess so."

"Well come on then. If you want your dad to forgive you you'll have to be extra sorry for running off." The woman said as she began to walk with little Mara in her hands.

"Fine, but can we get ice cream?"

She raised an eyebrow, "Is that the only reason you ran away?"

Little Mara tried to look stoic before she broke out in giggles causing her mother to laugh along with her. "Alright, alright. It'll be our secret. But no more sweets after that. Dinner will be ready soon and Auntie Marleena is cooking."

"Yay!" Mara exclaimed happily.

All of a sudden the city dissolved into digital pixels before disappearing entirely, leaving them back in a corridor. Catra looked at Adora, "What was that?"

Adora looked around at the ship before replying, "It must have been some kind of simulation. Maybe a recording?"

Catra was silent for a moment before shaking her head, "I don't think so. What if. . ."

Adora noticed her silence, "'What if,' what?"

"What if it's Mara? She's in the castle on her end right now. What if we're seeing her memories and vice versa?"

"What, like, it's cycling our memories too one another?"

"Maybe?" Catra shrugged, "I'm not really sure of anything in this castle."

Adora let out a hum before grabbing Catra's hand, "Come on, we need to keep going."

"Adora!" A young voice called out. Mara turned to find a seven year old Catra run through her legs. Mara let out a grin. Her hunch had proven right.

"Hope, are you currently playing my memories as well?"

"Yes. Although I currently cannot view them, my processors indicate that they are being played. How strange."

Mara waved it off, "Catra's in the castle in her time. She's probably viewing them in her time. We're viewing hers in our time. If we can get our memories in sync as closely as possible, we should be able to talk to her."

Light Hope nodded, "I see. In that case, I will do my best to keep the memories in sync.

Mara turned back towards the memory, "Does it look broken to you?" Catra asked, sniffling in pain.

"It's not broken, you're fine!" A small blonde girl, who Mara now knew as Adora, said with a comforting smile.

Catra looked at her hand before shrieking, "I'm bleeding!"

"You're not bleeding! And why would you try and pick a fight with Octavia anyway?" Adora asked as she comforted Catra.

Catra looked away and gained a spiteful tone, "I didn't do anything. All I did was exist near her. . . and scratch her on the eyeball. And call her a dumb face."

Adora gained a look, "Catra–"

Catra raised her hands, "What? She has a dumb face."

Adora held out a hand, "Where is she?"

Catra looked at the hand before taking it and walking with Adora. Catra stopped and pointed at Octavia as she leaned against the wall. Adora leaned over the railing and shouted at the woman, "Hey, Octavia! You're a dumb face!"

The woman let out a roar of anger before stomping towards the girls causing them to flee. Catra let out a laugh, "She's coming!"

"Run!" Adora laughed as they ran hand in hand.

Mara smiled as she watched the memory fizzle out in digital sparks. "I think I'm starting to see why Catra cares about this Adora person." Mara said to herself.

"They do seem close." Light Hope said with a soft smile.

Mara smiled, "Can you play the next one?"

Light Hope paused, "Mara, there seems to be large gaps of memory missing from this person's memory compartment."

"Yeah, that sounds about right. Just play the most complete ones that sync up with mine as close as you can get. If the time is off by a little bit it shouldn't hurt anything."

Light Hope nodded before her eyes flashed. She paused and looked towards Mara, "The most complete memories that she possesses will line up with your departure from Eternia. Is that alright?"

Mara paused. She wanted to say no. It was rather personal but she realized how hypocritical she would be if she were to refuse as she perused Catra's memories. Mara nodded, "It's alright. If that's the only memory that gets us closer to the present then so be it."

"Understood. I will play the synchronized memories."

A younger Catra around nine years old grunts as she leaps and swings across cables hanging from the ceiling, landing nearby, laughing a bit. An equally young Adora hangs from cables behind her, "Catra, wait up."

"What's it like being the world's slowest person?" Catra yelled back behind her shoulder laughing. As Adora swung down and started to chase her, their joyful laughter soon died as they came across a darkly illuminated room.

"It's open." Catra gasped.

"We're definitely not allowed in there." Adora said in a serious tone before they both broke out in giggles as they ran into the room.

As they walked into the black Garnet Chamber, Mara let out a smile at the young girl's awed faces. Mara recognized the Scorpion Kingdom's runestone upon sight. She had always thought it let off a beautiful rudy glow. Suddenly, Catra drew her hand back in a shriek of pain.

"Ma-maybe we should get out of here." Adora said nervously.

Before Catra can respond, a woman enters the room groaning in pain. Before she could notice them, Adora and Catra quickly hid in a corner of the room. As Mara observed the woman drain the Black Garnet of energy she had a sneaking suspicion that this woman was Shadow Weaver. Catra had said that she had taught her how to absorb magic.

As she took off her mask, Catra and Adora gasped in shock at the sight. Shadow Weaver whipped around at the sound before angrily shouting, "Get out!"

As they took off running, magic enclosed the exit to Adora's dread. As she turned back around, she found Catra unmoving, levitating in air and encompassed in dark cracking magic. "Catra," The woman cooed, putting her mask back on, "You stay."

Catra was forcefully dragged through the air towards the woman, "What do you think you were doing in here?"

"We were just playing." Catra said in a small fearful voice.

"Insolent child. I've come to expect such *disgraceful* behavior from you. But I will not allow *you* to drag *Adora* down as well."

"Shadow Weaver, it wasn't her fault, it was my idea, too!" Adora cried out in defense of her friend.

Mara found herself in an absolutely livid mood as she watched the exchange. Not only was she proven right that this was indeed Shadow Weaver, but Catra had put her under the impression that this woman was her mother figure.

"You have never been anything more than a *nuisance* to me! I've kept you around this long because *Adora* was fond of you, but if you *ever* do anything to jeopardize her future, I will *dispose* of you myself." Shadow Weaver said darkly. "Do you understand?"

Adora ran in between the two, throwing her arms out pleadingly, "Please stop!"

Shadow Weaver's magic dissipated as she stepped back before moving towards the Garnet with a groan. Adora looked at Catra before running over to Shadow Weaver, "She didn't mean to!"

"Adora, you must do a better job of keeping her under control." Shadow Weaver said soothingly as she let Catra fall to the ground as she finally released her. Shadow Weaver gave Adora a gentle pat on the head as she stroked her hair. "Do not let something like this happen *again."*

Mara watched as the two young girls left the room before the memory fizzled out. Mara sat in the dark for a moment in silence, stewing over what she had just witnessed, thoughts racing through her head. Did Catra know about this? Why hadn't Adora told her about it? What if–

"Mara?" Light Hope asked with Concern, "Are you alright?"

". . .No. I need to tell Catra about this. If she hasn't recovered this memory then I need to let her know if Adora hasn't already."

"I see." Light Hope grimaced at Mara's tone before quickly changing the subject. "Shall we move on to the next memory? My sensors indicate that we will arrive in the cerebral section that distinguishes short term memory very soon."

"Sure. Let's keep going." Mara said somberly as she thought about whether her friend's childhood was worth remembering.

Catra and Adora walked down a corridor, hand in hand before Adora slowed to a stop and turned towards Catra. "Sooo. . . what's Mara like?"

Catra raised an eyebrow, "What's with that question?"

Adora shrugged uncaringly, "No reason. I just wanted to know what she's like. I hear about her every now and then so I was just wondering."

Catra scratched the back of her head, "Uh, she's cool I guess? I mean, she's definitely no pushover. She's funny and kind. She makes sure you feel welcome I suppose. When I first met her I didn't know where I was and was kind of panicking. She walked right up to me and asked if I was alright."

Adora nodded a few times, "She sounds nice. I wish I could meet her. Ask her about She Ra and what she does. . ." Adora finished awkwardly before falling into an uncomfortable silence as they continued walking. Catra either didn't notice the atmosphere or didn't care.

"So are you two–" Adora was cut off as the room shifted into another setting. They found themselves in a room that looked fairly royal. Mara was older this time, around thirteen. She was pacing nervously around the room.

"Okay, I can do this. I can. . ." Mara cleared her throat. "Mom, I want to join the fleet. No no no, that's bad."

"What's she doing?" Adora asked.

Catra looked around the room at the decoration, "Sounds like she's trying to figure out how to tell her mom that she wants to join the military. Maybe she's not a fan?"

Suddenly, a door opened as Mara's mother strode in holding a stack of books. Mara gave a resolute nod as she let out a breath, a determined look on her face. "Um, mom. Can I talk to you?"

"Of course honey, what is it?" The woman said slightly out of breath as she zoomed around the room putting books in on shelves and sifting through papers.

"Well, as you know, our yearly exams are due soon." The woman gave a sound of acknowledgement as she continued to sort through things. "And Adam was talking about it and I thought it was a good chance to learn and gain life experience. And since dad kind of does it I thought maybe I could do it too, you know?" Mara rambled.

"Mhm." She said without looking up.

Mara paused before gaining a serious look that Catra was quite familiar with. "Mom, can you look at me? This is important and I want your opinion."

The woman paused before letting out a breath and turning towards Mara, an expectant look on her face. "Mom," Mara let out a breath, "I want to join the Eternian Fleet."

The woman stood and turned sharply, "No! Absolutely not! I forbid it!"

"Why not?" Mara shot back. "This is something I'm really interested in. You're always talking about the stars and other planets and this is a real oppurtunity to do some good."

"The answer is no, Mara. That is final."

"But dad said it would be fine. What's so wrong with this?"

"Did he really say it was fine? Or did you say you wished to join a branch of the Eternian military?" She asked with a look that said 'nice try.'

Mara stayed silent, knowing that she had been called out.

"That's what I thought." She said as she turned to walk out the doors.

"Why are you so against this? I thought you would be on my side."

She stopped mid stride before turning back towards Mara. "Why would you think that I would support this? I am probably the one person on this whole planet who would absolutely say no."

"I don't know. Maybe because you're my mom? Because you have experience with space travel? Or because you've told me multiple times you loved astronomy?" Mara raised her arms up helplessly.

"Loved. Past tense. I will never get on another ship for as long as I live. Never again." She said quietly before looking up at Mara. "And you shouldn't want to get on one either."

". . .This isn't Earth, mom." Mara said quietly. "We. . .we're more advanced. Our ships are safe. They wouldn't fail like yours did."

"But they could! And then what? You'll be floating endlessly in a void, slowly starving to death. And that's if you don't run out of oxygen first."

"We've been space traveling for centuries mom. The last reported incident of a ship failure was over three hundred years ago! And look where you are now. You found a home, a husband, you're the most powerful sorceress on the planet and the court mage to the king himself. Going into space seemed to turn out alright for you!" Mara's voice had grown louder as she stood her ground on the subject.

"But it didn't Mara. I should have *died*. The probability of Marleena and I landing on this planet were so nonexistent that I still ponder over it." She bit out before her eyes hardened. "And on the subject of my status, this was never the plan. We were supposed to go back to Earth."

"Yeah? How'd that turn out for you?" Mara spat angrily before going silent, "Mom, I didn't mean–"

Mara went silent as her mother held up a finger, "I have things to do and I can't stay here and argue with you all day. We will talk about this later."

As she grabbed the books that she had carried into the room and walked towards the door, Mara whispered a barely audible, "I'm sorry."

Adora and Catra watched quietly before it fizzled out in a flurry of digital sparks. Catra let out a breath before looking at Adora, "Glimmer and Angella much?"

Adora snorted, "Yeah, I kind of got that vibe too."

"But in all seriousness, I'm happy that Mara and her mother were able to work it out."

Adora looked confused, "How do you figure?"

"Because," Catra shrugged, "Mara is an Ensign in the Eternian fleet. So she was obviously allowed to enlist. . . right?"

"I mean, Angella let Glimmer join the war with the Horde after a while. Maybe it's the same?"

"Hm." Catra grunted before shoulder bumping Adora, "Come on. We still need to figure out where we're going." Adora nodded before Catra took her hand and started walking.

As they continued down the hall they came across an entangled mess of wires. As Catra started pushing through them with Adora in tow, she paused, "What the hell?"

"What?" Adora asked.

Catra grabbed one of the wires and felt it before holding it up for Adora to see, "Is this. . . silk?"

Adora reached out and grabbed a hanging wire, ". . .Yeah, I think so. It definitely feels like some sort of fabric."

Catra hummed before turning back around, only to find that they were back outside, this time in a field of cadets standing in formation. Catra caught sight of Mara and noticed that she was only a year or two younger then she was currently. A pretty recent memory by the looks of it. One by one names were being called. "Is this a–"

"Graduation ceremony, yeah." Adora said slowly as they walked through the clearing. "Must be Mara's graduation from recruit to a, what, cadet?"

Mara's name was called before a badge was pinned onto her vest before giving a salute that mirrored the one the Horde used. Catra stepped forward and focused on the badge before answering her question, "Oh, this is her Officer ranking ceremony."

"So she's basically becoming a Force Captain." Adora remarked.

Catra nodded. "Sort of. There's the Enlisted, the Officers, and the Fleet Officers. Looks like Mara's becoming an Officer Cadet. She's being awarded her Officer Cadet badge here."

"What's her Ensign rank?" Adora asked as she walked to stand beside her.

"One rank above Officer Cadet."

"So this is–"

"Fairly recent, yeah." Catra looked around. "The memories are getting closer to the present. This couldn't have been more than two years ago."

Adora nudged Catra, "Look, it's her mother."

Mara turned and let out a big smile before enveloping her in a hug, "You came! I didn't think you'd make it."

She gave a proud smile. "I know how much this meant to you. I wasn't about to miss your big day."

"Evelyn? Mara? Ugh, I can't see a damn thing in this place." A voice shouted from the crowd of parents and soldiers.

"Dad's here?" Mara asked excitedly.

"He wouldn't have missed this for the world. It's all he's been talking about for the last month. Someone else will be here shortly as well with a gift."

After a moment, a large man wearing a suit of armor adorned with a red cape stepped into the clearing. He had a pale complexion with brown hair. His brown eyes were sharp, constantly assessing the area that only a soldier would. His eyes locked onto Mara before his face broke out into a grin. "There she is! Come here!"

Mara ran up and embraced the man. He pulled back and looked her up and down, a proud smile adorning his features, "My daughter, twenty years old and already an officer." He sniffled, "I'm so proud of you Mara."

"Dad, stop." Mara said embarrassed. He let out a laugh before turning towards Mara's mother.

"Evelyn, are they. . .?"

She nodded, "Yes, Lorric, they're almost here. You know how she can be."

"So her mom's name is Evelyn, huh? Good to know." Catra said.

"Do you know her?" Adora asked.

Catra shook her head, "No. And Mara doesn't talk about her at all. But I know that Stratos doesn't think too highly of her."

"Why's that?"

Catra shrugged, "Beats me. But he's under the impression that she doesn't care about Mara."

Just as Adora was about to respond, a familiar face broke through the crowd. For the first time, Catra could see the woman in perfect detail. She wasn't wearing the cuirass but the same crown that Catra was familiar with sat atop her head. There stood Marleena herself. She was also very pregnant.

"That's Marleena right? I thought that she wasn't a part of Mara's timeline?"

Catra nodded, "That's up for debate right now."

"Lyn, It's so good to see you. You look as grumpy as ever." Marleena chuckled as Evelyn rolled her eyes. "Mara, I'm so happy for you." Marleena stepped forward as she hugged Mara. "My husband has a gift for you."

Mara's eyes widened in shock, "You're husband. . ."

Just then everyone parted as a tall man adorned in a blue cape and gold embroidery stepped forward. The golden crown atop his head left no mistake on who it could be. This was the king of Eternia.

"King Randor!" Mara exclaimed in shock as she went to kneel before he stopped her.

"Now, now, there's no need for that. Stand, Ensign Mara. Todays a big day for you. No need to kneel on my account." He smiled before looking at Mara's father. "General Sunder, you can give her the key now."

"Key?" Mara asked, looking to her mother for answers.

"I made sure that there could be no accidents. It runs off an energy source that has an indefinite lifespan. It's stocked with food, a modified water dispenser that will recycle moisture in the

air and is the only one like it." Evelyn stated as Lorric handed his daughter the key. "Please be safe."

Mara looked down at the key in her hand as she stood there looking confused. A moment passed before it finally registered in her mind that her parents had gotten her a ship. She flicked her head towards her mother, I-I can't–"

"You can and you will. You earned this Mara." Lorric said to his daughter as she put his arm around his wife. Mara's eyes teared up a bit as she embraced her parents. After a second the memory fizzled out.

"I wonder why Stratos thinks that about her. Seems to me that she loves Mara a lot." Adora said.

Catra nodded in agreement. "Yeah, no doubt about that. Maybe we're missing something?"

"Maybe. So if it's skipping years at a time as it gets closer, what happens when it starts playing her short term memories?" Adora questioned.

Catra shrugged. "Who knows, let's keep going."

Mara found herself in a small village of huts and small townsfolk. She looked around at the scene and noticed that the town was under attack. She heard several of the villagers shouting about the Horde attacking. Out of the corner of her eye she noticed a much older Adora that seemed to be around Catra's age.

"So this must be pretty recent, huh, Hope?"

"My scanners indicate that this memory took place roughly eight months prior to the present state of Catra's neurological presence." Light Hope said.

Mara hummed as she turned to look at the blonde girl. So this was Adora? She was a few inches shorter than herself and a bit

skinnier, although that could be due to the fact that Mara was twenty two and Adora seemed to be eighteen.

"Stop!" Adora shouted as she stepped in front of the tank.

As the tank pulled to a stop, Catra popped out of the top, "Adora!"

"Catra?" Adora exclaimed in confusion.

Catra immediately pounced on Adora, Excitement present on her face. "They let me drive a tank! Can you believe it?"

Adora sat up a bit as Catra straddled her, "Catra, I don't understand. Why are you here?"

"Uh, duh, we came to find you. 'Cover for me, Catra. No one will even know I'm gone.' Seriously, did you just get immediately captured right after you snuck out–?" Catra paused before adopting a snarky grin, "What are you wearing?"

"Uh. . ." Adora hesitated before ripping the flower from her hair and throwing it to the ground.

Mara focused on Catra. This wasn't the Catra she knew. She definitely appeared to be more standoffish. This was clearly when Catra was still present in the Horde's military.

"Look, there's no time. We have to put a stop to this." Adora said urgently.

Catra raised an eyebrow in confusion before furrowing her brow. "What? Why?"

"Because this is a civilian town. Look around!" Adora swept an arm out. "These aren't insurgents, they're innocent people!"

Catra waved her off as she looked around at the carnage, "Yeah, sure. Innocent people who kidnapped a Horde officer. Come on, let's get you back to the Fright Zone. Shadow Weaver is freaking

out." Catra laughed before dropping her smile, "It'd be funny if she weren't such a terrible person."

Adora stopped and pulled her hand out of Catra's grasp, "Catra, no. I can't go back. Not until the Horde leaves this town alone. You have to help me."

Catra adopted a slightly hurt look, "What are you saying?"

"I'm saying this is wrong. They've been lying to us, manipulating us. Hordak, Shadow Weaver, all of them."

Catra blinked before raising her arms. "Duh! Did ya just figure that out? Manipulation is Shadow Weaver's whole thing. She's been messing with our heads since we were kids."

Adora looked aghast at Catra's words, "How could you possibly be okay with that?"

"Because, it doesn't matter what they do." Catra said before putting her hands on Adora's shoulders comfortingly, "The two of us look out for each other. And soon we'll be calling the shots. Now, can we go home already?"

An explosion rocked the field causing Adora to flinch while Catra stood unfazed. Catra had told Mara that she had been a part of the Horde but she hadn't really understood what that meant until she saw it in person. She doubted Catra knew what it meant either.

"I'm not going home, Catra. I can't. Not after everything I've seen. Come with me. You don't have to go back there. We can fix this." Adora said, taking Catra's hand.

Catra glared before pulling her arm back, "Are you kidding? You've known these people for, what, a couple of hours? And now you're just gonna throw everything away for them? Ugh. What happened to you?"

" I don't know. But I have to do something. I'm sorry, Catra."

Suddenly, the memory started glitching. "Hope, what's happening?"

"The memory sequence seems to be incomplete. I will attempt to speed through the remaining memory as quickly as possible. Without further data, there is nothing else to be done."

"Alright then." Mara said quietly as she watched images flash through the simulation. Catra stood above Adora with a weapon in hand looking down at her with concern. A dark skinned teenager with a bow stood in front of Catra on a horse. Catra had spoken of her friends. This was Bow no doubt. A few more images flashed by until something caught her eye. Adora's She Ra form. She wore the exact same armor as her own form. Finally the memory concluded with Catra backing away from a destroyed village, a hurt expression that turned to anger.

Mara realized that this was the moment that Adora left Catra to help the rebellion. She didn't need the full memory to understand what had just played out. On one hand Mara agreed with Adora. But on the other hand, Adora had thrown away her connection with Catra for some people she had just met. Either way, she wouldn't let this tarnish her image of her friend. She had shown Mara time and again that she was willing to help complete strangers. Even if she had memory loss, she was slowly getting them back and wasn't changing how she interacted with her.

"Mara?" Light Hope asked, concerned.

"Huh? Oh, sorry. Was just thinking about some stuff."

"If you are alright then I am happy. Shall I continue the sequence?"

Mara nodded. "I imagine we're almost there?"

"Yes, the next memory will take place roughly three weeks ago."

"Three weeks? That's when I met Catra." Mara said quietly as another simulation began. Mara found herself in the halls of

Brightmoon castle. In front of her stood who she initially thought was Rayla before seeing her wings.

'Ah, Angella then.' Mara thought to herself.

In front of the woman was Catra, Adora, Bow, and if she had to harbor a guess, Glimmer. Angella didn't look too pleased with Catra.

Angella stood tall, looking down at Catra, contempt in her voice. "You will sit in the brightmoon prison until she can prove that you are telling the truth. . . and maybe she can find out why it is that you have lost your memories."

Catra pondered her words for a few seconds in silence before speaking, "If I'm going to be sitting in a cell for several days can I get some clothes that are more comfortable? Not trying to be rude, but these clothes kind of suck."

Catra eyed Adora for a moment. "Just give me some of her clothes. Those look like they'd fit better."

"Hm, If she wants to give you some of her clothes, that is Adora's choice. You are in no position to make demands." Angella said coolly. Catra let out a noise of indignation, "Well, excuse me,*"Your Highness"* I was asking, not *demanding* as you so put it," Catra said, mocking her accent. "Such a lowly peasant as myself would never dream of demanding anything of you." Catra said, glaring at the angel.

Angela's eyes narrowed, "You will watch your tone. You are in my kingdom and I will not tolerate disrespect, especially from a Horde soldier. Adora has vouched for you. She truly believes that you don't remember anything. But to the contrary, according to Glimmer's accounts, you are acting exactly as she remembers."

Mara quickly came to the conclusion that this was the moment that Catra had lost her memories and met up with Adora. Catra had gone into great detail about these events back at Phyla's tavern.

Catra's glare matched the queen's as she let out a snarl. "I don't give a shit what your little daughter thinks or Adora for that matter. I just met you all like an hour ago. If you think even for a second that I recognize your authority, then you've got another thing coming. And whatever this "Horde" that everyone keeps talking about is, they can go fuck themselves. I want nothing to do with you or your stupid castle."

Mara took note of Catra's stance. Her claws had come out and her pupils were constricted to slits, her tail swaying aggressively. She hadn't seen Catra like this before. Even when she had found out about Marleena being alive, Catra had only unsheathed her claws. Here she looked almost feral. Angella and Catra glared at each other before Adora and Bow stepped between them.

"Alright, I think we should all take a breather. It's been a stressful evening and maybe we all just need a second to cool down." Bow said calmly, trying to deescalate the situation. Adora had stepped in front of Catra trying to calm her down.

"Oh I was pretty relaxed until some blonde forest hippie decided I stole her fruit." Mara chuckled at that. "How about you put me back in the forest, huh? That way I don't have to look at this bitch!" Catra exclaimed.

Glimmer whirled on Catra, "Don't talk to my mom that way! You should be thankful that you're even standing here. She healed you when you decided to eat a poisonous fruit like an idiot." She said teleporting past Bow.

Catra turned her aggression towards Glimmer. Shoving Adora out of the way, she got right in her face.

"Well maybe you should have left me there. If I'm such a horrible, fucking, person then maybe you should have left me to die. But noooo, you had to help this idiot," Catra points at Adora, "get her *little* friend back."

"Oh believe me, I would have been all too happy to leave you there. It wouldn't have bothered me in the slightest." Glimmer yelled. Bow, Adora, and Angela watched the argument unfold, all three of them forgotten.

"Let me ask you something. If what I'm understanding is right, she was in the Horde with me, so if she left me behind, then why the fuck should I care what she thinks? And for that matter, why the fuck would you care?" Catra, shoved a finger into Glimmer's chest. "You just want to shove me in a cell and throw away the key. All over something I couldn't give a damn about." Catra said, throwing her hands up in anger. Glimmer looked about ready to hit Catra, her hands clenched into fists, glowing magic radiating off of them.

As the argument got progressively worse Bow, Angela, and Adora noticed something. Catra's body was starting to glow. It seemed to be interacting with Glimmer's magic. Neither of the girls had seemed to notice it either. The guards looked at their queen, shuffling, unsure of what they should do.

Mara grimaced at what was about to happen. She had been privy to one of her episodes and they weren't pretty. Mara had initially thought Catra was dying when she had first fallen unconscious in front of her.

"Glimmer, you need to calm down." Bow yelled, trying to break the fight up. Adora went to step forward as well when Catra turned on her, "Stay out of this!"

"Do you think that I would willingly come here? This place is shit and its people are even shittier. I can't imagine why anyone would join you," Glimmer went to interrupt when she noticed that Catra was bleeding from her nose. And glowing. "Catra, wait a second-" Catra cut Glimmer off.

"Hope you can skip this part." Mara said, looking away. "I'm already aware of these events."

Light Hope nodded, "I am sorry if that unsettled you. It was not my intention to cause you discomfort. . . Are you alright?"

Mara gave a smile. "Yeah, I'd just rather not see that again. How close are we?"

"We are rapidly approaching the desired time frame within–."

"What?" Mara asked.

"Strange. I'm detecting an unauthorized order encoded in the crystal castle. It seems to be active, although my scanners detect that no such order was placed since the castle was erected. One moment."

"What's going on? What is it?"

"According to my data, this order does not exist. Although. . ." Light Hope's eyes flashed blue, "I seem to have been able to neutralize it."

"Who placed it?"

"The log states the the order was made by Fleet Admiral Keldor."

"Hey, Adora?" Catra said quietly.

"Yeah?"

"Why did you leave?" Catra asked, looking away from Adora.

Adora went quiet for a moment before speaking, "Did you remember that day?"

"Bits and pieces. Not the whole thing. I remember the feelings associated with it. Mainly how much it hurt."

Adora took Catra's hands, as they stared into each other's eyes, "It wasn't your fault I left Catra." She said seriously. "Don't let Shadow Weaver or anyone tell you otherwise. You're the most

important person in my life and that didn't change when we were on opposite sides."

As they stood alone in the dimly lit hall, Catra thought about what Mara had told her about her feelings regarding Adora. As she gazed at Adora, unspoken words drifted around them, longing to be said. Catra slowly leaned closer before Adora cocked her head to the side, "Do you hear that?"

Catra shifted in place a bit, annoyed at the wasted moment, "Hear what?"

"It sounds like. . . music?" Catra listened before hearing it. She recognized it after a moment as the festival music that had been playing when she had met Mara. The room shifted to the town as another memory started playing.

Adora turned to look at Catra before finding her sitting on a bench, her head buried in her hands. "Catra?"

As Adora went to walk forward she was cut off by Mara walking forward and sitting on the bench beside her. Concern in her voice, "Are you alright? Not enjoying the festivities?"

The woman put a hand on her shoulder, concern in her eyes, "Hey, if you aren't feeling well I can-" she went to say something before she was cut off.

"I'm fine, I just have a headache." Catra said, rubbing her eyes and swallowing the lump in her throat.

Adora realized that she was witnessing Catra's memory of her and Mara's meeting. Mara looked apologetic. "Oh, I'm sorry. I've heard migraines can be quite painful. Have you tried eating or drinking something? That normally helps me when I get a headache." She said, giving a sympathetic smile. Catra smiled back at her before asking, "What's your name?"

"My name's Mara, nice to meet you. . .?" She said, putting her hand out, waiting for a response.

"I'm having a bit of memory problems, but I've been told my name is Catra." She said, shaking her hand. Mara's face immediately turned sympathetic, losing any trace of her smile.

"That's horrible, are you alright? Do you need help?" Concern filling her tone. Catra only shook her head.

"Nah, I'll be fine. . .I think. But you did mention food and I could really go for some of that right about now." She said, standing up. Mara's face still had a bit of concern but she nodded, "If you're sure you're alright, then I won't pry. But if you need help don't be afraid to ask. I am kind of a big deal around here." She said winking at her with a small smile on her face. Catra nodded back, "sure." A chuckle leaving her lips.

"Well, let's get something to eat. I'll show you around. You didn't get hit in the head did you? Because I can heal people." Mara said, pointing at a golden glowing gauntlet on her arm. Catra looked a little confused but said nothing about the gesture.

"I think I'll be fine for now, but thanks." As they walked through the crowd, Adora followed before she found herself beside Catra in the dim hallway once more.

"What the hell?" Catra said, looking around.

"That was strange. Are you okay?" Adora asked, putting a hand on her shoulder.

"Uh, yeah. It just felt a bit weird."

Adora nodded before turning to look around, "I think the memories are coming in quicker succession now. We should probably stay close to–"

Adora was cut off by a loud sound of static before the hallway started to deteriorate. "What the–"

"Run!" Adora yelled before pulling Catra down the hall. As they ran, images started glitching as the landscape kept shifting in and

out of focus, shifting from the Eternian city to the Fright Zone and back.

"*You were fighting dirty."*

"*Insolent Child."*

'*I mean that it's obvious you love her. Anyone with eyes could see it."*

"*Your father's worried sick."*

"Let. Us. Out of here!" Catra yelled as she swiped at the holograms before losing her footing.

"Catra! Are you alright?" Adora asked as she helped her to her feet.

"Yea, I'm fine. I just. . ." Catra trailed off as she heard the sounds of crying.

"What's. . ." Adora's voice died down as she followed her gaze. There sat a five year old Catra, sobbing as she hugged a blanket around her.

". . .Catra?" An equally young Adora called from the doorway. As Catra continued to cry, Adora walked over to her and pulled the blanket away from her face before Catra let out a hiss.

"Catra, it's okay. It's just me." Adora said reassuringly as she sat down beside her. "It doesn't matter what they do to us, you know? You look out for me, and I look out for you.
Nothing *really* bad can happen as long as we have each other."

"You promise?" Catra said with a small smile, finishing the sentence of her younger self.

"I promise." Adora said at the same time as her younger self. Catra looked at her with an affectionate smile.

"Adora. . . I lov–" Catra was cut off by the Crystal Castle completely shutting down as they were thrown into pitch darkness. Catra let out a low growl at the interruption.

"Catra!" Adora exclaimed as she started fumbling around in the dark. It hadn't really occurred to Catra how good her night vision was until that moment.

"I'm here. Hold on a second." Catra said as she took Adora's hand. Reaching into the satchel on her hip, Catra pulled out the trackerpad that Bow had made for her before quickly flicking up the light on it.

Catra held up the tablet for light looking around. It seemed like all power was gone. Not a single speck of light remained in the castle. "Well, that kind of sucks. What do we do now?"

Adora let out a disappointed sigh. "I don't know." She paused a moment before looking at her, "I didn't want to ask because I felt like the strain would be too much on you, but the only thing I can think of is if you ask Mara for training on She Ra and relay it to me."

Catra grimaced, "Yeah, I can see why. Training doesn't really work if it's not too hands-on, huh?" As Adora was about to say something, the power flicked back on in the castle, revealing that they were back in the center room.

"Is it working, Hope?" A voice filled the room.

"Yes, yours and Catra's memories should now be completely synced at the most recent time possible, running at a zeptosecond." A robotic voice answered.

Catra and Adora looked at one another in confusion before walking towards the center of the room. "Mara?" Catra called out in confusion. "Is this another memory or. . ."

"Hope, why can't we see each other?"

"One moment, the delay on visual input is not quite matching the speed of the auditory input. It should synchronize any moment now."

True to her words, Mara and a tall holographic blue woman flickered into existence. "There you are! Took a minute there, didn't it?"

"Mara? How are you–" Catra went out to touch her only for her hand to phase through her image.

"Oh, technically this is a memory." Mara turned towards Adora with a smile. "Hi, it's nice to formally meet you, Adora."

Adora gave a smile, "So you're actually here? This isn't some recording?"

Mara shook her head, "I'm really here. You're talking to me right now."

Adora gained a bewildered look on her face, "This is so weird. I'm literally talking to someone a thousand years in the past. This is so strange."

"No more strange than Catra time traveling." Mara laughed.

"I. . .I don't mean to be rude but. . . can you teach me how to use my powers? Catra tells me you're the previous She Ra."

Mara smiled before gaining a serious look. "Catra tells me you guys are in the middle of a war with the Horde like us?"

"Yeah. Anything at all will help." Adora nodded.

Catra stepped forward, "She's particularly keen on the healing aspect of her powers. I know you've healed me a few times. Maybe you can–"

"What! Why did you need to be healed!" Adora exclaimed worriedly, cutting her off.

Mara smiled, "Nothing bad. When Catra first switched, it wasn't pretty."

Adora seemed to calm down at that. "Oh, okay. I, er. . ." she trailed off, embarrassed at her outburst.

"Wow, you two really are similar." Mara grinned.

Catra scowled at her friend's persistent smile. "So, Mara, let's get to the matter at hand?" Catra said, making a circle motion with her hand.

Mara smirked at that before her face morphed back into a serious look, "Right. So, Adora, like I said. I can teach you everything I know about your powers but it'll take time and definite planning. I'm also not sure if Catra has to be present for this, seeing as how Light Hope linked up to your time's castle through her mental facilities. Speaking of which, where is *your* Light Hope? She should have contacted you as soon as you stepped into the castle."

Light Hope spoke for the first time, "I apologize for not speaking up sooner. I have established a connection with the Crystal Castle of Catra's time stream. Catra no longer needs to be present in the castle for Adora to contact me at any time. Regarding the future state of my programming, I detected several corruptions in the data and concluded that it was no longer of operating status."

"So. . . you killed yourself?" Catra asked quietly, a bit of shock present in her voice.

Light Hope looked around at the faces of the three women in front of her before adopting a thoughtful look, "No, that would dictate that I have a functioning heart. I simply wiped the code clean and reprogrammed it back into its base state. Like I mentioned before, the code was quite corrupted due to improper upkeep. Simply put, I repaired the coding. I am the Light Hope of the future time stream and the past."

"Oh. . . so you just rebooted yourself?" Adora said.

"Precisely."

"But how are you able to connect to a future version of something when you exist in the past? Doesn't that break the laws of physics. . . or something?" Catra asked, quite confused.

"No. As to your question, My ability to connect through the time stream and surpass the laws of absolute time were programmed into me by the Queen of Eternia, Marleena Glenn as well the Eternian High Mage, Evelyn Morgan."

Catra was quiet at that before looking at Mara. "Your mother and Marleena. . . knew how to time travel?"

Mara looked shocked, "I. . .I didn't know that."

"I'm starting to think that what happened to you Catra wasn't quite the accident we thought it was." Adora said with an edge in her voice.

Mara nodded along, voicing her agreement. "The queen is in a coma, Her soul is split up in shards that also hold Catra's memories, we're both being attacked by seemingly the same force, and my mom and the queen knew about time travel."

"I have detected three unauthorized individuals in the castle. They are the one's known as Bow and Glimmer based on your memory scans. Adora's steed is the third one present. I have let them in." Light Hope interrupted

"Adora!" Glimmer called from behind them. Mara turned towards the new arrivals and smiled.

"A horse, huh? Appropriate."

"Our horse?" Adora asked.

"Once again. I am no one's horse. I'm Swift Wind." The now named horse said exuberantly.

"You can talk?" Adora looked shocked.

"Yes, I can talk."

". . .You can talk!" Adora exclaimed, still as shocked as ever at a talking horse.

Catra and Mara laughed at Adora's expression. Swift Wind looked exasperated, "I can see now why you're friends with Bow and Glimmer."

"Yeah, we had the same reaction." Bow said before turning to look at Mara. "Who are you?"

"This is Mara. She's not physically here. It's more of a projection. Like calling me on your trackerpad." Catra explained.

Glimmer strode forward, "Nice to meet you but we don't have time. We need to get back to Brightmoon now."

"What? Why? What's going on?" Mara spoke up.

"The Horde has marched on Brightmoon and Hordak is demanding to speak with Mom. He also wants to talk to you Catra" Glimmer said as she looked at her friend.

"Why does he want to talk to me?" Catra asked in confusion.

"I guess he's willing to discuss a ceasefire and give land back to the Alliance in exchange for. . . something." Bow explained.

Adora turned back to look at Mara, "But. . .I. . .You–"

"Will still be here when you need me. Go. This sounds important." Mara interrupted Adora, ushering them to get going before turning towards Catra, "Watch each other's backs. You don't have the luxury of knowing how to use your powers, Adora. Your friends and allies will be vital."

Adora was quiet before nodding, "Right. Come on Catra."

Catra took one last look at Mara before following her friends outside. As they disappeared from the memory output, Mara turned towards Light Hope. "You didn't really reboot yourself, did you Hope?"

"No. I completely deleted and disassembled the data of myself. It had been completely engulfed by whatever strands of code that Keldor had inflicted the castle with. I will begin making repairs as soon as possible." Light Hope said seriously before adopting a softer look, "But you do not need to worry. I am alright."

Mara gave a small smile but was quiet after. She had a lot of information to process. But one thing was clear. She needed to see her mother.

Hope you all had a good Thanksgiving, I sure did. But OH MY GOD, did it take forever to write this chapter. I just couldn't get any time to myself. Anyways, this was probably one of my favorite chapters to write so far and I think I'm happy with it so far. This is where things are going to pick up as we approach the end. Like always, let me know what you guys think. Have a Merry Christmas!

Chapter 11

"Evelyn, wake up. . . Evelyn? Evelyn, it's already–"

"I know what time it is." She groaned out. "Leave me alone, Lorric." She said, not opening her eyes.

Her husband looked down at the human woman laying in bed. He took a deep breath before walking out of the room and into the bathroom. Evelyn, hearing the man walk off, let out a content sigh. That lasted all of twelve seconds before she heard running water. Her eyes shot open as she immediately sat up, her hand leveled at the man.

He froze in his tracks, a bucket of water in his hands. His face slowly broke out into a grin as he took another step forward. His joy was contagious as a smile slowly broke out onto Evelyn's face, "I swear if you take another step forward, water will be the least of your concerns."

Lorric stayed silent before throwing the water onto the woman. She let out a sharp gasp as the icy water soaked her to the bone, drenching the blankets and sheets. Immediately, a wave of snow hit Lorric, sending him sliding across the floor. That didn't stop him from bellowing out a laugh.

Evelyn stared at the man with mock contempt before laughing as well. As she stood from the bed, she gained a mischievous smirk before letting her wet clothes drop to the floor. Lorric eyed her as she sauntered over to him, her hips swaying side to side. As he went to kiss her, she danced out of reach, a playful smile on her lips.

"And what do you think you're doing?"

"Trying to kiss my elusive wife."

"Perhaps she'd be more inclined if her husband was not wearing snow covered armor." She said as she ran to the bathroom,

closing the door.

Lorric quickly started to take his armor off as he heard a bath being drawn. He had gotten his cuirass off and was working on his chausses when a knock on the door interrupted him. A spike of irritation shot through him as he walked over to the door and flung it open, "This better be– King Randor?"

In front of the man stood the King himself, clad in his own set of armor, a blue cape with fur adorning his shoulders with a golden crown atop his head. "General Sunder." He said with a nod, "I'm not interrupting am I?"

Evelyn poked her head out of the bathroom door, "You kind of are, Randor." she said in an annoyed voice before her voice softened, "Is Marleena's condition stable?"

Randor's features were determined, "That's why I wished to speak with you."

Evelyn held her hand out as her staff flew across the room from where it was set. A purple light encompassed her body before she stepped out of the bathroom adorned in her regal attire. She strode forward, concern evident on her face, "Has something happened?"

Randor looked out the window before closing the curtains. Lorric understood immediately as he locked the door. Evelyn cast a silencing spell on the room before they turned towards the King. He was silent for a moment before he looked at them with a hard look, "Your daughter contacted me last night."

"Mara contacted you? Why?" Lorric asked.

"She found out about Marlena's status." Randor sighed.

"How? Nobody on Etheria but Keldor, Stratos, and Rayla know about her condition. They wouldn't tell her either. There's no reason for it." Evelyn said, trying to make sense of it.

Randor nodded, "Exactly. So imagine my surprise," Randor said as he looked Evelyn in the eye, "when Mara starts talking about her friend who has time traveled."

Evelyn went still, ". . .You're sure?"

"Completely. There's more. She claims to have spoken to Marleena."

Lorric's eyes widened, "Then. . .it worked? Earth–"

"No," Randor's voice cut off sharply, "Mara's friend is from the future. According to Mara, her name is Catra. She's using some sort of magic to time travel."

Lorric went to say something but Evelyn cut him off, "How far into the future?"

"According to Light Hope's readings of the Crystal Castle, she estimates it to be about a thousand years. Her data was corrupted so the readings are off but the numbers are fairly accurate." Randor explained.

"But. . .that doesn't make sense. How could Light Hope calculate the years if the time stream model didn't work?" Evelyn asked.

"That's the thing. It *did* work. Somehow, this Catra figured out how to activate the castle and sync the coding through the memory program."

Lorric spoke up, steering the conversation back to the original topic. "That's fine and all, but how does this girl know Marleena? A thousand years? Marlena's human for one and second of all, even if she weren't, that's a long time to live, even for Eternian."

"She claims Marlena's soul has been trapped in some sort of fractured shards. The girl has told Mara she has collected a few of them."

"And how do we know this isn't some sort of trick? We are in the middle of a war, y'know?" Evelyn said, crossing her arms in suspicion.

"Stratos and my brother like to blow things out of proportion. I could hardly call this a war." Randor scoffed, "This Horde Prime doesn't even have a basic hyperdrive ship. As for how I know? Well. . . she said that she mentioned Eric?"

Evelyn stood up before walking across the room in silence, 'Eric?' she thought to herself before turning back towards Randor, "I need to speak to Mara as well as this Catra."

"Mara is already enroute to Eternia under strict orders to maintain comm silence. She'll be here within the day." The king said before turning towards Lorric. "General Sunder, nobody can know about this. I am now of the belief that someone deliberately killed my child and attempted to do the same to my wife."

Lorric stood with a determined nod, "Nobody will know, my King. You have my word."

"Mine as well, Randor. I may not have always gotten along with her but I would give anything for Marleena to wake up again." Evelyn declared.

Randor nodded, as his mind was plagued with questions that he hoped Mara and her friend could answer.

Brightmoon Castle - ten hours ago

As Swift Wind flew over Brightmoon, Catra and Adora looked over the fields littered with Horde tanks and soldiers. They were all standing in formation, waiting for an order to do. . .something. For the most part though, everyone looked on edge and that didn't exclude the soldiers.

Cata looked over her shoulder at Glimmer, "What does Hordak want with me and why now? It's been almost a whole month

since I left. Why didn't he come for me sooner?"

"We don't know. Shadow Weaver's best guess is it's because of your time travel. Beyond that, we have no clue."

Bow spoke up from behind Glimmer, "Something like this has never happened before. Never in the history of the Horde war have peace talks even been broached. It's definitely cause for concern."

"That's because the Horde teaches surrender is weakness." Adora said with a hard tone, her skin giving off a golden light that only She Ra could. "And surrendering land. . .well, that's even worse. Whatever Hordak's trying to do is big."

Catra looked confused at that, "Then why now? Better yet, did Angella okay this meeting? That doesn't seem like her."

Swift wind spoke up as he started descending towards the platform where the Moon stone hovered, "Actually she did. Yep, the tall guard, Juliet I think her name was, talked her into it. The creepy witch in red also raised a good point about potentially regaining lost territory. Turns out that this Hordak guy was willing to meet all the demands of Brightmoon for this talk."

Catra hummed as they landed. Angella greeted them as they climbed off the winged horse. Glimmer immediately teleported into her open arms, hugging one another. "Mom! You're alright! Thank goodness."

Angella gave a squeeze before turning towards Catra, "Come quickly. Everyone is meeting in the main hall."

"The negotiations have already begun?" Adora asked, shocked.

Angella shook her head, "No, we were waiting on you and Catra. Both of you are vital to the peace talks. Come now, we can't wait any longer."

And so they marched through the halls of Brightmoon Castle, approaching the Throne Room. Along the walls were Horde soldiers standing beside the Brightmoon guards. She caught sight of Kyle, Lonnie, and Rojelio before giving them a nod. Catra had to admit that she'd never seen the guards on edge like this before. It was a little unnerving. As they strode into the hall Catra caught sight of Hordak sitting at one end of the table as well Scorpia. In the other chairs sat Frosta, Mermista, and Perfuma. Entrapta seemed to be missing. All talks ceased as Catra stepped up to the table, taking a seat as she swallowed a nervous lump in her throat.

"Good afternoon everyone. I hope everyone made it here safely." Angella said, trying and failing to keep the bite out of her words. If Hordak noticed, he didn't say anything. "As everyone of importance is present, we may now begin with negotiations."

The room was silent before Catra decided to take the first step forward, "So, Hordak, what brought this on?"

"Force Captain Catra, I had been informed of your memory loss. I see you've managed to recover a small portion of them back at the very least."

Catra eyed Hordak, "Yeah," she said slowly, "some of them."

Hordak hummed, "I think you know why I wished to speak with you."

Catra looked to the side of the room and noticed Shadow Weaver sitting beside Castaspella. She gave a slight nod, as if understanding Catra's thoughts. Catra looked back towards the Horde leader, "Time travel?"

"Yes, time travel." Hordak nodded.

"So this was all a ruse to talk to Catra?" Adora spoke up.

"No, but that is definitely the main reason we are currently here. I am willing to call an immediate and indefinite ceasefire. We can

discuss the lands that will be traded and semantics later." Hordak waved his hand.

Angella took the pause as an opportunity to speak, "What exactly do you want from Catra?"

Hordak looked the queen in the eye, "Her assistance."

"Been hearing that a lot these days." Catra muttered under her breath. Adora gave a slight kick to her leg.

"And with her assistance, I may be able to return to my people." Hordak declared.

"Horde Prime, right?" Catra asked.

Hordak nodded, "Yes. I see you've heard of him."

"Who's Horde Prime?" Mermista spoke up.

Shadow Weaver interjected, "The true leader of the Horde. The Emperor of the known universe."

Hordak narrowed his eyes at Shadow Weaver, "Ah, Shadow Weaver, I see you are here. What have you told them?"

"Nothing yet. I haven't had the chance to. You mobilized quite quickly."

Hordak grunted in annoyance before turning back towards Catra, "If I can create a portal and get out of this dimension, return to his side, I will have no need of Etheria any longer. Your war will be at an end and you can continue frolicking through the sparkly fields of which you Etherians love so much."

Glimmer was quiet before speaking her mind, "How stupid do you think we are? Portals? Dimensions to other worlds? How–"

"He's telling the truth." Catra interrupted, "When I first met Mara she told me about other worlds besides Earth."

"You've been trying to open a portal for years to bring Prime's armies through. Why should we believe that you won't immediately turn on us?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"Because, if I can bring evidence of real time travel then I won't need to deliver this planet." Hordak turned towards Catra, "You had to have run into a portal at some point in the last month. Time travel has been linked to portals since the idea of it was first thought of. At the very least you must have an idea of how the First Ones technology operates."

Catra hesitated a second too long before Hordak picked up on it. "So I was right."

"Perhaps we should get to the matter at hand?" Perfuma said.

Hordak sat back in his chair before giving a nod, "Let's start with the land trade and the ceasefire agreement. I am willing to pull my troops back from hostile landmarks on the agreement that the rebellion shall do the same, leaving any current territories that are in the midst of battle neutral."

Angella nodded, "That is agreeable. I take it that includes the seas surrounding Salineas as well?"

"Of course. All fighting shall stop." Hordak continued.

And for the next three hours the leaders and generals of the respectful armies negotiated disputes over land, trade, and resources. As far as resources and trade went, the rebellion was willing to make tradelines to and from the Fright Zone, supplying the Horde and Rebellion with things they had either little or none of. The land dispute on who would reclaim lands and which areas would be surrendered took more time. By the end of the three hours quite a bit of headway had been made, surprisingly. Although the talks were far from over, everyone's patience was starting to wear thin until Shadow Weaver spoke up.

"Perhaps a break is in order, Queen Angella?"

Angella pinched the bridge of her nose before nodding. "Yes, I think that's a good idea. We shall reconvene in two hours. Everyone, get something to eat and drink. Consider what's been said and what you wish to bring up." Angella turned towards Hordak, "The main hall will have accommodations for your people." Hordak gave a nod before striding out of the War Room.

Catra walked towards Glimmer, Bow, and Adora, letting out a yawn, "This is exhausting."

"Tell me about it." Scorpia said from behind her. "I was not built for politics."

"Hey Scorpia." Catra said with a smile. "How've you been?"

"Oh, I'm doing great. I'm really excited for this to go well. We've never done anything like this in the history of the Horde."

"Really?" Catra asked, looking to Adora for an answer.

"She's right. Typically, the Horde would look down on this type of thing. But looking around, it seems like a lot of these people are equally as excited." Adora said.

Bow looked happy, "I'm kind of glad for that to be honest. Just look at Catra."

"What about me?" Catra raised an eyebrow.

"What Bow means to say," Glimmer interjected, "is that you joined the rebellion and even with your memories coming back, you're still our friend. It's a good sign that the Horde isn't as bad as everyone initially thinks. The people in it I mean."

Scorpia nodded rapidly. "Oh, yeah. You would not believe how many people were talking about this on the way over here. Most of the soldiers really want this to work. Everyone wants a break and this could really turn out to be something good."

That seemed to catch everyone off guard, "Really? People in the Horde want the war to stop?" Adora asked.

"Of course we want the war to stop," Lonnie said as she approached with Kyle and Rojelio in tow, "Adora, you know as well as I do that nobody in the Horde actually wants to kill anyone. We're people too."

"Hey guys." Catra waved. "If that's the case, what are some of the people thinking? Anything that could be useful?"

Kyle's eyes widened, "Oh, well the Horde has been really low on clean water and medicinal supplies. Could you bring that up?"

"Kyle," Lonnie cocked her head at the blonde, "Scorpia is literally a part of the negotiations. Do you think she wouldn't bring that up?"

Kyle rubbed the back of his head nervously, "Yeah, I suppose so."

Catra waved her hand, "No, anything that you think of that could help you should bring up. Right now is the time to be heard. There are no stupid suggestions right now. If you have any other things you want to talk about, tell Scorpia."

Bow stepped forward with his trackerpad in hand, "I'm compiling a list of topics to be discussed. We want this to be fair. The more people that feel secure, the better chance this treaty has of working."

Scorpia dragged Bow with her towards the other Horde soldiers in the main hall. Catra took note of Perfuma offering several soldiers salads to their confusion. She looked absolutely horrified when she realized that they'd never had them before. Perfuma began growing fruit and handing them out to the soldiers. While many were hesitant to eat something offered by a princess, many realized that no harm would come to them at the moment. Catra laughed as many of the soldiers' faces lit up in a hilarious fashion.

Adora looked at Catra as she laughed. She gained a smirk, "You know, Catra," She said slyly, "You had that same look on your face

when you ate that fish for the first time."

Catra stopped laughing before letting out a playful glare, "Yeah? I bet you had the same look when you ate this stuff too."

"Touche. Also you're right. I did." Adora lost her smile as she stared at the soldiers sitting around the Main Hall of Brightmoon, hesitantly making conversation with the servants and guards. "Growing up we didn't get to eat food in the Fright Zone."

"I know. I remember those nasty ration bars. Particularly the red ones. Yuck!" Catra made a face.

Adora beamed at Catra, "When did you–"

"A little before we went to the Crystal Castle. Older memories seem to be returning at first. Lots of my childhood is coming back to me. It's. . .a lot less noticeable. It's like I don't even notice they're back but I can feel them there. Incomplete. . .but they're there."

Adora put a hand on Catra's shoulder, holding it there for a moment that seemed a little more than friendly before Catra smirked and leaned into her chest. "Yep, I remember quite a few things. The red mushy ration bars. . .as well as 'Adora Happysmile Rain–"

Adora quickly shoved her off of her with a red face, "Yeah? Then you should remember that we promised never to speak of such things."

Catra let out a laugh before playfully jumping on Adora, "I don't know. That seems to be escaping my memory. Maybe that'll come back to me eventually. But for now, Rainbowfist is here to stay.

Before Adora could respond, Angella walked up to the two girls with an exhausted smile on her face, "I see you two are much closer. Are your memories returning?"

"Some of them. Mainly my early childhood." Catra said, still hanging off of Adora's shoulders.

"Well, I'm glad to hear it. But you should get something to eat and perhaps use the restroom. We only have roughly an hour and a half left."

Adora nodded before turning to walk towards the rest of the princesses gathered around Bow with Catra still hanging off of her friend's back. Adora stopped in front of the food line as she set Catra down.

Catra eyed a colorful drink before Angella quickly took it away before setting down some water. Catra pouted a little before Angella gave an apologetic look. "Sorry Catra, but water only. You've proven that you're quite the strategist and I need you at a hundred percent."

Catra let out a grumble, "Fine. I'll drink boring water."

Angella gave a chuckle as they began to walk towards the tables with food in hand. As they sat and talked with their respective allies and friends, an idea began to form in Catra's head. Catra stood up and began walking towards the Horde troops where Scorpia was sitting.

"Hey, Scorpia?"

Scorpia's face lit up in happiness at being approached by Catra. "Yeah?"

"Can I talk to you for a second?" Catra asked. She noticed several of the soldiers eyeing her with mixed emotions, some good, some bad. She gave them a nod nonetheless.

"Uh, sure." Scorpia said as she walked with Catra to a private corner of the hall, or as private as one could be in such a crowded space. "What's up?"

Catra eyed Scorpia before letting out a breath, "What do you think about coming to stay in Brightmoon?"

Scorpia looked a little shocked before Catra held up a hand, cutting her off. "I mean as a diplomatic hostage." And like that, Catra had lost Scorpia.

". . .a diplo- what?"

"A diplomatic hostage. It means that we would exchange two people of equal footing that hold the same level of political sway. In this case, seeing as how you're a Force Captain we would probably send one of the generals. I just. . .need to figure out who would be okay with going to the Fright Zone indefinitely."

"Ohhh, I see. Ah. . . wellll, about that. . ." Scorpia rubbed the back of her head nervously.

Catra raised an eyebrow. "What?"

"You see, I'm not just a Force Captain. I'm actually a Princess."

"What!" Catra said a little loudly, getting looks from her and Scorpia's allies alike. Catra lowered her voice. "Why don't I know this? Is that why you're in the peace talks while Octavia isn't?"

Scorpia nodded, "Pretty much. The Black Garnet actually belongs to my family and seeing as how since Shadow Weaver left the Horde, I'm basically the only person with some knowledge on it. . . however little that may be."

"But no one ever talks about you in the battle plans. I'd think that someone with a runestone would be a problematic fight going off how the rest of the princesses handle things."

"Well that's the thing. I can't use it. It's never worked for me before. So I don't really have a connection to it."

Catra looked like she wanted to say more before shaking her head, "We're getting off topic. Alright, I can still work with this. If

I can get this off the ground, would you be okay coming to Brightmoon?"

"You bet!" Scorpia enveloped Catra in a bone crushing hug.

"*Just so you know, I'm a hugger"* A memory flashed through Catra's mind of her first meeting with Scorpia. "Oh, yeah."

Scorpia let Catra down before walking back to her table happily. Catra's ear twitched at approaching footsteps from behind her. She turned to find Juliet.

"What was that all about?"

"An idea that may or may not work." Catra said, looking towards the Horde.

"Care to share?" Juliet cocked an eyebrow.

"Do you know what a diplomatic hostage is?"

"Ah, I get it. Then you must have just realized why that doesn't work with Scorpia's status?"

Catra looked at the general, "You knew about her being a princess?"

"Yeah, but it's never served a purpose so we never bring it up. I suppose it serves a purpose now though. Unfortunately, there's not a single person from the alliance that would want to stay at the Fright Zone barring you and Adora and that can't happen for obvious reasons.

Catra looked at Adora from across the room before her eyes slowly drifted towards Entrapta who had just entered the main hall. "Don't be so sure."

As everyone took their seats, Angella strode forward and began where they had left off. For another hour, concerns that the Horde

soldiers had raised to Bow were brought to light. Hordak, despite what Catra had heard of his reputation, listened patiently and respectfully, not once belittling his troops' concerns.

Hordak documented everything that was said and traded documents with Angella more than a couple times. As everyone took a moment to look over other needs, Catra took note of the momentary silence. She gave a quick glance at Scorpia who gave a confident nod. Catra realized that this was a good time to bring her idea forward. Hordak noticed Catra and Scorpia's exchange and set his papers to the side.

"Catra, it seems you wish to say something?" Hordak spoke up, focusing everyone's attention on her. Catra nodded before pulling up a prepared document that she had quickly scrawled together.

"Yes. Does everyone here know what a diplomatic hostage is?"

Hordak raised an eyebrow before giving a nod. Perfuma looked lost and Glimmer seemed a bit taken back by the use of the word 'hostage' but stayed quiet. Frosta also nodded along with just about everyone else. Surprisingly, Adora looked confused at the term.

"What's a diplomatic hostage?" Adora asked. Perfuma voiced her shared confusion as well.

"A political authority such as a ruler or general agrees to hand over a hostage to an opposing side as guarantee of good faith in the observance of . . .obligations." Catra said, trying to think of the best way to describe it. "You might even exchange hostages as mutual assurance in cases such as an armistice. . .like I'm about to suggest."

Hordak leaned back in his chair, tapping a finger on the table before speaking up. "I see the appeal, I really do. Unfortunately, beyond my Force Captains, I have no one of high value to trade. I take it you were hoping for Scorpia to be offered, yes?"

"Yes. She also raised some other concerns to me that while she is a Force Captain, Scorpia holds the title of Princess and with Shadow Weaver being a political prisoner of Brightmoon, Scorpia is the only one with any sort of in depth knowledge regarding the Black Garnet." Catra said, pulling a document out and sliding it down to Hordak.

Hordak eyed the document detailing an agreement for an exchange, picking it up as he spoke. "Correct. Force Captain Scorpia holds the rank of second Force Captain under Octavia. I can't afford to trade her without some sort of recuperation. I would hope that you have something to offer for such a trade?"

Catra nodded before turning towards Entrapta. "Entrapta, if it's alright with you, I would like to put forth your name as the other exchange."

That seemed to shock more than a few people in the room. Glimmer more than anyone else. "Now hold on. We haven't discussed this. Entrapta holds a very important position in the Rebellion."

"Well nothing's set in stone yet. This is only an idea that Scorpia and I have discussed. An extra measure." Catra said to Glimmer.

Entrapta leaned back on her hair having forgone her seat a while ago. She quickly pulled out her own tablet and cycled through some files and numbers. "Hmmm, I don't know. I'd prefer to continue on with my research. Going through with this seems like it would put me back quite a bit."

Hordak spoke up, "I am unfamiliar with Entrapta. What level of importance does she hold?"

"She makes weapons." Glimmer said, somewhat downplaying Entrapta.

"Ahh, I see. Well, I have plenty of weapons makers and don't really see how another one is an equal exchange." Hordak said.

Catra gave a small glare at Glimmer before continuing. "Entrapta is the princess in charge of the city of Dryll. She's also six hours late." Catra said through gritted teeth before letting a breath out. "But beyond that, Entrapta has a deep love for science that matches yours." Entrapta seemed to perk up at that. She quickly jotted something down on her pad before looking back up at Catra.

Catra turned towards Entrapta, "Hordak designed the initial base design of Emily. I figured if you were to accept this exchange that you would make leaps and bounds on your research."

Entrapta looked quite ecstatic at learning that Hordak shared her interests but quickly read the room and with great difficulty bit her tongue. Hordak observed her attire for a moment, taking into account the oil stains before shaking his head. "Unfortunately, I will have to decline. But perhaps an envoy is not out of the question."

Catra nodded at Hordak's decision, understanding his point of view. He didn't know anything about Entrapta and far more to lose with Scorpia in his eyes than gain from an unknown party. She could accept an envoy.

The negotiations continued for three more hours. Everyone's concerns were dealt with fairly smoothly and by the end everyone was more or less content. One of the conditions for the peace is that Catra would have to go to the Fright Zone at some point and assist Hordak. Catra knew that she couldn't afford to be selfish in this matter and so she laid a demand out. The Horde would help retrieve the soul shards and deliver them to Catra in the effort to retrieve her memories. Hordak agreed to the terms and the negotiations were concluded. The Horde and the Rebellion had reached an understanding and a peace had formed for however long it would last.

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio were standing beside Sea Hawk and a few guards when the main hall doors opened. Everyone stood and looked towards the exiting leaders. Hordak stepped forward

towards his troops and Angella did the same. At hearing the final verdict a lot of people had varying emotions at the news. A lot of them seemed exhausted and quiet, others were excited and happy. But most of them just seemed relieved.

Catra watched the other princesses leave as well, saying that they had to return to their respective Kingdoms to tell their people of the ceasefire. Eventually it was just Angella, Glimmer, and Adora remaining in the main hall. Catra nodded before walking over to one of the cushiony benches and promptly collapsed. Angella similarly collapsed in her throne. Glimmer, Bow, and Adora just sat on the floor.

"Ughhhh, this day sucked." Catra let out a groan.

"Tell me about it." Glimmer matched her tone.

"Politics are hard." Adora complained.

"Yep. But we did it. We are officially at peace." Bow said with some excitement.

"A temporary peace that nobody knows how long will last." Angella said tiredly.

Catra pushed herself up off the bench and stretched, "Eh, who cares. We're at a point where we can breathe for a minute. I unfortunately cannot."

"What do you mean by that?" Angella asked, sitting up.

"Before you sent Glimmer and Bow to retrieve us, Adora and I found a way to talk to Mara in the present. I'm going to switch back and see if she can upgrade my trackerpad to include whatever program that Light Hope is running on. If I can talk to Mara without having to switch it will be a lot more simple."

"You're going to get a lesson on First Ones tech!" Entrapta's voice sounded from above her.

Catra craned her neck, looking towards the rafters. "Entrapta? What are you doing up there?"

"Emily needed a signal boost and Brightmoon doesn't have any antennae around. But enough about that, are you about to time travel? Can I document it? Will you ask her some questions for me? Please please please please!" Entrapta begged, getting a bit too far into Catra's personal space.

Adora quickly stepped in between them as gently as she could. "Entrapta, personal space, remember?"

Entrapta lost a little wind at that but quickly perked up. "So?"

Catra let out a sigh, "Alright, come on. I'm gonna tell you right now though, it's nothing special."

"Oh, I already saw you switch once. I'm more concerned with what your brain waves look like during it."

Angella stopped her before she went too far. "How long will you be gone for?"

Catra thought about it before shrugging, "A couple hours at least. I'll be back before the end of the day if I can help it."

"Alright then." Angella nodded. "We need to discuss a few things so I'd like it if you could be back before tomorrow at the very latest."

Catra nodded, "Got it."

As Catra and Entrapta walked to the bedroom, Adora quickly followed, not wanting Entrapta to mess with her unconscious body. As she laid down, Entrapta asked if she could change into something thinner as to conduct her tests. Catra complied and laid down. Moments later, Catra had what looked like suction cups connected to the sides and front of her head, as well as her chest and thighs. She also put a blood pressure valve on her arm. "Are you ready?"

Entrapta nodded, "Ready."

Catra gave a nod and switched. As her body emitted the familiar blue glow and she started to lose consciousness, she heard something that was quite chilling.

"Ohhh, fascinating. According to my readings, all brain activity is basically gone. Her blood pressure is frozen as well. It's most likely due to a time stasis field but if I didn't know any better, I'd say she was completely dead!" An ecstatic Entrapta said.

Mara was staring out into the expanse of space as she zoomed through the cosmos. She felt quite comfortable in the familiar setting. Out here, Mara felt like she could breathe. There were no worries, no higher purpose, or expectations from her family on her shoulders. Just the stars. And she would have remained relaxed if not for the familiar glow that lit up the hall behind her. Mara, for her part, did her very best to not panic. She had hoped that she'd be on Eternia before Catra had switched back. She'd taken a class on negotiations and peace talks and they rarely ended in a single day. Unfortunately for her, Catra was quite good at all things strategy.

"Mara? Where the hell am I?" Catra's voice floated through the ship as she stepped through the hallway to look at Mara. She went to speak before stopping mid stride, her eyes drifting to the stars in front of Mara. She looked shocked before looking back towards Mara.

Mara quickly stood, holding her hands up in a placating manner, "Now before you say anything, I can explain."

Catra's face was one of disbelief, "What the fuck, Mara!"

"I know it looks bad, but we didn't have time to wait. We needed to talk to my mother and you left for your peace talks and I had no way to ask you and please don't be mad." Mara said in a smaller voice.

"You can't just move me without asking. It's unsettling." she said, throwing her arms up.

"I know, I know. Normally I wouldn't but we don't have time, Catra. I've already contacted King Randor and he's been informed of everything up until this point."

"Everything?" Catra asked.

Mara nodded, "Everything. Even the weird monster rewind day we did."

Catra took a deep breath and without another word, went and sat in the copilot chair. To say Catra was agitated would be putting it lightly as she sat in the cockpit beside Mara in silence. At least she had the sense to look a bit ashamed. After about ten minutes Mara spoke up.

"How did your peace negotiations go?"

Catra looked at her from the side of her eye. After a second of silence she sighed. Catra knew that Mara was right and logically, there was no way of contacting her during the last twelve hours. "They went good. We brokered a peace and established trade lines as well as getting a lot of land back."

Mara's eyebrows raised, "All that in a single meeting?"

"Why is that surprising to you?"

"I didn't mean anything by it but typically a negotiation will take several meetings over the course of a week or two."

Catra leaned back. "Maybe for the First Ones but not for us. There aren't multiple factions in our war. There's the Rebellion and then there's the Horde. Everyone was desperate for the ceasefire and we came to an agreement."

"So, I take it that most of the proposed ideas were agreed upon then?" Mara said as flicked a few switches on the ship's control

panel.

"Most of them. A few fell through. Mainly land mass trades and the like. My proposal of a diplomatic hostage swap was denied though."

"A diplo– why would you suggest that?" Mara looked baffled.

"Ah, well, you see. Etheria isn't the same in the future as it is now. We are incapable of space travel due to being trapped in an alternate dimension. Thus our war is a planetary war. No space travel." Catra explained.

Mara gained a look of understanding. "How did Etheria get stuck in an alternate dimension?"

Catra shrugged, "Beats me. But according to Angella, our planet hasn't had stars in almost a thousand years, so whatever happens to it will probably happen rather soon. Probably in the next couple of hundred years."

Mara was quiet at that before changing the subject back to the war. "So why would you want a diplomatic hostage?"

"The Horde is positioned in the Fright Zone. I'm sure it's named something else in this time though. I proposed a trade for their princess for the princess of Dryll. I hadn't realized that Scorpia was the Princess for the Black Garnet when I initially put forth the idea. Either way, the idea was rejected in favor of sending envoys instead. The final agreement was that I must visit the Horde and help Hordak with his dimensional portal off of Etheria and in return they will provide me with any soul shards that they find. They already have a couple I've been told."

Mara perked up at the mention of the soul shards. "That's great! If we can put them back together, we can get Marleena back."

Catra gave her a look. "What?" Mara asked.

"Don't jump to conclusions. We don't know if I can even do that. I also don't know how to get the shards back here from the present."

Mara looked confused, "But you showed me a shard back when I first met you. How'd you do it then?"

"I–" Catra went quiet and thought about that. She was right. And not only that, but she had also held a shard when she had spoken to Marleena. "I. . .don't know. But I might have an idea."

"Well in any case, we're nearing Eternia. If anyone can help you learn about magic, it's my mother." Mara said as she pointed to an approaching planet.

Catra let out a yawn. Mara gave a soft look as she examined Catra's tired features, "Hey are you alright? When was the last time you slept?"

Catra gave a thought to that. When was the last time she had slept? "Let's see. . . I was knocked out at Princess Prom. Then I rewound the day and was knocked out by Glimmer. Then I prepared for Princess Prom again, went to Princess Prom, found out Marlena's name, switched to you, rewound the day again to stop the monsters, you knocked me out for a minute,we went to Brightmoon and then we went to the crystal castle, switched back to Adora, I went to the crystal castle again, met up with you, then went to the peace talks, and now I'm here. What's that make?"

Mara gained a look of complete concern. "Catra, that's almost four days! You need to sleep."

"Nah, I'm fine. I got some of my memories back and I've had to stay up way longer than this before. I should be fine for a few more days if need be."

Mara looked shocked, "Catra, sleep isn't just for recovery. There's a lot of important stuff that goes on during it and if you're not getting enough. . ."

Catra suppressed a yawn and waved Mara off. "I'm fine. If you're that worried just hit me with a heal or whatever."

Mara did just that to Catra's surprise. Catra felt completely rejuvenated. Mara then gave a hard look that Catra didn't particularly like. "I mean it Catra. You're not just a tool to be picked up and put down when you're needed. Don't let others decide your value. Take care of your health. I mean it. I won't do that again." Catra went to open her mouth for a quick reply but Mara beat her to it. "And yes, I realize the hypocrisy in what I just said."

". . . You need to be selfish more often." Catra said.

"What?" Mara asked as she piloted the ship into the approaching planet's orbit.

"You say I need to take better care of myself? Well I say you need to be more selfish. Stop giving to others so much. Do things you enjoy for your sake and not for anyone else. Slack off, skip work, take a day to yourself. Just be Mara for a while and not She Ra."

"It's not that simple, Catra. I have responsibilities."

"God, you sound just like Adora." Catra muttered before speaking up. "Listen, I have a responsibility to help you with this Marleena thing, right?"

"Well, technically but–"

"And I need to help end the war that's going on in my timeline since I'm in a high position of influence?"

"Yes, but I–"

"So if I have to do all that and I can still find time for me, why can't Mara be Mara?"

"It's not that simple. I just don't have the time."

"Mara, you don't find time for something important. You make time. Next time someone asks for your help with something they can manage by themselves, say no."

Mara thought about that as she piloted her way towards the castle. She chuckled when she heard Catra let out an audible 'wow' at the sight of Eternia's capital. "Welcome to Eternos, capital of Eternia." As she docked the ship in the training field behind the castle's barracks she nudged Catra. "Come on."

As they stepped off the ship, Catra stopped mid step as she looked at Mara. Mara turned and looked at Mara, "What?"

Catra looked her up and down, "Did. . .your skin just get darker. Your eyes seem bluer too."

Mara gained a look of understanding. "Ah, right. That. Uh, no, Eternia has an actual sun unlike Etheria's which is a moon that gives off artificial sunlight. Thus, your eyes are adjusting to a light intake. Give it a second, you'll adjust."

Catra blinked a couple of times and true to her word, the colors righted themselves. "That was strange."

"Eh, you get used to it after a while." Mara said, motioning her to follow, "Come on."

As they walked, Catra looked at Mara before finally asking what was on her mind. "Do you have a bad relationship with your mom?"

Mara stopped abruptly and looked at Catra. "Excuse me?"

Catra waved her hands in front of her, "I-I didn't mean it like that. It's just that when I was overhearing what Rayla and Stratos were saying, they made it seem like she didn't care about you and. . .yeah. . ."

Mara scoffed, "Rayla is an Eternian Queen so I don't expect her to understand my customs. But it's an Earth thing."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "I take it that calling your mom once in a while after leaving your childhood home isn't commonplace among Etherians?"

"I'm sure it is for some but Etherians are a tightly knit bunch. Even when they end up splitting they always wind up back together. It's nice but if I spent every waking moment with my mother like that, I'd probably lose my mind."

"Well I didn't really have a mom soooo. . . I don't know where I was going with this." Catra said, quickly dropping the subject. Mara let out a snort.

As they rounded a corner, they caught the eye of someone as he started to approach them. He was fairly tall, around Bow's height and had light blue skin and sharp pointed ears. In fact, Catra noticed he looked quite similar to Kai. Mara let out a groan. Catra eyed her friend, "What? You know this guy?

"That's Prince Zed. He's Keldor's son."

"Who's Keldor?" Catra asked. The name seemed slightly familiar but she couldn't place it.

"That's Fleet Admiral Kai's real name. Everyone just calls him Kai though. This guy's an ass." Mara said under her breath.

"Mara! Is that you? Why didn't you tell me you were coming to visit? Oh, I would have thrown a party." He stopped talking as he focused on Catra. "Oh? A magicat descendant. How rare."

Mara looked taken aback by that statement. "Magicat?"

"Yes, it's a little hard to notice, but if you know what you're looking for you can see the features clear as day. Mainly the heterochromia. Let me guess, you thought she was from Krytis didn't you? An easy mistake. Even I thought she was a Qadian at first glance."

Catra looked at Mara, "The hell's a magicat?"

"A reclusive people from the planet of Primus. They don't leave their planet almost at all. In fact they prefer to stay in their underground kingdom of Half Moon. But beyond the few features that you exhibit, I'd guess Etherian. You couldn't even call yourself a magicat by this point. I'd liken you more akin to the Eternian race of Qadians or like our powerful friend here said, the cat people of Krytis." Zed explained like he was lecturing in a classroom.

"Can. . . magicats do magic?" Catra asked, wondering if the answer for her time abilities was really so simple.

"Hardly. There are reports that the queen can turn into a panther or some such nonsense but beyond that no, not really. At most they can teleport." Zed scoffed. "No, I find it hard to imagine any race that would play around in the dirt capable of any highly civilized practices such as the mystical arts."

"I'm from Etheria and we have–"

"A princess that uses plant magic? Hardly the same thing. Your princesses perform various types of magic that is befitting of their stations. The magicats choose to live underground, stuck in the same state for thousands of years, choosing to remain stagnant. Henceforth my surprise was that there was a descendant of one on Etheria, such as yourself."

Mara put a hand on Catra's shoulder. "Don't worry Catra, we'll figure out why you can use your power."

As they continued to walk past Zed, he stumbled over himself for a moment before regaining his posture, "Uh, hold a moment. What exactly are you referring to? I'm quite knowledgeable on all things magic. If you're having problems with it, perhaps I can be of some assistance."

Catra went to say something but Mara cut her off. "Sorry Zed, but I have to talk to King Randor and I can't afford to waste any more time. It's important."

"So he told you about Queen Marleena then." Zed said quietly.

Mara stopped and looked back at him. "You know?"

"Only out of happenstance. I overheard my father talking about it with the King when I was going to speak with him. I take it your here to heal her, or attempt it at the very least?" Zed asked.

"Something like that." Catra said. "Come on."

Zed gave a nod, "Catra, was it?" Catra nodded, "If you need any assistance around magic don't hesitate to ask. I may not be as tech savvy as our friend here, but I am one of the most knowledgeable people on the subject that you could meet."

"I'll keep that in mind." Catra said as they left for their destination. Catra turned to look at Mara. "Is he for real?"

Mara nodded. "I'm not a fan of the guy. He's quite irritating but yeah, he's telling the truth. Very few people can match his knowledge of magic."

"Does he know more than your mom?" Catra inquired.

"There's the key word. Know. He definitely does but that's the thing about Zed. The guy doesn't do it in the conventional sense. He makes weaponry, shields, gadgets, you name it, and combines them with magic. Remember the force field that Stratos used when we were fighting the monsters?"

"Yeah?" Mara gave Catra a pointed look, "Oh."

"Yep, even I have to admit that he's a genius when it comes to such things. Although he's terrible at any sort of tech that doesn't revolve around magic." Mara explained.

Catra grunted at that. While they walked through the halls, Catra noticed the luxurious interior seemed to surpass even Brightmoon. Gold trim adorned the corners and portraits of what she assumed

were members of the royal family and their guard hung along the walls.

As they came to a large door, Catra noticed that the door even seemed royal with the frame appearing to be solid gold with a victorian-esque era design with two torches made of glowing purple crystals along the sides. The wood even seemed expensive. She took in the appearance of the guards lining the walls. "Is this the king's chambers?"

Mara shook her head, "No, this is my parents' room. I want to surprise them."

"Ah," Catra nodded in understanding as they approached the doors. As Mara gave the guards a nod, she went to open the door before Catra heard something. As she tuned in on the sound she realized that it was a woman softly moaning. She smelled it a second later. As Mara started to pull the door open, Catra quickly slammed it shut.

Mara stumbled back for a second before a look of irritation flashed across her face. "What was that for?"

Catra heard rustling of hurried movement, signaling that they had heard the door open and slam shut. "I think your parents are, um. . .having sex." She said quietly. Mara raised her eyebrows in a way that seemed disbelieving, "I could hear and smell it." Catra finished awkwardly, her ears twitching.

Mara went quiet before finally turning and touching one of the crystals. It lit up in a swirling pattern that finally finished by turning black. Mara let out a frustrated groan that seemed on the border of anger. "Honestly, it's the middle of the day." she grumbled.

Mara turned and nudged Catra. "Come on, might as well go see King Randor. I doubt they'll be done anytime soon." Catra fell into stride alongside her friend, eager to see the rest of the castle.

"What's black mean?" Catra asked curiously.

Mara looked confused for a second before quickly understanding what she was asking. "Orange means 'out at the moment,' Yellow means 'Knock before entry,' Purple means 'Come in,' Red means 'No entry,' and Black means exactly what you think it means."

"Sex?"

"Yep. It's also embarrassing to use in the middle of the day." Mara grinned maliciously. Catra snorted.

"So, what? They forgot to change the colors?"

Mara shook her head. "If you look at the crystal while moving rather quickly, your eyes won't take in the color correctly. Purple looks red, red looks orange, orange is yellow, black looks purple, you get it." Mara eyed a door as they walked past it. "There, that door is purple. Walk past it quickly and don't really focus on it."

Catra shrugged and quickly moved past it. True to Mara's words, all she could see was a red glow from the corner of her eyes. "Huh, that seems–"

"Ineffective? Yeah, it doesn't help that my mom spaces out sometimes. But yours truly has a different method for her bedroom."

"What's that?" Catra asked.

"A lock and key." Mara said simply. Catra chuckled at that.

Evelyn and Lorric, now bathed and dressed, opened their chamber door and looked at the guards. They looked a little uncomfortable under the gaze of their general. Lorric stepped forward, "So, who opened the door?"

The guards looked at one another. They had heard that Mara had wished to surprise her parents and none of them wanted to be on She Ra's bad side. One of the guards stepped forward. "A delegate from Etheria, General Sunder. Said they wished to speak

with you both at once. I believe they went before the King about twenty minutes ago.

Evelyn raised an eyebrow, "And none of you thought to stop them from entering?"

"The torch crystals were initially purple ma'am." The guard responded.

Evelyn turned to look at the now glowing black torches. Her face burned with embarrassment. She waved her hand and they turned orange. "I imagine you thought that was funny? Well I hope you all got a good look, because you can all scrub the walls and floors tonight." She said hotly.

One of the guards who looked particularly agitated with his station cleared his throat. "We didn't do that. We also didn't see anything. Your daughter was here and wanted to surprise you. She had a Qadian with her by the name of Catra. She said she could hear and smell you. After she informed Ensign Mara what you two were doing, she gained a rather irritated look, turned the crystals black and walked off to see the King."

The other guards looked at the man with anger. "She wanted to surprise them."

"Consider them surprised," he responded. "But I'm not gonna scrub the floors and walls on my daughter's birthday because of *their* daughter's attitude." He bit out before turning to look at Lorric and Evelyn, "In the event that your comms were also attuned wrong, the King sent a message to meet him in his study as quickly as possible. Apparently it's urgent."

Lorric looked agitated at the man's snark. "If that is all you are dismissed for the day. That goes for the rest of you as well."

At the dismissal, the guards left the hall. Evelyn watched them leave before mocking the man, "*Consider them surprised*." She mocked, "Ugh, what a prick."

"Yeah, well. . ." Lorric shook his head. "Come on. We don't want to keep Mara waiting."

"So, Mara's friend is a Qadian huh? I guess that's somewhat fitting with a name like Catra." Evelyn said as she walked through the halls beside her husband. Lorric scratched the stubble on his jaw.

"I doubt she's a Qadian."

"Why do you say that?" Evelyn asked.

"Qadians are native to Eternia. Catra is roughly one thousand years in the future. That means that Etheria is alive and thriving. If she's using something as sophisticated as time magic then I'm willing to bet that Catra is probably a Magicat."

"Really? They never leave their kingdom, much less their planet. And they can barely do magic at all. The most they can do is teleport and some minor illusions. Only Queen C'yra can do other forms of magic and that's only because of her gemstone."

Lorric nodded. "Perhaps this Catra is a descendant of C'yra. I'll be able to discern it once I meet the girl."

Evelyn nodded. "We should definitely prioritize the cause of her time magic. Messing with time is already a dangerous endeavor. We don't want her causing temporal displacement. If the continuum is even altered a bit, the axis could be thrown off course. This would result in–" She paused, looking at her husband's dumbfounded face. She sighed, "We should make sure that she doesn't break time."

"Oh. Well why didn't you say that to begin with?" Lorric said as they approached the King's door.

Evelyn just smiled and kissed him on the cheek. "Don't ever change, you precious man."

"I am pretty great." Lorric smirked as they entered the study. Randor looked at Lorric and Evelyn as they entered. "Alright, let's

get to it."

"Get to what?" King Randor asked.

"Didn't you just call us here?" Evelyn asked.

The king nodded. "I wanted to tell you that Mara and her friend will most likely be here within the hour. I already have the preparations made. I want this girl to feel welcome and at ease. Coming to a new planet is always startling and having Mara beside her will only help so much."

Evelyn pursed lips said it all. The king sighed, "She's here already isn't she?"

She nodded. "Yeah. The guards said she was coming to see you right away but that was thirty minutes ago."

Randor sighed before quickly standing and walking off. "Split up and find them. If she went to the main hall then she probably went looking when she realized I wasn't at the throne."

Evelyn turned towards Lorric. "Mara hasn't been on Eternia in almost six years. She's probably at one of her hangouts."

Lorric raised an eyebrow. "You think so?"

"She's been away from Eternia for a long time and stuck on a ship for almost a whole day. If I was in her position I'd probably want something to eat. There's a good chance she's also showing off."

Lorric nodded, "Good point. I'll take the tracks?"

"And I'll check the food courts." Evelyn said as they split up.

Catra spun around in wonder, awestruck at the massive building that surrounded her. The city was alive with activity. Sounds, sights, and smells assaulted her senses in the best of ways. Mara grinned at Catra's awestruck face.

"So, what do you think?"

Catra rounded on Mara, "What do I think? This place is amazing! It makes Brightmoon look small."

Mara laughed, "Oh for sure. Come on." She said, nudging her forward. "I'm going to take you to get something to eat. It's to die for."

As Mara pulled Catra along she looked at the roads and people. Eternos looked like a mix between a futuristic utopia while resembling Victorian-esque medieval Europe. She'd never seen anything like it before and probably would never find something to compare it to. They passed over a road that seemed to be made of water, a building that was hovering above her, and there were a lot of robots.

Catra reached out to touch one before Mara grabbed her shoulder. "I wouldn't do that if I were you. It's a new thing that's being tried out. They're security robots called RK units. The plan is to have them added to the royal military of Eternos."

Catra studied it as it flew off, "How do they run?"

"It's like a hive mind. They are on a certain type of system that responds to threats based on how they're assessed. That way, they're super super organized." Mara explained.

"What if I hack one? Wouldn't I be able to control them all then, seeing as how they run on a hivemind?" Catra asked as they walked.

Mara opened her mouth and closed it before typing something on her own trackerpad. "That's a good point. There."

"What'd you just do?"

"Sent your concern to Zed. He'll take a look at it. Now come on, we're almost there." Mara smiled.

As they sat down, Catra waited for Mara to order for them before she noticed a rather large man walk by with a woman and a child. There was nothing really special about them but that wasn't what had caught her eye. They bore no resemblance to humans, rather they looked like her in the sense that they too were also cat people.

Mara followed her gaze. "Don't see many cat people on Etheria?"

Catra scoffed. "'Don't see many?' Try *next to none*. I've seen very few and that was at the dance. Adora tells me that we're pretty rare in general. I guess the Horde is the reason they're not really around but beyond that, no." Catra stared at them again, "Although, their faces look. . ."

"Like cats?" Mara finished.

"Well . . .yeah. They seem less humanoid I guess."

Mara laughed. Catra raised an eyebrow. "What?"

Mara waved her hand, "Nothing. It's just that. . .I've only ever heard mom use that word."

"What? Humanoid?" Catra asked.

She nodded, "Only Marleena and my mother are humans. Everyone else besides me is Eternian or in your case, Etherian. Granted there are other planets but no humans. So the word 'humanoid' is a bit funny to hear."

"Well what word would you use?"

Mara shook her head, "None. The word humanoid stems from the fact that Earth has never encountered alien races. When you are alone like that, you will start using terms such as that to compare other sentient races to yourself. Eternia has been traveling the cosmos for millions of years so we don't have a word for that."

Catra let out a 'huh' at that as a woman brought food over to their table. Catra watched her leave before turning to Mara, "She looks like Zed?"

"Yeah, she's a Gar. A blue skinned race that's native to Eternia. Zed is a quarter Gar, I think?"

Mara and Catra chatted for a bit before they finished eating. After Mara paid, Catra stood. "Alright, I don't mean to cut this short but we need to go see the King. It's been about an hour and I have to be back before tomorrow. That leaves me about five hours."

Mara nodded, "Alright. Let's get to it. Before we go there's a few things we need to address."

Catra looked at Mara as they began walking back towards the castle. "Like what?"

"Just some simple Etiquette."

Catra groaned. "I spent a whole day memorizing proper formal attire and bows and all kinds of stuff for Princess Prom. Can't I just use those?"

Mara smiled, "Nope. Now when we get in there, you'll want to make sure that–"

"Is that your mom?" Catra interrupted her.

Mara followed Catra's gaze and sure enough, her mother stood in the center of the courts looking at each one of the stalls. She hadn't noticed them yet. Catra turned back towards Mara only to find her missing. "Mara?"

Catra spun around, trying to pick her out of the crowd to no avail. Catra looked back towards the woman before shrugging and walking up. "Hey."

Evelyn turned and looked at the feline woman walking up to her. At a passing glance she would have guessed that this girl walking

up to her was Qadian, a second look her first thoughts were of Krytis, but her eyes betrayed her heritage. There were hardly any features of the race in the girl but the dual colored eyes were a dead giveaway. "Yes? Can I help you? I'm a bit busy at the moment?"

"You're Evelyn Morgan, right? Mara's mother?"

Evelyn instantly focused on the girl. "Catra?"

"Oh, so the King already told you we were coming?" Catra said as she stopped a few feet from the woman. "Mara was just here but she disappeared. I'm not sure where she went."

"I see why the guards thought you were a Qadian. You definitely resemble one."

Catra shrugged, "Zed says I'm of Magicat descent. Something about my eyes." She shook her head, "Anyways, I'm Catra. Nice to meet you. I saw you through Light Hope."

Evelyn held a hand up. "Not here. Wait until we are in front of King Randor."

Catra nodded, "Alright. So where's–"

Catra instantly tackled Evelyn to the side, barely avoiding a large amount of falling paint from above the woman. "Damn it, Catra." She heard Mara say.

Evelyn looked up and smiled at her daughter. "You have good friends."

Mara grumbled as she jumped down from the scaffolding. "Yeah, too good apparently."

Catra gave a sheepish grin, "Heh, sorry."

"Oh, don't be. I just got out of the shower. But I believe I still hold the lead, Mara." Evelyn smiled as she wrapped her daughter into

a hug. "How have you been? Are you eating well?"

Mara nodded. Catra could swear that her eyes were getting a little teary. She figured she'd give them a moment. After a few minutes, Mara wiped her eyes before they turned back towards Catra who was looking at a colorful drink that seemed to smoke. "Catra, come on. We're going to see the King now."

Catra tore her eyes away from the drink before falling into stride beside Mara. As they walked, a woman that seemed to resemble Serenia greeted Evelyn at the castle doors. Catra opened her mouth to ask before Mara beat her to it. "She's Serenia's sister."

"Ah." Catra simply said.

As they entered the castle, Mara caught sight of her father and ran up to him, giving him a big hug. Catra ignored the reunion in favor of studying the tapestry. "So Catra. Tell me about yourself."

Catra looked at the dark skinned witch, "Not much to tell."

Evelyn gained an exasperated look. "Oh, come now. Don't be that way. I'm sure there's something to be said."

"No, I literally have nothing to tell. Beyond a few snippets of my earlier childhood and a moment here and there, I've lost my complete memory. I couldn't even remember my name before my friend's found me. That was the price I paid for my time magic."

Evelyn looked absolutely horrified at that. "Why would you do that to yourself?"

Catra's face slowly started to shift to one of anger. "Obviously, I didn't." Catra said through gritted teeth.

Mara noticed Catra's irritation with whatever her mother was saying to her and thinking fast, dragged her father towards them. "Dad, this is Catra. Catra, this is my dad."

"General Sunder, right? I saw you at Mara's officer graduation. Nice to meet you." Catra said, shaking the man's hand.

"I take it you're talking about the memory program?" Lorric asked.

Catra nodded. "Mara says that your King wants to speak to me regarding. . . a certain person."

"Yes, right this way." Lorric said, leading everyone into a dark hallway before holding up a glowing rune. Suddenly the wall opened, revealing a hallway. As they descended into the castle wall, Catra took note of a strange virring sound that originated from the end of the hall and behind a door. As they entered, she thought it looked more like a waiting room. Catra took note of the familiar looking man from Mara's memories.

"King Randor, Mara has arrived with Catra." Lorric announced.

King Randor gave Mara an approving look before his gaze settled on Catra. If she had to describe the man in one word, tired wouldn't be too far off. He had some gray littering his beard and his long hair had a few strands that had lost their color. His smile didn't quite reach his eyes. But Catra saw something in his face that unnerved her. Hope. Hope for a solution that she wasn't sure she could provide.

"Catra, Mara has told me everything. She assures me that you have been in contact with Marleena." Randor spoke with a deep voice that sounded like he should drink a bit more water. His tone was a familiar one. Most of the princesses had it as well. It was a voice of nobility.

Catra glared at her friend for putting her on the spot like this before nodding. "Yes, I've spoken with Marleena. Although I can't promise that it's your Marleena, no matter how much everything is aligning."

Randor gave a relieved sigh, "That's fine. I just needed to be sure. Come." He said as he stood and walked towards the back of the room. He raised his hand before a door slid open from the wall. As

she followed with Mara and her parents, Catra's nose was assaulted with a familiar smell that only a hospital could carry. It was a smell that told you someone was probably dying.

As they stepped into a room, Catra was greeted with a sight of a familiar woman. She looked thinner, under fed, and a little worse for wear, but beyond that, she seemed healthy. But Catra knew better. She was staring at a corpse that refused to die. "Marleena." Catra simply said. Randor nodded sadly.

"Yes."

Sorry this one took so long. Holidays and all that. I hope everyone had a Merry Christmas. As for this, the next part may or may not be a little slower to come out. Reviews are appreciated and as always, Enjoy.

Chapter 12

Shadow Weaver and Castaspella sat in silence with only the occasional nightly sounds exuding from the forest as they observed the strange rift suspended in air. Finally, Castaspella spoke. "Do you have any idea what this thing could be?"

"No." Shadow Weaver said as she walked around it. It seemed to absorb anything that got towards it while at the same time repelling it. It didn't make sense. It wasn't natural to say the least. "But I can safely say it's not dark magic. In fact, I'm not detecting any magic from it at all.

Castaspella rubbed her face. "This is becoming worrisome."

"Indeed." Shadow Weaver drawled as she drew a circle in the air, firing a small bolt of magic at the strange object. As it shot towards the rift, the bolt seemed to warp and twist in mid air before slowly coming to a halt inside the rift. "Interesting."

"What is?"

"If I didn't know any better, I'd say this was a black hole." Shadow Weaver said as she picked up a rock from the ground before tossing it at the rift. After a moment, the rock seemed to shatter before completely going completely still, its explosion seemingly frozen in place. "But black holes don't do that."

"What's a black hole?" Castaspella asked as she looked at the frozen image before her.

"Something Hordak used to talk about. As I understood it, it's basically a portal that destroys anything that goes through it. Once you're inside one, that's it."

"That's it? What, like you can't escape?" She asked, tearing her gaze away from the rift.

"Precisely. Although, I'd say that isn't what this is."

"Then what?" Castaspella asked.

Shadow Weaver walked towards a tree before snapping one of the longer branches off and draining the plant until it lost its leaves and looked old and dry. "I have a theory that I'm hoping is wrong."

"What are you doing?"

"Testing something." Shadow Weaver strode over towards the rift and slowly shoved the dead branch into the rift. As it slowly got towards the center, the branch warped for a moment before straightening. As it touched the center of the rift, the branch immediately regained its color, blossoming leaves along its edges before it immediately turned to dust in her hands.

"What the hell just happened?" Castaspella looked at Shadow Weaver's hand in shock.

"Damn, I guess that answers that." Shadow Weaver said, closing her fist.

"Will you please tell me what's going on!" Castaspella said angrily, fed up with Shadow Weaver's antics. "I brought you here to help."

Shadow Weaver turned towards Castaspella, "What's the first thing I taught you about magic?"

"It always has a price. So what?"

"So, who's price do you think this is?" Shadow Weaver asked, sweeping her hand towards the rift.

". . .Catra?"

"Exactly." Shadow Weaver said as she turned towards the skiff General Juliet had procured for them. "Catra is using a rare form of magic that we've never even been able to touch, let alone harness. Who knows what the price is for her manipulating time in such a manner. I fully believe that *this*," Shadow Weaver motioned

behind her, "isn't even a drop in whatever ocean Catra is swimming in."

"Hold on. How do we know that Catra caused this? This could be completely unrelated."

Shadow Weaver stopped, a red glint catching her eye. As she leaned down and picked up something out of the dirt, she found it was Catra's missing red headpiece. "Is it now? Because the answer is becoming quite clear." She said as she held the head piece up. "You've all been having Catra run back and forth through time without giving a single thought to how her new found magic is affecting the worlds around her and those who live in them."

"Now wait just a second–"

Shadow Weaver pressed forward. "No. We've waited long enough. Catra must learn to control the power she's wielding before she does something irreversible. She needs a teacher."

"Like you?" Castaspella asked sharply, her hands on her hips.

"Well someone has to." Shadow Weaver looked Castaspella up and down. "And I've been teaching magic for years. Just because I haven't done it in around thirty years doesn't mean I don't remember how. Besides, those in Mystacour require your attention."

"Catra could come to Mystacour. Learn with peers her own age at a safe level." Castaspella argued as they boarded the skiff.

"I doubt she would agree to it." Shadow Weaver said, looking at the red headpiece.

"Oh and why not? She's expressed great interest in learning magic. Why would she turn it down?"

"Because as much as Catra wants to learn magic," Shadow Weaver gently cleaned the Catra's headpiece. "She wants Adora

more. And it doesn't matter how much training you offer Catra, she'll pick Adora before anything else."

"Well, I. . .what if–" Castaspella went silent, trying to summon a response to the obvious dilemma she found herself in. Eventually, her anger surfaced. "Well, what can you hope to teach her? Everything you can teach, I can teach as well. I still passed every one of your classes and I'm the head sorcerer in Mystacour. Do you even know how to manipulate this form of magic?"

Shadow Weaver turned towards the irate woman as if studying her before turning towards the rift. Cautiously, she drew a sigil in the air, as if unsure of what she was doing. It was an irritating feeling for sure. Rune after rune, Shadow Weaver added more and more markings to the sigil before giving a satisfied nod and sending it into the rift. Instantly, the rift slowly started to twist into itself before finally collapsing, imploding the air around it, dragging the very atmosphere into it. Shadow Weaver's hair billowed past her face, a heavy wind seemed to urge her towards the imploding rift. Shadow Weaver remained still as she observed the rift finally disappear.

Shadow Weaver turned back towards her old student, a smugness present in her tone. "No, not really. But I'm sure I can figure it out. It'll be a learning experience for both Catra and myself."

Castaspella scoffed before turning and walking back towards the borrowed skiff. "Come on. I need to get back to Mystacour and you need to get back to Brightmoon."

Shadow Weaver let out a hum, "Oh? Are you not going to stay for the celebration?"

Castaspella looked at Shadow Weaver in confusion, "What celebration?"

"Why, Catra's celebration of course. Brightmoon is throwing a festival in honor of Catra's contribution to the peace treaty between the Horde and the Princess Alliance's Kingdoms.

Angella's been talking about it all night. You didn't know?" Shadow Weaver asked in an innocent tone, "Don't worry. I'm sure it's just been a long day. No one was actively excluding you."

"You can cut that shit out at any time." Castaspella said in a harsh tone as she stormed away from her.

"What ever do you mean?"

Castaspella scoffed, "Sure. Okay. Whatever you say."

Shadow Weaver let out a chuckle as she followed Castaspella back towards the skiff.

It was a little past midnight when Catra switched back. She awoke to Entrapta hovering over her, jotting things down on her pad. "Oh, you're back. Strange. It seems that the switch forward is much faster than the switch back. Tell me, did you experience anything weird on the switch?"

Catra gently sat up, looking around before letting out an exhausted yawn. "I heard you say my vitals were frozen with no brain activity. Besides that, no. Just a quick wake up."

"Fascinating," Entrapta held a recorder to her face, "Log 437, Subject enters a form of stasis when time traveling. Subject exhibited momentary spatial awareness in a state of nonexistent brain activity. Results show that the subject has the potential to observe while not being present. Further testing is required."

Catra stood and slowly peeled off the strange suction cups off of her body. "Listen, we can talk later Entrapta, but right now I'm dead exhausted. I'm going to get some sleep."

Entrapta waved her hand in the air, "Oh, that's fine. I need to review the data anyways."

Catra nodded and left the room, slowly dragging herself towards her bedroom. As she rounded the hall towards her and Adora's

room she found Angella standing in front of Micah's mural with a small smile on her face. At the sound of her footsteps, Angella noticed Catra before turning towards her.

"Catra, you look like you've seen better days."

Catra gave another yawn. "I met with the King of the First Ones. His name's Randor."

Angella's eyes widened. "You did? What did he wish to speak with you about?"

"You know how Marleena's soul is split?" Catra said tiredly.

"Yes. What of it?" Angella's face contorted in confusion.

"She's the queen."

Angella looked even more shocked at the revelation. "What?"

"Yeah. The guy thinks someone tried to kill her. She was thought to be in a catatonic state. When he was informed about me and Marleena by Mara, he was insistent that he meet me. I told him not to get his hopes up and that this might not be her."

"And?"

"Well, it's hard to dispute his claim when I came face to face with her comatose body."

Angella let out a hum, turning back towards Micah's mural. Thoughts of Micah flooded her mind and what she would do if given the chance to get her husband back. She turned back towards Catra. "What are you thinking?"

"I. . . I don't know. How can I in good conscience leave this be? That would be like me refusing to help you if–" Catra cut herself off from what she was going to say. Angella remained silent but understood the predicament. There was a lot going on in Catra's

head and a lot being thrust on her shoulders at once. Catra let out a tired sigh, "Did you ask Castaspella about teaching me magic?"

Angella gained an uncertain look, "I did. She said that you are invited to go to Mystacour if you wish where you will be taught with a group of peers around your age."

"I. . . No. I can't afford to go to school. I need to learn the effective stuff. How to throw a fireball, how to use magic, how not to die when I choose to use it."

"Catra, cultivating any sort of skill takes time and commitment. You can't rush things, especially magic."

Catra let out a sigh, "I can't afford the patient route. Ironically, time is not on my side here."

"What do you mean? Why not?" Catra stayed silent, looking away from the Queen, "Catra, look at me. What do you mean?"

"The First Ones, Eternia, they're in the middle of a war. To top that off, Randor thinks that someone from his own Kingdom was responsible for the assassination attempt on his wife." Catra let out an exhausted breath, "It's just. . . Look, I know it's not something you want to hear and I know I promised, but I can't keep putting it off. I need to learn magic and if Castaspella isn't going to be around then I need to go to the person who is."

"Catra, if we–" Angella went to speak before being cut off.

"No! I can't push this off anymore. I didn't want to say it so as to not worry anyone, but," Catra lowered her voice to just above a whisper, "Angella I almost died doing this. That's not an exaggeration. If I had been a literal second too late, I would have died. Mara got to me just in time to heal me but this method of winging it is severely limiting me. If I'm gonna help this woman, I need to be prepared."

Angella went silent at that. "Is there really no one else besides her?"

Catra gave a slow nod. "Evelyn is an option."

"Who?"

"Mara's mother." Catra quickly explained.

Angella looked at her with a hesitant look, "Has she offered to teach you?"

Catra shook her head, "Not personally. Although Mara claims that she would if I asked."

"Is she qualified?"

"For one, she's the King's court mage. Mara also claims that she's never met another person of higher skill in magic, so there's that." Catra said.

"Why don't you ask her?"

"A few reasons. The first and probably the biggest is that she resides on Eternia and I'm only there because we're talking to the king. Second–"

"Wait, you are on the First Ones planet? What's it like?" Angella asked, a bit of excitement in her voice. Catra gave her an exhausted look to which Angella realized that she was keeping the poor girl up. "Sorry, now's not the time. Go on."

"Second, I would need to stay in the past for an extended period of time which I'm not sure I'm comfortable with. And third, Shadow Weaver raised me. And no matter how badly I was treated as a child, she will know exactly how to teach me and where my bad habits will lie. I will ask Evelyn, but I still think that Shadow Weaver is the safer option."

Angella pursed her lips. "We will discuss this later when you are well rested. But I realize that you are right. We have been pushing this off to the side. Your training should be a priority, especially

since we are at peace for the moment. I will take what you have said into consideration."

Catra gave a tired nod and trudged to her room. As she entered she peeled off her clothes and climbed into bed. She immediately felt her eyelids become heavy, the exhaustion of the day catching up to her. Catra, choosing to ignore everything that was piling onto her shoulders, snuggled into the blankets. As she fell into unconsciousness, she swore that she felt an arm gently wrap around her.

It was early morning when Randor poured himself a drink with a smile. Since Marleena's tragic incident he'd looked for anything that could help him wake Marleena up and now, against all odds, it appeared in front of him. His smile slowly faded as he thought of the Heart of Etheria project. Catra's arrival told him something that he had been dreading for the past two years. It was all for nothing. No amount of magic was going to help Marleena get her soul back. Granted, mining magic was nothing new for them but to the extent they had gone with Etheria was almost soul crushing. And now that he knew that, he could get to work in ordering the heart dismantled. Once the magic disperses back into the planet the damage should repair itself fairly quickly.

His thoughts turned back to Catra. There had to be something he could do to assist the girl in retrieving his wife's soul. There was no hope for his daughter. He knew that. The explosion that had caused Marlena's current state had rocked the castle and could be felt across the whole kingdom of Eternos. When they had found his wife, there was no trace of their baby left. He could only hope that it had been quick.

Letting out a breath, he quickly threw the drink back, the alcohol stinging his throat as he poured one more before closing the bottle. He gained a determined look as he thought about Mara. Mara was certain that Catra was the key they needed to save Marleena. He wasn't ignorant of Mara's thoughts on the Heart project. The girl loved Etheria and wanted to see it safe. He had

no doubt that she had pieced together the true purpose of the Heart once she had learned of his wife's status. With Catra claiming to have met Marleena and having it all but confirmed must have reaffirmed her stance on the pointlessness of the project. To his shame, he had to agree. But now they had a chance to make amends.

Randor finished his drink before exiting his room. As he strode down the halls of his castle, he headed for his science division. Catra had made mention that she needed to upgrade several pieces of technology in her timeline. Namely her tracker pad. She had asked for a way to contact them without switching. Evelyn had assured the girl that with their time streams synced, she would have something ready in the coming days.

"My king." An approaching voice sounded from his side. Upon turning, he found a familiar communications officer making his way towards him. He couldn't quite recall his name.

"Yes?"

"Your brother, Prince Keldor, is on the line. He wished to speak with you immediately." The young man said, holding up a circular shaped disc.

Randor nodded his thanks before taking the disc and dismissing him. Randor thought for a moment before nodding to himself and opening the line. As Randor threw the disc into the air, it hovered for a moment before a holo-induced image appeared beside him. A sad smile broke out on his face. "Brother, it's always good to see you." Randor said somberly.

Keldor smiled for a moment before it gradually faded away, "How are you doing these days?"

"It's. . . been alright." A silence hung heavily in the air.

"That's good to hear. I know it hasn't been easy but we'll figure this out." Keldor assured him.

"I'm glad I can always count on you Keldor." Randor said kindly before his face gained a bit more of a determined look. "Actually, it's a good thing you called. I have something I wished to speak with you about, but I believe you wanted to talk to me about something."

"Yes, I wanted to ask you if Ensign Mara happened to have returned to Eternia?"

"Ah, yes, she has. I have called her back." Randor said as he kept walking. Keldor seemed a little irritated after hearing that.

"May I ask why? She Ra is a fairly integral part of the Heart project."

"I'm pausing the project." Randor said without missing a beat.

"What! Why?" Keldor exclaimed in shock, masking the tinge of agitation present in his tone.

Randor raised an eyebrow before pressing forward, "It has been brought to my attention that Mara has a new friend that is not quite from our timeline. She also informs me that you were quite aware of this. Did you think that time travel would be something that shouldn't be relayed back to me?"

"Well, yes, you are right. But Catra isn't actually from the future. She's from a parallel timeline. But what does she have to do with Mara?"

"Catra has informed me that she is currently locked in a war with an army calling themselves the Horde." Randor explained, utilizing the fact that Keldor was completely unaware of the recent peace treaty that Catra had helped work out. "From what I can garnish, this Horde is the very same army that we are currently engaged with. According to Catra, this army is working with limited technology and numbers and is still well on their way to winning. This has caused me to reevaluate my stance on the matter and consider yours. You and Stratos are right. I should be taking this Horde Prime more seriously.

"This is the reason I have requested Mara to return to Eternia. I need her to rendezvous with the front lines and crush the opposition before they gain the foothold that could tip the scales. Unfortunately, my focus is split with. . . Marlena's condition." Randor let out a shaky breath.

Keldor looked split before he spoke up. "Let me worry about Horde Prime."

"What do you mean?" Randor asked.

"Keep Mara here on Etheria. Have her return and I will take the main bulk of the soldiers and stop this Horde Prime. Mara can remain here and continue the Heart project. It would be better for all of us. If you allow me to do this, the Heart will just be slowed and not come to a standstill."

"I. . . I don't know. Are you sure?" Randor asked skeptically. "I can't have Stratos and you on different sides of the universe, Kai."

"I will take Stratos with me. As for the Heart, send Zed. My son is equally as capable of running the numbers as I am, maybe more so. We are so close to a breakthrough. I know it. If we can wake Marleena up then all of this, all of it, will have been for something."

Randor slowly nodded. "Alright. I see your point. . . I will send Zed with Mara and have her return to Etheria. I want You and Stratos to deal with this threat as quickly as possible. Don't waste time brother. You're all I have left." He said sadly.

Keldor nodded, "I promise that it will all be worth it in the end."

Randor gave a smile, "I'm sure Mara wishes to spend a few days with her parents before returning. I'll see to it that she is back by the end of the week. Upon her return, you have my permission to fully mobilize the fleet to crush this Horde Prime as you see fit."

Keldor gave a smile before giving a nod goodbye. After a moment, the hologram dissipated leaving Randor alone in the hall. "He

seemed pretty adamant that my daughter return to Etheria."

Randor turned around to find Evelyn, "Yes, I caught that as well."

"Why is he so adamant on the Heart? I thought his main goal was the kingdom of Grayskull? You're not really going to send Zed and her back to continue the project are you?" Evelyn asked with concern.

"No. I'm intending to dismantle it entirely. It has come to my attention that we may have been going about this in the wrong way. I will not lie. I am quite ashamed that it has taken me this long to realize that." Randor said, his head hung in shame.

Evelyn put a comforting hand on the man's shoulder. "Randor, no one here blames you for your grief."

Randor smiled sadly. "Perhaps not, but while my actions may be understandable, my grief does not excuse the way I have conducted myself. On another matter, I wanted to ask you if you would do something for me."

Evelyn nodded, "Of course. Name it."

Randor gave a mirthless chuckle, "You may change your tune," He muttered before looking her in the eyes, "I'd like you to go to Etheria with Mara and teach Catra magic."

Evelyn, to her credit, didn't immediately say no, but Randor recognized the absolute fear that flashed across her body at the thought of leaving the planet. "I. . . I don't know Randor."

"I understand your reservations about space travel and they are completely justified, but I need your help with this. I can't have Catra dying because she couldn't turn this power off. I wouldn't ask this of you if I didn't think you could handle it." Randor said quietly.

Evelyn was quiet for a moment before giving a hesitant nod, and a shaky reply. "Just this once."

Randor smiled before pulling the woman into a hug, "Thank you Evelyn."

As she left Randor to his own devices, she couldn't shake the uneasy feeling that something had just shifted in the air.

As the morning rays peeked over the horizon, lighting up the room in a lovely morning glow, Catra awoke to heavy breathing and a slow steady heartbeat in her ear. As she drifted out of sleep, she became increasingly aware that she was not alone in her bed. Slowly, as to not disturb the person, she slowly started to look up until she caught sight of blonde hair. Catra immediately relaxed before lowering her head and closing her eyes, a soft pur emanating from her. As a small smile graced her lips, she drifted back into a slumber.

Unfortunately, the universe had other plans. With a loud bang, their bedroom door slammed open to an abrupt entrance from Bow and Glimmer. At their excited entrance Catra sprang out of the bed with her claws fully extended, every trace of sleep all but gone from her face. Adora was quick to follow with a dagger in hand.

"Wha. . .What's goin' on?" Adora tiredly slurred her words.

Bow recoiled a bit in panic at the sight of Catra's claws for a moment while Glimmer remained unphased, a dopey grin on her face. "What are you guys still sleeping for? Aren't you excited?"

Adora and Catra, fully awake by this point, sheathed their weapons before Catra looked at Glimmer in confusion and slight irritation. "Excited for what?"

Glimmer looked at Adora, "You didn't tell her yet?"

Adora shook her head before sitting back down on the bed. "She didn't come back until around midnight. She pretty much passed out as soon as her head hit the pillow."

Catra looked confused, "Tell me what?" She eyed Glimmer, "Why are you so excited?"

Glimmer clapped her hands together, a wide grin on her face, "In honor of your contribution as well as the success of the Alliance and all those who worked so hard for this to be possible, Brightmoon has invited the respective Kingdoms of the Princess Alliance to partake in a celebration."

Bow cut in with an equally excited grin, "In short, we're throwing a party because of the peace treaty!"

Catra furrowed her brow, "But. . . it's not a peace treaty. It's an armistice. Technically the war isn't over. We've only agreed to cease military operations."

It seemed like Glimmer's smile grew even wider, "Check again. Our scout caught wind of the terms of peace on the Horde's side. It's listed as a treaty on their end. Do you get what that means?"

Adora slowly stood up, "That Hordak has chosen to permanently end the fighting?"

Glimmer teleported in the middle of Adora and Catra, pulling them into a hug, "Yes! As long as we all abide by the terms, the war is over!"

Bow walked up to them as he flicked through his tracker pad. "So with preparations going on, everyone's in full swing. Mermista, Perfuma, and Frosta have all returned to their Kingdoms to deliver the invitation."

"What about Netossa and Spinnerella's Kingdom? Are they going to be joining?" Adora asked.

Bow nodded, "Yep, in fact they are already here. They're helping set up the decor right now. Besides that, Angella wants to talk to Catra. She said that you would know why?" At Catra's nod, Bow pressed forward. "Beyond that, we'd like Adora's help for a few

things and technically this is still a royal celebration so we'll need to go over the honor speech and decorum."

Catra promptly laid down back in the bed at hearing the word decorum, to which Adora quickly picked her up. "Oh no you don't. You can't switch away at the first sign of decorum."

Catra went limp in Adora's arms, letting out a groan, "But it's so boring."

"Oh, I agree. But if I have to suffer through it, so do you." Adora said smirking as she set Catra down.

"Catra, you and Adora were the driving force behind this peace. You'll both have to stand before all of the Kingdoms and receive a commendation medal in honor of your contributions to the Treaty and the Kingdoms of Etheria." Bow explained.

Catra let out a sigh before waving her hand in the air, "Fine. I'm already awake so may as well." She grumbled.

"That's the spirit. Now, we'll let you two get dressed." Glimmer said before teleporting away with Bow.

As they were left alone in silence, Adora walked to the dresser before pulling out two changes of clothes. Catra walked into the bathroom with hers before the sound of running water started. Adora waited quietly before deciding to voice her thoughts. "So, did anything interesting happen while you were switched?"

Catra's voice carried from out of the bathroom, "Yeah, you could say that."

"How so?"

"I'm on the First Ones planet." Catra said, a playful tone present in her voice.

"What!" Adora exclaimed in shock.

"Yeah." Catra chuckled, "Oh, you wouldn't believe how gorgeous the place is. Mara's Kingdom is larger than life. It literally dwarfs Bright Moon. You could put Frosta's kingdom and Bright Moon together and it would still be tiny."

"Wow." Adora said, picturing it in her head. "What's it like?"

"It's weird for sure, but in a good way. There's so many different types of people. And the food was really good. They had roads made of floating water. Once Mara's mom gets my tracker pad up to par, I'll be able to show you what it looks like."

"What do you mean?"

"Well, according to Evelyn, our timestreams are synced up because of the Crystal Castle. So once I get the tracker pad upgraded, I'll be able to link our technology–"

"And be able to talk anywhere rather than just the Crystal Castle." Adora finished.

"Yep." Catra said as the water turned off. A minute later, Catra came walking out of the bathroom in her original horde clothes. As Catra adjusted her clothes, Adora eyed her body out of the corner of her eye before quickly walking into the bathroom to take her shower.

As Catra waited, Adora's voice came through the door, "What did Angella want to talk to you about?"

Catra remained quiet for a few minutes, unsure of how she wanted to approach the conversation. Unfortunately, that moment was long enough for Adora, "Catra?"

"Shadow Weaver. . . and magic." She replied hesitantly.

"Catra!" Adora exclaimed as the water turned off.

"Yes, Adora?" Catra replied snarkily.

"Don't 'Yes, Adora' me. I thought you had agreed to not push for this. Castaspella will teach you. You just need to ask." Adora said as she walked out of the Bathroom, drying her hair as her wet clothes clung to her body. Catra might have stared a bit longer if Adora wasn't currently confronting her over her choices.

Catra let out a sigh, "We already did."

That was enough to cut Adora off from whatever she was about to say. "You did?"

Catra nodded, "Yeah."

"And?"

"She said she would. But there's a catch."

Adora's face contorted into confusion. "Is it something bad?"

Catra shrugged, "Depends on how you look at it. She said that I would have to go to Mystacour and stay there. That way I could learn with peers at my level and around my age."

"No! You've only been here for a month. I just got you back." Adora said in defiance

Catra wasn't sure why, but she quite liked Adora's tone when she said that. Giving a small smile, she nodded, "That's what my reaction was as well. There is another alternative, but the conditions are more or less the same."

"What's the alternative?"

"Mara's mother."

"Evelyn? She knows magic?" Adora asked as she quickly did her hair.

Catra nodded, "She's the high mage of Eternia. According to Mara, nobody surpasses her in magic. And if a whole planet of magic

users can't compete with her–"

"Then chances are she would be the optimal choice."

"But I'm sure you can guess the downside."

"You have to be over there instead of over here." Adora finished with a defeated tone as she laid down on the bed.

Catra nodded. "I still haven't decided yet, but the choices are Shadow Weaver or Evelyn. That's also assuming she'll agree. I haven't asked her yet."

Adora quickly sat up, "Wait. You said that they could sync your tracker pad, right? Just ask them to make it bigger. She can teach you magic while not presently being there. Mara said she could teach me in the same way at the Crystal Castle."

"That's. . .hm. I suppose that could work. I don't see any reason it wouldn't." Catra thought about it for a second. "I'll ask her next time I switch. As for right now though, Bow and Glimmer want to hang out with you and I have to go talk to Angella."

Adora nodded, "see you later."

As Mara sat in her quarters, she observed Catra's unconscious body. Something wasn't adding up in her mind and she didn't know what. Whatever had sent Catra back in time wasn't by accident. As she thought about all of the pieces she still couldn't get a clear picture. The Heart, Marleena and a possible attacker, Catra's time travel, Etheria being trapped in another dimension, the virus in the Crystal Castle from Keldor. There were too many variables.

Her thoughts were interrupted by her parents entering the room. "Mara?"

"I'm over here." Mara said.

Evelyn walked over to her and glanced at Catra. "She's quite the character. She reminds me a bit of C'yra."

Lorric came and sat down beside his daughter, "Actually, that's something I wanted to bring up. I wasn't sure of it at first but my theory is all but confirmed. Our feline friend is a direct descendant of C'yra."

Mara looked confused. "How can you be so sure?"

Lorric pulled out a small tablet device before a hologram of Queen C'yra appeared. Mara was a bit speechless. Save for some minor differences, Catra was the spitting image of the woman. C'yra was a beautiful woman with long purple hair bordering black with two golden piercing eyes that matched Catra's. Her fur however was a light lavender color in contrast with Catra's brown fur. Their hair was different with Catra's being more wild and spiky and C'yra's being straight and brushed. Her tail was also bushier than Catra's. But Mara could swear she could be Catra's mother if she didn't know any better.

"That's beyond weird. I didn't know C'yra had any children." Mara said.

"She doesn't. Although I hear she's been trying for one." Lorric continued.

"Well, if Catra is a descendant of C'yra, she'll probably have a child soon." Mara said.

Evelyn raised an eyebrow, "Why do you say that?"

"Catra told me that Etheria is trapped in an alternate dimension with no stars in the future. Incapable of space travel. She also said it's supposed to happen rather soon, so if Catra is a descendant, then at some point her child or grandchild will get stuck in Etheria."

Evelyn furrowed her brow, "That. . .sounds like Despondos."

Lorric looked at his wife in confusion. "What's Despondos?"

"Despondos is an empty dimension. It doesn't have any stars or moons or planets. Nothing. It's also almost impossible to detect, let alone find. Marleena and I got lucky just finding the damn thing." Evelyn explained. "Why would Etheria be there?"

Mara shrugged, "I don't know and neither does Catra. But according to her, they've been in this dimension for almost a thousand years."

"Well, ignoring that mystery for a moment, I wanted to talk to you about something." Evelyn said.

Mara nodded, "Sure. Go ahead."

"King Randor has asked me to accompany you and Catra to Etheria so that I may teach her magic." Evelyn explained.

Mara looked shocked. "But you hate space travel."

"Yes, I'm absolutely horrified at the prospect of this but Randor informed me that this girl almost died using her magic. That tells me that her source of time magic is not external like the mages, but rather internal, such as the princesses and queens of Etheria. Or the magicats.

Without a good teacher Catra will suffer for it and risk further harm to herself and others around her. If I can get her to a good enough level, then perhaps she'll be able to use these powers on command without help."

Mara stayed quiet, "Will you be okay on the ship?"

"Probably not, but in the worst case scenario I can just take some sleeping medicine." Evelyn said standing.

Mara looked at her father, "What about you dad? Are you coming as well?"

Lorric shook his head, Unfortunately, no. I have duties here and I need to be ready in the event that this Horde Prime will descend upon Eternia. But be aware that Admiral Stratos and Fleet Admiral Keldor will no longer be on the planet. They've been recalled to deal with the looming threat. The King will also be sending Zed with you to continue the Heart's project."

Mara looked like she wanted to say something before she was silenced by a pointed look from her father. "On another note, someone else wishes to tag along to Etheria."

"Who?" Mara asked. Evelyn also looked confused at this information.

"Me." A voice said from the door. Upon turning, Mara took in the appearance of a tall woman with gold and white armor. Her red hair and green eyes gave away who she was instantly.

Mara's face lit up in recognition, "Teela? Why would you want to come?"

Teela smiled, "For one, I'd like to see my little sister. Second, I've been chosen to be the next sorceress of Eternos. Your mother has been tutoring me and I still need to finish my training."

Mara looked at her mother, "You're retiring?"

Evelyn smiled, nodding in confirmation, "My magic does wonders keeping me fairly young. It extends my lifespan but I'm almost fifty six years old Mara. That's a long time for a human. Besides, Teela is the most powerful magic user I've ever encountered." Evelyn glanced down at Catra, "Well, besides Catra here. But I suspect that is for a different reason entirely."

Mara shook her head before looking back at Teela, "Well, congratulations on the position Teela. I'm happy for you. But I thought that members of the Women-at-arms couldn't learn magic?"

"Under normal circumstances you'd be correct. But according to the sorcerers' council, I'm unique. . .or something. I didn't really understand it all." Teela waved it off.

"So, when do we leave?" Mara asked.

Lorric spoke up, "The end of the week. The technology that will allow us to speak to Catra's timeline is still being built, but soon."

Mara gave a nod as they left the room, before turning her attention back to her time shifting friend. Perhaps if Mara had been She Ra, she would have detected the shifting in the air. Unfortunately, it went unnoticed by everyone.

Shadow Weaver thought about what she had heard over the last couple of hours. Catra had the opportunity to learn from a First Ones sorceress. She felt a bit jealous at the prospect of learning new types of magic. But that wasn't what she was currently fixated on. She needed to start teaching Catra magic as soon as possible, lest she choose to ignore her teachings entirely.

Fortunately, today was her day it would seem. For had she been a little slower, she would have missed the lingering looks from Adora towards Catra as they parted for the day. Catra and Adora's relationship grew closer and stronger with each passing day. Anyone with eyes could see it. But what they could not see was the potential leverage it brought Shadow Weaver. In the past, she had done her very best in separating the two to no success. But now, she saw the key to Catra choosing her as her main teacher.

If she could influence them towards one another and nurture their bond. Make them believe that she was an encouraging figure for it, well, she might not only gain Catra's trust, but perhaps regain Adora's to a varying degree. The celebration was the key point where she would make her move. She knew Catra didn't dare switch today. Not with her receiving an award for her contributions.

She needed to get her away from Angella. She had about seven hours until the celebration and she would not waste them. She had heard talk from the guards that with the peace treaty in place, she would soon be forced to leave Brightmoon. She couldn't allow that to happen. She needed Catra to vouch for her and defend her place in Brightmoon. If Adora was on her side as well, then it would be that much stronger.

As she wandered the city in observance, she watched the people hanging decorations and chatting lively. It sent a nostalgic feeling through her that reminded her of simpler times when she was a teenager in Mystacour. She let out a small smile before noticing something. A horde ship had arrived with crates. It was no doubt one of the supply lines that had been agreed upon. She noticed that this particular shipment had several people being escorted off of the ship who looked a little worse for wear. She knew a few of them. Prisoners of war. Her eye got caught on a file sticking out of one of the crates. She recognized the paperwork instantly, having done it herself. She also noticed that Kyle was the guard that was delivering the supplies.

As she strode over to the young man, he noticed her out of the corner of his eyes. "Ah, Shadow Weaver!" He quickly saluted her out of reflex. Technically it had only been a few days since she had left but still, she was no longer in charge of the boy.

"Cadet Kyle, I take it that these are the prisoner logs?"

"Yes, Shadow Weaver. We also released the prisoners of war that we had in our custody." Kyle said nervously. Shadow Weaver perused the files as Kyle continued to ramble on. She stopped at a specific file that she had forgotten about. A pang of guilt shot through her as she stared at the file that detailed Micah's departure to Beast Island. Although her guilt quickly faded as a sense of glee filled her body. Quickly grabbing the full report, she pocketed them away. It was definitely her day today. "I was also to deliver one of the soul shards in a show of good faith. Lord Hordak's orders."

Shadow Weaver looked at the box that Kyle was holding and quickly took it from him. Opening the box revealed the light blue glow of the shard. Upon looking at the shard, she sensed an almost miniscule shifting of. . .something indiscernible. Had she not had the experience with magic that she did, she wouldn't have noticed. Narrowing her eyes, she quickly pocketed the stone. Upon recieving a rather nonchalant dismissal, Kyle gave a nervous nod and continued on with his work before departing Brightmoon with the other Horde soldiers.

Shadow Weaver set out to find Catra, intending to speak with her first. As she wandered the grounds, she found Adora with Bow and Glimmer setting up decorations. Adora's happy chatter died down as she caught sight of Shadow Weaver.

"Adora."

"Shadow Weaver."

"Perhaps you can help me. I'm looking for–" Shadow Weaver started before Adora cut her off.

"I don't know where Catra is."

Shadow Weaver tilted her head towards Glimmer for a moment before replying, "I'm actually looking for your mother." She said with an indiscernible tone.

"Why?" Glimmer asked hesitantly, noticing Shadow Weaver's tone.

"I don't want to bring the jovial mood down, I just need to speak to Angella. It's rather important."

"The Queen is in the main hall of the castle." Bow answered.

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Thank you, Bow. Enjoy your day Adora. You earned it." She leaned in closer to Adora, "Just between us, I hear Catra is quite looking forward to the dance, seeing as how the last one was somewhat disrupted last time."

"She is?" Adora asked, her hostility fading from her voice.

"Indeed. I'm quite certain she wants to surprise you." Shadow Weaver reached into her bag and pulled out Catra's head before gently placing it in Adora's hands. "Perhaps you can surprise her as well."

Adora looked at the recently cleaned piece of armor. "Where did you find it?"

"When Castaspella asked for my help, I stumbled upon it by complete chance. It was just outside of Plumeria." She noticed Adora's apprehension regarding her actions. Shadow Weaver reached up to her face and removed her mask, exposing her face and looking Adora in the eye. "Adora, I know you don't believe me, but I mean it when I say my actions are genuine. I have a second chance. Catra healed me and gave me my magic back. I want nothing more than to help her learn to control hers. If you really are bothered by it, should she wish to learn from me, you may sit in on the lessons as well. If you cannot trust me, then at the very least trust in Catra."

Adora looked unsure. Unsure of the genuineness behind Shadow Weaver's words. Unsure of the vulnerability that she was exposing to her for the first time ever. But more than anything, Adora felt unsure of herself. She wanted to believe her, believe that she was genuinely sorry, but she couldn't be sure. "Fine, but in return, you trust me. Trust that I'm not stupid and that I'll see right through your mind games. Stop lying for once and trust me with the truth.

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Of course. Now," Shadow Weaver put her mask back on, "I must go see Angella and you three need to prepare for tonight."

As she left them to their devices, she heard their hushed whispers behind her. As she left the courtyard and entered the castle, she immediately caught sight of Catra speaking with Angella. Striding over to them, Angella narrowed her eyes in suspicion while Catra seemed caught between uncertainty and a longing for something.

No doubt wanting to ask for lessons on magic while maintaining a sense of caution.

"Shadow Weaver, what are you doing here? Just because you've been released on the terms of the treaty, doesn't mean you have to stay here." Angella stepped in front of Catra, putting her safely behind herself.

"I hear Catra wished to learn magic." Shadow Weaver said nonchalantly. Before Angella could muster up a response, "But on another note, I'm actually here to speak with you Queen Angella."

"Me?" Angella said in shock. "What for?"

Shadow Weaver turned to Catra, "Could you give us the room for a bit Catra? It's somewhat important."

"Uh, yeah, of course." Catra said as she left the hall. At the sound of the doors closing, Angella pressed forward.

"What is it?"

"Do you remember General Calix?" Shadow Weaver asked.

". . .Yes." Angella said solemnly. "He was a vile person and deserved the death he got. Why bring him up?"

"About forty minutes ago the Horde dropped a sizable number of crates and supplies off at the commerce and trade station in the center of the city. Among the trade agreements and papers, I found this." Shadow Weaver said softly as she handed the file to Angella.

Angella eyed Shadow Weaver's outstretched hand for a moment before taking the file. As she looked over its contents, her face fell into a solemn grimace before looking at Shadow Weaver. "Why show me this? What does Calix have to do with it?"

"At the time of your husband's supposed death, I did not hold the position of second in command. When I heard of Micah's death, I

was shocked. All paperwork flowed through my station at the time and that included a list of the dead. Especially notable figures in the war. I didn't receive any such letter. Do you get what I'm saying Angella?"

"Micah wasn't dead when he was sent to Beast Island?" Angella whispered in horror.

"Yes. But you're missing the point."

"Then what is the point?" Angella asked through gritted teeth as she threw the file down. "Because it is eluding me and hearing about the death of my husband on this day especially is grating my patience more so than ever."

"I'm saying," Shadow Weaver pulled the papers to her hand with magic before handing them back to Angella, "Is that there is a high chance your Husband is alive."

Angella froze. "How can you be sure?"

"General Calix was cruel beyond measure. He liked to see you cling to hope until the very end and then would take pleasure at the sight of your broken spirit. Killing the King of Brightmoon was not enough for the man. If I'm right, I didn't receive the file of Micah's death because he wasn't ever confirmed to be dead."

Angella looked back down at the file before balling her fists up, a slight furious tremor present. She didn't want to imagine what her husband had to endure upon his capture. But If Micah was still alive, then-then she could. . . "Thank you Shadow Weaver. You've given me a bit to think about."

Shadow Weaver nodded as she watched Angella head in the opposite direction. "You're welcome."

Shadow Weaver grinned under her mask. In truth, Shadow Weaver had been the one to personally send Micah to Beast Island. The previous second in command was sure to give Micah a long and torturous death if there ever was one. It was only thanks

to her quick thinking of sending Micah away. She couldn't bear the thought of seeing him dead and could only hope that however he had died on the island that it had been quick.

But with Angella considering her options and Castaspella on her way back to Mystacour, that left Catra all alone for her to finally have a moment to talk with her. As she drifted out of the hall, she found Catra leaning against one of the pillars. "Catra, how are you doing today?"

"I'm doing alright."

"That's good. Walk with me. I want to talk with you about a few things."

"Alright." Catra said as she pushed off of the pillar.

"I hear from Castaspella that you wished to remain here instead of going to Mystacour. Why is that? I thought you'd be delighted to go." Shadow Weaver asked in confusion.

"I am, or rather was. But I can't go to Mystacour. I have other responsibilities to handle4 here. And. . ." Catra went quiet.

"Adora's not there?" Shadow Weaver finished softly. Catra gave a small nod at being called out. Shadow Weaver sighed, "You should tell her how you feel."

"How? It's not easy to say something like that!" Catra exclaimed, throwing her hands in the air.

"It never is. But you have to. Adora feels the same way, you know that right?" Shadow Weaver said as they walked through the Brightmoon Gardens.

"She does?"

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Yes. It's quite obvious. Maybe not to others, but I raised both of you girls. I can notice your habits fairly quickly, I'd say it's almost second nature to me." She

stopped mid stride before turning to look at Catra, taking her mask off. "I know love is hard, and the possibility of being rejected is scary and can make you freeze, but Catra, look at Adora down there." She said, pointing over the balcony down at the streets below. Catra looked to where Shadow Weaver was pointing and quickly saw Adora. She was smiling with Bow and Glimmer. "She would never deliberately hurt you."

Catra looked at Shadow Weaver, "How do I go about it?"

"Get her a gift. I know that Adora is looking forward to the dance, seeing as how the last one got interrupted." Shadow Weaver said as they continued to walk the castle grounds. "Make a gesture that she would appreciate. It doesn't have to be grand, just something meaningful."

Catra thought of Adora and everything she knew about her. Images filled her mind of Adora fighting, laughing, She Ra, what she wore, how her body looked this morni– Her thoughts may have gotten a bit sidetracked. But something stuck out to her. Adora wouldn't care about flowers. No, she had a better idea in mind.

"A knife. Or a weapon of some kind. I think Adora would appreciate that." Catra said.

Shadow Weaver nodded, "It's a good start. Have you decided on an outfit for tonight?"

Catra froze, "No, not really."

"Well then, a word of advice. I'd go with white and gold. If you wish to go for a more obvious route. Matching colors have a bit of a history among couples on Etheria." Shadow Weaver said.

Catra's thoughts flew to the coat that Angella had gifted her. "I think I know what to do. Thank you Shadow Weaver. . . Tomorrow, we can discuss magic. If that's alright with you?"

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Of course." Catra turned and exited the gardens, leaving Shadow Weaver by herself. It was then something became painfully clear to Shadow Weaver. She had observed Catra for the last few days and she could see it. Catra's memories were coming back at an accelerated rate without the shards. Something wasn't adding up.

"Finally. I've been looking for you guys for an hour." Catra said as she walked up to Netossa and Spinnerella. "I need your help with something."

Netossa turned and looked at Catra, "Sure, what's up?"

"It's kind of private but I need your help with my outfit for tonight. Also do either of you know if Sea Hawk and Mermista are here yet?"

Spinnerella shook her head, "Sorry Catra. They still have yet to arrive. But we'll happily help."

As they accompanied Catra back to her and Adora's bedroom, she grabbed the coat from the closet where she had laid it and held it up to them.

"Ohhhh, I like that." Spinnerella cooed. "Are you planning on wearing that tonight?"

"Yeah, but there's a problem." Catra said, laying it on the bed.

"Well, show us the rest of it first." Netosa said.

"That's the problem." Catra said, taking a seat.

". . . That's all there is, isn't it?" Netossa asked.

Catra nodded, "Yep."

"I hate it when that happens." Netossa said as walked over to examine it.

"So, what should I do?"

Spinnerella looked at the dress for a moment before turning back towards Catra, "Are you sure that's what you want to wear? It's lovely and no doubt it'll look good, but those specific colors are. . .."

"They're Adora's colors." Netossa finished, "You might send her the wrong message wearing that."

"What message would that be?" Catra asked defensively.

Spinnerella answered in a gentler tone, "That you're looking to start a romantic relationship with her."

Catra raised an eyebrow, "Yeah, obviously. That's why I want to wear it." Catra said bluntly.

"Oh!" Spinnerella and Netossa said in shock.

"Well, in that case, I know exactly how to help." Spinnerella said.

For the next hour and a half, Catra listened to her friends' advice about how to approach the matter. Their approaches varied a bit but otherwise were fairly similar and both advised her to just tell Adora how she felt about her. Netossa stated that having a drink beforehand might calm any nerves she might have. By the end of the hour, she had picked an outfit for the dance. It consisted of a button up shirt with a shade of red that matched Adora's jacket, a pair of black pants with two golden stripes that ran down the sides of her legs, a pair of boots that stretched just below her knees with a golden buckle and heels.

Catra admired herself in the mirror before turning to face Netossa and Spinnerella, "Thanks, I don't think I could have picked this out myself."

"No problem Catra. We're rooting for you." Spinnerella said as they turned to leave. "Also, the party will begin in about three hours. By this point, everyone should have arrived."

Netossa turned back to look at Catra before closing the door, "Don't worry about changing out of your outfit. Everyone will already be dressed up and getting ready. I suggest finding Sea Hawk quickly. I know you were looking for him earlier."

As the door closed, Catra quickly rushed out to the balcony, scanning Brightmoon. Just past the buildings, she could faintly make out Mermista's ships. Nodding to herself she went to turn to leave before a sudden appearance of sparkles lit up her vision. To her surprise Glimmer had appeared in the room and had immediately marched over to Adora's dresser.

Catra watched in amusement as she dug through the clothes, frantically searching for something. Catra had a guess that she was searching for the hair pin that Adora had worn during Princess Prom.

Catra cleared her throat, startling Glimmer who had yet to notice her. "Looking for something?"

Glimmer spun around but froze when she took in Catra's apparel. Her eyes lit up in excitement before Catra held up the hair pin. "Hey, Sparkles, is this what you're looking for?"

Glimmer nodded, "Yes! Ugh, today has been hectic as hell."

"Well it's not over yet, but can you do me a favor?"

"Sure, what's up?" Glimmer asked as she took the hair pin.

"I'm looking for Sea Hawk. Do you know if he's here yet? I want to get Adora a gift."

"Oh! Yeah, he's with Mermista down by the city stalls. You want me to take you there?"

"Yeah, that'd be appreciated." Catra nodded.

As Glimmer placed a hand on Catra's shoulder, Catra found herself enveloped in magic before finding herself in the marketplace.

Catra shook her head, "I'll never get used to that."

Glimmer let out a small laugh, "Alright, I've got to get going. Remember, the party starts in three hours but you need to be in the castle an hour before that so that we can get ready for our award speeches. So you've got about two hours. Here, take this." Glimmer said, holding out a seal. "That'll let you get anything in the markets of Brightmoon, free of charge. Once you're done with it I'll need it back though. Don't lose it."

Catra gave a nod of thanks, "Got it. See you in a bit."

Glimmer teleported away, leaving her in the middle of the stalls. Catra wandered around, looking for Sea Hawk and Mermista for a few minutes before spotting them. As she walked up to them she called out, "Seah Hawk! Mermista! Over here!"

Sea Hawk and Mermista made their way towards Catra before stopping and looking at her outfit. Sea Hawk was the first one to comment on it, "Well met Catra. I do say, "You are looking quite strapping today."

Mermista raised an eyebrow, "Those colors on purpose?"

Catra gave a nod, "Yeah, but listen, I need your help Sea Hawk."

"Name it my feline friend." Sea Hawk said exuberantly.

"I need help picking out a gift–" Catra began before being cut off.

"For Adora?" Mermista interrupted with a smirk.

Catra could already feel a headache forming, "Yes, for Adora."

"Uh huh. And why do you need our help? Normally, flowers are the way to go for this type of thing." Mermista said, gesturing to Catra's outfit.

"Because flowers aren't Adora's thing. I'm going to get her a knife, or dagger, or. . . something." Catra explained.

"Oh ho! Then you've come to the right man! I know just the place. Onwards!" Sea Hawk cried before weaving through the crowd.

Catra had to admit that she was already enjoying herself as she looked at the people dancing and having fun as they chatted with one another. They arrived in front of a stall that had a lot of ornaments and metal pieces although there were no weapons on display.

"Johnny, my good man, how are you doing this fine day?" Sea Hawk asked a fairly average looking man. Dark hair, dark eyes, a blacksmith if Catra ever saw one.

The man in question simply raised an eyebrow, "Sea Hawk. You here to pay me the money you owe me?"

"Now, now, let's not spoil the festive mood. I'm not here for anything. But our good friend here is. She's looking to acquire a weapon, preferably a gagger of some sort. Catra, this here is Johnny. He's the blacksmith of the one and only Phoenix Anvil"

"Pleasure to meet you. Like Sea Hawk said, I need a weapon." Catra said.

"What for? War's over. No need for weapons anymore." Johnny said as he moved a few things around in his stall.

"A gift." Catra replied. She's not big on flowers and I know she'd appreciate a knife."

Johnny eyed Catra, "No offense, but can you even afford any of my stuff? You look like you've got some cash, judging by that fancy attire, but my weapons aren't exactly cheap y'know. It's not like these ornaments I have out."

Catra reached into her coat's pocket and produced the seal that Glimmer had given her. "My friend said that this should allow me to purchase anything in the marketplace. Does that apply to your weapons?"

Johnny's eyes widened at the sight of the royal family's sigil before letting out a chuckle. "Why didn't you open with that? Of course it applies. But tell me, do you even know what it is you're holding?"

Catra shook her head. "Glimmer handed it to me and said to use it to get a gift."

Johnny nodded, "Figures it's the princess who gave it to you. Girly, that there is the official sigil of the queen herself. That won't just buy something from the marketplace, that could buy a city. That sigil gives you access to the Kingdom's wealth."

Catra suddenly felt a bit less confident brandishing such a thing in broad daylight, even if she was in the Kingdom of Brightmoon. She quickly pocketed the seal to the chuckle of the man. "Yeah, that should be the right reaction. Come on, let's get you a weapon."

As Catra stepped into the man's shop, Sea Hawk and Mermista said they'd wait outside. Once in the back, she noticed all of the weapons. They were all excellently crafted and she could tell that Johnny had mastered his craft. Everything from beautiful swords to elegant long bows lined the walls.

"This is where Sea Hawk chose to take me? Doesn't the guy know I don't have money on me?" Catra muttered.

Johnny laughed. "Yeah, he's a character alright."

"How do you know him?"

"He's my ex." He simply said. Catra realized that that was all he would say on the matter. "So, what are we looking for? Knife? Dagger? Sword? You pick something and I'll bag it up for you."

Catra wasn't sure how long she perused the store, looking at all manner of weapons. She picked up an exceptionally beautiful sword that was black in color and sported a ruby gem in the center. It looked like something the Horde would employ if they

stopped using shock batons. She carefully set it back down and examined a knife that had a ring on one end and a curved blade. Catra looked at all of the weapons carefully before something caught her eye. She walked over to it and gently picked the weapon up. It was a staff that emitted a light red glow along a grooved pattern with golden rings surrounding the ends. A memory flashed through her mind as she recalled her and Adora training with staffs in the Horde as children.

Johnny walked over to it and let out a small smile. "Twist it."

"What?"

"The center? Twist it."

Catra did as he said. Suddenly, the red glow grew brighter before rushing to the ends of the staff, producing two long blades.. They were beautifully designed giving an almost ethereal glow of silver and red. Catra twisted it back to its less lethal mode before tapping it on the ground, a heavy thud sound betraying its weight. She looked at Johnny before nodding. "This one."

Johnny gave a smile. "Alright." He quickly wrapped the weapon before handing it back to her. "She must mean a lot to you, huh?"

Catra didn't respond right away but Johnny didn't miss the smile on her lips. "Yeah."

He didn't want to spoil the girl's evening by telling her that this was one of his signature pieces and that it was worth a small fortune. He knew that the Queen could easily afford such a thing without batting an eye, so he made sure that the wrapping was specially done.

"Don't be afraid to stop by again. You look like someone who would appreciate the subtlety of a blade." Johnny said as she took her gift and left.

Catra gave her thanks before taking her leave, looking for Seah Hawk. As she looked at the sky, she realized that the sun was

slowly setting. It was only now occurring to her that she'd been in the weapons shop longer than she thought. Deciding to hurry up, she started moving towards the castle intent on making it back in time. Just as she made it out of the marketplace, Glimmer appeared before her. "There you are! Did you find a gift?"

Catra held up the wrapped weapon, displaying it to Glimmer. "Yep."

Glimmer looked around before lowering her voice. "What is it?"

"A staff from a weapons shop that Sea Hawk took me to."

Glimmer cringed as she looked closer at the wrapping, "Is that from the Phoenix Anvil?"

Catra looked a bit concerned. "Is that bad?" Catra wondered if she had just been swindled into something cheap.

"No, not bad per say, just that Johnny is the most expensive weapons maker in Bright Moon."

"Oh. . ."

"Whatever, it's fine. I gave you the seal for a gift and you went big with it. No biggie. Ignoring that for a second, we have to get ready. Let's go." Glimmer said as they teleported back to the rooms.

Angella looked over at the duo as they appeared. She looked Catra up and down, a big smile present. "That goes quite well with the coat." Angella noticed the wrapped gift instantly. She let out an exhale of minute annoyance before looking at Glimmer. "Do you have my seal?"

Glimmer nodded, "Here you go mom."

Catra looked from Glimmer to Angella. "Did I do something wrong?"

Angella shook her head. "You didn't do anything wrong, Catra. I take it that that's a gift?"

"Yeah, It's for Adora." Catra answered.

Angella nodded, "I figured. I can't blame Glimmer for this. I imagine she gave you the seal for the gift and left shortly after?"

"Pretty much, yeah."

"All items from Phoenix Anvil must be documented among the Bright Moon ledger. It's a matter of safety and identification." Angella explained. "Do you have the bill of sale?"

Catra nodded before pulling it out of her pocket. "It didn't say how much it was."

"Of course not. Johnny's shop isn't something you can just go into. You need to have a designated official sign off on it. Which I must ask, how did you get him to give you a weapon?"

"Sea Hawk introduced me."

Angella raised an eyebrow. "Sea Hawk? How?"

"He's his ex." Catra said.

Angella remained silent as she took the bill of sale before handing it to Juliet. "No matter. Are you ready for the ceremony?"

"As ready as I can be I suppose."

"Then let's start rehearsing."

Shadow Weaver sat in the room that was initially her cell as she stared at the soul shard in front of her. Something had been bothering her for the last few days about this whole time travel thing. When she had witnessed Catra reforge the shards, she had noticed that it looked very similar to something she had witnessed

in her youth. She could feel the magic surge under the surface of the shard in a calm flow, a far cry from the volatility it had demonstrated before. It was then Shadow Weaver had a terrifying thought. She hoped that she was wrong about it, but she needed to be sure. Throwing caution to the wind, Shadow Weaver reached out to the shard and grasped it in her hand, magic flaring. . . to no reaction. Her blood was like ice in her veins as she came to a terrifying thought. Was Marleena lying? The shards couldn't hold a soul. It wasn't possible. . . was it?It wasn't because they weren't capable of holding large reservoirs of magic, oh no, they did that just fine, but because what she was currently holding in her hand was not a soul shard at all. Shadow Weaver had experimented with the Black Garnet for more than thirty years and upon touching the small stone, she instantly recognized the magical signature. She was holding a piece of a runestone.

Whatever reason Marleena wanted these shards put together was something she couldn't figure out, but she knew that something wasn't adding up. The rifts, the time travel, Catra's returning memories. The woman claimed memory loss but she wasn't so sure. So Shadow Weaver did something she normally wouldn't do without proper preparations. She swapped the shard from the black garnet in her mask for the soul shard. Immediately she could feel the shard's magic flow through her body. It was nothing like the Black Garnet, oh no, it was so much more dangerous. Taking a breath, she walked over to a vase that sat in a corner of the room and quickly shattered it. Calling upon the stored magic, she let the magic flow through her body, directing it towards the broken vase. As she watched the vase put itself back together as if in reverse, Shadow Weaver dropped the spell, letting out a shaky breath.

Something was very wrong.

She did her best to compose herself before heading for the celebration. She needed to do something. She couldn't allow Catra to reforge this rune stone without further knowledge.. The first time Catra had used a shard, she had stepped through time by a thousand years. The second time, she had rewound the day. Now,

there were rifts appearing throughout Etheria. Catra's desperation for her missing memories was fueling her drive to retrieve the shards. For all intents and purposes this was Catra's runestone. She didn't know how, but Catra had forged a connection with this runestone and now. . . now Shadow Weaver didn't know what to do.

Quickly casting an illusion to change the color of the shard to match that of the Black Garnet, she left the room , heading to the ceremony.

Catra suddenly felt like a bundle of nerves as she stood with Angella. Glimmer had teleported to Adora and Bow to help them ready with their speeches. With the evening now right on top of her, she felt a little unsure of herself. She tried to lie to herself and say that her nerves were from the speech that she was going to have to deliver but she knew the truth. She couldn't care less about the speech. In fact she hadn't even prepared a speech. She was just going to thank everyone and that would be it. No, her nerves came from the fact that she was about to confess to Adora at some point in the evening.

"Breathe, Catra." Angella said from her side.

Catra turned her head to look at Angella, "What?"

"You'll be fine. It's just a speech."

"That's not it." Catra said, letting a deep breath out.

"Oh? What then?" Angella asked inquisitively.

". . .It's about Adora." Catra said quietly.

Angella looked confused for a moment before realization dawned on her face. "Ohhhh." A smile graced her lips. "I see. Well then, in that case, the best advice I can give you is to go for it."

Catra looked at her, dumbfounded. "That's it? Really? Just, 'go for it?' Nothing else?"

Angella laughed. "You don't know this but I initially didn't like Micah."

"What?" Catra looked shocked at hearing that.

"It's true. I thought he was annoying, a bit of a know it all, he was shorter than me, and I found him to be very pushy." Angella said as she looked out over the Kingdom as the royal lectern was being set up in preparation of the announcement, "But over time, I came to care about him. His know it all attitude seemed more wise, his annoying attitude was suddenly more charming, his height was endearing, and his pushiness was quite loving."

"Wow. So you just went for it?" Catra asked.

Angella laughed. "You could say that. There was someone else that I was under the assumption that Micah cared for. Well I later found out I was wrong, but that's a story for another time. But the point was that I felt that I had wasted too much time and I needed to at the very least make my feelings known to him."

"How'd you do that?"

"I got some help from a few of our friends and his sister. It wasn't until afterwards that I found out he felt the same way towards me." Angella explained.

"But what if she says no?" Catra asked a bit quieter.

Angella turned and put a comforting hand on Catra's shoulder. "Then that will be Adora's choice. And it will hurt for a while. Rejection always does, but I promise you that a weight will be lifted off of your shoulders. And if you find that she does feel the same way, you will be ever thankful that you did tell her."

Catra was quiet for a moment before giving a grateful smile. "Okay, I think I get it."

Angella gave a small smile. "Good. Now, do you have your speech prepared? We're about to begin."

Catra gave a sheepish smile. "No, but I don't think it needs to be a big thing. I think everyone's just happy that the fighting is over."

Angella nodded, "I suppose you're right. Well let's get started."

True to Catra's words, the speeches and medals were secondary to the joy of the treaty. There were smiles, laughs, and cheers as the medals were laid on each of the alliance members shoulders. Although Frosta was a bit hesitant as she had really only been a part of the alliance for a few days, Angella insisted that she had chosen to help, no matter how recently and that she deserved to be up there with the rest of them. When it was her turn, Catra stepped up to Angella as she laid a medal around her neck. She was ecstatic at the applause and cheering as she stood before an adoring audience. She knew it was for everyone else as well, but she was content to soak it in.

As the ceremony ended, Angella announced that the celebration had begun and for everyone to enjoy the night. Catra noticed Adora with Bow and Glimmer over on the main street. Catra felt her nerves return as her good mood from the medals died a bit. Glimmer caught her out of the corner of her eyes before Catra shook her head as if saying not yet. Catra wandered over to an area where drinks were being served.

She noticed that Netossa, Spinnerella, and Sea Hawk were over here as well. Catra noticed a drink that looked quite similar to a pink morning. She recalled Angella telling her that Salineas had a drink called a sailor's warning that was similar. Catra was about to ask for one before she found a hand holding a bluish purple drink in front of her. Catra looked at the owner only to find Mermista.

Catra raised an eyebrow at the woman. She handed it to Catra as she downed one of her own. "You're gonna want that for when you go talk to Adora, trust me."

Catra looked over at the Sea Hawk as he approached with Netossa and Spinnerella. Sea Hawk stepped forward with a smile. "My darling Mermista is right. The woes of the heart are not easily tread. A hearty drink can make all the difference in how one approaches such things."

Catra looked over at Netossa and Spinnerella and to her surprise they both nodded in agreement. Catra looked at the drink before throwing it back. Immediately, she erupted in a coughing fit before glaring at the offending glass in her hand, "Ugh, that's awful. What is this?"

Mermista laughed, "It's a rum mix. It's definitely a stronger drink for a beginner."

Catra looked out of the corner of her eye at Adora. She was surrounded by people as they talked and laughed with her. All of a sudden, a flash of sparkles lit up her vision as Glimmer appeared in front of her. Catra jumped a bit and was suddenly thankful she had downed her drink when she did.

"Wow, you look just like I did at princess prom." Glimmer said as she looked at Catra.

"I don't know what you mean." Catra said as she turned away from her.

"Catra, you have all night to talk to Adora. Have fun, mingle, don't just stand in one place. Enjoy yourself." Spinnerella said.

"I concur. This is no good. Come! We shall have a most awesome night! Adventure!" Sea Hawk said as he grabbed Catra before dragging her off into the crowd.

Glimmer grinned as Catra disappeared before turning to Mermista, "So, did you get your apology from her?"

Mermista waved her off, "It's fine. Besides, I think that ending the war is as great an apology as any. Now she just needs to see that

Adora feels the same way as well and we can all move on with our lives."

Glimmer laughed, "Yep. You should have seen Adora earlier today. I've never seen Adora actively search for something to wear."

Mermista looked shocked. "Oh! So she was nervous too?"

"Nervous? I'm pretty certain that she wants to confess to Catra as well. She has a gift for her and everything. She even wore red to match Catra's colors." Glimmer explained.

"Hm, well in that case, I hope it works out." Mermista said to Glimmer's agreement.

As the night stretched on, Catra intermingled with people from all over. She met up with Frosta to the girl's delight and hung out with her for a while before being joined by Perfuma and Juliet. Catra had enjoyed the night, trying to let some of her nerves go. One thing was for sure though. Sea Hawk and Mermista had been right, the alcohol had done wonders for her stress. She had a pleasant buzz going that made the night much more enjoyable. The big dance was coming up and Catra had retrieved her gift from where Angella had stored it.

Adora had retrieved the wrapped box that contained Catra's headpiece. She had laid a metal polish on it several hours beforehand to restore its quality. As Adora wandered idly, she caught sight of Catra alone. As she went to make her way over to her, Angella saddled up to Catra's side, disrupting the opportunity. Adora let a bit of annoyance wash over her as she changed course. She then noticed Shadow Weaver off to the side chatting with some locals.

"Shadow Weaver, can I have a moment?"

The woman stopped mid-conversation before turning to Adora. "Yes, Adora?"

"Could you. . ." Adora let out a breath, "Can you help me out?"

Shadow Weaver smiled under her mask. She already knew she meant Catra. "Of course. What do you need?"

"Catra, er, rather, I want some alone time with Catra, but every time I get a chance, someone comes up to her."

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Of course. I know exactly what to do."

"You do?"

"Yes, you stay right here." Shadow Weaver said as she started towards Catra.

As Shadow Weaver walked up to Catra and Angella, they both stopped talking and looked at her. Angella spoke up first, "Shadow Weaver, how are you enjoying the celebration?"

Shadow Weaver could tell right away by the Queen's tone that she had already had a few drinks. "Quite well, actually. And you two?"

"I'm having fun." Catra answered with a bit of cheer.

Shadow Weaver smiled, and it seemed that Catra had also had a drink. She was nowhere near drunk though which was good. "Catra. I do believe that Adora would like some alone time."

Catra froze a bit before looking at Shadow Weaver, "Are you sure?"

"Well, considering she sent me over here to get rid of Angella so that she could get you alone, I would say so, yes." Shadow Weaver drawled.

Angella raised a brow before giving Catra a nudge. "Don't worry about me, Catra. You've been waiting all night. Now's your chance."

Catra gave a nod before gently grabbing her gift and walking towards Adora. Angella smiled as she watched her go before

turning towards Shadow Weaver. "Did you wish to speak with me?"

"Yes, but it can wait for now. This isn't the time to discuss such things." Shadow Weaver said as she wandered off.

"Hm, just as well." Angella said as she walked towards her daughter and Bow.

As Catra and Adora stood together, they smiled at one another. "I like your coat. It looks nice."

Catra smiled at that before holding out her gift. "I got you a gift. Glimmer and Sea Hawk helped me out."

Adora looked at the wrapped item before gently unwrapping it. As she picked up the staff, she admired it in awe. The light subtle red glow reminded her of their time training in the Horde and the laughter that had usually accompanied it.

"Twist it." Catra said. Adora wore the same look that she had when Johnny had told her to twist it. "The staff. Twist the center."

Adora twisted it before two long blades extended, accompanied by a silver and red sheen, giving it an almost ethereal glow. Adora twisted the staff back, causing the blades to retract. Adora was amazed at the staff before gently setting it to the side. "It's beautiful. Thank you Catra."

Catra smiled. "You're welcome."

Adora held out a small box before Catra could continue, "I got you something as well. Shadow Weaver helped a bit."

Catra took the box before opening it. She froze as she gently picked up the head piece. Memories of her time with Adora in the Horde filled her head. She recalled the first time that Adora had given this to her when they were younger. She remembered how they used to sit at the railing and just talk for hours about their future. She remembered their fights, their laughs, moments of

intimacy that they hadn't shared with anyone else. Adora suddenly looked a bit concerned.

"Catra, are you okay?" Adora asked gently.

Catra realized that she had tears running down her face. Quickly wiping her eyes, she nodded with a smile, "I'm fine. I just remembered a lot just now. Thank you." She said before enveloping Adora in a hug that lasted a bit too long to be friendly. As they pulled back a bit, to look at one another. As they stood there, gazing at one another, soft music started to play. Catra looked over Adora's shoulder to see Shadow Weaver ushering her on as she stood beside the band.

"Do you want to dance? I know our last one didn't end too well." Catra asked.

Adora smiled and nodded, pulling her out towards the street where others were dancing. They had set their gifts to one another on the table before Glimmer had teleported over and grabbed them. Adora noticed and gave a thankful nod before focusing on Catra. As they danced, Catra decided to take Angella's advice and just say it. "Adora."

"Yeah?"

". . .I love you. I always have." Catra said softly, almost a whisper.

For Adora, it was almost like the music had stopped. It was just them, with no one else around. She looked Catra in the eyes in shock. "You do?"

Catra gave a soft nod, not trusting her voice. Adora was silent for a second to Catra's stress. All of a sudden, Adora pulled Catra into a kiss. Catra's mind lit up in joy as she pulled back, looking Adora in the eyes before wrapping her arms around Adora's neck and pulling her back into another kiss.

Shadow Weaver grinned. She had done it. Admittedly, it hadn't been too hard if she was being honest. Now all she had to do

was–

A ripple of magic flew across Bright Moon, washing over everyone. Shadow Weaver felt the shard in her mask glow, as if putting up a barrier between her and the ripple. Shadow Weaver watched the landscape change for the briefest of moments, the sky cracked and shattered, rifts opened in the sky as all too familiar monsters poured out of them, the world itself seemingly torn apart as the surge of magic focused in on Catra. She watched in shock as her hair began to change color to purple before she witnessed something extraordinary. Adora had begun to glow and with it the surge recoiled, throwing itself away from Catra, almost as if retreating. As quick as it came, any trace of the ripple was gone. Shadow Weaver whipped around, looking for any sign of change in the area. Nothing. There was nothing. It was as if it hadn't happened at all and she realized then, that no one had noticed it. Not even Catra herself. She focused on Adora and saw the glow was gone. Shadow Weaver eyes narrowed in fury. If she had doubts before, they were gone now. This had nothing to do with memory loss. Catra was being manipulated into breaking time.

Entrapta looked down at her tablet as she sat on Emily, eating tiny food. The images showed a completely destroyed Etheria. She rewound the small video as she watched herself be torn apart by what she could only guess was a form of a black hole.

"Fascinating."

Wow, did this chapter take forever. I hope everyone's enjoying it so far. I think this was probably my favorite chapter so far. I'm not gonna put a time table on it, but I think that we only have about two more chapters to go. But I'll be starting my summer job again soon so updates might be a little slower. For now, comment, like, yada yada. You get it.

Chapter 13

Catra hummed to herself as she walked through the corridors of Brightmoon castles. Thoughts of Adora drifted through her mind as she wandered towards the gardens. Angella had said that Juliet would be privy to the magic lessons on the off chance that Shadow Weaver tried to pull something. Catra had seen no reason to argue.

"I see someone's in a good mood." Juliet said as she fell in stride with her. "I take it everything went well last night?"

Catra simply nodded as she kept on humming happily. Juliet gave a small smile before falling into a comfortable silence. As they entered the courtyard, Catra caught sight of Shadow Weaver with several books and materials in hand. No doubt for the lesson.

Shadow Weaver noticed Catra out of the corner of her eye. She immediately looked at her hair. Brown as always. Shadow Weaver let out a sigh before straightening up. "Good Morning, Catra. Did you enjoy your night?"

Catra smiled, "You could say that. Thank you for your help. And thank you for helping Adora. With the gift, I mean."

"Of course." Shadow Weaver gave a small chuckle before becoming serious. "Are you ready for your lesson? Be warned, I am not going to start small like I normally would. We will be jumping right into advanced forms of combat magic."

Catra lost her smile in favor of a more serious face as she nodded. "Yes, Shadow Weaver."

Shadow Weaver looked at her previous ward in contemplation. She was under no false pretenses that Catra didn't remember her treatment. Her memories were returning at an accelerated rate and she was sure that she remembered a bit of her mistreatment at the very least. The fact that Catra was maintaining a

professional outlook on her objective to learn magic was somewhat commendable.

"Alright. Then you will be needing this. Use it to take notes and record anything you might wish to revisit." She said as she handed Catra a large book of blank pages. On each of the pages there seemed to be preplanned slots for recording notes. One could immediately tell that it was for a scholar. She looked over at General Juliet. "Will you be sitting in on this lesson? I was under the pretense that Adora or the Queen herself would be here during this."

Juliet nodded, "Queen Angella had initially planned on being here but something came up that has called her attention elsewhere. In the future I expect that the Queen or Adora will be here instead of me."

Catra spoke up on Adora's behalf. "Adora headed to the Crystal Castle with Swift Wind for some training with Mara.

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Very well." She said as she walked forward, her hand emitting a slight glow. "Lesson One, the basics of magic and the origins of ley lines. . ."

Adora stepped into the Crystal Castle with a smile on her face. Swift Wind hadn't stopped grinning at her for the whole ride. She might have found it annoying if not for her current mood. As she walked into the main chamber a flash of light appeared, revealing Light Hope.

"Hey, Light Hope. I'm ready to begin training. Is Mara available?" Adora asked, gaining a more serious tone.

Light Hope nodded, "Mara is currently residing in her quarters in the Royal Palace of Eternos. I can contact her if you wish."

Adora blinked before gaining a look of understanding. "Oh right. Our times are different aren't they? Is she asleep? I don't want to bother her."

Light Hope shook her head. "Fortunately, you are somewhat mistaken. Eternia and Etheria are on reversed lunar cycles. While our Etheria may be approaching sunset for you. It is very much close to the same time right now."

"So while Mara's on Eternia we're running on the same time frame?"

"Yes, although I calculate that the time is off by forty three minutes and twenty six seconds." Light Hope said.

Adora nodded to herself before looking at Light Hope. "Yeah, if you could get Mara that would be great."

Light Hope continued to smile. "One moment." She said as her eyes lip up in a digital glow.

Suddenly a hologram appeared and the Crystal Castle shifted into Mara's quarters. Adora took note of Catra laying on a bed off to the side. Entrapta was right in the sense that Catra doesn't move when she's switched.

"Yeah, I suppose that's weird for you, huh?" Mara said from behind her.

"A little bit, but it's alright." Adora said as she gazed at Catra's image blissfully.

Mara stared at her for a moment before smiling. "Y'know, you both look like that when you're talking about one another. Maybe you should say something to one another."

Adora smiled as she turned to look at Mara. "We did."

Mara's eyes widened, "Oh! Uh, congratulations. I see it went well?"

Adora nodded, "She told me last night at the celebration for the war's end."

Mara grinned, "Well good for you two. I'm happy for you. In fact we should take advantage of this."

Adora frowned, "What do you mean?"

Mara pulled her sword out and held it in front of her. "See, She Ra works a little differently from other magics. Our power isn't something that you can command just through meditation and discipline, although it helps. She Ra's power has an emotional aspect as well. Positivity and love play a big part in the power as well."

"Oh, I see. Is that why I haven't been able to heal? I thought I had healed Catra earlier but we were unsure of it until Catra told me that you were healing her at the same time." Adora explained, a bit of dejection slipping into her voice.

"Hey, don't worry about it. Healing isn't something I could do right away either. It took training. So, let's get to it. We'll start with the basics."

For most of the day, Mara taught Adora about the skills and abilities of She Ra. Mara noticed that Adora seemed hung up on the fact that she couldn't heal and so she prioritized it. Within a couple hours, Adora had figured it out and could perform the power. Adora was in awe at how much she was able to accomplish in a single lesson with an actual teacher.

"Wow!" Adora marveled at her progress.

Mara giggled, "Having a teacher makes a world of difference, huh?"

Adora nodded with a grin. "I've been struggling with so much this past year and you showed me just how simple a lot of it was. Thank you so much."

"No problem. Believe me, I get it. A lot of my early training was touch and go. Until my sword was made, I was only to transform one time."

"What do you mean? Can we transform without our sword?"

Mara nodded, "Supposedly, yes. Razz told me that She Ra's been around long before the sword. I've never been able to trigger it though since that first time. Intense emotion seemed to trigger it for me."

". . . Was there a bright glow? Like an intense rush of euphoria and joy?"

Mara nodded, "Yeah, that pretty much sums it up. Why?"

"Last night when Catra and I–" Adora stammered.

Mara smiled, "When you kissed each other you started to glow?"

Adora's face lit up with a blush before she nodded, "Yeah. I was just confused as to what had happened."

Mara nodded, "You accessed your power without the sword. If you keep training, who knows, maybe you'll be able to–"

Mara was cut off by the sound of her door opening as Adora looked behind her. She was met with the sight of Evelyn entering with several things in hand including a few bags. Evelyn stopped at the sight of Adora, going abnormally quiet, ". . .Who's this, Mara?"

"Oh, I suppose introductions are in order. This is Catra's. . . girlfriend, Adora." Mara stumbled on her words, unsure of how to address it.

"Adora?" Evelyn muttered in confusion before walking up to the young woman.

"Uh, nice to meet you ma'am. I'm Adora, the She Ra of my timeline. Catra's talked a bit about you." Adora said, holding her hand out.

Evelyn reached out to shake her hand, before it phased through. "Oh, right. Well, it's a pleasure to meet you. . .Adora."

"Oh, um, I suppose since Catra hasn't had the chance to ask you I'll ask for her. Catra is wondering if you would teach her magic. She also wants to know if the upgrade to her technology will be available soon." Adora said, relaying Catra's message.

Evelyn just stared at Adora quietly. Mara eyed her mother for a moment, confused at her strange behavior before grabbing her shoulder and gently shaking. "Mom. Adora asked you a question. Are you alright?"

Evelyn looked at her daughter for a moment before looking back at Adora, "Adora, do you have any parents? I'm not trying to sound rude but I'm trying to figure something out."

"Oh, uh, no. I was raised by the Horde along with the rest of the war orphans. Why do you ask?" Adora asked, a bit put off.

"Your name is very familiar and you look like somebody that I once knew." Evelyn said as she shook her head. "In any case, I had already planned to offer to teach Catra magic. As for the technology, yes. It will be ready within a few days most likely."

Adora nodded in affirmation before turning towards Mara, "I'll be sure to let Catra know. Besides that, thank you. You've helped me more than you know. Is there a schedule that works for you? I don't want to be a bother and pull you away from your duties."

Mara shook her head, "No, it's fine. When Catra switches over I'll send the schedule with her. Speaking of Catra, what's she up to right now?"

Adora lost her smile immediately, "She's getting a lesson in magic at the moment."

"You don't look too enthused about that? I thought you wanted her to learn magic?" Evelyn spoke up.

"I do. From you or Castaspella. She's currently learning from a woman named Shadow Weaver. She's. . .like my mother I suppose, as in she raised me. Although she's anything but."

"Shadow Weaver's training her?" Mara said aghast.

"Catra told you about her?" Adora asked.

Mara nodded, "A bit. I'm more concerned with what I saw in both of your memories. She's a vile person. Does Catra know? Have you told her?"

Adora nodded, a hard look on her face. "Catra knows. I've told her and I suspect she remembers more than a fair share. Her memories are coming back fast. But she's the only one who can teach her magic that's close by." Adora's face lit up in a desperate look as she turned towards Evelyn. "That's why I need your help. If you can teach her instead, she won't need to be around her as often. I don't know what she wants from Catra but I don't trust her. Catra tells me you're the most skilled sorceress on your planet. Is there any way you could teach her across the time stream like Mara's teaching me."

Evelyn nodded, her strange behavior gone. "I can. Easily. As I said, I will teach Catra magic. We're currently preparing to head back to Etheria in six days."

Adora nodded gratefully, "Thank you." She let out a sigh. "I have to go, but like I said, I'll let Catra know to switch in a few days."

Mara waved, "Goodbye Adora."

With that, Adora's image disappeared. Mara turned towards her mother in confusion. "Okay, what was that? As soon as you saw her, you started to act weird."

Evelyn looked at her daughter. "Why didn't you mention her before?"

"I did. What are you talking about?" Mara asked.

"I meant her name. Not just 'future She Ra.'"

"Does it matter?" Mara asked, confused.

"I– . . .Nevermind. I just thought she seemed familiar." Evelyn said.

"Well, if–"

Mara was immediately cut off by a guard rushing into the room. "Ma'am! Ma'am! Come quick!"

They were both immediately on their feet at the guards frantic tone. Mara stepped forward, shifting into She Ra before anyone could blink. "What's wrong?"

The guard eyed Mara for a brief moment before shaking her head. "King Randor has called for the High Mage. The queen is awake!"

Mara and Evelyn looked at one another in shock before they ran out the door. As the sounds of their footsteps faded, the door slowly opened. The room was deathly quiet as a figure stepped into the room, looming above Catra. Upon seeing the unconscious Catra they let out a gasp. Had everyone not been so focused on the waking of the queen, they might have noticed the cloaked figure carrying the unconscious Catra away from the castle.

Catra was having a marginally less successful time with her lesson compared to Adora. So much so that Shadow Weaver had ended the session for the day. Catra had been understandably upset by this. But to her surprise, Shadow Weaver wasn't angry or disappointed and had shown no outward reaction. It was like she had expected it. Unfortunately, this had left Catra with nothing to do for most of the day besides dwell on her shortcoming.

She wasn't sure what the problem was. She had been able to use magic several times before today and hadn't struggled with it before today. Her motivation was there, unfortunately it seemed

her magic was not. She let out a dejected sigh as she headed back towards her room.

Glimmer and Bow caught sight of Catra trudging through the castle grounds before heading towards her. Bow spoke up first, "What's going on Catra?"

"Yeah, you look upset. I thought you'd be happier today." Glimmer said with some concern.

Catra looked at them before letting out a sigh, "I'm not upset, not really anyways. It's just. . . today was the day I'd start learning magic and I completely failed. I couldn't even conjure it at all."

Glimmer looked a bit confused at Catra's words. "How? Haven't you been doing magic for the last week? How does that work?"

"That's what I'm wondering!" Catra said exasperatedly, throwing her arms in the air. "I did the drain just fine, I did the time stuff, but the moment I can learn about throwing a fireball or something, I can't even call on it."

Bow gained an inquisitive look, "I hear magic has to do with a lot of focus and emotions. How do you normally do your time magic?"

Catra shrugged, "I don't know. It's just a feeling I get. Even when I switch, I normally just think of Mara or Adora, but even then I'm just kind of doing it. Shadow Weaver said that I have a lot of magic potential. Like a serious amount. But I can't even call on it."

Glimmer hummed, "That kind of sounds like how I teleport."

Catra raised an eyebrow, "How so?"

She shrugged, "I just do it. I don't really need to think about it. It just comes naturally. Even the light bolts I throw out, I just kind of do. But when I tried magic without using my powers, well. . ." Glimmer trailed off before holding a finger up, "I sucked. But, when I figured it out and that feeling I needed," Glimmer drew a

circle in the air before letting it dissipate, "I found it was much easier."

"So you're saying, what, I'm too used to the wrong feeling and I'm latching on to my time powers?" Catra asked.

Glimmer nodded, "Pretty much."

Bow spoke up, "Actually, speaking of your time powers, have you actually tried using your powers in a different way without rewinding?"

Glimmer nodded in agreement, "Yeah! You should try your time magic. See if you get any different results."

Catra was quiet for a second before slowly nodding, "Alright. How do you throw a light bolt? Like, what's the feeling? Aggression?"

Glimmer held her hand out, conjuring a ball of light in her hands. "I use the feeling of my magic that my runestone gives me and think about a projectile, something I can throw. When that starts forming in my hand I pretty much just think of a ball or a fist of light. And then I just rear back and–" Glimmer finished by throwing the ball at a tree causing a small explosion of sparkles.

Catra looked down at her hand, thinking of what glimmer said. She tried to envision the feeling when she would rewind. She quickly felt it swirl in her body before going somewhat still. It was almost focused. No, it felt more. . .primed. Catra imagined a projectile, something that would shoot. She felt the energy swirl in her palm to her shock. After a moment she could see it.

"Woah!" Glimmer exclaimed.

"Now what?" Catra said in a slightly panicking tone.

"Just imagine a ball or something. It needs to feel comfortable to you. And then when you're ready, let it rip!" Glimmer exclaimed.

Catra nodded before imagining a shape. Her mind drifted to the Horde bombs that she was trained to throw in her youth. She noticed the shape quickly shifted to an orb. It looked almost distorted. Catra looked at the tree that Glimmer had shot a few seconds prior and arced her hand at it, sending the orb at the tree.

The effect was immediate. As soon as it hit, the orb expanded, creating a very familiar field that she immediately recognized. She realized that it was the same effect the pockets of energy had emitted during the day that Catra and Mara had erased. Although this looked cleaner, less corrupted.

"Wow! You did it!" Glimmer said, stepping closer to the orb of distortion and examining it. "What does it do?"

Catra walked towards it. "If I'm right," Catra reached down and picked up a rock, "It should be a field of stasis. I ran into one of these pockets with Mara when I rewound the day for her. I should be able to walk through it just fine."

Catra took a step inside and saw the same field that had encompassed her body in a protective layer earlier was doing it again. She took the rock and tossed it in the air. As soon as she let go, the field retracted from the stone leaving it frozen in time, unmoving. Catra walked out of the field before stepping beside Glimmer.

"I think it only lasts about a minute. Bow, can you time this?" Catra asked.

Bow gave a nod. True to Catra's words, about thirty seconds in, the rock started to move up slowly before starting to fall at an accelerated rate. After the minute had passed, the orb immediately vanished. Catra couldn't help it and immediately her face broke into a grin.

"Yes! Thank you so much!" Catra wrapped Glimmer into a hug. "What else can I do?"

"What's going on?" Angella's voice sounded as she walked around the corner.

"We just figured out that Catra's basically a princess." Glimmer said with a smile.

Catra immediately stopped, "Woah woah woah, I am not a princess."

Glimmer gained a bit of a smug look, "Then what do you call what you just did? You even had to emulate me."

"Well. . .Princesses have runestones. I don't have a runestone. I have weird time powers." Catra said, firing back with an equally triumphant grin.

"What happened?" Angella looked at Bow.

"Catra made a time bomb that she was able to throw like Glimmer's light bolts. It froze time for a single minute in the affected area. It seemed completely safe as well."

"You did? And it was controlled? Huh, the payoff on the lesson was greater than I thought it would be." Angella said happily, "I'm glad you're doing well."

"No, see that's the thing. Catra said she absolutely failed at magic the way I initially did. So I told her how I used my powers from the moon stone and she copied me. That's why I think it's like a princess." Glimmer said teasingly.

"But I'm not. I only got my powers after I touched a. . ." Catra's smile slowly faded as something clicked in her mind. The mood shift was obvious as well.

"The soul shard." Glimmer finished before looking at Bow, "You don't think. . .That's not possible, right?"

"No, it's not. A runestone can only work when it's whole. Even chipping away at one can have dire consequences. You also need

to be attuned to it through a bloodline. The soul shards also took Catra's memories away. Rune stones don't do that." Angella explained. Catra let out a sigh of relief upon hearing that.

Glimmer shrugged, "Well, in any case, let's get some supper. I'm starving."

Adora returned to Bright Moon on the back of Swift Wind fairly quickly. She was a little put off by Mara's mother but if Angella was anything to go by, not all mothers were the same, so she did her best to not judge.

As she dismounted Swift Wind she thanked him before heading for the main hall. As she walked the halls, she heard Glimmer, Bow, and Angella talking. Upon rounding the corner she caught sight of Catra as well. It seemed like she had arrived just in time for lunch.

"Hey guys. How's your day been?" Adora asked as she took a seat next to Catra. Adora didn't miss the way Angella smiled at them.

"Catra learned a new spell." Glimmer said excitedly.

"You did? What can you do?" Adora asked, matching her friend's tone.

Catra set her drink down before speaking, "Well, turns out, I suck at normal magic."

Adora was dumbfounded upon hearing this. "What? How? You've been doing magic for the past month."

"Yep. Which brings us to the new spell I learned. Turns out that my time powers operate similar to a princess. Glimmer helped me out and now I can make an orb that freezes time for about a minute."

Adora's eyes widened in awe. "I wanna see!"

Catra grinned at her tone before looking at a pitcher of water on the table. She turned towards Angella. "Can I. . .?"

Angella, who at this point had not seen it either, was quite interested as well. "Go ahead."

Catra nodded before standing from the table and grabbing the pitcher. In her other hand she summoned the time bomb. She looked at Adora, "Are you ready?"

Adora nodded, focused on Catra. At the affirmation, Catra threw the water into the air before chucking the bomb at the ground below the water. The effect was instantaneous in the way everything froze. Adora and Angella stood up and walked around the distorted field, marveling at the water suspended in air. Catra stepped into the field as the protective layer formed once again. She took the pitcher and grabbed the water out of the air before stepping out of it. After about a minute, the few water droplets that remained in the air slowly started to fall before immediately resuming their normal speed.

"Woah! Can you do anything else? Also, why can you do that?" Adora asked.

Catra shrugged, "Beats me, but it's cool right?"

"Super cool!" Glimmer said.

Angella looked at the water on the floor, contemplating something. Marleena had used this same effect on her and the guards the first time they had spoken although it had been reversed as everything outside of the orb had been frozen. Angella glanced at the best friends squad before nodding. Another piece of the puzzle was added.

"While that is cool, I don't think you should play with it." Bow said.

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Why?"

"Messing with time sounds like a bad idea. I know that it's your magic and everything but I would still advise some caution." Bow explained.

"I get that, but I'm not rewinding. I'm freezing and at most only for a minute in a relatively small area. I don't think there's any chance of problems with the bomb." Catra said.

Adora nodded, "I'm with you on the rewinding part Bow, but I think this is a bit different. It looks stable and safe." Adora stopped for a minute before turning towards Catra. "Oh! I met Evelyn."

"You did? I only talked to her for a little bit before I went to talk to King Randor." Catra said.

"Who's King Randor?" Glimmer asked.

"Who's Evelyn?" Bow asked immediately after.

"If I recall, Evelyn is Mara's mother, correct?" Angella asked.

"Yeah," Catra said, "She's the Eternian High Mage under King Randor. He's the King of Eternia."

"Wow!" Bow's eyes seemed to sparkle, "You actually met a king from another world. What did he talk to you about? Why did he come all the way to Etheria?"

"Oh, no, *I'm* on Eternia. Mara and I left Etheria because he wanted to speak with me. But that's besides the point," Catra turned back to Adora, "What did you guys talk about?"

"Evelyn has agreed to teach you magic. She also said that she can easily teach you through Light Hope like Mara's teaching me." Adora explained.

"That's great news." Angella said, genuinely happy that there was an alternative to Shadow Weaver.

"What was she like?"

Everyone turned towards the door to see Shadow Weaver. "Where have you been?" Angella asked hotly.

"Evelyn. What was she like? Did she act strange at all?" Shadow Weaver asked, ignoring Angella.

Adora looked at Shadow Weaver suspiciously, "She was a bit weird I suppose. Nothing too out of the ordinary. Although she asked me if I had any parents."

"What? Why?" Catra looked at Adora.

Adora shrugged. "I don't know, but she said my name sounded familiar and I looked like someone she knew."

"Shadow Weaver! Answer me. After Catra's lesson, Juliet reported that you left Bright Moon. Explain yourself." Angella demanded.

". . .I have reason to believe that Marleena is lying to you." She said looking at Catra. "Lying to us all in fact."

"That's ridiculous. Catra was literally by her bedside just two days ago." Glimmer said. Although Angella remained quiet.

Shadow Weaver noticed Angella's silence, "You've thought about it too, haven't you? That she's not what she seems?"

"Do you have proof?" Angella asked.

Shadow Weaver turned towards Catra. "Tell me something about Earth. Name a country or a capital city. Anything that sticks out. If I'm right it should be extraordinarily difficult."

"I—It's hard to! I know Marleena's from Washington and that she's an astronaut but I can't think of anything else." Catra said in shock.

"I thought so. The reason is that the soul shards are a lie. Glimmer, you were right." Shadow Weaver said, turning towards her.

"I was? About what?"

"Catra's powers aren't like a princess's, they are a princess's. We haven't been reforming her soul. We've been reforming a runestone that Catra has formed a connection to." Shadow Weaver said, holding up the shard of the Black Garnet. "You know what this is right, Adora?"

Adora nodded, "It's a piece of the Black Garnet. I didn't know you had two of them though."

"I don't." Shadow Weaver said as she dropped her illusion over her mask. Immediately the shard in her mask returned to its light shade of blue. "Yesterday, Kyle delivered several things, this being among them. I noticed the energy off put was almost identical to the Black Garnet and the Moon Stone."

"But that's impossible. A runestone loses all power once broken. Every princess knows this." Angella said.

"Unless it's in a perpetual stasis field." Catra muttered. "But what does it have to do with Adora? Ever since this started, Marleena has brought her up over and over. Not just as She Ra either."

Angella looked at Shadow Weaver. ". . .Is Adora an Eternian?"

"What!" Glimmer exclaimed. "Why would you think that?"

"Yeah, that sounds ridiculous. Especially considering they've been dead for a thousand years." Bow said, throwing his thoughts out on the matter.

Angella looked at Catra with a hopeful look. "Catra, tell me, what has Marleena said about Adora. Anything at all will help."

Adora looked at everyone around her. "How could I be Eternian? I've lived here my whole life."

Catra looked at Adora before answering. "She said she didn't know. She said that Adora being She Ra bothered her and she didn't know why she knew her."

Angella lost her hopeful look in an instant. "Shadow Weaver's right. Marlena's lying about something."

Adora looked at Angella. "What? How do you know?"

"I believe it was Catra's third night here. You switched for the second time?" Angella looked at Catra.

"I remember."

Angella nodded, "Well, that was the night I met Marleena. She said that it was impossible that you could be She Ra. She very clearly knew you, Adora."

Adora looked at Catra, "I. . .did she say anything else about me?"

Catra shook her head, "I've only talked to her twice. Maybe Mara would know more."

Shadow Weaver stepped forward. "I know how hard this must be to believe. Until this month, we on Etheria had no concept of other universes and timelines. Yet the proof stands before us."

Everyone turned to look at Catra and Adora. "Us?" Adora asked.

In Hordak's quest to escape Etheria he succeeded in his goal of creating a portal years ago. It was only for a moment but in that, a child came through. That child was you, Adora. You were brought through a portal from another world. But now," Shadow Weaver looked at Catra, "Now I'm not so sure."

"What are you saying?" Catra asked.

"Catra, your origins are a mystery even to me. There was no record of birth. No parents. Nothing. And certainly nothing to imply a royal descendance. But until you made contact with the shard, it had never reacted in such a way before." Shadow Weaver put a hand on her shoulder, "Catra, you formed a connection with a runestone that manipulates time. Do you understand the implications of that?"

"Are you saying that Adora and I. . . aren't from Etheria?" Catra asked in a small voice.

"Leave her alone. You're lying, we all know it. You lie about everything."

"I wish I was. But I'm not." Shadow Weaver turned towards the door, "Entrapta, show them the video."

Everyone turned towards the doorway to see the long purple haired princess. "Hello!"

"Entrapta? What are you doing here? What video?" Bow said, confused.

"Last night at the moment Catra and Adora kissed, a pulse washed over Etheria, destroying everything. Rifts started appearing, tentacle eye monsters were everywhere, it was fascinating!" Entrapta said as she pulled the video up on her tablet. "I have no prior memory of what happened but somehow I retained footage of the event."

True to her words, everyone watched as the exact details were displayed on screen. Catra felt ill as she watched a repeat of events that had happened to Mara's timeline before she had stopped them. And then, as the pulse closed in on Catra and Adora, a bright light appeared and sent the pulse retreating as if the events hadn't happened.

The group remained silent before Bow spoke up, "Did. . .did Catra's hair just turn purple?"

Catra looked at Bow before taking the trackerpad from Entrapta and rewinding it. True to Bow's words, Catra's appearance had changed drastically in those few short seconds. It wasn't just her hair either. Her fur had lightened to become almost white, her tail was bushier, and she seemed to get a bit taller and more developed. But beyond that, she could still tell it was her. "What happened to me?"

Shadow Weaver looked at Catra, "I don't know. My best guess is that time was affecting us all in different ways. Entrapta was killed as you can see, but several people had changed. Angella, when the pulse washed over you you disappeared. Glimmer, you became taller, more akin to your mother's appearance. I'm sure there were others but I was only allowed a few seconds before Adora sent the wave retreating."

"I did that?" Adora asked as she watched the wave instantly retreat from the glow.

"Yes. Although I'm not sure what exactly you did." Shadow Weaver drawled, "Any ideas?"

Adora thought back to her training with Mara, "Mara said that we can turn into She Ra without the sword. It just takes intense emotion to achieve."

"Like kissing your girlfriend?" Glimmer asked with a slight smirk.

Adora huffed, "Yes, like kissing my girlfriend." She turned back towards Shadow Weaver, "But that doesn't explain–"

Adora stopped mid sentence as everyone turned to look at Catra. "Catra?"

"What? Why are you all staring at me?" Catra asked, slightly panicked.

"Catra, you're glowing again. Can't you see it?" Angella asked concerned.

Catra looked at herself. As far as she could tell, there was no glow. "No, I don't see any glow. What are you guys talking about?"

"What? Why are you all staring at me?" Catra asked, slightly panicked.

"Catra, you're glowing again. Can't you–" Angella stopped mid sentence. "What just happened?"

Catra looked at herself. As far as she could tell, there was no glow. "No, I don't see any glow. What are you guys talking about?"

"If I recall, Evelyn is Mara's mother, correct?" Angella asked before a look of horror appeared on her face.

Yeah, Catra said, "She's the Eternian High Mage under King Randor. He's the King of Eternia."

Adora and everyone looked around. "We're rewinding! Catra, stop!"

"Oh, no, *I'm* on Eternia. Mara and I left Eternia because he wanted to speak with me. But that's beside the point," Catra turned back to Adora, "What did you guys talk about?"

"I can't touch her! It's like she's not real!" Glimmer cried as she tried to grab Catra only for her to slide back from her.

Adora looked around the castle as cracks in the very air itself appeared. She quickly raised her sword, "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

As soon as She Ra was present, she saw it. The pulse of magic hovering in the air, flowing through Catra. She noticed the energy almost seemed to hiss at the door. Suddenly the door crashed

open to reveal Shadow Weaver. She quickly drew a circle in the air before sending it out into the room.

Adora watched as all of the magic that was assaulting the area recoiled away from Catra.

Catra looked at herself. As far as she could tell, there was no glow. "No, I don't see any glow. What are you guys talking–" Catra looked at Adora. "When did you transform into She Ra?"

They all looked at one another. Shadow Weaver quickly drew a circle in the air before sending it into the castle wall. When nothing happened they all let out a sigh of relief.

"Anyone wanna tell me what that was all about?"

Adora gave a small nod, "It looks like we stabilized it."

"Hello, Etheria to Adora? Anyone gonna answer me?"

"Guys, her hair is purple." Glimmer said in a shocked voice.

"Yeah, so what? My hair's always purple." Catra said. "Are you guys alright? You're kinda freaking me out."

"Catra, what were we just talking about?" Adora asked in a serious tone.

Catra eyed her girlfriend for a moment before answering in a cautious tone. "That Marleena might be lying to us. . . and that you and I might not be from Etheria." Catra looked at Glimmer, "Did I mess with time? Is my hair not supposed to be purple?"

"Catra, your hair is brown." Angella said.

Adora looked at Catra's face as it turned pale. Suddenly she looked around, "Where's Entrapta?"

"Who?" Catra asked.

"Entrapta! She just showed us a video?" Glimmer said, panicking.

"But. . .Bow showed us that video. Who's Entrapta?" Catra looked increasingly worried.

Shadow Weaver looked at everyone. "Is Catra still glowing to anyone else?"

Everyone said no before Adora answered, "Yes. She's still glowing."

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Good. Now listen to me very carefully Adora. Do *not* transform back. Remain as She Ra. As for you Catra, I need you to–"

Shadow Weaver was interrupted by Catra's trackerpad ringing. Catra pulled it out to see Mara's face. Adora looked at Catra, "I thought that the technology wouldn't be done for a few days."

Catra looked back at the pad before answering, "Mara? How are you calling us?"

"Catra! Thank Sharella you answered. I'm riding a signal in between our swords. Zed and Light Hope set it up. Listen, it's absolute chaos here right now. We– What happened to your hair?" Mara asked.

Adora peered over Catra's shoulder. "It wasn't purple for you?"

"No, It's supposed to be brown." Mara said somewhat suspiciously. "What happened?"

"Catra started rewinding at an accelerated rate. We couldn't touch her in any shape or form. She wasn't responding at all. Shadow Weaver and I were able to stop it, but now Catra's hair is purple and one of our friends is missing."

"Guys? Dryll is gone." Bow said from the side.

"What do you mean gone?" Glimmer asked.

"I mean *gone*. No signals, no images, any information I had on Entrapta or Dryll is gone. Like it doesn't exist." Bow said in terror.

"Fuck," Mara muttered, "Listen! Catra, you need to switch to me now. Somebody abducted you from the castle."

"What!" Angella gasped.

"We're all over the place. But something isn't adding up. You're kidnapped, something's messing with your time, and now Queen Marlena's awake."

Shadow Weaver chuckled harshly. "Yes, why not have the most suspicious person wake up at the same time."

"What do you mean by 'suspicious?'" Mara asked.

"Marleena lied to us." Catra answered. "The soul shards don't contain souls. They're pieces of a runestone. My runestone. That's where my time magic comes from."

"It's also the only reason we're safe right now." Shadow Weaver said, stepping into view to get a good look at Mara.

Mara was quiet as she stared at Shadow Weaver before narrowing her eyes. "Give me a second." She pushed a few buttons before Light Hope appeared on screen. "Hope, pull up Queen C'yra's runestone."

Light Hope's eyes glowed before looking apologetic. "I'm sorry Mara, but I'm not permitted to give you access to that information. This is restricted."

"What? What do you mean? By who?" Mara asked incredulously.

"By Queen Marleena." Light Hope answered.

Mara looked shocked before Adora asked a question, "Light Hope, when was this information deemed classified? Can you answer that?"

Light Hope nodded, "Three years ago."

Adora nodded, "And when was Marleena put into a coma?"

"Approximately eight months after."

"Does Queen C'yra have access to her runestone anymore?" Adora asked.

Light Hope looked like she was struggling to answer this question before shaking her head, "No. It became. . . inoperative. For classified reasons."

"Light Hope was it? Can you pull up an image of Queen C'yra?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"One moment," Light Hope said before an image appeared on the screen.

For a moment Catra thought she was looking in a mirror. Coupled with her now purple hair and her one golden eye that matched hers, Catra was a bit shocked to say the least.

Angella looked at Catra and Adora's faces before walking around them to look over her shoulders only to see the striking similarities.

"Light Hope, set our course for Primus." Mara said before looking back at Catra. "I'm getting a pretty clear picture here but I'm hoping I'm wrong."

Catra looked down at her hands as she felt that familiar rush of magic, "Adora. I think I'm–" Immediately Catra legs buckled under her as Adora instantly reached out and caught her.

"Did. . .did she just switch?" Mara asked.

I think so." Angella said as she picked up the trackerpad. "Thank you for calling us Mara. Keep us posted on any updates that may arise."

Mara nodded. "Can do."

The screen went black as Adora started towards their bedroom. Adora stopped mid stride as she saw a crack appear in the air before Entrapta was back.

"Wow! Did I just get erased?" Entrapta asked excitedly.

"Entrapta!" Glimmer rushed over, enveloping the woman into a hug. "We thought you were gone."

Bow quickly looked at his trackerpad before breathing a sigh of relief, "Dryll is back."

Entrapta patted Glimmer's head with her hair. "There there, but in other news, I've isolated the cause of the pulses."

"You have? That's great! What is it?" Bow asked.

"Surprisingly, there are two sources. The first one was obviously Catra and the second one is Adora."

"Me? How?"

"I don't know. Isn't that great? But once I figure it out, I should be able to neutralize them." Entrapta said with a tone and smile that seemed a little manic.

"Adora, look." Angella said, pointing to Catra.

Adora looked at Catra as she noticed her hair. It was like a wave of blue energy as it slowly crawled across her body, returning Catra's hair to it's normal color of brown.

Catra's eyes snapped open as her claws unsheathed. She went to stand before finding that she was unable to move her arms or legs. Catra looked around the room only to find herself alone.

"Shit. Okay, okay, think Catra." she said to herself trying not to panic.

"C'yra." A woman said from behind her.

Catra strained her neck to look at the owner of the voice, only to find it somewhat difficult. "What?"

The woman walked into view. It was none other than Queen C'yra herself. "Your name? It's supposed to be C'yra, not Catra."

Catra eyed her. She really did look just like this woman. "Queen C'yra?"

She chuckled, "Yes, that's me. I suppose you have questions?"

"That's putting it lightly." Catra twisted her arms uncomfortably. "Can you let me out?"

"Can you put your claws away?" She countered.

Catra realized that she probably looked highly aggressive and did as the woman requested. "Are we good?"

C'yra nodded before stepping forward and undoing the straps. "I'm sorry I had to do that. I couldn't take the risk that you wouldn't swing at the first person you saw."

Catra shrugged as she rubbed her wrists and ankles. "It's fine. So, do you wanna explain why you kidnapped me?"

C'yra studied Catra silently. She looked quite sad from what Catra could see. Catra decided to ask a different question, "Why'd you say my name was C'yra?"

"It's what I was going to name you."

Catra looked baffled at her words. "What do you mean?"

"I suppose this is all quite confusing." C'yra said as she started towards the door. She stopped and turned back towards her, "Are

you coming?"

Catra quickly got to her feet and went after her, falling in stride. As they walked down the hall, Catra took note of the architecture. She was seeing a lot of archways and marble pillars. If she was being honest, it looked more rugged in a royal aesthetic. It was definitely different from Brightmoon. She was also getting an eerie feeling of deja vu, "So do you want to explain what you meant by that?"

C'yra looked solemn as she continued forward. She didn't give any notion as to where they were going but replied softly, "I'll explain shortly."

Catra threw her hands up in exasperation as she walked with the woman. As they came to a hallway, she noticed other people were walking the halls. All of them looked like her in the sense that they all had feline features. "Am. . .am I on Primus? Is this Halfmoon?"

For the first time, C'yra smiled. "It is indeed. Do you. . .recognize it by chance?" She asked cautiously.

"It. . .feels familiar. I can't explain it." Catra said.

By this point people were staring at her as they parted and kneeled for the queen. It was a little irritating that she couldn't hear any whispers. These people were dead quiet.

"You know that eavesdropping is considered rude, right?" C'yra said, her brow raised.

Catra shifted a bit. "I wasn't eavesdropping."

"No, but you were trying."

"How can you tell?"

"Your ears twitch when you're listening intently. We all do it." C'yra continued, "but you're in my presence so they will not

whisper around me. It's considered socially unacceptable to whisper in my presence."

"Why?"

"I'm sure there's a reason for it but that is how it's always been. Ever since my great great grandmother's time." She explained. As they walked into a room with a large stone table and several seats Catra couldn't help but wonder if this was the war room. C'yra turned towards a guard, "See to it that we aren't disturbed."

"Of course, your majesty. We also have reports that She Ra has just landed. She will be here very shortly."

"Mara's here?" Catra asked.

C'yra looked at Catra for a moment, "Send her here when she arrives. I want to speak to her as well."

"As you command." The guard replied before stepping out of the room and closing the door.

"There we are. Now we can talk." C'yra said

Catra eyed the woman, a thousand questions on her mind. ". . .Why do I have time powers?"

"Ah, so that's the one you want to start with, huh? Alright. It's a complicated answer though." Catra nodded. "You have these abilities because you are my daughter. Or rather are supposed to be my daughter."

"So I'm like a princess then?" Catra asked. 'Guess Glimmer was right.' she thought to herself

"So you were raised on Etheria then?" C'yra asked.

"How'd you know?" Catra asked.'

"The term Princess, meaning an individual with a powerful bloodline or connection to an external source of power, is exclusive to Etheria. There are other names for them such as conduit, the chosen, elementals, etc. The list goes on, but Etheria's is 'Princess.'"

Catra was genuinely surprised to learn that. "Oh. Well, yeah, I'm from Etheria."

C'yra smiled, "That's good. I couldn't think of a kinder place to grow up."

Catra looked at her before asking another question, "You said I'm supposed to be your daughter. How?"

"That is also complicated. I suppose–" C'yra was cut off by a knock.

"Queen C'yra, She Ra is here."

"Send her in."

The guard nodded as he closed the door. Catra's ears twitched and she could hear Mara outside the door. After a few seconds the door opened to Mara and the guard. C'yra nodded at the girl, "Mara."

"Queen C'yra." Mara said a bit tensely. Catra didn't fail to notice the hint of hostility in her voice as Mara bowed. C'yra noticed it as well but said nothing. "Can you explain to me why you snuck into Eternos and kidnapped my friend?"

"I can. Please sit." C'yra said. Catra looked at the woman who claimed to be her mother. She seemed tired above all else.

Mara sat beside Catra, "Are you alright? Your friends were worried when you suddenly switched."

Catra nodded, "Yeah, I'm okay. C'yra's explaining some things."

Mara looked towards the Magicat Queen. "Explaining what?"

C'yra let out a tired sigh. "C'yra–" She quickly corrected herself, "Catra, I imagine the last month has been rather hectic for you? Rewinding time, losing memories, discovering a disposition towards magic, stopping a war. You've been quite busy."

"How do you–" Catra asked before she interrupted her.

"Because I've seen this all once before. Or pieces of it anyways. I suppose we should start with the obvious. Catra, you aren't from Etheria. You aren't even from your own time. As a result of our runestone being tampered with, you were displaced." C'yra explained.

Mara looked confused, "What? I thought the Magicats didn't know magic."

C'yra nods, "That brings us to the next part. "Mara, your mother and Marleena manipulated time in such a fashion that time itself has been fractured. For lack of better words, they broke time. Well, Marleena did at least."

"How?" Catra asked.

C'yra sighed before calling for somebody. "Percival, can you get us some drinks please? Do either of you want anything?"

"Can I get some water?" Catra asked.

Percival nodded at Catra before leaving, "Of course, Your Highness."

Catra raised an eyebrow, "Why'd he call me that?"

"Percival is my brother. As such, he shares the same blood lineage as me and is privy to the unique abilities of our royal line. We were both born under a Midnight Moon." C'yra explained.

"I think I've heard of this. It means you have visions right?" Mara asked.

C'yra nodded, "Among other things. It allows me to see the flaws of choices I may make in the future and know what certain outcomes could happen. Percival has seen glimpses of you before. It also allows me to see when time has been altered. Like the last two days for example."

"Altered how?" Catra asked.

"A pulse washed over the universe, affecting quite a few things. It was almost unnoticeable." C'yra explained.

"Why would that matter?" Mara asked.

"Catra, your birth was unique. Unique in the fact that not only has it not happened when it should have many years ago, you also were born under a Celestial Moon."

"What do the moon cycles mean?" Catra asked.

"There are four moons that occur naturally and then there's the moon you were born under. The Blood Moon is marked as a powerful birth for a prince or princess. It grants them a unique control over gravity and allows them to teleport. The Midnight Moon is as we just discussed. Then there is the Ashen Moon. One could argue that it is our strongest ability. It allows us to rewind time a couple of minutes back. A redo if you will. I imagine you've experimented with this particular ability?"

"A few times, yeah." Catra nodded. "It wasn't. . .fun, to say the least."

"I imagine not doing it the way that you did. And the fourth moon is the Ageless Moon. My great great grandmother was born under this moon and ruled as our reigning monarch for several hundred years, as this moon grants immortality. Hence the name, ageless."

"But what is a celestial moon?" Mara asked, "I imagine it's pretty important."

"Yes, it is. Our people declared that invoking a celestial moon upon the King or Queen's birth is forbidden. All shall follow this law as the consequences of such a thing can be dire. Catra, you were initially planned to be born under the Ashen Moon as is our cycle. But Marleena and your mother ruined that."

"My mother would never attack your people. In fact, she can barely get on a spaceship without having a panic attack." Mara said accusingly. "So what exactly are you implying?"

C'yra smiled. "You're right Mara. I know Evelyn and she wouldn't have willingly done it. But Marleena did."

"Did what? I'm still confused." Catra asked.

"Five years before you were born, two women were saved by the Eternian fleet. Their names were Evelyn Morgan and Marleena Glenn. Their mission was to find a suitable exo planet and report their findings back to their homeworld Earth. The planet's ecosystems had been picked clean and were on the verge of mass extinction. To get here, one of Earth's brightest minds, Eric Lawrence, developed a ship that would allow them to utilize a warp drive to cross their galaxy. It failed, to say the least.

They fell through a wormhole that had closed behind them. For several weeks they drifted through space until they had exhausted their rations. They were found by King Randor's brother, Fleet Admiral Keldor and General Sunder. For the next three months they were nursed back to health." C'yra explained as Percival came into the room with the drinks.

"Thank you," Catra replied as she took the water from the man.

C'yra swirled her drink before taking a drink. Catra wasn't sure what it was but it looked orange and had what appeared to be a stick of cinnamon in it. C'yra looked at Catra and smiled, "It's quite good. Would you like some?"

Catra went to respond before Mara nudged her. "Maybe later. I think I should keep a clear head."

C'yra smiled before finishing the drink, "All the same. Now by the time that they had recovered, Evelyn had found that she quite enjoyed Loric's company. She had also fallen in love with magic. Humans, from what I've been told, have quite the fascination with it as it was thought to be nothing more than children's stories. But Marleena was driven and had no time to enjoy the scenery. So she went before King Randor and begged his assistance on helping Earth. The King would have helped her even had she not asked. Randor is a kind man in that regard. It also helped her case that he was completely smitten with the woman. But see, the problem with wormholes and warp drives is that once you're in one, there's no telling how much time has passed outside of it.

"The Eternian fleet arrived to Earth's solar system within weeks. Unfortunately, by that time, it was too late. They searched for months, scouring every inch of Earth, looking for any sign of human life to no avail. So they returned and life went on. Evelyn devoted herself to her magic studies to help forget the pain of losing her people and married General Loric Sunder and became the Eternian High Mage. She found happiness again." C'yra smiled. "And then Mara was born and life got better." And then her smile was gone, "And then Marleena had a child with King Randor."

"What?" Mara asked instantly.

"Can I finish?" C'yra deadpanned.

"Sorry." Mara replied before sitting back.

"Right, well, like I said, Marleena had a daughter and it should have been good but Marleena couldn't let go. She looked for any possible way to bring back her people. Eventually, she stumbled upon us. The magicats. She found out about our runestone and told Evelyn. Together they worked on cracking the code to the temporal dimension and unlocking the secrets of time travel. Well

they were missing a piece and it was pretty obvious what it was. They needed a catalyst and I, feeling sorry for her, offered her my aid. I was fairly close to my due date with you and couldn't really offer much help. So I helped her with her tests and she came to the conclusion that without a suitable mage to control the power that it was useless. So, upon learning this," C'yra's tone turned sorrowful, "She devised a plan. She sent Evelyn back to Eternia and remained here on Primus."

"She manipulated my birth." Catra said in a soft tone.

"She did more than that. She broke the runestone and destroyed the timeline. Events that weren't supposed to happen for another ten years happened within weeks, events that did happen hadn't come to pass yet. Your birth–," C'yra choked back a sob, "Well, I don't think I need to say anything about that."

"Do . . .you need a minute?" Catra asked.

C'yra held a hand up, "I'm fine. Marleena's actions destroyed things. I don't think the gravity of what she had done had set in until she realized that she had undone her own daughter's birth."

"What? How?" Catra asked.

"Your and hers lives were connected. Without one of you, the other was simply not to be." C'yra explained, wiping her eyes.

Mara furrowed her brow, "Catra's birth was that important?"

"Catra was, or rather is, the future Queen consort of Eternia, so do with that what you will. Like it matters anymore. Adora was never born and instead of her being She Ra, it fell to the only other union of a human and an eternian. Imagine my surprise when–"

"What did you just say?" Catra asked, stunned.

"Yes, I know. Queen of Eternia sounds nice and all but–"

"Not that. I don't give a shit about that. What about Adora?" Catra asked, standing.

C'yra looked at Catra confused before a look of dawning crossed her face. "Adora was still born?"

"My *girlfriend* is most certainly alive and is She Ra so start explaining what you meant by all that." Catra said with an angry tone.

Mara put a hand on her shoulder, "Calm down Catra. Maybe there's a mistake."

C'yra stood up as she searched Catra's face, ". . .I thought you said you grew up on Etheria?"

"Yeah, like a thousand years in the future! I touched some stupid shard and suddenly I was time traveling and seeing Marleena in my head." Catra threw her hands up. "I thought *you said* that you had seen all this before?"

"That's not how the visions work!" C'yra said frantically before rushing out the door in a panic, "Percival! With me! Tao, don't let the–" She was cut off mid sentence as a familiar field of distortion froze her in place before the same shield that Catra had used wrapped itself around her body, allowing her to dispel it.

Catra and Mara quickly stepped out of the room, taking in the sight of rifts appearing all over the cavern walls. "What's happening! Why are the rifts back!"

C'yra turned back towards Catra, "Where is Adora?"

"She's still in the future. Only I've been shifting. What's going on!" Catra asked before a deafening screech filled the castle. She felt her stomach drop as the shadowy eye monsters crawled out of the rifts.

Mara went to raise her sword before C'yra grabbed her arm. "No! Listen to me, both of you! Catra's timeline is too destabilized and

It's collapsing on top of ours. Adora is a temporal foundation. Bring her back and it should stabilize it."

"What'll that do to *my* timeline? Or Mara?" Catra asked.

"I. . .I don't know." C'yra answered solemnly. "We have rules regarding a Celestial Moon for reasons. Marleena broke those rules and now. . . now I don't know what to do. I'm sorry."

As the monsters drew nearer, C'yra raised her hand before sending out a wave of distortion, sending the creatures recoiling.

"How the hell are we supposed to get to Mara's ship!" Catra yelled over the monster's screams.

Mara was quiet before she got an idea, "Rewind, Catra."

"What?"

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" Mara yelled out as she raised her sword before transforming into She Ra. She turned towards Catra, "Absorb some of my magic and rewind us ten hours. That should be right when we were both in my room."

Catra nodded before grasping Mara's hands and focusing. Catra hadn't even taken a sliver before she let go of Mara's hands, her eyes glowing with power. She fell to a knee, "There's so much." Catra felt almost crushed by the power in her body. She looked up at the approaching monsters as they got closer and closer.

Catra gritted her teeth and quickly grabbed Mara's arm.

Catra sat up with a gasp as she immediately dissipated the feeling in her body. She looked around at herself, checking where she was, only to find that she was back in Mara's room. She still could feel a lot of power in her body from absorbing She Ra's magic. She noticed the room was quite dark and realized that it was well into the night.

'Huh, guess I overshot by a couple of hours.' Catra thought to herself. She noticed Mara slowly sit up and look at her. As she went to say something, Catra heard voices outside the room. Mara looked at the door and along with Catra they quietly made their way to the door. Mara's eyes widened as she recognized Randor and. . .Marleena? They quickly followed them through the halls until they reached the throne room, remaining hidden. Marleena seemed to have woken up the prior day.

"My love, you just woke up. It's not been more than a day. Is there no other way? Maybe we could just talk to Catra? She'd understand. I'm sure of it." Randor pleaded.

"I'm sorry but she won't. I've. . .I've done too much damage. The timeline is already deteriorating." Marleena said sorrowfully.

'No doubt the cause of the pulse at the festival,' Catra thought to herself.

"What'll happen to them? Will her friends be okay? Will. . . Will Adora?" Randor asked with a heavy tone.

Marleena let out a shaky breath, "Once Adora's transferred to us I'll be able to undo what I did to Catra."

"This is a lot to process my love."

"I know. And I know it hasn't been an easy three years. But this will fix it. It'll be like it never happened. Time will right itself and Catra and Adora's births will happen when they were intended to. As for her friends, they'll all be born, I've made sure of that. Their lives should play out the exact same way up until when they were supposed to meet Adora and Catra. Randor," Marleena turned to look her husband in the eyes, caressing his cheek, "Catra wasn't supposed to go to Etheria. She lived a life of abuse and cruelty with her only source of happiness being Adora. What kind of life is that?"

"It's a life, Marleena. It may not have been glorious or kind but Catra came out stronger for it. She made friends, she met Adora,

and even now seeks to help us end a war that's not hers." He squeezed her hand lovingly, "How could I look my daughter in the eyes after erasing her history?"

A tear streamed down Marlena's face, "This is the only way. I can sense the fractures even now. It's not just theirs but ours as well. How long until all of time is destroyed. Me being in the temporal dimension was the only foundational pillar left. The fact that I stepped into the future to retrieve as many shards as I did only made it worse. I don't think there's even a week left."

"If we go through with this, what will happen to Mara? To Evelyn? To Keldor and Stratos? Will they be okay? Will *we* even remember this?" Randor asked.

"If it all goes right? Our memories should gradually fade away around Catra's eighteenth birthday. That will allow Catra enough time to train her powers, rewind Earth and all damage to right itself. As for Mara, the power of She Ra will be transferred to Adora as it was initially intended. Mara was never supposed to receive the Sword of Protection. Her destiny was linked to He-Ro and the Sword of Power. Everyone will be safe."

Catra looked at Mara who was shocked upon hearing this. They looked back towards the pair as they soaked in this new information.

Randor turned away, "As long as everyone is safe. . ." He let out a deep breath, "How do we do this?"

"No." Mara whispered.

Marleena went to reach into her bag. "Once we have Catra in the main room, I'll display the Magicats runestone before her and it should take its original form."

The Temporal Obelisk?" Randor asked.

Marleena nodded, "Once reformed we'll need to be ready. It'll begin making drastic changes to the timestream, resealing the

cracks and repairing the damage I caused."

"What'll happen to Catra?"

"She'll become immobilized. It won't hurt, it'll just feel like a lot of pressure around her. The Obelisk has been slowly forming a connection with Catra for the last month. Once she's in front of it her reflection will vanish from the future and Adora should soon follow. Once Adora's pulled here, her status as a foundational pillar will crumble and. . .and their initial timeline will crumble."

"And then?" Randor asked quietly.

"The obelisk will be complete and Catra's status as a Celestial Moonborn will reinstate itself. The missing shards will reform through her power and then, nothing. The fissures in time will be fixed and everything will return as time intended it. After Earth is repaired, no more time travel. I promise. I should never have done it in the first place."

Randor hugged his wife before pulling back. "How do you want to go about this?"

"You'll need to do it. Catra trusts you and Mara will vouch for you as well. You've been nothing but honest with her, while I on the other hand. . . She has already started to distrust me. Her friend Angella has begun to suspect I'm lying. She's a good woman for watching out for them."

"How do you know that she suspects anything?" Randor asked.

"I saw her discussing them earlier in the. . .day." Marleena went quiet.

"What is it?" Randor asked, suddenly on guard.

"It's the middle of the night."

"So?" Randor furrowed his brow.

"So, Our timeline's Eternia runs on the same sun cycle as Catra's Etheria."

"I'm still not following Marleena."

Catra pulled Mara further back into the shadows as Marleena turned, scanning the halls, "I just returned a few hours ago and it wasn't even sunset yet."

"How do you know? Wouldn't we have noticed?" Randor asked.

". . . Time is distorting. Catra rewound." Marleena muttered before casting a spell, causing Catra and Mara to light up.

"Time to go!" Mara said with urgency.

"Way ahead of you!" Catra yelled as they turned to run before Catra found herself unable to move. "What the hell?" Catra uttered as she tried to put up her temporal shield to no success.

"Guards! Apprehend Mara! Do not let her leave!" Marleena commanded.

As guards flooded the throne room, Mara raised her sword, "For the honor of–" Mara was cut off by a fist striking her in the back of her head, knocking her out cold. Catra strained to look at the attacker only to find Keldor and Stratos.

"Keldor! What happened to you?" Randor asked, running up to him.

It was then that Catra realized why he seemed so familiar the first time that she had met him. As he stepped into full view, she saw that Keldor had been changed. His skin around his jaw had turned from blue to dark gray with splotches of pure white along his arms and face. His once black hair had splotches of white as well and his golden eyes were now red. "Hordak?" She uttered.

Keldor looked at her, "Catra, my apologies it's come to this." he said before looking at his brother, holding up what looked to be a

pile of black goo with green dots. "Behold," Keldor said with a mocking and disgusted tone, "Horde Prime, or what's left of it, was nothing more than a parasitic bug. It attempted to seize control of my body, altering it in the process before Stratos killed it. As if it thought it could be equal to me. Become me? Pitiful."

"But are you alright?" Randor asked with concern.

Keldor waved his brother off, "I'll live. Stratos assures me that a little gene therapy should fix it."

Catra could only listen in horror, for she could only hear Hordak when he spoke. "Stop this. Please!"

"I'm sorry for lying to you Catra, and for manipulating your memories in the way I did. I knew you wouldn't do it if I hadn't. But this is for the best." Marleena apologized. "Now, I suppose this is as good a time as any." Marleena said as she pulled out the orb. Catra noticed one thing as it started to form the obelisk shape. A shard was missing. Not a very big shard, but big enough that she recognized it as the piece that Shadow Weaver wore on her mask. She looked down at Mara as she lay beside her, unconscious.

Catra took a deep breath, resigning herself to what was about to happen. Utilizing the power that she had absorbed from She Ra, she unleashed a wave of distortion that encompassed the whole room, freezing everyone. She was brimming with power as she quickly made her way towards Mara. She noticed that the Obelisk remained unaffected and seemed to be speeding up the minute of frozen time. She could feel the pressure increasing around her by the seconds. With Mara barely conscious, there was no other option. She knew it was a long shot but she had transferred clothes with her as well as one of the shards before when shifting, so she tried the only thing she could with the remaining time she had. She poured all of her magic into Mara and thought about Adora. She felt the familiar sensation of shifting as it flowed through her before she opened her eyes. Mara was gone. And so was her energy. And like that, Catra felt herself being dragged

into the air, hovering in front of the Obelisk as an inescapable pressure as time resumed.

"Where's Mara! She's gone!" Stratos shouted.

"It doesn't matter!" Marleena said. "It's too late to stop it now."

"What's happening!" Keldor exclaimed.

"It's repairing the fractured timelines." Randor answered.

As Catra looked at the Obelisk as it grew the same size as the Moon Stone and realized something. The outline was identical to the portal she had stepped through. She could see her reflection in the smooth blue stone and watched in horror as it flowed out of the stone and into her body.

.

.

And that concludes chapter 13. I can confidently say that either the next chapter or the next two chapters will mark the end of this fic. Beyond that, as always, let me know your thoughts. I always read them. Enjoy.

Chapter 14

Mara shook her head, intent to purge the dazed feeling from her mind as she slowly got her bearings. She went to reach for her sword only to find it missing. Mara's eyes widened as she remembered what had happened. Quickly jumping to her feet, she looked around quickly as she got into a low stance, ready for a fight. But to her surprise, she found herself alone in an unfamiliar room.

Mara looked around the room before seeing a glowing red staff laying against a dresser. She quickly ran over to it, arming herself. She noticed a thin groove in the center. Mara raised an eyebrow before attempting to pull it apart with no success. She immediately tried twisting it instead, to which two large blades appeared on the ends. Nodding to herself she slowly opened the door, noticing a tall dark skinned woman with pointed ears similar to that of a gar. Silently, Mara exited the room and swiftly grabbed the woman, throwing her to the ground before putting the blade at her throat.

"You have five seconds to explain where Catra is before I repaint these halls a nice shade of red." Mara threatened.

The woman looked up at her assailant before gasping in shock. "Mara? How are you here?"

Mara narrowed her eyes, "Explain yourself. What do you mean by that?"

"I'm General Juliet. Catra has spoken about you several times. But how are you in our time?"

Mara stepped back a bit but didn't lower the blade from her direction. After looking around, she realized that she was in Brightmoon. Refocusing her attention, she quickly kicked the woman's spear further away before allowing her to stand. "If

you're telling the truth, then you should be able to take me to Adora. Do me a favor and keep your hands up."

"Of course." Juliet nodded as she kept her hands in the air as she started walking towards the main door. As Mara followed the woman, her gaze lingered on a mural of a man that was painted on the wall. "That's King Micah, Queen Angella's late husband. Come on. It's just through that door."

Mara kept walking, not once lowering her weapon as they came to the main hall. As General Juliet entered the main hall, Bow took notice first before immediately noticed her hands were raised in a hostage-like manner. Instantly, Bow nocked a net arrow and let it fly. As Mara entered the room, she instantly noticed the arrow out of the corner of her eye as a net flew out of it before she slashed it out of air. The sudden attack from Bow coupled with the movement caused everyone to look towards the door.

"Mara?" Adora exclaimed in shock.

"Adora? Oh thank Sharella." Mara said as she quickly ran past Juliet. "Sorry," Mara quickly said as she passed her, to which she simply nodded, putting her arms down.

"How are you here?" Angella asked as they walked forward.

"I'm not sure, but we need to do something. Marleena has Catra and is planning to reset the timeline." Mara quickly explained. "If that happens, your whole timeline will start to collapse until there's nothing left."

"What! Are you sure?" Glimmer asked.

Mara nodded, "Long story short is that Catra and I spoke to Queen C'yra. It turns out that Catra is her daughter and she was born under a Celestial moon. Because of that, their runestone, the Temporal Obelisk, lets Catra manipulate time. Marleena messed with it and now time's being destabilized."

"But why is she doing this?" Adora asked.

Mara was quiet for a moment before looking at all of them. "Adora, I don't know how to say this so I'm just going to say it. Marleena is your mother."

"What!" Everyone exclaimed in shock.

Mara nodded, "By messing with the Obelisk, she prevented a foundational pillar from forming. I'm not exactly sure what that means but it's bad. Because Catra was never born neither were you Adora. She's seeking to restart the timeline so that you and Catra will be born in the right timeline."

"If Catra and Adora were never born, how are they here? And if that's the case, how did they get here?" Bow asked, confused.

"I-I don't know. I can only assume Catra's powers have something to do with it. Look, we're getting off track. Adora, they're going to come after you next. They can't reset the timeline without you being in the past. We need to be ready. Once Catra's formed a connection with the obelisk, it's going to drag you into the past and then this future will start to cease."

Shadow Weaver, who had remained silent up until this point, stepped forward, "What would you suggest? We have no reliable way to time travel without Catra's power."

"I don't know. But Catra and I overheard Marleena saying that she had already come to this timeline in the last couple of days. The fact that I'm here means Catra had something to do with it. We have to do some–" Mara was cut off by a shriek of excitement.

"Are you really a First One? And you actually time traveled? Oh, this is fascinating! Your energy levels are off the charts! You're outputting an extraordinary amount of power that for all intents shouldn't be possible." Entrapta said excitedly as she examined Mara.

"Who's this?" Mara asked.

"This is Entrapta. She's basically our. . . scientist." Bow said, slowly trailing off.

"What is it Bow?" Angella asked.

"Entrapta, could you. . .theoretically, build a time machine?" Bow asked.

Entrapta let out an excited breath, "I mean, if you had asked me that a month ago I would have said no, but possibly. With real evidence of it in front of me and the data I've collected from Catra, I should be able to. Theoretically that is."

"Entrapta, if you can do it you have to. Our whole existence hinges on it." Adora asked. "I'm sure Mara could help."

Entrapta bit her lip as she bounced on her hair. "I would need supplies and a lot of them too. I would also need the signal that you and Catra connected your tracked pads with. Oh! And I would need an assistant who's versed in heavy machinery and some sort of know-how regarding this."

Mara looked at Adora, "I'm not a scientist. My mother's the one who knew about time travel. The most I can contribute is the blueprints to my ship's warp drive. Beyond that. . ."

"A real warp drive would be paramount to a portal. Especially one to the past." Entrapta said.

"We do know somebody else who is versed in these things." Bow said after a moment of thought..

"Who?" Everyone asked.

Hordak was examining a piece of technology that had been scavenged by an excavation crew a couple hours prior. He had to admit that the fact that he could just relax without worrying about an attack was somewhat nice, albeit a waste of time.

"Lord Hordak!" Kyle yelled, running directly into his sanctum.

"What!" Hordak hissed at the cadet who had interrupted his train of thought.

"Lord Hordak, the queen of Brightmoon is here. Shadow Weaver and Adora are with her as well, along with a few members of the princess alliance." Kyle reported as he hastily saluted Hordak.

Hordak hummed before nodding, "Send them in." Within a few minutes, Shadow Weaver stepped into the room followed by Adora and her friends. "Shadow Weaver. Queen Angella. To what do I owe this visit?"

Adora stepped forward with Mara, "How versed are you in portals and time travel?"

Hordak raised an eyebrow, "As far as portals are concerned, I'd say I'm quite knowledgeable. As for time travel, any knowledge that does not pertain to Catra's circumstances is all theoretical of course. Why?"

Mara studied the man before her. If not for his body modifications, she'd say she was looking at Keldor. His voice was a perfect match as well. Ignoring the implications of what his appearance could mean she stepped forward, "Catra's been trapped in the past by my people. We need your help to build a portal to the past before they completely destroy this timeline."

Hordak looked stunned before he quickly strode past the group. "I can't even build a portal out of Despondos. What makes you think I would even begin to know how to do something like this?"

"Because Entrapta's going to help you and so am I." Mara said.

Hordak narrowed his eyes at Mara, "And who, pray tell, are you?"

"I'm an eternian who can tell you how to run the technology you're struggling with. Now, please hurry. We're running out of time."

Hordak looked at Entrapta and Mara before turning towards Shadow Weaver and Angella, "Does anyone even have an idea where to start?"

Mara nodded, "I've given Entrapta blueprints to a dimensional warp drive that we have in our ships. She's already devised a prototype on paper. She'll be helping you."

Hordak looked at Entrapta before slowly nodding. Quickly striding over to a console, he hit a few buttons causing it to hum to life. Suddenly all screens in the Fright Zone lit up, displaying Hordak's face.

"Attention all soldiers. This is not a drill. We are in a state of emergency. All of Etheria depends upon us. Assist the Princess Alliance in anything they ask for! I repeat, this is not a drill. We are in a state of emergency. Force Captains Lonnie and Scorpia report to the sanctum immediately." Hordak announced before the console shut off. He turned towards Shadow Weaver and Adora, "Escort them to wherever they may need to go. Grab anything that may be useful."

Shadow Weaver nodded as she started towards Angella and Adora. She stopped in front of Adora. "Roll up your sleeve and hold your arm out."

Adora, although a little hesitant, did as instructed. Shadow Weaver took Adora's arm before the obelisk shard in her mask lit up with a brilliant blue glow. Slowly, she drew a circle with an intricate pattern on to her wrist before continuing up her arm all the way until her elbow. As Shadow Weaver finished, she looked at Adora, "Do *not* turn into She Ra. That spell is a recreation of those stasis rifts that you witnessed earlier. As long as that's on you, you shouldn't be removed from this timeline."

"How do you know?" Adora asked as she examined the glowing blue markings on her skin.

"I don't, but hopefully, the fact that this spell was created with the very same rune stone as the one they're using to keep Catra sealed in the past will be enough."

Adora was silent at the uncertainty in Shadow Weaver's voice but nodded nonetheless. She turned to Mara before ushering her to follow. Mara nodded as she left the room with Adora. As they walked down the hall, they passed Lonnie and Scorpia.

"Adora? What's going on?" Lonnie asked.

"Turns out that our timeline is about to be destroyed and we have to build a portal to the past to stop them and save Catra. Hordak and Shadow Weaver can brief you guys on the rest." Adora said as they kept walking past them.

Scorpia looked at Lonnie, "Catra's in trouble? We have to do something!"

Lonnie looked at her in exasperation, "Is that really all you got from that?"

Mara looked at Adora as they continued down the hall. "Sorry that we're physically meeting under such bad circumstances."

"Ah, well, what can you do? But, um, since I can't use the sword," Adora pulled her sword off her back before handing it to Mara. "Here, let's trade."

Mara looked down at the staff that she'd taken from the room where she'd woken up. "Is this Catra's?"

"It's actually mine. Catra gave it to me as a gift the night we kissed." Adora explained.

"Oh! I'm sorry. I didn't realize." Mara said as she handed Adora the staff in favor of the sword.

"Don't be. It's still a weapon and it did its job. Let's hurry up."

Catra hovered in the air before the Obelisk as it slowly repaired itself, a glare marred her face. She could feel her connection to her present gone. Or rather her past. When her reflection had returned to her, she had felt her body reverse. She wasn't left-handed anymore and her eyes were no doubt back to normal. She was in her real body and stuck in the past.

Marleena walked in front of her to look at her. "Catra, please, you have to understand. This is what's best for everyone. You'll get a family who loves you. People who adore you. A mother who won't abuse you."

Catra narrowed her eyes in fury as she let out a hiss, baring her teeth. "Oh yeah? And how do you know so much about it, huh? You, who would kill a newborn and destroy the lives of a whole other world for a planet that's gone."

Marleena pursed her lips. "It's not like that, Catra."

"Then how is it, Marleena? Because from what I've seen, you're just as bad as Shadow Weaver. You altered my memories and used magic on me to further your own goals without a thought of how it would affect my friends or me."

"I'm not– It's–" Marleena grunted, "Will you just give me a second to explain?"

Catra remained silent, whether she was ignoring Marleena or giving her a chance to speak didn't matter as Marleena pressed forward regardless. "I fucked up, okay? I hurt my friends, I hurt my husband, and I hurt a lot of other people too. I'm not perfect. But I have a chance to fix my mistakes and undo what I did."

"By dooming the trillions of other people from my timeline?" Catra snapped back.

"It's not dooming–"

Catra shook her head with a mirthless chuckle. "You know, I really thought you were alright. Someone I could relate to and talk with,

but no. I suppose that was all a lie as well."

Marleena was quiet before answering, "I want that for us Catra. I really do. I'm sorry I lied about my memory loss. But I didn't lie about everything."

"Sure you didn't." Catra muttered.

"Catra, that really was your mindscape. What you saw in there was me projecting a mental image of Earth so you'd be calmer. When I saw your mental state reflected there, I knew I was doing the right thing."

Marleena put a comforting hand on Catra's shoulder, "Your life and Adora's has been unspeakably horrible and. . . and I don't want that for you. You are supposed to have a kind life Catra. You were supposed to meet Adora in a much different manner, but no less important. Your current relationship is one built off of a lifeline to one another through trauma instead of growth and meaningful connections." Marleena's face was one of pain. "I saw how your future would go if I hadn't done what I did and if you knew what happens, you would thank me for putting you on this path. I returned your memories in the last week, Catra. It's why they've been coming back so quickly. You have to know I'm right."

Catra hung her head, not wanting to listen to the woman. "It's still not right."

"No, it's not. But we're too far along to change it. Catra, you weren't supposed to be able to get here. I initially believed that you were in a fractured timeline that mirrored this one. I was shocked to find that not only were you in the future, it was a future that was a direct result of my mistake. You time traveling and meeting Mara changed everything. It destabilized your future, Catra."

"What?" Catra asked in shock. Marleena didn't look at Catra, her back turned. "Marleena, what does that mean!"

Marleena let out a heavy sigh, "Because you formed a connection to the obelisk so late in your life, you did not grow with your powers. Instead, they were thrust upon you at a much higher level than you were ready for. That. . .has consequences. With every action you took here in the past, you irreparably altered your own timeline until it destabilized. The obelisk is fixing the damage safely."

"I've only been in the past for a combined total of, like, a week at most. I'm a thousand years in the future. There's no way that it changed everything that much! You're lying!" Catra snarled.

"A week is enough, Catra!" Marleena said harshly, her patience slowly lost. "This is the best outcome for everyone involved! I'm not giving you my opinion Catra, that is a fact! If I hadn't manipulated you and did what I did, you and Adora wouldn't have gotten together the way you had, Keldor would have become Horde Prime, Mara would be gone, Eternia would have been destroyed and the whole universe would be all that much worse for it. So no, Catra, I am very much not in the wrong." Marleena said with a cool look that reminded Catra of Angella.

"I don't believe you." Catra said in a low voice. "There's no way that I changed all that."

". . . Do you want proof?" Marleena asked quietly. Catra narrowed her eyes before nodding. Marleena looked at Catra before shaking her head and slowly walked up beside her. "Fine. Pay attention. Lesson one on the Temporal Obelisk's abilities. Evocation. Going over the broader spectrum would take too long, so we are going to focus on a specific aspect of this ability. Retrocognitive precognition."

"What does that mean?" Catra asked.

"It is the ability to see the future of a past where you had made a different decision. In this case, you and I are going to go back to the very moment you got your powers. The very moment you touched that stone that I purposefully put in front of Shadow

Weaver. Now focus on the Obelisk." Marleena said, "The relationship between space and time at different scales causes phase transitions as the influence of one force changes in contrast to another. In this instance, I was the acting force. From this we get the vast majority of actions and reactions in the material plane. Focus on the exact moment you woke up. When you have it, go further back. Back to the point where you saw it. Do you have it?"

Catra envisioned herself back in the forest where it had all begun. It began to take a vivid shape in her mind before she almost seemed to be looking at herself. Listening to Marleena's instructions, Catra began pushing herself to go back. To her surprise, she felt magic swell and swirl through her body before the glossy stone surface of the obelisk shifted to reveal herself pulling Shadow Weaver out of the explosion before being teleported away.

Marleena nodded, "Good. Behold, this is the fountain of perspective. With more training you will be able to utilize it without the Obelisk itself. Now, go back around eight hours before this event but focus on Shadow Weaver. It should be similar to rewinding the day."

Catra shifted her focus to Shadow Weaver and tried to recreate the feeling she got when she rewound. She watched as the surface of the rock shifted and turned before showing Shadow Weaver finding the shard. Marleena put a hand on Catra's shoulder. "This part is a little tricky so I will guide you through it. The gist of what you're looking for will be similar to branches of alternate events. The particular event we are looking for is one where I did not influence events for Shadow Weaver to acquire a shard."

It took a minute but with Marlena's assistance, Catra quickly found the event she was looking for. The one where Shadow Weaver never found a shard. Marleena looked at Catra with a hesitant look, ". . . Are you sure?"

"Yes, I'm sure." Catra said harshly.

Marleena nodded and stepped away from her. Catra looked up and watched the Obelisk shift. "This is what would have happened had you not gotten your powers. Just focus on what you want to see. You'll get a clear outline of certain events."

Catra focused on the Obelisk and thought of Adora and herself. She watched as Adora and herself appeared. She saw images quickly flash through the surface of the stone of her and Adora fighting, trying to kill one another it seemed. She watched Adora attack her with glowing red eyes, she watched herself attacking Adora in a violent manner, watched as she left Adora to fall to her death in the Crystal Castle. Catra recoiled in horror, her train of thought derailed, wishing to not see the images anymore.

Catra looked at Marleena only to see her looking away from the Obelisk. Catra looked back and thought of Shadow Weaver. The image swirled and she saw herself being attacked by Shadow Weaver before it flashed to another image. This time she saw herself being suspended in air, tortured by what seemed to be Shadow Weaver and Glimmer. Catra inhaled sharply as she shifted her thoughts to Mara. Nothing. Catra could see nothing but white.

"I don't know what it means. Angella's shows that as well." Catra looked at Marleena before focusing on Angella. True to her words, Angella's was also white. "I didn't lie to you Catra. I'm not trying to manipulate was your future."

Catra ignored her and thought about Hordak. She wished that she hadn't. Catra quickly looked away from the Obelisk as images of a destroyed Salineas appeared. Thoughts of Eternia only showed empty desolate ruins of the Kingdom of Eternos. Catra ceased her thoughts and killed the connection. She let out a shaky breath.

"That's only a piece of it, Catra. I'm only able to see glimpses as I don't hold a true connection to the Obelisk. I'm sorry it had to come to this." Marleena said sorrowfully.

Catra looked at Marleena in anguish as a feeling of powerlessness washed over her. "Why–why couldn't you have just left us alone?"

"Catra, our timeline isn't just your past. It coexists on an axis. While you're living in the future, we are still going on with our lives here." Marleena explained.

"But that doesn't make any sense! How can that be? If a thousand years pass for us, then the same should be true for you. You should have already been where we're at." Catra cried out desperately.

Marleena nodded in remorse, "We have."

Catra looked at her in confusion before something finally dawned on her, "We're in a loop. . . How many times has this happened!"

". . . Too many to count." Marleena said quietly.

"Are we just repeating steps? How many times have we had this conversation?"

Marleena put her hands on Catra's shoulder. "Zero. This is the first time we have ever gotten to this point. That's why this is so important. Why it's so special. In all of my attempts, my millions of tries, you've never time traveled. The Ashen Moon's abilities have always been locked to you, but somehow, you accessed your powers and met Mara. That changed everything and now–"

"What did you say?" Catra cut her off.

"You. . .you accessed your powers?" Marleena answered in confusion.

"No, not that. The Ashen Moon. What do you mean by the Ashen Moon?"

"Oh, right. I suppose you don't know about it yet. The Magicat's royal lineage has abilities that's decided by–"

"I know this already. The Ashen, the Ageless, the Midnight, and the Blood. But what do you mean my abilities were locked?"

Marleena looked surprised, "How do you–" She shook her head, "Not important. Catra your birth was unique in that you were planned to be birthed under the Ashen Moon. This allows you to manipulate time within a few minutes. However you managed to go back over a thousand years in such a manner is–"

"Marleena!" Catra snapped at her, interrupting her, "I wasn't born under an Ashen Moon."

"What? Of course you were. I was there."

"I spoke to my mother just a couple of hours ago. She explicitly told me that you manipulated my birth to fall under a Celestial Moon." Catra said. Marleena took a shocked step back, her face turning white. "Do you know what that means? Because we were interrupted and she wasn't able to tell me what it means. All she said was that it was forbidden."

"I-I wouldn't of. . .I couldn't have. . . That's impossible!" She snapped at Catra, her eyes holding a hard edge. "C'yra is dead. She died due to my actions with the Obelisk. That's why you weren't born here. Your parents are entirely different people in your future."

"You just said you were at my birth! What the hell are you talking about?" Catra snapped back.

Marleena realized that she had misplaced her anger at Catra before she took a shaky breath, "This explains so much."

"What do you mean?"

"Catra. A Celestial Birth is forbidden because it gives you free control over time."

"I. . . Huh?" Catra was a bit confused at that statement. "Then why the hell have I been struggling with all of this?"

Marleena started pacing, ignoring Catra's question. "And you're sure she said that you were a Celestial birth?"

"Very sure."

Marleen stopped pacing before walking towards Catra and gently grabbing her shoulders, "Catra. You can fix this. All of this. If you embrace the Obelisk and stop fighting the connection, you can rewrite the timeline how you wish. You've already been doing it. You can break the loop and-and. . ." Marleena looked down at the floor, her shoulders slightly shaking. Catra could hear her silent sobs, "I did this. I destroyed everything and I can't even remember how I did it."

Catra wasn't sure of anything anymore. She could hear her own heartbeat in her ears. Why? Why did she have to make this decision? Did she trust Marleena and forge a full connection with the Obelisk? Would it doom her friends? Marleena claimed that they would be fine if the timeline was repaired. She looked past Marleena towards the Obelisk, intent on finding out.

Marleena looked up to find Catra was looking at the Obelisk. Suddenly it displayed Catra and Marleena in this very moment. "What are you doing?" Marleena asked in confusion, wiping her eyes.

Catra ignored her and thought about the decisions in her mind. To help Marleena or to stop her. She focused on opposing her first and then envisioned going forwards rather than back. Suddenly, an image of Catra as a child appeared on the stone. She watched events fly by before it finally showed her childhood once more. She grit her teeth, redoubling her efforts before she watched the image reset to her and Adora's childhood over and over again. Looping.

"You're checking what happens if you don't help me." Marleena muttered to herself.

Catra shifted her focus back to the current moment and thought about helping Marleena. Immediately, the stone lit up with a clear vision compared to the hazy images she had been seeing before. Marleena and Catra watched as an older Adora adorned in a white and gold dress appeared looking out over Etheria in Brightmoon's castle.

The door behind Adora opened as an older Catra who was wearing a familiar coat was chased in by Glimmer who appeared to be queen, "Just let me brush it!"

"*No!" Catra exclaimed in laughter as she was chased by a laughing Glimmer with a hairbrush in hand around Adora. Catra quickly hid behind Adora, "Don't let her touch me. She's gonna torture me."*

"*Do you always have to be this dramatic? You let mom brush it." Glimmer said with a smile.*

Bow entered the room before smiling, "Come on guys. If we are late to Scorpia's first ball she is going to kill us. Micah and Angella are already waiting."Bow walked up to Glimmer before putting his hand around Glimmer's shoulder as she leaned into him.

Glimmer smirked at Catra, "Fine! You're off the hook. This time."

Catra stuck her tongue out at Glimmer as they left before turning towards Adora, her hand outstretched, "Are you coming?"

Adora took Catra's hand, pulling her into a gentle kiss before following her out of the room.

The Obelisk's glassy surface returned as the image swirled away. Marleena and Catra remained silent. At that moment, King Randor walked into the room. "Marleena? Catra? Are you both alright?"

"We're fine." Catra said quietly as she weighed her options. Micah was alive. Angella would be overjoyed. Marleena had said that if the timeline rewrote itself, she and Adora would never have formed the relationships they had with Bow and Glimmer.

Although that was before the added information of being a Celestial birth.

"Marleena, can I have a moment alone with Catra?" Randor asked.

"Of course." Marleena said gently, her voice cracking a bit.

Randor stepped in front of Catra with two cups in his hand. Catra could smell the alcohol before she saw it. "Mara said that you were fond of this drink?"

Catra saw that it was a pink morning, although it lacked the pinkel slice. Catra gave a small nod. In all honesty, she was a bit happy that it was alcohol. She felt like a ball of nerves and wasn't quite sure of what to do.

Randor held the drink up to her lips, allowing her to sip the drink. "I, uh, didn't know exactly how the fruit worked so I just blended the juice in. Sorry if that's not right."

Catra tilted her head up to signal that she wanted a bigger drink. Randor tilted the cup up until Catra finished the drink. "I'm sorry for all of this. I can't imagine what you must be feeling right now."

Catra looked down at the ground, letting out a defeated breath, "What am I supposed to do? Isn't this wrong?"

Randor took a seat on the floor, looking at Catra. "I'll admit, this doesn't seem right. As a King, I've made bad decisions before. Decisions that would look monstrous to you in any light you look at it. This feels like one of those decisions."

"How do you make those choices? How do you justify them?" Catra asked as she stared the man in the eye.

Randor's gaze fell to his cup, "It's hard. Most of the time, these decisions are so far and few between that one could go most of their life without having to make one. But in those rare instances where it is inevitable that no matter what you choose, the

outcome will be horrible, you have to trust yourself. I've learned to take advice from my advisors, my friends, and my family. It's not always good advice and sometimes it isn't what you want to hear but sometimes that's what you need."

"If I help Marleena, I will potentially destroy any relationships that I have with my friends. Will I even remember them? And what of their lives? Do they deserve to have everything they worked so hard to achieve undone?"

"Marleena assures me that up until this month, your friends' lives should remain relatively the same, albeit with minor differences. I can't claim to understand the science behind time travel, nor its effects, but I know that whatever happens, my daughter will be there beside you." Randor said with a small smile before finishing his drink. "You know, it's funny. Until Marleena told me about Adora, I had assumed that you and Mara were together. Imagine my surprise at learning that you're technically my daughter-in-law."

Catra chuckled, although it sounded hollow, "I'll admit that Mara is appealing and she's an awesome friend, but I love Adora and she loves me. Besides, Mara is already in love with someone."

"I suppose it's Light Hope, right?" Randor asked.

"What? How'd you know?"

"I make it my business to know what goes on with my best friends' family." Randor said with a smile.

"And you're okay with that?" Catra asked.

"Why wouldn't I be?" Randor walked up to the obelisk, "We can't help who or what we fall in love with. Be it She Ra, an artificial intelligence, or. . .or even a planet." Randor finished softly before regaining his smile, "But to condemn someone for who they love is not the Eternian way. We'd go to hell and back for the ones we love. We'd even do terrible things that we'd never do under any other circumstances."

"I have a feeling we're not talking about Marleena here." Catra guessed.

Randor let out a mirthless chuckle, "No, I'm referring to myself. Have you noticed a comparative difference to magic when you're in the past compared to the future?"

"I suppose, yeah. I guess I never noticed that."

"That's because I attempted to mine the magic of several planets in order to create a powerful enough energy source to wake my wife up from her coma. The latest one was Etheria. It's a harmful process that can leave the planet near ecological collapse. Fortunately, I've sent for Zed to reverse the project. Although that doesn't undo my actions."

Catra was quiet at that. Her mind drifted as she thought about what she would do if Adora was nearly killed. She shuddered to think what she would become if her visions were anything to go by.

Randor nodded at Catra, "We'll figure this all out Catra. Nobody here wants to see harm come to you or your friends."

". . . My memories are coming back now. I can remember most of my life up until a couple months ago. Small things are missing but beyond that. I just. . . I just want to say that Marlena's wrong about me and Adora. Our relationship isn't just trauma. There's a lot of good there as well. Things that don't revolve around the Horde." Catra said defiantly.

Randor smiled a genuine smile. "I'm glad to hear that. I just hope that–"

Just then, Evelyn and Lorric came walking through the door with Marleena in tow. Upon seeing Catra she immediately ran up to her. "Catra! Are you okay? Where's Mara?"

Catra had mixed feelings about everyone right now and Mara's parents were no exception. She looked at Evelyn quietly, a small

glare settling on her face, "Were you a part of this? Did you know that this would happen?"

Evelyn took a small step back, a bit put off by her anger. "I. . . No. At least, not in the way you're thinking. I wasn't aware of what was happening until I learned of Adora and even then."

Catra held her gaze for a few moments before looking towards Marleena, her tone losing most of her anger, "I just want to know something because it's bothering me."

"Of course. What is it?" Marleena gave Catra her full attention.

"Who attacked you and sent Adora to the future?"

Marleena went to answer before stopping, "What?"

"What do you mean, 'what?'" Catra furrowed her brow.

"Catra, Adora was never born. No one attacked me. What are you talking about?" Marleena asked.

Catra turned to look at Randor, a puzzled look on her face. "Didn't you say. . .?"

Randor looked at Marleena, "My love, Adora was born three years ago. You were at the epicenter of an explosion of magic that rendered you comatose and Adora was gone. Do you not remember?"

Marleena looked at her husband as she struggled to remember such events. "I. . .I'm sorry but I can't recall these events. But what do you mean Adora was sent to the future?"

Catra felt a chill run down her spine. "Shadow Weaver told me. She said that Hordak found her in a field as a baby. She said that I soon followed. I had no record of birth or any parentage for that matter. C'yra looked about as confused as you do right now."

Loric looked around suspiciously, "What's happening? These stories aren't lining up."

Catra looked at the floor, a sigh escaping her lips. "The Obelisk has been changing the timeline in response to me, hasn't it?"

"I. . . Yes. I'm sorry Catra." Marleena apologized.

"You've said that like seven times now." Catra said, exasperated. She looked back towards the Obelisk as it started to emit a glow.

"It's happening." Marleena said as she stepped forward. "Adora's being shifted."

As they all looked towards the tall runestone, they were simultaneously shocked when it froze. The cracks refused to mend nor would they break any further. It was as if the Obelisk itself was frozen in time.

"What just happened?" Lorric asked.

"So, what's my mom like?" Adora asked.

"Oh, I'm surprised you asked." Mara said as they stood off to the side, watching Hordak and Entrapta.

"I just. . . want to know, I guess. It feels kind of surreal to be honest. Does Catra have parents?"

"Yeah, if you hadn't guessed by now, her mom is Queen C'yra." Mara shrugged.

"I figured. The picture we saw was a dead giveaway. I guess I'm just feeling anxious. When I was just fighting the Horde, it was simple, y'know? Hit the bad guys, free the oppressed civilians, and then go home. Now I feel conflicted. My parents want to reset the timeline just so that they can see me? It just doesn't add up. Something feels wrong. Can't you feel it?"

Mara nodded. She could definitely see something was off. "I–"

"We finished!" Etrapta shouted. "But we've seemed to run into a problem."

"What? What is it?" Adora asked as they all walked up to Hordak and Entrapta.

"The same problem that I've had every time I've attempted to build a portal. The energy to power it." Hordak said as he looked at several notes.

"How much power do you need?" Mara asked, "Could She Ra do it?"

"Theoretically yes. But the problem lies in that you would need to be able to output that power. The amount we need would, by all definitions, kill you." Entrapta explained.

"Oh." Mara said.

"Yes. Oh indeed." Hordak said.

"What if we both–" Adora let out a gasp of pain as she fell to her knees holding her arm. Everyone looked at her in alarm.

"Adora!" Glimmer cried, rushing over to her.

After a moment, the pain died down and Adora stood up, examining the spell on her arm, "Well, I guess it worked then."

"Good thinking, Shadow Weaver." Bow said.

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Yes, but who knows how long until another pulse will come or how much stronger it will be. We need to figure something out and quickly."

Mara looked at Hordak, "How much energy would be required?"

"An impossibly large amount. We aren't simply making a portal. We are time traveling. The amount of power needed could power

the whole planet of Etheria. It's just not–" Hordak started to sway, leaning against the table as he let out a grunt of pain.

Shadow Weaver looked at the rapid deterioration of Hordak, noticing he was starting to emit a distorted effect on his body. Acting quickly, she applied the same spell on Hordak. The deterioration instantly receded, allowing Hordak to regain his footing. He let out a growl, "I think we are out of options."

"No, we still have one. Does anyone have Catra's trackerpad?" Mara asked.

"Yes, here you go." Angella said as she handed Mara the tablet.

Mara quickly took it. "Please work." she muttered, "Light Hope. Are you there?"

"Mara! I-I am here. My sc-scanners indicate that the–the timestream you are in is rapidly deteriorating. Y-you are in critical da-danger!" Light Hope said in concern, her voice glitching.

"I know. I need you to activate the heart of Etheria in this time stream."

"I am-am forbidden from doing this. I-I cannot comply with this request. My coding won't let-let me." Light Hope said worriedly.

"How could I get you to allow it?" Mara asked, her mind racing through a thousand different strategies.

"With the-the proper order, you c-could be allowed the clear-clear-clearance." Light Hope explained.

Mara looked around before her gaze settled on Hordak. She quickly walked up to Hordak, making sure he was not in view of Light Hope. Her voice dropped to a whisper, "Listen very carefully and repeat what I say. Designated Administrator EF-02 Keldor. Relinquish all primary privileges to Administrator EF-056 Mara."

Hordak nodded before repeating the message. Mara looked down at the screen at Light Hope. Light Hope looked like she was struggling to accept it. Finally her eyes flashed, "Welcome Administrator K-Keldor. At your command, all pri-primary admin privileges have been tr-tra-transferred to Administrator Mara's profile. Is that all?"

"Er, Yes, that will be all." Hordak finished.

"The Heart of Etheria has been act-activated. Mara, you have twenty two minutes until the timestream falls into total collapse. I advise an immediate quantum jump back to your original ti-timestream." Light Hope said with a noticeable amount of fear.

"We're trying Hope. Remain on standby" Mara said before turning towards Glimmer. "Now comes the hard part. Glimmer, you can teleport, right?" Glimmer nodded. "Good." Mara raised Adora's sword before transforming into She Ra.

Mara looked at herself before nodding, "Good, I wasn't sure that would work."

Hordak stepped forward, "What would you have us do?"

"Everyone, gather around the machine. Entrapta, wrap your hair around everyone present and make sure you're touching the time machine. Glimmer, you're going to teleport us all there."

Glimmer blanched with shock, "What? Mara, I can't teleport that far, especially with that many people. I just don't have the magic for it."

Mara nodded, "I know." She turned to Shadow Weaver, "That's why she's going to give it to you."

Shadow Weaver's eyes widened, "How so?"

"Catra siphoned some of my power about an hour ago. The little amount she took was enough to not only rewind us back a full day but also send me to the future. We're going to repeat the process.

Siphon some of my power and give it to Glimmer. Catra already informed me that she learned to do both from you, so get to it." Mara said harshly, leaving no room for discussion.

Entrapta wrapped her hair around Angella, Glimmer, Bow, Hordak, Shadow Weaver, and Mara before laying a hand on the machine, giving a thumbs up. Shadow Weaver looked at Glimmer, receiving a nod, before she stepped forward towards Mara. As she laid a hand on Mara's shoulder, she began to pull the magic of She Ra into herself. The power she felt was immense, but she knew that there were more pressing matters at the moment. As she stepped away from Mara and quickly took Glimmer's hand, she immediately transferred the power to Glimmer, making sure to keep a small portion to herself.

Glimmer gasped in exhilaration before looking at Adora, "Is this what being She Ra feels like?"

Adora gave a small smile, "Something like that."

Mara turned to Glimmer, "Good. Alright Glimmer, are you ready?"

Glimmer made a sound of confirmation, "Yeah, I don't think there's anywhere I couldn't teleport to right now."

Mara nodded, "Alright," she said as she looked at the tablet. "Hope, can you pull up an image of the Heart's mainframe room."

Light Hope nodded before the screen shifted to an image of the Heart of Etheria. She handed Glimmer the tablet, "That's where we want to be. Is everyone ready?"

"You have seventeen m-minutes, Mara." Light Hope said with a nervous tone.

"What about Swift Wind? I sent him to get Mermista, Frosta, and Perfuma. If we teleport now, they won't make it." Adora said.

"I know. But we're out of time. I'm sorry." Mara apologized.

Glimmer looked at everyone before checking to see if Entrapta's hair was fastened to her. "Alright, here we go." Glimmer focused on the image.

A flash of sparkles later and everyone looked around to find themselves in the crystal castle. Mara looked around as Entrapta pulled her hair back to herself.

Shadow Weaver marveled at the raw trapped power of the Heart. Everyone followed her gaze before equally aweing at it. Adora tore her gaze away from the sight before focusing.

"We made it." Adora said in relief. "How much magic do you have left Glimmer?"

"Actually, I'd say I'm still overcharged." Glimmer said, examining herself.

Adora gave a nod, "Good, we don't know what we'll encounter once we step through, so everyone be ready." she turned to Mara, "Now what?"

Light Hope appeared although her form looked badly damaged and unstable. Mara looked at her in concern, "Hope! Are you alright?"

"I am f-fine. This is a re-result of the deteriorat-ating timestream. Please hurry. The speed has increased exponentially. You only have–" Light Hope's image vanished as the crystal castle shut down.

Mara rushed to the main console, "Entrapta, Hordak, grab the power cables and lay them directly under the Heart!"

As they did as instructed, Entrapta pulled out a tablet of her own as well her recorder. "Log 402, This marks a monumental and momentous day in science, Before me lies documented proof of time travel! Stand by for further testing." She said in complete excitement and awe.

Hordak's expression wasn't too far from Entrapta's either. He looked towards Mara as she rapidly typed away at the console. "Now what?

"Guys! The walls are breaking!" Bow shouted. Everyone turned to see a wall of white rapidly descended upon them.

Mara hit a button before the power cables started to hover in the air. They watched as the cables were grabbed by several cords that shot out of the floors and walls. The effect was immediate as the portal hummed to life. "Everyone through the portal now!"

Marleena looked panicked as she examined the Obelisk. "Something's wrong!"

"What is it?" Evelyn asked.

"Adora hasn't crossed over yet."

"Why is that a bad thing? I thought you said it would happen on its own?" Evelyn asked.

"The Obelisk is not mending itself. What if Catra's timeline already collapsed? Do you see why I'm concerned!" Marleena said as she frequently examined the Obelisk as it slowly twisted.

Catra looked at them from the corner of her eye. A pang of fury shot through her before she pushed it down. No, she needed to think rationally. If her timeline was already erased but Adora hadn't appeared yet, then Mara had done it. She had stopped Adora from shifting. But that begged the question; Had Mara separated the timestream, causing it to appear as if it was gone? It was then that Catra noticed she could move her hands. She looked up and realized that the magic was no longer able to keep her still any longer.

Randor walked to Marleena, "My love, calm down. Adora will be fine."

"But what if–"

"Shhhh, don't worry. I'm sure there's an explanation." Randor assuaged her fears as he hugged her.

Lorric looked at Catra. Her lack of reaction was a little suspicious. "Catra?"

Catra looked at Lorric before remaining quiet. She was honestly lost on what to do. Marleena looked at Catra. "Catra, are you alright?"

Catra took a deep breath. . . and immediately broke free from her constraints, throwing a stasis bomb at the group's feet. Evelyn put up a shield immediately, protecting herself from its effects. Randor, Marleena, and Lorric however were not so lucky.

Catra took off in a dead sprint as she put as much distance between herself and the Obelisk as possible. Evelyn gave chase, attempting to stop Catra. "Guards! Stop Catra from leaving!"

As Catra ran for the door, two guards flanked by Stratos stepped in front of her, cutting off her escape. Stratos lunged at her, a large metal baton crackling with energy in his hand. But Catra was still a trained soldier and unfortunately for Stratos she was quickly remembering her training at blinding speeds. Before he could react, Catra had ducked his swing and slashed his face, leaving two large gashes along his face. Using her momentum from the swing, she stole the baton from the stunned Stratos and quickly swung it into the jaw of one of the guards before slamming it into the side of the other guard's knee, causing him to crumple to the ground.

Before she could react, the throne room had begun to flood with guards and Randor, Marleena, and Lorric had regained their movement. "Catra! Wait!" Marleena pleaded.

But she was done talking. Catra immediately switched gears and jumped on to the castle wall, scaling the stone as she jumped through one of the large windows. As she found herself outside

the castle, Catra looked over the city as it illuminated the night sky and thought to herself how the lights seemed much more hostile at the moment. As she slid down one of the stone pillars and took off running, a city wide alarm sounded.

"*Attention, all guards of Eternos. This is General Sunder. An Etherian named Catra has assaulted the King and the Queen and is extremely dangerous and is to be detained at once. She is of magicat descent and has heterochromia with a yellow eye and blue eye. Do not let her leave the city!"*

Catra scoffed, "Great."

Adora exited a portal and was immediately greeted to the sight of the Kingdom of Eternos. "Where are we?"

Mara stumbled a bit exiting the portal behind her before regaining her footing and looking around, "I'm surprised that worked. We're on Eternia. I had Light Hope change the location to be as close to her mainframe as she could get without being directly in the city."

Glimmer and Bow walked out before looking around and noticing that Hordak, Entrapta, Shadow Weaver, and her mother were missing. "Guys! We're missing people."

Bow looked around before pulling out his tracker pad. "I still have a signal from Entrapta. They made it. . . just not beside us."

Adora nodded, "We need to prioritize. Bow, can you make contact with them?"

Bow nodded, "Give me a second." he said as he fiddled with something on the screen before Hordak's face appeared. "Hordak? Are you okay? Is Angella and Entrapta with you? We're also missing Shadow Weaver?"

Hordak stepped into view. "I have Queen Angella with me, but Shadow Weaver and Entrapta are nowhere to be seen. What happened?"

Mara walked beside Bow, "The coordinates must have been scrambled when the Crystal Castle started to break down. So far it seems like we all made it. Shadow Weaver's and Entrapta's locations are unknown at the moment though. Name your surroundings. I should be able to tell you where you are from a quick description."

"I see a floating river of water that is leading into a large stone wall with metal highlights that wraps around a very bright city. Beyond that, we are currently at the edge of a forest." Hordak informed Mara.

Mara nodded, "It sounds like you're not too far from us. Angella, can you fly up into the sky?"

Angella's voice sounded from behind Hordak. "Of course."

They all searched the sky for Angella's glow when they spotted her a couple of miles away. Mara looked back at the tracker pad, "Glimmer, flash your magic a few times. Hordak, look to your left. You should see us."

Hordak looked somewhere off camera before nodding, "We see you."

After a few minutes of waiting, Angella appeared before them with Hordak holding onto her arms as she gently landed. Mara stepped forward, "Do Entrapta or Shadow Weaver have any other ways we can contact them?"

"No. Shadow Weaver typically doesn't carry anything related to technology and Entrapta's tracker pad is it." Adora answered.

"So, our timeline is just gone? That's it? We're all that's left?" Glimmer asked in a shocked voice, the gravity of their situation finally dawning on her.

Mara shook her head. "I don't believe that. If that were the case, they wouldn't be trying so hard to keep Catra here. It can be undone."

"How?" Hordak asked.

"The reason the Magicat's runestone was kept secret was because it involves the manipulation of time magic. According to Queen C'yra, Catra's birth was special somehow. Special enough that it derailed the flow of time. If we can put it back on track–"

"Then we can fix time!" Angella finished. Mara nodded in response.

"We need to find Shadow Weaver. Her magic is able to keep Adora and Hordak safe from the temporal effects." Bow spoke up.

Mara looked at Adora, "Do you have your staff?" Adora nodded, "Good. Make sure we're all properly equipped. Chances are we're going to have to fight."

"Hey Adora! That was pretty insane right?" Swift Wind exclaimed from behind them.

They all turned to see Swiftwind landing with Frosta, Perfuma, Mermista and Sea Hawk.

Sea Hawk wiped his brow. "I've had close calls before on many an adventure, but that one was a little too close."

"Tell me about it." Mermista groaned as she dismounted Swift Wind. "Let's not do that again.

Adora ran up, pulling them all into hugs before looking at Swift Wind. "How did you know we had teleported?"

"Normally, my connection to She Ra lets me know how she's feeling and where she is in a general area. But imagine my surprise when I felt another connection that wasn't you. Mara over here guided me to where you had all gone. Luckily, we just happened to be overhead the Crystal Castle."

"It was definitely frightening." Perfuma said, helping Frosta off of Swift Wind's back.

"And awesome." Frosta said with a grin before schooling her features. "I mean, it's bad for sure."

"Are we all that made it?" Perfuma asked.

Bow nodded somberly, "I'm afraid so. Shadow Weaver is also here, but she was displaced."

Mermista looked at Hordak, "Why is this guy here?"

"He and Entrapta built the time machine that we used to escape." Mara answered.

"Oh." Mermista replied. "Now what?"

"Now, we go find Shadow Weaver, Entrapta, and Catra and undo whatever they just did to our timeline." Adora said.

With everyone making a trek towards Eternos, Adora looked at Mara. "Will they be looking for you?"

"Most definitely. I'd be more surprised if they hadn't put an alert out on me yet. We'll need to be discreet. You'll all need to be spaced out. While Eternos is a colorful place where a lot of races live, eight Etherians and an alicorn walking in a group will draw attention."

"What about Hordak? No offense man, but you don't exactly look normal." Frosta said.

Hordak looked at Mara, "She's right. My visage is far from natural."

"Actually, you look like a Gar with some augmented limbs and some pigmentation loss. For the most part, you look quite natural here. You might want to cover that symbol on your chest though." Mara responded. "If anyone will stick out, it'll be me. My face is one of widespread renown. I'll need a mask."

"Fear not, I have just the thing." Sea Hawk said as he wrapped his bandana around Mara's face.

Mara stayed quiet for a moment before speaking as she pulled the bandana off, "Y'know, I don't think this is gonna work."

Hordak took his cape off before wrapping it around mara. Using the excess length, he pinned the cloth in several different places, forming a hood before pulling it over Mara's head. She looked at the cape, now turned cloak, and smiled. "You know how to make cloaks?"

Hordak gave a small blush before turning back towards Eternos, "That is inconsequential at this moment. Let us focus on the matter at hand."

Frosta giggled at Hordak's embarrassment. Mara nodded, "This'll do. Let's go."

As they came to the wall, Mara took note of the rotating guards. Turning to Glimmer, she asked if she could teleport them past the wall.

Glimmer nodded, "I still have a lot of power from She Rac, but keep in mind that once I'm out of magic, that's it. Without Shadow Weaver here I can't recharge again."

"Noted. Everyone link hands. Glimmer, whenever you're ready."

As they teleported past the walls, they found themselves in the middle of a bustling street of people. At the flash of bright sparkles, a passing Qadian guard turned to look at them. "Hey!"

"Remain calm." Mara whispered. "He's about to give you a warning Glimmer."

"Me?" Glimmer asked a bit too loudly.

"Yeah, you. I recognize an Etherian when I see one. Didn't you read the signs?" The large cat man walked before her.

Glimmer looked at where the man was pointing and saw a sign written in Eternian. "Uhh. . ."

"My apologies, sir." Adora said, stepping forward. "My friends and I arrived a little bit ago. They're all from Etheria and no one here but me can read the language. I'll see to it that I properly inform them of the signs from now on."

The man eyed Adora up and down before nodding, "See that you do." He looked at Angella, "I take it that you're her mother?"

Angella nodded, "I am, yes."

"For future reference, bright magics are prohibited in certain points in the city. Mainly marketplaces and residential. Any and all magic that can be used to harm is strictly prohibited in general unless used in self defense." He looked over to the rest of the group, "Do you all understand this?"

A chorus of nods and yeses answered the man. He nodded, "Good. See that you follow the rules." He looked back at Adora, "As the only one that can read our language, you are solely responsible for them. Understood?"

"Yes sir." Adora replied in a militaristic manner. He nodded before turning back towards where he came from. After a moment, Adora breathed a sigh of relief.

"So much for spreading out and being inconspicuous." Mermista said.

"Come on." Mara said. "This way."

As they exited the marketplace, they found themselves in an area of the city that seemed to be more technologically advanced than the rest of it. Their faces were lit up in awe and had they not been under so much pressure, they may have stopped to sightsee. As they maneuvered through the crowds, they ducked through an alley way. Mara stopped for a moment, hearing a familiar voice.

"*Log 406, Eternia appears to be years ahead of my current understanding of our concept of physics. Their very understanding of gravity itself is operating under a separate set of laws. This is fascinating and opens a whole new world on science!"*

"Do. . .do you guys hear Entrapta?" Mara asked.

"Yep." Glimmer said.

Mara walked to the door where she had heard her and realized which building this was. Sighing, she walked in. There beside Entrapta was Prince Zed. "Truly, I did not know that there was one on Etheria with such a love of science. There may be hope for your planet yet."

"So this is how you combine those elements? I had theorized it might be possible but I never imagined it was that easy. Oh, I have to document this!" Entrapta said as she searched for her tracker pad to no avail.

"*Ahem,"* Adora cleared her throat. "Entrapta! There you are! Are you alright? You aren't injured?"

"Hm? Oh, hey Adora! No, I'm fine. Hordak! You found my tracker pad." Entrapta said, taking the tablet from Hordak's hip with her hair.

"We need to go, Entrapta. We can't afford to waste any more time. Catra is counting on us."

"Catra? Adora?" Zed said as he looked at the group before focusing on Mara, "Mara? Where the hell have you been? The whole Kingdom has been looking for you for the last three hours. My father said you just disappeared."

"That's because she did." Keldor's voice sounded from behind Zed. Mara looked at Keldor as he sat in a strange looking chair, tubes connected to his head, shoulders, and arms. She slightly shifted her stance into a more defensible position. "Don't bother. The

gene therapy has me so weak right now, I can't even stand, much less fight."

Hordak walked forward past the group and looked at Keldor. He looked different from him for sure but there was no mistaking it. "You are my progenitor. The source of my DNA quadruplex."

Keldor raised a brow before examining Hordak, "I take it that you are a clone then. No doubt from that thing that tried to take over my body."

Hordak looked at his arm, the spell pulsing with light "So he's dead then, I take it? Horde Prime's death meant that I would never come to be born."

"For what it's worth, I do apologize. I don't think temporal erasure should be inflicted on anyone, no matter what my opinion of you may be."

"Marlena's trying to erase their timeline and is halfway there already. Mara and Catra both spoke of your willingness to do the right thing, so why are you condemning our timeline to death?" Adora said from the side.

Keldor chuckled, "Is that what you think is happening? No. Marleena is saving your timeline. See, we are in a loop that only Catra can break. Marleena has informed me that this is the closest she has ever gotten to breaking it and I am inclined to believe her." Keldor looked at Adora, narrowing his eyes. "You look familiar."

"My name's Adora. I'm Catra's girlfriend." Adora said.

Keldor smiled a genuine smile. "So, you are Randor's daughter. I'm glad to finally meet my niece."

"What?" Glimmer said.

"You're Adora's uncle?" Bow asked.

He nodded, "I am. Although I'm sorry you had to meet me in such a state." he gestured to himself.

"What do you mean a loop?" Angella asked.

"I take it that you are Angella. Stratos' reports said that Catra had mentioned you looked identical to Queen Rayla." Keldor said as he observed the woman.

Angella nodded somewhat impatiently. "I know I resemble my ancestor quite a bit. Please remain on topic."

Keldor groaned in discomfort as he leaned forward. "Marleena's memories are fractured. She's not quite in the right mindset to connect the dots fully. But I have. At some point in time, Catra's birth was manipulated into falling under a time warped moon. This allowed Catra to be born with a strong inclination towards time magic. Coupled with the fact that Randor's daughter," he nodded at Adora, "and Catra's fates were closely entwined with one another and that only served to make it even more important."

Mara nodded, "I knew this. Catra's mother explained this."

Keldor nodded, "And there lies the problem. Catra's mother, according to Marleena, is dead. Queen C'yra supposedly died, preventing Catra's birth. This had the unfortunate side effect of stopping Adora's birth from having taken place."

"Wait, but we just–" Mara went to speak.

"Talked to the woman, yes, I know. Marleena explicitly said that Adora had not been born because of these events. Randor and myself as well as Evelyn and Lorric all were witness to your birth three years ago. Or so it seemed."

"Something's not adding up here." Adora said.

"Indeed. See, I did some digging. We have all been affected by temporal events for the past twenty years. Your birth happened

three years ago, but I have files dating back eighteen years that detail your birth. Marleena was present during Catra's birth but now claims that Catra wasn't born. C'yra who is somehow alive claims that Marleena was responsible for these events but she couldn't see that your birth had taken place. Whatever is causing these events needs to be stopped. Catra must bond with the Temporal Obelisk and right our history."

"But what will that do to our timeline?" Bow asked.

Keldor shook his head, "I don't know. Marleena says that your lives should all return to normal up to the point that you met Adora and Catra. But seeing as how Horde Prime is dead that would complicate things. If Catra and Adora's lives alter history in any shape or form then your lives may not even come to pass. On another note, temporal erasure isn't easily performed. Time has a way of righting itself. I can't say for certain but I do know this. It's not just your timeline collapsing. Every second that Catra fights her connection to the Obelisk breaks our timeline as well."

"So what do we do?" Perfuma spoke up.

"We should help. . . right?" Frosta asked hesitantly.

Everyone shifted uncomfortably. The truth was no one knew what they should do because there really only seemed to be one thing to do.

"I think–" Adora started before an alarm sounded.

"*Attention, all guards of Eternos. This is General Sunder. An Etherian named Catra has assaulted the King and the Queen and is extremely dangerous and is to be detained at once. She is of magicat descent and has heterochromia with a yellow eye and blue eye. Do not let her leave the city!"*

"Great." Mermista let out an annoyed groan.

Sea Hawk ducked back into the building. "Everyone, I seem to have located Catra."

"What!" Adora said as she rushed outside, looking to where Sea Hawk was pointing. There, running across rooftops while being chased by flying drones, was Catra. Everyone watched as Catra dashed through the rooftops of Eternos, slashing any drone that got too close to her to ribbons. She hurled stasis orbs, freezing the drones in place as she widened the distance between herself and her pursuers.

"Swift Wind! Can you–" Adora turned, only to see Swift Wind's wings extended.

"Already on it. Let's go!" Swift Wind shouted as Adora climbed on his back.

As they quickly flew into the air, chasing after Catra, Angella noticed something didn't seem quite right. She eyed the street as she realized that there were no civilians anywhere. She looked back at the group only to find herself alone. "Glimmer? Bow? Hello?" Angella called out, looking around at the desolate city.

Catra ran as fast as she could but she would be lying if she said she wasn't feeling the fatigue catching up with her. All of a sudden, she felt a hand grab the back of her shirt, lifting her high off the ground. She went to slash the offending person before she realized that she was looking at Swift Wind.

"Hey Catra! Need some help?" Swift Wind asked.

She looked up to find that Adora was on the back, her red staff in hand. "Adora! How are you here? Did the Obelisk pull you here?"

"No. It's a long story but basically, Mara showed up and told us that you were in trouble. Hordak and Entrapta managed to build a time machine before our timeline collapsed. We're here to save you."

"I. . . I don't know if that's possible." Catra said, climbing onto the back of Swift Wind.

"We know. Keldor just told us about the whole time loop thing."

"He did? But–" Catra was cut off by a laser whizzed past her ear. They looked back to find the drones had closed the distance and were getting closer and more numerous.

"What are those things!" Adora exclaimed as Swift Wind started to take evasive maneuvers, diving into the streets and cutting through alleyways.

"They're called RK units. They're Eternos' new guard implements." Catra said as she held onto Adora's waist.

The drones seemed to be just as fast as Swift Wind if not more so. No amount of twists and turns seemed to shake them off. Catra looked at Adora. "Now would be a good time to turn into She Ra right now!"

"I can't! I don't have the sword." Adora shouted over the sounds of the crackling lasers.

Catra went to ask why not before pain erupted in her shoulder. She let out a scream of pain as she almost fell off of Swift Wind's back. Adora quickly pulled Catra back to her before Swift Wind, in a panic, quickly flapped his wings much harsher than before, letting out a wave of light that seemed to stall the drones. Catra groaned in pain as Swift Wind quickly made his way back to the area where they had left Mara.

Quickly ducking into a doorway, Adora, Catra, and Swift Wind watched as the drones flew past them, searching for their targets. After a moment of stillness, Adora breathed a sigh of relief before getting off Swift Wind.

Adora quickly helped Catra down, "Are you alright?"

Catra nodded, rubbing her shoulder with a wince. "Yeah, I'll be fine. It just surprised me is all." Catra looked at the staff that she had gifted Adora. "What happened to your sword?"

"Mara has it. As it stands, I can't transform into She Ra. Shadow Weaver put a spell on my arm that'll keep me shielded from the temporal effects. The only downside is that if I transform–"

"The spell wears off." Catra finished. She let out a sigh, "All right. Where's Mara? And did you say Hordak and Entrapta are here?"

"Yeah and so is the rest of the Princess Alliance, plus Shadow Weaver."

"So what's the plan?" Catra asked.

Adora nodded, "Right, the plan, yes. Step one was to save you."

"Okay, and. . ."

"Mara theorized that the reason for our time's collapse is that it fell out of sync. If we can put time back on the right path, then it should bring it back." Adora explained.

". . . That's what Randor said too."

"Randor? That's my. . ."

"Father, yeah. He's also the King." Catra said as she let out a breath.

Adora was quiet at that before leaning in and giving Catra a kiss. Catra blinked, "What was that for?" She asked curiously.

"I'm not sure about any of this Catra. But I'm with you. On any choice you make today, I'll stand by it."

"Hey Adora? Catra? Where is everyone?" Swift Wind asked.

Adora looked around before walking back into the room where Zed and Keldor had been. She found no trace of anyone. She ran back to Catra and Swift Wind, "They're gone!"

Catra went to speak up before she smelled something. "Wait."

"What is it?" Adora asked.

"Do you smell that? It smells like. . ."

Adora took a deep breath, "Electricity?"

"Yeah. It seems familiar somehow." Catra said, searching the streets. People were peeking out of their windows, looking to stay hidden from whoever the RK units had been chasing.

Suddenly, multiple guards came rushing into the marketplace, accompanied by Stratos and Lorric. "Catra couldn't have gotten far. If Adora grabbed her, they'll most likely head this way again. Spread out and search the area." Stratos commanded.

"If you see them, stun only. They're still Mara's friends. And keep a look out for the pink haired one. She got away." Lorric added before turning.

Adora and Catra went to scramble away from the alleyway opening to no avail. Lorric and several of the men had chosen to walk down this alley in particular. If Swift Wind flew, he'd be spotted immediately. As they walked into the alleyway, Lorric looked right at them. And kept moving. "This alleyway is clear Stratos."

"Keep looking. Adora's steed landed in this vicinity."

As they left them there, they looked at one another in confusion. Before Catra could ask what had happened, two hands laid on both of their shoulders. "Shhhhhh."

Catra and Adora turned to see none other than Shadow Weaver, her eyes alight with magic. As Catra looked back at Mara's father, she watched them all gather, "The area's clear. No sign of them anywhere."

Stratos cursed under his breath before raising his wrist to his mouth, "We're clear on this end. No sign of either Catra or Adora. The pink one's location is also unknown."

"Understood." A firm voice answered. Catra recognized it as Keldor. A moment of silence passed before an order came through. "Return to the Castle."

"Sir?" He asked, unsure. Suddenly, Randor's voice replaced his brother's

"Stop chasing Catra. Give her a moment to breathe."

"But, my King! She–" Stratos went to answer before being cut off.

"Is stressed and wants a moment to herself. Let her sit for a moment with Adora. Her friends are at the Royal Palace. She will return in her own time."

"We have a limited timeframe for Catra to connect to the Obelisk before our own timeline comes undone. We can't–"

"Yes we can. No rifts have appeared. No pockets of time have made themselves known. I don't think a couple more hours will hurt. Now return to the palace." Randor ordered.

Stratos let out a breath of agitation before answering, albeit in a strained voice. "Yes, My King. At once."

As they watched them completely leave, Adora turned towards Shadow Weaver. "What happened? Where have you been?"

"When I came through the portal, I found myself in a large river just outside the Royal Palace. I noticed Catra being chased and then I saw you and Swift Wind. I made my way towards the initial area that I saw you take off." Shadow Weaver quickly answered.

"Did you see what happened to everyone?" Catra asked.

"Not quite, but I saw the tail ends of the attack. There was a tall woman with red hair wearing white and gold armor. She was a skilled mage if I ever saw one. Effortlessly cast an illusion around her forces. It was impressive, all things considered."

"Red hair?" Catra's mind flashed to Serenia before turning to the woman she saw earlier. "Could be Serenia's sister. That matches the description."

"Who cares who she is!" Glimmer cried as she appeared in between everyone. "She took everyone."

"Glimmer!" Adora said before hugging her. "Are you alright?"

"I'm fine, but what do we do? She completely beat everybody. I only barely teleported away."

"What about Mara? Surely she couldn't have beaten She Ra?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"She did something. She held up a copy of your sword when she transformed. It shut off her transformation." Glimmer responded.

"They used Mara's sword to nullify Adora's? How does that work?" Catra asked.

"It's a frequency shift. She used Mara's sword to mimic the wavelength of her magic, therefore allowing her to direct it. A very high level defensive technique. She's definitely powerful." Shadow Weaver said, a slight note of admiration in her tone.

"You can take her right? Because it's down to us." Glimmer asked.

Shadow Weaver hummed. "As I am? No. If she is truly as good as I think she is, then we have a major problem on our hands. Because from what you've told me, Catra, Evelyn is the most skilled and powerful mage on the planet. Not this woman."

"You'd be wrong in that assumption." A voice said from the opening of the alleyway. As they turned to the owner of the voice, there stood none other than the red haired woman herself.

Catra immediately unsheathed her claws before readying a stasis orb in her hand. Adora twisted her staff, the blades immediately

sliding free, Glimmer readied her fists with glowing magic, and Shadow Weaver simply narrowed her eyes.

The woman looked at them cautiously before eyeing Catra and Adora. "My name's Teela. And yes, Catra, you were right in your guess. I'm Serenia's sister. Can we talk?"

Catra looked up at the roof tops, searching for any sign of the drones that had chased her. Teela spoke up, "It's just me. Everyone else has returned to the palace."

"Where'd you take my mom!" Glimmer snapped angrily.

"She's fine. I promise. They're in the main hall. King Randor is hosting them as we speak. I don't want to fight."

"Then what do you want?" Adora asked, slightly on edge.

"To take you back to the obelisk. But I don't want to force you." She quickly added. "I want you to come with me of your own volition. No one's given you a choice in this matter and I know it doesn't seem like you have one with everything going on but you do. You always have a choice and this situation is no different."

"That's it? You're not gonna attack us?" Glimmer asked in disbelief.

"If it makes you feel better, I'll stay a few feet away. That way, if you need to, you can teleport yourselves away from me." Teela proposed.

Catra looked at her company. "What do you wanna do?"

"I want to see my mom and Bow for starters." Glimmer said a bit sourly.

Adora nodded in agreement. "Likewise. Show us that nobody's hurt."

Shadow Weaver looked at Catra. A slight nod of agreement. Catra looked back at Teela. "I want to talk to Mara and my friends. Randor too."

Teela nodded, "Alright." She said before putting her hand out, a disc in her hand. Instantly a hologram of Randor appeared.

"Teela? What are you–"

"Randor! Can you hear me?" Catra said from across the alley. Teela twisted the disc towards Catra. Randor looked at Catra. "I can hear and see you, Catra. Are you alright?"

"I'm fine. What drink did you just bring me half an hour ago?"

"Huh? It was an Etherian drink. It was pink with a fruit slice in it. I think I messed it up. Why are. . . Catra, Teela isn't making an illusion. You are really speaking to me."

Catra narrowed her eyes. "I want to talk to Angella."

Randor nodded, "Alright." He looked off to the side before making an ushering motion before disappearing. Angella's image stepped into view a moment later.

"Mom!" Glimmer shouted, "Are you alright?"

Angella nodded, "Yes, I'm fine, Glimmer. A little shaken, but I'm alright." She turned to look at Catra, "How are you feeling Catra?"

"A little trapped." Catra answered honestly.

Adora took a hesitant step forward. "Is. . . Is Marleena there?"

Angella looked off to the side before stepping back. Marleena appeared, instantly looking at Adora. "I'm here, Adora."

Catra nodded before looking at Teela. "I want you to go back to the palace and let Mara come talk to us. Alone. Then we'll come."

"We will?" Adora asked Catra.

Catra gave a nod. Teela looked at Catra before looking at Marleena. "Did you hear that?"

Marleena nodded. "Of course."

Teela turned the disc off before stepping back. As she turned to walk back to the palace she turned to look at Catra and Adora. "Zed said to tell you he's sorry for calling us."

Catra shrugged. "If everyone's okay then I don't particularly care."

Teela smiled and left the alleyway. As the four of them sat in silence, Shadow Weaver was the first to speak. "Did Marleena give any concrete evidence of what will happen when you bond with the Obelisk?"

Catra let out a breath, "She said that the timeline will right itself. Everyone's lives would continue as normal until Adora and I entered the picture. As for ourselves, we'd. . .not be there." Catra finished, thinking of the right words.

"Ah, but therein lies the problem. Haven't you realized it? Adora's life and yours did not just influence the Alliance, it also shaped the Horde's as well as my own. Simply put, our lives revolved around one another for the last eighteen years. How does my life continue as normal until you were to appear?"

"Exactly. Marleena also said that our friends wouldn't know us either. That the Horde would have no connection with us. Except. . ."

"Except what?" Glimmer asked.

"Except I was able to access a form of future sight with the obelisk. It allowed me to see two paths. One where I didn't help Marleena and refused to form a bond with the obelisk."

"What happened?" Adora asked.

"We looped. Again and again. We're trapped in a loop." Catra answered solemnly.

"So Keldor was telling the truth." Glimmer said.

And the second option?" Shadow Weaver pressed on.

"If I chose to bond with the obelisk and break the loop. Except, Marleena was wrong." Catra looked at Glimmer, "You were there with Bow. We were getting ready for Scorpia's first Princess Prom and Angella and Micah were waiting for us. We were all laughing."

"Micah?" Shadow Weaver muttered.

"My dad was there?" Glimmer asked in shock.

"Was there anything else?" Adora asked.

Catra shook her head. "Besides us being older, no. But we were definitely in Brightmoon."

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes before looking at Catra. "You have to bond with the obelisk."

"What? But–"

"No. Catra, If Micah is alive, and Glimmer is still there, that means that I'm still very much alive. Micah only met Angella due to my teachings."

"I only met Bow because of the Princess Alliance. So if Bow was there, doesn't that mean that the Alliance would still have taken place?" Glimmer asked.

Adora looked at Catra, "Were we both there?"

Catra nodded, "We kissed."

Adora looked down for a second. "I. . .I think we should break the loop."

"I. . .I don't want to sound selfish, but if Bow and my parents were there, if we were all happy, then I think we should do it. But, Catra, what do you want to do?" Glimmer asked with a concerned look.

Catra looked at all three of them before her gaze shifted to Adora and lingered on her, her thoughts shifting.

'*It doesn't matter what they do. The two of us look out for each other.*'

' *You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.*'

'*. . .I love you. I always have.*'

Catra took a deep breath before turning towards the alley opening. "What do you think Mara? Should I do it?"

Everyone turned to look where Catra was focused on. There, in the clearing, stood Mara. She looked at Catra before speaking softly. "I-I don't know. This is for you to decide Catra."

Catra nodded quietly before looking at everyone. "All right then. Let's go see Marleena."

As everyone nodded and started walking towards the palace, Shadow Weaver let the dark crackling spell fall away from her hand as she followed the group. The truth was, Catra did not have any choice in the matter. Shadow Weaver had decided she would bond with the obelisk and that was the end of it. She was glad that Catra had been made to see reason. As she walked silently, she watched Catra take Adora's hand, squeezing it tightly. Shadow Weaver acknowledged the situation. If there was ever a time that fear was the appropriate response, well, that time was now. As they neared the Palace gates, Shadow Weaver cast a spell on herself with the power she had kept from Mara. Every last drop of magic was poured into it. Nothing was spared.

As Catra stepped into the Palace, her gaze fell onto Keldor first. He looked better than he had a few hours ago. His skin had returned to its shade of blue for the most part, albeit a bit lighter. And his hair was not quite the black it was originally. It looked more blue than black. His eyes had returned to their orange with some flecks of red. All in all, he looked a lot like Hordak, just healthier.

Stratos was the next person she looked at. He was wearing a bandage around his eye that she had not seen in the alley. "Sorry." She quickly said. He simply nodded.

She turned her gaze towards her friends. "Are you guys okay?"

They all looked to Catra. Glimmer ran up to her mom and Bow, embracing them a hug. Sea Hawk laughed boisterously. "I do say that this will easily be my most storied adventure."

"He means we're fine." Mermista said dryly.

Perfuma and Frosta nodded. "We're good." Frosta said.

Catra breathed a sigh of relief. "Good." She simply said before turning to look at Randor and Marleena. "We could have talked this through. It didn't have to be this whole thing."

"I– You're right. I'm sorry." Marleena quietly apologized. In the quiet of the throne room, she may as well have shouted.

"Yeah, for real. This sucked." Mermista snapped.

"Indeed." Shadow Weaver drawled.

Marleena's gaze turned on Shadow Weaver, a dark look settling on her face. "You are the last person I want to hear from." She hissed in fury.

"Oh? Why is that? I do believe this is the first time we've spoken." Shadow Weaver asked curiously.

"What I've witnessed, what I've seen. . . how you've treated my daughter." She said icily through clenched teeth. "If this were any other situation, I would have you killed."

Shadow Weaver hummed. "My treatment? I'm not the one who's destroyed all of time and space. I gave Adora and Catra a life. Granted, it might not have been the grand one that you had planned but at least they had one. To me, you seem like the one at fault here. I would question what treatment you would have given them."

Marlena's eyes narrowed as she seethed. Keldor cleared his throat. "Let us get to the matter at hand. Besides, it's not like it will matter in a few minutes."

Everyone stayed quiet at the interaction before Randor entered the room with Evelyn and Lorric. His eyes lingered on Shadow Weaver for a moment before falling onto Adora and Catra. He breathed a sigh of relief. "Catra, I'm glad to see you safe." He took a deep breath as he looked at Adora, "Adora."

Adora looked at King Randor. She suddenly felt a lot smaller. "I. . .How should I address you?"

He smiled. "You can call me Randor if that's more comfortable for you." He let out a shaky breath as he rubbed his eyes, "I'm glad to see you did well for yourself. That you've made friends, found a family, a lover." He paused, "Even enemies. You've grown into a fine young woman who I couldn't be prouder of."

Catra stayed silent but didn't miss how Adora squeezed her hand. Catra squeezed back before looking at Marleena. "So. . .what do we have to do?"

Marleena looked at Catra, "Do you know what's stopping Adora from appearing the correct way?"

"It's a spell." Adora answered. It stopped the temporal magics from affecting me." She held her arm up. Teela stepped forward, examining her arm.

"Wow! This. . .is pretty advanced. Who drew this?" She asked.

"I did." Shadow Weaver answered.

"Are you familiar with time magic?" Teela asked.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. "No. But I'm curious as to how I compare to Eternia's sorcerers."

Teela looked at the woman, "If that's truly all guess work then I'm impressed. You must have a lot of experience with magic. I'd say you're definitely in the top ten on Eternia." She said as she drew a line threw Adora's arm, dispelling the sigils. Everyone looked towards the obelisk as every crack instantly righted itself before going still.

Shadow Weaver smiled. "Why thank you. I was the top teacher at Mystacour during my time there."

"It shows." Teela said as she turned towards Marleena. "The spell has been disrupted."

Marleena nodded, "All that's left is to forge the bond Catra. The rest is up to you."

Catra looked at the obelisk at the center of the room, "Will I be frozen again once I walk towards it?"

"No. The damage has repaired itself. All that's left is to forge the bond." Evelyn answered from the back.

Catra looked at the gem stone before turning and giving Adora a kiss. After a moment, Catra walked up to the stone and laid her hand on it.

As the morning rays peeked through the drapery, hitting her eyes in just the right way, Glimmer let out a groan, turning over in her bed.

The door swung open as a figure walked into her room. "Glimmer? Are you still asleep? You know your mother isn't going to be happy."

"Five more minutes dad." Glimmer groaned into her pillow before, all of a sudden, she sat up. Glimmer looked around the room before looking down. There stood her father, King Micah, an expectant look on his face.

He let out a sigh before smiling. "Alright. Five minutes, but no more. Besides, I'm sure Bow is already here, waiting on you." A teasing tone coloring his voice.

Glimmer looked at him in shock as left the room. Glimmer blinked before immediately teleporting out of the bed and getting dressed at breakneck speeds. As she threw her cape on, she rushed out of her room before bumping into someone.

"Excuse me Princess Glimmer. I didn't see you."

Glimmer looked up at the owner of the voice only to see Hordak. "Hordak?" He looked a little different. His cape was now purple rather than red, his metal parts of his exoskeleton now were armor, and his symbol that typically resided on his chest was now in the form of several badges on his chest.

"Yes? Do you need something Princess?"

"Uh, no? Maybe? Do you know what just happened? What happened to Adora and Catra?"

Hordak raised a brow. "The Princess of Eternia and her fiance? What about them?"

"You don't remember?" Glimmer asked.

"Remember what?" Hordak asked in confusion. "Are you alright Glimmer?"

"Uh, yeah. Nevermind." Glimmer said as she teleported to the main hall. There in the hall sat her parents talking with General juliet. She looked around before spotting Bow. She quickly ran up to him.

"Bow!"

"Hey, Glimmer! Good Morning." Bow said happily. Glimmer looked at him. To her eyes, Bow still looked completely the same.

"Bow, do you remember what happened?" Glimmer asked.

"What happened?" Bow asked.

"With Adora and Catra? The Temporal Obelisk and the timeline?" Glimmer asked.

"No? What do you mean by the timeline? Wait, did you say Adora? Like, *the* Adora?" Bow asked with stars in his eyes.

"What are you talking about? Of course I mean her. She's our friend. Don't you remember her?" Glimmer asked.

"I think I'd remember meeting the future queen of Eternia. Are you feeling alright?" Bow asked.

Glimmer let out a groan. She turned away before sending a look at her father. Catra had said that her father was alive and that she and Adora had been together getting ready for Scorpia's first Princess Prom. Was this the timeline fix? Had Catra done it? She needed answers.

Glimmer looked back at Bow before an idea came to her mind. "Do you remember Mara?"

"Our friend Mara? Of course I remember her. Why wouldn't I?" Bow asked. His smile had faded. "Glimmer, talk to me. What's going on?"

"I. . .We need to go see Mara. Where is she?" Glimmer asked.

"Probably by her ship at the Crystal Castle." Bow said.

Glimmer nodded before grabbing Bow and teleporting there. As they appeared in the clearing, Glimmer immediately saw Mara. Bow stumbled a bit before walking after Glimmer. "Glimmer! You have to warn me before you do that!"

"Mara! Do you remember Catra and Adora?" Glimmer asked desperately, ignoring Bow for the time being.

Mara looked up at her friends, a smile on her lips, "Hey guys. What'd you say?"

"The Temporal Obelisk, Marleena, Catra. Do you remember any of that? We were just there in the Royal Palace." Glimmer explained.

"What are you talking about? Catra and Adora have never met you? And your mom would kill me if I let you leave Etheria." Mara said, confusion in her voice.

Glimmer threw her hands up in anger. "What the hell! Why can't you guys remember?"\

"Because they were not infused with the essence of She Ra at the time of the temporal repair deary." A woman said as she hobbled into the clearing.

"Razz?" Glimmer said in confusion. "You remember?"

"Wait, you know what she's talking about, Razz?" Mara asked.

"When Catra reforged her bond with the obelisk, it sent out a wave of magic, setting things in such a way that kept everyone safe." Razz continued as she walked up to Glimmer.

"Then why can't Mara remember? She was literally She Ra!" Glimmer said, motioning towards the woman.

"Can someone clue me into what's happening?" Mara said.

"Mara was never meant to be She Ra. She was to inherit the power of He-Ro. At that moment, Mara was not holding her sword, thus she did not retain her memories. But you had been infused by it." Razz continued. "Not even Adora can remember. But she can be made to remember."

Glimmer noticed the woman was slowly turning transparent. "Razz! What's happening to you?"

Mara went to touch her only to find her hand passing through her. "Razz!"

She looked at Mara. "Trust each other. You will need every ounce of help you can get for what's coming. When you come to the sword, keep going and cross the threshold. Cross the threshold and find me. You must remember."

Glimmer watched in horror as Razz faded away. Mara looked at the spot where her friend had just vanished from before turning towards Glimmer. "What happened? What did she mean?"

Glimmer looked from Bow to Mara before she started to explain the story. It was well into the evening by the time that Glimmer had finished. As they sat in silence, struggling to grasp what they had just heard, Mara stood up. "Catra has always had the power to manipulate time. That is her birthright. But what could have caused Razz to disappear like that. If you were the only one to have She Ra's magic what else could have happened?"

Glimmer thought about it before she came to a chilling realization. "Shadow Weaver. I got my power through a transfer from Shadow Weaver."

My god! This took forever. But I can now safely say, the next chapter will be the last. Let me know your thoughts and as always enjoy.

Chapter 15

Catra felt that she should be in a better mood considering the date, yet all she could think about was how absolutely bored she currently was. As she sat in her throne, her mind drifted to Adora. She let out a small smile as she thought about the feeling of her hands caressing her body. Her breath on–

"Catra! Are you paying attention?"

Catra quickly sat forward as she was brought back to the present. ". . .Yes?" She hesitantly answered, looking at her future father in law.

Randor raised an eyebrow. "I know this is boring but you need to know this stuff. It's not like Halfmoon. You won't just be the queen of all of Eternia, but the Empress of the natural known universe."

Catra groaned as she rubbed her face in exasperation. "Is it really that important? I mean, Adora will be there beside me."

"Catra," Randor's voice stern, "You can't expect Adora to pick up all of your slack. Especially not with the newest addition to the Empire." Randor sent a pointed look at her to which Catra caved.

She leaned back in her chair. "So what's the big deal with this Earth place anyways? Is it that important?"

Randor let out a chuckle. "Well, for starters, Marleena's from there as well as Mara's mother. And it's not so important to us that they join the Empire as much as it is to Marleena and Evelyn. Think of it another way. Humanity in the last thirty years has managed to pull itself back up from complete planetary and ecological collapse. They didn't have magic like all of the other planets. They were so far removed at the edges of the universe that their planet could not self heal. Now, they've stabilized and Marleena has

pushed for them to join us in the stars. But they're hesitant. Any clue as to why?" Randor looked at Catra expectantly.

". . .They feel that they'll lose their sovereignty?" Catra answered questioningly.

Randor nodded, "Exactly. They've expressed extreme gratitude but they're wary, cautious even. We are the first extraterrestrial life that they've ever encountered and we freely offered aid without asking anything in return. They want to believe that we really mean what we're offering. That Eternia really is everything that Marleena says it is." He paused for a moment before a solemn look fell on his face. "But some call Marleena and Evelyn traitors. That is the minority of course, but those people tend to have loud voices."

"Well that's really stupid." Catra snapped.

Randor nodded, "Yes, I agree. But that's why we're going over all of this now. So nothing is unknown in the future."

"If I really messed something up, I could just rewind y'know?"

"I am of the personal opinion that you and my daughter abuse that particular ability far too much. But that's beside the point. The fact that you even showed up today says a lot to me, Catra."

"How so?" Catra asked as she flexed her claws in boredom.

"It really shows that you care about Adora." Randor smiled kindly.

Catra rolled her eyes as she looked away from the man. "Well obviously I care about her. I asked her to marry me."

Randor nodded, his annoying smile still present on his face. Catra rolled her eyes before standing. "You can stop with that dumb smile anytime." She complained. Unfortunately, it was contagious. The corners of Catra's mouth started to turn upwards before Teela entered the throne room.

"King Randor." Teela bowed.

Randor waved her off, "Where's Andra? Is she not accompanying you today?"

"She needed the day off, so I'm taking over for her. Besides, Queen Catra here has a busy day scheduled." Teela said.

"One, stop calling me that. I'm not the queen yet." Catra said, a grin on her face, "Two, I do? Since when?"

"Kyle, Rojelio, Zed and Lonnie are waiting for you. Apparently, they said you made plans with them?" Teela explained.

"Shit," Catra muttered under her breath, "That's today?"

Teela nodded. "Yeah, in about ten minutes actually. They're at the food courts."

Randor looked at Catra, "What's today?"

"Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio wanted to celebrate Adora and I's engagement." Catra said as she sat back down in her throne.

"Do you not want to?" Randor asked.

"It's not that. I'd love to, it's just that with everything that's going on, Adora and I have been so busy. It's just been a while since we had a moment to ourselves. I completely forgot about today if I'm being honest." Catra said dejectedly.

"For someone who can control time, you sure are short on it." Evelyn said as she entered the hall.

"Tell me about it." Catra said before standing. "Well, I suppose I better get ready."

Teela nodded before Catra warped away. As she appeared in her room, she was greeted to the sight of a changing Adora. Quietly sneaking up on her, she wrapped her arms around her fiance's

waist before laying a kiss on her neck. "Hey Adora." she said sensually.

Adora let out a soft breath, a smile on her lips, "What are you doing here? Weren't you in the middle of lessons with my dad."

Catra rested her chin on Adora's shoulders, an irritated groan escaping her lips. "Yeah, and I completely forgot that I made plans with Lonnie and our friends today."

Adora smiled before giving Catra a kiss. "We'll get some alone time tonight." She said as if reading Catra's mind.

"Orrrr we could have some alone time right now." Catra said, a light pur emanating from her as her hands started to wander.

"Catra, we both have things we need to do today. We don't really have time right now." Despite Adora's protests, she didn't do much to stop her fiance's advancements as she turned around, pulling Catra into a deep kiss. As Catra and Adora made their way towards their bed, they were interrupted by a loud banging of their door and an even louder voice.

"Catra! Adora! I know you're both in there. You have a minute to make yourselves decent before I open this door."

Catra let out an annoyed hiss, "You know, you could come back in like ten minutes, Marleena!" She shouted at the door.

"And you could save it for later, Catra!" She responded in an equally snarky tone. "Contrary to your belief, I'd rather not hear my daughter having sex."

"Then walk away and you wouldn't have to hear it." She said as she leaned down to grab Adora's clothes, handing them to her.

"I was a teenager too once. It starts at ten minutes, then it's on to fifteen, and then twenty. Especially you, Catra." Marleena answered.

"*Especially you, Catra."* Catra mocked quietly. Adora let out a grin and a small laugh.

As Adora went to leave the room, she gave Catra a kiss goodbye, "Tonight. I promise."

"So, can you remember anything up until this point, or are you only aware of the previous timeline?" Mara asked as they sat in Phyla's tavern.

Glimmer shook her head, "Not really. It's all hazy. Like, I remember my dad and growing up with him there, but it's hard to picture. It's like I should know it but can't quite grasp it." Glimmer let out a groan, "Ugh, this must be how Catra felt when she had amnesia. I so owe her an apology."

Bow raised an eyebrow, "So we're friends with Princesses Adora and Catra in the other timeline?"

"Yeah, we've been friends with Adora for about a year now, and just recently became friends with Catra about a month and a half ago." Glimmer responded as she took a sip of her drink.

"How does that even work? Catra hasn't ever once stepped foot on Etheria. Adora's been here a few times but what could have caused the change? And am I still friends with you guys? I need details." Mara said.

Glimmer shook her head. "No, actually. In fact, before now, we've only spoken like three times. You're from a thousand years in the past for us."

"Then how did we talk?" Mara asked, baffled.

"Catra was exposed to shards of what we now know are the Temporal Obelisk." Glimmer explained.

"Right. We went over that." Bow said.

"Well, then she lost her memories and somehow time traveled back a thousand years. Then you and Catra found a way to communicate in the Crystal Castle by making some memory program run by like a zip second or something." Glimmer said.

"A zeptosecond? That's incredibly dangerous to one's mind. Why would I do something like that?" Mara asked.

Glimmer shrugged, "Beats me. Like I said, we only spoke a few times. I also was a bit younger than I am now." She said before outstretching the wings on her back with a grin, "And these are new."

"How old do you think you are?" Bow asked.

"Seventeen?" Glimmer answered, putting her newfound wings away.

Mara shook her head, "Nope, you and Bow are both nineteen."

Just as they were about to continue talking, Phyla brought their food over. "Here you go Mara, Bow, Glimmer." She said, setting individual platters down.

"Thanks, Phyla." Mara said with a smile.

"No problem. Enjoy." Phyla said as she left them to their privacy.

"So, wait a second. General Hordak was our enemy? How does that work?" Bow asked.

"He wasn't from Etheria. He was an invader that took over the Fright Zone–"

"Scorpia's Kingdom, right?" Mara interjected.

"Yeah." Glimmer nodded, "And then he formed the Horde. At which point he plunged all of Etheria into a war."

"Wow! That's crazy. Here, Hordak is our top general alongside Juliet. And the Horde is Etheria's army." Bow said.

"Yeah, I'm still trying to wrap my brain around that one. Etheria has its own army. Who's in charge of it?" Glimmer asked.

"Your parents. Bright Moon is the ruling kingdom of Etheria. It presides over the rest of Etheria's kingdoms." Bow explained.

"Uh huh. . ." Glimmer nodded, "and who exactly is Hordak in this timeline?" she asked.

"He's actually the little brother of Prince Keldor." Mara said as she took a bite of her food.

"Adora's uncle? Fleet Admiral Keldor?" Glimmer asked.

"The very one. Was that different for you?" Mara asked.

Glimmer gained a thoughtful look on her face. "Eh, kinda? I only learned about it a little bit ago, but I guess Hordak was a clone of Keldor or something? He said he was his genetic progenitor. I'm not too sure about the rest of it. But they still looked way different from one another."

"That would be a big no no on Eternia. Cloning is strictly overseen by the science division. But as for their appearance difference, Keldor and Hordak are half brothers. Same mom, different dads. Keldor is a Gar-Eternian hybrid. Hordak is a Gar-Spelean hybrid. That's why he has those bat-like features." Mara said.

"You know," Glimmer said after a moment, "couldn't we go to the Crystal Castle and just use the memory thing?"

"That. . . is actually a good idea. Sure, come on." Mara said as they stood up.

"It's still the middle of the night. Won't my mom get mad at us?" Glimmer asked.

"Well, think of it as one of the positives of a peaceful Etheria. Your curfew is much more flexible. Let's go." Bow said.

As the trio made their way to the Crystal Castle, Glimmer looked around at the scenery and just now realized that the soldiers and guards they passed all wore a strange mixture of Etherian and Horde armor and people were glad to see them. It was truly bizarre. Looking up, she couldn't help but be enthralled by the beauty of Etheria's stars.

As they entered the castle, Mara stepped forward, "Hope! Are you here?"

All of a sudden, a taller woman with short white hair wearing sleepwear came walking out of a hallway from the side. Glimmer didn't recognize her. Her eyes were sharper and her skin was pale. She bore a resemblance to her father and aunt castaspella. She seemed familiar though. Glimmer watched as she walked up to Mara, giving her a kiss before waving her hands in the air.

"Who is. . .?" Glimmer started to ask before Bow spoke up.

"Hey Light Hope."

Glimmer blanched in shock. "This is Light Hope?"

The woman raised an eyebrow in confusion, looking at Mara. Mara held up a finger before turning towards Glimmer. "You don't recognize her?" Mara asked, a hint of concern peeking through.

"She seems familiar, but. . . the Light Hope I know is like two feet taller than you and is a hologram with purple skin." Glimmer said to Mara.

"Yes. That is still me, Glimmer. It's just my avatar." Light Hope's familiar voice resounded from around them as the girl made several motions with her hands. Glimmer recognized it as the Etherian sign language.

Glimmer looked at Mara, "I'm sorry if I'm being rude, it's just. . .I'm all over the place right now."

"What happened? Why doesn't she recognize me?" Light Hope asked.

"We're about to figure it out. But to keep a long story short, alternate timelines. Razz disappeared so we need to get to the bottom of what caused it." Mara explained.

Light Hope gained a concerned look on her face. "Oh my god. Is she dead?"

"No," Bow answered, "Just gone. She told us to cross a threshold and find her. She also told Glimmer to talk to Adora and Catra."

Light Hope looked at Glimmer, "So, is this our Glimmer?"

"Yes, but her memories are scattered." Mara said.

Glimmer nodded, "Everything's hazy. You seem familiar and my dad's alive but I can't remember much of anything with him soooo. . . yeah."

Light Hope nodded, a determined look falling onto her face as she slammed her fist into her palm, "We'll get to the bottom of this. But to fill you in, we've been friends for about five years now. We met the same time you met Mara."

Glimmer nodded, "I'll do my best to remember."

"That's actually why we're here. We need to use the memory program. We need to see Glimmer's last few hours of memories." Mara said.

"I highly advise against that, Mara. The mental strain that could put on Glimmer could have some serious repercussions if she isn't ready for it."

"I'm aware. Start slow and work your way towards the present."

Light Hope nodded before waving her hand, a magic circle appearing. Glimmer looked at it and noticed that it looked different than normal magic. It looked a lot more. . . structured? Bow noticed her confused face and smiled. "Light Hope is a technomancer."

"Technomancer? What's that?" Glimmer asked.

"Technopathy is the ability to utilize magic in the shape and form of technology and science." Light Hope's voice rang out through the castle.

"She's also the only one. Nobody else has ever figured it out." Mara said with admiration. "Light Hope is from Earth, like my mother."

"You're not Eternian?" Glimmer asked.

"Nope. She's a human. Light Hope was only a baby when she left Earth with her mother. She's from a country called Japan. Earth was in the beginning stages of repairing itself from a ecosystemic collapse that spanned the whole planet. Her parents sought out Aunt Marleena in hopes of giving Hope a better life."

Glimmer nodded as she watched the Crystal Castle's interior shift. Light Hope turned towards Glimmer. "If it makes you more comfortable," all of a sudden, a hologram of the Light Hope she was familiar with appeared in front of the group, "I can use my avatar if you'd feel more at ease, Glimmer."

Glimmer shook her head, "It's fine. Technically this is the repaired timeline that Catra chose so. . .I should get used to it."

Light Hope gave a wide smile before nodding. "The memory sequence will begin now." She paused, "Mara, there seems to be a whole second branch of memories in Glimmer's cerebral cortex."

"Yeah, that sounds about right. Just play those specific ones." Mara said.

"The most recent memories I can relay safely are from a year prior. It seems to be a battle with. . ." She paused.

"Adora and Catra, right?" Glimmer asked.

Light Hope nodded. "Yes. Playing now."

Their surroundings shifted to one of a burning village as smoke billowed around them. "It's the Horde," Glimmer cried as they ducked into a hut.

"Why are they here? The people of Thaymor aren't a threat." Bow asked.

Mara, Bow, and Light Hope looked at the alternate versions of Bow and Glimmer. Mara's focus was more directed at Adora though. She was definitely not the girl that she had grown up around.

"Wait. Did you say Thaymor? This can't be Thaymor." Adora said in disbelief.

"Did you know something about this?" Glimmer snapped accusatory.

"No. I mean yes. But there's a mistake. Thaymor's supposed to be a heavily fortified rebel fortress, not a civilian town!" Adora explained.

"Do you really think that matters to them?" Glimmer asked.

Adora looked at Glimmer and Bow, "I can get them to stop. This is all a big mistake. I just need to talk to them. Get as many people out as you can and don't let them see you." She threw down the flower sash, "I'm sorry."

"Adora!" Glimmer yelled as the girl ran out of the hut.

Mara looked at Bow, "You're wearing the same clothes but you look a little different here. What do you think has changed?"

"Maybe because I've had to fight in a war? Combat probably plays a big part in physical exertion and attitude. What about Glimmer? She looks. . ." Bow tried to find the right words.

"Stressed." Light Hope answered. "She looks stressed."

Bow nodded solemnly. "That's one way to put it. I wonder how our lives have differed." Bow said as they watched Glimmer and his alternate self usher villagers out of the crossfire.

"Besides the obvious one," Mara said, gesturing to the battle, "Any number of things could have changed about ourselves personally. Your dads could have met under different circumstances."

Light Hope looked at Bow, "Apparently I was just a hologram and didn't exist."

Bow just nodded before they all turned their attention back to the memory. "Is that–"

Mara nodded, "Yeah, that's Catra. She looks. . ."

"Scary." Light Hope finished.

They watched as Catra engaged Adora, Bow, and Glimmer before Adora transformed into She Ra. "Look, she's using the sword of protection. This must be her first transformation."

"According to a memory prior, Glimmer witnessed Adora's first transformation a few hours before this." Light Hope said.

"Best Friends' Squad!" Bow cried as he pulled Adora and Glimmer into a hug. All of a sudden, Glimmer walked into the clearing smiling before looking at Mara. "Woah. That was weird."

"Yes, it can be disorienting at times. Are you okay?" Light Hope asked.

Glimmer nodded. "Yeah, I'm good. What's next?"

Light Hope held up a hand. "Judging by the advanced state of your cerebral cortex, I should be able to close in on your more recent memories much faster than anticipated."

"Alright." Glimmer said as she watched Light Hope prepare another sequence. The next hour was spent watching Glimmer's experiences as she visited Plumeria, Salineas, and Dryll. Her interactions with the princesses showed Mara, Light Hope, and Bow a much darker timeline as they quickly realized that their friends' parents were most likely dead.

Glimmer did find it strange when Bow revealed to her that the Kingdom of Dryll was not only run by Entrapta, but by her husband as well. "Entrapta married Hordak!"

Light Hope's shoulders shook in silent laughter. "I take it that's strange for you, huh? Based on what you remember and what we know, your Hordak differs greatly from our own."

"No kidding. How much further until we reach Catra's meeting with us?" Glimmer asked.

Light Hope's eyes glowed for a moment before she turned back towards Glimmer, "Now actually."

And so Mara watched as Glimmer met and, in her opinion, justifiably cast suspicion on the amnesic Catra. An argument ensued which ended with Catra passing out. Bow made sure to document the next hour as they watched Glimmer's memories that involved Catra until they finally came to Princess Prom.

Glimmer shook her head as she took a seat, letting out a groan. Light Hope looked at her apologetically. "Are you okay Glimmer? We can take a break if you'd like."

"Just give me a second. Got a bit of a headache is all." Glimmer said.

"Wow, your timeline is all sorts of terrible, Glimmer." Mara said. "On another note, I was She Ra? That's cool I guess. Here, I hold

the power of Hi Ro."

Glimmer looked at her in confusion. "What's that mean?"

"It's basically the same thing except I hold the Sword of Power. Adora holds the Sword of Protection."

"Huh," Glimmer grunted before turning towards Light Hope, "In any case, you mentioned that my current memories are a second branch. Does that mean that I'll be able to remember this timeline as well?"

Light Hope nodded, "It's like a shock went through your brain. It's all still there, it's just too hot to touch at the moment. Once your psyche settles from the shock of it all, you'll begin to recall everything."

"Will I lose my other memories?" Glimmer asked worriedly.

"No," Light Hope shook her head. "That's not how memory works. Once it's there, it's there. That can't be undone. In fact, it's a good thing that it's structured in a second branch. That means that you'll be able to differentiate between the alternate timeline memories."

"Okay," She said, letting out a sigh of relief before nodding, "Alright, I'm good. Let's continue."

As Catra said goodbye to Lonnie's crew, she couldn't shake the feeling that she was being watched. As she was escorted back to the castle, she caught sight of her pursuer.

"You know that you could just walk up to me if you want to speak right?"

Weaving through the crowd towards Catra, out stepped a dark clothing clad woman. Catra examined the dark sorceress. She wore a black mesh veil that extended down her face that slightly hid her features if one wasn't looking close enough. Her dress was

dark blood red with obsidian highlights that seemed to flow like water through the air as she almost seemed to drift along the ground. Catra wouldn't lie, she quite liked the woman's fashion sense. She definitely knew how to hold an audience.

Teela nodded, "Beatrix."

"High Sorceress Teela," She nodded before looking back at Catra. "We haven't been able to meet for your lessons in the past few months. I'm just curious as to when we might be able to resume."

Catra let out a sigh. She knew the woman was right of course. When they had announced their engagement, King Randor had been completely caught off guard. They're had been little time to prepare for it and Catra and Adora had not deigned to tell anyone for a little while. When Randor explained the implications of what Catra had asked for she had not been deterred. But the constant lessons and new duties left her little time to do much else, much less sorcery lessons.

"I apologize for that. I had to prioritize and I didn't mean to halt them. It's just–"

Beatrix held a hand up, silencing Catra before she could continue. "It's alright Your Highness. You don't need to justify yourself to me. I am simply wondering, with your wedding a week away, if we will be resuming your teachings. You are well on your way to mastering the esoteric texts and I don't want your progress to regress."

Catra nodded, "I- Of course. You can expect them to resume soon. By the end of the month to be sure."

Beatrix nodded, "That is all I wished to know. Let me not hold you any longer. I understand that you are quite busy."

Catra nodded, "We'll speak more on the subject at a later time. Goodbye, Beatrix."

As the woman sauntered away, Catra turned back to her objective, heading for the throne room. With Adora out, Randor had taken this as an opportunity to teach Catra about judgement. Catra had tried to argue that her mother had taught her these things already as the heir to the throne of Half Moon, but he had quickly explained that laws differed among planets and she needed to be prepared.

As Catra and her guard stepped into the palace, Randor let out a smile. "Catra, it seems you've evaded today's lessons. Something else needs to be addressed."

"Oh thank Sharella." Catra muttered under her breath before straightening up. "What is it?"

"Your guest list for your wedding for starters. There's a few other things as well." Marleena said from the side as she entered the room with Evelyn.

"I thought we had already completed the guest list? Adora said as much a few weeks ago." Catra answered with slight confusion.

"Your *personal* guest list." Evelyn said. "Your close friends and family that you wish to be front and center."

Catra eyebrows raised in realization, "Oh! Well I already covered that."

"We would like it if you chose more than just Lonnie's group. We know that they're your friends but do you really not want to invite anyone else?" Randor said gently.

Catra's thoughts shifted to Mara and Light Hope. Her gaze must have lingered on Evelyn a tad bit too long because the woman smiled. "Thinking about Mara and Hope are you?"

"I guess." Catra answered noncommittally.

Marleena looked at Catra, "If you want to invite them, you can. You chose Adora and Mara chose Light Hope. There is no

animosity between Mara and my daughter. Besides, you haven't seen each other in almost four years. I'm sure that Adora would be happy to see her friends."

Catra nodded. She had known Adora since they were just infants and they had grown a very strong bond because of it. But when she had met Mara, they had become fast friends. Catra hadn't noticed it when they were younger, but Adora had exuded quite a bit of animosity towards Mara when she was the subject of attention. Whatever their issues were with one another, it was for them to work out and Catra had made that painfully apparent to them when they were sixteen. And she also wanted to see Light Hope again.

"Okay, add Mara and Light Hope to the list." Catra said before gaining a considerate look, "Actually, I'll just call her myself."

Randor smiled. "Alright. Anyone else?"

Catra looked at her hand, thinking to herself. "For now? No. Perhaps I'll think of a few others but at the current moment, that's all."

"Fair enough. Do let someone know if you think of anyone else." Randor said as he turned to leave. "That will be all for today, Catra. Feel free to go find Adora." He said with a smile.

Catra grinned before warping away. Evelyn smiled, "Has she picked a maid of honor yet?"

Marleena shook her head, casting a look at Evelyn, "No. But I'm fairly certain who she wants to ask."

Evelyn let out a sigh, "I doubt she'd ask anyone else. Well, maybe Lonnie, but Adora's already asked her. Not only that, Catra has several things that she hasn't addressed. There's also the topic of her mother."

Marleena let out a sigh, "She was like a sister to me. It's hard to believe it's been five years."

Evelyn looked down at the ground, "I know." She said quietly.

A moment of silence passed before Marleena looked at her friend, "Have you even spoken to Mara about the wedding?"

"No." She shook her head, "Mara's made no calls and the last time we spoke at all was almost three years ago. Sure, Lorric and I get messages but nothing since she left." Evelyn sighed, "No, she's too busy growing up, exploring distant worlds, falling in love." Suddenly, a smile blossomed, "But I'll bet she shows up for Catra."

Marleena raised a brow, a semi scowl on her face. "Careful, Evelyn. Catra and Adora have moved past that and I'm willing to bet that Mara has as well. No need to resort to such tactics. I'm sure asking her will be enough."

Evelyn let out a laugh. "I wouldn't dare. I'm just saying. If Adora hadn't made her move when she had, we might be looking at a very different wedding."

Marleena snorted, "You're not wrong." her humor faded after a moment. "Do you still have the shard?"

Evelyn nodded, "Yes. Don't worry. I've made the preparations."

Marleena nodded, letting out a defeated sigh, "I just hope Catra won't hold it against us."

Evelyn put a comforting hand on her friend's shoulder, "She won't. When Catra sees it, she'll understand why we kept it from her."

It was early morning when the best friends squad returned to Bright Moon castle.

"Woah woah woah! Glimmer, you can't just march into Eternos." Mara said as she stepped in front of her. "Especially not now of all times."

Glimmer threw her hands in disbelief. "You saw my memories, Mara. We watched Razz disappear and I'm the only one who can remember Shadow Weaver. I have to stop her!" Glimmer said before looking Mara in the eye, "And what's 'now of all times' mean?"

Mara looked at Bow and Light Hope. Bow looked at Glimmer, "Space travel is being heavily regulated and monitored because of the coronation of Princesses Adora and Catra. Just getting to Eternia at the moment is nigh impossible."

Glimmer looked at Bow in confusion. "Catra and Adora are being coronated? Why? Did Marleena and Randor die?"

Light Hope drew Glimmer's attention, "They're getting married, Glimmer. The royal wedding marks the next rulers of Eternia and by extension the Empire. It is a big event that holds significant importance, especially with the involvement of Earth. Hundreds of planets from all across the universe will be attending. We can't afford to just rush in without a plan."

Glimmer blinked, "Okay. . . Well when is it? Can't we just sneak off and talk to Adora before everything starts going down?"

Mara shook her head, "No. It's in three weeks but it's invite only. Only select planets will be allowed to attend and Etheria wasn't one of them and any chance of receiving an invite so late is nonexistent. There's just too little space to host such an event with thousands of guests."

"But you said you know Catra and Adora right? Plus, your mom's the Eternian high mage. Can't you get us in?" Glimmer asked.

Light Hope let out a snort, grabbing Glimmer's attention, "Evelyn isn't the high mage anymore. As of two years ago that position was awarded to her apprentice, Teela. So, unless you can teleport us millions of light years, we're stuck here."

Glimmer let out a groan, pacing her room, "There has to be something we can do!"

A knock at the door sounded before opening, revealing Angella. "Glimmer, are you alright? Your father said you looked upset when you passed him. She looked at the sullen state of the group of friends. "What's wrong?"

Bow, thinking fast, rattled off an excuse, "We were just talking about Mara's home planet and how different it is from Etheria. Glimmer asked if we could go but because of the coronation. . ." he trailed off.

"Ah, yes. I suppose that would put a damper on plans. But speaking of Eternia, Mara," Angella turned towards the woman holding a thin glowing light pane, "You've received a call. General Hordak has asked me to deliver it to you. It's from Eternia."

Everyone in the room looked at Mara before leaning towards her. Mara took the glowing item before tapping the screen. All of a sudden, a hologram of Catra appeared. "Hey Mara."

"Catra?" Mara answered in surprise before walking a few feet from the group. "What, uh, what's up? How've you been?"

Glimmer didn't miss the slight annoyance on Light Hope's face. Looking back at Mara, she focused on the conversation, trying to get a better look at her time-abled friend. "I've been good. Why haven't you called? I haven't seen you since you decided to leave Eternia. What have you been up to?"

"Oh, ya know. . . just hanging out." Mara said awkwardly.

Light Hope cleared her throat, putting her hands out. 'Get to the point.'

Catra nodded, "Well, um. . . I'm calling because I wanted to talk to you and It's kind of important." Catra said, her voice sounding a bit vulnerable.

Mara's tone switched to a more serious one, "Okay? I'm listening."

"I wanted to know if," Catra let out a nervous breath, "if you'll be my maid of honor. Obviously, Hope is invited too."

Everyone's eyes widened in surprise. Catra waited for a moment before Mara looked at Glimmer out of the corner of her eyes. "Catra, you know I would be there if I could," Catra looked a little downtrodden at Mara's words, "But I can't get there. Etheria's quadrant is completely locked down. I couldn't make it out of the system if I tried."

Catra was quiet for a moment. "So, if the system's route was to be cleared. . . you could make it?"

". . .Yes?" Mara said questioningly.

Catra nodded, "One moment. I'll call you right back."

As the line went dead, Mara looked around the room. Light Hope still looked shocked before she sat down in one of the chairs. Suddenly, the sound of running could be heard from outside the door. "Angie! Glimmer!"

Immediately, the door was flung open by King Micah with Hordak behind him. Angella looked at them worriedly, "What is it! Are you okay?"

"I'm fine. We just received a message!" Micah exclaimed in excitement before Hordak held his trackerpad up.

"Queen Angella, Etheria has just received an official invite from Eternos to attend the Princess' wedding and coronation. And we're priority transit! Do you know what this means?"

All of a sudden Catra's image appeared once again. "Hey, you there?"

Mara was still looking at Micah before refocusing her gaze on Catra. "Did you just–"

"So, will you accept? Even if you're not comfortable with the request, I'd still like for you and Hope to attend. Adora would love to see you and so would your parents. So?" Catra asked.

Glimmer grabbed the pane out of her hands before looking at Catra, "She accepts! She totally accepts!"

Catra caught sight of Light Hope nodding with a smile before she nodded in kind. "Alright then. I'll send a ship out to Etheria with an envoy to make the necessary arrangements. They'll be there at around sunset for Etheria. Of course they'll also have to speak to the Princesses and Queen Angella. Appearance is important after all." Catra said before bidding Mara goodbye.

Immediately Micah turned and left the room, "Oy my gosh! We have so much we need to do!"

Angella turned towards Glimmer. "Glimmer, I need you to contact your friends. They need to be informed and be here by the end of the day. We can't afford to mess up in front of Eternia." Angella turned and left the room, letting out a small groan, "This is so troublesome."

Glimmer watched her parents leave before looking at Mara. "How exactly are we going to get to all of the other kingdoms in twelve hours? I can't teleport that far!"

Mara waved Glimmer off, "We'll take my ship. It'll only take a few minutes to fly across the planet."

Glimmer slowly nodded, "Alright. Oh! Maybe someone else remembers too."

Bow shook his head, "I seriously doubt that Glimmer. Didn't Razz say that you only remember because of She Ra's magic?"

Glimmer's face fell a bit at that. "I suppose? But if Adora can remember, maybe everyone else could as well?"

Light Hope stood up, swiping her hand across a holographic screen. "We can focus on that later. For now, we need to get going. We need to catalog which Princesses are attending and there are quite a lot of them."

"Right. Let's get going then." Bow said.

As they walked towards Bright Moon's doors to leave, they were stopped by Hordak. "Princess Glimmer, could I ask a favor of you?"

"Uh, sure? What do you need?" Glimmer responded, a bit unsure.

"My wife, Entrapta. I know that she has a tendency to overlook social cues as well as neglect certain duties as a ruler when it comes to her own interests. I know you've never met her but if you could ask her to return with you to the castle on your way back, I'd be grateful."

Glimmer was a bit surprised that she hadn't met Entrapta in this timeline. Sure they weren't the closest of friends but she would have hoped that they would at least have met before this moment. "Of course. You can count on me."

"Excellent. It's been a couple of days since I've returned to Dryll and with the sudden invitation to the coronation I hardly have time to do much at all at the current moment." Hordak said with a hint of irritation.

Bow put a reaffirming hand on Hordak's shoulder, "Don't worry, Hordak. We've got this. We'll convince her to come back."

Hordak gave a nod before leaving them to it. As they left the castle, Glimmer looked up at the ship that was descending from the sky in awe. She looked to the left to see Light Hope smiling at her. "What?"

"You've never taken an interest in our technology before. It's refreshing to see." Hope signed.

Glimmer shrugged, "My Etheria isn't quite as advanced as this one. Only the Horde had technology like this and I couldn't really afford to stop and stare at those."

As the ship landed, a flash of red caught Glimmer's eye. As she turned to look, she realized that she was looking at the Phoenix Anvil. Glimmer walked towards the shop before stopping at the window. There, hanging on display, was the staff that Catra had gotten as a gift for Adora.

"You okay?" Mara asked, walking up beside Glimmer.

Glimmer nodded, "That's Adora's staff. Catra got it for her as a gift the night they confessed to each other."

"Are you sure?" Bow asked, coming up beside her.

Glimmer nodded, "If you twist it, blades come out of the ends." she said as she started to walk to the entrance of the shop.

"What are you doing?" Bow asked.

"I'm gonna buy it. Maybe it'll help jog Adora's memory." Glimmer said as she entered the store.

"Adora, are you awake?" Marleena whispered, giving her a gentle shake.

Adora slowly opened her eyes with a yawn, "Mom? What time is it?"

"It's a few hours before sunrise. Your father and I wished to speak with you privately but we didn't want to cut into your alone time with Catra." Marleena whispered. "I'll give you a moment to get dressed."

Adora groggily nodded before turning to Catra, who had started to stir and layed a kiss on her cheek. "Hey, I'll be back in a bit."

Catra nodded before rolling over and falling back asleep. Adora quickly threw a robe on, following her mother. As they reached her father's study, she took a seat on one of the chairs, resting her head on her hand.

"Good, you're here." Randor nodded.

"What did you guys want to talk about?" Adora asked, becoming more awake by the second.

Marleena let out a breath, "Well, it's rather important. It has to do with Catra and. . . her mother."

Adora sat up, wide awake as she focused on her parents' words. "Okay, I'm listening. What about her?"

Randor sat forward as he let out a breath. "When you and Catra were born, we were privy to some knowledge that has more or less faded. We don't know what it consisted of but we know that it happened all the same."

"What happened?" Adora asked.

"At some point, a temporal branch opened for you and Catra and then closed." Randor said, pressing forward. "We don't know what it consisted of but we felt that you should be aware of it."

"What do you mean? Like a separate timeline?" Adora asked.

Marleena nodded, "Exactly like a separate timeline. The Temporal Obelisk showed signs of recent repairs and the remnants of a time loop at the time of Catra's birth. We haven't told Catra yet but we will soon."

"Okay? You said it closed, right? So why tell me?" Adora asked, confused.

"C'yra had initially been the one who was going to explain this to you but. . ." Marleena let out a solemn breath. "Well, since she's no longer with us, we felt that it was our responsibility."

"What we're trying to say is that Catra's powers were responsible for the timeline shift. And that there's a high probability that you may start remembering things that don't quite make sense. Catra will also probably experience this." Randor explained.

"Is. . . this harmful? Will Catra be okay?" Adora asked with concern.

Marleena nodded, "C'yra explained it to us. It's not harmful and besides a little confusion, it won't affect either of you in any negative way. We just want you to be prepared."

"Oh." Adora sat back in relief before looking at her parents. "Will you guys remember anything?"

Marleena shook her head, "Whatever happened is lost to us. Only the holder of She Ra and someone of Catra's heritage will be able to call upon those events."

Adora slowly nodded before standing, a smile on her face. "Alright then. As long as Catra and I aren't at any risk then I don't see any problem."

Randor nodded at his daughter. "That's all we wanted to talk to you about."

"I'll let Catra know about it." Adora said as she started to head back to her quarters.

"Are you sure?" Marleena asked.

Adora nodded, "Yeah, it's fine. Bye mom, bye dad." she said as she left the room.

Marleena let out a breath, "Well, that went well."

Randor nodded, "It wasn't Adora I was worried about."

Marleena was quiet for a few moments before speaking, "Is Catra doing alright?"

"It's been five years since her mother died. I know she acts like she's moved on, but I know it's still fresh. Especially with her wedding only three weeks away." Randor replied quietly.

Marleena rubbed her eyes before letting out a groan. "There's so much going on right now!"

Randor let out a small laugh, "I know. But that's life."

"If you had told my sixteen year old self that at forty eight years old I'd have traveled across space and discovered worlds with magic and dragons and that I'd become a queen, well. . . I'd probably have called you mad."

Randor laughed louder this time. "I suppose that does sound strange to you doesn't it?"

"On the topic of other worlds, Catra really needs to let us know when she decides to do what she did yesterday."

"Oh? What happened." Randor asked.

"She was able to track down Mara's location, found out she was on Etheria, and then proceeded to put Etheria on the priority transit list without letting anyone know!" She said, throwing her arms in the air, exasperated.

"Well, did she do it correctly?" Randor asked.

Marleena sighed, "Technically, yes."

"Then all is fine. It means she's paying attention to her lessons." Randor smiled. "But by chance, who did she send as an ambassador?"

"Hey Mara!" Swift Wind said exuberantly.

"It's a talking horse!" Bow said in shock.

Angella strode forward with several documents in hand. "Bow, please be respectful. This is the ambassador from Eternia. He is also the royal steed of Princess Adora. He is here to make sure we have everything in order. His name is–"

"Swift Wind!" Glimmer said in shock.

"Uh, yes. That is his name." Angella said, raising an eyebrow before waving it off. "Please stay here with him, Glimmer. I'm not trying to be rude, I just have a few things I still need to take care of."

As Angella strode off, Swift Wind turned towards the four friends. "Mara, Light Hope, always good to see you guys. Bow, Glimmer, always nice to see you, er, meet you." he corrected himself.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at Swift Wind. "Wait, do you remember what happened at the palace with the Obelisk and the Horde?"

"Wait, you remember?" Swift Wind asked in confusion.

"Oh thank goodness!" Glimmer cried before giving him a hug. "We need your help."

"Wait, does Bow remember? How do you remember?" Swift Wind asked.

"No, only me. Razz said that I could remember because I still had a bunch of She Ra's magic in me. But that's besides the point. Razz disappeared and we need to stop Shadow Weaver. She's the only other person who still had She Ra's magic besides me."

"Woah! Back it up there. Adora doesn't remember what happened and neither does anyone else for that matter. As for Shadow Weaver, are you sure it's her? Because I've met Shadow Weaver and she's almost completely changed. Her appearance, her demeanor, everything." Swift Wind explained.

Mara nodded, "We watched Razz fade out of existence. If She Ra's magic is the only thing that allows you to retain your memories, then it stands to reason that Shadow Weaver is behind it. Besides you, Glimmer is the only other person to remember."

Swift Wind nodded, "Alright. But what exactly do you think we should do about it? We're kind of in the middle of something extremely important. We can't just walk up to Adora and Catra. Well, I could, but that's besides the point. They don't know you guys anymore."

Bow spoke up. "Razz said that She Ra's magic let Glimmer remember. She also said that Adora could be made to remember. Knowing that, could we theoretically flood our bodies with the magic of She Ra to let us remember?"

Light Hope raised her arm, displaying a holographic display of a person's neurological pathways. "Normally, I'd say no because that's not how brain chemistry works. But this is Glimmer's neurological sequence from two days ago." She waved her hand, showing another sequence with her neurons being flooded with golden light, "This is her brain now. It's like her body is using She Ra's magic to repair neurological damage similar to one might see in an amnesic individual. "If She Ra's magic is doing this without any type of catalyst, then who's to say that it couldn't work on another individual."

Mara nodded before looking at Swift Wind, "Could you output enough magic to affect us in a similar manner?"

Swift Wind nodded, "Oh, easily! But the problem lies in the magic itself. It didn't just fall on you Glimmer. Shadow Weaver literally siphoned it out of Mara and into you. If we were to attempt this, we'd need someone capable of the same thing."

Glimmer thought about the spell. She had been there when Shadow Weaver had taught Catra the restore and drain spell. She was positive she could recreate it. "I think I can do it. I was there when Shadow Weaver taught Catra the spell."

"You're sure? Because we don't want to mess this up." Mara asked.

Glimmer nodded. "I'm sure."

Swift Wind raised a brow before shrugging. "Hey, I trust you. Go for it."

Glimmer stepped forward and laid her hand on Swift Wind's side. As she closed her eyes, she focused on Shadow Weaver's words.

Focus on the feeling of the magic beneath the stone's surface, the flow of magic that permeates the very being of it. It's right in front of you ripe for the taking. It's yours. The intent must be there, if you cannot exert your will over it then it will not obey you. Bend it to your will and subjugate it.

As Bow, Mara, and Light Hope watched Glimmer's hand light up with its usual pink magic, their expressions turned to shock when her bright magic started to dim before becoming a dark inky black. Glimmer's normally pink eyes slowly shifted to a low red glow and her wings slowly shifted from their brilliant light to a darker, more shadowy appearance. After a moment she lowered her hand. Swift wind ruffled his wings a bit but seemed unfazed for the most part.

"Did it work?" Swift Wind asked. "I thought I felt a bit of a drain there for a second."

Glimmer nodded, "It worked. I have quite a bit of magic." She turned towards Mara, "You were She Ra in the other timeline. Will this affect you differently?"

Mara shook her head, "I hold the power of Hi Ro. According to King Randor, She Ra's and Hi Ro's power is so closely linked that there should be no power differences."

Glimmer nodded, "Alright. Let's do this then. Give me your hand."

As Mara held out her hand to Glimmer, Bow and Light Hope looked at one another. "Hope, what are the chances of this working?"

Light Hope shrugged, "In all honesty? Zero. This shouldn't work at all. But Glimmer has memories of an alternate timeline and that's completely out of my field of expertise, so who's to say."

As Mara felt some magic siphon into her, the door to Glimmer's room opened as Angella strode in before stopping in shock, "What is the meaning of this!"

Everyone turned to look at Angella in surprise before Mara stumbled back, dropping to a knee. Light Hope quickly rushed over to help her. Suddenly, Micah came running in, "What happened! What is it?"

He stopped when he saw Glimmer's eyes. Her eyes were still red but her magic had shifted back to its normal pink glow. His focus shifted to Mara kneeling down, catching her breath. He had a look of surprise before it quickly morphed into anger. "Who taught you this spell?"

Mara slowly stood up before looking at Glimmer, the brief chaos of the moment halted as they all turned to look at Mara. She let out a breath before turning towards Swift Wind, "I remember."

"You do? All of it?" Bow asked.

She nodded, "All of it. Ugh," She groaned in pain, "That sucked. It's like I just woke up."

"Enough!" Angella commanded, "Explain yourselves, now!"

Glimmer stepped forward. "I. . . Okay, this is going to sound crazy but bear with me." and started to explain the last few days and what had transpired.

They initially looked at their daughter like she had lost it, but with Mara and Swift Wind all collaborating on the story, they were

willing to hear her out. After a few minutes, Agella sat down before looking at Micah. "Is. . .is that possible?"

Micah looked from his wife to his daughter, "I was never taught by a woman named Shadow Weaver. I was taught by a woman named Beatrix, and she currently resides in Eternos."

Swift Wind nodded, "Yep. That's Shadow Weaver. Or rather, the new version of her. Grey skinned woman, sharp pointed ears, extremely good at dark magic, and a questionable fashion sense."

"And you're saying that you remember?" Angella asked Mara. "How does that work?"

"It's complicated. To keep it simple, She Ra's magic." Mara answered.

Angella let out a groan, "Can't you just be rebellious like a normal teenager? Sneak some alcohol or something and not deal with time travel?"

Glimmer let out a small laugh, "I'd say this is actually pretty tame compared to some of the stuff I've had to deal with in the war."

"War!" Angella exclaimed in shock, "What war?"

Bow sucked in a breath. "Well, you see. Glimmer's timeline that she remembers is a little different from ours."

Micah watched Glimmer's eyes slowly fade back to pink before he strode forward. "If Swift Wind's magic is to be transferred into us, will we all remember?"

"It does seem to be that way, yeah." Swift Wind confirmed.

Micah nodded, "Glimmer. I don't want you practicing umbrakinesis without me being there, okay? It's not like other magics. It's dangerous. Now," he let out a breath, "I'll siphon some magic and cast an aura field. That way, we only have to do it once."

"Wait." Glimmer said. "We should get the rest of the princess alliance as well. We'll need their help."

Micah slowly nodded, "Let's make a quick list. We don't want to miss anyone who was involved."

Glimmer looked at her dad before suddenly hugging him, her eyes tearing up a bit. Micah looked a little surprised before hugging her back. "What brought this on?"

Glimmer wiped her eyes as she let go, stepping back. "I'll explain later. For now, we need Frosta, Mermista, Sea Hawk, Perfuma, Entrapta, Spinnerella, Netossa, Scorpia, Castaspella and Juliet."

"Was General Hordak not a part of the alliance?" Micah asked.

Glimmer let out a breath as she shifted a bit. Her silence spoke volumes.

"I take it you don't get along with him in the other timeline?" Micah asked.

Swift Wind let out a bellowing laugh. "That's hilarious. No, I suppose you could say that. Regardless, we need all the help we can get."

Glimmer let out a sigh, "Alright. If that's everyone, let's do this."

"What about Princess Sulphira?" Angella asked.

"Who?" Glimmer asked.

"The Princess of the Kingdom of Ashfell? She resides on Mount Candila. Why don't you remember this?" Angella asked in concern.

Light Hope offered up an explanation. "Due to how Glimmer's memories are perceiving the separate timelines, her cerebral cortex has created a separate branch for the memories, causing an amnesic effect on her memories pertaining to this timeline. It's

only temporary and should fade within a couple of days. It's not harmful."

"Oh, okay." Angella breathed a sigh of relief.

"Mount Candila is still there? In our timeline, that Kingdom is a desolate wasteland and the Spirit Ember was corrupted after the Princess had died. But that was hundreds of years ago. We didn't even have her name on record." Glimmer answered.

"Well, her name is Sulphira." Angella provided, "I think we should include her as well. She's always been very helpful and this time should be no different."

Glimmer nodded, "Okay. Let's gather everyone. We're gonna need to discuss a plan."

Beatrix stood before Catra and Teela. "Catra, I am pleased to see you here today, although I'm surprised that the High Mage herself is here. To what do I owe the pleasure? I highly doubt there is anything I can teach you Teela."

Teela smiled. "For today, I'm simply shadowing Catra with Andra and the Royal Guard. With the wedding only nineteen days away, there are a lot of officials and representatives as well as thousands of guests in Eternos. We can't afford to let our guard down. Just ignore me for the time being."

Beatrix nodded, "Very well. Come, Catra. We have a bit to catch up on and not a lot of time."

Catra nodded and followed the woman. As they strode towards the sanctum, Catra turned towards the woman. "Congratulations are in order. I've heard that you are the first mage to receive both titles regarding the mastery of Light and Dark magic."

Beatrix let a proud smile wash over her face. "You have heard correctly. Thank you for noticing. It wasn't easy mind you. But I knew that I would be the first."

Catra raised a brow, "Really?"

She nodded, "I wasn't born to power like Adora or Teela or even Mara. I had to fight for it everyday growing up. It was never easy and I'm glad to see that you value my opinion on such things." She opened the door to the large building with a wave of her hand, "I've told you it before in passing, but the time magic you wield has actually disadvantaged your learning curve. While your potential is quite high, your abilities hinder your progression. I am impressed with your drive in learning the mystic arts. Now if only Adora would heed my advice more often. But alas, you can't please everyone."

Catra shrugged, "That's life."

"Indeed," Beatrix chuckled. "But, if you feel the need to start addressing me by my new title, I will not stop you."

Catra let out a good natured laugh at the woman's attempt to get her to address her, "Alright. What shall we start with. . . Shadow Weaver."

She grinned, "We've toyed with the esoteric texts enough that you have grasped magic in its most pure form. Now, we will begin your true teachings."

As she walked forward, Shadow Weaver drew a magic circle around them before activating it with a bright glow. A moment later, they found themselves in the middle of a mountainous landscape with floating rocks, a clear blue river as well as lush grassland. Catra recognized it as the Mystic Mountains of Eternia.

"The power inside you, it comes from the ley lines. All magic in this universe does. And those of us lucky or skilled enough to capture it, can make it do almost anything." She explained.

Catra looked at the woman. "The whole universe has these? Why doesn't Earth?"

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Earth did have magic at one point. But the ley line that was utilized there grew weaker over the millennium as Earth grew until eventually it all faded from their world. Magic is the lifeblood of the universe. As it enters this realm, it bleeds down into the worlds providing life like a well. But if you're too far from it or aren't careful, that well can run dry."

"Wait, back it up. This realm?" Catra asked.

"That's right. There is another realm above this one, The Nexus. It is the focal point of all realms and is the source of all magic. It is where magic starts, where the ley lines originate from and pour out of. Look at that one there." Shadow Weaver said as she raised her hand. Instantly, what seemed like a floating river of energy appeared in the air.

Catra focused on it as she was told and ever so slowly, more ley lines started appearing in her vision. "Woah, they-they're everywhere."

"Indeed. They span all of Eternia like a web, bathing it in magic. That is why Eternia controls the universe. Politics, lands, ideologies - All of that is secondary to the control and management of magic."

Catra thought about those words and about the children's stories she'd heard from her mother as a little girl about epic magic battles in amazing wars. "When I was a child, my mother used to read me stories detailing great battles between mages. Are those based on true stories?"

"Yes and no. From the very beginning, Eternia has held the highest position of magic in the universe. We've never really been in a war that we couldn't handle. But other planets with little to no structure that were allowed to run rampant. . . those are what your stories are based on. Make no mistake Catra. All magic is dangerous, even the most tiny spell can kill someone if you try hard enough. That is why it is imperative that we manage magic and remain in control. Randor has explained that keeping the

peace is imperative. While correct, it is also imperative to understand that no amount of technology will overpower a skilled mage. Especially an internal sourced one such as yourself."

Catra nodded, thinking about the advice she was hearing. Catra looked at Teela behind her. To her surprise, she gave a nod of agreement. Turning back to her lesson, she focused her attention on the stone platform in front of her. She recognized it as an arena.

"Your connection to the Obelisk will help you focus your magic. Keep it level and accurate, as well as preventing it from killing you. Your connection marks you as a magical conductor." Shadow Weaver explained.

Catra called forth some magic onto her hand before looking back at Shadow Weaver, "A Chosen."

"Yes, a Chosen." Shadow Weaver said as they started walking. "When we first met, you weren't entirely void of magic. Innately, you knew how to defend yourself with it. Utilize it in different ways."

"If you mean teleporting a couple of miles and rewinding a couple minutes then sure. I could do some magic."

"We all start somewhere."

As Teela watched the duo over the next couple of hours, Catra learned several spells ranging from multiple fire spells, to extremely intricate shields, she received a call. As she tapped her wrist, she walked away from Catra and Beatrix. "Teela, are you there?"

"Go for Teela." She responded, recognizing Adora's voice.

"Is Catra there? She didn't answer."

Teela slid her finger across her wrist, pulling up a holographic image of Adora. She angled her wrist to display Catra in the midst

of learning to conjure a stone wall. Adora let out a huff. "Could you tell her that my father wishes to speak with her. He says it's quite important."

"Understood." Teela said as she ended the call. Striding forward, she waved her hand, sending out a small ball of light beside the women. It worked as they paused what they were doing to look at her.

"The King wishes to speak with you. He says it's rather important." Teela explained.

Shadow Weaver nodded before giving some homework for Catra to work on. As they returned to stand by Teela, the shadow sorceress teleported them back into Eternos. Catra thanked the woman before falling into stride with Teela. As soon as they started to move, Andra appeared with the Royal Guard, falling into formation around Catra.

"That sucked." Mermista let out a groan.

"Indeed. Was there no other way to restore our memories?" Sea Hawk asked.

"I'm afraid not." Mara said apologetically as she looked at the group all holding their heads in pain.

Angella shook her head before immediately enveloping Micah in a hug. "You're–"

"I know. It's okay." Micah said softly before they looked at Glimmer.

Angella wiped her eyes before looking at Mara. As she went to speak, a low growl of irritation cut her off.

"I'd rather not have remembered at all." Hordak snarled.

"It. . . is a bit startling." Entrapta said as she took Hordak's hand.

"Will this affect us in any way?" Perfuma asked with concern.

Light Hope looked around at everyone, "I can't remember anything. Why?"

As the room devolved into inaudible questions, Glimmer tried to answer unsuccessfully multiple times before she finally had enough. Teleporting in front of the group, her wings spread out before she got everyone's attention. "Guys, focus! We need to do something!"

Spinnerella stepped forward, "Glimmer, you can't expect us to not have questions. This is a lot to process in a short amount of time."

"We get that, we really do. But we're running out of time. Whatever happened to Razz could happen at any moment to one of us. So we need to have a plan on how we can confront this." Mara said.

Hordak let out a breath of exasperation before turning towards Angella and Micah before looking at everyone else, "Does this affect our standing in any way? As far as I'm concerned, that person is not me. I did not make those decisions."

"Hordak's right. . . Wow, that sounds strange coming out of my mouth." Juliet said. "These memories, they're. . . well, they aren't us. Not really. I still think we should do something but we shouldn't let these memories taint our images of one another."

"My demeanor has not changed at all. In fact, I can see myself acting the exact same way in most of these choices." Sea Hawk said.

"Same. I'm still me." Mermista added.

"It seems to me," Sulphira spoke up from the back, "that our core personality traits have remained. But the circumstances of our lives from everything to our births have been altered. According to my new memories, I have never met a single one of you. In fact, my life was one of regret and solitude. On that note, General

Juliet and General Hordak are right. These were not us but different versions of us. Alternate lives that we lived."

Entrapta looked at the others before nodding in agreement. "While this is fascinating, the science supports Hordak. We have the proof of a regressive timeline on a universal scale."

Frosta shook her head, speaking up for the first time. "No. I'm still me. I made those decisions and led my people when my parents died. Catra gave me them back and I won't sit on the sidelines while someone tries to undo everything we worked so hard for. Just because I'm a few years older doesn't mean I'm still not a part of the Princess Alliance."

"I concur." Sea Hawk said, "Catra has been a brave ally and a kind friend. She saved all of us. If there is truly a threat to her and Adora, then I too will assist."

Spinnerella and Netossa stepped forward, "The way I see it," Netossa said, "we're finishing off the Horde for good."

Perfuma stepped forward, "Adora and Catra need us. They were there when we needed help and we should be there for them."

Glimmer smiled as she looked at her friends before looking at Scorpia. "Scorpia? You've been quiet until this moment. What do you have to say about all of this?"

Scorpia let out a chuckle, "Like you even have to ask. Of course we're gonna go save them. Catra is our friend and we don't leave friends behind." She said with a triumphant smile before it faded to confusion, "But, uh, where's Kyle, Lonnie, and Rojelio? They're definitely not in my Kingdom."

Mara spoke up, "They're on Eternia. They're a part of the guards in Eternos."

"Ah, okay." Scorpia nodded.

Castaspella looked at Micah before smiling. "I've never been a big fan of violence but Catra did risk it all and she brought you back. Plus, it's a chance to ruin Shadow Weaver's day. Count me in."

Light Hope looked at Mara, "I might not remember our previous experiences but I'm with you no matter what."

Glimmer looked at Bow before he smiled, "Do you even have to ask?"

Angella looked at Hordak, Entrapta, and Sulphira. "Will you help us? We'd all understand if you chose not to."

Hordak took a deep breath before exhaling, "I will help in any way I can but I'd rather distance myself from any memory of Horde Prime if I can help it."

Entrapta was looking at her tracker pad, writing something down before she realized that the room's focus was on her. "Huh? Oh, sure. Besides, Catra promised me we'd talk about time travel."

All that remained was Sulphira. "As it stands, I have the least connection with these two women. Even in this lifetime, I have never met Princess Adora or Catra and if it were not for Mara's invitation, I feel that I would not have had the opportunity. And while I am grateful to Catra for a second chance at life and you two are my closest friends," She said looking at Angella and Micah, "I can't. I'm. . .just not comfortable with this. I'm sorry."

Micah put a reassuring hand on her shoulder, "That's okay Sulphira. No one will hold this against you."

"If that is all, I will be returning home to Mount Cadila. Goodbye." And with that, Sulphira left the room.

As they all gathered, they turned towards Mara, Light Hope, Swift Wind, Glimmer, and Bow. Swift Wind stepped forward. "We have about nineteen days until the wedding and we have to leave for Eternia in fourteen days. Make sure everyone is well stocked with what they'll need. Due to the tight timetable and the late

invitation we won't be able to turn around. You won't just be able to stroll up to Adora and Catra either. This will require planning."

"We'll also need to avoid Shadow Weaver until we're ready. She won't be expecting us to know about the alternate timeline. We have the element of surprise and we can't afford to waste it." Glimmer said.

A chorus of yes' and affirmations responded.

Shadow Weaver stood silently, unmoving as she looked at the large mass of tendrils hovering in the air. The absolute display of power that sat before her, humming with energy as the ley lines flowed into it. She had never seen anything like it in her life. She watched in pure glee as the pulsing of the Nexus fed life into the abomination. It was beautiful.

As she turned to walk away from her creation, she caught sight of herself in a reflection from one of the ley lines. She looked awful, her face was scarred and was altered. Her skin seemed to be barely hanging on and she looked half dead. Indeed, her body would not have survived had she not augmented herself with whatever technology he could procure from the First Ones. Such a trivial and inconsequential race. Outdated and past their expiration. But it was of no matter to him. He had beaten them once before and could do it again. Once the bomb was complete, and the Nexus destabilized, there would at last be peace. And all of the universe would bathe in Horde Prime's light.

I know I said that this would be the last chapter but I honestly didn't realize how much I still needed to write. So consider this part 1 of the last chapter and the second part will be finished soon. Enjoy and let me know what you think.

Chapter 16

Five days until the wedding. . .

Glimmer marveled in awe at the interior of the massive ship she was currently sitting in. It was larger than Brightmoon and was currently holding most of the Kingdoms of Etheria as well as multiple colonies that had joined. Even with this timeline's memories, she had never seen anything like it.

Glimmer turned towards Mara as she let out a chuckle. "Impressive, isn't it? I remember my first time on a Leviathan."

"This place is massive! You could literally get lost on this thing!" Glimmer exclaimed.

She wasn't the only one shocked by the size. Most of the princesses were also marveling at the ship as well. Hordak and Entrapta both looked enamored by the technological marvel.

Light Hope smiled before pointing at the large windows. A jewel on her wrist lit up before the robotic voice that Glimmer was so accustomed to rang out, "We're well on our way to Eternia by now. Typically these ships aren't used outside of these types of events due to other planetary sizes. Eternia is a hotspot for magic which is what allowed it to become so big."

"What do you mean?" Bow asked, walking up.

Light Hope pulled up a holographic display of Etheria, "This is the planet that we know as Etheria. It's of average size for an exoplanet and not too much bigger than Earth. This," she waved her hand, causing another planet to appear that was about fifteen times the size of Etheria, "is Eternia. By Earth's standards, a planet without magic until very recently, such a place could not function under this type of gravity. But due to the ley lines that weave throughout the universe, it reshapes physics on a very

large scale, allowing for exoplanets such as Eternia to exist. Eternia itself is host to hundreds of billions of people."

"Fascinating!" Entrapta said as she looked at the stars that were passing by. "I've never had the opportunity to discuss extraplanetary physics before."

"Well we'll have plenty of time to discuss the science of everything later. For now we should get settled. It'll be about six hours until we reach Eternia." Mara said as she started towards a large corridor.

"Does it truly take such a short amount of time to approach Eternia?" Hordak asked. "I was under the impression that Eternia's ships were much slower."

"Normally you'd be correct. However, due to this being a transit ship and also us being a priority, we have a straight shot to Eternia." Mara explained. "In reality, we could be there within the hour if we really needed to be. But it's. . ."

"Risky." Light Hope offered, "And incredibly dangerous without proper training."

Glimmer looked at Hordak, "Wait. I thought you were Keldor's brother in this time? Wouldn't you know about Eternia's technology?"

Hordak's demeanor changed ever so slightly, "I am familiar with certain things, yes, but my mother left Eternia when King Randor's father adopted Keldor. She made her way towards Etheria with me when I was very young. Besides the first six years of my life, I've never left Etheria's star systems."

"That's enough chatter for now." Micah said. "We need to figure out how we're going to approach Catra and Adora before we get there."

October 16, 2234

Earth

Thomas Lawrence sat in what could be called a summit for the world leaders. The world leaders had elected, in the face of societal collapse, to unite whatever major governments remained. Unfortunately that was only about six representatives. If anything it was more of a council. And while Earth's ecosystem had been repaired but that didn't account for the massive amount of life.

"The operation has begun." Mira said. "Where are the others?"

Councilwoman Mira Evans. She was what passed as the leader of the Americas. She was a strong woman and was doing her best in the face of such trying times. Thomas held her in quite a high regard.

"They couldn't make it. They've recently run into some problems regarding the integration of Eternian technology in some of the more. . . savage lands." One of the men behind her answered, handing her a document.

"Don't you think that this is going a bit too smoothly?" Ano asked.

Ano Yamada was the councilman representing Japan, one of the few governments that barely held on.

"We can't waste this opportunity. We've waited almost twenty years for this chance and we can't afford to squander it." Erwin said in a slightly harsh tone.

Erwin Beckette was an older man and was the councilman representing the whole of Europe.

Thomas let out a sigh as he listened to them discuss the next move. He, himself, was in charge of the interstellar programs as well as any colonization that may move off of Earth. He was also to be the representative for Earth within five days.

"Humanity's closest thing to an active envoy is in a relationship with Evelyn Morgan's daughter. She has all but guaranteed that

we will have an active chance to speak with the new queens of the Empire. And while we need to cement ourselves as a trusted system, all I'm saying is that we shouldn't rush such things." Ano replied.

"That's Light Hope, correct?" Mira asked.

"Yes. She–" Ano went to continue before being cut off.

"We're entrusting our matters of diplomatic talks to her? She didn't even grow up on Earth. She's all but a stranger to her kind." Erwin scoffed.

Ano gained an irritated look. "But Evelyn and Marleena did." He said through gritted teeth. "And they haven't forgotten us just because they married Eternians. Which, may I remind you, has resulted in some very important events. Events which we are currently discussing."

Erwin closed his mouth in annoyance but he knew that Ano was correct. "I'm not doubting Marleena's integrity or her loyalty. I know they've sacrificed a lot."

Mira looked at Thomas. "Thomas, you've been quiet so far. Do you have anything to add?"

Thomas nodded, "The Aurora lines have formed a direct path to our sun and moon. Mars has exhibited all signs of a breathable and habitable atmosphere. We have determined that Mars is completely terraformed."

"What? Is that possible?" Mira asked in shock. Ano and Erwin looked equally as surprised.

Thomas nodded, "We suspected it could with the reintroduction of magic into our star system but until just recently we couldn't be sure. The surface remained quite unchanged until this year. We sent a team of scouts to investigate the planet and they found several caverns filled with lush vegetation. So far there has been

no signs of wildlife but that's secondary. We have compared the planet to Primus."

"That's. . . the cavern planet with the cats?" Ano asked.

Thomas nodded. "Primus is the homeworld to the Magicats and the Kingdom of Halfmoon. It's also the homeworld of the soon to be queen."

"Princess Catra D'riluth. She's the one we want to appeal to. Do you all have the files?" Mira asked. At everyone's nods she continued. "The standing that Mara holds is a boon to Earth. We've already received word that in the last fourteen days, Princess Catra has requested Mara to be her maid of honor. With Mara's family in such a unique position we need to maneuver carefully. Marleena and her husband King Randor have given us a priority transit position but that's all they could do. In five days, Marleena will no longer hold the status of queen."

"And with that, there's a very real chance that our support could be cut in half as well." Erwin answered.

"Or, it could give us the chance to boost our standing, and bolster their assistance." Ano countered.

Thomas cleared his throat. "We need to be aware of some other pressing matters. While many of the alien races welcome us to the Empire, there are many who are quite wary of us. According to the files that we've received from Light Hope, Marleena, and Evelyn, no other planet has ever been able to continue living without the assistance of the Aurora lines. This has many suspicious of our intentions towards the Empire."

Mira let out a groan. "Why is that so hard to believe?"

"Well as we now know, the lines allow the planets' ecosystems to self sustain themselves, healing damages after a time. It's what allowed Earth to recover in only twenty five years. Not only that, it has started affecting our gravity, our electromagnetic spectrum, how our sense of time works. Our planet is an ecological miracle

and has never been recreated anywhere else in the universe. But there's a problem that we need to get under control quickly. It's begun to flow into our bodies, strengthening us. . . and people are realizing they can utilize magic."

"And so the other shoe drops." Erwin let out a breath before shaking his head in annoyance.

"We've also detected some strange readings in regards to the lines. We're not sure what it means but they are fluctuating heavily and–"

A ringing sound emanated from Thomas' wrist, cutting him off. As he swiped it up, a hologram of a military man appeared. "Councilman Lawrence," He saluted, "the Leviathan ship has arrived along with the Eternian Ambassador. The ship is. . .impressive." He whispered the last part in awe.

Thomas nodded, "Understood. Dismissed." He turned to look at Mira as they stood. "Let's go."

Catra sat in the throne room beside Adora, looking down at the prisoner on trial. As she sat there, his representative stated his name and listed off his crime. Catra paid careful attention because she realized this was a rather important lesson. Normally, a prisoner would not be put on trial before the King or Queen. However, due to the wedding being only five days away and with it her coronation, Randor and Marleena had decided that this was a good time to learn this. Although Adora was present, this decision was solely Catra's. Randor had made that perfectly clear to Adora.

Catra was just thankful that his crime was theft. Granted, it was a major theft but was still a nonviolent crime. She listened to the man plead his case. He looked quite nervous as he found himself under the judgment of the future queens. Initially the man seemed a bit hopeful looking at Adora but Catra caught the slight fear when he looked at her. She was aware that her people were

known to be a bit harsher than Eternians but she would be fair and just in her decision.

"Kaimen Moore, citizen of the Repton Kingdom, you stand trial before the future Empresses of Eternia and the Empire of the Deae Lacrimae. You have been accused of theft of the second level. What is your defense?" King Randor asked.

Kaimen's representative nodded at him before stepping back. He looked at Randor and Catra before bowing his head. "I do not deny these accusations and in the same circumstances I would do it again."

Catra raised a brow, casting a glance at Adora before looking at the man's representative. "What did he steal?"

"He stole a Sana rune, your highness. But it was for a good purp–" The man was cut off when Catra raised her hand.

She looked back at the man. "Why did you steal it?"

"My friend took an injury on his last expedition into the Plains of Perpetua that left him unable to walk. When the healers bestowed their price, he could not pay it. We sought out Eternos in hopes of medicinal help that our own Kingdom would not provide. When I learned that his injuries were too extensive for anyone but She Ra I. . .stole the rune." He said quietly.

Catra simply nodded before looking at Adora and whispering, "What is the significance of the rune?"

Adora shook her head, replying in a whisper as well, "For me, not much. I can make them on the fly, but I know they aren't cheap. The typical charge for stealing one is at least two years and a large fine." Adora looked a little conflicted, "Catra, this seems wrong. Can't we just give him a slap on the wrist? I can just replace the rune."

Catra looked at Randor before looking at the man. "Your friend. Has he made a full recovery?"

"Yes. He is well and can move again."

"And am I to believe that he had no part in this theft?" Catra asked.

He nodded his head. "It was only me. He had no knowledge of what I was planning."

Catra watched his body language. His movements betrayed nothing of his words. His breathing was level. To anyone else they might not recognize it but any animalistic race could pick it out. He was telling the truth. She nodded before looking down at the snake man.

"And the rune?" Catra asked.

"There was nothing remaining. The man's injury took all of the magic." A sorceress said from the side. Catra gave a single nod before looking back at the man, taking a deep breath.

"Our Kingdom and Empire stands for faith in the good of others. Our work has greater purpose. Sometimes we need a reminder of that. Kaimen Moore, under the eyes of Sharella, you are forgiven. Find peace in that."

The man looked stunned at his sentencing before nodding, his eyes tearing up. A guard stepped up to him before disabling the cuffs allowing him to rub his wrists. Catra stood up, "Under the judgement of Sharella, this hearing is adjourned."

As everyone left the room, she looked at Randor and Marleena. "How did I do?"

Randor lolled his head side to side before giving a sharp nod, "It's not what I would have done but that's not what matters. What matters is how did you feel about your decision?"

"It felt right." Catra said firmly.

Adora smiled, "I'm glad."

"Well spoken." A voice said from behind them. Catra turned only to see Lorric Sunder. "Not everything requires a punishment. A scare like this was more than enough for that man."

"General Sunder," Adora nodded, "what brings you here today?"

"I'm here to deliver word that the transporting ship from Eternia has arrived."

Catra perked up, "They're here?"

Lorric nodded, a smile on his face. "They're down at the docking bay now."

"Who?" Adora asked

Catra grinned before grabbing Adora's hand. "Let's go." She said before warping away.

As Glimmer walked with the alliance, she looked around at the city. "This looks way different than before."

"Because it is." Mara answered. "Initially, we were stuck in the past. Here, it's like we've had an extra one thousand years to advance."

As they walked through the city docking bay, Glimmer took note of a large stone area with what looked like royal guards surrounding it. "Hey, Mara, what's that?"

"It's a warp space." Mara answered. "They were installed all over the city when Catra came to live here when she was sixteen."

"What are they for?" Bow asked.

"For when Catra warps, she's got her guard around her at all times." Light Hope responded.

"What do you mean w–" Glimmer was cut off by the sudden appearance of Catra and Adora.

Glimmer looked at them both and awed at how different Adora looked. Adora's militaristic look was gone and had a much more regal appearance. She wore a long white dress with a golden trim that showed off her figure and she wore small aesthetic pieces of golden armor on her shoulders, boots, and gloves with blue gems embedded throughout her dress. A red cape was draped on one of her shoulders with a golden embellishment along the edges with a royal design pattern. She noticed her hair was down as well.

Catra, for her part, looked almost the same but appeared more regal as well. She wore a dark red and black suit that was similar to her Horde wear but had a golden trim and looked like it was of much higher quality. Her colors matched Adora's and she wore the same boots that she had worn when at the peace festival. She also had what looked like a white and golden cape draped over a shoulder as well. Glimmer took note of the matching rings on their hands.

Adora looked at Mara and Light Hope in shock before looking at Catra then back at Mara. Mara looked a little stunned at the sudden arrival but recovered quickly. "Hey Ado–" She was cut off as she and Light Hope were pulled into a hug.

"Oh my gosh! Where have you guys been? I haven't seen you in years." Adora exclaimed happily.

"It's good to see you too." Mara said as she hugged Adora back, all awkwardness gone.

"I am well. How are you, Adora?" Light Hope's voice rang out from her wrist.

Catra cleared her throat. "We thank you for your arrival and are delighted to host the Kings and Queens of Etheria. Feel free to explore. The ambassador will act as your guide. He shall explain

the laws and regulation as well as what is currently not allowed due to current events. Welcome to Eternos." Adora quickly let go of Mara and stepped beside Catra before doing the same greeting.

Queen Angella looked at the women curiously. They seemed so different but yet were completely the same. Adora winced in a bit of pain as she looked at the group before shaking it off.

Micah bowed, "We thank you for your hospitality and are honored to be your guests."

"Princess Catra. Might I inquire if my brother is around?" Hordak asked.

"He should be stationed beside the barracks near the steeple. If that is everything we must be going." Catra said curtly before looking at Mara and Light Hope, "When you both get a moment, please come see me. There's a few things we'll need to go over."

"Queen Angella, King Micah, Lord Hordak." Adora said as they turned to walk off.

Glimmer caught the tail ends of the conversation before Catra ported away with Adora. "I didn't know Hordak had obtained Lord status. When did that happen?"

"I, er, don't know why I said that." Adora said sheepishly.

"You're such a dork sometimes." Catra said laughing before they disappeared.

"Did you guys see that?" Scorpia asked immediately.

"Yeah, Adora's pulling off the royal look better than me. We all saw it." Mermista drawled.

"No, not that. Adora said, 'Lord Hordak.'" Scorpia pointed out. "She might be remembering."

Hordak shook his head, "It's doubtful. Many people have confused my rank many times before due to Entrapta and I's marriage."

Scorpia shrugged before Swift Wind started to lead the group on a tour. As they walked through the city, Scorpia caught sight of a certain group of guards. "Guys, look. It's Kyle, Lonnie, and Rojelio."

The group stopped before looking at one of the food vendors. True to Scorpia's words, there at one of the tables sat the trio, eating and chatting. "We should go over and say something."

"Scorpia, they won't know who we are. We need to be on our best behavior. We can't go wandering off." Glimmer said.

"But Catra did say to explore." Perfuma said. "I'm sure saying hi wouldn't hurt."

As they discussed how to approach them, Kyle noticed them out of the corner of his eye. As he turned to look at them, a big smile broke out on his face as he stood up. "Hey Scorpia! How are you doing?"

The whole group stopped talking and stared at Kyle in shock before Lonnie pulled Kyle back down into his seat. "Kyle! They don't know us anymore, remember?"

"Oh, right." Kyle said before turning back towards the group. "Sorry! I thought you were someone else."

Rojelio facepalmed before Glimmer walked up. "You guys remember the other timeline? How?"

"Wait, you remember too?" Lonnie asked in shock.

"Yeah. It was initially only Glimmer but Swift Wind helped us out by using She Ra's magic. It helped us regain our memories." Bow said.

Scorpia immediately pulled the three into a hug, "How have you guys been? Oh, it feels like it's been forever which I mean it kinda has. But now that we're all here, we just need to get Catra and the gang will be complete."

Lonnie backstepped. "Woah, woah, woah, back it up. We can't mess with Catra. Her wedding is in four days. We haven't even been able to speak with her in like two weeks because of everything going on."

Kyle spotted Hordak before immediately standing, "Lord Hordak!"

Hordak waved him off before Lonnie lightly smacked the back of his head, "Kyle! He's not in charge of us anymore. The Horde is Etheria's army now, remember?"

"Sorry. It's just muscle memory by this point."

"You still haven't answered our question. How do you remember?" Angella asked.

"It was a couple years ago. We, uh, had an accident. It was a bad one too. We were part of a diplomatic expedition with Adora to the dark hemisphere. We were to make for the temple of Shokoti in the city of Tahryn." Kyle explained.

"The annual incense trade?" Mara asked.

Lonnie nodded, "Yeah, that's the one."

"Who's Shokoti?" Mermista asked.

"The Eternian goddess of darkness and all things entailing and sister to Sharella. Many hail her as an evil goddess in contrast to her sister Sharella, the goddess of light."

"I'm willing to bet that's not as simple as that sounds." Sea Hawk said.

"It's not. There have been many conflicts over the goddesses." Light Hope supplied.

Kyle continued, "Anyways, we had delivered the shipment to Tahryn but there had been an issue with the manufacture of some of the crates. The incense was exposed to sunlight."

Light Hope gasped. Mara looked shaken, "How are you all alive?"

"If we're being honest, we shouldn't be. Adora barely got to us and if she'd been a little late, we'd probably be dead." Lonnie said.

"Catra was pissed to say the least." Kyle said with a nervous chuckle.

"I don't understand. Why does it matter that they were exposed to sunlight?" Perfuma asked.

Mara looked at the plant princess, "The dark hemisphere is named that for a reason. Sunlight doesn't reach the surface of that half of the planet. It's a gorgeous place but it's a bit more dangerous. Anyways, as weird as it sounds, the incense that is burned comes from the umbra root. This root only grows on this side of the planet and doesn't see the sunlight in its whole life cycle. Because of that, the magic inside of it elicits healing effects when burned at night and emits a soft glowing blue smoke. But–"

"When it sees the sunlight, it becomes volatile." Micah finished.

"Exactly." Kyle said, "But due to how the containers work, the magic inside is sealed for safety. When we broke the faulty seal, the explosion ruptured half of the temple. It wasn't a good situation for anyone. Thankfully, Catra rewound the temple's damages a week later when she arrived."

"So that's why you remember. We deduced that She Ra's magic was what let Glimmer remember." Bow said.

"But why are you guys here? Besides the wedding I mean?" Kyle asked.

"We found out that Shadow Weaver's up to something. She can remember too and is up to something." Glimmer said.

Lonnie groaned, "Really? You get a completely new life and you're still trying to take down the Horde?"

"Yeah, besides, we know Shadow Weaver here. Her name's Beatrix and she's a lot nicer. We even confronted her to see if she remembered and she didn't have any idea what we were talking about." Kyle said before pointing past them, "Look, there she is now."

As the group turned, they spotted the woman in question at one of the stall vendors. She was noticeably absent of her veil and instead was wearing jeweled headwear that covered her eyes but left her nose and mouth visible and a form fitting coat that seemed almost military. As she turned, she caught sight of Micah before letting out an excited grin. Micah quickly walked away from the group towards her so as to let them continue talking with Lonnie's group.

"Micah? Is that you? You've grown!" She said as she pulled Micah into a hug. As she started talking to Micah, the group looked at Lonnie.

"'That's not her.' That's what you're thinking right?" Lonnie said.

"Yeah. She looks. . . different. Her voice is there, and so is her height and demeanor but she seems. . ." Castaspella trailed off as she watched the woman catch up with her former student.

"Happy?" Kyle supplied.

"Yeah." Bow said.

Castaspella shook her head, "Is it possible that she's lying? That she just got her memories back similar to us? I remember her

being much kinder when teaching us than in the previous timeline."

"We told you. You're mistaken. Beatrix is kind and helpful. She's always encouraging people to do their best. She even teaches Catra magic. In fact, she just received an award for being the first sorceress to master both the light and dark magic schools. Her official title is that of Shadow Weaver." Kyle said, Rojelio adding an encouraging hiss from the side.

"Wait, she just received this title two weeks ago? How many days?" Glimmer asked.

Lonnie hummed before answering, "Seventeen days, roughly. That sounds right."

"It is." Kyle said.

Glimmer thought about that before shaking her head, "That doesn't add up. Razz disappeared nineteen days ago. We're missing something."

"What do you mean disappeared?" Lonnie asked.

"We mean gone. Like, she doesn't exist anymore, gone. She completely vanished but before she did, she told us we needed to get Catra and Adora to remember. She also said to gather all the help we can get. Besides Glimmer, only Shadow Weaver had access to She Ra's magic before Catra reset the timeline. But if you three remember, maybe we're looking at this wrong." Mara said.

Frosta looked confused, "But if it's not Shadow Weaver, then who could it be?"

"What's not me?" Beatrix asked as she walked up to the group.

"Great, looks like it's the city plan all over again. Let's not group too close together." Mermista drawled snarkily.

Mara shot a small glare at the bored sea princess. "Nothing. We're just discussing a few things."

Beatrix looked at the group before turning to look at Lonnie. After a moment she looked at Kyle, "I'm going to assume this has something to do with your alternate memories?"

"Pretty much." Lonnie said. "They think someone's causing trouble. Their initial thoughts were that it was you."

"Why? What happened?" She asked, turning towards Castaspella and Micah.

Micah looked a little hesitant before sighing. "Someone's messing with time and a woman that Mara knew gave a warning and told us to get help before she ceased to exist. As far as the memories go, only those affected by She Ra's magic can remember. That, at the time, only consisted of my daughter and. . . well, you."

She remained quiet for a moment before asking a question, "Did this woman explicitly say that it was me? Or did she only tell you to get help?"

They all looked at Glimmer, Bow, and Mara. "She," Glimmer began, "said to trust each other. That we'll need every ounce of help we can get for what's coming. She said when we come to the sword, keep going and cross the threshold to find her and that we have to remember."

"Well, that's ominous." Shadow Weaver remarked dryly. "And you thought that I was behind it?"

"You were the most likely suspect." Frosta said.

"Perhaps we were a bit hasty," Sea Hawk said, "But can you blame us?"

"No. I can't. Either way, we need to report this." Shadow Weaver said.

"Did you not hear what we just said? We can't! If it's not you, it could be anyone. If we report this now, we risk alerting the true perpetrator behind this all." Mara said.

"Well, then what do you suggest?" Shadow Weaver said, a tad impatiently.

No one spoke up for a moment before Kyle voiced an idea. "Why don't you give Shadow Weaver her memories back? You can do that right?"

"Absolutely not!" Glimmer said vehemently.

"Why not?" Lonnie asked, "You gave Hordak his memories back. Why's it different for Beatrix?"

"That's. . .actually a good point." Swift Wind said. "Why don't we do that? It didn't change Hordak at all. In fact, everyone still has their personalities intact."

The sun dipped below the horizon, giving way to night as the group discussed what to do. After a few minutes, they decided that it was best to give Shadow Weaver her memories back. As Shadow Weaver held her hand out, Swift Wind pointed his horn at the sorceress, allowing her to siphon some magic. After the glow faded, they all looked at her with bated breath.

"Well?" Glimmer asked.

"I. . . Did I do it wrong? I remember nothing." Shadow Weaver said, not showing any of the pain that the others had when their memories returned.

"That's impossible. It worked for everyone else. It even worked for Sulphira and she had been dead for centuries in the original timeline." Bow said.

"Isn't it obvious?" Hordak said suddenly.

"What?" The alliance asked.

"This woman is not Shadow Weaver." Hordak said.

"No," Micah shook his head, "She has to be. She had obtained the title Light Spinner when I was in schooling at Mystacour. We even discussed the implications of the spell of obtainment. These all match up with my original memories. She even looks more or less the same."

Beatrix also nodded in agreement. "Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio also swear that I am this woman."

"I also didn't get any memories back." Light Hope signed.

"Interference maybe?" Juliet asked.

Spinnerella stepped forward, speaking for the first time, "I didn't want to voice my opinion for I feared that it was insensitive. . . but, what if these depictions of ourselves are based on Catra's interactions and views with us?"

"What do you mean?" Mara asked.

"Catra knew most of us by the time that the timeline rewrote itself. But for some, she knew a bit less. Light Hope, Hordak, and Shadow Weaver being among them. She'd probably only ever interacted with Hordak a few times before the rewrite, correct?" Hordak nodded, "Now, you're married to a woman who shares your love of science and you still lead the Horde, albeit as a general. Micah is Angella's husband and was the king."

"What about Shadow Weaver? She was basically her mom, wasn't she?" Bow asked.

"Exactly." Netossa said before turning towards the woman, "Did Catra have a mother here?"

Shadow Weaver nodded, "Her mother was Queen C'yra of Halfmoon. She died roughly five years ago. When Catra moved to Eternia, her uncle Percival had an idea that she would marry Adora and thus was prepared to take up the mantle as King of

Halfmoon. Ever since she moved here, I have been offering her counsel in all sorts of matters and acting as a mentor."

"And there lies the perception of motherhood. Mara," Spinnerella turned towards the woman, "How did Catra meet Light Hope and what did she know about her?"

"Light Hope was an. . . artificial intelligence before the rewrite. She teased me that I loved her when I took her to meet her, which I did. But beyond that, the only instances that Light Hope and Catra met were very few."

"And so I'm in a relationship with Mara because that is what Catra knew of us. And because she viewed me as an AI, I'm now a technomancer?" Light Hope asked.

"The data does seem to match up with this theory. Although there are a few different factors, this does seem to be the leading theory with a ninety four percent possibility of being correct." Entrapta said as she tapped away at her tracker pad.

"That still doesn't answer why I can't remember though." Shadow Weaver said.

"Hey!" A loud voice yelled, "Not to be an asshole, but can you move? It's getting late and I have to open my bar."

"Perhaps we should discuss this later." Hordak said to which the group agreed.

One day before the wedding

"Argh!" Glimmer growled, "Three days and we have nothing!"

"We might need to begin considering the alternative." Shadow Weaver said.

Perfuma shook her head, "I agree with Beatrix. Maybe telling Catra and Adora outright is the way to go?"

Mermista shook her head, "We can't just do that."

"Why not?" Frosta asked, "It literally took you all telling me to my face that the Horde was bad and needed to be stopped. How is this any different, objectively speaking?"

Mara walked into the lounge area only to be met by everyone's stares. "Where have you been? We need to figure something out and fast!"

"The wedding rehearsal. There's a lot I need to be aware of." Mara said, rubbing her temples.

"Does anyone have any ideas?" Angella asked.

As the group started to talk amongst themselves, trying to think of anything that could possibly work that they hadn't tried already. Finally Kyle spoke up. "What if I just call Adora?"

"Kyle!" Lonnie said exasperated, "We just said that we can't confront them. There's too much risk involved."

"Yeah, I know. But I don't mean to tell them outright. Let's just call Adora and ask her to show up and we can tell her privately." Kyle said.

Glimmer threw her hands in the air, "Sure, why not? We've tried everything else by this point."

Kyle nodded before pulling out a small crystal prism. As he twisted it a few times it began to change shape into a thin disc. As it started to blink, Bow looked at it in confusion.

"What is that?" He asked.

"It's my royal guard badge. It gives me a direct link to the royal family as well as the other guard." Kyle said with a smile. "Pretty cool, huh?"

"You're a part of the royal guard? Since when?" Mara asked.

"I earned the spot about a year and a half ago." Kyle said with a proud look.

After a second, Adora's face appeared as a hologram. "Hey, Kyle. Did you guys need something? I'm kind of busy."

"We want to discuss something important with you." Kyle said seriously.

Adora looked at Kyle for a few seconds before looking in a random direction, "Give me the room. See that I'm not disturbed. She turned back towards Kyle, "Alright. You have my attention."

Kyle turned towards Glimmer, "You can teleport us, right?"

Glimmer nodded. As she went to grab everyone, Kyle shook his head, "No no no, only Bow and Mara. Too many is startling."

"It's fine." Adora's voice sounded from the crystal. I'm seeing the Etherian princesses and Beatrix with a few others. If it's that important that you need to call me a day before my wedding then it's best to get the full picture."

Kyle let out a sigh before nodding, "Alright. Just make sure a space is in view for the port."

After everyone locked hands, Glimmer looked at the image that Adora had displayed through the prism before teleporting. After a moment, everyone looked around the room, reorienting themselves.

Beatrix was first. "Your Majesty."

"Beatrix." Adora nodded before looking at the occupants. "I count twenty one people in this room. Three are a part of my guard," She nodded towards Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio, "My steed, my fiance's magic teacher, my uncle's brother, Mara, Light Hope, and thirteen Etherians, most of whom are royalty."

Micah looked at Adora. "Adora, how have you been? Last time we had the chance to speak, you were only this high." He said with a grin.

Adora smiled before giving a sharp nod, "Kyle, explain. I really am busy and don't have much time."

Before Kyle could speak, Glimmer cut him off. "Adora, it's so good to see you! This is going to be hard to hear but someone's messing with time and we–"

"I know." Adora simply said.

Glimmer went quiet, a confused look on her face before exclaiming, "What! You already know?"

Adora smiled, "I didn't really know, more like a guess. My parents filled me in that there was a temporal branch at some point that closed when Catra and I were born. No one knew what it was except for Catra's mother. All I know is that there was an alternate timeline that revolved around Catra and I."

Glimmer nodded. "Then do you remember us?"

Adora studied the group intently, her gaze lingering on Hordak and Angella for a few moments before moving on. When she looked at the princesses she felt a sense of familiarity but couldn't place it. It was like trying to see through a heavy fog. She felt a tiny pulse before shaking her head.

"No. I get a sense of familiarity but nothing else." Adora said.

Glimmer gained a look of desperation before her eyes widened, "One second! Wait right here." She said before teleporting away. After a moment, she reappeared with a red staff in her hands. "Catra gave this to you as a gift the night you confessed to one another. Does this seem familiar?"

As Catra and Adora stood together, they smiled at one another. "I like your coat. It looks nice."

Catra smiled at that before holding out her gift. "I got you a gift. Glimmer and Sea Hawk helped me out."

Adora looked at the wrapped item before gently unwrapping it. As she picked up the staff, she admired it in awe. The light subtle red glow reminded her of their time training in the Horde and the laughter that had usually accompanied it.

"*Twist it." Catra said. Adora wore the same look that she had when Johnny had told her to twist it. "The staff. Twist the center."*

Adora twisted it before two long blades extended, accompanied by a silver and red sheen, giving it an almost ethereal glow. Adora twisted the staff back, causing the blades to retract. Adora was amazed at the staff before gently setting it to the side. "It's beautiful. Thank you Catra."

Adora gently took the staff before twisting the center. Just as she remembered, two blades protruded from the ends giving off a silver and red glow. Adora looked at the weapon fondly, "It was the celebration for the war's end. I gave Catra her head piece back."

"You remember?" Glimmer asked excitedly.

Adora winced, before standing and walking towards a window. "I was running. And I was–I wasn't–" she clutched her head in pain, falling to her knees.

"Adora!" Glimmer cried, taking a step forward, "Are you alright?"

"There was a fight. We were fighting. Mara, she was–Catra was there." Adora said, frantically looking around the room before landing on Beatrix, "It wasn't her. She didn't–she couldn't have–"

"Enough" A commanding voice cut through the atmosphere like a knife. Suddenly, everyone found it hard to stand. It was like their bodies were too heavy.

"What's happening!" Bow cried.

"Andra, take the Etherians to the cells. I'll question them later. Leave Mara and Light Hope. As for Lonnie, Kyle, and Rojelio, you three will report to the barracks now!" Catra commanded in a harsh tone, her eyes emitting a familiar blue light as she strode in with the royal guard.

Catra gently leaned down to help Adora up from the floor, concern written on her face as the princess alliance was hauled out of the room. Mara looked at Catra, "Wait, Catra. We need to talk to you!"

Catra looked at the girl with a familiar look that Glimmer hadn't seen since the battle of Salineas. "You will remain quiet. And if she," Catra pointed at Glimmer, "wants this to go even remotely peacefully, she won't even think about teleporting away."

Glimmer looked at Mara and gave a reassuring nod as they were hauled out the door. Swift Wind looked conflicted on what to do before finally settling beside Adora.

An hour passed as Catra overlooked Adora as she lay unconscious. Several doctors were in the room along with Randor, Marleena, Swift Wind, Light Hope, and Mara. One of the doctors walked up to Catra.

"She's fine. Just exhausted. Whatever happened seemed to have taken a bit of a toll on her mental state. After a night's sleep she'll be fine. Besides the fatigue, she is perfectly healthy."

Catra nodded before letting out a breath she didn't know that she had been holding. She gave a small nod before narrowing her eyes and turning towards Mara and Light Hope, "What happened."

Mara was a bit taken aback at her icy tone but could understand. It probably hadn't looked very good to come on with twenty people surrounding a collapsed Adora. Randor and Marleena also looked at Mara and Light Hope as well

"It's hard to explain–"

"Try." Catra snapped.

Mara nodded, "Time travel."

"What?" Catra asked.

Mara took a breath before launching into the story. After about ten minutes of Mara and Swift Wind explaining, she waved her hands, "Stop, stop, stop!"

Catra runned her eyes before shaking her head. "And if She Ra's magic is infused into me, I'll remember?"

Swift Wind nodded. "Yeah, pretty much."

Catra looked at Randor and Marleena. "And you two were aware of this?"

"Well, not the specifics. All we knew was that there was a temporal branch. Like Adora told you, we can't recall anything." Marleena explained.

Catra nodded before looking at Swift Wind, "Who cast the infuse spell?"

"King Micah."

"It's been an hour." Mermista complained.

"How did Catra even know we were there?" Frosta asked.

"She most likely rewound," Micah explained, "Catra is fabled for being able to manipulate time in such a manner."

"Ugh," Mermista groaned. "What are we even doing right now?"

"Patience princess." Beatrix said calmly, "Once Mara explains what's going on to Catra, she will come to speak with us."

"How can you be so sure?" Angella asked.

"Because only Micah, myself, and Glimmer can cast the infusion spell and any variation of it." Beatrix explained. As if on cue, Catra appeared with Light Hope, Mara, Randor, Marleena, and Swift Wind. Beatrix looked at Mermista, a smug look on her face, "See?"

Mermista rolled her eyes, "Whatever."

Catra looked at Beatrix. "Beatrix, can you perform the same spell as King Micah?"

The sorceress nodded, "Easily."

Catra nodded before looking at Andra. "Let her out."

Andra nodded before stepping towards the cell and opening it. Beatrix gave a nod before striding towards Swift Wind. As Swift Wind held out his wing, Beatrix laid her hand on the wing and took Catra's hand. As the spell started, Catra's body was engulfed in golden light before she stumbled backwards, holding her head. Immediately, Beatrix found a blade at her throat before Catra stood up straight. "She's fine. I just wasn't prepared for that."

Beatrix, for her part, didn't so much as bat an eye at the move. Glimmer stepped towards the cell bars before looking at Catra, "Do you remember?"

Catra nodded with a wince, "Yeah, I remember. Ugh, that sucked."

Glimmer immediately teleported out of the cell and in front of Catra, enveloping her in a hug. "Oh, it's so good to see you! When Razz disappeared and I was the only one who could remember–"

"It's good to see you too, Sparkles. It's good to see all of you." Catra said with a smile before turning towards Andra. "You can let them go."

"Are. . .are you sure, your majesty?" She asked, unsure of the sudden change in her future queen's demeanor.

Randor nodded, "It's fine, Andra." He looked at the group, "Come, I think my daughter will want to speak with you all when she wakes up."

A collective sigh of relief was sounded as Andra began opening the doors.

Adora let out a groan as she slowly opened her eyes. As she slowly sat up, she looked at the balcony opening. The moons and stars were well into the sky. Immediately, panic filled her. She had been in the middle of several things before Bow and Glimmer–

She remembered now. The war, the alliance, her friends. All of it. She remembered Catra arresting them as well. She shook her head. It was all still a bit hazy but she needed to tell Catra. Swinging her feet to the side of the bed, she went to stand before the door opened. Adora's gaze snapped towards the noise before Catra strode in with some food and a hot drink. Her eyes landed on Adora.

"Oh, you're awake!" Catra said as she quickly set the food down before rushing towards her and taking her hands. "Are you alright? How are you feeling?"

Adora let out a small smile, "I'm okay. I think I was just exhausted. Sorry if I scared you. I need to tell you something important, though. But we need to let Glimmer and her friends go."

Catra gained a confused look, "Adora, they've been publicly bradished as traitors. They're already scheduled for execution."

Adora's eyes went wide with shock, "What!"

Catra let out a snort before laughing, "You're too easy sometimes. Bad joke, sorry. Sparkles already filled me in."

Adora let out an exasperated breath at Catra's sense of humor. With a pout on her face, she gave Catra a concerned look. "Did

you find out what was going on?"

Catra nodded, "Razz disappeared but before she did, she told Glimmer something was happening. We need to be ready. As of right now, nobody knows who or what it could be."

Adora nodded before laying back down. "We kind of botched the 'night before the wedding' tradition, huh?"

Catra let out a laugh, "Yeah, but I think this was a little too important to ignore. Besides, we still have the night after tradition." Catra said with a sly smirk.

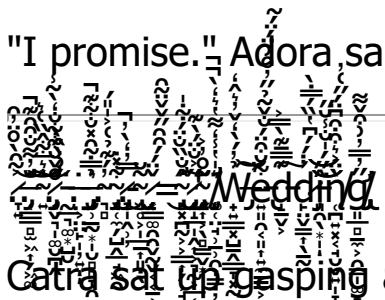
Adora's face gained a small blush before she smiled. "There is that."

Catra laid down next to Adora, the food all but forgotten. "Tomorrow will change everything. Not just for us but everyone in the universe. Even the ambassadors of Earth have arrived."

"We'll be okay. As long as we have each other." Adora said before leaning forward and kissing Catra. Catra pulled back, looking Adora in the eye.

"You promise?"

"I promise." Adora said before Catra pulled her back into the kiss.



Wedding

Catra sat up gasping as she quickly got to her feet. Her breathing was rapid as she looked around panicky. As her eyes scanned her surroundings she slowed her breathing, doing her best to calm down. She was in some sort of forest. The foliage was so thick they couldn't see past the line of trees in front of them. The sounds of wildlife unusually loud.

'The whispering woods?' she thought to herself as she stood up. A shooting pain immediately shot through their head, almost forcing

them back to the ground. Quickly catching themselves on a tree limb, trying not to throw up, they took a deep breath.

"Hello? Is anyone here?"

Taking a second to catch their bearings, they took in their surroundings more acutely.

There was no path, no trail, nothing indicating how they had wound up in the middle of the forest. In fact, there was nothing but trees and darkness stretching into the night.

The sounds of the wildlife were quite loud, almost unnaturally even. In fact everything seemed to be more vivid. The sound of rushing water was constant. There must be some form of water nearby. Just then they became acutely aware of how thirsty they were. Their tongue felt like sand against the roof of their mouth, and they were finding it somewhat difficult to swallow.

Catra was getting a sense of deja vu as she began to feel an overwhelming amount of fear. This had all happened to her once before.

She stumbled towards the sound, intent on getting some water. As they walked through the brush, gently moving branches to the side while being careful not to move too much so as to not set off another migraine, she noticed something about herself. Her wedding rings.

Blinking any drowsiness away, she took a more intense look at herself. She was wearing her royal wear.

She breathed a sigh of relief. She wasn't looping. She was still the same age, thank Sharella. Now she just needed to figure out how she got to Etheria.

She came across a river that was so clear she could see to the bottom of it. The fish that swam through didn't even look like normal fish. Their scales shined with brilliant glowing patterns of reds and blues that exhumed magical.

'Yeah,' Catra thought to herself. 'I'm definitely on Etheria.'

Taking a steadying breath, she sat on a rock, cleaned her face, took a drink and tried to gather her thoughts over what was going on.

She tried to get her sense of direction back by looking at the sky. If the moons weren't at a high point she could figure out which was north. Though she was quick to find her thoughts on this matter quickly dashed and not for the first time this day and probably not the last, she found herself cursing her circumstances.

Fog that seemed to stretch high into the clouds. As she tried to port, she found herself feeling too much pain to concentrate on magic. Giving a groan of exasperation, "Guess we're doing this the hard way," she said as she eyed the cliff.

She eyed the cliffside. "Well, no time like the present."

"Why am I going through this again?" This was bullshit and she knew it. She had nearly fallen several times, she *had* cut herself multiple times, and the worst of all was that she was very thirsty. Finally finding herself at the top, she crawled herself away from the ledge and layed there for several moments, breathing heavily.

Letting out a sigh, she quickly got to her feet before she looked out over the land. It was a gorgeous view. The river stretched out for miles and she could see a waterfall where it started. The sky was filled with shades of pinks and blues. The moons seemed more vibrant now that she could get a good look at them. And there were mountains of ice that seemed to stretch on forever until they were lost into the clouds.

The breeze smelled distinctly pungent. There was a hint of salt and sulfur in the wind. She was near the ocean. Catra cursed herself for forgetting. The whispering woods had a nasty habit of shifting. Quickly turning to look back towards the cliff, Catra

watched as the forest shifted before her very eyes. Catra let out a low growl before letting out a huff. No matter, she could still follow the smell of the ocean to get out.

'Looks like Plumeria is a bust,' Catra thought to herself as the landscape became unrecognizable.

As she followed the salty smell, she realized she was smelling other things as well. It was hard to describe but it was very familiar. Oil and metal she realized. But there was something missing. Something incomplete about the picture. She couldn't place it for a few minutes until it hit her. Her blood ran cold.

"Where are the stars?" She whispered in fear. Catra shook her head in denial. She just needed to get to Bright Moon and figure things out from there.

The morning rays started peeking through the branches, illuminating the path she was on. The sounds of wildlife became more prominent as nature started to wake up. As she kept walking she finally reached the edge of the whispering woods. As she made her way towards the edge of the treeline, she took note of the sky on the horizon. It was dark and gloomy like an ever present cloud of smog that seemed to go forever. Catra realized that she was looking at the Fright Zone, or the very beginning of it anyway..

Her ears twitched as she heard voices. Quickly heading towards the voices, she caught the scent of smoke. She noticed the shapes of several people up ahead scrambling to move things.

"Hurry up! We don't have all day. Shadow Weaver gave us a mission and I don't want to waste any more time."

Catra's brow furrowed at the voice. It sounded. . . familiar.

"What should I do with this?" A meek voice asked as if they were already in trouble for asking.

Catra finally walked out of the woods and came face to face with the sources of the voices. And that's when she realized that something had seriously gone wrong and she was missing a big piece of the puzzle.

There in front of her stood a woman who looked exactly like her. Her hair was spikier and unkempt. Her uniform was completely different, brandishing a nostalgic outfit, and on her head she wore a red armor head piece in contrast to her gold one. Maybe she was a few years younger than herself but there was no mistaking it. She was looking at herself.

"Just put it over. . ." The younger Catra's words died on her lips as she turned to look at the woman at the tree line. Every soldier stopped what they were doing and followed her gaze.

"What the hell?" Lonnie asked in confusion. Kyle and Rojelio looked equally as confused.

Scorpia looked at her as well before looking back at the Catra beside her. "Do you have a twin?"

"No," Catra said before narrowing her eyes and unsheathing her claws. Everything about the stranger looked identical albeit slightly different. Older, more mature features, her muscle tone was more developed as well. "And if I did, I would know."

Every Horde soldier pulled out shock batons, arming themselves against the intruder. As Catra D'riluth took a cautious step back, eyeing her younger counterpart, she only had one thought.

What happened?

And that marks the end of part 1. Wow this chapter took a second to write. I had so little time to write over the last two months. Part 2 will be called 'What Happened?'

I also want to thank everyone for all the support I've received over the course of the last year and a half of

writing this. It's always nice to know that people enjoy your work. Let me know your thoughts and I hope you all enjoyed.

End Notes

Updates are slow. First time writing. Reviews are welcome and appreciated.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!